Throw away The Mask

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Characters:	Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Original Child Character(s), Entrapta (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)
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Throw away The Mask

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

What's done is done. There is no turning back… However, there might be another path.
It's true, not many in Mystacor really cared about Shadow Weaver being there or not, but everyone is crushed by how much it affected Castaspella, their dear Head Sorceress; they understand her pain. Queen Glimmer feels partly responsible and usually finds herself reflecting, just like her aunt and father do; she has to fix it, there has to be something she can do, not only for Castaspella, but also for Adora and Catra, who seem all too willing to seize her father and drop him on Beast Island once again.

»—This isn't just about your sibling squabble and how you've obviously hurt Aunt Casta. Now, you have to explain to the council exactly why you vanished the summoning spell without authorization.
»—Authorization!?— he cried out, indignant. —I *made* that spell! I drew it!
»—There is no point in further discussion, dad. I expect you tomorrow, early, to explain yourself to the council— she stated and turned around to leave.
»—Will she explain herself too?
»Glimmer stopped in her tracks, looked back, and simply said —Whatever is making you this immature, father, I hope will pass soon.

Notes

Me? Using Persona 5 song names again? Never.....

Well, this part is a 100% dedicated to my readers of Cast-a-Shadow, and especially to the ideas most of u gave me in the comments, some opened my eyes to the great potential of ideas I hadn't considered, others encouraged me to give more importance to ideas that were originally mere details, and I'm gifting this to Cana_Alberona because I totally changed the format thanks to a certain comment and I have *no regrets at all*, this is so much better than the original format, goodness! Everyone thank Cana, please.
There are also ideas from Coffee__Ams and SWGang; a certain something funny with DT (among other things) and SW *actually* having a proper conversation with Micah, respectively.
Edit: Now adding ocean_galaxy too!! Much appreciated!!
Edit 2: Now adding sunset_luster XD Thank you so much!!
Edit 3: Riddl3, welcome to the list! Thank you so much for all those comments and the suggestions!!!
Edit 4: With such great ideas, Bitzy Bee, I owe you a lot now heh, so dedicated to you too!
Edit 5: Adding RainbowLake to this list for the amazing idea of Ch 66 that I won't spoil here hehe

Now, notes on the rating: Teen and up audiences because, while there's still nothing explicit, there are *a lot of heavily implied mature subjects*, again, only implicit, not explicit nor graphic at all. Hence, the change in rating. This also allows me to treat the characters more maturely, of course.

In light of recent twt events, I'd like to remind everyone that all my fics are about the potential to grow everyone has, and how every soul in the universe deserves at least basic respect. Respect isn't being nice, it’s remembering we’re talking to another human being; we all make mistakes from which we are supposed to learn, and we can judge and reproach people respectfully, it even works better than attacking, which makes the other person defensive and closed to learning. I believe we all deserve to be given the chance to grow, while just punishing people for their wrongs only makes them feel their behaviour is “justified”, so they will be less willing to see what they are doing wrong and why, much less take that chance to be better; or, if they recognize all of that, they may never believe it’s possible for them to grow because everyone treats them like trash. Some people will decide they don't want to change and may be cruel enough to revel in the pain they cause, in which case it's always better to block/ignore them, because insulting and harassing them would make us just as bad as them.
If believing everyone deserves at least basic respect will get me blocked by half of twt, and make plenty of people send me death-threats or the like, then so be it. But I stand my ground: if you will call out someone’s bad behaviour, don't be a hypocrite by doing something just as bad (or worse). Don't become them. Instead, give them a chance to become you, to learn, regret, and grow enough to properly apologize.
All my fics will forever work with this concept, *this* is what I believe in, and I know from experience that this might as well save a soul… as it has already saved mine, as it saved my bff's (who went through this irl, not on internet). **This is the core of my writings.** -Jan, 2022

Excuse me for the sour note, I hope you can still enjoy :)

The Aftermath

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was nighttime already, the sky darkened completely after the sun sank under the horizon, and only the stars and moons lit up the night sky. On a balcony, overseeing Bright Moon, Queen Glimmer observed the firmament as her usual thoughts and worries occupied her mind. Everything that had been happening with her father, ironically enough, made her think about her mother. How would she have handled this? Would she side with him or with her trying to talk him out of his obsession and hatred?

She let out a long sigh as her thoughts were interrupted by the sound of someone entering the balcony, possibly to announce dinner was ready.

But instead, what she heard behind her was —Your majesty. Should we expect King Micah to be back for dinner?

She quickly turned around to ask —He's not in the palace? Where's he gone?

—We haven't seen him in hours, your majesty; but it seemed like he was headed to Mystacor.

—Hours… and he's not back yet?— she insisted, as a bad feeling began building up inside her.

—I am sorry, your majesty. He isn't.

Without saying another word, Glimmer disappeared in a puff of sparkles and teleported to Mystacor. She appeared in the Hall of Sorcerers and ran towards the Lunarium, fearing the worst.

Her mind was racing. If he really was there, it would be her fault. She was already cursing herself for being specific and telling him they would be practicing *there*. Why wasn't she vaguer?

—Please don't be there. Please, dad, don't be there— she whispered, wishing her gut feeling was wrong.

However, when she arrived at the entrance of the building, she froze in place. For a moment she couldn't even breathe and it felt as if her stomach had been petrified. The glow of the summoning spell area she had become used to seeing wasn't there; moonlight came through the oculus, illuminating a figure standing in the middle of the room, and meters away, a second figure, barely distinguishable. She realized it was her aunt, kneeling on the floor, her back towards her father.

—You better have a great explanation, Castaspella.

As Glimmer heard her father's angry tone, it finally hit her and she couldn't hold her tears anymore. She hadn't felt such guilt in quite some time, but now there was also the feeling of having failed. She had failed every time she tried to get her dad and aunt to talk and make peace; and now, when she had tried to make sure Micah would leave them alone, she only allowed the exact opposite to happen.

When Castaspella finally stood up, without looking back at her brother or saying a single word, Glimmer was still staring in shock. She could only watch as the Head Sorceress silently stalked out of the Lunarium with a severe expression; she never answered Micah nor did she pay any attention to her niece as she walked past her.

Collecting herself, the Queen approached her father as she asked —What did you… why did you do it!?

Ignoring the sorrow and indignation in her tone, he simply answered —You and your friends are too innocent, baby girl. I won't hold it against you that you never saw what was actually going on.

—No. *Don't* "baby girl" me!— Glimmer retorted, trying to keep her composure. —We are not innocent, we know exactly what was happening and that it *wasn't* concerning at all! I tried, by *all means*, to make you understand it! Why did you come here!?

—I- No, no. I didn't come to *do* this, but if you had seen what I saw…

—Nothing! I don't care! Dad, you don't understand what you have done!— she interrupted him, standing straight and addressing him with severity. —This isn't just about your sibling squabble and how you've obviously hurt Aunt Casta. Now, you have to explain to the council exactly why you vanished the summoning spell without authorization.

—Authorization!?— he cried out, indignant. —I *made* that spell! I drew it!

—There is no point in further discussion, dad. I expect you tomorrow, early, to explain yourself to the council— she stated, as calmly as she could, and turned around to leave.

—Will she explain herself too?

Glimmer stopped in her tracks, looked back, and simply said —Whatever is making you this immature, father, I hope will pass soon.

The council meeting the next morning began without either sibling. The Queen couldn't bring herself to bother her aunt yet and, on the other hand, she wanted to talk with the rest of the council about the events from the previous night before her father joined the meeting.

Meanwhile, the Head Sorceress had been unable to sleep at all, she remained locked up in her room, staring at the ceiling, unable to think. Her mind was like an empty canvas, it felt like the blank first page of a study she found herself unable to begin. However, she knew it would only be a question of time; like before, Castaspella just needed to process what had happened so she'd be able to resume her normal life.

She forced herself out of bed, walked towards the window, and noticed —It's already late—. Recalling Glimmer had called for a meeting early in the morning, she guessed it had begun at least a few hours earlier. —I suppose I still have to go— she told herself.

As she walked up to her mirror, to put on her cape and crown before leaving the room, a sudden pain invaded her chest. It lasted mere moments, seemed related to that spell still bound inside her, but Castaspella couldn't feel anything other than excruciating pain. Whatever that had been, it disappeared just as fast as it came, and she couldn't afford to give it any attention now.

With her cape on, she was about to tie her hair up as usual but halted mid-way. She hadn't noticed how used she had become to that little gesture the woman had every morning the past months.

And now… she simply didn't want to do it.

Without dwelling much on it, she decided to tie the locks of hair that always hang at both sides of her face, keeping them separated from the rest of her loose hair, then put on her crown, and left the room with the unfamiliar weight and feeling on her back.

Hours earlier, Micah arrived at Mystacor for the council meeting. He had also stayed awake all night, feeling extremely angry and incapable of calming himself down. At first, he seethed in silence for hours, but it wasn't yet the break of dawn when remorse hit.

He had done the right thing, no?

Of course! It *had* to be the right thing to do!

Yet his sister was obviously broken, and *he* had done that.

But she was being manipulated, wasn't she? Clearly, she couldn't see how the woman was playing with her head and feelings! He *had* to break her free from that! Didn't he? Now she would hate him for a while, but she was already too entangled in her web of lies. He *saw* how she had Castaspella at her mercy! *It was the only way!*

Wasn't it?

Now, he had to "explain himself", as Glimmer had told him. He knew she was now telling the councilors what had happened, and he trusted she'd fairly explain it all. However, he had the feeling no one in the council would agree with him. And how could he expect them to understand!? It wasn't *their* sister under the influence of the wretched sorceress…

—King Micah— a councilor called, having just opened the door to the meeting room, and interrupted his reflections. —You can now come in.

By noon, both siblings were in the meeting room. No one questioned the Head Sorceress' tardiness, as they supposed she needed time until she felt better enough to continue her work and official business as usual, but Micah couldn't help noticing her loose hair and told Glimmer that was "proof of her influence", yet the Queen made sure he wouldn't bother her for that.

This was the first time the siblings saw each other since the Lunarium, and when he observed her expressionless demeanor his remorse returned. She wanted him gone, that was all Micah could think about; if she could find a way to permanently blind herself to his existence, she'd take it.

But he already expected her to be mad at him after she had been so masterfully manipulated. His sister was still delusional due to the months spent under her influence, wasn't she?

She couldn't… *actually* miss that woman, right?

—…With this introduction in mind, we shall begin discussing the first subject— a councilor sentenced, raising his voice.

Micah was shaken from his thoughts and realized he had been, once again, absorbed by his reflections during the beginning of the meeting; they were only clarifying how Glimmer informed them of everything that happened and why they were holding this meeting, which he knew, but he missed the part about this being the first of many, only intended to cover the most urgent matters in this occasion.

Being the Head Sorceress, Castaspella began —The first issue I would like to settle right now is that I've decided to give the eleven pupils under Shadow Weaver's tutelage a free week. They received very shocking news this morning and deserve the time to rest and adjust to the fact that, from now on, their tutor will have to be someone else. Which leads to the second urgent topic: who is to take over their tutelage.

—Given the special conditions in which they were introduced to sorcery, perhaps we should let them and their parents decide who should teach them from now on— a councilor suggested.

—That means the group could be separated— another chimed in.

—It's a possibility, yes.

—But it would permanently affect their learning.

—The most difficult part has already been done, they only need further perfection of their technique.

—Wait a moment, hold on— Micah interrupted. —Before we discuss this subject, shouldn't we resolve the first one?— he asked.

—It has been settled, King Micah— the councilor next to him replied calmly. —It was more of an announcement, a formality.

—What? But why? I don't see why those pupils would need a full week of "rest" before resuming their training— he argued. —I understand halting their classes until they are assigned a new tutor, but once that's done, why should they be granted more free time?

The sorcerer asked in general, but his gaze fixed on his sister at the end. He wanted her to explain herself.

—Like I said, they have to adjust to this sudden change, Micah— Castaspella answered. —They deserve time to accept they will be taught by someone else, with different methods and understanding of magic, after months of being the pupils of a literal summoned spirit. There is no room for a smooth transition.

—I have to disagree. That is not enough of a reason to give them that much time off— he retorted, crossing his arms in front of his chest.

No one dared interfere and the Head Sorceress took a deep breath with her eyes closed before answering.

—Listen, Micah. Do me a favor and dig into your memory; think, back in the time when you admired Light Spinner and felt she was everything to you, how you would have felt if she suddenly disappeared— she requested. Before he could answer, she quickly added —Forget the corruption, forget the stupid spell. Put yourself in their place, like you once were. These kids only knew the greatest tutor ever, and lost her overnight.

The sorcerer couldn't help noticing how her speech had become less careful, she was making a great effort to keep herself controlled, so Micah yielded. Perhaps he should make an effort too.

—I see— he let out. —I suppose it does make sense— he admitted.

—Speaking of rest— Glimmer interrupted. —I believe everyone here would agree that you need a rest too.

—That's unnecessary— she simply replied, before changing subjects. —I say we should agree on leaving the decision of the new tutor to the pupils and their parents. And now, we better continue with the next urgent issue.

—I agree— Micah let out, his arms crossed in front of his chest.

—Great timing to agree, you two— Glimmer muttered with annoyance. —In that case, the next subject is the council's decision regarding my father's actions last night.

—It has been decided—, a councilor began, —That King Micah shall be on probation for a month and under permanent vigilance—. His expression of indignation showed immediately, but he couldn't say a word as the councilor continued —It is clear he's not yet used to how this council works, as he disregarded the required authorization to dismiss the summoning spell at the Lunarium and neglected the notorious hindrance caused to Mystacor as a whole.

—Can I ask why this decision was made without my consent?— Castaspella inquired calmly.

—I took the initiative to discuss this matter and decided he needed a month of probation, to make sure no more "rushed decisions" will be made— the Queen explained, trying to be as formal and neutral as possible. —We all agree that you are biased against yourself on the matter and wouldn't fairly solve this issue.

—The only authority we could recognize to discuss this, besides yours, is the Queen's— another councilor added.

—I see.

Glimmer let out a sigh and finally announced —Those would be all urgent topics for today; further subjects will be discussed in the upcoming meetings. But I have to insist you take a rest too, Auntie.

—And I insist there is no ne- Ugh!

A sudden pain, similar to that morning, left her breathless for a moment. As soon as she could take a deep breath, it was gone.

—What was that!?

—Are you alright, Head Sorceress?

—Is it the spell?

—It has to be— Micah commented, silencing the councilors who kept asking questions.

—It's nothing— she quickly replied. Castaspella made a huge effort to hide the impact it had and simply explained —It's nothing dangerous, the spell isn't hurting me, I promise.

—Perhaps we should discuss removing it— Glimmer suggested.

—No need.

—She's right, Casta. There's no use for that spell anymore— Micah agreed.

—I said there is no need— she sentenced, severely. —And you're the last person I'd hear on this subject.

—If you insist, Aunt Casta— the Queen let out, calling her attention. —Then please accept the week of rest we proposed. Not only you need it, but also it can give you time to focus on investigating what is causing this pain— she suggested.

Resigned, she finally accepted —Then I suppose I will. But don't hesitate to call me if necessary.

As the Head Sorceress readied to dismiss the meeting, her brother looked around in confusion, about to question why it had been such a short meeting. However, a councilor called everyone's attention as he raised a hand, asking for a moment, so the King preferred to let it pass.

—Excuse me, Head Sorceress. Who should lead the council during this week? Should it be the Queen?

He was the one who had plotted the Double Trouble fiasco with Micah. Usually, he was the one left in charge if Castaspella wasn't in Mystacor, but after what he had done, he considered himself unfit and felt the need to ask.

—Glimmer already has her own responsibilities, which aren't little— she replied, looking at her niece's expression of relief. —And we all know you are the most capable to lead the council while I rest.

She still trusted him despite it all; he was surprised, honored, and didn't hesitate to accept. He dismissed the meeting in her stead, and everyone left the room.

Chapter End Notes

deep breath

Okay, don't try to guess where this is going yet. I myself don't know.
This time, I'm still writing, I have like 2 month worth of updates only…

Also, next week (updates on Wednesdays as usual, but the time of the day may vary a bit) you have a *surprise*, so to say… I promise it's good!

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this sequel and the new format, and I REALLY hope you, my readers, see the core of this fics. It's pretty evident the ship itself isn't the main focus, just a kind of trigger for events, if you may (I'm SORRY! I promise to feed you better with this sequel!), so… I don't really know what to say, except: please enjoy my poor attempt at teaching basic respect in the most entertaining way I could manage (._.")

Until next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Accepting you were wrong
Status: Being processed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She found herself within a familiar nothingness; once again in this dark abyss that felt so similar to the moment she was corrupted by the Spell of Obtainment. But this time, she was powerless while feeling the same pain she had felt back then, burning her skin down to her very soul.

She was in the core of Etheria, as there resided the power she had tried to dominate, the parasite magic that had owned half her lifeforce since that fateful day. She could get away from it a few kilometers, yet reaching the surface was simply unattainable; the core kept pulling her back, and that abysm was completely impossible to navigate, up and down meant nothing.

Whatever had first led her to the surface, it just didn't exist anymore.

She soon gave up; she had been there the months prior to her summoning, and got used to the pain, the silence, the darkness. Eventually, she had learned how to keep the pain at bay, and she could still do so, as long as she felt nothing. This wasn't the first time she had to turn her semblance of a heart into pure stone, she had done so the last half of her life; however, she now seemed to have trouble achieving it, because every time she managed to be just as apathetic as back in the Horde, there would come a memory to disturb her carefully built "shield" against all feelings.

It was a sunny afternoon. Shadow Weaver was tending to her garden as Castaspella was around. It was her lunchtime but, lately, the Head Sorceress had been preparing herself small lunch boxes to take to the garden so the woman could work on her plants for an hour or so each day.

As Shadow Weaver shook the dirt from her hands, she turned around to find the sorceress eating some small rounded pieces of food she had never seen before. She stared for a moment, watching her pick one up with a pair of chopsticks before eating it in a single bite. However, when Castaspella looked up, she couldn't let her know she was observing her out of interest.

—What?

—Your eating habits only get stranger— Shadow Weaver replied, rolling her eyes as if she was internally laughing at her.

—And your sorry excuses of insults are getting old— the sorceress replied, without looking at her, and picking up another piece of food. —Your turn.

—Please, as if eating baby portions wasn't enough to make a mockery of yourself. I don't need to put that much effort.

Castaspella set down her food and chopsticks before looking back at her and indignantly asked —What is your problem!? I'm here as a *favor* to you! Go back to your gardening and stop annoying me!

—Giving up so soon? That was quick— she mocked her.

—Just stop it already! Why do you always watch me eat!?

—It's quite amusing.

—Is that a joke? How can you think something so mundane as eating is "amusing"?— Castaspella asked, deadpan.

—You have no idea how terrible the meals were in the Fright Zone— Shadow Weaver replied, rolling her eyes, annoyed this time.

—Really?

—Absolutely. Sometimes I managed to smuggle some wine, but otherwise…— she admitted.

—Seriously, wine. Why not *actual* food?

The woman looked away for a moment before explaining —This is something Adora doesn't know but, I did feed her real food at first, since she was a baby and for quite a few years. Until it became increasingly difficult to get, that is; and she started sharing that food with Catra, so I simply didn't get any food again.

—How rude of you! That was terribly awful, how could you…

—Save it— Shadow Weaver dismissed her, shrugging and looking away again.

—No, no. You listen to me now— she insisted with a firm tone. —That was *spiteful*. I understand if it got difficult to get the food, but cutting it *just* because she shared it with Catra!? You were just being mean to her!— she reproached her.

While she was right, the woman refused to admit as much and instead replied —It's not like I could smuggle enough for the both of them, so I couldn't have done it regardless. Now stop chastising me, I can't change that now.

—I know! But you can at least admit how awful it was!

—What would be the point?

—Acknowledging that is the first step to regretting it, and only once you regret what you did to her will you be able to genuinely apologize to Catra— Castaspella patiently explained.

—Apologizing would fix *nothing*. What I did cannot be changed.

—That isn't the point— she denied. —It's for you to grow, and for them to heal. Don't you think your girls deserve that at least?

—Sometimes I can't decide whether you are too stubbornly nice, or just plain gullible.

—Says the woman who is making an effort to be mean— Castaspella muttered.

—What are you talking about!?— Shadow Weaver asked, mildly annoyed.

—I mean how you decided to mock me instead of, I don't know, asking me what this is— she replied teasingly, gesturing at her food. —You said it's amusing to see me eat because of the… food from the Horde. I hadn't heard anything about that before.

—You haven't seen either of the girls eat, I presume— she began, her arms crossed in front of her chest. —The colors, the flavors, the shape even… I had almost forgotten them.

Castaspella reflected for a moment and then picked up her lunch and the chopsticks, inviting her —Come here.

—Not like I have anything better to do— the woman sighed, and complied. When she sat next to the sorceress, she noticed the small bites of food looked like pouches, the thin skin translucent enough to let her see the pinkish color of the filling, and the box in which she carried them seemed to be made with some yellowish wood fixed in a circular shape. —I hadn't seen such food even before the… corruption.

—Well, taking into acount I had to explain my chopsticks to you last week…— she began, teasingly, but interrupted herself. —This is one of my favorite foods. It's meant to be a snack, not an actual meal, but I'm not that hungry at noon.

—That explains the… tiny size— she let out. However, she still seemed confused and asked —And this box is something like the chopsticks? Specific for this food?

—In a way— Castaspella replied, hesitant. —These are steamers designed to cook this and other kinds of steamed buns simultaneously, as you can stack several of them. See how it has holes? It's to let the steam flow up and cook all servings at the same time.

—What a… curious device— Shadow Weaver commented.

The Head Sorceress laughed a bit at her genuine, child-like, admiration, which made the woman instantly change her expression back into a more serious frown.

—A shame you can no longer taste or eat at all. You seem…

—No, I wouldn't have tried them either way— she instantly interrupted.

Castaspella rolled her eyes, holding back another laugh.

—Sure.

She suddenly opened her eyes; the pain struck quickly and deeply, like a dagger right in the middle of her chest. She had let herself miss the stubborn sorceress, who could go from reprimanding to gentle in a mere moment. She still couldn't understand why she was so patient with her.

Why wouldn't she give up? Why was she *so* convinced she'd regret her actions? She hadn't even spared a thought for her behavior in the Horde. Why would she start caring about it now? And yet, there she was, telling the sorceress everything in an effort to break her confidence, which only made her dwell in the whys of all she had done.

No matter how much she told herself she shouldn't care about it, that none of it could be fixed or changed, her mind would keep her reflecting on it. Castaspella was, perhaps, right. Eventually, she

was compelled to regret the things she did, at least a bit; she now had no choice but to admit she had been senselessly cruel, her confidence faltered, and the seeds of regret found their way into her.

Perhaps… she hadn't done the right thing at all.

Perhaps… she had simply chosen to be the bad guy, and deluded herself to think she was the good one.

Perhaps…

Chapter End Notes

This, and all the flashbacks that follow, kinda represent (are based on) my own growth process (unfinished yet).
If any of you happen to have read *Nice Punch*, you'll know how I write SW learning to apologize (and amazingly failing at it too!), and that's 100% based on my own experience learning to apologize. I had been taught anything less than perfection is unacceptable, and apologizing meant admitting a mistake, meaning I "deserved" punishment for it.
But all of that is wrong and, at this point it's obvious, that is exactly SW's mentality, which was also inherited by Catra, and should be cleared out in order to make any progress.
So: these flashbacks show how SW's mentality is gradually cleared from that bullshit, how her beliefs are defied by the eventualities, her view of the world shatters and she little by little has no choice but to accept it has to be entirely redone.
These are all events she's already been through, but she paid no attention to them, or most probably elected to dismiss whatever she felt at that moment. Yet, just like when we lay awake in bed at night (do I have insomnia? Yes. Do I reflect just like this? Absolutely), SW now spends 24/7 relieving all these moments and now has to see what she did wrong, admit what she tried to ignore, and feel everything she had shielded herself against.
This is how she will learn to have empathy, to regret, to admit when she's wrong, to accept when something is her fault, to genuinely apologize and seek forgiveness, and to have respect, for herself and others. I don't mean she'll be a whiny mess, and it's true she has self-respect already, but what she needs is to balance out the extremes she lives in (not like Casta isn't on opposite extremes too, of course).
Point is (and with this I'm closing the note): SW won't rest in peace, not for now; she'll learn, grow, and one day you'll see that, even if it's still the SW we know, there is, in fact, notorious progress even *she* might have trouble noticing.
I know from experience that it will take long but it can and will happen.

Forgiveness is Personal

Chapter Summary

Queen Glimmer can't help feeling guilty and decides it's time to talk with her aunt. They both have a lot to unpack, yet perhaps this is the right time to do so.

»—I shouldn’t have to say this, but don’t tell your father.
»—O-of course; don’t worry— she quickly replied. Yet, almost immediately, her guilt returned to torment her, and she felt the need to apologize. —I’m sorry, Aunt Casta. It was my fault.
»—What?— she asked calmly.
»—Dad… He knew where you were at because I… told him.
»—And how did you know?
»—I…—, Glimmer looked away embarrassed, —I spied on you two the night before.

Aunt and niece have their own views on the events from the past years, including the last year of the war, making them both regard this whole matter differently. Their relationship is finally getting better, and listening to each other was exactly what they needed.

»Glimmer understood; at least now she did. She hadn’t noticed before, but her guilt and helplessness in this situation were slowly filling her with hatred, just like Micah felt. (…) And, after months of asking her father to be more understanding, shouldn’t she be understanding too?

Chapter Notes

Okay, I admit I did tear up when editing, but just with the ending; it's wholesome, happy tears, I promise.

Anyways, unrelated to the chapter, you guys may like this little thing I did the other day.
(Edit: As I'm deleting my twt that link may stop working. Here's the linked picture:)



Well then, I hope you enjoy it! ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As the Head Sorceress walked back to her room, Glimmer caught up to her. She didn't know how to begin so she only walked a few steps behind, trying to figure out what to say.

—What is it?— Castaspella asked after a few minutes, having realized her struggle.

—I… Ahem- Sorry, Aunt Casta, I didn't mean to… Ho-How are you feeling?— she stammered.

—I presume you know…

—I didn't mean…—. Glimmer let out a long sigh, once again, considering what to say. —I can imagine the pain, the sorrow, I can see it in your expression but, the real dimension of how you're feeling… You have always been very expressive, Auntie, in control of your emotions but never silent; now you barely spoke. I wouldn't want you to feel like you have to bottle up how you're feeling now just because…

—It's about her— she interrupted, finishing the sentence for her.

—Yes—. The Queen let out a sigh again, feeling her guilt as a lump in her throat. —If you do… You will just explode sooner or later. This week of rest is also because of that.

—I understand, Glimmer— she replied; finally looking back at her, she briefly caressed her left cheek. —I'm glad you're not repeating my mistakes when handling your grief, it's very considerate of you.

Glimmer looked away quickly before explaining —I don't want to assume you feel like I did, but… Time to rest and recover is something everyone should have when grieving; the people here need you… More than I was needed as Queen.

Castaspella shook her head, let out a sigh, and put a hand on her shoulder to get her full attention.

—You are a Queen forged by the heat of war. You're exactly what Etheria needed. It doesn't matter if Bright Moon could or couldn't survive without you as a queen back then, we were going through something bigger than a single kingdom— she began. —Instead of giving you time to rest *with* your friends, or even asking you what you needed… Well, you know what I did—. They both chuckled lightly. —However, if you hadn't been ready yet, I know we would have done all in our power to halt the war until you were.

—Well, but… I mean: everyone knew how to fight, when, and where. If I had a breakdown or something, everyone would be able to just go on without me— she insisted. —Like during the time I was in space, remember? The situation as a whole was chaotic, yet Prime showed me how you kept fighting regardless— she assured. Then her expression showed some concern as she continued —But this morning… Ugh, I still can't believe it. The council was a disaster! They honestly thought they were doomed! By themselves, they wouldn't get anything done! I had to shout at them several times because as soon as one panicked, they all collectively panicked!

Castaspella had to cover her mouth to hold her laughter, but the next moment her thoughts went to how Shadow Weaver would have commented that they *are* doomed without her. As her expression suddenly darkened, Glimmer's worry returned.

—They will be fine; they always are.

—Auntie, listen— the Queen spoke in a low tone. —I want you to take your time to recover, but I also want to make sure you will return to your duties as soon as possible because I can't see this place holding up for long without you knocking some reason into the council— she explained, her conflict visible all over her face. —I regret many of the terrible decisions I made while I was still trying to heal, so I don't want to push you to retake command, but I'm afraid of the consequences your absence may have.

Castaspella took a deep breath before replying —You've managed the council perfectly, Glimmer, trust me. So, feel free to intercede if you think it's necessary: they respect your authority as the Queen of Bright Moon and powerful sorceress you are—. She renewed the walk back to her room as she continued —I fully trust your judgment to solve the issues regarding… all of this… in my absence. Even without this week off, I would have preferred not to intervene. You are right about my bias.

—Then, don't worry. We'll make sure dad makes up for everything, Auntie, I promise.

Castaspella opened the door to her room and Glimmer followed her inside.

—*You* should solely focus on the fact that my brother, your father, broke his promise to the literal saviors of our world; the council should concentrate on how Micah's actions have hindered

Mystacor's performance— she explained, as she walked towards her mirror to take off her cape. —It wouldn't matter if things were like during the war but, now that we are *actually* trying to help other kingdoms, we can't afford to make mistakes such as the fiasco in Plumeria, or worse.

—At least it was only once… The others weren't that terrible— Glimmer was commenting until she interrupted herself. She noticed Castaspella's reflection in the mirror, and carefully pointed out — There's something… there on your neck.

The Head Sorceress let out an annoyed sigh; she had completely forgotten. As she placed her cape back on, she went to sit on the edge of her bed.

—I shouldn't have to say this, but don't tell your father.

—O-of course; don't worry— she quickly replied. Yet, almost immediately, her guilt returned to torment her, and she felt the need to apologize. —I'm sorry, Aunt Casta. It was my fault.

—What?— she asked calmly.

—Dad… He knew where you were at because I… told him.

—And how did you know?

—I…—, Glimmer looked away embarrassed, —I spied on you two the night before. He was insufferable and I wanted to prove to him there was nothing devious going on! It was just a few minutes… I-I left after you said you'd practice at the Lunarium—. She rushedly explained herself, not looking back at Castaspella, who let the queen speak without interrupting. —I wanted him to leave you two alone, and to stop walking around the palace complaining like a maniac, so I told him you only practiced magic when you meet at night, that I heard you speaking of going to the Lunarium. And I know he believed me, but he still went after you… I can't- I'm so sorry.

Glimmer fell to her knees, trying to hold back her tears. Castaspella left her bed and soon was kneeling in front of her; she hugged her niece in silence for a moment while she kept apologizing, her voice strained.

—You've been under a lot of pressure because of this, Dear— she whispered. —You had no obligation to mediate, yet you put so much effort into it… I don't- I can't overlook you spying on me, and I know someone must have helped you if I didn't see you inside my own room… But, I won't hold it against you either, alright?

Glimmer couldn't help hugging her tighter; she was expecting the worst scolding of her life, yet it was the exact opposite.

—I promise I was just trying to help.

—I know— she replied, finally letting go to properly look at her. She let out a faint smile seeing how her reddened eyes and cheeks, wet with tears, made her look like the young princess from years before. —However, I suppose you will have no objections if I ask you to tell me exactly who was with you and what you saw and heard.

The Queen's face reddened as she replied —Right, of course—. They both took a seat at Castaspella's desk as Glimmer explained with detail how her friends had seen her struggling to calm down Micah and convince him to stop trying to spy on them. They could only think of doing so themselves as they would "protect their privacy", while he would have made a scandal of anything. After a very long,

sometimes funny, retelling of their *mission* that night, Glimmer arrived at the moment when they noticed Catra wasn't with them. —… When she reappeared, she seemed very disturbed and didn't tell us anything, so I suppose perhaps she came to your room again, but don't know what she saw.

Castaspella only had to think for a moment before realizing.

—It's no problem, I believe I know what it was…— she admitted. —I may need to speak with her if she's still troubled about it when she's back.

—Is it bad?

—No, not at all— she quickly denied. —But I'd like to make sure she won't agonize about it for too long.

The Queen nodded and looked down at the table as she wondered —Changing subjects, why… won't you do anything about your personal affront? I- Dad can't simply hurt you like this and never face the consequences.

—Glimmer, that's a familiar quarrel, not something to be discussed officially.

—Then, can't you, at least, speak with him? You could try explaining to him that he's exaggerating, make him see what he's oblivious of.

Castaspella shook her head in denial.

—We really can't do anything about it, Dear— she replied with a sad smile. —He sees what he wants to see, I mean that literally. For instance, the evening Double Trouble tried to trick Shadow Weaver, when she dragged me to see Micah and confront him, he was "upset" because we had barged in "holding hands", according to him. But the woman was literally holding my wrist as if I had no hand at all— she explained, gesturing dramatically.

Glimmer remembered how she had willingly, much to her current regret, held hands with the sorceress to let her use her runestone magic, and considered for a moment if that could be related to Shadow Weaver grabbing Castaspella by the wrist instead.

—You have a point…

—If he sees even something that tiny distortedly, then we can't possibly change his view of this whole matter. Only when he decides to actually observe, then maybe he'll understand. But we can't- we *shouldn't* force him.

Glimmer understood; at least now she did. She hadn't noticed before, but her guilt and helplessness in this situation were slowly filling her with hatred, just like Micah felt. If her aunt hadn't stopped her, she would be seeking revenge for something that wasn't her business to begin with. So Castaspella was right: she had to focus solely on the matters that officially required her attention, while the personal side of the issue would be settled between them. And, after months of asking her father to be more understanding, shouldn't she be understanding too?

—Thank you, Auntie. I wasn't thinking clearly…

—It was nothing, Glimmer, please, don't feel bad about it. You have really been handling too much lately, you shouldn't be expected to know it all and take everything into account— she assured her.

—Yet you do.

—Not exactly… I'm just used to seeing without interfering, you know? The past few months would be the longest period of time I've dared to actually do something instead of just staying on the sidelines— she replied. —I've only ever acted when there was no choice left, or for important matters here. When it comes to how people around me interact, I never felt it was my place to interfere. It really isn't, of course, but I've realized I *can* help avoid problems or misunderstandings sometimes.

—Yes, you can. Please keep doing it— Glimmer instantly replied, making her laugh. —Well, for now just take care. But, what I meant is… if you managed to have someone like Shadow Weaver around and after more than half a year only dad wanted her gone, you definitely did something right.

—So I hope— she let out. Her expression softened for a moment before she suddenly changed subjects again. —Thank you too, Glimmer. I suppose I really needed to talk at least a bit.

—Well, I have time if you want to talk more, Auntie— she offered with a smile.

Castaspella let out a sigh and laid back in her chair.

—If you really want to know how I'm holding… It feels similar to when we thought your father had died at the hands of the Horde— she admitted. Interested, Glimmer leaned forward giving her aunt her full attention. —Once again, I'm noticing there are things I can't do, moments I can't have, without noticing the painful absence of someone I had come to take for granted— she explained. —However… normally, we are all aware of our mortality and will suffer if we weren't expecting someone's death to come so soon… But when it's someone who isn't supposed to ever be gone, be it because it's an immortal being or because it's literally a summoned spirit, how could we ever imagine we'd lose them? We can't ever be mentally prepared for something like this…

They both let out a heartfelt sigh.

—And what did you do back then when dad was taken?

—Well, I pretty much took over Bright Moon's kitchen— Castaspella confessed, looking away. —I wasn't even hungry and didn't eat much of what I cooked after all, but I needed to keep my hands busy, my mind busier, and I wasn't Head Sorceress at the time, so I spent about a month just baking all kinds of dishes.

—What!?

—You loved them! You were always so happy to have so many pastries around! I believe your mother blamed me for your sweet tooth after that, but at least she must have been glad to see you so happy— she recounted with a small smile.

—The kitchen is all yours… If you don't mind dad being around. I figure you'd prefer to stay away from him for a while.

—Oh, no, not at all— she quickly refuted. —I'd love to go cook for you and just anyone in the palace, it's very helpful. While I'm extremely furious at your father, to say the least, I'd be a hypocrite if I avoided him for this. And it wasn't any different with Angella back then, you know? I won't make this worse than necessary; he's still my brother, whether he likes it or not, so if he ever wants to talk with me, I'll listen. As long as he doesn't directly attack me, I don't see why I should stay away. After all, I can understand what provoked his reaction; it pains me, I'm… grieving. But, if he wants to interact with me, I won't just shut him down, Glimmer.

—That means… you forgive him?

—I won’t ever *forget* what he did, and how he never spared a thought for me at all, but I forgive him because I refuse to let hatred overtake me as it did to him— she replied with a serious expression. —Forgiving is a personal thing; I forgive him for myself. To heal.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you were able to read this correctly. If not, hopefully, the rest of the chapters will make sure you do.

I am not angry, you all can love and hate whoever you want, but do me a favor and don't misread what Casta says word by word. If she was being sarcastic, I would have said it. If she was saying something with second intentions, you'll know so from her thoughts. If I did not clarify any such things, then take her words literally, not as a "subtlety" but as her directly speaking her mind about the matter.

Again, I'm not mad, just a bit concerned I may be writing this wrong. But I really hope you can enjoy this, so I'll try not to insist on this matter.

Until next week it is

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Apologizing to the people you hurt instead of thinking they are being dramatic
Status: Slowly overcoming rejection issues

Chapter Notes

Yes, you will see the woman was, in fact, *very* afraid of being distracted herself, as Casta commented in C-a-S Ch13 XD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She had no sense of time in that dark nothingness and had no idea how long she had managed to keep all feelings at bay when a wave of pain came from Castaspella through the spell. A reminder that the sorceress could still feel her; this wasn't the first time she had felt this emotion from the Head Sorceress and, soon, a memory came to disturb her.

Shadow Weaver held a book right in front of her face. This was one of the few occasions for her to read as, usually, the Head Sorceress would be too busy, and only when the woman took a break at the library could she enjoy reading a book. They sat on a couch in companionable silence; she was so immersed in her reading she never noticed Castaspella had already left her book on the small table next to her, seemingly too tired to continue.

A moment later, the sorceress laid down, resting her head on Shadow Weaver's lap, yet she completely ignored it, focused on her reading. Once again, she hadn't really noticed when the woman dozed off until she yawned and had the *fantastic* idea of stretching her arms over her head. Just great; now she could barely focus on the book.

How could she let the sorceress distract her!?

What was she!? A teenager!?

No, no; she refused to let Castaspella's stupid games mess with her.

—Would you *stop* doing that?— she let out, her sight on the book, but her attention inevitably on the Head Sorceress.

—What? Stretching my arms?— she asked, genuinely confused.

—Yes. I am trying to read here— Shadow Weaver replied angrily.

—How can I possibly- I'm not trying to bother you in any way!

—Well, you do. I'd like to focus.

—Don’t tell me I’m *distracting* you— the sorceress realized, her tone more teasing now.

—Just cut it.

—Why? You can perfectly control your eyes. Can’t you, Spin?— she kept taunting her, trying to imitate her tone when she did the same.

—Woman…

—Say…

The sorceress kept the teasing tone, closed her eyes, and stretched even more.

—That’s it. Stop!— Shadow Weaver insisted, slamming the book shut.

However, Castaspella only continued, taking it a step further like the sorceress always did; she walked her fingers up the right side of her chest, taunting —Can’t take a little teasing?

Shadow Weaver immediately grabbed her wrist, pulled her up, and left her sitting on the couch again. The next moment, as if she hadn’t just rudely pushed the Head Sorceress away, the woman opened the book again.

—Better— she sighed.

Castaspella crossed her arms in front of her chest, mildly annoyed and trying to look more offended than she really was, then asked —Why are *you* allowed to tease me like that but I can’t?

—I didn’t say that— she replied, looking at the book yet still unable to actually read.

—Well, the way you pushed me away says otherwise— she reproached in an obvious taunt.

Shadow Weaver moved aside the book, keeping it open with her thumb this time, and looked back at her defiantly.

—You’re getting the wrong idea, Cas— she teased. Right after, she leaned forward and continued —It’s not that you can’t tease me…—. Her free hand held one of Castaspella’s locks as she kept approaching; soon, she was close enough that the sorceress thought Shadow Weaver would touch the corner of her mouth with her lips. Instead, she lingered and finally whispered —You just can’t tease me like I tease you, because you’d never dare go as far—. The Head Sorceress felt chills at how malicious that had sounded, yet the woman managed to make it worse when she added —You’re far too respectful and *nice* for that.

Shadow Weaver noticed her trembling, breathless and flustered at the proximity; *that* is proper teasing. However, the next moment Castaspella withdrew, her expression genuinely offended this time. It didn’t matter to her, now she was sure the woman wouldn’t attempt that again, and could return to her reading.

A moment later, the Head Sorceress stood up, turned around, and walked away muttering with a sour tone —Whatever.

Soon enough, Shadow Weaver’s summoned body lost its density, the book fell and she had to stand up from the couch she couldn’t sit on anymore.

How dramatic of her. It wasn’t that serious, was it?

She didn’t want to dwell on it. Instead, she ignored the sorceress’ reaction and the strong feeling she felt from the spell bound to Castaspella. None of that should matter to her, the woman was being too sensitive for sure.

It couldn’t have affected her that much, right?

However, the hours went by and the Head Sorceress hadn’t once looked for her needing advice or anything. Shadow Weaver decided to look for her as she could no longer stand the ghostly feeling of that summoned form, but every time she managed to find her, the woman would let out an excuse, convincing or not, and promptly leave to fulfill some other duty of hers.

Fine, so she was actually offended, how *mature* of her. In that case, perhaps a few hours of brooding were necessary. Besides, Shadow Weaver was sure she could simply find her later, when she retired to her room, and all this drama would finally end.

As expected, the sorceress arrived at her room as soon as she finished with her duties, and Shadow Weaver didn’t lose a second.

—Good evening, stranger. Think you’re now free enough?— she mocked her.

Castaspella snarled at her in a way she hadn’t seen since before that fateful exploration for the failsafe. Her whole body tensed as she pointed at the door; there was no mistaking her anger, even if Shadow Weaver told herself she was just exaggerating or even testing her.

—Out of my room! Now!— she ordered.

—As if I couldn’t just come back through the walls or the closed door— she teased, fully convinced the woman wasn’t serious.

Yet, contrary to what she expected, the Head Sorceress only got angrier; enough to grab her by the arm, pull her to the door and push her outside. Right after, she turned around to cast a spell on the door to her room while the woman stared at her, all too shocked to react. As soon as she was done, Castaspella re-entered her room and looked back, frowning.

—Now you can’t— she sentenced before slamming the door shut.

She didn’t just do that.

How *could* she do that!?

How *dared* she betray her too!?

Shadow Weaver could feel her anger building, and she wanted nothing more than to tear down the door with her claws. And yet, something suddenly froze her for a moment.

The painful feeling she received through the spell was impossible to ignore this time. Her rage suddenly vanished as she could now hear a faint sobbing behind the door. The woman looked down at her hands, still tense and ready to pierce her way in, and little by little relaxed them. Realization slowly took over her, much to her displeasure, but she couldn’t force herself to avoid it this time.

Had she been dismissive of genuine feelings, thinking they were mere dramatism? Had she purposely ignored how her words completely destroyed her?

No. She hadn't even spared a thought for it.

That wasn't "her thing", but for something she considered so unimportant, it certainly got her worked up pretty quickly.

Perhaps she had made a mistake.

Another two days went by. Shadow Weaver was still unable to comprehend why Castaspella was so affected, why she felt so hurt, and why she kept avoiding her. And when she couldn't, like during the classes, she would speak the bare minimum and with great bitterness. It felt *so much* like her interactions with Micah before he got chipped. However, what she hated the most was how the Head Sorceress wouldn't reply to a single tease, how she put effort into keeping her out of her personal space, and seemed to find it unbearable to be in the same room with her.

What *was* her problem!?

How… how could she be so *petty*!?

And why was she herself getting angrier the longer this dragged on!?

Shadow Weaver finally got so frustrated one night that, upon seeing Castaspella promptly leaving the Lunarium, and ignoring that she was calling out to her, she finally exploded.

—You're acting like a child!— she yelled.

The Head Sorceress froze for a second before turning around, indignant.

—*I* am acting like a child?— she repeated, her tone severe. —*You* behaved like a bitch. *You* pretended it was nothing. *You* have not, a single time, attempted to apologize or approach seriously to at least ask what was wrong!— she rebuked. —I can understand you're too apathetic to realize what you did *when* it happened. But even *after* I made it clear how offended I am… you *still* pretended it had been nothing! And *now* you dare get angry!? So you *suddenly* have feelings!?

—Fine, fine… I'm sorry or whatever. Not my fault you're so sensitive— Shadow Weaver sputtered, rolling her eyes and crossing her arms in front of her chest.

—No, you're not. You're *obviously* not sorry. For that poor excuse of an apology, better shut up— she snarled, right before turning around, ready to leave.

Immediately, the woman was behind Castaspella, grabbing her arm to keep her from leaving. The sorceress didn't pull away, just looked back at her and held her sight, as if daring her to speak again.

Shadow Weaver just stared angrily at her for a while, breathing heavily, but gradually loosened her grip on her arm.

Finally, she released the Head Sorceress and took a deep breath before beginning —I hadn't noticed… how much it affected you. I don't think you *can't* tease me—. Castaspella silently

waited for her to continue. The woman seemed to be struggling with her words or the shame, and looked away as she admitted —It's the opposite… that's why I tried to dissuade you.

The sorceress was confused but noticed how hard she was trying, and preferred to be more lenient.

—Why not tell me you felt uneasy with that?

—And admit how much you got to me?— she countered, smirking with clear disgust.

—I was *just* doing what you always do to me; what you felt is what I *always* feel, but I genuinely thought you could, I don't know, control it better than me. So I never…— Castaspella interrupted her own argument, noticing she was digressing. —You could have said it. *I* would never judge you for it, nor would I tell anyone. You *know* that.

—No, no. You *really* don't understand. But…—, the woman sighed, resigned. —I should have known you're *not* like me.

Castaspella looked down and let out a long sigh, finally letting her posture relax completely.

—I suppose that's… good for a first *heartfelt* apology— she admitted, with an ambiguous tone.

The next moment, she looked up again and Shadow Weaver noticed a small smile that brought her more relief than expected, which allowed her to tease the sorceress as usual.

—Bold of you to presume I have a heart.

—Oh, please, you *almost* teared up!

—In your dreams!

—How did you know that was my dream!?— Castaspella mocked her, letting out a loud laugh as they both began walking back to her room.

—Suddenly I'm missing how distant you were— she commented, pretending to be annoyed but smirking.

—Uh, sure, woman. Keep telling yourself that— the sorceress replied. —Now come on.

Soon, they arrived at Castaspella's room and, while she dismissed the spell she had set, Shadow Weaver pointed out —I must say your barrier was pretty much perfect, congratulations.

—Thank you— she accepted proudly. Right after, she opened the door and told her —Come in, you have a lot of work to catch up on.

Castaspella showed her several piles with scrolls and documents, among other things, stacked on her desk.

She could remember they had stayed up all night sorting those…

There was no doubt; what she felt from the sorceress now was just like that time: hurt. It could have been caused by anything; something deeply hurt her and there was no telling whether it was some argument with Micah or, perhaps, she was also assaulted by now-sorrowful memories.

In any case, this only made her look back at how cruel she had been.

Was she now regretting her idiocy? How would she even know whether it was regret or something else? She couldn't recall ever feeling regret…

Except…

No, she did once regret, and a lot, what she had done. But she had also told herself it was necessary, so such regret didn't last. What she did to Micah in Mystacor, what she did to Catra in the Fright Zone prison; she had so easily found reasons why it was "necessary", but now couldn't justify this. And, perhaps, none of that could actually be justified.

Did they also want an apology like Castaspella demanded? Perhaps, long ago, they did. It was no longer worth it… Yet the sorceress would surely tell her she had to.

And if she was right? And if even a very late but genuine apology could somehow help them heal?

For once, she was actually wishing Castaspella's naïve beliefs were in fact true. Even if she still wouldn't dare try, even if part of her couldn't start formulating any kind of apology… another part of her had hoped to make up for all of that even before dying. And she now knew she hadn't, at all, achieved that.

Could she ever accomplish it? Perhaps no; but she owed them at least trying.

Chapter End Notes

I'm half sure hardly no one reads these notes, but…
Look, guys. I love your comments, and this is for you to have fun, but *I can't enjoy writing this* if all the effort I put into realistically representing reactions to trauma, character growth, and understanding/compassion, will just be misread and/or watered down to mere "they r gay, ur honor"
Honestly, it's fun and all, but I have been unable to work on the fic since I posted the last chapter, because Castaspella was misread, *grossly* misread, and it made me notice how all of Micah's trauma is seriously being dismissed, and how none of SW's progress, despite being so minimal, has been acknowledged for what it is.
I KNOW already that you read this chapter as "SW has feelings for Casta and won't admit it", but that is NOT the point here. Please READ: This is so early on C-a-S that not even 2 months have gone by, Casta still calls her "Spin" when in private; SW has no feelings other than respect for her yet, perhaps something akin to friendship was growing but that would be all. What happened here, was that SW *finally, for the first time* had to acknowledge she HURT someone, and it wasn't Casta being dramatic. She had to FEEL what Casta was feeling, which worked as a wake-up call. This was a small PROGRESS of SW, not mere "gayness".

Really, I will keep saying it: I adore you guys, and I know you're here for the lesbian disasters, but it HURTS me to see you ignore all of that. Full disclosure: I had to go through this kind of growth process, I'm still on it, and seeing it all boiled down to "SW being gay for Casta" is driving me crazy. Besides, dismissing Micah's trauma is like feeding my intrusive thoughts that say what I did to him wasn't "that bad", and that he isn't traumatized but rather just "being a jerk", and *none of that is true*. I can't stress this enough: SW, back as LS, heavily traumatized

him; just like I did to my brother. We were under the delusion we were doing the right thing but we became their personal nightmare, and only if we admit as much can we grow.
I *almost* changed this chapter to a flashback when Casta reproaches exactly this to SW, but I had no motivation to write…

I am sorry for this outburst, but this has been the worst week of my life, solely because of this. I cannot go through this again. PLEASE, I'm begging you. READ this mindfully. Enjoy it too, but don't twist it, please.
You want to hate Micah and praise SW, go ahead, it's your life, but know I don't agree; I don't hate SW because it's like hating myself and I've done enough of that and it's useless, but I do loath her behaviour because it's what I've been trying to unlearn. I had to be more gentle with myself, like Casta is being to her, so I could start growing. THAT is what you are reading.

I apologize for the grim note, but I'm afraid I will lose all motivation to continue this if I don't state this clearly.
For now, see you next week.

Too Gentle

Chapter Summary

After that much-needed conversation between aunt and niece, Queen Glimmer finds herself pondering again. Although her head is much clearer, she's still troubled, there are things she can't quite understand yet, and mostly they have in common Casta's attitude towards them.

»Perhaps we should make them sit and talk again? Auntie said we can’t push dad into opening his eyes, but… She really did open mines without intending it.
»—So if we have them sit for dinner together once again…
»—…she may knock some sense into him!— she exclaimed.
»—Glimmer, I feel like you want your aunt to punch someone— he replied, clearly concerned.
»—Maybe she should! She’s been too gentle to people who do not deserve it!

And, perhaps, Glimmer isn't that wrong…

Chapter Notes

I love this chapter so much; it's deep while also funny, I enjoyed writing it! It was so cathartic! Hope you guys like it!!

Edit: sorry, I had forgotten the summary; I've been a bit distracted this week, you may imagine why

Anyways, enjoy and until next week, I guess

The sun was setting over Bright Moon when Bow found Glimmer reflecting on the balcony. She had told him about her conversation with Castaspella, and how she had to tell her all they had seen and heard when they spied on them. But it had been the rest of the conversation that left Glimmer meditating in silence that evening. Bow hadn’t seen her so troubled in a while and understood it was related to how she almost did the same thing she had lectured her father about.

—Hey, Love, can I interrupt?

—Yeah, I’m done self-loathing— she replied jokingly.

—That bad?

—It could *definitely* be worse.

—And how do we make it even *less* bad?— he asked, trying to sound optimistic.

—I don’t know… Perhaps we should make them sit and talk again? Auntie said we can’t push dad into opening his eyes, but… She really did open mines without intending it.

—So if we have them sit for dinner together once again…

—…she may knock some sense into him!— she exclaimed.

—Glimmer, I feel like you want your aunt to punch someone— he replied, clearly concerned.

—Maybe she should! She's been too gentle to people who do *not* deserve it!

Bow realized she was boiling with anger and couldn't think of any way to calm her down. However, it seemed like there was something else to her words, so he focused on that instead.

—When you say "people who don't deserve it", who do you mean?

Glimmer looked away for a moment before resignedly answering him, knowing he wouldn't tell anyone.

—At first, I really thought Shadow Weaver didn't deserve her gentleness, not after all she had done, even to me. But… she was right to do so and, if I'm honest, in my case I did ask for it.

—No, you just accepted lending her your power, never allowed her to completely deplete you of it— he reminded her.

—But when you told her she was hurting me, she stopped!— Glimmer retorted. —Look, I'm not justifying her, but Aunt Casta was right. Shadow Weaver has done awful things out of cruelty, but most times she hasn't even realized the damage she caused.

—Which is exactly the issue with her! She doesn't bother enough to have such care.

—Well, that's the thing, no? I disagreed with my aunt's treatment, and yet it was just what was needed; I've watched some of her classes, and I noticed at first she was still prone to do those nasty things we've seen, but Casta stopped her every time. After so many months, she would rarely do anything like that, making her classes some of the most interesting lectures I've watched! And you should have seen those kids' faces when I told them she'd never teach them again. They are truly fond of her, Bow!

—So what you mean is… Your aunt's judgment was correct.

—Yes… I suppose— she replied, doubting again. —But It wasn't just about Shadow Weaver, you know?— she continued, her expression more sorrowful. —She has also been too gentle to dad, and that councilman who wanted to spy on them, and even… to me— she finally admitted.

Bow approached and carefully hugged her. The Queen rested her head against his shoulder and sobbed.

—I understand why you think she shouldn't treat nicely neither your dad nor that councilor, but why do you think she should be harsh with you? It's not like you *wanted* to spy on her, Babe— he reminded her. —You did it to protect her from your father.

—Guess what? Both dad and the councilor wanted to do it "to protect her from Shadow Weaver". I was no better and didn't even manage to help at all. I did the exact opposite!

Bow hugged her tighter.

—It wasn't your fault, Glimmer. It wasn't.

—It was…

—No, it wasn't. You know she'd tell you if it was— he insisted. After a few minutes of silently hugging her, he offered —Would you like me to invite her for dinner? Even if she won't speak with the King, she may like the company, right?

—Yeah, I suppose…

With a faint smile, he let go and kissed her briefly before setting off to Mystacor.

Nevertheless, since Bow's arrival at the island, around half an hour went by and he was still unable to find the Head Sorceress. He asked several people about her, but no one had seen her, and her room was empty. At some point, a pair of sorcerers told him the past months they had been resorting to Shadow Weaver's help to find the Head Sorceress whenever they urgently needed her, so no one had a clue where to begin looking.

Giving up, as he was getting no useful information, he decided to check every room that would usually be empty, those places the people of Mystacor would rarely visit. Much to his surprise, before another hour had gone by, he found her at a storage room, full of food supply boxes and crates.

He discreetly took out his tracker pad and sent Glimmer a message asking her to find him as soon as possible at Mystacor's storage rooms, then carefully approached Castaspella, who was sitting on the only table and chair in the place.

—Excuse me, Your Majesty?

—Oh! Look at that! It's my nephew-in-law— she began, completely flustering him. —No, no, wait, you aren't married yet. The boyfriend then, you *are* her boyfriend, right?— she babbled, obviously out of her mind.

—"Bow" is fine, your Majesty— he assured her, nervously.

—Then… "Castaspella" is fine, *Bow*— she replied, light-heartedly mocking him. —Or "Casta", consider yourself part of the family already!

—I'm sorry to bother you, Castaspella, are you alright?— he asked, starting to worry.

—I'm fine…— she assured him. Right then, Glimmer arrived and stared at the confusing scene. —Oh, Glimmer! Look, I'm talking with your boyfriend.

—What the… Not again— Glimmer muttered. Addressing Bow, she whispered —Did you see her drink something?

—She just has a cup there, but hasn't touched it since I arrived— he assured her.

—Hey, Auntie, what are you doing here?

Sitting at that small table, the woman stared at the cup in front of her, and absentmindedly began speaking —I once found her here, you know?—. Bow and Glimmer exchanged a confused look but wouldn't dare interrupt. —It's so odd… I came to find her because I felt her upset with this… spell thing, it was like the feeling of longing or nostalgia— she continued. Then she let out a dry laugh before saying —Can you believe it was just because she misses drinking wine!? Can you believe it!? I

swear, that woman has a rock for a heart. What even is so amusing about *wine*?—. She laughed again, sadder this time, and looked into the cup before adding —I made fun of her for that… And she didn't complain. She never complained when I mocked her. Why wouldn't she if I *wasannoying* her? I heard so many things she did, from your friend, Catra, about how the tiniest of things would easily anger her, and yet…

Her voice lost strength until she simply stopped speaking. Glimmer looked back at Bow and they exchanged a look of understanding.

—She doesn't have her powers anymore, Casta, she wouldn't have done anything even if she wanted to— Bow reminded her.

—And she has never tried to hurt you either, Auntie— Glimmer added.

—Still! Someone so irascible as her would at least yell at me or something!— she insisted. —I'm *very* well aware I sometimes can't take a hint. All that polite people I *ususually* have around just… silently slip away, you know, like you'd do, Glimmer— she continued, making it obvious she wasn't sober. —But she stayed…

—I… I didn't know you had… noticed— the Queen let out, embarrassed.

—It's fine, Dear, I don't mind— she quickly dismissed her, her voice sloppy and her tone light-hearted enough to reassure them she honestly didn't mind. —It was a good way to realize I had to shut up already.

—Perhaps she didn't mind being teased?— Bow suggests.

—She!?— Castaspella exclaimed. With a loud laugh, she laid back on her chair, almost falling back. Once she calmed down, she replied —No, no. She likes laughing at others, never being mocked herself, no…

—What if she only allowed *you* to tease her? It's obvious you're special for her— Bow insisted.

Castaspella laughed loudly once again. Perhaps louder.

—*Special*!? Me!? Oh, no, no. I am *not* the special one. Wrong sibling— she retorted, dragging the words even more than before, but with a hint of bitterness this time. —You *perfectly* know who's the *talentedandspecial*… How did she call him? "Sweet".

—Wait, what are you talking about?— Glimmer asked, staring with consternation.

—Your father! It has *always* been Micah! The "sweet" Micah, the "talented" Micah, the "gifted" Micah. *He* is the special one *for'er*!

—But he *hates* her! And she *knows* it!— her niece exclaimed.

—Yeah but it's like… like your friends, no?— she replied, nonchalantly. —She told me how she kept trying to get Adora back, and never cared that Catra was still there with her. I know she's still more focused on him, I'm sure…— she continued, visibly angry. —I just hope Catra didn't feel like she *needed* to stay by her side to be worthy; she doesn't deserve to have gone through that too— she reflected.

Glimmer remained silent, wanting to speak yet not daring to.

The next moment, Bow gave her a look of encouragement and she finally asked —Is that how *you* feel, Auntie?

—It was thanks to her that I was confident enough to fight Horde Prime's forces… or to help you when Mermista almost drowned us!? *I'msorry*, Dear, but otherwise I'd have never thought myself of any use to you. Not to fight, at least…

—I- Auntie, what do you mean?

—It's… well… it's silly, but… I was not ready to fight— she admitted, her voice weak. —I'd try, I-I always try. It's just that… if she hadn't told me to trust I had enough power to be of assistance, I wouldn't have helped you when you needed it—. Her expression of sorrow almost made the Queen tear up. —I was even afraid you'd be unable to fight your dad's black magic and… y-you *could*, you-you overpowered it! I can hardly believe only *she* fully trusted your powers and even *I* doubted you! I sound like an awful aunt and a coward! But I was so afraid… I really, *really* needed that old hag to tell me you could! That I could… She's not someone who fake-praises people, more like… real praises burn her inside out— she joked with a smirk. —I knew she really meant it, and *boom*, confidence!

Her exaggerated moves at the end made Bow and Glimmer hold back a giggle; it was almost endearing to see her so loosened for once.

But they understood it was time to take her back to her room and approached as Bow said —You've accomplished a lot in the past few months, Casta. And it wasn't all her doing, it was mostly you. Aren't you feeling more confident now?

—I… don't know? Maybe?— she replied with a weak tone, and rested her head on the table. —I feel less… useless than before. I've learnt a lot… But I *want'er* here.

With an expression of deep concern and sadness, the Queen carefully helped the Head Sorceress up from her seat.

—Let me take you to your room, Auntie— she whispered. —You just… miss her.

Glimmer teleported both Castaspella and Bow into the woman's empty chambers and left her laying on the bed. As she seemed unwilling to speak anymore, they both left the room and walked away down the hall.

—*That* was a metaphorical punch to everyone who deserved it. But I'm strangely glad— Glimmer commented light-heartedly.

—Hey, um… If your aunt was so tipsy from half a cup of wine; how did she even *survive* that time she drank a whole bottle of sake?— Bow asked with concern, ignoring her observation.

—That was half a cup!? I can't believe it!— she exclaimed, indignant. —Aunt Casta isn't really a drinker; I swear it had never happened before that night… and now she probably didn't eat at all, so it *really* hit her badly.

Bow looked away, pensive for a moment.

—Babe… I think Casta must really love her if she went there and tried wine *just* because of the anecdote she told us and not because she wanted to drink— he reflects.

—I suppose… wait! You called her "Casta"! Several times!— she suddenly noticed.

—Yeah… before you arrived she told me to call her so— he explained. —I wasn't sure about it but, it felt like she could use some kindness— Bow admitted with a shy smile.

—She told you…?— Glimmer repeated, staring at him with eyes full of love. She hugged him tightly, squealing, and said —She considers you part of the family!

—Does she?— he asked, flushing as he remembered Castaspella's initial greeting.

—I'm so happy!

Bow caressed her hair and hugged her back.

—Then I'm glad, Love— he whispered with a smile.

The next morning, worried after leaving her aunt in such a questionable shape, the Queen went to Mystacor early in the morning to check on her.

—Aunt Casta? Are you awake?— she asked, as she knocked on the door.

—Yes, come in.

Glimmer expected to find her in a state similar to the previous day, however, she found her aunt knitting on her bed, both her cape and crown discarded on the sofa, and noticed dark marks under her eyes. She hadn't rested at all, again.

—Auntie, did you sleep last night?

—Not a second, Dear.

Her voice seemed energetic, but her expression couldn't reflect it at all, which worried her niece even more.

—Please, you should try to sleep— she insisted.

—Oh, I've tried, I did— she assured her. She continued knitting while looking at Glimmer as she said —You see. Every time I close my eyes, I see- I see her vanish. Or, if I pass out from exhaustion, I suddenly wake up with that… pain in my chest—. She let out a long sigh. —If it's not one thing, it's the other.

—But… Wait, is that supposed to happen?

The Queen was about to argue yet Castaspella's knitting called her attention as her red thread suddenly changed colors mid knitting. And she was absolutely sure her aunt had *never* used black wool before.

—You *have* to be kidding me!— the Head Sorceress muttered, annoyed. —She really messed up my yarns!?

—Wait, what!?

—Last week she said next time I knitted I'd "think about her". She was mocking me, and I *absolutely* didn't expect her to pull a prank like this!— she complained, more annoyed than usual.

—Why would she do that?

—Revenge for my prank.

—I… Okay, I don't want to know— Glimmer sentenced with a serious expression. —Auntie, please try to sleep. If possible, right now. Just do me that favor before sleep deprivation makes you lash out at the tiniest of things.

—So you're saying the lack of sleep will turn me into her?— she replied with a smirk.

—Now that I think about it, yes. You and anyone— she admitted, surprised by the question.

—I was joking.

—That proves you have to rest!— she yelled, indignant.

Castaspella laughed lightly as she set aside her knitting.

—You sound like your mother when you get angry.

—I… know— she replied, both nostalgic and sad. —I'll come back later, alright? Try to sleep, Auntie.

Once Glimmer had closed the door behind her, the Head Sorceress let out a long sigh. How was she supposed to sleep? She needed it, wanted to sleep, but this wasn't just her usual trouble to fall asleep like before. Now it was the pain, the memories; it was all unbearable.

—You just *had* to become so important, didn't you?— she muttered. —And now… what even is that sting I keep getting from you?— she asked, as if Shadow Weaver could listen. —What is happening to you now, Bea? What am I supposed to do?

For a second, she imagined her standing next to her closet, smirking defiantly, like every time she helped while also laughing at her misery. Wouldn't be caught dead, literally speaking, being nice without being mean at the same time.

Her funny little imagination made her realize she had forgotten to put away her cape and crown so, knowing she wouldn't fall asleep any time soon, she went to get it done. However, after hanging her cape and before she could close the door of the closet, she noticed a box full of vials, sitting at the back behind her shoes, and took it out, curious about its contents.

Around twenty tiny vials, half full with translucent liquids, filled the box, accompanied by a single scroll. It was a sleeping potion. The notes in the scroll explained how to make it and instructed her to take a really small dose so it would only *help* sleep.

It had to be her doing. But why would she? Perhaps she didn't want to continue helping her sleep with illusions. She couldn't have known Micah would pretty much kick her from the walking world like that so, what other reason could she have? Unless it was because Castaspella had told her she didn't want to bother her with that?

Whatever the reason, she couldn't help feeling a wave of deep sorrow at the thoughtful detail. She felt like crying, she wanted to scream and hit something, but she had no strength left in her. As silent tears

fell down her cheeks, she opened a vial and drank a bit; leaving the box and the scroll on her desk, she threw herself on the bed, and soon enough sleep claimed her.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Trust
Status: 80% download complete

Chapter Notes

I had to! I kept laughing about it, but I had to!

Guess who reopened Tumblr?
It's been so long, oh my…
Anyways: whoever reads me, uses Tumblr, and would like to follow the updates there, here it is
However, I'm still far more active on twt, oh, but now I also spoil if asked on Tumblr so XD at your our risk, dears
And before I forget: Go see THIS
Cana did an amazing job TT^TT I'm so happy, I love it
Just go see it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She was suspended, with no up or down, no solid surface to be touched, no light to be seen. And yet, she could feel her body moving: it was probably the energy around the core, spiraling in loops around her, but it felt so much like a dance. Yes, a dance, just as fluid, just as smooth, just… Like the few times they danced. She recalled that one night, not when the Moons of Enchantment aligned, but rather the day of Castaspella's birthday.

Shadow Weaver had been wandering around Mystacor all day, one of the few things she kept doing since her summoning, but as she had been a tutor again for some weeks now, she was nostalgic perhaps and wanted to see how much everything had changed.

It had come to her attention that plenty of the sorcerers she came across with that day mentioned this was "the Head Sorceress' free day", yet she gave it little importance at first. Curiosity got the best of her when she found Castaspella in the dark of her room that night and she couldn't help asking about it.

—Did I hear right? Today would be your birthday?— she asked her. The sorceress nodded, barely sparing her a look, while comfortably sitting in front of her desk. —I'm surprised you don't make more of an event about it— she mocked her.

—No, no. I wouldn't— she immediately replied, confusing Shadow Weaver for a moment. —I like parties and organizing them but, being the center of attention? I rather not— she added, with a bitter laugh.

The woman slowly approached, while urging her to continue —So you just…

—Shared a meal with my brother, my niece, and her friends. Yes.

—I see.

Shadow Weaver remained pensive for a moment, just standing next to the sorceress. She had read her all wrong; Castaspella kept defying every presumption she made, and she had the feeling this wouldn't stop any time soon.

—What is it, Spin?— she asked her, genuinely interested.

—I was just curious— the woman dismissed her, yet the sorceress didn't buy it.

—Well… It's not like I can invite you to sit and have a drink with me, but I welcome the company if you're *free* now— she teased her.

—Well, it's not like I'd accept that juice for babies you drink— she replied in the same way, copying the tone and wording.

—It suddenly makes sense how you felt nostalgic about wine— Castaspella let out, deadpan. —And if you had *ever* tried sake, you wouldn't call it "juice for babies"— she added, almost offended. Then, it occurred to her —But have you *tried* drinking anything?

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes as she asked —Where exactly would the liquid go!? I'm just a dense illusion!

It was pretty obvious, yes, but the Head Sorceress had been noticing a few things that were now causing her confusion.

—But, the other day when the vial exploded, the shards were stuck in your body until I got far enough— she pointed out.

—True, but even so, I'd still not even *try* to drink, lest you want to spill some good wine— the woman countered, smirking mockingly at the end.

—Fine! Fine! Never mind…— Castaspella surrendered. Mildly annoyed, she muttered —I won't *ever* suggest anything to comfort you ever again.

The woman gestured dismissively and rolled her eyes once more, replying —Don't be so dramatic—. She slowly passed behind the sorceress as she strode to the opposite side of the desk, commenting —There are things other than sharing a drink that can be done, if you so want to—. She extended her hand, and Castaspella carefully took it, while Shadow Weaver added, grinning, —This time we shouldn't have unexpected effects, no?

Soon, they both were gracefully swiveling in the small space available inside the room, letting the light of the moons wash over them every time they slid past the window; the Head Sorceress allowed the woman to guide her once again and felt the flowy movement relax her more with each step.

Once all tension had abandoned her, Castaspella looked up at her and let out —I… thank you, I guess—. Unsure, she finally admitted —It really isn't a good day for me.

—Why?

—When we thought Micah had died… it just became very difficult.

Shadow Weaver kept guiding her, not a step out of sync, and after a brief silence, she finally said —I see.

Neither of them said another word. For some more hours, they both continued dancing to some inaudible melody. The sky was still dark when Castaspella began feeling sleepy; the sorceress easily noticed and gradually slowed down the pace.

—Thanks— she yawned.

—You don't need to keep thanking me, woman— Shadow Weaver replied, her tone serious yet light-hearted.

—Uh, sure.

The Head Sorceress was already too sleepy and possibly hadn't heard her at all, so she preferred to walk her towards the couch.

—You're…—, she sighed, taking a seat and guiding her to sit down too. Castaspella was obviously too sleepy, she didn't even hesitate to lay down and rest her head on her lap. —You're too naïve.

The dark sorceress would have never imagined anyone could feel comfortable enough with her to drop all defenses, yet this wouldn't be the last time it happened.

Indeed.

Just like that night, Castaspella made herself comfortable on her lap plenty of times later on. She'd easily fall asleep with her around and kept allowing her to just "take care" of her; an exact opposite of Micah, always alert and expecting her to backstab him. She never understood why the sorceress wasn't wary of her, or rather, it became obvious she was, yet not at all times, as if she knew when she had bad intentions and when not; so she had always found far more logical her brother's extreme reaction. There was no denying how much the Head Sorceress actually trusted her, for some odd reason, but it was true that, now, she also fully trusted Castaspella.

She trusted the sorceress.

She just *knew* she would stubbornly look for a way to get her back. Since displaying such lack of fear after that night, and until her last demonstration of stubborn confidence even when she threatened to sink her claws into her throat, the woman proved as much.

She had insisted one couldn't just "know" what someone else would do, that behaviour can be predictable but loyalty is too ephemeral… Yet there she was, "knowing" what the sorceress would do; Castaspella had managed to prove those ideas wrong, and now she just spontaneously trusted the Head Sorceress, without a shadow of a doubt.

As she was unable to stop the sudden wave of regret, nostalgia, hate, anger, and powerlessness, more pain invaded her, and it took all her will to control the damage it could possibly cause the sorceress… Supposing the spell was still on her.

Of course she still had it on; just like Castaspella knew she wouldn't hurt her no matter what, now she also knew the Head Sorceress would keep the spell.

She’s too sentimental to let it go…

But this time, perhaps… she even *wants* to believe the sorceress hasn't just gotten over her.

Chapter End Notes

Funny story time:
When I first wrote this, I was making a reference to how Casta had found her dancing back in C-a-S, “as if some invisible magical current guided her around”, so I got mixed up and wrote “dancing to some invisible melody” (x-\)
I laughed for a whole minute but I wanted to cry, gods, *invisible* melody, I’m an idiot XD

And again: Go see THIS (Yes, Cana’s FanArt, just go, see it, love it!)

That’s it, see you next week!

It is not about fixing

Chapter Summary

The aftermath of Shadow Weaver's banishment still affects Mystacor and its council: her pupils have decided to riot.
Fortunately, Castaspella can perfectly manage them, yet someone else needs her now. The Queen's concerns and worries have peaked, she can't take it anymore, she needs her aunt's help; after how understanding she had been with her, and now that she looks more rested, she dares open up and ask for counsel.

»—(…)I just don't know who is good and who is bad!— she ranted, speaking quickly, gesturing nervously, and only briefly looking at her aunt; she kept her sight down, embarrassed or angry at herself. —Am I bad for what I've done? Is dad bad for ignoring how you feel and everything you tried to tell him? Is Shadow Weaver bad for being such a monster to Adora and Catra? We all think so, but then, how come she was so necessary? Not only during the last years of the war, but also lately. Mystacor would have literally fallen if it wasn't because of her knowledge; the issues she helped us deal with, or how well she taught the pupils, even… I think she helped *you* a lot too; I hadn't seen you so confident in a long time, Auntie… So how- how do I know who is good and who is bad?

Chapter Notes

You know how I'm basically making Casta someone who cooks to cope, and how I've described always Asian food and drinks (cause I don't know how similar to our world is Etheria supposed to be)?
Well, my thorough investigation made me want to try some of those things, and not only have I know discovered that sake is the only alcoholic beverage I like, but also: Guess who learnt to use chopsticks to stir!! Plus, in this chapter, she's making some sweet steamed buns and I maaay or may not have just made Manju for the first time yesterday!! (TT^TT) Actually, I bought a steamer just two days ago, which I've wanted for a while, so it's great that now I can also put my research into actual use XD

Enough anecdotes, enjoy the chapter!

One last thing, an addition before I post this: Today, March 16th, it would have been the 6th day an Ukrainian teen I follow on twt was inactive, and since day 4 I had been worried sick about her; fortunately, today she entered twt and let us know she's safe
I hope everyone who reads me is well aware of the horrors that wars imply, the innocent people that suffer, on both sides, but mostly in the country that is *actually* being attacked
I mean, aren't you reading a fanfic of a series that literally took place during a years-long war? Didn't we see the sacrifices made, didn't we see the madness it could cause on people and how it caused many to take reckless action? Goodness! Just before posting this I was watching Zelenskyy addressing the US Congress and there was a video of the bombarded cities and the wounded people, and I'd be lying if I pretended that, now, I *suddenly* understand LS a lot; if it was within my reach to do something extremely risky but with any potential of stopping that

madness, I would, risks be damned. I wouldn't join the oppressing side if I failed, but those are details (not like I wasn't already, and by mere chance, using this exact concept in a draft)
But, you know what, this sounds light-hearted said like this, but the reality remains: there's a war out there, and we're all acting like the "kingdoms that are safe" in S1; we're just watching as Ukraine keeps suffering loss after loss without ever giving up. If you watched S1 and considered it was selfish of the other princesses to abandon BM, then know we're now doing the same. We are just civilians, we can't do much, but let's not pretend nothing is going on, alright?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sun was setting already when the Head Sorceress abruptly woke up, sweating, because of a sudden pain in her chest that felt like a stab. Her hair was slightly wet and stuck to her face, and she had forgotten to take off her dress, so it now felt attached to her back.

—Not again— she muttered, breathless. She carefully got up, felt dizzy for a moment before she could go for a clean dress, and finally headed to the bathroom. Once freshened up, she told herself —Just… Breathe…

As she stared into her reflection in the mirror, watching her tears fall silently, she wondered why this was happening.

Why that nightmare *again*?

Why now that she's alone?

It was probably due to the sting on her chest, but she didn't know what caused that either; perhaps if they found a way to remove the spell, she wouldn't keep suffering and the nightmare wouldn't repeat.

But what if it was unrelated?

And was she really willing to remove that spell?

Part of her stubbornly refused.

A knock on the door interrupted her thoughts right before she heard —Castaspella? Are you awake?

—Micah!?— she noticed. As she left the bathroom, she hastily washed away her tears before opening the door. —Wha-what are you doing here?

—I- Are you crying?— he realized. —What happened, Casta?

—It- It was just a nightmare, don't worry— she dismissed him, looking away.

—Are you sure? Please, tell me— he insisted.

Castaspella took a deep breath, bracing herself for his reaction as she began —With all the times you… a-and just anyone, warned me about how "dangerous" Shadow Weaver was, and how she could hurt me… I-I had this nightmare once, about precisely that. And the same just now but, this time, the pain in my chest had me see it as if she- As if she was piercing my chest with her claws.

For a moment, Micah was so shocked he had no idea how to respond. He noticed her hesitation, she was afraid yet it didn't seem like the nightmares scared her as much as telling him about it. Had he

really lost her trust like that? And had he contributed to such a terrifying dream because of his own fears?

The sorcerer let out a sigh and opened his arms, offering a hug which she couldn't reject. Micah hugged her in silence for a moment, letting his sister sob until she calmed down.

—I am sorry, Sis— he finally let out. —I'm sorry for scaring you like this, it was never my intention. I just wanted you to be careful because she's devious but… I-I know she would never do something like *that*— he assured her.

—I'm aware— she nodded. Once he let go of her, she dried her tears again and asked —Did you need me for something?

He looked away uneasily before replying —Look, the council didn't want to call you, but we definitely need your help with this. I am really trying to- I-I'm *trying*.

—It's alright, you don't have to say it— she interrupted, understanding what he meant as she noticed his struggle. —I'll go, just give me a moment.

As she turned around to go for her cape and crown, Micah remembered what he had noticed when she opened the door, now that he saw it once again, and couldn't help asking —Sis, did something happen to you? You have some… reddened skin on your neck.

—Insect bite. Should disappear soon— she replied casually, without looking back.

That couldn't *possibly* be true. Micah was sure it had to be a lie. But if she wouldn't say, then what could it be?

No, no. He was *not* going to think about the alternatives. Insect bite it was.

Moments later, they are both walking down the halls and the sorcerer can't stop looking sideways at her. He had promised Glimmer not to mention it, but it just looked so strange to him, and he had now seen it wasn't a question of laziness, but rather that she deliberately changed her hairstyle.

—Sorry to ask, Sis, but I can't help noticing how different your hair looks… loose like this. Does it- Does it resemble hers on purpose?— he asked, trying to sound as casual as possible, despite his nervousness.

—You don't want to know— she calmly replied, keeping her gaze fixed on the path ahead.

In fact, Castaspella had barely repaired on how her hair now looked similar to hers; less wavy, but almost the same length and color. Of course he would notice and ask.

But she couldn't tell him the truth, could she? He seemed calmer now, but maybe it was too soon to tell him how the sorceress had been fixing her hair every morning, how it now pained her to even think about doing it herself, or that the last night before he vanished her, she had told her she should wear it loose.

No, either he'd get angry once again, or he'll feel guilty realizing the pain he inflicted on her. One way or the other, Castaspella refused to provoke either; it was not the time.

Simultaneously, Micah understood the answer was likely affirmative but he would *not* get an explanation, and perhaps he didn't really want it. He could barely handle what he knew, he certainly

didn't want more; he promised himself he'd support his sister because she needed it, but he had a limit.

Before either of the siblings could break the tense silence that settled between them, a loud commotion called their attention. Micah didn't seem surprised, so Castaspella knew *that* had to be what the council needed help with. As they turned around the corner, they found all of Shadow Weaver's pupils crowding the entrance of the meeting room.

—Please, calm down. We can't tell you anything else.

—You should tell us the truth!

—What happened to her!? Why won't you tell us anything!?

—You've been informed of what you *have* to know!

—That's not enough!

The teenagers demanded answers, and the youngest supported however they could, echoing the demands or just standing their ground so the council couldn't leave the room, while a pair of councilors tried, and failed, to deflate the situation.

—What is going on here!?— Castaspella interrupted.

—Head Sorceress!— a councilman exclaimed, surprised but also relieved. —They won't return to their rooms, they don't want to listen to us— he affirmed.

—No! He's lying! We're here for the truth! It's not that we don't listen, it's that they are keeping it from us!— a teenager argued, making his way into the front of the group. As he stood in front of Castaspella, she could almost feel something inside her shrink painfully. —We *know* she would never abandon us. So what happened to *our* tutor!? Tell us!— he demanded, noticeably furious.

The Head Sorceress took a deep breath; of course her favorite pupil would be so much like her. Just her luck.

However, this had to be carefully handled, and she couldn't let her emotions get in the middle. Not yet.

—Councilors. Why are these children here so late?

—We called for the reunion with their parents tomorrow morning. They were not supposed to…

—We are here because they just want to change our tutor as if it was nothing, but no one will tell us what happened with *our* sorcery Master!— he interrupted again. —Are we just numbers for you? We get assigned to one teacher or the other and that's it!? *She* was teaching *us*! We don't want someone else to be our Master!

—I understand, Sahm; believe me, I do— she replied, speaking gently and trying to calm him down. —But it can't be undone now, I'm sorry— she added, placing her hands on his shoulders.

His expression went from enraged to sorrowful, but he still sounded outraged as he asked —Have we done something wrong!? Are we not good enough!? Is it because of what I did the first week!?

Castaspella couldn’t bear seeing him in such distress; she carefully pulled him into a hug and tried to calm him again. It was heartbreaking; he was anguished, furious, and clearly felt helpless as he couldn't get answers, which only led him to that conclusion.

—She did not abandon you. She didn't want to leave. I promise. It was not her choice— she sentenced, making sure all of them would listen. As she looked around, she realized they were unmotivated, sad, some even crying in silence. —None of you did anything wrong, she’s proud of all of you and your quick progress— she insisted, as she let go of Sahm.

—Then why? Why did she leave?— he asked again with a calmer tone, staring at her hoping for an answer.

But she couldn't tell them. How, just *how*, could she explain what happened? They would only hate Micah, they might even blame her for it, or accuse her of not protecting Shadow Weaver. And they would have all the right to feel that way. Yet that would fix nothing, and she simply couldn't guarantee they wouldn't react like the kids they are.

—Knowing exactly what happened won’t bring her back. There is no point in telling you— she finally replied, holding back her tears.

Once again, he was denied an answer. Looking away, he closed his fists tightly, and muttered something under his breath no one could listen. Right after, his classmates moved aside as he stalked away down the hall.

—I’ll get an answer. One way or the other— he told himself.

As everything fell silent around them, the Head Sorceress addressed the kids —I understand how all of you are feeling. If I gave you a week to rest, it is for all of you to process and accept that, from now on, Shadow Weaver won’t be teaching you again—. She took a deep breath before continuing —So please, return to your rooms now, then attend the reunion with your parents tomorrow, and take the rest of the week for yourselves, either here or back in your homes—. They finally gave up; looking dispirited, they walked away together, and the councilors were finally free to go. Only one of the kids remained, sitting against the wall nearby, an illusionary bird between their hands. Castaspella approached and sat next to them. —Ari?— she called. When they looked back at her, seemingly about to cry, she gently said —Can I ask why you stayed here?

They only curled up and tightly hugged their legs while the tiny illusion flew in loops in front of them; she patiently waited for them to speak, until they finally let out —I don’t want to go home—. The sorceress exchanged a brief look with Micah; they were both surprised and worried but preferred to wait for Ari to continue. —I- They sent me here to- to learn magic, but… to keep it under control. To keep it *hidden*— they explained, looking down at the floor. After a deep sigh, they looked back at Castaspella, and resumed, with a weaker voice, —Master told us to be proud of our magic. That- That it’s a beautiful thing!—. She nodded, holding back tears as she remember how she’d get so passionate about it; sometimes too much and not in the best way. Ari looked up as their bird flew higher, grew brighter and bigger, and finally went up in colorful flames. —I don’t want to hide this— they sighed.

The siblings couldn’t hide their sorrow; Micah looked away, ashamed of his fondness for a similar memory he had convinced himself to hate, while Castaspella could barely hide the pain this caused her. For *once* her influence had been positive, and yet, it’s still hurting Ari.

—You can always stay here if you prefer— she gently said. —Some of your classmates have been living here and there’s enough room for you to stay with them, so you can choose whether to go home or not.

A few tears rolled down their cheeks and they washed them away, replying —Thank you, Head Sorceress.

Ari leaned against her arm, silently sobbing, and she allowed it, although she wouldn't dare to comfort them in any particular way as she didn't feel confident enough. But she could, maybe, reassure them.

—I know you're sad, and that's fine, alright? It's okay to feel like this, and now we have a whole week to be as sad as we want— she spoke, trying to add some humor. —I know you'll make her proud, Ari.

Taking a deep breath, they nodded, more confident, and Micah approached, offering to help them both up. She stared as the kid left, and her brother let out a sigh of relief.

—Thank you, Casta. You're really good with kids— he began, calling her attention back to him. —While I'm just… so terrible— he continued. With a distressed expression, he recalled —You should have seen the times I tried to interact with Princess Frosta; I still think I made her hate me or something. Am I really that bad with kids? Because I seriously did everything wrong!—. He seemed very disturbed and Castaspella noticed he was speaking out of paranoia, yet she couldn't get a word in as he was talking too fast. —This- this was impossible for me to handle, really. Thank you, Sis.

She let out a bit of a sardonic snicker, and shook her head, denying —I'm not good with children, believe me. I'm either too condescending or as severe as if I were talking to an adult. Oftentimes they don't even take me seriously!—. She laughed at herself, thinking about it. —It's just that…— she began, but interrupted herself, her smile faded and she shook her head slightly. It was better to change subjects. —Ne-nevermind. Micah… Do you understand now what they are going through?

—Yes, yes. I get it— he sighed. —But why weren't they told what *actually* happened? What I… did?

Castaspella began walking, preferring not to look at him as she replied —Glimmer decided not to tell them—. He followed her closely, and it shocked him when she explained —You will have more than enough problems with Catra once she's back, and now Adora may be less willing than usual to keep you from harm's way.

—You're joking, right? Tell me you're joking… Casta!?

Hours later, Queen Glimmer found her aunt in the palace kitchen, in the middle of making a dessert, steamed buns with fruity filling. She let out a faint smile and cleared her throat so she wouldn't startle her when approaching.

—Good evening, Glimmer— she greeted, her sight still on the dough she was handling.

—Hey, Auntie. How's the cooking going?

—Without a hitch up to now— she cheerfully replied. —With some luck, there won't be any incidents — she continued. Hesitantly, she explained —I still feel that… *sting* on my chest occasionally; it only happened when I was preparing the filling but, had it happened when I was handling the steamers…

—Please don't get burnt, Auntie.

—I won't, don't worry— she laughed, still focused on her cooking instead of looking back at her niece.

Glimmer walked closer and leaned against the counter, right next to her, and asked —Could you get any sleep?

—Yes, I got a few hours of sleep, fortunately.

—Dad told me about… the nightmare? He is really sorry— she commented.

—I know— she assured her with a rather sad tone.

—And I am sorry too. You shouldn't have been called for the issue with the pupils, the council should have been able to manage that! I'm so- ugh…

—It's nothing, Glimmer, really— she replied, wanting to calm her. She spared her a glance but continued quietly making the buns. After a long silence, once she placed the last bun inside a steamer, she turned toward her niece. Her troubled expression made Castaspella ask —Is there something you wanted to talk about?

The Queen let out a long sigh.

—I'm… doubting my judgment, Auntie. I don't know if I made the right choice— she began, her conflicted gaze fixed on her hands. —I feel unable to judge who is good, who is bad, and I fear I'm making poor decisions because of that… I don't- I wonder if maybe I'm just punishing dad because I'm siding with you, or even- I mean, you know how- Ugh— she tried to explain herself, yet began stammering as she struggled with the ideas in her head. Castaspella patiently conceded to her all the time she needed until she could properly put her thoughts into words. —Look… Back when Shadow Weaver was our prisoner, I made many mistakes. I feel some decisions were bad, yet a necessary evil; others were just plain terrible or perhaps I just handled them awfully… For instance: I think it was a good decision to let Shadow Weaver teach me sorcery and concede her a bit more freedom because of that, but Adora was right to be annoyed at me for letting her roam free and unsupervised! I should have at least made the guards keep her under vigilance, and I should have told her what I was going to do! But I didn't think about it, I was so- I was like now: confused, doubting myself but trying to make decisions regardless, feeling like I have to do *something* or I'm a failure, and that it's expected from me to make the right decisions, but I can't even tell if I was right to do this to dad… He feels like I'm siding with Shadow Weaver, just like Adora felt back then. So what if he's right? What if I just *feel* like I'm siding with you, like I felt I was doing what was best to win the war? I just don't know who is good and who is bad!— she ranted, speaking quickly, gesturing nervously, and only briefly looking at her aunt; she kept her sight down, embarrassed or angry at herself. —Am I bad for what I've done? Is dad bad for ignoring how you feel and everything you tried to tell him? Is Shadow Weaver bad for being such a monster to Adora and Catra? We all think so, but then, how come she was so necessary? Not only during the last years of the war, but also lately. Mystacor would have literally fallen if it wasn't because of her knowledge; the issues she helped us deal with, or how well she taught the pupils, even… I think she helped *you* a lot too; I hadn't seen you so confident in a long time, Auntie… So how- how do I know who is good and who is bad?

Castaspella took a deep breath, shaking a bit; Glimmer's intense emotions had made her unconsciously hold her breath, so she first let go of her tension before trying to reply with as much gentleness as possible.

—Listen, Dear. There aren't good and bad people— she began. —It's far less simple than that; your conflict is perfectly understandable.

—Then how do we evaluate people?

—We aren’t either good or bad, we just… make good or bad decisions, with good or bad intentions— she replied. Glimmer listened attentively as she elaborated —We judge people based on those decisions, which depend on the reasons we see for such decision-making and, furthermore, those reasons will vary *a lot* depending on our own view of the world; we can only see the reasons that *conform* to our worldview—. She took a moment to think, then continued —So, we would be considered “bad” if we fit a certain range of combinations of those factors. From the tamer extreme of making bad decisions with good intentions and then realizing it was wrong, to the opposite extreme of making bad decisions thinking they are right and constantly convincing ourselves of the "rightness" of such decisions—. She rolled her eyes before adding —Finally, off the charts and rarely happens I guess, there's the case of someone choosing to make bad decisions, with the bad intentions of hurting someone, and completely aware of what they are doing, not under the impression they are doing "what's right", although convinced it’s “legitimate” or “justified” because of their *particular* worldview.

It barely took Glimmer a moment to realize —That would be… Shadow Weaver? So, were you trying to fix her?

—Not at all, Dear— she denied, shaking her head, eyes closed. She took a deep breath, looking for the proper words to explain —I’m- I *wasn’t* trying to fix her. She doesn’t need fixing, nobody does because no one is broken; ruined perhaps, twisted, lost… blind. But, as I said, it’s all a question of choices, so I just wanted to give her a reason to make a good decision again—. Noticing her niece’s confusion, she attempted to be more specific. —You know… Your friends, Adora and Catra, have been the only ones who gave her such a reason. She made the awful choice of sacrificing herself with the *best* of intentions, for once at long last; while she did escape, in a way, from taking responsibility for her actions, that sacrifice was, ultimately, to make sure they would save themselves and live their lives.

Glimmer looked away, recalling —Catra mentioned she told them it was just the beginning for them.

—Exactly— she nodded. —In a similar way, when your mother made the terrible decision of pulling out the sword to fix reality, it was with the sole intention of protecting you, to make sure you all would return to reality and enjoy your futures. No matter how awful of a decision it seems to us, she had the best intentions in mind; she never meant to abandon you, it was for your current present to be possible— she assured her, speaking as gently as possible.

Glimmer was already crying, Castaspella gently washed away her tears, and it took her a moment to compose herself again.

—Thank you, Auntie. I think I understand now.

—This is only my opinion, alright? Just an example of how things aren't absolute and often depend on the context and the point of view; you surely have a different view of things, but it’s important that you remember everyone is equally capable of both good and bad and not "doomed" to be one or the other. That’s *always* within our control.

The Queen nodded with a faint smile.

—I know that, but I suppose I needed the reminder— she admitted.

Chapter End Notes

I sobbed so much editing this chapter, so I know you probably did to…

Oh, but I wanted to comment something: As you can see, the chapters are slowly broadening their focus, in fact, there are some to come even *more* "broad" in that sense, and now you also have the names of the two most relevant pupils of SW!
So, why is this? How come their names had *never* been said in C-a-S if they were so important? And how come most of the conflicts that were already brewing in C-a-S are only now being explored?
Well, as we all know, SW is a very selfish person who, as stated in *Behind The Mask* purposely chooses not to ever get close to her wards again, after what happened with Micah; hence, C-a-S, like her worldview, was too narrow and only had a minimal consideration for Castapella because, apparently, she earned her respect after that investigation in S5 or something. But now, after those 8 months of being around her, having so many beliefs proven wrong, and having been shown there are other (better) ways of handling things, her worldview is expanding little by little as she becomes mindful of others. So, now those kids have names, now we'll see in more depth not only Micah's struggles, but also that of Glimmer, Adora, and Catra with her "return", so to say, and there's even some insight into the council's regard for her presence in Mystacor during C-a-S (now, that's an interesting flashback, I hope I can insert it soon; edit: I finished writing this note and 20' later had a "revelation", I know *exactly* when to insert that flashback, so I can tell you it's coming in around 8 chapters, approximately).

Point is, and I'll try not to half-spoil anymore, this is why the focus is more spread through the characters now; everything remains connected, usually by either SW or Casta, but now it's less *centered* in them and we get to see the big picture of the environment where their relationship develops.

That was long, I'm sorry ("^_^)
Until next week!!

Another added note: I don't know if it was right for me to say all of that, but I couldn't help it. I feel like a hypocrite otherwise, I literally can't do anything other than spread information and check on the Ukrainians I know. And yes, you come to read this to escape from the awful real world, but that's the greatest issue my country has: we always escape, and we leave behind those who don't; most of our population descends from war refugees, escaping from wars, especially from world wars, is pretty much in our blood, but that's also why I loathe it.
I considered not writing anymore, but not only this is the one thing keeping me sane, but also, I never know who needs this to cope; in fact, this might be the only contribution I can make: provide some sort of relief to overwhelmed minds.
Gods, I keep ranting about this, I hope this isn't disturbing; I especially hope this won't have to keep repeating, may the war end soon.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: accepting what you feel is not a weakness, believing in someone is not naïvety
Status: being processed with the utmost confusion

Chapter Notes

Today I almost attached a picture of my breakfast because hehe, remember that flashback in which I pretty much described a bamboo steamer? Well, my breakfast today is some manju I prepared and it occurred to me "I can simply take them on the steamer", so here I was, looking at my breakfast tray and remembering what I myself wrote XD
Almost because this round of manju don't look good, so I decided against it heh

Okay, anecdote time is over, ENJOY!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The perpetual silence surrounding her was briefly interrupted by faint voices she recognized. She couldn't understand a word, but just hearing them was enough to make her sentimental.

Sentimental. Now, this is new.

And it was no use trying to deny how moved she felt, it wasn't just what came through the spell, this was her own feeling. The pain invaded her for a moment, along with another memory.

The Head Sorceress arrived at her room around noon, finally able to take a break, and flopped down on her bed. Shadow Weaver had been waiting for her so she could pleasantly sit on the bed once more and continue to read what she left there that morning. Once the woman made herself comfortable with the opened book, Castaspella tried and moved closer, despite barely having any energy left.

—You seem tired— she commented with a neutral tone.

—I am…— she mumbled with a weak tone.

—I warned you— Shadow Weaver chuckled. —Sometimes you're worse than a child, Cas.

—Shut up— she managed to mutter, curling her legs up a bit against the woman. The next moment she felt her move slightly and asked —What?

—Nothing— she replied with an "innocent" tone, laying back against the wall to continue reading her book.

—Tell me…

Shadow Weaver smirked hearing her tired voice and couldn't let go of the opportunity.

—Just noticing your… *lower back*. Looking nice there— she let out with a rather musical teasing tone.

—Shut up… I don't even have the energy to get get angry at you— the sorceress groaned.

—Which makes this a great moment to say it. Don't you think?— she mocked her.

Before Castaspella could retort, they were interrupted by frenetic knockings on the door. quite literally two people unsynchronizedly banging the door; could they be any more annoying?

A pair of sorcerers outside kept repeatedly calling —Head Sorceress! Head Sorceress!

—Ugh… No, no…

—You're *not* going— Shadow Weaver sentenced, knowing she was about to get up regardless.

—But they sound anxious, Bea. It must be important— she countered.

—In that case, I'll go ask them what they want. You stay here and rest— she ordered. Castaspella couldn't exactly refuse, she really didn't want to get up. The woman left the room going through the door, slightly startling the sorcerers, but she ignored their reaction and simply spoke with a severe tone —She's not feeling well at the moment. What is it this time?

—Two of your pupils are fighting with spells!— one of them blurted out.

—And we can't stop them!— the other added.

The panic in their expression was obvious, and yet, Shadow Weaver deemed this situation more annoying than actually important.

—You have sorcery too— she severely reproached them. Even as a mere spirit, it frightened the sorcerers how she towered over them. —And aren’t you far more trained than them? You should be able to stop them— she humiliated them.

—No, no. They are more powerful than us— the first sorcerer admitted.

Not even a trace of shame. It was strange for her to see someone completely ignore her belittlement and even admit weakness. She couldn't understand that at all.

Before she could say anything, the other sorcerer interrupted —A-and they aren't just fighting each other; both of them attack us if we try to interfere.

She narrowed her eyes, considering. Perhaps this was in fact important, yet still merely a trifle; why bother Castaspella? Literally no one seems to respect her enough to notice when they put too much on her shoulders and she’s *too selfless* to realize not everything is her duty.

No, no. She'd better try something else.

—I'll go handle it.

The sorcerers didn't even question her decision, too desperate for just any help they could get. Instead, they thanked her profusely, which unsettled her for a moment, and she hastly insisted

they take her to them, and soon, they were at the lower gardens.

Upon seeing the kids fighting, she signaled the sorcerers to stay back as she approached. Spells came and go: one was the boy who hated her so much since the first class, he kept throwing attacks, full of rage; the other was the little kid she had taught the illusion spell, they only blocked the attacks and tried to impair the boy, most likely wanting the fight to stop.

—What exactly is going on here!?— she questioned, her voice threatening enough that everyone looked at her.

The boy immediately threw a fireball at her, yelling —Stay away!

Shadow Weaver calmly stayed in place, her hands behind her back, and simply observed as the fireball went right through her summoned form. Then, she looked at him with a mocking expression.

—I thought you were smarter than that, but again, you seem to forget crucial factors for your plan— she began, with a condescending tone. She slowly walked closer as she continued —I am *already dead*. And even if Castaspella was close enough for my body to have density, you would still be unable to hurt me.

Yet he seemed determined to retort instead of backing down, and defied her with the same tone —But I could still hurt her, *again.*

Everything around him became darkness in a second as he heard —You will *not*!

Shadow Weaver hadn't exactly given it any though, she merely reacted. It all happened too fast for anyone to interfere, but it wasn't like anyone would dare either; they had to *trust* she is entirely harmless now. However, the voice of the other kid called her attention as they immediately ran to stop her.

—No! Master, stop! Don't hurt him!

She froze.

For a second, their expression of fear made her see that young Micah she had endangered with the Spell of Obtainment. The illusion vanished in an instant and the boy fell to his knees breathing heavily.

—You two better stop fighting now, or I'll make sure you get expelled— she let out, failing to sound severe or threatening. She was still trying to recover from that disruptive trick of her mind; but it wasn't just that. She couldn't find it in her to *actually* threaten them, and she was unable see why. In her head, she could already hear the scolding she'd be receiving from Castaspella if she were there. Shadow Weaver was finally extracted from her thoughts when the boy tried to use an illusion like hers and failed miserably. —You have quite the spirit, my child, but drive alone is not enough— she laughed, smirking as she spoke. Before leaving, she added —You better start studying if you plan on fighting me any time soon.

While Shadow Weaver was leaving, she caught a bit of her pupils' interaction.

—Get off me!— the boy yelled, rejecting the help his classmate offered.

—I just defended you, Sahm!— they reproached him. After a moment, they added, with a weaker tone, —You could thank me, at least…

—Fine! Thank you! Whatever!— he replied, annoyed. —But I didn't need your help, Ari!

The woman chuckled sardonically as she made her way back to Castaspella's room. She went through the door, and soon was back where she laid before, picking up the book to continue her reading.

—Crisis averted— she sighed.

—Thanks…

—Now rest. No more excuses— she sentenced with a certain severity.

Castaspella wrapped her arms around her and resignedly accepted —Fine…

—That…—, Shadow Weaver began speaking but interrupted herself; her disbelief made her brain go blank for a full second. —That's *not* my back you're hugging.

—I'm aware…

Her tone was obviously smug despite how weak her voice sounded. She laughed at the sorceress' boldness, but still couldn't believe it.

—Is that revenge for the comment I made earlier!?

—Absolutely.

Shadow Weaver hummed, amused, and smirked as she replied —Noted. I'll have to comment more, I guess…

And so, another one of Castaspella's attempts to tease the sorceress backfired splendidly.

—You are impossible...

She was right, wasn't she? She had been a handful from the beginning to the end, not different to that belligerent pupil of hers. She found it amusing how he always fought back, but now she noticed she was just like that and *worse;* she refused to lose at absolutely anything, even something as irrelevant as some bantering.

Why had that sorceress put up with her for so long?

Was she really that stubborn? Did she also refuse to lose, being determined to prove she "can still learn"? Or was it just genuine hope on her?

That would be so naïve of her… right? Another one of her foolish beliefs, no?

Then why couldn't she find it "disgusting" as usual? Perhaps it isn't that Castaspella is "too innocent" but rather that her spirit is much stronger than hers ever was…

Even now, Castaspella proved her wrong again…

Chapter End Notes

Clarifications time!

“Didn't you introduce the names of the kids in the last chapter? What happened here?”

Well, like I said, SW didn’t really use their names *at all* for what I’ve explained since *Behind the mask*: she doesn’t want to get attached again (FUNNY! CAUSE SHE DID!)

Ahem… so, this flashback, which (you may have noticed) only goes into her inner thoughts, is the one in se which she first registers and allows herself to remember their names, even though she still denied them at the time when that flashback takes place (it would be perhaps 4 months since she began teaching?)

Also also, notice how the acolytes thanking her *unsettled* SW? That's EXACTLY why Casta’s gentleness has managed to pretty much pierce through her tough (stubborn!) layer of apathy. People like her can, and will, be unsettled by being treated this way because they believe everyone hates them, just dying to themselves their bitchy behaviour.

Thanks for coming to my TedTalk; I MEAN, thanks for reading XD

No need to be perfect

Chapter Summary

As days go by, Glimmer continues to try and repair her father and aunt's strained relationship, decisions are made, and Castaspella feels pulled from every direction.

»—I have never depended on someone else, never had to rely on someone else to handle this kingdom. I know that now, helping all of Etheria like we haven't ever done before, no one expects me to handle everything or to deal with so much on my own, but I still have to try at least. It's my responsibility and it was, in fact, irresponsible of me to rely so much on her. I should have known better.
(…)
»—I understand how you're feeling, but if you're doing this for your kingdom, you should also take breaks— Perfuma began, speaking gently. —Exerting yourself won't help anyone; it is one thing to want to get better, I understand you want to feel good enough for them, but if you push your limits like this just to reach perfection, you might only get yourself hurt, it certainly won't help anyone— she insisted. —Besides, you don't have to be perfect, it's enough to do your best.

In addition, the Head Sorceress learns how Catra seems badly affected by what she *has seen*, Castaspella decides to do what she can to help.

Chapter Notes

Ahem *taps mic* Big thank you to ocean_galaxy, to whom I owe some of the chapters to come and blanks I would have had no idea how to fill were it not for those comments guessing what could come or asking about things that happened; all things I had not considered at all, they turned out to be great additions and key subjects to help me further elaborate this plot! In this chapter, I'm introducing one of Coffee's ideas, and it fits so well solely thanks to ocean_galaxy's contributions. So, of course, just like I did with Cana for providing this fantastic format, I'm now also dedicating this fic to you.
Seriously, guys, you all have contributed a lot, and I adore you for that; and those who didn't perhaps contribute to the fic itself, your comments still motivated me to go on despite, you know, all issues associated with writing… well… this particular ship.
It's already obvious how important this is for me, so I really can't thank you enough <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That night, Glimmer decided to take advantage of her aunt's cooking coping mechanism and decided to convince her dad to have dinner all three together, seeing how Castaspella had already made more than enough food for that day and the next.

She walked into the kitchen to find the Head Sorceress skillfully stirring something with a pair of chopsticks, and immediately let out —Don't you think you've cooked enough already?

The woman chuckled slightly and replied —Believe me, it will all be gone pretty soon.

Behind them, King Micah had just arrived and couldn't help staring at his sister with a somewhat stunned expression. For a whole second right there he could have sworn he saw…

Of course not.

It's just hair… Loose, black and long…

That looks a lot like…

Nope! He should *not* follow that train of thought. He'd sorely regret it.

Before the Queen could reply to Castaspella, she noticed her father and immediately realized what was in his mind. She retreated without a word and walked up to him, with a look that said more than enough.

—Don't you *dare* say a thing!— she whispered, her tone between warning and threatening. —She's in a good mood, alright?

He cleared his throat before replying —Fine, I'm not- I won't ruin it, baby girl, I promise—. They exchanged a brief look of concern and then approached Castaspella, who was still stirring her mix with the chopsticks. It immediately caught his attention and, with genuine admiration, he commented —Woah, that's impressive, Sis! I've always wanted to learn how to do that!

—You need to learn to boil water, dad— Glimmer replied, mockingly, rolling her eyes.

The sorceress giggled and asked —What about you, Dear? Do you know how to do it?

—Of course!— she exclaimed, excited. —I used to spill everything at first, it was a disaster! But I've been able to do it for a few years now!

—So I'm the only one who can't cook?

Micah seemed disgruntled, but they could only laugh at that.

Soon after, they had set the table for four, and, while waiting for Bow to arrive, Castaspella placed several plates with what she had cooked, and two steamers with warm buns. Once she took her seat, she reached for an ornate ceramic bottle, but Glimmer immediately snatched it away.

—Ah, no!

—Glimmer!?

—Nope, you're not drinking sake unsupervised again— she insisted. —I can serve you a cup, but that's it. And good quality this time!

—Oh, come on!

—What happened?— Micah inquired, more confused than ever.

Bow arrived right as the Queen explained —Last time she emptied the whole bottle on her own. So, I'm sorry, Auntie, but we can't exactly handle you that drunk now.

—She's right…— Bow supported her. —We were lucky that Shadow Weaver showed up and made sure you'd go directly to sleep…

—Bow!— Glimmer grumbled, irked; she glanced sideways at her father, noticing he was making an obvious effort not to react, pressing his lips tightly. She cleared her throat and said —Even with Catra and Adora's help, it's was truly difficult, Auntie…

—I don't really remember much— she admitted, taking the cold cup she was served. —I woke up and couldn't recall a thing since around noon or so—. The sorceress retold what happened that morning while casually casting a spell with a single hand to have a small vial appear in front of her on the table: she poured a bit into the cup of sake, and teleported it away just as easily. —I asked what had happened, but she insisted I didn't want to know…

—You *really* perfected that spell— the Queen noticed, so amazed at the ease she showed she completely forgot what they were talking about. However, she immediately realized —Wait, what *was* that just now?

—It's… a sleeping potion. It should be less invasive if I drink it diluted, but may also take a little longer to make effect, so this is the best time to have it.

—Oh, right! The sleeping potions!

Castaspella's surprise was obvious in her expression as she asked —And how do *you* know about those?

—She… mentioned she had it, and that she'd give one to you so you'd fall asleep as soon as possible despite how drunk you were— Glimmer explained, looking away.

This time, they all looked a moment at the King, but he had just grabbed a bun and silently chew on it, keeping himself out of the discussion.

—I only found those vials by chance…

—Well it's just… Look, I don't even know why she showed up at just the right moment, but we couldn't really do much for you, and even if I could take you to your room, I didn't want to leave you alone— Glimmer explained, lowering her tone a bit. —She mentioned she could give you that so we considered it was the best solution. I don't know why she'd refuse to tell you what happened, though. Unless she thought you'd feel ashamed that we saw you so out of sorts?

—That doesn't convince me, but let's suppose you're right— Castaspella sighed. Right after, a bit more cheerful, she said —Well, now. We're all here, so: Let's eat!

The next morning, the Head Sorceress woke up feeling much better than on previous days but, as she was preparing herself to start the day, she felt the sting from the spell briefly pierce her chest once again, and remembered she hadn't yet investigated what that could be; perhaps, going through the archive for some blind investigation was the best way to spend the day.

She ate her breakfast between mountains of knowledge stored in many different media, and quickly discarded almost every lunar crystal as none of the writings had anything remotely useful. A few hours later, half the scrolls she had gathered were also discarded, and her frustration increased.

Castaspella sighed, tired already, and grabbed a document from a tall pile on her left. Nothing useful, just a long desertion on how it was believed that the souls of the damned would forever be trapped within the core of the planet and suffer for eternity. Why even did they keep such irrelevant works about ancient beliefs!? It's exactly what allowed something like the Spell of Obtainment to ever be known! It was but a legend, carvings in the walls and snippets of information among their sacred writings; had those stories about the "great power" within Etheria never been recorded…

But it's done now. What's the point of dwelling on "what ifs"?

Before she could continue, Castaspella heard footsteps approaching and turned around just as two councilors arrived.

—Good morning, Head Sorceress. We come bearing great news— one announced.

Although she could hardly believe that, she hid it behind an impassive expression and allowed them to speak.

—As you know, today was the meeting with the pupils and their parents to make a decision on their new tutor— the other began. —They have all unanimously chosen *you* as the new tutor for the kids.

They had *what*!?

Goosebumps; a chill immediately tensed Castaspella and it took her a minute too long to finally reply, as calmly as possible, —That would be a *very* unwise choice.

—On the contrary. The council agrees this is probably the best option since they already know and trust you. Besides, regardless of our opinion, this was their decision and we have to respect it.

The afternoon was cloudy yet warm when Princess Perfuma arrived at Mystacor. She hadn't been there many times, and it still amazed her how beautiful and well cared for the gardens are. Her admiration delayed her a few extra minutes but, eventually, she arrived at the training grounds, where she had been told she could find the Head Sorceress.

For some reason, the princess expected her to be supervising a class, perhaps training someone or just on some routine check. However, it was the exact opposite. Only the sorceress was using the place, training with such intensity it made the princess think that, most likely, she had ordered for the place to be emptied until she was done.

She cleared her throat and called out —Excuse me! Head Sorceress? Castaspella?

The woman dismissed the spell she was about to activate and turned around, noticing —Princess Perfuma! Good afternoon—. She was clearly exhausted, sweat shining on her forehead, and she seemed a bit out of breath as she approached her, asking —To what do I owe the pleasure of your visit?

—Oh, I just wanted to… I-I'm sorry, you look so drained, we should probably take a seat— Perfuma suggested. Castaspella immediately nodded and they both walked up to a nearby bench where the sorceress had left a jug of water and a small towel. While the sorceress freshened up a bit, the princess decided to ask —Why are you training like that? It seemed pretty intense, almost… violent.

—It's not like that. I'm just trying to perfect my casting— she replied. Castaspella dried her face with the towel before continuing —I have to keep training, repeating all the spells I've yet to master,

paying attention to every detail—. She stared at the floor for a moment, then sighed and sat next to Perfuma, whose concern was evident. —Shadow Weaver isn't here to help with anything anymore, and now *I* have to train her pupils— she explained. —I feel too… mediocre for such a task; they could probably teach me more than I can ever teach them. So now I need to be enough for them; they deserve this effort from me… And so does Mystacor— she sentenced, her expression resolute. —I have *never* depended on someone else, never *had to* rely on someone else to handle this kingdom. I know that now, helping all of Etheria like we haven't ever done before, no one *expects* me to handle everything or to deal with so much on my own, but I still have to try at least. It's my responsibility and it was, in fact, irresponsible of me to rely so much on her. I should have known better.

The princess saw her angered expression, how she stared at the floor intensely, and her concern only grew. Perfuma placed a hand on her shoulder and it immediately snapped her out of that trance-like state. Castaspella's tension vanished and, when she looked back at the princess, her fatigue was even greater. Now that she had dropped the façade, it looked like she was ready to fall on the spot.

—I understand how you're feeling, but if you're doing this for your kingdom, you should also take breaks— Perfuma began, speaking gently. —Exerting yourself won't help anyone; it is one thing to want to get better, I understand you want to feel good enough for them, but if you push your limits like this just to reach perfection, you might only get yourself hurt, it certainly won't help anyone— she insisted. —Besides, you don't *have* to be perfect, it's enough to do your best.

They don't have to be perfect, it's enough if they are doing their best. Hadn't she said that once? Why wasn't she applying it to herself now?

The Head Sorceress sighed deeply and leaned back, she took a long sip of water and sighed once again.

After a moment, she nodded, looked back at Perfuma, and asked —So, why did you come, Princess?

—Oh, right! I forgot— she realized, smiling apologetically. —I- Perhaps I should give you some context first. Since the war ended, I've been helping Adora and Catra talk out some of the things that trouble them, the past that keeps haunting them— she began, her expression fond remembering how much they had progressed during the last year. —When Catra was in space, the silence and vastness of the universe helped her think and reflect, so now, as they began their missions in space, she asked Adora to talk about these things when they are out there— she went on. —But… They have such different views of everything and especially of their childhood that, at first, they returned pretty angry at each other. I spoke with Adora, and Scorpia spoke with Catra, and we came to the conclusion that they needed someone to mediate. So we spoke a few times while they were here, and it worked well helping them see each other's point of view— she assured, smiling happily. —In fact, Catra is handling her anger better as time passes, and Adora's been more chill about fulfilling missions; nothing like when she lost She-Ra, she's more mindful of her own safety.

—That's great news!— Castaspella commented, surprised. —I'm sure you're being of great help.

—I want to think so— she admitted, looking away shyly for a moment. —However, Catra has so much unsaid that sometimes we have extra talks with her, especially when they are out in space like now. It depends a lot on how she feels, since whenever she keeps too much inside, her irritability increases again. And, well, I won't lie: *everything* related to Shadow Weaver puts her on edge pretty easily. It doesn't even have to be something bad— she explained. The sorceress seemed especially interested in that clarification and attentively listened as Perfuma elaborated. —Last year, when they learned you had successfully summoned her, Catra was actually pretty excited to return, or perhaps impatient. But, at the same time, she snapped at everything. Also, Adora told me she seemed pretty irritable here when they finally talked with her; it wasn't bad, on the contrary, it had been a good

conversation, they both needed it, yet Catra kept lashing out at Shadow Weaver, mostly out of frustration— she told her, with a hint of pity in her voice. —I suppose part of her can't help being concerned, but she's still so hurt and resentful of how much of a bi- I mean, how badly she treated her, that Catra's emotions are all over the place.

—Of course, it makes sense. She's still learning to manage her anger and the woman is… Pretty annoying, and frustrating, and… Well, you know— Castaspella admitted. —I've been so close to snapping several times, but I have plenty of years of practice— she laughed. —However… When you said she was already like that before returning… So you mean any matter *somehow* related to her makes Catra more irritable?

—Exactly. It's a sore spot— she confirmed. —And, right now, she's… not in the best emotional state — she added, unsure of how to say it. For the sorceress, it was almost too obvious why that was, but she didn't expect Perfuma to know too. —The reason why I came today is that, yesterday, Scorpia and I talked with her for a long while and she- I wanted to let you know she told us what happened. What she *saw*— she finally let out. Castaspella didn't know how to react, mostly because of how shocking it was, but the princess quickly continued —We won't spread it, of course, we wouldn't tell anyone, but I wanted you to be aware that we know what… happened.

The Head Sorceress let out a heavy sigh, shaking her head as she closed her eyes for a moment.

—Is this affecting Catra too much? It sounds like she's completely freaking out. How bad is it?— she asked, genuinely concerned.

—It made her quite anxious, we still don't know what exactly impacted her so much. I mean, it can be uh… disturbing, perhaps— she considered, making the sorceress laugh briefly, —But there has to be something else to this. At first, she felt bad for telling us about it, but she was so unnerved… Adora had to beg her so she'd tell us, but still, we have no idea what is the reason behind her current state.

—I understand— Castaspella sighed. —I appreciate you letting me know she told you but, please don't worry about it; it's not like I will- Oh…— the sorceress interrupted herself as realization hit. — You know, Princess, perhaps I know exactly why this is so troubling for her. I wanted to speak with Catra about it as soon as she returned, mostly to make sure this exact thing wouldn't happen but… Is there any chance she'll be alright with speaking with me? The sooner the better.

Perfuma consider it for a moment but her expression already said enough.

—I'm sorry, but I'm quite sure she'd panic if she saw you right now— the princess admitted. —If you want to tell her something, I can let her know— she offered.

However, the Head Sorceress shook her head, and insisted —No, I want her to see my expression, so she knows I really mean it—. If she was right, then the most important part of her message would be to make sure Catra *sees* she's genuine. —Perhaps… Do you think Bow could maybe make a recording for her?

Chapter End Notes

Ah yes, I had been waiting for this.
So, coffee's idea was that Perfuma kind of worked as Catra's therapist, so to say. And while I do have a lot of scenes (for later on) in which Casta and Catra talk a lot and it's very helpful (for

both of them), the way I’m obviously projecting myself on Casta means she may be a good guide but not a therapist. And I could only fit this scene because of some stuff ocean_galaxy mentioned when trying to guess what will come, and it worked perfectly to introduce the suggested idea, plus show the difference between what Perfuma does and what Casta has been doing (and will continue to do) in these fics, plus introduce the tutor change thing, plus highlight something very important: sometimes we don’t apply our own advice.

Gods, I need to stop doing this. Oh, but, let me say: while here we have a biiiit more about the sake incident, just you wait; SW will remember that event and you’ll know even more than Casta and the BFS about it XD
Ah, right, and a detail I don't know how many caught: Glimmer here says the sake is "good quality", which already implies (and yes, it's like that), that the sake of said incident was "bad quality". Well, notice how here the cup was cold? Good quality sake can/should be served cold so that its flavors and aromas are highlighted, while standard and bad quality sake have to be warmed so it will hide the bad quality components (and, may I say, it's better to keep warming it every time it goes cold than to try and drink it at room temperature because the difference is *very* notorious).

Now, yes, until next week!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: not everyone is like you, even those who are
Status (1/2): being processed…

Chapter Notes

I am
So so so so sorry

The AWFUL SHITTY DISGUSTING ENRAGING day I had…
To begin with: I had to leave my phone at a service, meaning I have absolutely no internet without wifi, which limits what I can do and where.
Hence, as I couldn't edit and post this before I left home, I had to wait until I got wifi to do so.
But GUESS WHO absolutely confused destinations and, because of this lack of internet, couldn't know that!? YES, THIS FOOL!
I had a 1 hour and a half trip, I would have posted around like 3pm max. Instead, I traveled on the OPPOSITE direction! So yeah, another hour and a half… now it's past 6pm and I wanna shoot myself but a shotgun
(Okay, dismiss that)
Oh, right, and I'm this grumpy because I'm hungry. I had breakfast at 8.30am, a single mochi and a coffee. I left the house before 11am, and was supposed to arrive and my mother's office (instead of going home, I did NOT want to go home to my brother), so I could at least have a late lunch. WELL NO! I'm now running on 2 coffees and 5 cookies!

I feel like an idiot, and I'm so so sorry, really
Gods, please, I hope you enjoy. And, my original clarification: the end of this flashback is NOT here <(“*v*) ehe… it was too long, longer than a main-line chapter.
SO
Please enjoy (TT^TT)/

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A certain feeling came to her through the spell; a lot of strong emotions were troubling Castaspella, it seemed, but she was entirely unable to identify them. Could it be concern? Or sorrow? Guilt? Self-loath? Anger, perhaps? All of them, even. If anyone could feel so much simultaneously, that was the Head Sorceress. However, what could have happened to make her feel like that?

And it wasn't just these feelings, there was also notorious exhaustion; she couldn't feel accurately the sorceress' physical pain, but could feel strong sensations like this one, and get a general idea of her state. What was Castaspella doing now? Probably something she'd consider foolish.

Back to those troubling feelings, she couldn't help reflecting on when, after being summoned, she also felt all of these. She focused intently on observing her memory without letting her guard down, to make sure that cursed place wouldn't inflict her pain once again, but it would simply be a question of time until the memory managed to break her resolve.

—It will need far more power than when you recharged the shield, possibly ten times more, and you don’t have external help from the eclipse this time— she told Castaspella, implying this is more than she can handle.

Castaspella turned and with a confident smile answered —I’m sure with all the sorcerers, Micah, Glimmer, and myself, it will be enough—. She then looked at Catra and told her —Better stay here to keep guard.

That made Shadow Weaver inevitably raise a brow. Why would the sorceress ask for that?

—You expect her to flee or something?

—More like I fear someone might take advantage of the confusion.

She really- Why was she even concerned about that!? Catra seemed unable to answer and only stared as the Head Sorceress left, and when she looked back at Shadow Weaver, her expression revealed an astonishment similar to hers.

And how not?

—You don’t need to stay if you don’t want to— the woman sighed as she returned to sit on her illusionary couch.

Catra already looked confused because of Castaspella, but now her words seemed to have made her feel conflicted. She expected her to leave, but instead, Catra sat down, hugged her legs, and rested her head on her knees, her ears were down and her tail moved restlessly. She had seen her like that plenty of times, especially after a training for which she told her she had been *lucky*.

They looked at each other for a while, doing absolutely nothing. After long minutes, Catra’s hesitant gaze made Shadow Weaver stare at her questioningly.

—I…

She vacillated and closed her mouth, not daring to speak.

—What is it?— she asked in her usual severe tone, prompting her to talk.

—I just wanted to know… why’d you do that? When I was attacking the monster, you- You suddenly appeared out of nowhere, and not only faced that creature instead of me, you also… made sure to keep me safe— she finally let out, her conflict noticeable in her voice.

—Yes, I pretty much threw you back because you weren’t leaving and had to block you away so you wouldn’t return— she recalled. —So first, tell me, why did *you* try so hard to stop me? I did not expect you to care at all. In fact, had I been in your place right there, I would have taken Adora to the Heart without sparing a look back at me. No, I actually did. Why didn’t you?

—Well, I'm obviously not like you— Catra reacted, offended and mockingly, in a way that reminded her of the feisty girl who always talked back at her. However, a second later, her expression changed, there was sorrow again, and fear. Shadow Weaver realized her unmasked expression showed her contempt for the memory of her flippancy, and looked away. Before she could say anything, Catra talked again. —I've always cared. You just… pushed me away every time. I-I even tried to make you feel better after Hordak punished you for losing Glimmer, remember? And you only called me "mediocre" and tried to justify how you treated me— she reproached. —That was probably the only time you actually *admitted* how you were "harsh" on me, but only because you finally *knew* what it felt like; and you refused to apologize for it.

—Well, I wasn't going to get an apology from *Hordak*, why should *you* get one?— she asked, immediately getting a reaction from Catra. As soon as she stood up, Shadow Weaver raised a hand, stopping her to add —I am only pointing out that there were more than enough reasons for you to *want* me dead.

—I *never* wanted you dead!— she cried out, angry tears falling down, her body tensed. —Why don't you get it!? I am *not* like you! You wanted to dispose of me!? Well, I didn't want you to be disposed of! Didn't I told you I wanted you to stay after Hordak ordered for you to be sent to Beast Island!? A-and… You wanted me to "work and prove myself" and I tried! I really tried! But you still considered me less than nothing! I can't believe you didn't expect me to make sure Adora escaped; you were demoting me even *before* erasing her memory. Ugh, and I still would have *never* let you do that! Even- Even if that meant Adora would be back with me, I… wouldn't bare knowing… that if not she wouldn't have…

—Catra— she interrupted her. —If you know I loathe weakness so much, how did you expect me to accept your pity?

She shook her head, taking a deep breath to control herself while wiping her tears, and countered —*Concern*. Not pity. But you don't even know what concern is, do you?

The woman rolled her eyes.

—Fair enough. Still: I saw it like pity, which made me feel weak, and I wouldn't accept that. But there's also the fact that, seeng you show concern, made me remember when I cared for others like that which, once again, I loathed because caring for others is what doomed me.

—No it wasn't! It was your recklessness and *not* caring enough!

—Really? Talking from experience?— she mocked her.

Catra huffed and brushed her hair back. That was another thing Shadow Weaver recognized easily; she was making her stressed and angry.

—We're not the same. You only focus on the bad things we have in common, and how were both "treated" the same way— Catra pointed out. —Oh, but, you wanna talk about those? Perfect, let's begin with the biggest one right now— she taunted. —We've both hurt Glimmer and her family, haven't we?

She took a deep breath, wondering where this could possibly be going, and sighed —We have, yes.

—So she and her family should hate us! They should want us both dead; I kidnapped her and your powers did *something* to Glimmer; she lent you her powers and you almost drained her to

torture me to get me to- to what? Leave the Horde *with you*? And after you couldn't, I opened that damned portal for which her mother had to sacrifice!— she ranted, speaking angrily as she paced back and forth.

—Indeed.

—But don't they *fucking support you*!?— she reproached her, so full of wrath it was impossible for Shadow Weaver to hide her surprise. —I- That plan… The- the failsafe thing… Glimmer's aunt supports you since then; even if she repeatedly shoved to your face how you almost got her brother killed, she still *trusted* you! And now… Now she and Glimmer fully support you! Fuck! That sorceress is worried that the council wants you gone! And you dare say we're treated the same way!?— she went on, yelling furiously yet still controlled enough that she didn't even feint an attack, not even punching the air. —If I hadn't helped saving the world I've been cast out! You hadn't done anything and already had that sorceress trust, enough to rope us all into risking Adora's life with the failsafe! Yes, you then sacrificed for us, otherwise we wouldn't have saved Etheria, but that doesn't exactly give you any points in favor with them, yet the man who's life you risked helped with bringing you back!— she argued. Catra let out a bitter laugh, finally stopping her pacing, and looked up as she let out —You're a lucky bastard…

—So are you.

—What!?

Catra looked back at her, indignant, but once again she only rose a hand to stop her and explain herself.

—You have *always* been one lucky rascal: you always had Adora's love, since day one. Did you ever doubt whether you could be loved?

Catra looked away, pained, and hugged herself before replying —Of course I have, for years… And it was your fault; Adora left me, then you did too. How was I…

—I, on the contrary, now doubt if I ever was… At least when I was Light Spinner, of course. Seeing how much Micah hates me, I wonder if I haven't always been this loathed monster.

She saw Catra's ears perk up and her eyes widen; she sure wasn't expecting to hear her say that, was she?

…

Chapter End Notes

Erm, yeah, Catra was cursing right there. As I already clarified, I rose this fic's rating from G to T-rated so I can let them curse like this XD
Plus, they're all adults and will only get older, of course they will curse more (and let's be honest, with her around, how not?)

But, um, yeah, this flashback hasn't ended yet! (it was getting too long! I'm sorry!) So the reflection from it will come later; honestly, the part that follows is *mega* important, so perhaps it's worthy of its own chapter, after all…

Anyways, yeah, sorry, you'll have to wait 2 weeks to see how this continued, heh; apologies <("^_^)
Until next week!!

You Have Nothing to Worry about

Chapter Summary

After the unfortunate events occurred during their last day on Etheria, Adora is still doing her best to deal with Catra's anxiety; even with all the help Princess Perfuma and Scorpia have provided them, the root cause of such restless state of hers remains unknown.

Perhaps she just needed some encouragement to open up and be honest with others and herself.

»—Um… Catra, *why* did you return to the room? And alone?— Perfuma asked her, hesitantly.
»—I…— she nervously whispered, immediately curling up. She finally admitted —I was worried, alright?
(…)
»—What do you…
»—Look, what we all last saw was… you know, that kiss on the cheek, right?— she began explaining, looking away. —Our first reaction was like, the *disgust*; we just couldn't believe what we saw, it- it was so weird! Odd! But- but that just made me think that, you know, Shadow Weaver probably took it the wrong way. As in, she considers everything related to love and care is a weakness and always rejects it so violently…— she continued. —We left so fast after that, we never considered what her reaction would be, or that she could hurt Glimmer's aunt for that.

Chapter Notes

Well, I mean...
If you read the eliminated scene from C-a-S... Catra's concern was actually right; she just arrived *after* that little issue was solved

Okay no, I won't keep annoying you! I shouldn't!

Please enjoy the chapter! (And the references to details from canon, hehe)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Out in the beautiful silent space, Catra was piloting Darla while Adora left a moment to fix a meal for them. An incoming transmission from Etheria flashed on the screens in front of Catra, so she activated the auto-pilot and picked up.

—Hey, Arrow Boy, how are things back in the kingdom?— she greeted him, her tone almost cheerful.

—Hi, Catra. Everything's pretty chill in Bright Moon— he replied in a similar tone. Then he looked a bit unsure as he said —So… I have a recorded message for you; Perfuma and Scorpia came, so they'll be here to talk with you once you're done watching the recording.

—Oh, sure. What is it about?— she asked.

—Don’t freak out! I promise it’s good!— was all Bow said before starting the recording.

—Hey! I never said…

The screen changing interrupted her and, sure enough, her whole body tensed on the seat when she saw who it was. Remembering this is *just* a video relieved her enough but she could still feel her claws trying to dig into the armrests of the chair.

Part of Bow’s head was visible as he fixed the recorder in place and, behind him, a very confused Castaspella watched patiently until he was done. Once he gave her an indication, she looked at the camera a bit confused, unsure of whether she should start speaking or not.

—Is it- Should I start? Can I begin?— she asked. Off-screen, Bow must have nodded because she finally began in all earnest. —Oh! Alright. Um… I- Hello, Catra— she stammered. There was something off with the woman, but Catra couldn’t pinpoint what and eventually gave up, preferring to focus on what she’d say. —I hope your mission is going all fine, and I’m so sorry to interrupt your voyage like this, but… I’m sure you’re feeling distressed. From what Perfuma said, you may even be feeling uneasy from seeing me right now, don’t you?— she continued. Catra was surprised at how accurately she could predict what she’s feeling, and it made her doubt for a moment whether this wasn’t actually a live transmission. The sorceress looked down for a moment, her expression sad, and then continued —So… I’m now aware of what happened, that you all pretty much sneaked into my room and all—, she rolled her eyes as if annoyed but there was half a smile there, —And that you later *went back*, on your own, and returned to your friends looking distressed. So, I believe I know what happened, *what you saw*—, her tone sounded obviously careful, —For which I’ve been concerned about exactly this happening—. She is *what*!? Castaspella looked genuinely troubled as she continued —I was going to wait until you were back to make sure you weren't agonizing about this, but when she told me you’re basically panicking… there’s no point in waiting, is there?—. She let out a bitter short laugh. —Catra, I’d like to let you know you did nothing wrong; yes, you all disregarded my privacy, I can’t let that pass, but now Glimmer explained it all, and it’s fine. No one can punish you for this, alright? *No one will*. It wasn’t right, but it’s done, and that’s it— she sentenced, looking at the camera as if they were face to face. Catra couldn’t disguise her surprise upon hearing her: “No one can punish you for this. No one will”. How could she know? —Of course, I also hope the… um… memory of it won’t haunt you, because I know you already have more than enough traumatic memories to deal with— she added, awkwardly, laughing nervously at the end. —But, once again, I have to insist: You did *nothing* wrong. There won’t be “consequences” or any form of punishment, *at all*. Am I clear? You have *nothing* to worry about, I mean it— she assured, confident. Catra could barely believe her ears and felt her eyes watering; she hadn’t realized how much she needed to hear that, and suddenly felt immensely relieved. She stared, still a bit shocked, as the video finished. —Well, that would be all. Have a nice trip and a safe return. Thank you, Bow, you can sto-

The recording ended and soon enough the screen changed back to Bow, his expression worried as he noticed Catra on the verge of tears. As his sight moved to something behind her, she turned around to find Adora and Melog standing a few meters away, a tray with food between her hands, and a soft expression of understanding.

She approached, kissed her forehead briefly, and said —Why don't you stay and talk a bit with Perfuma and Scorpia, Love? We can eat afterward.

—No, no— she immediately responded. She wasn't aware of how she kept nervously tapping the armrest with her right hand. Looking back at the screen, she gulped and sounded apologetic as she said —Could we talk later, guys? I… I can't right now.

—It's all right, Wildcat. We can call later at the usual time! Now go enjoy your meal— Scorpia replied, smiling gently, before ending the transmission.

Catra let out a sigh; she was still stimming, staring at a window, her tail kept moving back and forth, and she breathed a bit shakily; Melog curled up at her feet, concerned. After a moment, Adora placed a hand on her shoulder to call her attention, and Catra realized she hadn't noticed it when she left the tray on the floor. Adora could see how unsettled she was, so she kneeled in front of her and smiled lovingly.

—How are you feeling?

—Confused— she whispered, somewhat ashamed.

—I couldn't hear it all, but I noticed you seemed more relieved for a moment.

—I- Yeah but- I don't understand how she knew… and I just- She said she's worried about me. I wasn't expecting that.

—Catra, you were so afraid of her reaction. But, look! She knows and she's *not* mad at you— Adora pointed out. —I think she's really understanding. I mean, she's been putting a lot of effort into that lately, remember?

Catra was still uneasy, yet she joked —And how not? To deal with Shadow Weaver…

—Yeah— Adora laughed. —Perhaps you should go talk with Castaspella when we're back.

—What!?— she immediately exclaimed. Catra looked back at Adora, tense, and stopped tapping the armrest; instead, she gripped it tightly. —No, no way!

—Catra…

She shook her head, sat back lifting her feet from the ground, and hugged her legs, trembling a bit.

—I *can't* go anywhere near them. I *can't* unsee it! A-and perhaps Castaspella won't do anything to me, but Shadow Weaver will! She'll sure want to kill me! Like- Like when we sneaked into the Black Garnet Chamber!— she argued, speaking fast. —I can already hear her saying I was not supposed to be there, a-and that I'm insolent, and that I'm still a nuisance to her even after she died, and…

—Catra!— Adora yelled, concerned, took her hands to interrupt Catra's frenetic rambling and claimed her full attention. They both took a deep breath and Adora kissed her hands briefly. —That was long ago, Love, it won't happen again. I will *not* let it happen again— she began, speaking slowly. —And I fully trust Castaspella won't let that happen either. Besides, Shadow Weaver doesn't have those powers anymore, she can't even *try* to do that.

She felt Catra's hands tensing as she insisted —She has those weird illusions now! And they are the *same* as the shadows she *always* used to trap me!

—We won't let her! I promise!— Adora immediately replied. She stood up and hugged her tightly; she was too scared. —I will keep you safe. I just think speaking with Glimmer's aunt will help you; you don't have to see Shadow Weaver any time soon.

—But *how*?— she retorted, her voice muffled by Adora's body. —She's always around her. *Always*.

—Castaspella can make sure she leaves us alone— she assured her, optimistically. —It's clear she wants you to be comfortable.

Catra let out a long sigh, hugged her a while more, and finally let go of her, saying —I'll… consider it.

It took Catra a few hours to make up her mind and gather the courage to call Bow and ask for Perfuma and Scorpia. While they were glad that she had decided to call, they were also concerned. Catra's uneasiness challenged her self-control and made it impossible for her and Adora to hold a conversation since lunch; this was a cry for help.

Catra looked away and couldn't answer when Perfuma asked her why she was so on edge so, instead, the princess suggested —Is it because of the videorecording?

—I…— she tried to reply but interrupted herself. After a deep sighed, she finally managed to say —Yeah, it's that but- I just- I can't go see her, guys. I just can't. I can't help remembering what I saw… and heard… and- and, you know… it was dark but I could still hear pretty well; not- not like it was loud, just- Ugh!

She kept stammering until she couldn't go on and pressed her ears down with such a distressed expression it further worried Perfuma.

—You know she's really worried. None of that matters to her more than how you're feeling now, she would never react as bad as you may be expecting— the princess insisted.

—But, remember a few months ago, when the king sent Double Trouble to pose as her?— Catra began. —Everyone was talking about how furious she was at him, and how scary it was 'cause she's hardly ever like that… I'm- she could also get mad at me. What if she only says that she's not mad so that I'll go see her and *then* she punishes me!?— she went in, clearly panicking.

—Woah, woah, Wildcat! She's honest, you know that! She- she's not Shadow Weaver, alright?— Scorpia interrupted. —Besides, Double Trouble also said that wasn't the first time King Micah did something like that, it had been going on for months! Of course she got mad at him, but even so, she didn't really do anything to him— she reminded her. —In fact, he had been so disrespectful to her for so long that many were surprised that it was the *first* time she finally reacted—. She let out a short laugh before concluding —Shadow Weaver would have *totally* given him one of those scares the very first time he was the tiniest bit disrespectful… That sorceress is exactly the opposite!

Well, she was right. The one to punish her for anything and everything was always the dark sorceress. Catra shivered as she remembered some of those and what she could do to her now if she ever knows that she spied on them. And what if Castaspella told her? All the more reasons to never go anywhere near Mystacor at all ever again.

—Um… Catra, *why* did you return to the room? And alone?— Perfuma asked her, hesitantly.

—I…— she nervously whispered, immediately curling up. She finally admitted —I was worried, alright?

The princesses exchanged a bewildered and concerned look, confused as to what that could mean.

—What do you…

—Look, what we all last saw was… you know, that kiss on the cheek, right?— she began explaining, looking away. —Our first reaction was like, the *disgust*; we just couldn't believe what we saw, it- it was so weird! Odd! But- but that just made me think that, you know, Shadow Weaver probably took it the wrong way. As in, she considers everything related to love and care as a weakness and always rejects it so violently…— she continued. —We left so fast after that, we never considered what her reaction would be, or that she could hurt Glimmer's aunt for that. I- I know she can handle her, we never heard of Shadow Weaver having hurt her. But this is something else. A-and… I did think she was hurting her at first. I didn't immediately leave 'cause when I *actually* understood what I was hearing I was so shocked!

Perfuma let out a small smile.

—Well… We just talked about how Castaspella got angry at King Micah, but it was because, when he was concerned, he always interfered. You did the opposite, you never attempted to do anything, you just left— Perfuma pointed out. —If it had been him… well, he would have made a huge scandal. I'm sure she really appreciates you being more respectful and realizing your mistake despite the, uh, privacy invasion. I mean, yes, you all did what he wanted to do, but didn't behave like him; you wanted to *avoid* more of that.

Catra still looked unsure and nervous, so Scorpia added —We're sure she'll be *very* understanding. Especially if you tell her what you just said! Don't be scared, Wildcat, your reasons were noble, she'll see that.

Although she curled up even tighter, Catra seemed to be feeling much better, let out a small smile and thanked them —I'll try… I guess I can try. Thank you, guys—. However, her thoughtful expression made Perfuma wait before ending their meeting. After a moment of reflection, Catra looked back at them and expressed —You know… I think what surprised me the most about the situation I found, you know, besides the *disturbing* image, is that it's completely opposite to what I expected. I- I mean, properly saying it… It's- Ugh!—. She stammered a bit and tried again. —Look… I- I expected to find Shadow Weaver inflicting her *pain*, making her suffer, alright? That's what anyone would have expected… But- but she was, y-you know, it was actually, *pleasure*—. Catra shivered disgustedly and immediately added —I won't repeat that *ever again*, but what I mean is: it's so difficult for me to imagine someone being happy *thanks* to Shadow Weaver—. Catra struggled a bit to explain herself. —But this… Actually this just made me think; you know, I'm not often around the Head Sorceress to notice it but, Sparkles told us a lot about how she's been the past eight months, and we saw it: she is *actually* happy! That woman *enjoys* having Shadow Weaver around, and even when she's a jerk, she only throws it back at her, and it's like bantering is their thing, some game or…—, she interrupted herself and let out a sigh, little by little letting go of her legs as the tension slowly eased. —I used to talk back to her, and she would immediately belittle and threaten me with her dark magic. I feel… I'd like to think I would have felt similar to Castaspella if she hadn't been so… violent to me for it. It *could* have been like that, right?

Catra's voice sounded so hopeful and sad at the same time, a nostalgia caused by a dream reality that never happened, and Scorpia couldn't bear the pain it caused her.

She briefly looked at Perfuma before replying —We Horde Kids know Shadow Weaver. The way she is now… This is all new, Wildcat. Perhaps it wouldn't have been possible if it weren't because the sorceress puts up with her… um, mean personality.

Catra scoffed, smirking, and Scorpia laughed at herself.

However, Perfuma was still concerned and said —Even if there was any chance for that to happen… It wasn't your fault, Catra. You do know that, right? The way she treated you, or that she was so awful instead of being a jerk but then replying to your defiance in this playful manner… It's *all* on her. Perhaps it just wasn't the right time, and now it is; perhaps *something* changed.

That made Scorpia ask, with absolute innocence, —Have you ever talked back to her these last months? Perhaps now she won't…

—No, no! Don't even think about it! She'll kill me!

—What!? No! Catra, she *can't* hurt anyone anymore!— Perfuma immediately reminded her, noticing her panic. —And no one will let her touch you! You're now safe!

The princess did her best to reassure her, but to no avail. The damage had been done. They decided it would be better to end it there.

—Just… I know you still hope she'll treat you better one day, and perhaps this is proof she will. But even if she doesn't… You're strong, Wildcat. We're sure you will be alright.

—Please call us the next time you need or want to talk about this so you're feeling better by the time you return to Etheria.

After having hung up, the princesses and Bow exchanged a look, all of them with the same thoughts in mind. They know Catra has to be in her best mental state by the time they arrive because no one can predict how she and Adora will react once they learn what the king has done. But for now, this is absolutely *not* the time to mention it.

Back in space, Adora has once again heard the last part of her conversation and doesn't hesitate to go and hug her.

Supportingly, she says —I'm so proud of you Catra. I hope you can feel better now that you admitted all of this. And… I had no idea, I'm sorry I never asked.

—It's alright, dummy. Not like I wanted to say anything before.

—Look, I… I think I can tell you something to make you feel better about being worried and such… You know how we did that because King Micah is "worried" about Shadow Weaver being around his sister, but doesn't trust her and only causes them to keep fighting?— Adora began. Catra nodded and she continued —Well, a few years ago, before the… fall of Salineas, I did the same to Glimmer—. While Catra first felt ashamed when being reminded about what she had considered her greatest victory over the Rebellion, hearing Adora say that last part immediately shocked her out of it and caught her full attention. —Just like Micah now, I was worried about Glimmer learning from Shadow Weaver, and seemingly trusting her, despite her insisting she wasn't that naïve and wasn't merely believing her; Glimmer asked me to trust *her*, not Shadow Weaver, but I… II didn't. Just like Micah, I let that ruin our friendship. While you are far better than either of us— she insisted. Catra felt like

tearing up but just looked away. —Focus on that. You did what we couldn’t; you're doing amazing, I promise.

Just as they wished, the rest of the week her mood remained much calmer and stable, her irritability fully under control.

Chapter End Notes

For the record: I don't know how many times I point out the parallels between Catra and SW, but seriously, they are notorious. For instance, Catra’s paranoid overthinking about punishments for just whatever she does, is the exact same mental state that assaults SW with anything related to trusting or caring for others. Memories and what-ifs spiral into their minds and are just as difficult to stop; they both need the same kind of help, but Catra actively asks for help now, while SW still hasn't learnt to do that (she will, and it will be very wholesome because of what that means for her and everyone around her). And, um, of course, this is what happens to me, yeah. I end up getting anxious before the actually anxiety-inducing even happens. Oops! (I have help, worry not. That *exactly* why I'm elaborating so much on how these two learn to control that, and how much of a difference the proper support can do.) Catra feels safe enough to slowly open up with those she knows and her thoughts can only make her panic when it's about people she hardly knows, like Casta here. On the other hand, SW can't even trust herself, so entirely forget about opening up this quickly. Again, that is also my issue; you know how, in S5, SW tells Casta “And stop me if I try to take the power for myself”? That's because she *can’t trust herself*, she's well aware she isn't in full control of that; and for me it's the same with the violent impulses. I prefer not to interact with my brother when alone because I can't trust myself to keep such impulses under control if something happens; I'm afraid of my own reactions, and so is she but by know you must have noticed she doesn't exactly call it “fear” hahah

Oh oh, and that last part, what Adora said:
I was rewatching the series (with jp dub, the voices are a whole experience, especially LS/SW’s because you can *hear* the change, and in the portal reality, her VA used LS’s voice which made it even more significant TT^TT), I reached S4 and paid a lot of attention to Glimmer, Adora, and SW because I couldn't remember how their conflict began (aside from DT’s input). So, I noticed how one of the reasons why they argued was that Adora, out of concern, deemed everything SW could teach Glimmer as “dark magic”, and unintentionally considered she didn't have what's necessary to avoid being manipulated, as if she was “too innocent”. Glimmer does say “I’m not asking you to trust her. But can you trust me?”, and I realized that’s pretty much what I had Casta tell Micah (that wasn't on purpose), so I came and added this little detail here because, yeah, Catra is actually the only one respectful enough; eeven being greatly concerned, she doesn't consider herself the holder of absolute truth or entitled to meddle in Casta’s life “because it's for her own good”.

Alright, enough self-analysis <(^_^”)
Until next week it is! (and you'll get the ending of the last flashback!)

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: not everyone is like you, even those who are
Status (2/2): being rejected…
…
Initiating system reboot…
…
System breached
…
Retrying…

Chapter Notes

Alright, it finally is here
There are SO many references to *The Price of Power* episode that I suppose watching it after reading this might make you notice the same I did. I was thinking about this chapter one day, just because, and like… I swear I'm not imagining things, my gods. Casta *was* genuinely concerned for SW when Angella mentioned she was agonizing! Like, I do think Angella was concerned perhaps, her expression was kinda sorrowful, and like, they both *should* have considered it retribution for what happened with Micah, but instead, they just stopped the interrogation. I suppose Angella, thinking like the Leader of the rebellion, and considering there was nothing that could be done for her now, would have tried to continue the interrogation, but yeah, asking the Princess Alliance because she couldn't find it in her to simply continue (would have been what someone like SW would do, but in the rebellion they aren't like that). On the other hand, Casta must have been thinking only like someone who's lost someone she loved and perhaps noticed there Adora cared for the woman despite *everything*, so she was the one to suggest letting Adora see her before she died. Again, I suppose Casta also felt there was nothing to be done for her and, goodness, the sorrow when she said "her condition is getting worse", oh my heart. I love the writer of that script.

Okay, that's all for my Castawweaver POV of that chapter; just take it as Casta being too good-hearted for her own good hahah
AND, mind you, I think Micah would have been extremely conflicted seeing her like that, ngl. But mostly he'd latch onto what I had him say at the beginning of C-a-S: that's not the mentor he admired, she died the moment SW was "born", and he has nothing to grieve anymore.

I hope you like this awaited end of the flashback, hehe (If you don't recall the first part, I do suggest you reread it first)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

…

—I, on the contrary, now doubt if I ever was… At least when I was Light Spinner, of course. Seeing how much Micah hates me, I wonder if I haven't always been this loathed monster.

She saw Catra's ears perk up and her eyes widen; she sure wasn't expecting to hear her say that, was she?

—I'm sure he did— she confidently replied. —Just like Adora and I did- do— she added, looking down to the ground. The next moment, she closed her fists, angry again, and looked at her as if about to scream, but instead teared up once more as she continued —You were the only thing close enough to a parent we ever had! We both cared for you even when you were so cruel! I was ready to help you out even when it was your powers that hurt you for using them to *threaten me*! But you never *ever* saw it! Of course you now doubt if you could be loved; it's something you didn't *want* to see and still don't even now!— she reproached, hurt, disappointed even. —Can't you see!? I'm here, right now, because I was told to keep you safe! And *I want to* keep you safe!

—That makes no sense— Shadow Weaver immediately argued. —I don't need protection, I'm already dead.

—Ugh! You're a real imbecile! Or maybe just too much of a bitch to let yourself see it! I don't know at this point— Catra complained. However annoying that was, she couldn't really blame her for insulting her so much, so she only stared, waiting for her to actually say something. —Just like I didn't want to leave you alone facing this creature back in the Heart, now we won't leave you alone knowing so many of those idiots wanted to dismiss that weird spell thing just earlier! We both want you here! We-we want to keep you safe! That's- Well you understand. This is… all you're refusing to see.

She sounded more defeated than angry now, and her expression confirmed it. She had lowered her ears and was now hugging herself, yet something called her attention and Shadow Weaver followed her gaze to the left side of the summoning spell.

There was something nearing the drawn area on the ground; a light imp, something similar to her shadows spies, and equally capable of affecting magically infused things like the lines of the spell it was about to try and erase.

—Well, well. Look at that; you two were right— Shadow Weaver noticed, still sitting comfortably on the couch. She watched as Catra tried and failed to keep it away from the spell. —Those aren't as good as my shadow spies, but its flexibility is enough to escape your claws, Catra.

—Shut up and help! Won't you!?

—Why should I?

—It's trying to banish you!

—Then let it.

—No!— she yelled, indignant. —Stop being a jerk and do something!

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh and raised an illusion near the bright pinkish imp and it immediately recoiled as her illusion tried to smash it. Soon enough, it had run away, back to where it came from.

Seeing it gone, Catra laid down on the ground, exhausted. She remained like that for a while until Adora arrived and found her there.

—Catra!? Are you okay?— she questioned her, confused.

—Of course not! She's being an idiot!— she replied, raising an arm a bit and gesturing at Shadow Weaver's general direction.

Adora let out a sigh before asking —What happened?

—Some magical thing came to mess up the summoning spell… and she was going to allow it!— Catra complained.

She *really* cared, didn't she?

Adora looked back at her, surprised, and questioned —You-you don't care if you're unsummoned?

—I can hardly believe that wouldn't be for the best. You're just being too sentimental— she replied nonchalantly.

Catra scoffed and finally got up as she told Adora —She thinks no one has ever cared about her…

—But- You really think we hate you?—. Adora's hurt expression made her look away. However, Shadow Weaver looked back as she heard her approaching. —When you escaped the Horde and were almost dying, I healed you because I wanted to; I wouldn't just let you die, it was never for the information! And I only wanted to know why you were there, I never cared for your "vital information" to defeat Hordak— she explained. She stopped barely outside the area of the spell, looked away, and grabbed her left arm tightly as she admitted —I really liked how it felt learning from you. It was… the first time I really understood what I was doing with my powers…—. Adora let out a sigh, shook her head, and looked back at her, almost resentful. —You could have done the same at the Horde, with the both of us.

—Leave it, Adora. She's convinced we all wanted her to die— Catra sighed.

—You can't be serious… Don't you- Oh, wait, perhaps you *don't* know…— Adora began, but interrupted herself. She rolled her eyes and explained —None of us wanted you to die, and I *really* mean it. I just mentioned how I healed you but, before that, Queen Angella and Castaspella had forbidden me to go anywhere near you, so we took a chance when they left the room and Bow went to distract them.

—Yes, I remember. I don't see your point— she interrupted, unamused.

—We heard them speak for a moment, before sneaking in. They mentioned you were dying- Actually, Glimmer's aunt was just suggesting they let me see you because of that!— Adora replied. —They were concerned about you! And they are literally the two persons you've affected the most when it comes to King Micah!

Shadow Weaver was pensive for a moment.

—Yes, the Queen realized and pointed out I was dying, then Castaspella asked her to speak and they left— she recalled.

—You mean… the Queen would have continued?— Catra reflected and looked back at Adora.

—Well, I…— Adora interrupted, scratching her neck and looking away nervously. —I don't think so. The last I heard was how the Head Sorceress said the interrogation was going nowhere and that her condition was growing worse; and then Bow told us Queen Angella wanted to consult the Princess Alliance. So… it'd be unfair to judge just from that— she remembered. —In fact… Bow mentioned that because, if we hadn't sneaked in…

Shadow Weaver noticed her hesitation to finish, and snickered before saying it herself —I didn't have that much time, right?

—Whatever. That only means literally everyone was *at least* a bit concerned for you; we don't have a single example of someone saying it would have been better if Adora never healed you— Catra remarked. She crossed her arms and looked away, mustering all her confidence to say —So stop with the self-loathing already. You're giving me second-hand embarrassment.

Shadow Weaver sniggered at that, but before she could make some nasty comeback, which both girls seemed to anticipate, Adora interrupted, preferring to change subjects.

—So… What happened while I was away? Why- Why were you on the floor, Catra?

She looked ready to jump into yet another reproach, angrily replying at Adora while making a point of how annoyed she was; the sorceress already expected it. However, much to her surprise, Catra just brushed her hair back while taking a very deep breath with her eyes closed.

Much calmer, she explained —Something showed up. An imp, she said. And it was trying to erase a part of this thing on the ground. I don't know the first thing about magic but… it doesn't take a genius to know this thing is kinda fragile.

—*Fragile*? Well, that's certainly a way to call it— Shadow Weaver commented, amused.

—So… that imp. Someone sent it?— Adora asked. —And where is it?

—I chased it away.

—In fact, *you* failed to do so.

—You-

—Please don't start!— Adora interrupted, putting a hand on Catra's shoulder who glared at the sorceress in such a way that she had to ask about it. —Do you mean it was actually you who chased it away? Then why was Catra so tired?— she questioned her.

—Because she tried to use her claws to catch a being that is essentially the same I am now.

—Which means—, Catra interrupted, —That she could have chased that away on her own. But I practically had to beg her to do it!

—Why!?

—Because of what I was telling you before! She thinks it's better if she's definitely gone! She doesn't wanna listen to me!— Catra cried out, grabbing Adora's hands, possibly needing to ground herself.

Shadow Weaver could barely believe the sorrow in her voice. How could this be?

—It's alright, Catra— Adora assured her. —We can always tell Castaspella to keep an eye on the council. We lent her the mask, she'd surely agree with us.

—There is absolutely no need to tell her— the sorceress immediately sentenced.

That would certainly ensure the spell wouldn't be dismissed at all. After all, she did offer her help; the Head Sorceress would never let this opportunity pass. But she really shouldn't be there. Now she had seen the girls, perhaps provided some closure, and even made it up to Mystacor by ensuring it wouldn't plummet down to the ground. There was no need to keep her around, was there?

The girls didn't seem to share her opinion at all.

—Of course there is!— Catra replied, indignant. —We told you: we don't want you gone. She asked me to guard you, and good thing she did, because she wants you here too, much to your luck. Someone wants you gone, do you understand that?— she insisted. Shadow Weaver nodded, just as nonchalantly as earlier, and made it clear it didn't worry her in the slightest. —We're- Don't you see we're doing this for you!? You're just sitting there, even without that mask there's not a sign of concern even for yourself! So- So- So you don't even care!? Seriously!?— the girl yelled, stammering as her distress increased.

—Or you care too much— the sorceress replied with absolute carelessness. Right after, she noticed Glimmer and Castaspella had arrived; perfect to escape this unpleasant argument. Shadow Weaver immediately turned to address the Head Sorceress. —I see you're back already. Crises averted, I presume.

That had been one interesting day. And Catra's warning to Castaspella had resulted in nothing, after that; nothing ever attempted to erase the spell again. However, she's now gone; would Catra reproach her for that?

Speaking of which, the fact that Catra had caught up so easily how she was trying to keep Castaspella out of that… She had to admit that was quite sharp from her: noticing she really wanted something to happen so she'd be unsummoned, and that the sorceress was the only one who could keep that from happening… Yes, back then she wanted to be banished; could've never foreseen how things would develop.

She was so sure it'd be better for them, for that stubborn sorceress… But now she doubted it.

She had somehow gone from questioning whether she had ever been loved, to being reminded how much her girls cared for her more than she deserved, being patiently explained why her behaviours were wrong every single time, being admired by her pupils once again, and finally… *that*.

Had it really happened or was it her imagination?

No, of course it happened. That's why Micah smashed her mask, after all.

Somehow, the night before hadn't been half as unbelievable as that single kiss.

Lust she can understand, but that kiss was *not* the same.

Chapter End Notes

A lil point I'd like to clarify:

While it IS SW's pov, hence her considering Casta -like she'd do- only wanted her there for the help she could provide, I have the feeling you guys would consider Casta's intention were nowhere near that but

in fact

SW was right, at least back then. Like, if Casta did miss her, she'd be like in the woods in S5, reminding herself what's politically correct to feel for her, hence, missing her couldn't possibly be right. And she *did* need here there for the help she could provide, honestly.

So erm, I suppose it's obvious why, in the summary, I said she was like rejecting the lesson but then the system (aka, her mindset/beliefs/worldview) was breached ahah

Until next week it is!

Congratulations on doing the same they did

Chapter Summary

As another day arrives, Queen Glimmer makes it her mission to keep the council in line, especially now that her aunt isn't there to point out their flawed and paranoid thinking.
»—I wasn’t there to see how you treated Light Spinner, but I’m here now to see how you want to punish a kid whom you pushed to seek answers by any means, out of sorrow, not malice. By doing so, you are, in fact, forcing him into the path you so fear he will take.

And, once again, the wheel of the siblings' relationship goes down.
»—Well, congratulations, Micah, on doing the same they did.
»Her brother scoffed sardonically without even looking back, and merely said —I'm not taking *myself* away from you.
»Castaspella couldn’t help grimacing at his selfish remark and made a huge effort to remain respectful as she corrected him —I wasn't referring to *you*—. Micah immediately stopped in his tracks yet didn’t look back at her, shocked and not daring to wonder what she meant. But she needed him to know —You took *her* away from me. You're *just* as bad as them.

Chapter Notes

The fact that I wrote the beginning of this minutes before the song *Tender* by Lisa Hannigan began playing
You know what, I'm leaving you here a Playlist of songs that gave me such great castaweaver vibes they usually ended up inspiring me drafts for more fics hehe
That song is there and LITERALLY is the same! Even the "under lights and the dark" that is pretty much what I describe! Heh
So, from now on, I'm very likely to mention songs here in the notes if they are remotely related to what you'll read (and keep adding the link to the playlist too so you don't have to go searching for it back here)
Besides! I should probably say: there are so many songs that apply to this path in general; you may or may not cry <("^-^)

ANYWAYS! Please enjoy! (on the ending notes I'll explain a few things that are headcanons of mine that I'll maintain through basically all my writings)

Okay, no, one final note: Check out this, please. I'm so honored to have such talented reader (and may I recommend checking all the art too? Honestly, you won't regret it) (Edit, I THINK that's the correct link!? I mean, the dates fit and all… And again, the posted art you'll find in that twt is all fantastic and I seriously recommend it!)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were dancing. Under the moonlight. Darkness all around. And she was close once again, just looking right into her eyes.

The shine of the moon occasionally illuminated her face. Scars and split eyes barely a palm away. They were swaying with ease, focused solely on each other.

And then, a tender kiss.

Castaspella woke up, startled and sweating, with that pain in her chest once again.

—Ugh, fuck— she let out. —Curse my mind, that was… so mean— she complained, breathless.

A dream of something that now shall never happen; of something that wouldn't have happened anyways.

She wanted to scream out of frustration, sorrow, and with a new stung from the spell, she probably would have. But she couldn't let herself lose control like that, even being alone; she would never allow more than some cursing to escape her. After taking a deep breath, focusing on relaxing her tense body, she finally got up to ready herself for the day.

However, when she was about to leave the room, Castaspella looked at her mirror and walked towards it instead.

She stared for a moment and felt some sort of numbness. She felt absolutely nothing for a moment and couldn't help but observe the room in the reflection: everything seemed to be tied to a memory, nice or sad, funny or merely annoying.

She finally turned around, having seen something she had almost forgotten.

She had entirely ignored her little pets! As she went to the back of her room, she fondly recalled her bickerings with Beatrix about her tiny bugs and how annoying she had gotten, that it was in fact her way of satisfying her curiosity without admitting being interested, and that she had once found her experimenting with her illusions as she noticed how those attracted them just like other forms of magic.

She took a moment to feed and play with them before leaving as, after all, she's supposed to take this week for herself. Castaspella let out a nostalgic sigh; she could almost hear the woman's annoying opinions once again, although, this time, she only laughed faintly, finding them funnier now.

—Why would you keep such disgusting creatures…

—Call my spiders "disgusting" one more time…

—They- Are you serious!? What's next? My scars aren't "disgusting" either?

—I've already said they aren't!

Perhaps that ironic comment about the scars was, like those about her pets, just a way of asking what she thinks about them?

No, no. Why would she care about that? No, it had to be her overthinking the comment, or just some wishful thinking of hers.

But, the more she thought about those remarks, the more endearing they sounded. The Head Sorceress had come to greatly appreciate their constant bickering; even when the woman was a complete bitch, she enjoyed that, because it turns out that Beatrix was only this much of a jerk when something actually mattered to her.

It was messed up, especially when she realized that was exactly why the woman, most ironically, treated her girls like that; when she simply didn't care about something, she'd act as if it didn't exist. Castaspella had called out her behaviour so many times, always getting an eye-roll from her as she focused on how mean and derogative Beatrix was, until she realized this and it all made sense: she just won't show interest or concern because it makes her feel weak or pathetic, or whatever her fucked up beliefs told her, and the only way to bypass that, was finding the meanest way to express those feelings.

It seemed so stupid, but it was actually very obvious: Beatrix knew that insulting her pets would make the sorceress immediately counter whatever she had said in a way that could satisfy her unspoken curiosity, and she was so condescending to the girls because she couldn't just say "your plan might get you hurt" showing her concern, she had to go being spiteful and insist that the plan was "ridiculous" and "the worst strategy they had ever come up with".

That day, the only reason why Castaspella knew she was actually worried that the plan would lead them to their doom, was because she later annoyed her non-stop, wanting to know why she was saying all of that, until Beatrix finally exploded.

> —Don't you realize!? Am I the only one noticing how flawed the plan is!? They haven't considered how to get back, or whether the conditions on that planet are bearable for their bodies! It *is* ridiculous to simply barge into an unknown planet! And I didn't raise a pair of idiots who can only come up with "At the first sight of danger, we leave" as their only strategy! What if they don't even have time for that? Not all dangers can be seen!
>
> —Why didn't you just say that!?
>
> —I did!
>
> —No! You just reviled their plan and made them feel incapable!
>
> —Because they are acting like idiots!
>
> —You say that as if your plans hadn't been just as reckless or worse! If you're worried for their safety, *say it*! I'm sure they will welcome the help! But mere insults will only result in them pushing you away and carrying out their plan as it is out of spite!

Castaspella let out a sigh, nostalgic and dispirited. One of her pets looked up at her, moving its legs as if wanting to call her attention, and then crawled up to the top of the terrarium. The sorceress gave it one last treat before finally leaving the room.

It was another busy day in the kingdom and Glimmer was making sure the council put enough effort into handling everything without needing to call the Head Sorceress. But it proved to be more difficult than anticipated. She was lucky things were calm in Bright Moon so she could focus here, with only half the council being competent enough, she had to compensate for the rest of them.

However, they had a small issue around noon that Queen Glimmer had no idea how to deal with.

—This is unprecedented.

—No one has ever done something like this since…

—Since Light Spinner. Although, I don't think this is remotely comparable, only in terms of disrespect for the authority.

—That's what I meant, precisely. She presented her plan to us and we only rejected her without providing alternatives or heeding her warnings about the Horde, so she went and did it regardless. Now, the kids came to ask us and we refused to answer a single question, so Sahm resorted to this so he could get the information we denied them.

—So this is all our fault!? That's what you mean?

—Look: we did this now, like back then, for their own safety, but perhaps we didn't handle it the best way and underestimated just how far they were able to go, so they resorted to the alternatives they had, and this is the result! I'm just saying we didn't learn anything from what happened with Light Spinner, and we're lucky Sahm only used a mere truth spell.

—He's too young! Had he done it wrong, or confused sigils, you would have suffered excruciating pain!

—I *wanted* to let him know!

Glimmer remained quiet, listening to their chaotic discussion, until that last admission silenced the room. The council was looking at the old councilman in utter shock.

—Care to explain?— Glimmer finally asked, as respectful as she could manage, trying to hide her surprise.

—Ah… of course— he sighed. —As you all know… now that two of our oldest members retired, I am the only one left in this council who dates back to Light Spinner's time— he began. —I witnessed her impeccable tutoring and her later corruption. The damage those events caused to Mystacor, and how this has affected all Head Sorcerers since then. And I've also… seen how differently her story affected Micah and Castaspella—. He fell silent for a moment, looking for the right words to explain himself. —The behavior Micah has shown is the same as it used to be, but considerably worsened by how close his sister and Light- eh… Shadow Weaver became. On the other hand, Castaspella has always had a far more difficult relationship with the image of Light Spinner she crafted, entirely based on others' opinions. And, of course, I was here when it was decided how her admiration was to be handled— he elaborated. Right after, he couldn't help adding, with obvious reproach, —May I remind everyone that our Head Sorceress grew surrounded by our exaggerated stories, which she fully believed as we made her think those Light Spinner's former pupils with whom she spoke had been brainwashed by the woman. But we all know those are lies!—. Realizing how angry he was getting, he preferred to get back to his original point and, more calmly, continued —I trust our Head Sorceress' judgment, and understand these kids are genuinely fond of Light- Erm… Shadow Weaver. For that, I believe they deserve to know, especially after hearing how they thought she had abandoned them. I won't have anyone else believe lies about the woman, truth alone gives a picture of just how awful she was, and pretending none of the good things she has done ever happened, is just as bad as trying to justify her wrongs or pretend those didn't happen either.

—I see— Glimmer nodded, pensive. —In that case, how come you were affected by the truth spell?

—When he threatened me with the spell, I told him I wanted to tell them the truth from the beginning, and that now I would, but he suspected I'd only tell him what he wanted to hear, so I instructed him on how to fix the truth spell so he could use it on me and be sure I wouldn't lie to him.

Glimmer's expression darkened. She would've never imagined any of this. It's clear no one in the council is fond of Shadow Weaver at all, but this man absolutely acknowledges both the good and the bad she's done, just like her aunt does, making it even more evident how unfair the treatment she had received was.

Shadow Weaver was manipulative, a real jerk, and extremely cruel, reckless, and dismissive of the dangers her plans could entail, but the Queen had witnessed some of her good qualities too, the way she taught her sorcery, how cunning she had been when they were looking for the saboteur, and how she had been tutoring those kids, or helping her aunt with her duties, insecurities, and even her casting.

—I also think they deserved to know, but perhaps I was too afraid of their reaction to it— Glimmer began. —We have been unfair, exaggerating how much of a monster she was, when even Adora and Catra vouched for her to be a tutor again. We all know how awful she can be, but pretending she has nothing good to offer… if you were told you can't possibly have anything good to provide, would you even try? Or would you consider it's pointless to try at all, no matter how much you have to offer?— she inquired, with such a serious demeanor no one dared say a word. —I, just like Castaspella, know how much damage she has done and is still capable to do, but just like I acknowledged her expertise and accepted her lessons on sorcery, which appears to be something you all disapprove of, my aunt also recognized all the positive qualities she has but wouldn't ever offer due to considering no one deserved her help— she explained. —And she proved she could, in fact, help a lot when allowed, when she deems it's deserved. That's what Castapella's trust earned us! From the day the kingdom almost collapsed because of the Crystal of Arxia's decay, to her very last moment here, when she helped my aunt perfect the teleportation spell!

—We have all noticed the significant improvements due to her help, but we couldn't just trust her. And this kid, he's just like her in every sense. If he were to grow up following her path…

—That line of thinking is the problem here— Glimmer interrupted. —To begin with, neither my aunt nor me just trust her blindly, but immediately refusing to consider her advice is unfair. And now, thinking Sahm is doomed to become a new Shadow Weaver is even *more* unfair— she pointed out, indignant. —I wasn't there to see how you treated Light Spinner, but I'm here now to see how you want to punish a kid whom you pushed to seek answers by any means, out of sorrow, not malice. By doing so, you are, in fact, forcing him into the path you so fear he will take.

The room was silent for a long minute before the councilman provisionally in charge finally spoke up.

—We shall regard Sahm's transgression for what it is, with the extenuatory of having used this spell with our councilman's consent, and taking into account this was motivated by desperation and sorrow — he sentenced. —With regards to the kids now knowing the truth about King Micah's doing, I suggest we don't let our Head Sorceress or the King know about this for now, and instead have a proper conversation with the pupils as we should have done from the beginning— he added. —The Queen is right: we should have regarded Shadow Weaver as a mentor first, and given her pupils a proper explanation. We shall correct our mistake the way our Head Sorceress would have done— he concluded, and no one objected. —Meeting dismissed.

—Well, that should do…— she sighed.

The Head Sorceress made sure her dress was all arranged before leaving the bathroom of her room. She sighed again, observing for a moment how her brother picked up various pieces of glass from the ground, in an attempt to repair her mirror.

—Are you alright?— he asked, without looking back.

—Yes, yes, all patched up.

—Great, then… let me just…

Micah placed on Castaspella's desk all the big pieces he had gathered, then picked up the frame of the broken mirror and laid it on the desk too. He drew a sigil on it but, before activating it, he placed the biggest fragments of the mirror in their corresponding places.

—That really works?— Castaspella asked, curious.

—Let's hope so— he replied with half a smile, and finally activated it.

The whole frame lit up with the magic, so did the fragments of mirror left on the desk, and even some smaller pieces still on the ground. Slowly, they all gathered on the frame, and it was finally repaired.

So to say.

—So?

—It partially worked? I think?

The siblings stared at the mirror for a moment. It was *technically* in one piece, but the cracks between the pieces disrupted the reflection, as expected. Micah seemed disappointed with the results, but Castaspella only reached out and slowly traced one of the largest cracks.

—I suppose we can get you a new one— he suggested.

—No, no— she immediately reacted. —It's alright, trust me.

—Really?

—Yes, don't worry.

The Head sorceress picked up the mirror herself and accommodated it in place. She stared at it, as if looking at something her brother couldn't see, and that reminded him of how, just earlier, she had admitted that sometimes she thought she was seeing Shadow Weaver's reflection there.

He had been thinking about all of this for days, yet still, he just couldn't understand.

—You're really…— he began, hesitantly. He let out a deep sigh and gathered the strength to finally say —You're really happy with her, around her…

—I am- was— she admitted, without looking back at him.

—I don't understand— he admitted, defeated. —What makes you feel so- What made you fall in love?

In love.

She took a deep breath before attempting to reply, even if she herself wasn't sure about that specific term, —I guess… no, I *know*, it's because she really sees me for who I am. She values my skills, points out my flaws without hesitation, offers me help, she's always genuine, for the best and the worst, and I know she's not putting up a "polite" façade for me…

Micah shook his head, even more confused, or disappointed perhaps, and insisted —What I don't understand is how it doesn't seem suspicious to you. You aren't just anyone, you're *my* sister.

Castaspella froze and slowly looked back at him, indignant but remaining as calm as possible.

—So you think she wouldn't treat me like this if it weren't for that?

—I'm inclined to think that, yes.

—I'm sorry to say it like this, brother, but don't you realize how selfish that sounds?— she pointed out, as politely as she could. —You *always* say the same: that she's manipulating me to put me against *you*, she's flirting with me to annoy *you*, she agrees with me to contradict *you*— she enumerated. She looked away for a moment, pained, and finally dared ask —Is it really *so inconceivable* that she just regards me for *me*? That when she thinks about me it is not as "Micah's sister" but rather as "Castaspella"? Am I not worthy of that?

—Sis, you deserve much better.

—Why do you think I don't know what's "better" for me?

—Casta…

—Answer me something, please— she interrupted.

The King let out a deep sigh, complying —Alright.

—When you came to me, at the Lunarium, and suggested I missed her: You already thought she had charmed me, right?— she began. He nodded, so she continued —Then why did you ask me like that?

Right.

He breathed in, as if gathering strength, and began —I was… I wanted to prove it first. If you try to tell someone who is charmed that they are, usually they will go mad because the spell starts collapsing but tries to retake control—. He seemed a bit nervous but made an effort to continue —So, instead, I tried asking subtly, to see if you were infatuated with the idea of her. When I mentioned it, you threw it back at me, so I thought you *did* just need closure. Until… the moment I said we could summon her—. It was difficult to determine whether that was an expression of defeat or just his utter disbelief, but he looked away, notoriously conflicted. —You should have seen the way your eyes immediately lit up with… hope? Expectation? Like you had been told the best news since the war ended. I- I *had* to think you were masterfully charmed so it would be less noticeable…

Castaspella couldn’t comprehend where this was coming from and only shook her head, confused, as she asked —Why would she have charmed me? Why did you even come up with that idea to begin with?

Her brother looked away, embarrassed, and replied —I discovered you were reading all her old investigations. A curator mentioned it by chance. And I couldn’t understand why you would be doing that all of a sudden.

—Why didn't you ask *me* about that?— she inquired, even more confused now.

—I panicked! I- I was afraid, even after having died, she was still…

He hesitated and it immediately made Castaspella suspicious, angry perhaps, as she could guess what he could be trying to say.

—“Still” what?

—Ruining what I love.

So that’s what he feared.

Castaspella let out a sigh, approached him, and placed a hand on his shoulder.

With a pained look of understanding, she gently asked him —You really think she ruined me?

—No, of course not— he immediately replied. —But she has a knack for ruining everything she touches…

—Then I must be immune— she joked.

—Sis, I'm serious.

—As am I— she sentenced, her tone and expression more severe now. —I am not- I *can’t* keep discussing this with you, Micah. I can’t bear it. But you just won’t drop the subject or accept my word for it, so… either you stop questioning me about this, or- or entirely stop speaking with me.

Micah took a step back, away from her touch, and looked at her directly in the eyes, serious and feeling betrayed.

—Then I suppose it’s back to the silent treatment for us— he sentenced. Castaspella felt immensely pained, but preferred not to say anything, telling herself there was no point in replying. But, as he left the room, he added —You're choosing one of the people responsible for taking me away from you all these years.

He just *had to*.

Her blood boiled with anger, and yet, she chose to remain as calm as possible as she taunted back —Well, congratulations, Micah, on doing the same they did.

Her brother scoffed sardonically without even looking back, and merely said —I'm not taking *myself* away from you.

Castaspella couldn’t help grimacing at his selfish remark and made a huge effort to remain respectful as she corrected him —I wasn't referring to *you*—. Micah immediately stopped in his tracks yet didn’t look back at her, shocked and not daring to wonder what she meant. But she needed him to know —*You* took *her* away from me. You're *just* as bad as them.

So now she was comparing him to the Horde!? Comparing him to *her*!?

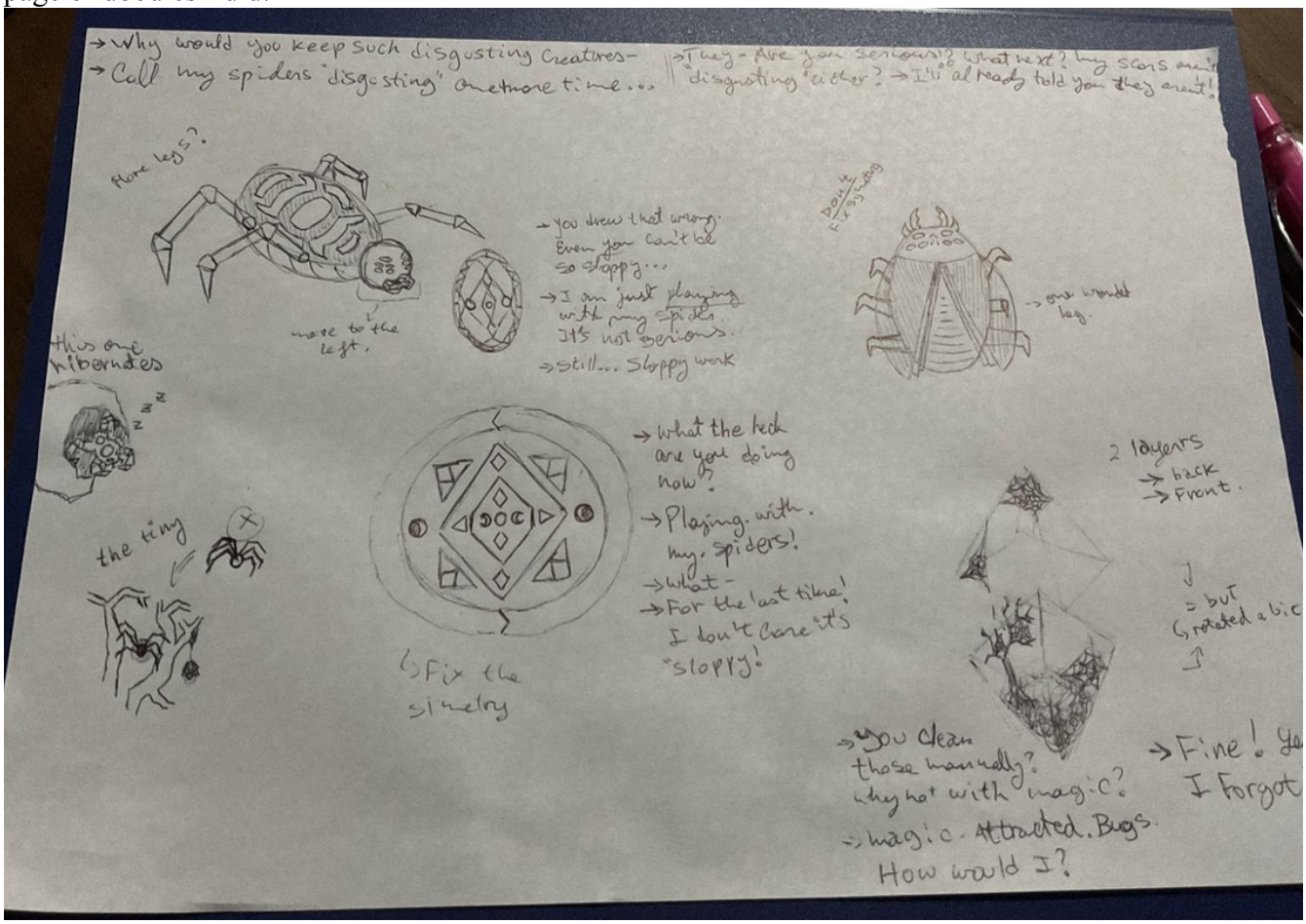
That was it. He couldn’t take it anymore. He closed his fists tightly and stalked out of the room.

That was enough.

Chapter End Notes

(Glimmer trying to be formal by using her full name but less than a minute later calling her "Aunt" again 😂😂)

Oh right, where to begin:
Casta's pets: One day I was thinking that, despite being a cats-person myself, I couldn't really see her having cats or anything; but then I remember that, in fact, I'm also a spiders-person, and for a while I've wanted to have terrariums with some (as in, instead of just going around the house, have them safely in a terrarium where my cat, dog, or *mother* won't try to kill them). So, since then I've been doodling some ideas, thinking about those animals that were either magical or seemed to consume it. I haven't yet had time to make a proper digital drawing of those, I have some drafts to do tho, but at least, so that you get an idea of how her pets would be, here's the page of doodles I did:



Oh, about SW only being such a jerk when something/someone mattered... let's just say I have, apparently, been including this detail in C-a-S even but hadn't noticed (like how SW kept mocking the whole festivity in Mystacor, or said Casta was a fool for letting them overwork her, instead of, you know, saying something like "I'm worried you're going to pass out from trying to do *everything*", so it seemed logical to me that Casta would end up noticing that's actually a pattern with literally everything. And I just *really* like the concept because it fits her twisted personality and the "battle" between her LS side and her SW side, so to say.

Oh, oh, before you ask: that councilman is kind of also a headcanon of mine; I mentioned in C-a-S how some members of the council had told the kids' parents about how LS was as a tutor, and that they even witnessed her classes and noticed she still taught the same way. So now I decided to have him as the last one of them left in the council, and his particular issue with calling her

"SW" will be explained a bit more in a flashback that I don't-yet-know when I'm posting. Erm, and the guy doesn't have a name, so if someone wants to suggest one, be my guest; I quite like this guy, and he voices my indignation for the blatant dismissal of her positive traits (sorry but that's quite hypocritical, it's the same SW did to Catra, so freaking lol to the part of the fandom who only see the bad traits, just as she did with Catra; with all due respect, you're no better).

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: You can be loved, truly loved
Status: Being debated

Chapter Notes

Oh
This flashback…

It's one of the latest memories of Shadow Weaver, you know? You may realize this since what Casta says about the class… She's finally showing growth, and wanting to grow. Which, I'll say it from now -I'm so sorry-, makes it all the sadder to realize *when* this happened.
But to compensate: wholesome. This is so sappy and wholesome!
Ahem…

I'd also like to link you to the second fanart of TaTM I've gotten ☺ This illustration of the beginning of chapter 13, by Cana_Alberona 🖤
It's so beautiful!! And it's a perfect representation of that beginning! Omgs! And with how much I liked that idea to start the chapter 😩 my heart! 🖤
SO GO CHECK IT OUT!!

Anyways: enjoy!!

(Oh, and I challenge you to discover which songs of my castaweaver playlist (now at 90 songs!) inspired these flashbacks heh [hint: one is *Time after Time* that totally fits both kinds of chapters here]. Don't feel obligated tho *-*)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Deep nostalgia. Of course that sorceress was feeling extremely sentimental. It's almost surprising for her that it took Castaspella this long to feel so utterly nostalgic.

But it wasn't *just* that. There was also something so difficult to understand for her, that it made her remember the first time she had felt that from Castaspella; she hadn't understood it back then either, so perhaps, she needed to revisit this memory.

She told herself not to fight the feeling, not to regard it overall, and just to observe the memory. That helped her keep the pain at bay for longer, even if the memory finally breaks her resolve, it would at least let her keep the sorceress from feeling these painful punishments through the spell for longer.

—You care too much about everything.

—And you don't care about *anything* in the slightest!

Shadow Weaver was calmly reading on a couch in the library, leaning over a book she had open on the armrest, but the sorceress insisted on discussing with her yet another stupid issue that shouldn't even be her responsibility. She made a point of showing just how little she cared and kept her sight on her book, even if she wasn't actually reading.

With how indignant Castaspella was, she'd normally press on and annoy her even more, but this time, she had a better idea to make sure she'd stop solving others' problems all the time.

—Then let's make a deal— Shadow Weaver began, looking back at her over her shoulder. —For every time you choose your fights more wisely and only give your time and energy to what *actually* deserves it, I shall also spare *some* energy in what you deem important…"

Castaspella stared at her in disbelief for a moment before snapping out of it with an amused scoff.

—We won't be able to keep track of that and you know it— she giggled.

—Maybe— Shadow Weaver admitted. Yet she only smirked as she added —But it's still worth a shot, isn’t it?

She'd make this woman cut the excessive free help one way or another.

Castaspella only let out a faint smile but didn't answer. Shadow Weaver got a strange feeling through the spell but didn't know what it was, so she just ignored it and returned to her reading.

However, shortly after, she felt the sorceress sit behind her, hug her waist, and rest her head on her shoulder. She had been doing this for a few weeks now, and Shadow Weaver was slowly getting used to it; the embrace was far less invasive than an actual hug, and feeling the weight of the woman on her back made her forget for a while that she's a mere spirit.

—Suddenly so eager to learn?— Castaspella asked, with a curious and slightly teasing tone.

—Well… Someone called me a hypocrite for getting mad at the children due to their slow learning pace— she reminded her, smirking in anticipation as she knew full well it would angry the sorceress.

—You just want to chastise them again without me calling out your hypocrisy!

—Perhaps…

Castaspella had to hold back her laughter yet couldn’t help letting out a big smile, finding it a bit endearing.

—You’re terrible— she laughed. —Especially since their learning pace is the fastest in Mystacor!— she reminded her. Once again, Shadow Weaver was expecting her to say exactly that, so she could barely hold back a laugh. But before she could say anything, Castaspella added —Speaking of your class; tomorrow it will have to be delayed a bit. I’m on recharge duty at afternoon.

Afternoon? It should be during the morning, mainly because their classes are always during the afternoon.

—And why not at the usual time?— she questioned, trying and failing to sound aloof.

—I'll be busy all morning, so I asked for a reschedule; as we can't risk postponing it a full day, we'll just do it a few hours later instead.

—I see…— she hummed. Shadow Weaver returned to her reading, yet stopped once again when she felt Castaspella's embrace tighten around her waist. The woman froze for a moment, confused, perhaps concerned, and finally asked —Is anything wrong?

—Not really…— she sighed. —I just…

—Need to hug someone?— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—I suppose— she breathed out, wistful.

That feeling again. Something difficult to discern and that, in fact, Shadow Weaver prefered *not* to understand. Instead, to distract them both from it, she just rolled her eyes and smirked, ready to tease the sorceress.

—I guess I don't mind being of service for that too— she began, gladly surprising the sorceress. Until she added —After all, you have the spell that allows me to feel alive again.

—You're such a fool— she complained, with a soft tone she now recognized as half-annoyed half-amused.

She snickered and asked —For what, exactly?

—Making it sound like you're just paying off a debt!— she exclaimed, indignant. —You don't owe me, just admit you like doing this for me— Castaspella teased her, leaning forward over her.

But Shadow Weaver only played dumb and looked away as she replied —I have no idea what you're talking about.

She looked back at the sorceress, smirking, and returned to her book, with the feeling of Castaspella resting on her back.

Right.

That deal. What a shame.

She could vividly remember that day… *that night*… and the next day.

Taking all of that into consideration; what if Castaspella was struggling with her feelings right there? What if, with that hug, the sorceress was trying to just *let her know* without having to say it because she wouldn't dare?

Nonsense. That's ridiculous.

But then…

Then *nothing*. That night was mere lust, plain and simple. And it had been an *accident*. That's all there is to it. The sorceress is too sentimental, then *that* happened, and then Micah decided that was enough.

Of course not! Micah banished her because Castaspella *kissed* her! And why would she if not because…

She was just trying to mess up with her. Why else would the sorceress do that? She had tried many strategies before, all failed, and this would have worked perhaps, if it wasn't because he was watching them.

But that makes no sense. Yes, Castaspella had done a lot of things to try and unsettle her the same way she'd always do to the sorceress. But this is a line someone like her wouldn't cross. Because the sorceress is *not* like her. That must have been genuine, and so, the only explanation for that sensation, is that she's struggling with feelings. With her feelings for *her*.

That's simply impossible. It's ridiculous; wishful thinking. Shameful weak thinking.

Perhaps; but, possible or not, the truth remains: That night, she had *chosen her*. Not her brother, not the advantages that came with helping her; just the sorceress that gave her so much time and patience for eight months.

She certainly earned it.

No, she didn't choose Castaspella because "she had to, she earned it"; she chose her out of nowhere, it just happened, and she accepted it.

That's how the *weak* behave.

Then let this be the one weak decision she'd accept! Why not!? It's what she wants! The sorceress is the only thing she now wants!

But she now won't ever have it. She chose Castaspella and *doomed herself*.

So why is she still trying to convince herself it was worth it? That all this pain she's once again feeling was actually a fair price for the opportunity she had been given?

Chapter End Notes

SORRY I HAD TO!

Edit: I actually do have something to say:
While this is, yeah, SW just arguing with herself trying to convince her it's not Casta having feelings but, in fact, by this point she has very real feelings for her, it is *also* true that it was mere lust that night. But, one thing doesn't cancel out the other
Hehe, that's all!

~~I have nothing else to say here today <("^_^)~~

So, em, until next week!

She was a lot of fun to have around

Chapter Summary

The Head Sorceress prepares to take over Shadow Weaver's classes as her week of rest approaches the end, but memories can be quite bittersweet after months of having the woman around: *everything* reminds her of the grumpy, stubborn, mean, bitch that Beatrix was.

Meanwhile, Queen Glimmer finds herself at a crossroads once again.
»How to help her aunt without abandoning her father? How to be supportive enough to her father, as Castaspella advised her, without condoning his behaviour? And how to handle the Council so they wouldn't be that dependent on her aunt, nor heed her father's stance blindly? How to make the Council think for themselves if even when Castaspella has given them so much freedom, they are still unable to do so?

Chapter Notes

I have something for you guys: I made an edit!



TECHNICALLY, I did two edits of this pic with regular color, but -as here SW is summoned and looks more opaque- I edited her color for a more fic-accurate version, hehe.

Now, it's STORY TIME:
I got roped into a shangella roleplay that has now turned into a poly roleplay we're calling "angellacastaweaver". No joke. Now, the anecdotic part is: I only complied cause the one playing Angella is really fond of shangella so I didn't want to ruin the fun with my contempt for the ship. I had Casta act all jealous, obviously, but SW also pushed the castaweaver agenda with me and, surprise surprise, we somehow sneaked in a while of pure castaweaver. Now *guess what!?* This all turned into a very dramatic poly roleplay where Casta and Angella pretty much embody the song *Horny Angry Tango*, with SW caught in the middle. The curious part is that, a bunch of songs from my castaweaver list fit the poly ship too; quite odd to be writing for the roleplay and hearing the list accurately represent what was happening (Spotify reads it, I don't know).
I can't yet decide if I like the ship, but at least I don't find it disgusting anymore, so that's a win.
~~Will I ever stop linking my playlist? No, I love it~~

Ahem! So… That's it, that's what I've been doing besides writing this, and studying, and drawing.

I hope you enjoy! Now you'll know what happened with the mirror!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Early morning in Mystacor. Sun shone through the windows of the higher storeys, while the lowers were sunk amidst shadows. Clouds filled the sky and half the kingdom would soon be under the rainfall. On such days, most people in Mystacor would make sure to spend the day above the clouds; the Head Sorceress, however, was always among the few who would rather remain within the lower levels, enjoying the sound of the rain.

Castaspella was nowhere near prepared to take over the classes Shadow Weaver used to give, so she spent all morning practicing the same spells they had been instructing the pupils the previous week, until it was time for her to have lunch.

The sorceress prepared herself a lunchbox and took it with her down to the steam grotto. The practice had worn her out and now she needed both a bath and some time to relax. With her bathing suit in place, Castaspella eased herself into an empty pool, and opened her lunchbox; she gradually relaxed while enjoying each piece and, once done, she allowed herself to fall asleep.

Less than an hour had gone by when Queen Glimmer walked into the grotto, wearing a bathing suit too. She had been told her aunt was there, and sure enough, she found her, almost certain Castaspella was asleep. Then a sudden cry startled her, the sorceress hit the water angrily, and Glimmer rushed at her.

—Auntie!? A-are you alright!?

The Head Sorceress looked behind and saw her arrive, looking concerned; she wasn't expecting anyone to go there on such a day.

—Oh, Glimmer! Yes, yes, of course. I'm so sorry for the… outburst— Castaspella apologized, fixing her bathing suit.

—Never mind, Aunt Casta— she immediately dismissed. —You have nothing to apologize for. But, um… do you… want to tell me what's wrong?— she offered. The Queen noticed her hesitation and assured her —I won't judge you, or mock you. I'm not telling anyone.

Castaspella let out a sigh, resigned, and nodded; Glimmer entered the pool and sat in front of her, giving her aunt enough time to collect her thoughts.

—I was just… *trying* to relax, you know, that's the *entire* purpose of this place… But, um, I remembered- remembered how she- how she'd show up here just to annoy me— the sorceress laughed. —The first time was before the… "accident" with the spell— she recalled, thoughtful. —She must have been bored or something so she came to pester me here. And—, interrupts herself with a laugh, —I was silly enough to try and splash water at her! It went right through!— she cackled. She rested her head back on the edge of the pool, sinking down to her shoulders, let out a tired grin, and added —She was right to call me a fool that time—. Glimmer kept quiet, noticing her aunt's soft smile, and let her continue reminiscing. —But then, she began following me around, almost all day, saying she wanted to "feel less like a ghost". She wasn't *always* around me, fortunately, she let me

have some space as she also likes her alone time, and yet, sometimes, she still came to annoy me— she went on, laughing once again. —My-my point is… um, well, I suppose she *forgot* she didn't have that advantage anymore. So, this one time she became so, *so* annoying that I pulled her into the pool! — she laughed.

Glimmer laughed with her, barely believing her aunt had done that, and then realized something.

—Wait, so… she *actually* got wet!?

—That's the funniest part! She did!— the sorceress replied, hardly able to keep herself from cackling. —I laughed so much that I thought I had offended her or something when she walked away, but she was just walking far enough for the spell to lose effect. All the water dropped to the floor immediately, and then she *returned*!— she retold, amused. They both laughed for a moment before Castaspella sighed and spoke again —She was really fun to have around.

Glimmer inhaled sharply, grimacing, and pointed out —Actually… you're the only one who finds her funny, Auntie. For the rest of us, she's just… plain annoying.

The Head sorceress stared at her for a moment, blinking, and finally let out —Brutally honest, I see —. She chuckled and added —Well, yes, that's true but, in fact, when you just annoy her too, it becomes really funny! It's like a game. It's especially funny when I win, which isn't exactly often- eh, *was*… I mean. Oh, but, at least, I could always tease her with how she looks- *looked* less threatening when happy.

Glimmer opened her eyes wide, shocked, and replied —I'd… actually find her scarier in that case.

—Why?

—Well, I… think she's more likely to be happy only when torturing *something*— she explained, puzzled and incredulous.

Castaspella sighed and shook her head, disagreeing —She may be, in fact, quite cruel, she's too… *creative* when it comes to being mean or spiteful, but- Ah… Despite her usual desire to take revenge for *every little thing*, despite her craving for power… having those *never* made her happy—. The sorceress sighed and leaned back. —She admitted that once, when we were investigating the failsafe, remember? In fact—, she interrupts herself to consider for a moment, —Now that I think about it, I've only seen her happy when our bickering got defiant enough, or… when teaching.

Now *that* is definitely something Glimmer had to agree with.

—I also noticed that when I went to see her classes! And- Wait, Auntie! What's that?

Castaspella looked down and cursed under her breath as she noticed the water of the pool was turning red with blood. Apparently, when she rested back, she pulled the wound open.

—Ah… don't worry, Dear— she sighed.

—What happened?

Glimmer observed how she merely healed the cut with a spell while explaining —It's nothing, really; just a small cut I got yesterday.

—Please, Auntie. That looks so bad. Can I help you somehow?

—No need, your father already helped.

The Queen wasn't sure whether that was a neutral statement or more of a sarcastic comment, and got serious, determined to know exactly what that meant.

—What happened?

Her aunt held her sight for a moment and finally gave up as she noticed there was no escaping.

—We… we're having a *decent* conversation with your father. Until I got distracted, several times because, I can swear, I was seeing her reflection in the mirror of my room. I- I felt like I was going crazing and admitted to him I was seeing Shadow Weaver in the mirror, as if she were right there, reacting to our conversation and all!— she began. —So he got up to investigate the mirror, saying it could have some spell, which I found ridiculous for several reasons, mainly that no one enters my room alone, and she doesn't have the ability to do that now…— she digressed. —But, well, the thing is… he was being so ridiculous, and I could have sworn I heard her laughing at him for that, and- and it startled me, I jumped back, lost my footing, fell to the floor… and accidentally hit the base of the mirror, which fell on me.

—Auntie— Glimmer let out, immediately covering her mouth.

—Just one shard cut me, but Micah helped me quickly, and I just cleaned the wound and patched it up. So, honestly, you don't have to worry about it.

Glimmer looked to the side, reflecting, then asked —Then why- I noticed you and dad aren't talking again; did something else happen?

Castaspella let out a long sigh, covering her face with her hands and moving them down, leaning back again, more carefully this time.

—Well… let's just say… He realized how- how *happy* I was around her… but then began with that manipulation bullshit again, insisting it was… just to annoy him— she sighed. —We've had this conversation *so* many times already.

—He won't be coming here that much, then? Only for his classes and council meetings?

Castaspella nodded and let out a long sigh before standing up and stepping out of the pool. Once she picked up her lunchbox and was ready to leave, she looked back at Glimmer with an unreadable expression.

—With today's climate, tomorrow you'll have to make sure there weren't any incidents; that can sometimes happen due to how unusually crowded the upper levels get— the Head Sorceress warned her before turning around to leave.

The Queen sank down to her chin and rested there for a moment, gathering energy to face the day, and considering what to do with this whole situation.

How to help her aunt without abandoning her father? How to be supportive enough to her father, as Castaspella advised her, without condoning his behaviour? And how to handle the Council so they wouldn't be that dependent on her aunt, nor heed her father's stance blindly? How to make the Council think for themselves if even when Castaspella has given them so much freedom, they are still unable to do so?

Late afternoon found the Head Sorceress among documents and writings, once again trying to find *anything* remotely related to the spell and how it kept hurting her sporadically. She had noticed it was less frequent than before and seemed far less painful; perhaps she was getting used to it, or perhaps the spell was fading. Whatever the reason was, she still had no answers, and that was driving her mad.

She wasn't bothered by anyone for hours, fortunately, so she managed to go through all the documents before nightfall. And found *nothing*.

—Just amazing…— she sighed. Castaspella felt worn out, physically and mentally, so she merely returned everything to its right place and teleported back to her room. But she wasn't tired enough to sleep. —I can't believe there's nothing useful… I- Perhaps…— she thought aloud, but interrupted herself when she realized something. *She hasn't dared read more of Breatrix's old papers*. — Perhaps… she had something about that…— she considered, but let out a long sigh, resigned.

She couldn't think about this now, she needed to distract herself. She went to play with her little pets, as she usually did some evenings before her world was entirely shaken by something as insignificant as the dismissal of a spirit. But, soon, she found herself overwhelmed by more memories…

—You drew that wrong. Even *you* can't be so sloppy…

—I am just *playing* with my spiders! It's not serious casting.

—Still… Sloppy work.

She could get under her skin so easily. Yet now, it was a funny memory. Castaspella felt nostalgic and happy thinking about that, laughing at her own reactions and how she never failed to fall for Shadow Weaver's baits.

—What the heck are you doing now!?

—Playing. With. My. Spiders!

—What…

—For the last time! I don't care it's *sloppy*!

What a stubborn woman. But then again, it was usually her curiosity speaking even though she refused to be openly interested in anything. And what's more: she'd put so much focus into being mean, that key details slipped her mind. It only made everything funnier as she'd go indignant when realizing just how foolish she sounded.

—You clean the terrariums manually? Don't you think it would be far easier with magic?

—Magic. Attracted. Bugs. How *exactly* would that work?

—Fine! Yes! I forgot!

Yes… She was a lot of fun to have around.

Chapter End Notes

I-
Well
You see...
I just finished this today, haven't had much time to reflect on it, so I don't have that much to say here
Perhaps I'll add something later

But I guess I could say: notice how it's being brought to attention that Casta's POV regarding SW is *notoriously* different from everyone else's!?

Hehe, well! Until next week it is! The flashback will add to that councilman who doesn't straight up hate SW! (Oh right, I wanted to get a name! I think someone suggested one... Feel free to suggest more tho)

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Get to know people before judging them.
Status: being argued.

Chapter Notes

Introducing!! The best councilman in the Council!!! (name credits to the suggestions of ocean_galaxy and sunset_luster; adding you to the fic dedication cause this was an invaluable contribution hehe)
This guy and the other one Casta leaves in charge when she's away (the one who profusely apologized for the DT fiasco) are the only worthy ones…
The rest are low-key sheeps who *sometimes* have a bright idea, and then there's *one particular bitch* you will hate once he defies Casta. First time he'll get a pass… Second time… well, you'll sure applaud Casta for her immediate reaction.

Ahem! But no more low-key spoilers of stuff that will only happen in +2 years in-fic time!!

Playlist highlight! *The* perfect song for a chapter like this: "My Shadow Self". It's right at the end of the playlist because I remembered it when I was writing this, hehe.

Now!
I hope you enjoy thisss!!
(I can even remember where I was sitting when I came up with this idea and immediately wrote it down; I just love this TT^TT)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Faint voices called her attention. At first, Beatrix thought those were voices from souls like hers, attached to the core of Etheria for different reasons. Or perhaps, for the same.

But soon she realized: those were the voices of Castaspella and Micah.

They chatted quite calmly, apparently, they were now on better terms. Just as Shadow Weaver had said, it was better without her around. She caught some parts of what they said, as their voices were sometimes difficult to understand with her senses so numb, and so, she'd occasionally laugh, roll her eyes and, in one instance, Beatrix even smirked in approval after a witty remark Castaspella made.
Then a moment later, she heard Micah saying something about her mirror having a spell.
Why would *she* charm the mirror!? And *how exactly* if she already had to resort to potions in the last years before dying, seeing how casting sigils required external sources of power!? Oh, right. And she didn't even have more than those illusions when she was summoned.

She cackled; his paranoia can be *so* ridiculous.

A sudden crashing sound was heard and, a moment later, the siblings' voices became too faint.

There it was again: the pain coming from Castaspella, the same she had felt when her brother entirely stopped talking to her that last month. So now, Beatrix wondered if, perhaps, it had happened again.

But why, just *why* was she so curious about these things in which she no longer had any participation, and that couldn't affect her at all either? Perhaps being on the receiving end of those feelings was the reason, yet that only made her remember how different the first month had been.

She hadn't thought about it before, but between the first and the last month, there was an abyss of difference in all imaginable ways. In the beginning, she didn't even want to stay there summoned; she wanted to see the girls, to know they had in fact survived, yes, but afterwards, she had no more interest in staying and loathed how both Castaspella and Catra made sure she wasn't unsummoned. It couldn't possibly be more contrasting with how she now curses that final second before vanishing. Seven months earlier, she would have welcomed it gladly.

But now…

Could this count as "repeating history" for Castaspella?

Beatrix clearly recalled a conversation about this in that first month, and the final warning "Do not repeat history; you will regret it so much you will never rest in peace".

> Shadow Weaver had now been summoned for, perhaps, a week, and felt a deep nostalgia she loathed with all her being. What was there to miss from Mystacor?
>
> She just wanted the place to go down; literally, if possible.
>
> But then again… this was her one opportunity for a final goodbye; her stay most probably wouldn't last long, so she took the chance to freely explore the place while she still could.
>
> Wandering around, she arrived at the Hall of Sorcerers; she eyed each statue as she passed through, and right when she had reached her own, she came across a councilman who was, curiously enough, standing in front of the statue too.
>
> She knew this man. What was his name? "Nollaris Remarius". No, That's not it anymore; he hated the name so much, most probably still does. So what was his new name? "Nolrem"? And he had also chosen a new surname… "Incertus". Certainly a great fit for the most indecisive councilman.
>
> Yes… this was "Little Inny", the youngest back when she just began as tutor. Not so little anymore…
>
> —Good Evening, Light Spinner— he greeted her, with a short nod.
>
> Curious…
>
> —Nolrem Incertus… Evening— she replied, her tone showing obvious curiosity. —I'm surprised you call me by that name— she remarked, with a more suspicious expression.
>
> He looked away with a frown as he admitted —I never got used to your… new name—. He cleared his throat before looking back, chin up, eyes closed, and arms behind his back. —But, if it weren't out of respect for our Head Sorceress, I would rather not speak with you at all.

—I see…— she let out, curious once again. As she circled around him, she commented —Now that I happened to come across you, I have something I'd like to discuss…

He looked back at her, following Shadow Weaver with his sight, and replied —Of course, what is it?

—Back when I was still alive, I had a very *interesting* conversation with your *dear* Head Sorceress— she began. —Apparently, she was under the impression I could control people's minds, among some other things, most of them *considerably* exaggerated— she continued, amused. Nolrem seemed alarmed for a moment as he realized what she meant, but he only closed his eyes, resigned, and let her continue. —Despite my hunger for power, I find it curious that she thought I had far more terrible powers as Light Spinner than as Shadow Weaver— she concluded. —I wonder why she had this *inaccurate* idea of me…

Her questioning look was more than enough of a warning: she wouldn't leave without at answer, denying her is not an option.

—Of course— he sighed. Nolrem cleared his throat and explained —Perhaps Castaspella never met you as Light Spinner, but she was always extremely *curious* about the one statue in the Hall of Sorcerers no one wanted to tell her about—. He stared at the statue for a moment before continuing —We discussed it and, while some of us wanted to tell her the full story, many refused, fearing she'd… admire you enough to *excuse* your actions.

Shadow Weaver let out a sardonic laugh.

—You really think she's such a poor judge of character?

—I don't, plenty of us don't- didn't— he immediately replied, perhaps too fast. Nolrem cleared his throat again, composed himself, and explained —Most of the ones who were with me on this matter were too old already, their influence in the council had deteriorated, and we were even accused of being "too sentimental"—. He looked down and sighed —We just wanted to be fair.

With a somewhat wicked laugh, she commented —No wonder she was so angry to learn how much you had exaggerated me—. She laughed, louder this time, and admitted —I *wish* I had been that threatening, I would have imposed my will easily.

Much to her surprise, Nolrem chuckled lightheartedly.

—I can't disagree— he conceded. —But yes, she was told plenty of lies or inflated truths, almost nothing of you as a tutor— he sighed again. —They were afraid because she'd often be found here, sometimes she'd even fall asleep under your statue, despite being scolded for it. We didn't understand…— he recalled, his expression confused as he still couldn't comprehend it. —The council had Micah involved and only then did she come less.

Shadow Weaver raised a brow, pensive for a moment. For every answer she got, new questions would rise.

—Then how could she be *so sure* I had been "one of the best tutors"?— she inquired. —She spent hours reproaching me how I disregarded all the apprentices I had… as if I didn't know— she added, rolling her eyes.

—Ah, yes— he recalled. —Apparently, she met many of your former-pupils and they were more neutral about you, so she learnt part of the truth. But…— he interrupted himself and looked

away, ashamed.

—*But*!? You better answer me, Inny…

Nolrem grimaced when hearing the nickname and he loudly cleared his throat to interrupt her.

—We decided- The majority decided to admit as much, it *was* true and she *may* have shamed us for hiding it— he confessed with obvious regret in his expression. —She was quite feisty as a teenager— he chuckled. Nolrem cleared his throat again and continued —However, that only scared everyone even *more*, and they- *we* arranged with Micah one final deception.

His long, heart-felt sigh piqued her attention and she hummed, interested.

—Let me guess… something about all my pupils being only tools?

Nolrem suddenly blushed, embarrassed, and looked away, stuttering —Tha-that would be an understatement—. Shadow Weaver stared, utterly shocked. *How* could it be even worse? He took a deep breath and explained —We told her you had exerted control over your pupils' minds, including Micah, and *only* because he was the most talented of them, you had him help you with the Spell of Obtainment. Nothing about how… he fully trusted you, enough to help willingly before he realized the risks of the spell.

She smirked and hummed in approval.

—Quite smart of you, very devious, I have to admit.

Nolrem frowned and mumbled angrily —Such praise from you only justifies my disagreement —. He scoffed and continued —It finally worked. She studied harder than ever, insisted she needed to be ready for the day you decided to strike back—. Nolrem took another deep breath, still looking away, ashamed. —It even seemed that she believed that ghost-story about you still wandering Mystacor— he laughed. Then, rolling his eyes, he added, —Our Head Sorcerer considered that to be a good thing, if I recall correctly. And when her brother was- Em… Let's just say it only got worse. The council was finally satisfied—. He seemed frustrated, but then snickered before adding —So, *imagine* the reactions of the ones left from that time when she decided to *summon* you!

Shadow Weaver snickered and commented with a malicious tone —I would have *enjoyed* so much seeing their faces…

Holding back a smirk, he let out —I imagine.

She hummed, amused, and admitted —The more I hear about that woman, the less I understand. In fact, knowing you lot manipulated her like that and yet now *she's* the one in charge… I have to suppose she got out of hand—. She looked back at him with a smirk, and taunted —You couldn't handle her, right? After all, she's very stubborn, even her trust in me is part of her stubbornness.

He snickered in agreement, which once again surprised Shadow Weaver.

—Oh, that’s very likely. Did you know about…— he began, but suddenly interrupted himself and his gleeful expression vanished. With a serious frown, he shook his head —No, I better not. She certainly wouldn't appreciate me talking about her late tutor.

—Hmm, so her tutor died?

—Actually- Ah… Do *not* mention this to her, ever— he warned her. His behavior kept surprising her, and she could only nod, increasingly curious. —The woman was *cursed*. And it was someone very close to her who did it— he began. He sighed and went on, hesitant —And… Ah… Solely because she gave him- She trusted him with *sensitive* information, and he used it to… *do that*—. With a sorrowful sigh, he concluded —That's why she promised herself never to trust blindly ever again.

Shadow Weaver could barely believe it. She would have never imagined such a thing could have happened to Castaspella, but now it explained a lot of things from her behavior.

—So she isn't as naïve as I thought— she hummed, pensive.

—Not anymore— Nolrem immediately agreed, looking down with a dark expression. —Which makes it all the more significant that she *does* trust you. You must have caused quite an impression on her— he considered.

She laughed, both sardonically and amused, and commented —As far as I'm concerned, it was mostly because I trusted her first, which is saying a lot. She kept repeating to herself all the common beliefs about me, like a reminder, and *after* having followed me for half an hour or so, she stated her resolve to "stop" me—. She snickered, mockingly, and smirked as she remembered —Now I understand where that came from. I had realized she was fighting her own thoughts, convincing herself it was a bad idea or that I would betray her, which is why I told her my real intentions and offered a deal: if I tried to take the power for myself, she had to stop me.

Nolrem was pensive for a moment before realization hit; he chuckled —That's… Now I get it—. He let out a laugh and went on —Just imagine! She almost kicked out She-Ra because, when the girl destroyed those lunar crystals, it must have reminded her of those events!

—That was *my* doing— she interrupted.

—But she didn't know at the time— he reminded her. —She's always been afraid of letting history repeat itself. I suppose… you showed her not everyone is like him, that one can… really get to know someone and trust them without… endangering those she loves— Nolrem suggested.

Shadow Weaver scoffed, dismissively, and turned around, as she argued —I had endangered someone she loved very long before that; which she *kept* bringing up. And I'm sure she learnt about it quite early.

—She did— he nodded. —In fact, she always blamed herself because she repeated his mistake and made it *worse*. Micah didn't help you kill Norwyn, yet blamed himself for "Light Spinner's death", but… I suppose you know Casta enough by now.

Know her enough? Whatever could he possibly mean by that? No, of course she didn't know her enough; perhaps it could be said she didn't know her at all.

She remained pensive for a moment before finally replying —On the contrary, I keep realizing I can't even *guess* how her head works. This is only more… difficult to understand now—. She scoffed again, frowning —She was quite indignant because I kept from her the risks of the failsafe. I suppose, seeing how I didn't have ill intentions but rather what she calls "poor judgment" may have played into her current "weary trust"—. She hummed, interested, and reflected —No wonder she insists I'm too mistrusting. She balances it quite well.

Nolrem took a deep breath and looked down before clarifying —What I just told you is why I vouched for you. But this is also a warning: do *not* repeat history; you will regret it so much you'll never rest in peace.

—No need for threats, Inny— she replied, smirking. This time, he only smiled faintly at the nickname and shook his head. —I value these things; after all, the council never trusted me at all, did you? I'd say your Head Sorceress is the only person truly safe from my schemes— she let out with a mischievous tone. Right after, she looked back at him, smirking maliciously, and added — She's not the one who requires your concern.

Nolrem cleared his throat, dissimulating his sudden unease, and finally excused himself — Ahem, well… I must now retire. It was… less unpleasant than I thought, talking to you… Light Spinner.

—Likewise, Nolrem.

—Good night— he noded, then turned and walked away.

Shadow Weaver watched him leave for a minute before turning back to look at her statue with a bittersweet expression.

No surprise it was so tattered. No surprise it hadn't been cared for at all. No surprise it doesn't even have a name.

But what a surprise it's still there. Why hasn't it been… removed?

All those things the council did to keep Castaspella away… why that much effort when they could have simply removed the statue?

Who cares? Not like those fools would have thought about it…

With one last scoff, she finally returned to the Lunarium, without looking back.

How much it all had changed.

How much Castaspella had proved to Beatrix that she couldn't just "figure her out".

No, the woman was playing her. She was just… *experimenting* with Shadow Weaver, trying to poison her with ideas that would make her weak…

But Castaspella… she believes in her, she's just trying to help Light Spinner!

Beatrix had never considered whether she wanted the help, or if the sorceress had put that idea in her head.

Of course she did! It was her plan all along! The woman just manipulated Shadow Weaver into regretting what she had done, what she *knows* were things she had to do! Someone had to make what was necessary. She just… did the same she had done to her brother that day! She guilt-tripped her!

No, no, that's not true! Castaspella was just helping Light Spinner see what she had done wrong, the flaws in her view of the world, and showed her that recognizing those mistakes is actually a sign of strength!

Reflecting on it, Beatrix realized she had gotten so angry at the council for their passiveness that she never stopped to think that it was all because they only follow whoever is Head of the Sorcerers' Guild. The decisions the council made in the time of Norwyn were so contrasting with those the council makes now under Castaspella…

And she had considered the sorceress “a fool” and “weak” for letting the council contradict her when disagreeing, diametrically opposed to Norwyn's stance, considering his word to be final and the only valid one at the end of the day. Only then she realized, the hard way, that Castaspella was actually right to give the council such freedom, that way, she had earned their respect, and always listened to their proposals. Opposite to Norwyn, *she* wouldn’t have merely rejected her plan to use the Spell of Obtainment, she would have considered it and made sure it would be safe to use before attempting it; perhaps, she’d get the help of all the council, and perhaps it would have worked… If not, at least it would have been less likely that anyone was hurt because of it.

Beatrix could recall that Castaspella once told her she wouldn’t have rejected her plan to use the failsafe if she knew about the risks; she said she’d let everyone know about that and let Adora choose.

When it really matters, Castaspella can be very wise. That must be why she’s trying to give Beatrix a chance.

Chapter End Notes

HEHEEEE

Oh my, I adore Nolrem, tbh. And in that roleplay I mentioned the other day, I used him hehe, with this same personality, and the one roleplaying SW asked the same, hah, about the name XD I'm surprised.

Now…
I don't know if anyone noticed, but if you did, CONGRATS! I'll now state it all clearly here and explain the whys hehe:
So, notice how I used the names "Beatrix", "Light Spinner", and "Shadow Weaver"? Notice a pattern?
Well, I might be projecting *a lot*, but -in my case- when intrusive thoughts/the urge to be an a*s overtake, I call that "Shadow Mode" (Cause of C. Jung's shadow! I swear! It just fits LS/SW so well because she embodies the "Dr. Jekyll/Mr. Hyde" stereotype that is literally Jung's theory made into a novel), and the opposite behaviors -more like Casta's- would be my Light Mode. So I'm using a similar concept with her and having the neutral/balanced SW be "Beatrix", as in her original self, the bitchy side that still latches onto her twisted beliefs and view of the world would be SW, and her more lenient/kind with herself "newborn" side would be LS, mostly because I noticed in the series that she tried *very hard* to conform to the norms of Mystacor and the authority system, *until the council and that je- and Norwyn let her down*.
Ahem…
And, what I wonder if someone noticed, is that in aaaaaaallllll previous flashbacks, there was *no name at all* (u have no idea how much I resorted to all I know of linguistics to manage that), and now the inner battle has begun: it's a battle of egos, which means that the names are an attempt to settle as *the* one and only.
"Light Spinner" may never overtake, but that isn't the aim either; the Shadow Weaver that speaks there is the resent trying to keep her salty and cruel, while the Light Spinner countering there just

tries to make Beatrix someone with whom you can have a normal conversation without wanting to bonk her, or fearing she'll lash out and hurt you. It's the part of her trying to find reasons to be a tad bit more respectful, just as Casta has been trying to teach her. It's the part that ~~simps for~~ respects and listens to Casta.

Heck, I made this too long. Hehe, I hope you enjoyed the flashback, and the bits of my HCs for Casta's past (attempting to explain Casta's behavior in general).

UNTIL NEXT WEEK!!

You owe them both so much

Chapter Summary

With the return of Adora and Catra less than 24hrs away, the Queen realizes she has yet to deal with a very important issue: Explaining what her father has done. But Glimmer's troubles don't stop there; with her aunt so broken, she attempts to confront her father once again, hoping she can make him see reason; she doesn't want to give up, but her aunt is right, and the Queen's efforts go to waste.

»—Why can't you just let go of that hate!? You prefer to ignore the pain you're causing her!? Really!? And you dare call her a monster!? Yes! She's been awful! But didn't Auntie tell you about how the whole failsafe thing could be done solely because they went to investigate how to free the magic of Etheria!? And didn't she tell you Shadow Weaver wanted to do that to save you!?
»—She just wanted that power for herself!
»—Auntie thought the same at first! But no! How could she have gotten that power!? Only She-Ra could bear that process! She already knew she could never get that power! But she made everything so we could save you before Prime made you hurt yourself!— she yelled, growing increasingly angry, frustrated, and sorrowful.

Now, Castaspella's soul is broken. But not her resolve.

Chapter Notes

Well… if anyone noticed that I added +10 Evanescence songs to the Playlist, you can imagine that it's mostly due to the angst in this fic, hehe. For the most part, there are also some for others. Oh, but, *Like you* is a 100% for this; you have both Beatrix's new-and-growing wish to be more like Casta, and also Casta's resolution to get SW back (or, um, go for her herself… and it may or may not have inspired a lil convo she will have with her brother. I don't know at what point yet).
OH RIGHT! And you can imagine that *Everybody's Fool* is pretty much what the SW voice thinks about Casta and the whole situation, insisting she just convinced herself of Casta's "lie" that she can grow and be better, etc. (and I'm sure I don't need to explain *My Immortal*, do I?)
Goodness, I can keep doing this for SO LONG! Haha…
Ahem, but I rather not, so you can enjoy the chapter now; you can always play guess and try to figure those out on your own (if you can't, it may be because it's related to a fic I have yet to post; like *Blind Eyed* that is more related to the beginning of Path 2, which I don't know if I'll ever post, hehe)

NOW: I'm trying to hold back on spoilers cause omgs, I've had such ideas… AND ALSO! The end of this chapter is THE FIRST NOTE I HAD for this part of the fic! Like… this chapter is the whole of the 6th day, and the events of this night are how the fic was supposed to begin! But… I didn't have the events of C-a-S Ch 12 planned back then, so the part of Adora and Catra having left Etheria wasn't contemplated, I had to add that (and it came in handy because the events of these 7 days fully depended on SW not being there at all).
And next week's flashback, I'm saying it now, will make you cry. Oh goodness… it may be one of the hardest I've written. It even has a part that was mostly inspired by how much we keep

talking about ~~Norbitch~~ Norwyn in that server where we roleplay. I shared the snipped there and (TT^TT)
So!
On a final note (I know, I keep adding stuff, sorry): The beginning of this chapter should be credited to ocean_galaxy; once again, that part of Perfuma and Scorpia helping Catra and Adora talk and process trauma (an idea Coffee proposed), could be included because of what happens in this chapter that pretty much required that to give more realism to what's gonna happen since this chapter on.
I hope you enjoy this chapter!

(Hold on, I need to add something because it will be mentioned here and I would like everyone to see it cause, not only it is canon, but also: I hadn't noticed it before! I wonder how many actually recall this scene…)







See the end of the chapter for more notes

Late morning in Brightmoon. Glimmer rushes into the room where Bow is connecting with Darla and has almost established a stable communication channel. He leaves everything to look back at Glimmer when she bursts in, yelling.

—Bow!

—Glimmer!? What's…
—What are we going to do!? They return tomorrow morning! And they *don't know yet*! They will be *so angry*!— she began ranting, while the screens behind Bow returned only static. —I- What can we tell them!? And *how*!? They will kill my dad! They will… throw him into Darla and drop him back in Beast Island! Or worse! They could blame Auntie! They could blame me for saying where they were! — she continued, her voice breaking at the end. —What am I going to do!?

He looked shocked as he stammered —Wait- That's- Glim…

The sound of the communication channel with Darla interrupted him and they looked back at the screens as an electronic voice announced —Connecting…

Glimmer yelped, startled, and instinctively blasted Bow's tacking pad, immediately shutting down the consoles connected to it.

—Sorry— she whispered, flinching.

Bow caught her by the shoulders, alarmed, his eyes wide open as he let out —We have to think of something before they arrive!

—No matter what we tell them it will be catastrophic! And they will also hate that we didn't tell them when it happened! It was *literally* the night after they left! If we had told them they would have returned immediately!— she panicked.

—But the mission was important! They- It wouldn't have changed anything! They- They have to understand!— he exclaimed, trying and failing to be optimistic. Glimmer's expression was enough of an answer. He shut his eyes, cringing, and admitted —We need a plan… And, I should get my tracking pad repaired.

—Again, I'm sorry— she apologized, looking away.

—Don't worry, Love— he immediately replied. They both sighed, calming down, and he suggested —Let's go to the Crypto Castle; I'll need Entrapta's help with this…—. He looked back at the blasted tracking pad for a moment. —And some spare parts for that…

Minutes later, Glimmer teleported with Bow to the entrance of Entrapta's labyrinthic castle, and they both followed a robot to the princess' laboratory.

—Welcome, guests!— Entrapta greeted them, hanging down from the ceiling, holding a small device between her hands. —Have you come for scientific advice? Would you like a tiny snack? I just made plenty!— she offered. Before either of them could answer her, they heard wings flapping and the princess immediately exclaimed —Oh, Imp! Tell Hordak and Wrong Hordak that we have guests!

As Imp flew away, Bow finally said —Uh… Hey, Entrapta. We need some help…—. He took out his tracking pad and her hair grabbed it carefully. While she examined it closely, he explained —We had an accident and now can't connect with Darla so… It's a bit urgent.

Seeing the charred circuits and shattered screen, she questioned —What happened to this?

Glimmer looked away, holding her father's staff tightly, and admitted —I… blasted it.

Entrapta immediately looked up, excited, and asked —Would you be willing to help me test some robots!? I need to measure the resistance of their cuirasses!

The Queen grimaced apologetically and replied —Perhaps another day, when I'm less busy.

—Much appreciated! Now I'll get this fixed! Be right back!— she exclaimed, noticeably glad. Holding both her device and Bow's, she left to the right, using her hair to briskly swing away with great ease while calling out —Hordak! Bring me one of the spare screens!

As they waited, they kept discussing how to explain to Catra and Adora what happened, in the most delicate way possible without needing to sugar-coat it. Being realistic, something like this would be impossible to sugar-coat, and they couldn't help considering lying instead.

—I don't know, they will be even angrier once they find out we lied— Bow argued, shaking his head.

—But… I mean… If it were that Shadow Weaver decided to go…— she began, but interrupted herself. —No, that's ridiculous… I'm still having the council pass judgement for what he did, they'd find out so quickly… Ugh! *Why* is this so difficult!?

—Hey, babe, calm down— Bow told her gently, holding her shoulders. —If you could deal with Shadow Weaver's summoned spirit for so many months, I'm sure you can do this too. I know it.

Princess Entrapta returned right in time to hear them and immediately exclaimed, enthusiastic.

—You have a summoned spirit that now disappeared and the daughters of that spirit don't know!?— she let out, speaking quickly and energetically.

Glimmer had to cover her mouth with both hands to muffle a cackle; it took her a minute to recover and compose herself. Meanwhile, Bow hesitated to answer, unsure of how to reply. Entrapta casually handed him the repaired tracking pad and he held it tightly while thinking of something coherent to say.

—Um… You could say… that's *a way* to see it?

—Oh! Fantastic! I have *never* encountered a chance to study spirits or other incorporeal entities! Can I run a few tests on…

—Hold on, she's not…

—But it's so fascinating! Spirits can't die again, which is *perfect* for the initial stages of experimentation! No matter how wrong it goes, if you could summon the spirit once, you can always do it again!— the princess ranted lively, squealing with delight at the end.

—How… didn't we think about that?— Glimmer muttered, exchanging a shocked look with Bow.

—Ah! It's just like with the portal; no one had made a working portal before, but I did!— she continued, laughing joyfully. —So now, I only have to repeat that! Reaching positive results is always hard, and can take *years*, but it can be done!

—Remember that you are *not* allowed to activate anything without our permission, alright?— Glimmer warned.

—Of course! I will request your permission before starting the activation tests phase— she assured her.

As they walked out of the Castle, Bow and the Queen discussed how they would word it all so they could finish explaining everything before their anger overwhelmed them. As long as Catra and Adora could keep in mind that there's a way to fix this, they would have something positive to focus on, instead of seething in rage and sorrow.

After all, they didn't want them to suffer for the same once more: she didn't die again, that can't happen, so she can be brought back again.

Back in Mystacor, Castaspella was just exiting the archives with every single paper signed by Light Spinner; both arms full of scrolls, more investigations stored in other formats levitating next to her in a tidy bundle. Soon, she was in her room, separating everything into a series of piles on her desk.

The Head Sorceress left on her bed everything she had already read and separated the rest according to format and length. She then gathered all the shorter scrolls and took everything with her; she sat at the table under her terrariums, dropping all the scrolls while sighing tiredly.

She took a moment to check on her spiders; her three rhombus-shaped terrariums hang about a meter over the table, bugs of various sizes and colors were walking around, apparently thrilled to see her, and she let out a smile while lazily casting a few illusions inside the largest one first, then a few more inside the others, and finally sat down.

For a few hours, she focused on reading as much as she could, yet the redaction of all those investigations was so much like Shadow Weaver's speech that she couldn't help hearing her voice in her head as if she were reading it to her.

She couldn't bear it for long, and she had been feeling a few pangs in her chest that day since she woke up; she needed a break, and having lunch was a great excuse for that.

Hours later, however, she was pushing herself to continue reading, despite the sorrow and the pain but, by nightfall, she couldn't take it anymore and had to drop everything. She rested her forehead on the table, a few tears rolled down her cheeks, and she couldn't hold back a few sobs.

She had barely been snivelling for a few minutes when a clinking sound called her attention. Casta slowly raised her head and saw one of her spiders, one of the biggest in the largest terrarium; it looked at her with its shiny cyan eyes, tapping the crystal wall repeatedly with one of its legs.

—I'm fine, little one…

She smiled faintly and rose to play with it for a moment until she noticed it was dark outside. Her stomach suddenly grumbled and she preferred to have something for dinner and continue reading the next day.

Queen Glimmer stalked into the dining room with a serious expression. She stopped a few meters before reaching the table and slammed her staff against the floor, calling the attention of her father, the only one sitting at the table, silently eating a meager meal.

He looked back surprised, and asked —Hey, baby girl. Is there something wrong?

—Do you really have to ask? Have you *not* noticed anything?— she reproached. He stared, genuinely oblivious, and Glimmer couldn't help but scowl. —I can't believe you're *really* doing this to Aunt Casta! Your own sister!

Micah immediately grimaced, disgusted, and argued —Yes, my *own* sister. The same sister who has chosen Shadow Weaver over me!

—What the fuck!? Dad! How can you be like this!?— she exclaimed, extremely indignant. —Can't you set that aside!? Don't you see how much you're hurting her!? She's a wreck! She- Ugh! She's so bad she couldn't even cook herself dinner! She burnt the rice! She! The same person who could perfectly cook meals for a whole week just a few days ago!— she insisted. —Don't you see!? If Casta, who could handle preparing three different dishes at the same time suddenly can't cook the most basic stuff, her head must be *so* fucked up she can't even think straight!

—Perhaps her mental state is so bad because she is infatuated with that *monster* who has her heedless! — he retorted.

The Queen opened her eyes, shocked, and replied —Why can't you just let go of that hate!? You prefer to ignore the pain you're causing her!? Really!? And you dare call *her* a monster!? Yes! She's been awful! But didn't Auntie tell you about how the whole failsafe thing could be done solely because they went to investigate how to free the magic of Etheria!? And didn't she tell you Shadow Weaver wanted to do that to save *you*!?

—She just wanted that power for herself!

—Auntie thought the same at first! But no! How could she have gotten that power!? Only She-Ra could bear that process! She already knew she could never get that power! But she made everything so we could save you before Prime made you hurt yourself!— she yelled, growing increasingly angry, frustrated, and sorrowful. Her voice broke as she added —You were using black magic! You almost killed us all! Can't you remember how you held Auntie over the ground!? She was *the only one* you did that to! You kept the rest of us attached to the ground! And- and you were starting to get scars from using that magic! I- I barely managed to purge it all out of you! And only because I have both your and mom's power!—. Glimmer couldn't hold back anymore and began crying, supporting herself on the staff so she wouldn't fall on her knees. —You owe them both *so much*! And I can't- I just- What would mom say!? Uh!? I've been thinking about this for so long! Have you ever stopped to consider she'd be disappointed!?

—Losing your mother was *her* fault!

—No, it wasn't! We almost, *almost* kept that from happening *because* Shadow Weaver helped me wield enough power to teleport us all to the Fright Zone! We could have- We were so close to stopping that…

Sorrow flashed on Micah's expression for a moment before he shook his head, banishing those thoughts. However, it broke him to see Glimmer so distressed, and he couldn't help approaching to hug her.

She sobbed on his shoulder, hugging him tighter, while he apologized —I'm so sorry… I shouldn't have… said that.

—Please, dad… please— Glimmer begged, unable to stop crying.

—I’m sorry…

While it soothed her hearing her father apologizing, the Queen wasn’t entirely sure whether he was apologizing for his behavior, or rather because he wouldn’t do as she asked.

Castaspella lay restless on her bed. She was so sleepless she preferred to try and continue reading until words made no sense, she then fed and played with her pets until they all fell asleep, and despite having taken the sleeping potion, she was still unable to sleep.

Eventually, the Head Sorceress wandered into the gardens, only realizing where she was when the variety of exotic magical plants managed to call her attention. It was her garden, so to speak, and now, it gave her such a bittersweet feeling…

Right on queue, she felt the usual sting of the spell and gulped down the pain, placing a hand on her chest. She needed rest, she felt so tired yet couldn’t sleep, and perhaps, the fresh air here could help her; without thinking much, Castaspella laid down on the grass next to a patch of small, tiny, decorative flowers that called her attention.

For a few hours, she wondered whether she had seen those flowers before. That led her to try and think about every single plant in the garden, whether she knew what they were, if they had a use, and if she could perhaps recall when Shadow Weaver planted them. Then the stars above her called her attention, and for another hour, she just stared at them, her mind blank.

However, the sorceress was shaken out of her trance by a pair of footsteps that approached her.

—Auntie?

—Glimmer?

The Queen sat next to her and stared at the flowers for a moment; realizing they were daisies, she let out a smile, supposing her aunt had chosen that spot because Shadow Weaver must have planted them.

—How are you feeling, Auntie?— she asked with a gentle tone.

—I don’t know— she sighed. Castaspella closed her eyes for a moment before looking back at Glimmer. —I’ve been trying to… understand that… but I don’t know yet.

—It’s alright. You don’t need to know.

They both sighed at the same time and stayed silent for a moment until the Head Sorceress spoke up.

—Your friends return tomorrow, right?

—Yeah… tomorrow morning. I- I told them today… and—, sighs, —They are incredibly angry with… everyone.

—Of course they are.

With a sorrowful expression, Castaspella closed her eyes again and a new silence installed between them before Glimmer interrupted it this time.

—Do you… miss her?

—After all the help she's given me, with my sorcery, with quite literally everything in Mystacor, and the tutoring even… I just feel… insufficient now, without her— she admitted. The sorceress couldn't hold back a tired smile as she asked —Is it that obvious?

—I guessed— Glimmer replied, smirking. Right after, she added —But there's also the fact that you're resting next to a patch of daisies, her favorite flowers. That was enough of a hint.

Surprised, the Head Sorceress pushed herself up a little, supporting herself with her arms, and asked —Wait, what? The… flowers?—. She looked back at them, and insisted —These… are her favourite?

—Oh, yeah! She also planted those in Brightmoon and when I asked, she said she finds them cheerful — Glimmer replied, covering her mouth as she giggled. Right after, she questioned, raising a brow — You *really* didn't know!? I'm surprised…

—I swear, I never… paid attention— she let out, briefly interrupted by a yawn.

The Queen let out a faint smile and suggested —Please go to your room, Auntie. You'll catch a cold out here—. She helped Castaspella up and laughed —If you need another day off, just ask for it, no need to get ill.

They both walked back into the building, laughing a bit, and silently walked through the corridors.

However, before they arrived at her room, they came across Micah. The Head Sorceress' expression revealed nothing, even when he angrily addressed her.

—Will you *really* go on like this!? I am still waiting for you to explain yourself! Or will you *never* take responsibility for what you have done!?

—No! Do *not* start, dad!— Glimmer interrupted. She looked back, watching her aunt for a moment as she silently continued walking to her room, then glared at her father, arms folded and seething. —*You* will have to answer for what you've done, the council expects as much. And *you* will have to explain to She-Ra and Catra what happened to the last memento they had of their parent-figure. You don't understand how they all feel, but it doesn't mean those feelings are any less valid, or that they justify the woman— she reminded him. —Shadow Weaver raised my friends, they had a terrible childhood, she traumatized them, but they still saw her as a mother, even if a cruel one, and they *never* hated her; they couldn't— she continued. —You knew exactly how important the mask is for them, and yet you *crushed it* without a second thought! They will arrive tomorrow early and will *not* wait a single minute. They want you ready to speak with them as soon as they land— Glimmer warned him, approaching. —And I will make sure you are.

—But…

—No buts! You won't dodge your fault! You will have to explain *everything*!

Micah huffed and replied —Everything. I will *absolutely* explain it all— he let out. —Without omitting a single *detail*— he sentenced, with a tone that sounded more like a threat.

It didn't take long for Glimmer to realize: He will also expose her aunt for kissing Shadow Weaver.

Chapter End Notes

HEHEEEEEE!

I'd like to say: the spider helping Casta a bit when she was crying MAY OR MAY NOT be me using what my cat did the other day when I was crying terribly, hehe.
That was today's anecdote. ^_^

And, um, you may have noticed at the beginning I said "Her father's staff" and then I went with "Her staff". Well! I doubted a lot but then realized Glimmer herself would think about the staff as one or the other depending on the circumstances. The last time, when it's "her staff", she'd considered it like that because she's standing her ground on a matter where she feels Micah is going too far and she needs to speak more as the Queen than as his daughter; that also relates to her rejecting the "baby girl", just as she did at the beginning of this fic. Hehe
You know, psychology influences our speech a lot:
> Micah always makes it about himself when he complains about Casta's and SW's relationship overall > SW's regard of… everything, is purposely cold: she never called the kids by their names, nor wanted to use the word "friendship", and in *Behind The Mask* it was a very relevant detail that she began using the nickname "Cas" (despite originally rejecting it), because it revealed a first stage of trust in Casta.
>AND my fav canon one: during that one interrogation, Casta said SW had to **answer** for her crimes during her time as Micah's tutor, instead of saying **pay**, because she didn't want her to be punished, just to own up to it! Like now in this fic.
H e h e

OKAY I'LL STOP! BUT THAT! I MAY BE OBSESSED WITH THIS STUFF BUT I SWEAR I'M NOT MAKING THIS SHIT UP!

Ahem, sorry

UNTILL NEXT WEEK!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: you continued the cycle of abuse
Status: successfully accepted; waiting for proper integration

Chapter Notes

I- I'll just say it: My Playlist is already +160 songs and over 11hrs long. And I added so many angsty songs... You can imagine... Ehe

So, I think I said it before but, the beginning of this chapter was inspired by how much we have been talking about Norwyn in that server... I realized *this I wrote here* is something SW REALY needed... Point being: that part made the beginning longer and, while this chapter is probably as long as the one I divided into two, ~~I was just being cruel that time~~ this flashback's ending is necessary cause of the next main-plotline chapter.
OH, AND GUESS WHAT! Next flashback is what you all have been waiting for! (˘ ڡ ˘) *The sake incident*

(I forgot was else I was going to write here, may edit the note later)
SO: I hope you enjoy your reading ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Suspended amidst the darkness of the core of Etheria, she had been able to keep the pain at bay for what felt like hours, until an opaque shape, darker than the rest of her surroundings, little by little came into view, moving closer to her, and a voice suddenly rang inside her head.

"What you propose is forbidden, Light Spinner."

From all the voices, from all the memories that could come back to haunt Beatrix… It *had* to be his voice…

"There can be no good from this."

That fool… Shadow Weaver knew perfectly well that they could have done *so* much with that power…

Light Spinner only wanted to save Etheria, the people, those she was fond off…

She had trusted them…

"Etheria will take care of itself as it has always done, without resorting to twisted spells."

“Twisted spells”; Beatrix was more than willing to sacrifice everything to do what’s right…

“Twisted”... Being comfortable seeing the world burn from the safety of the floating island is what’s *truly* twisted.

“Be satisfied with what you have, Light Spinner. Some power is not meant for you.”

It was for *all of them*! Not just for her!

Light Spinner *never* meant to take it for herself only! *But they* showed her she shouldn’t have taken them into account like she did…

They didn’t deserve Shadow Weaver’s help or consideration…

“You've always hungered after power. Bringing you into our ranks was a grave mistake.”

How *ungateful*. No matter how much Beatrix wished to become more powerful, she never resorted to shortcuts… She *always* worked for it with dedication and perseverance, regardless of how long it'd take her.

But when she saw they had seized the runestone… They couldn’t afford to waste a single day, there wasn’t nearly enough time to merely study until they had enough power to face the Horde; by then, *they wouldn’t have a planet to protect*!

The dark abstract shape became discernible; it continued to approach her.

Unnerved, not sure if she was really speaking or if the voices were all in her mind, she let out —No, no… you aren’t- you can’t be…—. *Oh, but it was him*. Norwyn’s voice repeated in her head how it was a mistake to take her in, and she grew anxious, desperate. —You- You left me no choice…— she argued, while his figure kept moving closer. —I- You called me a *mistake*! I was *never* enough! I- I killed you because you wouldn’t *shut up*!— she exclaimed, trying to justify herself. —But… I didn’t…— she tried to continue but hesitated, unwillingly thinking about Castaspella’s words. She admitted —I do regret it… I only wanted you to listen! If only you…—. She sighed —If only you had been more like her…—. Feeling angrier, she closed her fists, squinted at the approaching shadow, and sentenced —You didn’t deserve the position of Head Sorcerer—. Immediately after, she hesitated once again and recognized —But everything that came after was *my* choice… Trying to prove *you* wrong, but… still… my own choice… And I only repeated what you did to me—. She sighed and let out a bitter laugh before adding —How to blame Catra for all she did after I left… if it’s exactly the same I did after obliterating you?—. She looked away for a moment, somewhat ashamed, then immediately faced him once more, with a resolute expression; he was almost over her. —Do you want vengeance, Norwyn? Go ahead. I do not care— she let out. —I- I promised… so much that I can’t ever fulfill now… I have *nothing* left except this feeling of… what? *Longing*!? So ridiculous…— she scoffed. —Just go ahead and do what you must.

However, once Norwyn was face to face with Beatrix, he only spoke to her, his words resonating inside her head once more.

—I’ve done wrong. Just as… wrong as you. And I… was mistaken… about you. I should… have given you… a chance.

Beatrix was stunned for a moment in utter disbelief.

—I…— she sighed, defeated, lowering her sight. —I should have given Catra a chance too.

—I am… sorry.

His apology, so unexpected, so unbelievable, left her speechless. She couldn't reply as he placed a hand on her shoulder, and a single tear rolled down her face. Norwyn's shadow disappeared, as if finally relieved, and Beatrix's mind was left reeling.

How could this be possible!? She had *never* imagined she'd get an apology, least of all from *him*!

Tutors… All so different, all so flawed…

Norwyn was too severe, enough to frustrate his pupils and push them way too far trying to please him.

And she? She had also been quite severe, to say the least, and after her corruption she became just as difficult to please for those under her tutelage; in fact, she was even worse, cruel, violent… A *nightmare*.

And then… there was Castaspella. How could someone be so lenient yet so severe, unable to handle children or make them obey? As a tutor, she's *supposed* to make sure they follow her every word.

But she kept making a fool of herself, every single class; no wonder Shadow Weaver had to make sure the pupils would listen and comply… Now that she's not there, it will help Castaspella keep them in line. Or, as the sorceress would have said, keep them *safe*…

She couldn't help remembering that day, so Beatrix focused on the memory, keeping the pain perfectly at bay this time.

> It was almost a *déjà vu*. The pupils running around, Castaspella helplessly attempting to stop them, and finally scolding them in such a serious manner that the children were probably too scared to actually pay attention.
>
> What a fool…
>
> —Stop. You're frightening them— Shadow Weaver interrupted, placing a hand on Castaspella's shoulder. Before the woman could reply or complain, she addressed the kids —Listen here. Whether you like it or not, Castaspella is the head of the Sorcerers' Guild, the one who accepted you here for training. If you keep disrespecting her, you will *not* be allowed to continue your studies here. From now on, whatever she orders you to do *must be obeyed*. Am I clear?
>
> They all nodded, even the eldest pupils, perhaps reluctanctly but obviously resigned to comply.
>
> And so, to no one's surprise, Castaspella later questioned her for all she said.
>
> —Why on Etheria did you do that!?
>
> —They don't respect you. Don't obey you. So you get serious, forget they are *kids*, and scare them— she explained.
>
> The Head Sorceress rolled her eyes, scowling, and let out —Because you know so much about scaring kids…
>
> —As a matter of fact, I obviously do. Back in the Horde, frightening the kids into obedience was *normal*. Every authority figure would do as much, it kept them obedient and within safe zones. Of course, the girls still ran around, but I always maintained a close watch on them; I had to

make sure Adora wouldn’t get hurt— she replied, nonchalantly. Castaspella rolled her eyes but Shadow Weaver ignored her and continued —What's more, Hordak used fear to make sure those in high ranks like me wouldn't attempt to overthrow him. But you don't do that here, don't need to; especially scaring the kids, you *can't* do that. This- this *isn’t* the Fright Zone, and you are *not* me. You are too nice and only impose authority when you get angry. Hence, when you see them in danger, you panic, and severely scold them; you *forget* they are children, not adults.

—And *you* keep that in mind!?

—Of course. Manipulating kids and adults require different skillsets— she assured, with such a casual tone that the sorceress couldn’t help gaping.

—You can’t be serious…

—I’m dead serious.

—Was that a pun!?

—No.

Castaspella shook her head lightly, and returned to the original discussion.

—Alright. But, why threaten them like that? You know I won’t cast them out— she questioned Shadow Weaver.

This oblivious woman…

—But *they* don’t. And they *shouldn’t* know. If they *ever* learn their flippancy will go unpunished, nothing will keep them from disobeying you. It’s not just running around near the edge of the island; they could try dangerous magic and never listen if you warn them— she clarified.

The Head Sorceress couldn’t help raising a brow as she asked, reproachingly —Like you did?

—Precisely.

Shadow Weaver kept such a casual tone and demeanor it seemed to be irking Castaspella; it was actually quite amusing seeing her reactions.

—But they need to know the risks. Yes, that will frighten them, but then they will be wary and won’t tread with dangerous things!— she argued.

—Scaring them won’t work here. It is one thing to scare cadets, their weapons aren’t affected by that; but magic? They should *never* fear it for magic requires their full trust and respect. Fearing sorcery makes it rebel against the caster; if it marvels and amazes the kids, it will inspire them the necessary respect!— Shadow Weaver explained, almost indignant. Then, her expression changed as she asked —You are fearful of magic, at least some of it, aren’t you?

The Head Sorceress was taken aback for a moment.

—What makes you say that?

—Your offensive spells are pitiable, any aggressive practical magic, like truth spells…

—I know, I know. “Sloppy work”— she interrupted, letting out half a smile, and almost making her laugh too.

—It’s not exactly your strength, indeed— she replied, smirking teasingly. —But… when Micah, while chipped, attacked us… let’s just say you lasted longer than I expected. Which tells me... You’re *so scared* of other forms of magic that you focused on defense instead— she pointed out.

Castaspella looked away as she admitted —I suppose I did.

—Then *stop* fearing it! Fear is not the way here, understood? Manipulating them with fear is counterproductive…

—I do *not* manipulate them!— she interrupted, indignant.

Of course she’d say that.

—They are kids and can’t judge what’s better for them; you *have* to manipulate them to keep them safe. Otherwise, they won’t listen, even if you’re just looking out for them— she replied with a condescending tone that clearly couldn’t fool the Head Sorceress.

—They still know what they need or not, what is comfortable and what isn’t. Some things they won’t like, but you can’t just entirely dismiss them— she argued.

—Fine— she complied, rolling her eyes. She already knew full well there’s no use trying to convince Castaspella otherwise so, instead, she said —You can be gentle enough to keep that in mind, yes, but gentle manipulation is *still* manipulation. You can, and should, heed my advice without feeling so *guilty*. After all, you’re free to apply it as you see fit.

However, the Head Sorceress was still quite distressed, angry and perhaps frustrated now; she huffed just like she had done that night in the woods, when she seemed stuck between agreeing and disagreeing with her.

She began pacing, seething, and muttered between her teeth —I don’t know why I’m trusting you with handling the kids when you consider it mere manipulation. I should’ve known this was a bad idea…

Indeed… The exact same behaviour. Maybe that represents, just like back then, her conflicting ideas and hesitant trust. Shadow Weaver recalled that conversation with the councilman and attempted to test Castaspella’s trust and instinctual weariness.

—Was it? The kids will now obey you without a peep. That should make things easier for you until they are able to tell for themselves that you’re just looking out for them— she argued.

—I can’t agree— she immediately replied, shaking her head and looking away. —I- I shouldn’t have let you near kids at all. I can’t *believe* I trusted you this much.

She couldn’t help snickering before replying —Your trust in me is quite fluctuating…

—As is your behaviour!— she immediately retorted. —What's wrong with you!?

—Egocentricity and power-thirst, to begin with— she casually replied, fueling Castaspella’s indignation. —What about you?

The sorceress remained stunned for a moment, perhaps because of her blunt sincerity.

—I- I don't know— she hesitated, looking away. —I suppose I'm… insecure— she began. With a resigned smirk, she added —Boundaries might be an issue too.

—Quite right— Shadow Weaver agreed, making Castaspella look back with a light-hearted scowling. Ignoring her, she continued —You're also far too careful, opposite to how I'm far too reckless. And I'd say we both have trust issues too, no?—. She raised a brow and gave the Head Sorceress a questioning look; she seemed to agree, even if reluctantly. —You easily trust. I don't at all. What do you propose?

She hesitated for a moment, conflicted, hesitant perhaps. But then, her expression changed.

—If this is going to work, we need to make a deal, like back in the Woods— she began, confident. That councilman was so right… —I will help you, follow your lead yet stop you if you try to acquire power, but this time: no omissions. If you had told me what the failsafe would do…

—You wouldn't have carried out our plan— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—No— she denied without hesitation. *What*!? —I'd just take that risk into consideration, I would've explained *everything* to them, including that Adora was the only one with a chance to survive it. Then, we could *let her choose* with full knowledge of what she would agree to.

How ridiculous. What would be the point!?

—She would have elected to do it all the same. That's how she is— Shadow Weaver countered, dismissively.

—No. That's where you're wrong— Castaspella sentenced, serious, severe even. —*You* raised her to be like that. But she *deserved* the chance to choose it. Freely!

That had been… an annoying conversation. Perhaps because of how many flaws in her judgement she had pointed out.

It made Shadow Weaver feel so *angry*!

But Beatrix couldn't ignore that she was, in fact, right.

It made her realize: if she had told Micah the full extent of the Spell of Obtainment's risks… perhaps he would have accepted because of his recklessness and blind trust in her… but *perhaps*, he would have been scared enough to opt out.

Now, Light Spinner regrets having such poor judgement; Castaspella was right about her.

How *infuriating*! Shadow Weaver couldn't allow herself to admit that! She *shouldn't*!

Her thoughts were interrupted by faint voices, those of Castaspella, Adora, and Catra, that reached her ears. Similar to when she heard the siblings' conversation, she could now hear them speaking…

So Micah had revealed that the sorceress kissed her; how petty of him…

And…

Catra spied on them!? How *insolent*!

But… she thought Shadow Weaver would *hurt* Castaspella? Well, maybe she wasn't that wrong…

And they are *finally* using their brains! The grooves in the Woods, those places where magic is much stronger… That was quite smart of them.

Still, she never would have imagined they would be so adamant on getting her back! Who in their right mind would want *her* back!?

Much as Shadow Weaver tried to deny it, there was a feeling Beatrix got since hearing them say that they would look for her…

Excitement? Happiness?

No… Why would she?

But it was there, and she couldn't help dwelling on it. After a while, Beatrix came to a realization that overwhelmed her mind with conflict.

She was, perhaps, feeling something akin to love; after having rejected it so much, after denying it to her girls…

No, that's fucking bullshit! She did not want it. *She doesn't want it*!

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

Doesn't want it.

But she likes it.

No, she doesn't! She'd never be that *weak*!

But she can't help it.

Of course she can! She did it before, she can do it again!

But she doesn't want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

Doesn’t want to.

She *cannot* want to embrace such feeling. *Shouldn’t* want that. It doomed her.

But it’s done now, isn’t it? If she’s already doomed…

“You would be my downfall if I wasn't already as ruined as one can be” she told her…

“Great, no excuses then” was her answer…

No excuses.

Beatrix chose her… And *perhaps*, so did Castaspella…

In her last moment, she chose the girls… And they *seemed* to have chosen her too…

A feeling, similar to when she had just been summoned abruptly engulfed her: they were there…

Chapter End Notes

Yes! I went to the chapter transcription to copy-paste ~~Norbitch~~ Norwyn’s quotes!

Ehe, me and my perfectionism...

Also, I almost wrote this in the notes at the beginning, pretty much spoiling the punch to the gut I wrote... Remember how, in that flashback I divided into two, SW told Catra that, as she would never get an apology from Hordak, then why should Catra get an apology from her (aka, yeah, SW being petty cause just-summoned-yet-bluntly-honest SW, what else could one expect)
Well, while incredibly petty, as I said, it is STILL technically logical from a psychological POV; SW was so resentful, seeing herself on Catra and thinking she “deserved the same treatment”, as if envious of Catra having the possibility to be treated better and get what she never got, that this

apology is MEGA important. This is frankly crucial to make it possible for a woman like her, already old ~~and dead~~ to review her actions, admit the mistake, and genuinely want to apologize too...
Heck, I'm rambling again

And, once more, I've forgotten something I was going to mention here BUT never mind… if I recall I'll add it, if not, better for you, less to read, hah!

Until next week!! Get ready for SW's return!!

Mistake

Chapter Summary

The time has come for King Micah to explain himself. Adora and Catra have returned, and Glimmer has given him a chance to expose his reasons and "justify" his actions. But things only get worse and the damage this is causing to Castaspella becomes more evident.
Furthermore, the girls want to speak with the Head Sorceress; they all have too much to discuss. Fortunately, it proves to be a *very* productive conversation…

»—I can still feel that summoning spell that got bound to me… but it's just so weak without the mask to channel her.
»—Wait… You mean, it technically still works? But isn't strong enough to bring her here? Could you explain to me how that happened?
»—It-it was just an accident. It just happened to be the… moon alignment that night, and the Sorcerers' Guild has this one… traditional dance that Shadow Weaver *happened* to be performing when I went to see her. So, whe-when she invited me to dance… I suppose the enhancement of Etheria's magic with the eclipse must have had something to do with that?
»—So it just needs the magic to be stronger and she could be summoned again! I know a place where magic is stronger!

Chapter Notes

Apologies
Please excuse the delay
I fucked up big time and… pretty much had to, erm, make this chapter 3 or 4 times longer than usual. Literally. This chapter alone is HALF AS LONG AS C-a-S!
No joke! 10.6k words!

I ignored a few notes and, what should have been 4 chapters, turned into 2 EXTRA LONG chapters.

AND, anecdote time!
Last week, before I posted that chapter even, I *almost* fainted when I was taking a bath cause I woke up at three PM and had had dinner at around ten so, a good 17hrs without eating. AND GUESS WHO went and used that experience in this chapter!? Poor woman, I keep projecting...
In fact, writing this I realized how long it had been, wow... I'm an idiot... But also, I just realized: Micah helping Casta... that may be a projection of how my brother *did* help me too, even if at first I wasn't even going to TRY to call him, not expecting him to help... I n t e r e s t i n g

Oh, also: I would have posted this even earlier if it wasn't for the damned blackout yesterday night… I had to resort to a very complicated trick to manage to continue writing, goodness…

Again, I'm sorry for the delay but I PROMISE it's worth it! (And let's see if someone finds the small Evanescense reference, hehe)

Ladies, Gentlemen, and Beautiful readers of mine: the chapter you've been waiting for!

Enter Shadow Weaver… Again

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Queen stood proudly, back straight, staff in hand, and a solemn expression on her face, as she watched Darla carefully land on an open area that she has exclusively reserved for the ship's take-offs and landings. However, her attention remained on her father next to her, as if fearing he'd suddenly run away.

As soon as the ship's ramp was down, Catra stalked out and walked straight to them; her expression said more than enough about just how infuriated she was.

—You owe us an explanation, old man! And *don't you dare* use the "that is Shadow Weaver" excuse!

As soon as she was face to face with him, she gripped his clothes, almost ripping the fabric with her claws, and shook him roughly. Her glare scared him for a moment before his indignation overtook him.

—You can't be *serious*! What's wrong with all of you!? How can you…

—Shut up! Don't put up excuses!— she interrupted him, shaking Micah again. —You had *no right* to take this from us!— she exclaimed, her voice breaking.

Glimmer observed the situation, conflicted, and exchanged a look with Adora as she approached. The both of them remained a few meters away, arms folded, making it clear they wouldn't interfere for the time being.

—Why do you care so much!? She- That woman made you suffer too!

—*That woman raised me*! Just answer me before I actually lose it!— she retorted, clenching her teeth and seething with rage. —Why? Why break her mask!? It was *ours*! You had *no right* to destroy something we *lent you*! We *trusted you*!

—You weren't there!

—Answer me!

Her tears rolled down and her voice betrayed just how broken she felt. Adora understood Catra wasn't going to hurt him, just wanted an answer and felt increasingly desperate.

So, instead of trying to stop her, with a severe tone, she insisted —Answer now, King Micah. We just want to know.

—It had to be done— he replied, his expression serious and remorseless as he looked directly into Catra's eyes. —I had tolerated enough of her; she crossed the line, so I withdrew the privilege I had given her. I broke the mask because- because it was- I-I had to!

She opened her eyes wide, shocked, and loosened the grip of her hands to release him; Catra remained frozen for a moment before finally lowering her hands.

—You… don't even… have a reason…— she sighed in disbelief.

—What?

Both Glimmer and Adora were utterly confused, but Micah didn't contradict her, just checked his clothes and took a step back, trying to hide an ashamed expression.

He hadn't ever thought about the whys, he hadn't *considered* there had to be some "logical reason" to send Shadow Weaver back to death. And now, he had realized he simply couldn't word a reason…

—He- He just… did it— Catra replied, looking up at her friends with consternation. —I- It's- I don't understand— she stammered. Adora could see the rage in her eyes and took a step forward, ready to calm her down. But Catra only walked into her embrace and held onto her back tightly, speaking muffled against her shoulder with a shaky voice, —Take him away. To that… trial thing of the council. I can't- I don't think I can… control myself much more.

Adora and Glimmer exchanged a brief look before the Queen ordered some guards to escort her father to Mystacor. When she looked back at her friends, they were still hugging each other, visibly distressed.

—I'm sorry…

—You better keep your father away from me, Sparkles— Catra let out, seething.

—I think you should… go listen to what he will tell the council.

—He doesn't have an *actual* reason! He just hates her, and smashed the mask because he could! He just wanted her *gone*!

—I know but…

—But what!? *I* let him take the mask! I *knew* he would- I knew how he felt… Why did I trust them!?

—Catra, that's…

She turned around, furious, cheeks wet with tears, and interrupted her, exclaiming —Don't! Don't try to justify them, Sparkles! I don't want to blame you, but I will if you dare excuse what happened!

—I wouldn't ever do that! I- I've been dealing with this myself, almost went overboard even if this doesn't affect me directly in any way! I swear, Catra, I almost- I was- *I am* so furious too!— she replied, holding back tears. —Auntie is so… broken…

—Catra, I think that's true. Neither of them would justify him— Adora assured her, placing a hand on her shoulders. —We know just how much…

—I don't care— she interrupted. —That sorceress promised us nothing would happen to the mask! She lied! She let him destroy it!

—Catra…

—Cut it, Sparkles! I told you not to try to excuse them! Either of them!

Glimmer straightened her back, taking a more serious stance, and sentenced —I am *not* excusing anyone, not even myself. But I want you both to get the answers you deserve, and he will now tell the council everything that happened. Even if he doesn't have a reason, he will still have to explain himself—. She looked down, conflicted, and finally added —I think you both should hear it.

Adora moved to stand right in front of Catra, both hands on her shoulders, and looked at her with a pained expression as she said —I agree with her, Love. He said we weren't there, so… let's hear what happened. And we can then confront him again.

Catra closed her eyes and let out a sigh.

—Fine.

—Thank you— Adora sighed, pulling her into a hug and caressing her hair. —And I'm really proud of you.

She looked down and mumbled —He doesn't… deserve my rage…

When she looked up, Catra nodded and they both approached Glimmer to teleport directly into Mystacor's council room. Everyone was getting ready for Micah's arrival, and the Queen said she had decided to have Adora and Catra as witnesses as they had also been affected by his actions.

After a whole hour of Micah's declarations, Glimmer and the council had to discuss whether the month of probation was still a suitable penalty now that they had heard what motivated his actions.

In the meantime, they needed Micah to wait outside along with Adora and Catra, so the Queen order the guards, who had escorted him earlier, to keep an eye on Micah again.

While waiting, Adora and Catra discussed that which they couldn't talk about while in the meeting room.

—I don't know, it sounds very…

—Ridiculous? Yeah.

—I mean… Now we know *what* happened, and I guess it was to be expected that he…

—No! If he was so angry, he could have just gone to make a scandal and yell at his sister, I don't know! But he destroyed the mask, Adora!

—I know, but what I mean is… This also explains why Glimmer or the Head Sorceress didn't stop him.

Catra crossed her arms in front of her chest and let out a huff. She turned around, looked back at Micah, and noticed his expression go from shame to anger in a second when he noticed her staring. Behind her, Adora placed a hand on her shoulder, but couldn't stop her from approaching the king.

—Tell me something, old man: how did this make you feel, huh?— she began, standing before him with a defiant stance. Keeping a severe tone and expression, she continued —Did it satisfy you? Breaking the mask? Did it, I don't know, make you happy or accomplished? What exactly was the point?

He was stunned for a moment, eyes wide open and frozen in place.

But as soon as he was out of the shock, he replied —I- I feel relieved! My sister isn't in danger anymore!

His tone, indignant, hardly hid his bewilderment; that was yet another thing he hadn't thought about. He was enraged, since seeing that kiss and until Glimmer arrived; it was just *rage*.

But what had he felt when he broke the mask? What had he been feeling since that night? It was all confusing and nothing could really be considered positive.

—*Danger*— Catra repeated, disappointed. She scoffed and rolled her eyes. —From what I heard, the true danger for her, was *you*— she pointed out. She leaned forward as she added —And, in fact, you hurt her even worse than we could have imagined… So who, do tell, was the real danger for her?

He grimaced and immediately replied —She did *something* to her! She- She's manipulating Casta! I had to!

—Because of a kiss!? This was all because you- Have you *still* not realized that's bullshit!?— Catra exclaimed, disbelieving. She grimaced, disgusted, and reminded him —You *saw* the whole council's reaction: surprised, like literally any of us would be, and then simply dismissing it for what it is, a triviality! That's not a valid argument!

—They only said that because those councilmen are biased and adore my sister… or fear her, I don't know— he retorted, looking away and folding his arms.

—No!? It's literally just- It's stupid! You're just- Hah! *You* are doing to her *exactly* what *Shadow Weaver* did to us!

A nervous laugh escaped her as realization hit. She couldn't believe the irony. And so, Micah was, once again, being told that he's just like her.

But he refused to accept that.

—No, I am not. I- This is different!

Catra shook her head and asked him, genuinely confused, —*Why* are you so against their relationship!? I mean, yes, we all find it kinda disgusting, but this was so… *cruel*! We saw how happy your sister is! She…

—*Happy*!? What!? Are they "friends" now!? Who could *possibly* be friends with that- that *traitor*!? You think she has, what, *feelings* for her!?

—Of course! Haven't you seen her!? Are you blind!?— she shouted, increasingly angry. —You don't have an idea of how that sorceress feels, do you!? You don't…— Catra continued, but interrupted herself when she realized she was about to reveal what she saw. While it would be a very deserved punch to the gut, she wouldn't *ever* tell him about that. —You're blind… I can't believe you could do this to your *own* sister!

—She *betrayed* me! She- You have no idea how it feels to see your own family give that *monster* a damned kiss!

Adora slowly approached and placed a hand on Catra's shoulder as she asked —What did she- I know she was your tutor before the… spell thing. Light Spinner, if I recall correctly. But, what exactly did she do to you?

Micah looked away, frowning with a mix of pain and anger. He closed his fists tightly as he recalled that time.

—She used me… And took from me that which I treasured the most— he began. He clenched his teeth as he continued —*My* mentor? Light Spinner? She *died* the moment Shadow Weaver came to be. That's what she does! Take everything I love from me! All my family!

—*That* is your problem?— Catra let out, like a whisper, yet unmistakably indignant.

—Catra…

—No, no— she interrupted Adora, refusing to stay silent. —You, *you*, old man, have *no right* to hate her so much— she began, quite angry but mostly offended. She shook her head before continuing, fists tightly closed, —You- You got the long end of the stick! You're just being *immature*! Did she traumatize you? Clearly; now all your losses *must* always be her fault, and *everything* she does that is *remotely* nice or at least genuine *has* to be "manipulation", no? I've been there, we both were, but *at least* we can now recognize when it's genuine and when not! Because *we* aren't merely hateful!

—You didn't experience what I did— he argued.

Catra let out a cackle, tilting her head back, bitterly laughing.

—You are *so* right! *We* never got genuine love from her!— she exclaimed. —The closest any of us had, was something that clearly must have felt like what you had, but even so, it was just manipulation!— she continued, taking a step forward. —You weren't *used*! At least not at first, clearly! That's why you loved her so much! She genuinely cared for you! Even *after* her corruption! But *us*!? Adora was used since the beginning, she only saw in her someone with power whom she could control! While *I* was seen as a risk! She says she saw herself in me, and *guess what*!? Now I know why! Everyone in this damned kingdom saw her as a risk! So I *had* to be the same! And she *told us* that she didn't want to develop the same care for us that she had for *you*!

—I- No, she- It had to be fake… That- When she got corrupted… that… caress…— shakes his head. —She didn't care for me since the moment she made me… help with that… cursed spell entity.

—You're impossible— Catra scoffed. —The *only* time she caressed my cheek… It was *actual* manipulation… And all to make me give her the means to *abandon* me! You were *never* punished by her, never got your hopes up only to be *crushed* right after! You never got your power and competence questioned despite your best efforts!— she reproached him, her voice breaking. —I always thought Adora had it better than me, but *you* had it even better than her! You telling *us* that we didn't suffer what you did and using that to justify your… *hate*… It's insulting. To the both of us!

Adora placed a hand on Catra's shoulder once again but, this time, she only looked at Micah with a serious expression.

Before he could reply, Glimmer opened the door of the meeting room to call Micah back. As he walked inside, the Queen gave her friends a nod and they returned to Darla so they could get their things and return to their chambers in Brightmoon.

Meanwhile, earlier that day, Castaspella had tried and failed to sleep. She had perhaps slept two hours, maybe less, and then simply couldn't rest anymore. Before sunrise, she had gotten up and sat with her spiders and a piece of blank paper; her mind was racing, thinking about everything she wished she could tell Shadow Weaver and, soon, several loose lines began filling her papyrus…

Of all the things I could regret… the one I wish I could correct, is taking so long to finally… accept it. And not having been brave enough to show it that night; perhaps before. Earlier that day I could have… said it.

I know you… hate defects and weaknesses… But I should have dared tell you how much I like your imperfections… how perfect they are for me… I wouldn't change them for anything… And I really wanted you to embrace them. Everything people hate about you… is what you do to bury them… but your flaws are… strong enough to have kept a part of your heart intact. They are your strengths…

I feel like I was just… so close to showing you… what you could have if you allowed yourself to feel it… I only… wanted you to know you can be… loved too. And that… even with how much I've reproached you, how much I've pestered you, how angry I've gotten at you, I still… love you.

I wonder what you'd tell me if you could speak with me now: would you want me to move on? To grieve you? To forget you? Or to never let you go? Regardless… I'm not grieving for you: I'm coming for you.

The Head Sorceress didn't stop writing until she ran out of space; she closed her eyes as she finally stopped, leaned back on her chair, and slowly let out a sigh. She took a moment to read everything she had written and, after a while, couldn't hold back her tears anymore.

When she was done, her sorrow turned into rage and she took a new piece of papyrus to write on. This time, a series of furious lines, some like replies, some more akin to general reproaches, gradually filled all the available space with all her unspoken anger at her brother…

Do you really care!? That's the reason you keep repeating over and over again. But have you ever cared!? How could you possibly care about me if you don't fucking listen to me!? If you can't even trust me the tiniest bit!? What on Etheria am I supposed to do for your damned trust!? Eh!? What else do you want from me!?

You can be so… spiteful. You insist she's "a monster", but you!? You've been nothing but an unbearable jerk! To both of us! You're despicable! I can hardly believe you really are "my brother"! You're not him! You can't be! Who the fuck are you!? And why do you hate me so much!?

I don't hate you… of course I care for you, I'd never betray you… But I love her even more. You're… not worth giving her up. And you expect me to grieve her and move on? Absolutely not. I'm not… ever… giving up on her.

Angry tears began falling the more she wrote and, eventually, she didn't know how to continue; it was impossible to write another line. She only stared at the paper with an angry frown, teeth clenched tightly, tears of rage escaping her eyes, and before she couldn't hold back her cries anymore, she drew two sigils and placed them on both pieces to fully burn them.

Castaspella watched as the fire consumed each papyrus, then remained motionless for a few more minutes. She had no idea how much time had gone by, but she was sure it was now noon and she hadn't eaten at all; neither dinner the previous day, nor breakfast that morning.

She left her room and slowly made her way towards the kitchen. She could prepare herself a meal and take it with her to eat at the grotto; she felt like she needed to relax and have a bath. The Head Sorceress was lost in thought, deciding what she'd cook, until some yelling called her attention.

The Queen was running after her father, who was seething with rage and now stalked towards Castaspella. Glimmer managed to get in the middle so he couldn't reach her, but the sorceress remained there, too worried to simply continue walking.

—Out of my way!

—This isn't her fault!

—Yes it is!

—No! *We* decided this! She doesn't even know yet!

—Then go ahead! Tell her! Tell her how my spell casting is being *supervised* because of her *infatuation*!

—This is *not* Aunt Casta's fault! You did this *yourself*!

The Head Sorceress tried to understand what was going on, but her head now felt too light, her vision gradually darkened, and she leaned back on the wall, dizzy. It took her a moment to finally realize what was happening to her: she had yet to eat.

Ignoring the discussion, Castaspella pushed herself off the wall and continued on her way to the kitchens, but after a few steps, all her senses went numb, her vision darkened too much to distinguish anything, sounds and voices became pure noise, and she finally fell to the ground as her strength failed.

—Sis!

—Auntie!

The sound called Micah's attention, when he looked over Glimmer's shoulder she followed his gaze out of curiosity, and both of them immediately panicked and ran to help her. The King kneeled next to her, carefully picked her up by the shoulders, and set her head to rest on his lap. They both stared at her for a moment, holding their breath until she opened her eyes slightly.

—A-Auntie, what happened!?

It took Castaspella a few tries to finally reply, breathlessly, —I didn't… eat.

Glimmer immediately teleported to the kitchens, took the sweetest piece of food she could find, and returned to them. Micah helped the sorceress sit up enough to eat the bite-sized bun his daughter brought.

—This was the most sugary one left, Auntie— she assured her, as Castaspella reached for the bun.

—I don't understand… what happened?— the King asked, concerned.

—You said you didn't eat— Glimmer began, pensive. —But this means you didn't have breakfast either, and…

—But— Micah interrupted and looked up at his daughter with an alarmed expression. —Didn't you say she didn't have dinner last night!?

—Because she burnt the rice! Auntie!

Now he felt like an idiot. The biggest moron ever. Had he caused this?

So it seemed but… this wouldn't have happened if *that woman* hadn't poisoned her mind.

No… this had to be *her* fault!

But perhaps… now wasn't the best time to say so.

He sighed and requested —Can you get the cooks to prepare something for her? I will take her back to her room.

—Alright.

Glimmer immediately disappeared and Micah carefully lifted Castaspella up. All the way to her room, he walked in silence, trying to ignore the thoughts crashing inside his head, and the feelings of guilt and rage fighting to overtake him. Once he laid the sorceress down on her bed, he turned around, too ashamed to keep looking at her, and approached a window, not wanting to leave until Glimmer arrived with food, yet unable to face his sister now.

Micah was too restless, kept looking around, merely escaping his thoughts and feelings, and finally settled for observing Castaspella's pets. After a while, he noticed some remaining ashes on the table under the terrariums, moved forward, and reached out to touch them, wanting to be sure.

He didn't have the faintest idea of what she could have burnt, but before he could ask or give it too much thought, Glimmer appeared.

—Here, Auntie— she immediately said, approaching the sorceress. —Eat slowly, alright?

Once the Head Sorceress was comfortable enough to eat on her own, Micah left them both alone.

—I'm fine, don't worry— Castaspella assured, noticing her niece's distress.

—Still… Try to stay here today, please. You can call us if you need anything.

The sorceress smiled and nodded weakly; Glimmer stared at her for a moment, concerned, before finally standing up and leaving the room.

Later that afternoon, Adora and Catra returned to Mystacor, wanting to speak with the Head Sorceress. They knocked on the door right when she was about to get up so, instead, she just let them in.

—Welcome back, girls— she greeted them. It was clear she hadn't fully recovered, even if her voice sounded just as energetic as usual; her slow movements and apparent lack of balance gave it away. She noticed them slightly embarrassed, avoiding direct eye contact, and realized —He said… that I kissed her, right?—. They nodded silently and she let out a deep breath; right after, she dismissed the subject and asked —I- Where should we… begin?

Both Adora and Castaspella were looking away, ready for an uncomfortable silence, yet Catra's voice surprised them both.

—I want to start— she began, fists closed and head down, her sight fixed on the ground. —I shouldn't have… sneaked into your room. Not the first time, and especially *not* the second time.

—Oh my, that's… I- I understand. Glimmer told me why you had… sneaked into my room the first time— the sorceress immediately replied. —However, I don't think I comprehend why you returned — she admitted, tilting her head slightly.

—Oh… right.

She looked away, gripping her right arm, visibly distressed. Adora moved closer and placed a hand on her back.

—It's alright… she'll understand— she encouraged her.

Catra took a deep breath, looked up, and slowly breathed out as her sight finally settled on the sorceress.

—I thought- I was- Ugh!— she stammered. She growled, frustrated, and pushed herself to finally explain —I thought she would hurt you! We- We saw you give her a kiss on the cheek, and- and she *hates* anything remotely related to love! She- I don't know! Sees it as some… manipulation!? I just- We left without making sure you were safe! And I panicked! But *they* were panicking already, trying to come up with something to tell the King, so instead, I returned on my own! But… I was… wrong.

Catra hugged herself and looked down again, expecting to be scolded for her "flippancy", the words already filling her head; even Adora was expecting that, but she noticed Castaspella still sitting in place with a conflicted expression and seemingly just as shy as Catra.

—Well… You weren't that far off— she finally confessed.

—Wha- Re-really?— Catra let out. She blushed and pointed out —It didn't really *seem* like it…

When she saw them both looking back at her with a mix of surprise and embarrassment, she let out a snicker and explained —Then you must have returned after the worst had passed…

—I- I may have returned ten minutes after you, um, kissed her cheek— she nervously clarified.

—Oh! Yes, indeed… You missed it, but- Oh my, don't be alarmed, alright?— Castaspella replied. She sighed and began —Her first reaction to the… kiss was, naturally, accusing me of trying to manipulate her or the like, just as you said—. She looked away, ashamed. —She could have hurt me; she grabbed my neck and seemed… alarmed enough to, you know—, she interrupted herself to make a gesture near her neck, referencing killing her. —However, I knew she wouldn't hurt me, even if she kept threatening to do so, she wouldn't go over the limit— she assured them. She then raised her brows briefly, commenting —In fact, I think that when she really intends to kill someone, she just… does it. Why would she warn? The only time I've heard she "killed" someone, I was told she just *did it*; no warning, no threat, not a chance to avoid it.

—Sounds like Shadow Weaver, yes— Catra admitted, grimacing. She then looked back at the sorceress, confused, troubled maybe, and asked —But… How can you be like that? How can you *possibly* trust someone like her!? *Especially* when she's threatening you!

—My unwavering trust broke her confidence, enough to make her doubt all her twisted beliefs. Don't be fooled, I don't trust her blindly, I'm always wary and she knows that, which only makes it all the more effective to… disrupt her mindset that everything and everyone is a threat so she should strike first— she replied with absolute confidence. She then made an effort and stood up to approach them as she continued —Bea- I mean, Shadow Weaver lives- *lived* feeling she'd be attacked or betrayed at every turn, that *everyone* is the enemy, which made her a… I don't have a better word to use other than "bitch"—. She laughed briefly along with Catra and Adora, then went on —Who preferred attacking before being attacked, have everyone fear merely *considering* betraying her, and all of that made her desperate for control.

—That's- It explains a lot; her possessiveness and that *need* to be indispensable to Hordak… Always trying to be on the winning side…

—Not wanting you to get any position of power…— Castaspella interrupted. Both of them raised their brows and fully opened their eyes, surprised at the sorceress' remark. She sighed and continued —My point is: I can only teach her to trust again if, first, *I* trust *her*—. She looked away with a little smirk as she added —Besides, it's not like I can't keep myself safe if anything were to happen; I'm the one here who still has sorcery, remember?

Castaspella giggled, easing the atmosphere a bit.

—I- Can I ask…— Catra began, hesitant and surprised. —You haven't… warned me about… you know, not mentioning what I saw…

—I don't see why I should— she replied, dismissively. —It's not like you saw anything questionable or reproachable. It's something natural, and it *was* in private, as is proper…— she explained, giving her a light-hearted reproaching look. —However, it wouldn't exactly be a wise thing for you to do… You *did* spy on Mystacor's highest authority, I believe you'd have far more problems than me if that were known— she reminded her, raising a brow.

Catra immediately tensed up, a bit uncomfortable, and couldn't help letting out —That sounded a lot like Shadow Weaver…

Castaspella immediately laughed, covering her mouth with a hand, trying to calm herself, and admitted —I didn't notice! Oh my! But please don't worry. That wasn't a threat, more like a warning out of genuine concern—. She smiled gently and added —In any case, I wouldn't let anyone do *anything* to you. I just meant, it's not like I'd add any kind of threats when you already have more than enough reasons to make sure this little incident is never made public.

Catra looked away as she let out—Thank you…

The sorceress' expression softened immediately and she added —But… I'm so sorry, Catra. That- that must have been so disturbing.

She looked up at her, confused again —Wha- I-I don't understand. Why do you care!?

—I…— she tried to reply but her bewildered expression made her hesitate. —Of course I care! This is no little issue, and I can only imagine how much it could have affected you; I can't even tell what you're feeling now… seeing me.

Catra looked away and admitted —I just… keep… remembering…

—It's alright. Take a deep breath— Castaspella interrupted. She sighed before explaining —You just have to let go of this. I promise it's fine, no need to give it much importance at all. Think of it as some anecdotic accident and laugh it off. It will help you feel less troubled.

She took a deep breath as instructed and managed to calm down, yet she couldn't help asking, slightly alarmed once more, —What if she learns I spied on you two during… *that*!?

The sorceress held back a laugh, pressing her lips tightly together for a moment, then replied —If that happens, *please* do me a favor and make fun of her for it.

—Why do you want me to mock her?

Castaspella finally allowed herself to laugh when Catra looked at her even more puzzled than before.

—Because if *I* do, it just has no impact, and she *will* mock me back. If *you* do, it will *actually* get her; that way you'll eventually stop fearing her so much; you're quite bold, never let others intimidate you… I bet you even talked back at her a lot if she considered you so "flippant" as she'd say.

—But she'll try to kill me if I do that!— she immediately replied, tensing up as she felt goosebumps making her hair stand on end.

—I won't let her touch you— the sorceress sentenced with absolute confidence. —When I'm not there, she'll be unable to touch you; when I'm there, not only will I stop her but also you'll see her face the consequences immediately— she continued, taking a step forward to hold her shoulders. Catra's expression became conflicted and she was on the verge of tears, so she added —You deserve it, alright? You shouldn't be haunted by her all your life. Just like I told you to let go of that memory, I hope you'll let go of your fear of her, because you *don't deserve* this torment.

Catra seemed just as confused still, if not more each passing moment, and shook her head before questioning —I don't understand this either. How can you... love her but then say this? Why would you... side with me *against* her?

Castaspella was stunned for a moment, alarm and shock briefly crossed her expression before she looked down and pressed her lips for a moment.

Sure they wouldn't just go talking about this conversation, she finally allowed herself to say it properly instead of avoiding the word, and replied —*Because* I love her I wouldn't just overlook all the damage she has caused. Besides, I've come to understand the way she treated you is how she thinks she should be treated too, and because she sees herself in you…

Catra scoffed, indignant, and interrupted —She made my life literal hell! So, what!? Some self-love will make her treat me better!?

The Head Sorceress looked away briefly, with an ashamed smile before replying —I- Well… Oddly enough, it might just be it—. Her expression became more serious as she looked back at Catra, and sentenced —But, this isn't about *her*. I've done plenty of things for her, or her and someone else. But this is *just* for you.

—And *why* do you care? I get that you're a really nice person and all, it's just that this doesn't make sense! You don't know me!

—But I know *her*. And what she has done to you.

—She told you about it!?

—Yes, she did. One of her odd... tests— she explained with an unamused expression. —She was trying to prove I just see her like anyone else does, but pretend I don't. So she told me all the horrors of your childhood, didn't omit a single detail— she continued, fully opening her eyes at the end, with a disturbed expression and a low tone.

—She- I can't… What!?— Catra hesitated and exchanged a look of disbelief with Adora. —How can you know all of that, *recognize* she did that, and still love her!?

Looking away with a sorrowful frown, she replied —I understand why everyone believes she doesn't deserve love, kindness, or forgiveness; I suppose I agree. But people don't have to deserve my kindness, respect, or love; it is *me* who believes everyone can change for the better, that this is how I should treat people, it's the only thing that may help them become better, grow. So, I know I've said this already, but... I acknowledge what she has done, and choose to forgive but not to forget, because I love her, the real her. If I pretended she didn't do all the terrible things we all know about, would I really be in love with her or with the idea of her?—. She looked at Adora for a moment and noticed something in her expression that made her add —Tell me something, Catra. Honestly. Do you think Adora denies what you have done? Do you think she pretends you didn't command attacks for the Horde, or captured her and her friends, or…

—Stole her sword to activate a portal that broke reality and for which the Queen of the Rebellion is now trapped between dimensions— she interrupted.

Castaspella stared at her, stunned, blinked a couple of times, and finally said —That's very specific. There's no need to be that hard on yourself, you know?—. She sighed deeply and continued, once again speaking with a more gentle tone, —But answer me. Do you think she pretends you did nothing or that she accepts what you did, forgives you, and works to make sure you never feel compelled to do it again?

Catra looked away and hugged herself.

—I suppose you're right.

—Of course I love you regardless of that— Adora immediately assured, embracing her. —And I know you thought you didn't have a choice… but finally, you *did* change! You *chose* to change.

—Exactly— the sorceress let out, smiling. —You should focus on that. You didn't choose where you were raised or for what, but ultimately chose to leave that behind so it wouldn't define you anymore — she insisted.

—While, now we know… Shadow Weaver *chose* to side with those she knew were evil. *On purpose*.

—Specifically, because she considered the Rebellion didn't deserve her help; she could have fought the Horde herself with the power she got, no one forced her to join them. She just… did that intending to make everyone suffer for not acknowledging her power. Or not supporting her, I reckon? I think she herself doesn't know the exact reason, she kept changing it every time she spoke about it.

—Sounds like her— Catra replied, rolling her eyes. She then noticed Adora's conflicted expression and added —I- So-sounds like me too, I guess…

—The important thing is, you do deserve forgiveness, a chance, and to be free of the torments of your past— Castaspella summarized.

—We just want you to be happy, Catra. And I know you, like me, can't simply hate her— Adora added, speaking gently. —I mean, she raised us, of course we'll always be influenced by her somehow, as if tied to her…

—But neither of you should feel subject to the fear she caused you— the Head Sorceress interrupted. —She can't hurt you anymore, we won't allow it, and while I don't expect you to move on from this overnight, I want you to understand *you did nothing to deserve the eternal torment of fearing her*— she assured her. —One day, you'll be able to look back at it all like a bad nightmare, and whether you forgive what was done to you or not, it only concerns you and no one else; it's just *for you* to be at peace, even around her.

—Thank you— she sighed.

—In the meantime, I swear: mocking her is the *perfect* way to counter her "scary" behaviour— Castaspella laughed. —Especially if you don't back down; now that she doesn't have her powers, she gets more competitive and turns it all into a game of wits— she explained. Chuckling, she pointed out —I've noticed you're sharp enough to rival her; no wonder she was so petty at you.

The sorceress laughed daintily again, and Catra couldn't help but find the whole situation pathetic and laughed a bit too.

—Shadow Weaver is right, you're a bit foolish and naïve— she let out. Right after, she immediately added —But that's not a bad thing! I actually feel more at ease now!—. However, shortly after, she looked to the side, troubled —Perhaps… The mask should have stayed saved. I don't…

—Catra, it was worth it; we got to say what we couldn't, get some closure… I think it was a good decision— Adora interrupted.

And yet, Castaspella looked down and admitted —Actually, I agree with Catra. This was- Perhaps all of this was a mistake.

Adora's expression fell, so she tried to change the subject a bit.

—Can I ask… what exactly happened? Because I'm sure the King gave his *very* particular take on it all. Like… he insisted on the fact that Shadow Weaver must have charmed you for you to have… kissed *her*… and on the lips— she hesitantly said.

—He's actually right. About some of it, of course— Castaspella acknowledged shyly. —I *did* kiss her, not the other way round. But, as to *why* I did that… I don't- I don't think I can… fully explain it— she stammered. —It was an impulse? I was just… *so* happy! I had finally managed that teleportation spell! And… Remember her comment about hugs?— she explained, letting out a sad smile. —Well… she complained about it again and I was *so* emboldened!— she continued. She shook her head slightly, smiling more fondly now. —I just… leaned forward and kissed her. It was- If I didn't do it, then I'd never dare… So, perhaps I was reckless, but I *absolutely* don't regret it— she assured. Right after, her expression became sorrowful and she looked down as she added —What I do regret is that I never got an… answer. What did she think about it? Was she annoyed or upset, or angry like the night before? *I myself* didn't want to think too much about what I felt! And-and I'm so *anxious* right now!? I can only think she must have… hated it.

Castaspella let out a sigh that said more than enough. Right after, much to her surprise, Adora moved forward to hug her. She was stunned for a moment before hugging her back, withholding tears.

—I understand— she let out. —We, Catra and I, we've felt the same way, as if any demonstration of care for her were… a bad thing. She was our personal nightmare, but she's always been the woman that raised us; she made us suffer, but also taught us a lot. So, in the end, we both felt… a bit odd about it, but… when we lost her, we finally admitted that we still loved her as a mother.

The sorceress hugged her tightly, a single tear rolled down her cheek, and she finally let go of Adora.

—I know what I said before but… I can't possibly put into words what I felt, besides "complicated". I just *know* I got to know the real Shadow Weaver, or perhaps even the real Light Spinner. And maybe… kissing her was a *mistake*, but I still should have been allowed to make *one* such mistake without sentencing her to oblivion again!— she let out, noticeably distressed. —Especially after how she *trusted* me! I…—, she interrupted herself briefly, placing a hand over her chest. —I can still feel that summoning spell that got bound to me… but it's just *so weak* without the mask to channel her— she lamented.

Adora's sorrowful expression suddenly disappeared upon hearing that and she looked up to the sorceress, surprised.

—Wait… You mean, it *technically* still works? But isn't strong enough to bring her here?— she asked, pensive. Castaspella nodded and she inquired —Could you explain to me *how* that happened?

—It-it was just an accident— she replied. —It just happened to be the… moon alignment that night, and the Sorcerers' Guild has this one… traditional dance that Shadow Weaver *happened* to be performing when I went to see her. So, whe-when she invited me to dance… I suppose the enhancement of Etheria's magic with the eclipse must have had something to do with that?

Adora opened her eyes wide as she realized —So it just needs the magic to be stronger and she could be summoned again! I know a place where magic is stronger!

Castaspella looked back at her, inquiring curiously —Place… Do you mean one of those magical grooves in the Whispering Woods?—. Adora nodded and she remembered —I- Oh Stars! She *did* show me how the magic of Etheria was simply dormant when we walked across one of those!

—Do you still know where that was!?— Catra asked immediately.

—Absolutely!

—Then we *have* to go!

The sorceress couldn't help letting out an amused smile and held back a chuckle.

The three of them left at once and soon arrived at the Whispering Woods. It took them a while but eventually, Castaspella recognized the spot; some of the dormant beasts remained there, soundly asleep, but others had already risen and left huge hollow spots on the earth. They had barely walked into the clearing and were looking at the sleeping creatures, when Shadow Weaver's spirit rose from the ground, smirking against her will.

Noticing they weren't looking towards her, and feeling curiously *different* from the previous summoning, she tried something before calling their attention.

—Took you long enough to think about coming here.

Her familiar mocking tone made the three of them turn around, only to see a masked Shadow Weaver who looked *very much alive*. Catra immediately took a step back, Adora stood frozen in place, and Castaspella fell on her knees, covering her mouth and tearing up.

—How…

—I'm still quite dead, no need to worry— she immediately laughed sardonically, moving a hand in front of her mask to make it disappear. —In case you're wondering… Since the mask was broken and the original summoning spell was dismissed, I now seem to have some more… freedom to control this magical body I'm inhabiting. I can take any of the forms I've ever had.

They remained shocked for a moment, barely able to process her nonchalant explanation, before finally snapping out of it, exclaiming in surprise.

—How!?

—It really worked!

—You were *actually* right, princess. Hah!

While Castaspella slowly stood up, the girls carefully approached Shadow Weaver.

—You can *change* this… magical… body… thing?— Adora asked, curious.

—That's correct— she replied, tilting her head and smirking, amused.

—Does that mean… You could show us how you looked as Light Spinner!

—Like that statue!? Oh yes!— Catra immediately exclaimed, surprising them both with her excitement, and making Adora laugh.

Meanwhile, Castaspella stayed back, seemingly uncomfortable, and turned around as soon as Shadow Weaver agreed to take Light Spinner's appearance. Her mind immediately disconnected and she didn't hear the girls commenting on that un-corrupted version of the woman.

Instead, a series of memories flocked into her mind, overwhelming her senses:

"She was dangerous."

"Best tutor? Obviously they would say that; after all, she had all her pupils' mind-controlled."

"Yes, she taught me a lot. But she almost got me killed too. I was lucky to have escaped alive."

She shook her head, trying to clear her thoughts, but she couldn't stop thinking about all those things both the council and Micah had told her so many years ago. What finally managed to extract her from those oppressive memories, was a sudden embrace from behind.

She hadn't heard when Shadow Weaver mentioned she was taking the appearance from the moment she had just been corrupted, so it startled her to see the scarred arms that suddenly wrapped around her.

—What the- Bea!— she exclaimed. Castaspella jumped slightly between her arms, startled as she recognized Light Spinner's robes and Shadow Weaver's scars. The sorceress felt her face appear over her left shoulder and looked back at her with a pained frown, noticing the tattered veil and fresh scars. —Oh Stars…

Oblivious, she raised a brow and asked —Why so sorrowful, Cas? It seemed before that you were *slightly* more glad to see me. Or is it because of how I look?

Shadow Weaver let go of Castaspella and turned her around, more serious, wanting to look at her face as she simply couldn't understand what was happening to her. But the longer it took the Head Sorceress to reply, the worse her concern got; the feeling made her anxious, and she hated both the concern and the anxiety that was overtaking her.

Fortunately for the woman, before she went mad, Castaspella teared up and leant forward, embracing her tightly. It shocked Shadow Weaver who looked back at Adora and Catra, both just as confused as her.

After a moment, the sorceress finally let out —Just look at what it did to you!—. Her sudden cry only surprised them all even more; she had let go of her and now looked at her with utter indignation. —It's- They *really* saw you like this and immediately attacked? As if- as if you had *wanted* this!? I-I can't… understand how all of that happened! Yes, you shouldn't have done that! But just *look at you*! It's clear that thing almost killed you! It was so- so cruel! Why did they attack you when you needed *help*! I- I don't think- You didn't deserve it!

Shadow Weaver was expecting a scolding, something along the lines of "look at what you did to yourself", yet it was the exact opposite.

She couldn't help shaking her head and laughing sardonically as she replied —Don't be so innocent, Cas. That's not true. Your criterion is usually much better than this—. She tilted up her chin to look into her eyes as she spoke with absolute seriousness —Listen to me: when the spell failed, I was mortified, yes. I tried to fight it yet the spell managed to subdue me within seconds… I had *never* felt so powerless in all my life. And so, I gave up—. The sorceress looked back at her with such surprise she didn't even have to ask. —The feeling of… hopelessness made me disregard *everything*; I just embraced the power of that parasite magic because I no longer cared if it tore my body apart. Either I got the power that had managed to suppress me, or died trying. And I *did* expect to perish…

—Bea…

—I no longer deserved any pity, Cas— she assured her. —I had… accepted the corruption; your brother was just a child, the adults, Norwyn and those acolytes, they just did what anyone would have done: try to put down the obvious threat— she insisted. Then, she looked down, mildly annoyed, perhaps at herself, and admitted —I immediately regretted having him see all of that… having accused him of betraying me… so I preferred to teleport away as soon as possible.

—But Bea… you had just made *a mistake*— Castaspella immediately countered. —Your original idea didn't include turning into Shadow Weaver or fleeing to the Horde! A-anyone could have made a mistake, bu-but their reaction what pushed you to abandon the rebellion!— she continued, speaking loudly but relatively controlled. She wasn't crying, but still seemed on the verge of tears as she went on —You tampered with powers that corrupted you, yes, but you were in *full control* of them! I- I know I kept emphasizing how you endangered my brother, but I'd be a hypocrite if, now that I know the truth, I pretended the intentions that led to that event weren't *pure* at first!—. She scoffed, laughing bitterly, and added —The situation with the Failsafe was so similar, and you were a *real*

bitch for how you did that. *But guess what*!? It did work! So just… think about it! You *chose* to return to the rebellion and then did something *so much* like the Spell of Obtainment…

—And got told off in quite a similar manner by you all. Your point?

Castaspella shook her head at her interruption and grimaced as she realized she was digressing.

—Yes, sorry. Wha-what I mean is: you made *choices*. After the spell failed, even if you were corrupted, you didn't… strike first. They considered you a threat without giving it a second thought, they attacked and you retaliated. So, knowing you, I'm sure that attitude made you want revenge, no? And joining the Horde was your best, perhaps only, option: no other kingdom would accept you, but the Horde would welcome you. And, of course, you'd prove your point to them.

Shadow Weaver smirked and let out a malicious snicker, amused at her accuracy, and commented —Perhaps you *do* know what you're talking about…

A few meters behind her, the girls remained in shock; Catra was visibly confused, but Adora seemed to understand her. Two of the things she had said lingered in her mind: "they considered you a threat without giving it a second thought, they attacked and you retaliated" and "no other kingdom would accept you, but the Horde would welcome you".

Castaspella held her arms, as if hugging herself, and let out —If only I hadn't been a kid back then… I wouldn't have let you go, or attacked you, just- I would have made sure everyone else was out of the Lunarium, safe, and then… I would offer you help. You made a mistake, immediately paid the price, and… the power you got? You could control it, choose what to use it for!

—Is that so?— Shadow Weaver interrupted, mockingly. —What happened with "my crimes during my time as your brother's mentor"?

The Head Sorceress blushed but still looked back at her to clarify —That was *before* learning what *actually* happened!—. Right after, she folded her arms and looked away, concluding —And, in the hypothetical situation I was an adult like now back when that happened, I would have witnessed it all, and I *would* have done exactly what I said.

She immediately laughed again, walked around the sorceress, and grabbed her face, pulling her closer until the tattered veil brushed her nose. Castaspella couldn't distinguish her expression, but recognized her teasing tone and didn't pull away.

—How predictable. Of course you would put yourself in danger while keeping *others* safe— she began. At the back, Adora immediately blushed and Catra looked sideways at her with a smug expression; they giggled a moment before returning their attention to the sorceresses as Shadow Weaver continued —After all, you *did* perfect defensive spells to the detriment of your practical and offensive ones.

The sorceress scoffed and turned her face away to escape her grip; folding her arms tightly, she glared back and asked —If you're done mocking me, could you *please* get to the point already?

She rolled her eyes, sighed while slowly stepping closer once again, and took one of Castaspella's locks between her fingers, making the sorceress roll her eyes too.

—My point is: I don't know if it's because you're too gentle or…—, Shadow Weaver interrupted herself and dropped all the mockery. —No, I know it *is* that gentleness. Sounds very ridiculous to me, but it's a fact that you're a much more gentle leader than Norwyn ever was. History would have been

very different— she finally admitted, letting go of her hair. Gesturing over her face, she once again took the maskless appearance she had during her original summoning, and placed her hands on Castaspella's shoulders; her expression showed great conflict but also, determination. —If it disturbs you so much, then I shall remain like this; I owe you that much at least, no?

The Head Sorceress couldn't hold back a smile as she recognized that phrase, and looked up at her right when Shadow Weaver went to place a hand on her cheek to pull her in for a kiss. After being shocked for a few seconds, she gave in and kissed her back briefly, until she remembered why they had gone there.

At the back, Adora noticed Catra was looking at the distance, pensive, and realized what she could be thinking; she placed a hand on her shoulder and gestured at her to leave. However, a short yelp called their attention back to the sorceresses.

Castaspella had taken a step back, one of her hands covering her mouth after that squeal, and looked back at the girls briefly, before clearing her throat to explain —Wait, wait. Oh, Stars! I almost forgot why we came here! So much has happened this week and… Well, Micah insisted so much on how… unfair everything was for him that Glimmer promised him a chance to explain himself once they arrived…

When the sorceress gestured towards Adora and Catra, they approached carefully.

Shadow Weaver noticed her blushing but the way she had changed subjects so suddenly made her feel that, perhaps, it had been a mistake. A part of her immediately reproached herself for such idiocy, another part just considered she should ignore the subject and pretend nothing happened, so she settled for thinking Castaspella simply didn't want to discuss the subject now.

Her attention focused on the girls as Adora explained —Yes, we… tried to speak with him as soon as we arrived but… it wasn't very productive. So, we went to hear what he would tell the council, and…

—He said everything, including his *real* reason to dismiss the summoning spell, am I right?— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—Ho-how do you know!?— Catra asked, already fearful, guessing the reason.

—It appears that there are some moments when I can… hear things; I can't see anything at all, and most times I couldn't understand much, but I've managed to hear the voices of those kids I taught in Mystacor, mostly a bunch of noise— she began. Then, she looked at Castaspella as she continued —I also heard bits of your conversation with Micah; you made quite a number of smart remarks. And I believe I heard something shatter too?

—You- I was *actually* hearing and seeing you! It wasn't my imagination!

Shadow Weaver laughed mockingly at her tone, but only returned her sight to Catra, more serious, as she added —And I heard someone decided to play the spy at a *very* inconvenient time.

She gulped and took a step back, visibly frightened, but noticed the Head Sorceress giving her a reassuring look and a nod. Perhaps it was worth a shot.

—Right, "inconvenient". I suppose that's a way to call it— she began, trying her best to push away her fear. —We wouldn't want anyone to know your rock-cold heart got *heated up*.

Shadow Weaver's immediate glare made Catra recoil, but before the woman could so much as tense her claws ready to threaten her, the sorceress suddenly called their attention.

Castaspella snorted, covered her mouth with both hands, trying to hold back her laughter, but couldn't contain herself more than a second, and finally allowed herself to cackle in all earnest.

—I'm sorry— she tried to apologize, calming herself. —It's- Oh, Stars!— she let out before covering her mouth again. She took a deep breath, closing her eyes briefly, and finally pointed out, looking away with a smirk —Perhaps you're being too lenient implying she has a heart.

Shadow Weaver glared at her with an unamused expression but did nothing, even when all three of them were snickering.

However, it didn't last long as Adora realized something and asked —If she's… hearing us occasionally… and apparently heard more from our conversation than from the others… could it be related to *who* is involved?

Castaspella looked away, pensive, and thought aloud —You heard me when I was talking to Micah, also heard the kids… and then heard us three…—. She finally looked back at them and suggested —Perhaps it's because of an emotional connection? Like it or not, you *did* form emotional connections with us all…

—What about how clear the sounds were?— Adora insisted.

—It would seem like the number of people affect that but… both Micah and I were in front of the kids, who she couldn't properly hear so, I think, it's more related to the depth of that emotional connection— the Head Sorceress suggested.

—Oh! So with both of us *and* you, it was enough to give her a clearer understanding of our voices.

—You think?— Catra asked, shyly.

—I suppose that makes sense— Castaspella conceded, pensive again. —In fact… I think that's akin to being summoned. Perhaps… you two most likely can keep her here while in this groove— she suggested. —Without this spell I have, she'll be unable to touch anything real but…

—Still works. If we wanted to talk with her, we wouldn't need to bother you— Adora interrupted.

—That's right!— she agreed, smiling. —Now, speaking about this spell— she began, turning to face Shadow Weaver. —I've been feeling a certain pain from it; interestingly enough, I no longer get feelings from you, or didn't until coming here, but those sudden pangs make no sense.

—Ah… of course.

—And if it continues to happen, I'll be forced to remove the spell— she concluded, looking down.

—What!? But then…

—Not even you coming here would allow her to return as this spirit— she explained, interrupting Catra's sudden exclamation.

—But that's your choice. They can't force you!— Adora argued.

—As the Head Sorceress, I am expected to do what's best for Mystacor. My options would be to either remove the spell or give up my position.

—The day you step down as Head Sorceress will be the day those fools doom themselves— Shadow Weaver scoffed, rolling her eyes and gesturing dismissively with a hand.

—Bea…

—I'm serious.

—As am I. Answer the question— Castaspella insisted, folding her arms.

Adora nudged Catra and, once again, gestured to leave. This time, they did; after nodding briefly at the sorceress, they walked away and returned to Brightmoon.

—It is… apparently related to my status as a damned soul, I suppose— Shadow Weaver finally replied, looking away slightly ashamed.

—"Damned"? That's…— she interrupted herself as she suddenly recalled that one document she had ignored. —I found something about that but- but I thought those were just… stories.

—It is *very* true— she assured her. —I'm attached to the core of Etheria, it pulls me… towards it. The only thing that had been strong enough to pull me so far from it, was the summoning spell— she explained. —And *something* in the surrounding area of the core is… painful. It hurts horribly.

—Why hadn't you mentioned it!?

—Why would I!? I was *perfectly* able to keep it under control as long as I felt *nothing*!— Shadow Weaver immediately countered, mildly annoyed. —But now there are so many… memories. I can hardly keep that pain from reaching me, and you through the spell. Perhaps it wouldn't be a bad decision to remove it.

Castaspella immediately shook her head as she denied —Absolutely not. I- I told you I need your help. I- I'm sorry for everything that happened, but… I just can't lose- It wouldn't be wise to simply let you disappear with how much you have helped the kingdom. I rather keep the spell on me, even if it means I'll keep sporadically getting those sudden stings.

—That's enough— she interrupted. —Why do you insist you need me? It's clear you can fend for yourself perfectly well.

—Tha-that's not true, at all— she insisted, shaking her head. —I don't have half the skill you had… a-and your advice has been *indispensable* for us during these past months! For me and for all of Mystacor!

—How can you be so much of a fool? None of that is true— she replied. Her tone was harsh, but the sorceress could see her honest expression. And so, her conflicting thoughts overtook her. Seeing the woman so lost, Shadow Weaver approached carefully and tried to explain herself with the most gentle tone she could manage. —You have *everything* you need to lead the kingdom. My only advice was on evident things you would have figured out on your own sooner or later, and if you could trust me so much… I believe you just need to stop being an idiot and be more confident instead— she let out, smirking at the end.

Castaspella looked away, blushing slightly and holding back a smile. She took a deep breath and slowly let it out before looking back at her.

—I… slowly lost all confidence as the war got worse, and felt more and more powerless the longer it went on— she admitted. —The first time I felt confident again, was when you sought me out to find a way to save my brother. You told me to… stop you if you tried to take the power for yourself… and, for me, it meant that someone as powerful as you actually believed *I* can take you down! It gave me confidence for everything that came afterwards! Like fighting Micah when he found us at the Crystal of Arxia!— she went on, more excited now. —And when we last talked… if it weren't because of our conversation, reminding me to trust Glimmer and to help her, I-I don't think I would have had enough confidence to even *try*. I would have thought I was more of an obstacle than a help— she admitted, looking down. —So I *know* I need you to do this.

Shadow Weaver let out a mocking smile and laughed lowly for a moment.

—Then you're quite fortunate. I am not going anywhere— she reminded her, using that teasing tone the sorceress knew perfectly well. —You can always visit this groove again if you need to talk, and now… I'll be trying to keep an eye, or rather an ear, on you all making use of this *interesting* perk we have discovered— she offered, making Castaspella's laugh briefly. —I'll be aware of what's happening, in case you need any urgent help.

The Head Sorceress smiled gently and, without realizing it, she took her hands while she said — Thank you, Bea. I'll do so.

She then suddenly noticed her hands and let go of her, blushing nervously. Shadow Weaver preferred to stay silent about this too, and adopted a more serious stance instead.

—In that case… I shall be expecting you three to visit me— she let out, smirking again. Right after, remembering something, she added —In fact… *four*. I wouldn't mind your niece visiting occasionally.

Castaspella smiled softly and nodded before taking a few steps back to finally leave. Shortly after she was gone, Shadow Weaver felt herself being dragged down by the core, *back to eternal damnation*…

Chapter End Notes

I lost my changes at least twice when editing here, otherwise, I would have posted *many* hours before TT^TT I'm sorry… If there were any mistakes, I apologize, but the second time I had to re-edit everything, I was too frustrated to put the same effort into it as before ._.

SO!

I'm sorry to inform you: that was the last kiss you will see for *checks notes* a full decade in-fic <("^~^)

OH, BUT: may I remind you… next week (in time, I promise), comes the *flashback* you've been waiting for, (and you will hate that I robbed you of it *during* C-a-S that is when it happened), but I guess that can count as compensation too, no? Heh... ~~Obviously no, you'll want my head for these chapters~~

<("^-^)/ until next week!! ~~If I reach it alive~~

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: it isn't wrong to enjoy and want things you regard as "weaknesses"
Status: being questioned by self-loathing

Chapter Notes

UGH! LATE AGAIN!! I'm SO sorry!!!
I literally didn't know what day of the week I was on, and I could barely focus when editing!! In fact, with my studies I have a *really* busy schedule, I even kept pushing myself to finish editing this chapter so I could post it before my class today!! And I *failed*, of course. Goodness...

Anyways! You wanted it! You waited for it! And I'm so sorry I tortured you this much! BUT!! I promise you: the wait was worth it, I swear (°ʖ°)

Oh, but you will also hate me because this happened during the time of C-a-S yet I robbed you of it <("^-^) oops

Whatever, that's it; enjoy drunk Casta haha!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

What had she *done*!? *What exactly* possessed her to do something *so stupid*!?

Since *when* is she so…

So weak!

Shadow Weaver couldn't allow herself to fall so low…

And yet… Beatrix kissed her without hesitation, just like Castaspella did…

But it clearly had been a mistake, one she would *absolutely* never mention again. It would, of course, be a different thing if *she* brought it up; until then, Beatrix would simply pretend it never happened…

Reflecting on this, she now thought about how… that occasion, the *actual* first time Castaspella had kissed her… she considered it an effect of the alcohol; perhaps she should have considered that impulse kiss of hers, the one Micah saw, to be just due to the excitement of her success, not something she *meant* to do. In fact, she may even regret doing that, not just because it caused her dismissal, but mostly… because it was obviously *a mistake*.

And now… that "real first kiss" won't leave her mind.

Shadow Weaver had her reasons to dismiss it, yet now she couldn't help but brood over it.

Perhaps it was just wishful thinking, but not like she had let herself *think* about that at all before. Now, she *had to* admit she enjoyed it, which only angered her even more as it made her feel weak. She had allowed something *so small* to subdue her.

Unless… it wasn't as small as she wanted to think…

Shadow Weaver was back in the area of the summoning spell, comfortably reading a book. Before leaving for Brightmoon, the sorceress had helped her take that book to the Lunarium so she'd be able to read while Castaspella was gone.

However, hours later, before she returned, the spell bound to her made Shadow Weaver feel something quite unsettling. She was well aware that Micah had banned her from going to Brightmoon, but this feeling became impossible to ignore, so she went to find her regardless.

The Head Sorceress was on one of the Palace's balconies, and the scene she found was far stranger than anything she could have imagined.

—You got her!?

—Yeah, but she's trying to pull away!—Glimmer replied, struggling to hold back the sorceress by the right arm, while Adora easily kept her in place, unable to move her left arm at all. —Auntie! Stop! We're trying to help you!

In front of them, Bow stared for a moment, holding a ceramic bottle and a small cup; it seemed like he feared that Castaspella would break free and attempt to get it back. When he finally paid more attention to what he was holding, he seemed surprised and confused.

—Um… Glimmer… Is this supposed to be *warm*!?

—What!? Auntie!— she immediately exclaimed. —You drank a full bottle of such *terrible* quality!?

Shadow Weaver could only stare silently, in utter shock, as the sorceress kept struggling to break free despite being too drunk to stand on her own.

—*Wah*? Why *d'you* care… about the *quality*!? *Issas* good as any! You're *jus'* being… *pretenshious*! Hah! *Jus'* like your mother…

—Enough, shut up! You're drunk!

The scene became amusing enough that the woman could barely keep herself from laughing. However, Catra suddenly rushed into the balcony with a bucket full of water and threw it at the sorceress.

Shadow Weaver let out such a loud cackle that all four of them looked back at her immediately.

—What the- How long have you been there!?— Glimmer stammered.

—Just a few minutes— she nonchalantly replied, having immediately calmed down her laughter, while tilting her head slightly. —When I got that strange feeling from the spell, I absolutely did *not* expect this.

—What? You- Aren't you *banned* from here!?— Catra asked.

Looking back at her, and with the same calm, slightly mocking tone, she admitted —I am well aware that Micah has prohibited me from coming to Brightmoon, yes. But he is *not here* right now. Are *you* going to tell him?

She scowled and looked away. Before either of them could say another word, Adora interrupted.

—Did you come to help? Because…— she began, yet interrupted herself, grimacing as she glanced at the sorceress, still trying to pull away and whining in annoyance. —We have run out of options here.

—I suppose I *could* be of assistance, yes.

—Are we *sure* this is a good idea?— Bow asked, exchanging a skeptical look with Catra.

Glimmer sighed and insisted —Nothing is working here! Auntie is completely… um, out of sorts —. With an ashamed half-smile, she concluded —It's better to take her back to her room in Mystacor and leave her to… Shadow Weaver's care.

Catra immediately gave the Queen a look of disbelief that the woman couldn't ignore.

—If you can't *trust me* to take care of her, then you're welcome to think I'll just do it to preserve the advantages she provides me— she suggested.

—Hah! I *dare you*!— Castaspella exclaimed, dragging the words a bit.

While everyone chuckled, Catra kept her attention on Shadow Weaver; she scowled and rolled her eyes, crossing her arms in front of her chest while muttering —Obviously…

—I agree with Glimmer— Adora admitted. —It's clear that the Head Sorceress trusts her.

—I suppose…. But, Love, I don't see how she could help her more than us— Bow argued, genuinely concerned. —Your aunt is clearly hyperactive right now. She keeps trying to escape from you two, maybe to get the bottle of sake back, or a new one! To be honest, I don't think she will fall asleep any time soon. I- I think she's now a bit, um, reckless, so to speak.

Shadow Weaver looked up, clearly annoyed, and retorted —It goes without saying that none of you believes me to be trustworthy, but I'm sure you all know full well I have my *methods* to make sure things go my way—. She gave them a defiant look, smirking as her sight briefly settled on Catra. She then closed her eyes as she added —I will *not* let her out of her room, that I can assure you. I'm certain I can handle her quite easily but, if necessary, I can always give her a sleeping potion.

They all stared at her, too stunned to speak until Glimmer finally broke the silence.

—What- *Why* do you have sleeping potions!? How did you make them!?

Snickering, Shadow Weaver explained —To begin with, your *dear* aunt has allowed me to continue my little gardening hobby, which you would know if you *ever* visited her just for the sake of spending some time with her instead of only interacting with her for "official" business or when there's something concerning that requires your attention—. While clearly annoyed, the Queen preferred not to interrupt and only looked at her with an unamused expression. Satisfied with the reaction she got, she nonchalantly continued —I've been using some of those to produce the potions while alone at the Lunarium, when I was free to make use of the basin. As

for *why* I've been brewing them, that would be because she has quite severe insomnia; no surprise you had no idea about that either.

Glimmer rolled her eyes, finally too fed up, and complained —Can you *please* get to the point already!?

She smirked once more before concluding —The point is: those are for her. She has been relying on my illusions to fall asleep with more ease; I'm sure you agree that she shouldn't be so dependent on me for that. I haven't told her about them yet, but solely because I rather make enough before she can stop me.

—Why would she?— Adora asked, utterly confused.

—The woman is *too nice*, and stubborn; she keeps saying she has "asked too much of me already".

Seeing her disgusted expression, the Queen snickered and stated —It's decided. This is the best option.

—Ugh! I- I'm *nots*- not sleeping… I *refususe*!

Glimmer and Catra looked at the sorceress even more concerned than before, Adora and Bow had to cover their mouths to hold back a laugh, but Shadow Weaver cackled shamelessly.

—Didn't I tell you seeing you drinking would be concerning?— she mocked Castaspella, grinning sardonically.

—Fu-fuck you… *Bish*…

This time, it was Catra who cackled, too amused to stop herself. Glimmer shook her head, letting out a smile, and hooked the sorceress' arm over her shoulder with Adora's help. She then retreated as Shadow Weaver approached the Queen and her aunt.

As soon as she teleported the three of them to Mystacor's corridors, she let the woman carry the Head Sorceress to her room in her stead and took the chance to dry her a bit with a spell. Glimmer opened the door for them and stared for a moment, concerned, before sighing and finally closing the door.

However, a moment later, Castaspella began shaking, as if trying to get off her arms, and Shadow Weaver hurried to the couch before she fell off; she had her lay over her lap, with her head on the empty side to the right, and her legs over the armrest to the left.

She groaned, realizing it was quite hard to keep her still, and the sorceress speaking pure gibberish non-stop soon annoyed her.

—Just fall asleep already! How can you be this energetic if you're drunk!?

—Hah! *Youn*… know *so nothin'*— Castaspella laughed. —*Alcol nevah* tires me!— she continued, snickering.

—What have I gotten myself into?— Shadow Weaver muttered.

The sorceress pushed herself up, sat on her lap, and continued annoying the woman with her teasing. Castaspella kept pocking her cheek, mumbling gibberish once more until she moved her

face away, grimacing angrily.

—You're… so *gurumpy*… why?

Her tone seemed both offended and teasing, but Shadow Weaver was too irritated and immediately gripped her wrists to hold her still.

—Sleep, woman!

Castaspella shook her head and looked at her with a pout, then leant forward while saying —How *canay* sleep… when you're so *colose*?

Shadow Weaver was stunned for a moment, trying to process what she had said. As soon as she realized what she meant, her eyes opened fully in alarm.

Ignoring her nervousness, she dismissed it, saying —Right… stop teasing already. You really need to…

She was interrupted mid-sentence; the sorceress leant forward, completely ignoring her words, and laid on the woman's shoulder.

What on Etheria was she doing!? Clearly, she was far too drunk.

—*Dis* you… know *thas* Micah said… I'm bein' played? By you… heh…— she began, speaking in a very low tone. However, despite her drunken speech and the low volume, Shadow Weaver could perfectly understand her. —After- Uh… When I *toldya* to leave… remember? I- I talked *with'im*… I *convinced'im* he's *blamin'irall* on you… that he *said'at* but… it's *ununnecessary*? 'Cause you… did *not* mean- meant to…— she continued, hardly making any sense. The woman wasn't sure what to say or do, so she let Castaspella continue, wanting to figure out what she was trying to say. —*An'* he was like "why are you *tryrying* so much?", but I- Yeah, I'm puttin' effort? I *want'o* think… I deserve the same effort… *An'* I see… so much potential… *inya*— she went on, tilting her head enough to see Shadow Weaver's face. When she looked back at the sorceress, her surprise escalated, and so did her scare. She felt increasingly nervous and uneasy, but wouldn't admit that, preferring to blame it all on the alcohol. —*Foreal*, I- I'm sure you… can regret *whatya* did… And I *told'im*… and he said *thas*… won't fix… things— she explained, sounding more sorrowful. Her voice seemed about to crack, but Castaspella wasn't going to cry; she felt hurt, deeply pained. —He began… rambling "that won't brin' Norwyn back, won't *erasesed* the girls' *taruma*…" An- *an'* I *tol'im* I *know* that! But wha- The point isn't *fixin'* the past!— she exclaimed, indignant. —I *asked'im*… if he thinks the girls *an'* he deserves an apology… he s-said "yes" but… he doesn't think *thas* to be possible, *an'* again *with'e*… "won't fix" bullshit— she groaned. While her disastrous speech was quite amusing, the conversation she was telling her about made Shadow Weaver pay more attention to what she meant, not to *how* she was saying it. —I *tiried* to *explain'im* how a-a genuine apology could *help'em* all heal! *An' thas* you need to *lersn* to regret to-to apologize *foreal*! But you're treated lik'a *mounster*! Why *wouldya* want- You- If you see no reason to-to try! It- It'd be… like- *lik'a* justification of *thas* bitterness!?

—Cas…

Shadow Weaver tried to interrupt her, once again wanting her to just sleep, but the sorceress stubbornly refused.

—He *isnisist* you don't deserve kindness! *An'* said he's better without *an apologize*… *an'* said it'd be fake! *He'ssa* a bitch…

—Cas, you're drunk. You don't know what you're saying.

—No, no! I know! Look… He-he said you *can'tapologize* for-for a kill- for *whatya* did to Norwyn, *an'* I said you're help-helping *Mysatacor*!— she began again. The woman could barely bite back a cackle this time, but Castaspella continued talking, completely oblivious to her amusement. —I mean… you- Doesn't *thas* count as *payment*? *Repayments*? Uh… well, you *get'it*… Ugh! But he went on! *An'* on! *An'* said I'm *purusuin'* an impossible dream! *An'* lettin'ya manipulate me! *Thas* this will… fire back? Back… uh…

—*Backfire*…

—That! Yes!— she exclaimed, beaming with a silly smile that made the woman shake her head in disbelief at how foolish she was. —He says I'm *toostubborn*!? So I don't see…— she continued until her voice trailed off. Castaspella absentmindedly played with the rim of Shadow Weaver's scarf, comfortably resting her head on her shoulder still, and sounded broken as she asked —Am I… so stupid?

She was drinking that much because of that conversation with Micah!? Now it made sense why she got *so* drunk this time. A full bottle… It sounded quite dangerous.

—You *are* quite foolish— she first teased, smirking. However, her tone became more serious as she added —But certainly not for this. You're *right*, Cas; it's a shame your brother can't see it. If anything, the real fool is him for not trusting you.

The sorceress raised her head enough to look at her face as she asked —Really?

—I- Yes. I have to recognize that your intentions are… pure— she replied, looking away.

Right after, as soon as she looked back at the Head Sorceress, Castaspella moved forward; her arms, on each side of Shadow Weaver, gripped the back of the couch and trapped her there. The next thing she knew, the sorceress was kissing her on the lips without hesitation.

The woman was stunned, too shocked to move, or think; she made them both fall back on the couch, then intertwined her fingers on Shadow Weaver's hair while holding her close, and kept deepening the kiss. Soon enough, she couldn't resist it anymore; she gave in and kissed Castaspella back.

Even if her senses were numb due to her status as a summoned spirit, she could still perceive a faint taste of alcohol on the sorceress' mouth; the woman wasn't merely drunk, she was a cup away from replacing the entirety of her body water with alcohol.

How was she still conscious?

But also… she couldn't deny how much the *taste* compelled her to kiss back.

After a few minutes, the Head Sorceress pulled back, needing to breathe again, and stared at Shadow Weaver for a moment until exhaustion made her fall back on the couch next to her. She stared at Castaspella for a moment, still unable to accept what had happened, and shook her head as if trying to dispel a nightmare.

—Mhmm… this *coush* is very comfortable…

—She's drunk. She's completely out of her mind— Shadow Weaver told herself. She then looked back at the sorceress, smirked, and mocked her —You're lucky that, being so drunk, you will *not* remember any of this…

—*But'ay* want to remember!

—Trust me, you don't. You would have *a lot* to regret.

—Regretting isn't *bad*… It *jus'* means *recognizin'* your mistakes.

—Admitting as much is being *weak*.

—*Butya* recognized the bullshit spell *thin'* you did *wassa* mistake *an'* said you paid it- for it…

—I was at my *weakest*!

Castaspella immediately opened her eyes again and pushed herself up, enough to reach out and briefly touch Shadow Weaver's cheek.

Fully focusing on her speech to be as clear as possible, she replied —It was… the bravest thing you had done… since we met.

She remained frozen for a moment before moving the Head Sorceress' hand away while shaking her head, utterly skeptical.

—I will *never* understand how you can *possibly* trust me so much. I tried to escape and *avoid* admitting my mistakes!

Castaspella took a deep breath and spoke slowly —I trust… the person who… faced that *monster*… made sure that it wouldn't… hurt Catra. The-the person who admitted… after so many years of mis-mistreatment… that she was proud of Catra… a-and for whom the girls *cried*! I-I *trust* you have- That there's potential… in you… to *regret'itall an'* apologize… I know you can…

Her speech became weaker and the sorceress was, once again, leaning closer to her; Shadow Weaver stood up from the couch, left Castaspella laying on it, and walked towards a wardrobe from where she produced a small vial.

She approached the sorceress and tilted her head up, saying —Here, take a bit of this.

She made sure not to give her too much, and immediately returned the vial to its place. Afterwards, she picked Castaspella up, took her to the bed, and tried to leave her there.

Yet Shadow Weaver had to sit on the bed with her because the woman was still awake enough to hold on tightly and kept trying to kiss her, mumbling gibberish whenever she argued that she didn't know what she was doing.

But then again… this was solely because of her drunkness, wasn't it? For some reason, the sorceress was hellbent on kissing her… and there was such raw passion behind it, to the point it felt just as intoxicating as magic.

The next time Castaspella leant forward to kiss her, Shadow Weaver didn't hesitate and met her halfway, choosing to indulge while she could. After all, this surely wouldn't happen when she's sober, she may never have such a chance to taste this curious sensation again.

Little by little, the Head Sorceress fell asleep; even when still unable to believe what had *just* happened, Shadow Weaver let Castaspella lay on her, soundly asleep. However, she kept repeating to herself, over and over again, that it had been just the alcohol, that she wouldn't recall anything, that it all meant *nothing*.

And just as expected, when the sorceress woke up, she didn't have the slightest idea of how the night had finished.

—What do you *mean*!? If I'm asking it's because I *obviously* want to know!

—No, you don't. As I said: it's better for you not to remember what happened, or you would already be regretting *everything*.

Annoyed at her tone and mocking expression, she insisted —You *can't* know how I will react!

Shadow Weaver tilted her head to the side, grinning smugly, and approached slowly. She toyed with one of Castaspella's locks before replying with a sardonic tone that made her shiver.

—What *I know* is that you're better like this. It is *for the best* that you don't remember.

The Head Sorceress gulped, apparently nervous, and cleared her throat as she dismissed her.

—You are *impossible*. Why am I wasting time on this when you're just as stubborn as me? I don't know.

The shy yet still playful sorceress was back.

So she was right… It had only been the alcohol.

That would never happen when she's sober. Perhaps, it never should.

That had definitely been more than just a triviality. In fact, dismissing it so adamantly is the greatest sign of how relevant it had been for her.

But why?

Obviously because she enjoyed it.

Because she found it addicting, with that feeling that reminded her of the raw magic she felt at the Heart.

The Heart.

Hadn't the sorceress told her she had to "accept" that feeling of love to get the strength needed to protect those she cared for?

It sounded so ridiculous; it still does. But she *experienced it*! That sudden surge of power… She would *never* forget that feeling; it was like *nothing* she had experienced before or after.

Except for those… intense kisses the drunk sorceress had given her.

She had tried so hard to pretend it never happened…

Only to wonder now how things would have been if she had let her know about it.

Would it strain their already unstable relationship?

Or would it be the exact opposite?

Would Castaspella have kissed her, fully aware, much earlier?

Is it so wrong that Beatrix *wants* to feel that again?

Perhaps it is…

Perhaps… it was never meant to be something for her to experience at all…

Chapter End Notes

I can't decide what's more amusing: Castas' drunk speech, SW being all fed up with her nonsense, Casta poking her face, or SW's bewilderment! HAHA!

I've laughed so much with this XD
I mean, "Mysatacor" makes me cackle every time I read it!!

U may have realized that, when I write drunk Casta, not only is her disregard for boundaries completely enhanced, but also: she's shameless and doesn't give half a fuck for how her words can affect people around her.
Something that seems to characterize her in canon is how she always tries to keep a "correct" and decorous behaviour (which makes her interactions with SW in S5 even more amusing), so I believe it would only be natural for her to lose all filters and self-control in *that* field, which makes her say things like that "pretentious just like your mother" to Glimmer, or call Micah a bitch despite usually trying to be more lenient and understanding. Those things obviously have quite an impact on those she's addressing, for which she'd never say something like that -in her right mind-.
THAT is why, here, all her complaints about Micah are solely when drunk (or written and burnt in the previous chapter), as those are the only ways for her to just voice her thoughts, whether she means it or not, without having to judge what she's saying.
I suppose we all have this internal dialogue in which we may have some thoughts we actually disagree with, as that's just raw feeling speaking; when we're enraged, we may let those out without really meaning to say that. But Castas' self-control keeps that from happening. Only this particular state manages that, making her voice everything she's keeping bottled up.
Now that I think about it, it wasn't a headcanon of mine but rather just a one-time thing I came up with, yet I suppose it would be logical to think that she does that thing of writing her purely emotional thoughts and then burning them. It'd be a way to relieve herself without causing any harm...

Okay, end of the rambling! So sorry! Until next week!!

We want you to teach us

Chapter Summary

Castaspella can't rest yet: her *new* pupils await her, and Shadow Weaver's counsel can only help so much.

»—(…)our Head Sorceress can barely manage both courses and her administrative duties. (…) Usually, she'd just be supervising Shadow Weaver, now…
»—Now she's on her own and almost rejected this overall. (…)
»—(…) We can make things easier for her! Why don't we suggest…
»—But the kids! I don't think they will be content with this "rearrangement" at all. We know just how competitive pupils can get.
»—We must do something! (…) We have a group that stubbornly asks for her as their teacher, and a class that only learns when *she* teaches them because of their personalities.
»—(…)They (…) need someone with enough knowledge to clear their doubts so they won't be stuck for too long.
»—Enough debating. We shall suggest the Head Sorceress to merge the classes, so she will have more time available and won't need to keep rushing like yesterday. Whether she accepts or not will be her choice only. And we must respect it.

Between her lack of confidence and all the remaining tensions that have yet to be dispelled, her daily life will prove to be more challenging than ever.

Chapter Notes

._.
My apologies
Again...

I just returned from """""""""Vacations""""""""" on Tuesday, had it half written, approximately, and I DID finish it yesterday, but I had to edit (and just did all 3 mandatory edits today, took me from 9am to 2pm), so now I am posting it with *relatively* more confidence. I would still prefer to have more time... but well, I mean, it's decent enough, otherwise, I wouldn't be posting it

And, I think I had something else to say here, but I forgot so...
ENJOY!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The morning sun found the Head Sorceress of Mystacor rushing around now that her tutoring began once again. As per the arrangements made the previous week, she was now in charge of Shadow Weaver's pupils *and* her own, which meant she had to balance her administrative duties and two different courses.

Her pupils always had classes at the library or the lowest levels, for theoretical and practical lessons respectively, right before lunch. On the other hand, Shadow Weaver's pupils would *always* have practical classes, out in the gardens, with the occasional theoretical explanations the woman considered relevant at the moment. If there were any doubts, they could research on their own or ask the Head Sorceress. But those were right *after* lunch.

Castaspella attempted to organize all her duties, unrelated to tutoring, in a way that they could still be done during the day despite having twice her usual time fully taken by the classes. The past few months, she'd usually handle some of her paperwork while Shadow Weaver imparted her lessons; it allowed her more flexibility to do everything as she only had to keep an eye on the woman and could entirely ignore the classes in favor of her work.

But now, *she* is the one teaching.

The Head Sorceress felt frustrated by the mere thought of having to be the one mentoring and correcting a group of kids who are, in all ways imaginable, far better than her. She was so anxious about it, that she got up before sunrise and, when the sky was just getting light, she was arriving at the magical groove in the Whispering Woods.

—What are you doing here so early, Cas? Did I overestimate your observation skills?

Castaspella rolled her eyes as she recognized the teasing tone, and turned around to find her a few meters away.

—Mind you, I *did* sleep and I *did* find those potions shortly after you were gone— she began, approaching. Once she was in front of her, she folded her arms and, with a serious expression, explained —I- This afternoon I have to… start tutoring your pupils, and…

—You're not sure you can teach them anything.

—*They* could teach me more than I can teach them!

Shadow Weaver didn't even try to hide her amusement; she laughed loudly, approaching the sorceress despite her apparent annoyance, and looked down at her with a smug smirk.

—Much as it pleases me to be told even my pupils are better than the head of the Guild…— she began, with a low tone. Grabbing her chin to make her look directly into her eyes, she continued —This sounds like resignation. Are you giving up so easily?

The Head Sorceress kept frowning, this time genuinely annoyed, as she retorted —Not only have you made it *very* clear that my casting is far from perfect, but also, it did take me *months* to get that teleportation spell right!

—Your casting may be pitiable, yes…— she nonchalantly conceded. Her tone then changed as she continued —*But*: have I or have I not told you, repeatedly, that your theoretical knowledge surpasses almost every other magic user in Etheria? They have *a lot* to learn from you, and this is a great moment for them to better understand what they are doing, and *why* it should be done the way I've taught them.

Castaspella didn't pull away from her grasp, only opened her eyes in surprise and stuttered —I- That's- I hadn't thought about that at all…

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes, smirking, and let go of her chin, gesturing dismissively.

—Of course you didn't. You tend to presume everyone knows the theory if they can perfectly cast the spells.

—But for that, you *must* know what you're doing!— the sorceress complained.

—*Must*, yes. But is that what your acolytes do?— she asked with a malicious tone.

—I- My pupils do… but it also takes them… too long to learn— she replied, noticeably disheartened the more she spoke. —Their progress is *so* slow compared to your kids…

—Forget that— Shadow Weaser interrupted. —There's only a handful of magicians in that island who *actually* know what they are doing. And *you* are the only one who knows just as much as me— she continued, interrupting herself right before saying "perhaps more", as she was thinking. She looked away and, instead, added —May I remind you that, regardless of how easily your brother can cast just any spell he wishes, the actual knowledge of what he is doing, the effect it will have, what may interfere, what can be the results of doing it wrong, and just how dangerous failure can be, among other details… He doesn't have the slightest clue about it.

The Head Sorceress huffed and looked away —No one cares about those. The pupils only want to perform complex spells. Most times, they can only learn about basic security measures the *hard way*. It is *never* easy to have them pay attention to our warnings until something *bad* happens.

—Which is why you are, in fact, the perfect tutor for the- for *my* pupils now— Shadow Weaver immediately assured her. Taken aback, Castaspella could only stare back at her in utter shock. The woman simply continued —Those kids aren't just talented; even the most "untalented" ones in terms of formal casting are still incredibly powerful, which means failing a spell can easily be catastrophic for them. If now you make sure they understand what they are doing and why they should… take everything and everyone involved into account, they are far less likely to be a threat to others or themselves.

This time, Castaspella's surprised expression was for entirely different reasons. She hesitantly moved closer, with a mix of disbelief and hope in her eyes, as if a part of her insisted this was nothing but mockery again.

—You… are basically saying…

—That you have to teach them exactly what you've repeatedly reproached me— Shadow Weaver interrupted, looking back at her while keeping a solemn expression and both hands behind her back. —You may have realized these kids are… a lot like me, perhaps like your brother too. And if there's something we both have in common…

—Recklessness.

—Precisely. With your knowledge and *passion* for investigation, you would have been… quite a thorn on my side if, in your brother's stead, you had helped me modify the spell— the woman explained. She smirked mockingly before concluding —You wouldn't have been satisfied until you were sure it would work. With your brother, being able to perfectly cast it was "enough".

The Head Sorceress sighed, admitting she was right, but still seemed unsure.

—You know there are only a handful of pupils who, like me, can enjoy more theoretical classes. The rest *never* pay attention. They *never* read the material!

—But my kids have been ordered to *always* obey you. If you tell them to read, they *will*. If you decide to have a class exclusively for theory, they *will* comply— she reminded her.

Castaspella nodded in agreement but suddenly looked up at her in utter shock.

—You- You called them "my kids"— she muttered, covering her mouth with both hands.

Shadow Weaver immediately turned around, gesturing dismissively, and took a few steps forward.

—They aren't really *my* pupils anymore, so I shouldn't call them that. And saying "the kids" or "the pupils" is too general. Don't add to my words a meaning that is not there.

Her tone was so neutral that the sorceress couldn't tell whether she was angry or ashamed. However, from the spell, the feeling she could perceive was, maybe, anger *at herself*.

Of course. She's taking it as a weakness. Which also means… she *cares* for them. But she's only now allowing herself to admit how she cares for Adora and Catra, learning to accept that as a reality. Adding even more to the list of "admissions" so quickly can only backfire.

Castaspella moved closer and hesitated; instead of hugging her from behind as she wanted to, she only placed a hand on her shoulder, not wanting to feed that feeling of "weakness".

—Bea, it's… fine… to feel like this. I- I'm proud; I know this is like a weakness for you, but it isn't— she uttered, a bit shy as she wasn't sure whether that was a good idea either.

—Stop that. Know your boundaries— she sharply replied. The sorceress immediately recoiled, grimacing as her fear turned out to be right, but Shadow Weaver caught her hand the second it moved away. She didn't turn around, only placed her own hand on the sorceress', keeping it on her shoulder, and let out —At least don't be so *obvious*. It's uncomfortable and unnerving.

Letting out all the air she was holding, Castaspella sighed in relief and moved closer, stammering —I- I'm sorry. I wasn't- I feared it wasn't the best thing to… do.

—Yet you did it regardless.

—I couldn't *not* do anything.

The woman finally turned around, carefully lifting the hand she had kept on her shoulder and dropped it in a surprisingly gentle manner that left the Head Sorceress speechless for a moment.

—That's what all pupils need. Regardless of how much you can teach them… if you do *nothing*, you doom them— she sentenced.

—But you…

—I did the same, I assure you. Yet I was more… *aggressive*, perhaps.

Castaspella raised an eyebrow, curious, and asked —What? How so?

—You *did* point out once how, technically speaking, raising the girls in the Fright Zone means I taught them basic life skills— she began, rolling her eyes. —I *could have* just watched them struggle with everything, after all, I am *not* their mother, and they would figure out how to do things; not much of that was of any use to make them into useful soldiers which was my only task— she went on, making the sorceress scowl at her. —Yet I still taught them to eat like civilized beings, get dressed,

comb their hair, read, write, maintain their weapons, wash their clothes and armors… I suppose you understand what I mean.

—Well, yes… I guess it's only logical.

—It wasn't. As I said, most of those weren't necessary skills to have in the Horde, and those important were just expected to "be figured out by them", as some survival response.

—Right. I understand. But then, how is it any different from…

—You're careful and considerate— she interrupted. —I, on the other hand, used fear as "motivation"; if they were afraid to face my wrath, they would put extra effort into doing it all perfectly. Another incentive was shaming them: if you keep being told you're a failure and that more is expected from you, then you put even more effort into it, you'll force yourself to demonstrate you're *not* a failure.

This time, Castaspella grimaced in a way Shadow Weaver immediately recognized.

—I *went through that*. And you clearly have no idea how much that can break a person— she immediately reproached her.

—In fact, I do. Because I was also told none of my efforts were enough, that they would never understand *why I was allowed into such a high position*— the woman retorted. —That pushed me to do *anything* to prove everyone wrong, which is why I risked it all by performing the Spell of Obtainment; regardless of now considering it a mistake, it *did* show them I was right— she insisted. —And this worked just as well for Catra. Even if I never said it until the end, I *could* see her progress; I was proud, yes, but the more I belittled her prowess, the better she became.

—And just like you, she made a massive mistake just to prove everyone wrong! The portal thing!? She told me! It weighs down on her terribly!— Castaspella immediately exclaimed. —You didn't help her! You-you just turned her into *you*! Gave her the same fears, the same view of the world…

—As I said… even if I also couldn't *not* do something for them, it was *not* the best way to proceed.

—Then what makes you think I can do it any better? I might also make them… fear… magic…

Shadow Weaver took a step forward and slightly leaned closer, sentencing —They already see it as something beautiful, they sure are curious about it. And they have seen how we both possess more… obscure knowledge. I'd say they will *help you* lose that fear instead.

The sorceress looked up, surprised as she stuttered —I- Why do you think…

She snickered, amused at her obliviousness, and reminded her, with a slightly mocking tone, —Have you forgotten what happened in this groove? How the snoring of a beast startled you?

—That's- I remember but…

—What do you think about this place now?

—It's… quite beautiful. The specks of magic, and the sleeping creatures are…— she began, recalling that moment, and interrupted herself as she suddenly remembered *when* she went from fear to admiration. —You said… “Etheria isn’t a weapon. It’s a living creature”. I perfectly recall it because *you* saying something so powerful isn’t a weapon but rather a living being…

—Yes, yes, very funny— she interrupted, rolling her eyes before taking a deep breath to casually continue, pretending nothing had happened. —I showed you there was nothing to fear, helped you see its beauty. And they can do the same— Shadow Weaver admitted. Feeling considerably *vulnerable* saying these things, she immediately added —I suppose I was just as concerned as you about your brother, which made me be more… lenient with you. It was *the only way* to convince you to trust me.

Smiling slightly and holding back a laugh, Castaspella let out a sigh.

—I understand. I'll try… my best then.

—You kept pestering me with how "doing your best" is enough and that I shouldn't press anyone, not even myself, into doing everything perfectly. Interesting that it is now *you* who tries to be perfect.

—I just said I'll do my best!— she laughed. —But yes, I suppose you're being a bad influence— she mocked her.

Shadow Weaver smirked and replied —Then better go now, before you decide to cast the Spell of Obtainment too.

The Head Sorceress cackled wholeheartedly for a moment, farewelled before returning to Mystacor, and the woman's spirit sank under the surface of the planet once again.

When her late morning classes were done, Castaspella rushed to the kitchens with a handful of documents and quickly put together a meal; she sat right there to eat while skimming through her papers and was fully done in 5 minutes.

She finished with the documents as soon as she could and left them with the council before teleporting to the gardens, where Shadow Weaver's pupils were already waiting for her.

—…so now, pair up with one of your classmates and practice this. If you pay attention to how little variations affect the result when you activate the spells, you can notice how important it is to make sure you're using the correct hand position, angle, and tension— the Head Sorceress concluded, a gentle smile on her face, and both hands joined in front of her.

However, the kids only exchanged hesitant glances for a moment until one of the teenagers spoke up.

—But… we can't pair up for that.

—What- why?— she immediately replied, surprised. Her face fell and, she didn't notice, both hands on her sides tensed up nervously. —Age disparity between casters doesn't make any difference, you all have the same skill level. And I know you're an odd number, but two can take turns to practice with the same classmate— she argued. —I'd say one can practice with me, but I suppose we already know that it wouldn't be very productive.

—It's not that— the same teen denied. —You just taught us: this is to counter a magician with the opposite affinity. Most of us have sun-affinity, while only a few have moon-affinity. A-and there's Sahm with both.

—I- That's- Well, I hadn't- I hadn't noticed— she stammered, feeling more anxious the more she tried to explain herself. —I was- I didn't think about it…

—You told us about it *just now*.

—I know…

—But, Master…

Castaspella felt herself reaching the limit, and had to turn around to hide an enraged grimace; she pressed her hands to her sides so they wouldn't close in fists; she didn't want them, or anyone, to see her like that.

She had failed to see what one of them was doing wrong, she had been corrected by them at least twice already, and stopped when she was trying to demonstrate because she almost activated a faulty spell as she hadn't seen a tiny slip in her sigil.

—I am clearly *not* your master!— she began, her voice trembling. —I will never be like her! I just can't! I can't possibly teach you as much as her! Or help any of you improve more! I-I just- I am not enough!— she went on, more indignant than hurt. She turned around and looked at them all with a confused expression —Why do you trust *me*!? Why did you choose me to replace her!? We all know that's a terrible decision! Even if- No, I just can't…

She was visibly angry, nothing like Shadow Weaver's anger, but still obviously furious, perhaps at herself, as she was only frowning and looking down to the ground. And yet, the kids were concerned, not afraid.

Hesitantly, Ari approached her, saying —Head sorceress? We… didn't want to make you feel… like this. We were just… confused? Bu-but we can do what you said! And take turns!

She shook her head, keeping her sight down, uttering —No… I should… Perhaps I can…

—We don't need a different tutor— Sahm interrupted, confidently. —You know what you're talking about. I don't know if you're a good sorceress or not, and I don't care; we're still the pupils here. What you just taught us today is more than I ever thought I'd know from what's behind these spells… And the difference between affinities, how they affect our powers… We-we didn't have the chance to learn that from our master, we really wanted to ask more, to know why we're like this… What it means— he went on. He then took a deep breath and explained —Even if you'll never be our master… You're still a tutor, a teacher, and have a lot to show us. We-we want to know. We *want you* to teach us.

Castaspella looked back at him and stared for a moment in utter shock. Her expression allowed them to see her sorrow and she had to take a deep breath to keep herself from crying.

—Thank you. I- Thank you— she let out.

As soon as the class was done, the sorceress ran through the corridors, as fast as her legs could carry her, delivering a series of documents that were required by different tutors, some of which she couldn't find at the usual places, which meant she couldn't just teleport to them. By the end of the day, she still had a considerable amount of paperwork to go through, and the council couldn't help but consider she should merge her classes, have both her pupils' and Shadow Weaver's simultaneously. After all, both groups are small, and the area of the gardens can easily hold all of them.

—But it defeats the purpose of having recruited the woman as a tutor— one argued.

—But our Head Sorceress can barely manage both courses *and* her administrative duties. There can also be spontaneous issues that may require her. Usually, she'd just be supervising Shadow Weaver, now…

—Now she's on her own and almost rejected this overall. We can see how… tired she is.

—*Tired*. That's one way to say it— a councilwoman scoffed. —She's most likely dying on the inside! We can make things easier for her! Why don't we suggest…

—But the kids! I don't think they will be content with this "rearrangement" at all. We know just how competitive pupils can get.

—We *must* do something! The pupils have refused to have any other tutor, and her own pupils haven't progressed at all until she took them under her tutelage. We have a group that stubbornly asks for her as their teacher, and a class that only learns when *she* teaches them because of their personalities.

—They are just bookworms. Let them learn on their own then!

—No, no. That won't do. They are barely starting, they need guidance; to be precise, they need someone with enough knowledge to clear their doubts so they won't be stuck for too long.

—Enough debating. We shall suggest the Head Sorceress to merge the classes, so she will have more time available and won't need to keep rushing like yesterday. Whether she accepts or not will be her choice only. And we must respect it.

The next day, the council went to her with this idea, first thing in the morning. As they had said, it was her best option, seeing how her administrative duties are technically her priority and no one else could manage them for her. At least not more than they had already done.

And Castaspella didn't want them to bend the rules for her either, nor did she want to abandon any of the pupils, so she had to give in and merge the classes, even though she could already imagine the kind of situation it would generate.

It took the kids and teenagers at least a week to merely *try* getting along. The Head Sorceress' pupils were still annoyed about the lost week of lessons and every class complained about the way "those kids" had hindered their studies by keeping *their* master away from them like that. In reply, Shadow Weaver's pupils would argue that at least they *do have* their master still, and that they are merely reading books, which can totally be done even without Castaspella there.

And so, she had to stop these brief skirmishes every class. On the first days they barely lasted a few moments but, on the last day of the week, Sahm and a kid almost twice his age were on the edge of starting a fist fight.

—Enough!

The sorceress' voice was loud enough to be heard inside the building, and called the attention of a few acolytes who peeked out briefly. Her students were so angry they would readily ignore her without a second thought; Shadow Weaver's pupils, on the other hand, immediately looked back at her, forgetting about the argument, and lowered their heads while taking a step back. They remained silent, ignoring the confused looks of Castaspella's pupils, and waited for her to speak again.

All except Sahm, who ashamedly let out —Apologies, Head Sorceress.

She gulped and sighed deeply in relief. She had been fearing this kind of conflict since day one. Her students were obviously jealous of the kids they kept calling “newbies”, as they were even more advanced than them despite having barely half a year of tutoring, and kept making comments about them being “just as corrupt as their Master”, which always defied her self control.

It was a question of time.

—How many times already have I told you *not* to attack each other like this? If you can only speak ill of each other, then I rather you do *not* speak at all, because I will *not* allow such disrespectful behaviour in my class— she severely began. —No one is forcing you to interact; I can understand how you feel about each other, and it may seem unfair to most of you, so I have tried to keep your classes as separated as usual, but I can’t keep the usual schedules. I have to teach all of you at the same time from now on. Can I ask you to *please* cooperate? I am doing all I can but, if this doesn’t work out, then I’ll be forced to assign you both new tutors whether you like it or not.

—Apologies, Master— one of her pupils let out, the one who had provoked Sahm so much. —We didn’t… think about that. We don’t want to- We would like to continue under your tutelage.

She nodded at the group and let out a sigh, deciding to dismiss them. After they left, Shadow Weaver’s pupils remained. They gathered around her with clearly apologetic expressions.

—I am… really sorry— Castaspella began before any of them could say a word.

—No, we wanted to apologize. We keep… causing trouble— one of the teenagers said.

—Nonsense. They are *my* pupils, and I should have… known they would behave like this if I merged the classes. They are… quite proud, and fearful, if that makes any sense. They have been studying with me for *years* now, yet you’re already at their level, perhaps even above them, with only six months of classes— she argued. —You’re prodigies and had something no one has ever had. Even though Shadow Weaver can’t keep teaching you, you’re bound to progress quickly all the same. You have a lot to learn, but it *will* be easier for you.

—We still want you to teach us— Ari immediately said.

She let out a faint smile, feeling touched by the gesture.

—I appreciate it a lot. I can… teach you all I know, of course, but to put that knowledge into practice, you will have to rely on your past lessons— she replied. Right after, she hesitantly added —However, I have been considered you could benefit with more advanced casting… Even if I still teach you, I think it would be good for all of you to take some extra classes with my brother. Micah is far more skilled and can help you put into practice what you learn with me.

—Absolutely not— Sahm immediately denied, so serious it took her aback. —Even if he can teach us better. We do *not* want him to tutor us. He will *not* be our Master. Ever.

Castaspella looked through them all, and they seemed to agree with Sahm’s strong words, which completely shocked her.

—Wha-what do you mean? Has anything happened?

—You don’t like talking about him— Ari replied.

—We haven’t heard you mention him much, except a few times when you and Master talked about him during class.

—And we have seen you fight with him a few times.

—We sometimes saw you after having talked with him… You always looked upset.

Several pupils gave their reasons to reject Micah's tutoring, but they all seemed to be keeping something to themselves.

—I… understand— she finally let out. —If so you prefer, then I shall continue teaching you, I'll be glad— she accepted. Yet she couldn't help adding —However, I can see there's something else about this you're not telling me. I *need* you all to be honest with me.

The kids immediately understood what she meant and looked away, ashamed. But Sahm frowned and decided to confess it all.

—We know it was him who sent Master away. That he crushed her mask and that means her spirit can't be here anymore. We- *I* told them all, and we don't want him to replace her in *any* way— he sentenced, fully confident and serious, until his voice began breaking. His strong façade disarmed little by little, and he finally sobbed —He doesn't deserve to take us too! We are *her* students!

The Head Sorceress immediately pulled him into an embrace and he couldn't hold back his tears. She remembered how decided to get answers he was, so it meant that he, most probably, had done something *very* repudiable to get ahold of this information. But it also meant… this is so important for them all that he doesn't fear being punished. He just wanted to know. They all wanted to know.

—I understand— she whispered. —It's alright. He won't replace her. I would *never* allow it— she assured him, looking over at all his classmates. —And no one can force any of you to interact with him in any way, alright?

She let out a pained sigh as she felt him hug her back tightly, trying to hold back his sobbing but clearly unable to stop crying now. She felt extremely broken, but she couldn't let any of this feed her hatred.

That's the last thing they need.

It's the one thing that caused this whole mess to begin with.

Chapter End Notes

~~The foreshadowing I just included in this chapter, oh my…~~
Quick clarifications I love to make: Remember how in *Light Spinner* what enraged LS to the point she finally threw everything out of the window and go to perform the SoO was the decision of ~~the council~~ Norwyn of "letting Etheria protect itself as it always has"? Welp, that's precisely why SW tells Casta that it's actually a good thing that she doesn't remain passive and instead tries to do something, *anything*, even when she's not even sure it's the right thing to do. This parallel is mega out of proportion but, for SW, that tiny "I wasn't sure this was the right thing/But you did it regardless/I couldn't NOT do anything" represents the same spirit she had when, even if there were too many doubts about the SoO, she still performed it as she couldn't just do nothing while Etheria fell. *How ironic that she became part of the problem, but then again, that's because she felt betrayed*. POINT BEING: If you paid attention to S1, that time SW was (apparently) tortured or something like that by Hordak and then returns when Catra is getting

ready to leave, there's a short (but extremely revealing) conversation. SW insists what she did to Catra was to prepare her for the world which, in addition to how she saw herself in Catra, explains why her "preparation" was so cruel, it was a preparation for the world *she* had lived; what I added her, what SW says, is only logical in a mentality like SW's because it's the only thing that "makes sense". *Now and only now* can she see that it wasn't the best way to do it, maybe, but continues latched to that "It still worked". It's a bit of progress all the same, and there you see what Casta means when she says she sees potential in SW.

I think that's the only note I had to make heh
So, I hope you liked it and see you next weeeek!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: You've been in denial but can still regret, change your mind, and be better
Status: In the process of being assimilated.

Chapter Notes

Let me begin with this: the idea for this scene was thanks to this one tweet by Soviet Onion. As you can see, it's very old, and so is the idea, which makes it all the more interesting that it could fit here as if planned *after* what happened in the last chapter. In fact, I hadn't even thought about that scene at all until literally last week cause I only had the concept of Casta taking over the classes and nothing else, oops...

ANYWAYS, point is, you can see where this concept came from, cause it doesn't sound unlikely to be a canon thing -it aligns well with her character- and it makes for a great opportunity to write Casta scolding her *again* XD (I may like writing that a bit too much, oops)

And the other concept, SW feeling happy when teaching, LS's method of making her pupils be wondered by magic (which is also a concept that appeared in a previous flashback, remember?), would be another plausible headcanon of mine seeing how, in *Light Spinner*, she was teaching about illusions by first demonstrating not just "you do this and cast an illusion", but rather giving almost a show with those illusions, as if wanting the kids she was teaching to be excited to learn how to do that, admired by the spectacle. (Yes, this is also why I had her teach Ari an illusion to calm them down). In addition, there's the episode in which SW teaches Glimmer how to cast spells, and she made it so she'd be amazed by it, pretty much in the same way young Micah had been mesmerized by what could be done.
Ahem, about this, a little comment I shared on my Tumblr: Writing this, I've now realized that the initial scene of *Light Spinner* I just mentioned is, apparently, a metaphor for the whole chapter (mostly for what it shows about LS's past). We see LS moving a bird illusion around, that looks a lot like a Fenix, before Micah casts his own illusion, a ram, and shatters LS's. However, immediately after, LS easily recasts the bird, which rises from the bottom, like a Fenix born anew from its ashes, and flies right through Micah's ram, completely terminating the illusion. So now, when I was writing how LS was basically giving a show, I recalled that Micah interrupted with that ram and thought "Hah, a ram, just like Norwyn; what a coincidence". So it HIT ME! The moment Micah backed down, the spell grabbed LS and corrupted her, then Norwyn arrived and LS was on the ground, corrupted, yet she raises, stronger than before, *reborn as SW*, and obliterates Norwyn.
Can you see it!? I'm not insane, I swear.

There are so many parallels, I love the writer of that chapter so much, gods... Katherine Nolfi has my absolute admiration. (And she also wrote *Shot in The Dark* and *The Failsafe*, aka two of the episodes I've rewatched the most just for SW and Casta's interactions. I can't stress how much I adore her for this)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The pupils…

She called them “my kids”…

Shadow Weaver had always been quite reluctant to call Adora and Catra “my girls”, despite how many times Castaspella referred to them as “your girls”… So *why* would she have such slip of the tongue?

Perhaps it was for the best… never to call them that. And doing so with the pupils had *definitely* been a mistake.

This was something Shadow Weaver should *never* allow herself to do; she hadn’t before, and this wasn’t the time to start.

But… she hadn’t felt so *happy* in such a long time!

Light Spinner always treasured every second she spent teaching her pupils. There was nothing she loved more than seeing the wonderment in her apprentices’ eyes; no matter the age, she could always show them the beauty of sorcery as they had never seen it before.

But that was exactly why Shadow Weaver rejected all that *bullshit*. It wasn’t… *true*. Those were lies she would tell, weren’t they? Just to comply and pretend she was like all those fools in Mystacor; to make them all believe she agreed with their ridiculous rules. She was just lying just like they all would do.

So that feeling she had when teaching… was something to be *loathed*, not *treasured*.

But Light Spinner would never let go of those memories that, now, thanks to Castaspella, were returning once again. She had made her notice the differences between her regard of her wards in Mystacor and the Fright Zone.

She had gone from wanting to mesmerize her pupils, to employing intimidation and threats, overusing them to extreme lengths. She wasn’t just behaving like any other commander in the Horde. She was being merely *cruel*.

But only now does she understand that…

“Are you insane!? What exactly is your problem!? What were you thinking!?”

That was the *only* time she enraged the sorceress that much; and those were, in fact, excellent questions she had no answers to.

Inevitably, the memory of that particular argument returned and, this time, she *wanted* to revisit it.

She *needed* that.

> The corridors of Mystacor’s higher levels were silent as the sorceresses waited, leaning on the edge of one of the round arched openings, looking at the kingdom extending beneath them.
>
> A few hours before, they had been with the council, explaining the “little incident” with the fire spell. The irreverent kid had to stay in the council room, under Micah’s vigilance, until his

parents and those of his classmates arrived. But Castaspella needed a breather, and Shadow Weaver did *not* want to stay there alone with both Micah and that kid.

Apparently having remembered something, the Head Sorceress suddenly spoke up.

—Do you- Did you notice how dispirited those girls were after you used the “distraction” argument with them?— she began, looking back at her. An indignant expression matched her tone, as expected, and she asked —Wasn’t I clear the first time I told you how damaging and counterproductive that can be?

—It is a fact. Is it not?— Shadow Weaver immediately replied, keeping her sight on the horizon, her tone dismissive. —The girl has talent and could improve much faster if her *little friend* didn't talk so much, constantly diverting her attention. If she could at least keep up…

—She can— the sorceress interrupted with absolute determination. —It would be better if you *encouraged* them instead of telling them off.

—I don't do “encouragement”— she immediately replied. —And *this* is what I've done for years now.

—Come on! You did encourage me!— Castaspella argued. However, her expression immediately changed as she realized —Wait- Don't tell me the bullshit you told Adora that made Catra run away…

—I have repeated it *many* times, yes. Not only to them but to all my cadets.

—Well, it clearly didn't work at all— she mocked her, finally making Shadow Weaver look back at her.

—They were certainly… persistent— she admitted, tilting her head slightly. With a somewhat wicked grin, she added —And yet, I *did* manage to delay it for more than enough time.

The Head Sorceress frowned in confusion while asking —Persistent? You mean…

—They kept getting *closer*. Other cadets simply gave up any… silly romantic ideas. *But they didn’t*— she interrupted, glaring as she elaborated. —In fact, they would have been a couple much earlier, before Adora found that sword, *had I not interfered*.

She couldn’t help smirking as she saw how absolutely horrified Castaspella was for a long moment there. One could almost see as realization gradually sank in. The next instant, the sorceress *snapped*.

—What on Etheria is that supposed to mean!? What did you do!?

—Take a guess— she replied, still smirking, delighted with the reaction she got.

—I'm serious. What did you do to them?— the sorceress insisted, speaking through her teeth with the most enraged tone she had ever heard.

Judging it wiser to comply, she casually let out —Well… you know how I always had them under vigilance?—. Castaspella nodded and she continued —They would almost always go up to that roof; they spent more time there than on the training grounds…

—Because they are girls!

—They were cadets!

—You know what? Just tell me what you did to them already! I *know* it's bad, so it surely can't surprise me— the sorceress retorted, rolling her eyes with obvious annoyance.

—Fine— she groaned. —One time, I spied them when they were up there. It must have been Adora's birth-day; the day they had agreed, at least… What I saw was Catra being bold enough to *kiss her*— she began, making Castaspella open her eyes, alarmed in anticipation. —Naturally, the only way to fix such a catastrophic mistake was to erase Adora's memories.

—You did *what*!?

Shadow Weaver managed to surprise her.

However, with how much confidence the sorceress had shown, it became the perfect opportunity to “test” her once again by being *more* specific.

—And I made sure Catra *saw*. That way, she would know the consequences and *never* attempt it again…

—Are you *insane*!?— Castaspella yelled. Grabbing her by the “clothes” her summoned form emulated, she pushed her against the closest wall. —What exactly is your problem!? What were you *thinking*!?

—Nothing.

—How can you be so *indifferent* about this!?

—Why are you *so angry* about something that does *not* concern you?

—Because you sound like an absolute bitch!

It was clear she had angered her beyond imagination, but Shadow Weaver only pressed on, laughing —*Sound* only? You're more naïve than I thought.

—No, no, shut up! This is no laughing matter!— the Head Sorceress interrupted her. She let go of her and took a few steps back. She began pacing back and forth as she rambled —You messed up with Adora's *head*! You were enough of a *jerk* to force Catra to *watch that*! You quite literally did that because of your *stupid* belief that "Catra distracts Adora" as if they weren't evenly matched! We've seen them sparring, fighting… Catra can even keep up with *She-Ra*! You can't tell me you *never saw that*!

—You know nothing…

—No, no! I am *not* taking more of your bullshit! You told me more than enough already, trying to "make me hate you", and guess what!? Now I know for a *fact* that you noticed she was good! And *that is exactly* what bothered you so much!

—Fine! It was!

—Then, *why*!? Why did you have to be *so cruel*!?

—Why would that girl *deserve her*!?— she retorted, finally exploding.

Even when Castaspella was enraged, and cursing more than ever before, she could still find the exact words to break Shadow Weaver's confidence and force her to see what she had stubbornly denied for so long.

That could be so… *infuriating*.

Now she had no other option but to let the sorceress lead the questioning that would, inevitably, push her to admit that which she had never wanted to see.

—*Deserve*… What are you talking about? Why wouldn't she deserve the love of…

—Why *would* she deserve it?

—Okay, no, wait. Shut up— she immediately ordered, gesturing for her to stop. With her hands pressed against her temples, she looked away for a moment, pensive. —Do you- And if I asked the same about you? Do you *think* you deserve…

—Don't be ridiculous. Haven't you heard all I've been telling you!?— she let out, indignant, not wanting Castaspella to finish that sentence. —I don't *need* love. *I don't want it*…

—*I* am ridiculous? Are you *hearing* yourself, woman!?

—Enlighten me, please— she replied with utter sarcasm, rolling her eyes.

—You're *pitiful*— she began, absolutely serious. —I'm not even trying to insult you. It's just *a fact*. I can only feel *pity* for you. Did you become bitter because you were rejected? Because your stupid spell failed? Because the council didn't support you or whatever excuse you've been telling yourself all these decades? Whatever it is, neither of them deserved what you did! If you had *decided* to "become a monster" and reject all love, the *least* you could have done was let Catra have *that one thing*!

Shadow Weaver was stunned for a moment. While she was expecting quite a severe scolding, she never imagined Castaspella would make such keen remarks.

—*Pity*…

—Yes. You let *everything* make you miserable, and instead of fixing your pathetic life, you preferred to submit her to your same fate!?— she insisted, incredulous. —I can *hardly* believe they cried for you.

—Don't you think I question the same!?— Shadow Weaver shouted. —They should have been overjoyed! The monster is *gone*, they can be together! But they kept my mask!? They *came* to see this poor excuse of an existence I am now!? Why would they!?

—Because they have a *heart*! Unlike *you*!

The Head Sorceress' exclamation resonated through the corridor despite the huge openings, her voice being loud enough to bounce between the walls for half a second.

After a long moment of tense silence, Shadow Weaver let out half a smile, less smug than usual, perhaps tender even, as something inside her went numb while she reflected on Castaspella's words.

—And finally you speak some sense…

—As long as you listened…— the sorceress replied, much calmer. —Because if this entered one ear and left through the other…

—Oh, please, stop with the patronizing tone. I got the message— she interrupted, looking away in an effort to be dismissive. But she couldn't stop ruminating on everything said. —I can't change that now. And… I *certainly* can't deny you're right.

—Do you regret it?

—I… think— she replied, hesitant. —I don't really know. What am I even *supposed* to do about it now?

—Why don't you start by thinking about *why* you did it so you can realize *what* was wrong with your reasoning?

—Bold of you to think I can achieve such… *illumination*— Shadow Weaver replied, mockingly.

Castaspella rolled her eyes, using the same tone as she said —I can always push you in the right direction again.

She looked back at the sorceress, pretending to be indignant as she teasingly exclaimed —You call that a *push*!? You kicked me off a cliff, woman!

Neither of them could hold back a laugh, perhaps picturing the scene, which even Shadow Weaver couldn't help but find hilarious.

—Because you're tougher than a rock!— the Head Sorceress teased her back, still laughing slightly.

For a while, Castaspella leaned back against the wall next to her, taking deep breaths to calm herself down every time she spontaneously got the giggles, probably due to thinking again about the funny scene she had outlined.

Perhaps she *was* insane…

But… what exactly does "being insane" mean?

If it means "not thinking clearly", or "doing things that don't seem logical", or maybe "going against common sense", then perhaps she could consider herself to be "insane", at least for the last couple of decades.

However, Shadow Weaver would have *never* deemed her actions to be illogical or against common sense if it weren't because of the sorceress' remarks. She was absolutely sure she was thinking clearly… If anything, clearer than ever.

But Castaspella *wasn't wrong*. There was nothing she could argue against, nothing she could prove her wrong on…

So Beatrix now doubted…

Had she *ever* been able to "think clearly" after the shock of the corruption, the betrayal, and the need for vengeance that overtook her?

Could she think clearly in such a state?

In an effort to “prove” that she isn’t a monster and can change, Castaspella would surely say something like “it doesn’t justify what you did, but it would explain why you behaved like that”. She could almost hear it in her head…

Well, she *had* said Shadow Weaver *decided* to become a monster. Which meant the woman was still firm on her belief that she can still choose otherwise.

She just never gave up…

Still hasn’t.

Chapter End Notes

I'M ON TIME AGAIN!! I'm so happy TT^TT

Erm, first of all, I'm so sorry if you found so much swearing from Casta to be shocking, but that's *exactly* the point. Remember when Micah argued against giving the kids a week of rest? Remember how, when her speech went slightly less formal, to the point she did swear once, he was immediately hit by how angry she had to be if that had happened? Well, this is the same but, SW is *purposely* provoking her, pushing her, so Casta pretty much went feral for a moment. Her swearing not only makes a point of showing just how enraged she is that she can't even keep her composure, but also gives an idea of how much of an effort she's making so that she won't shove SW against the wall again.
I swear, if it wasn't for the show's rating, *every character who interacts with SW even for a moment* (except Scorpia, probably), would have let out one or two insults. The woman gets on everyone's nerves quite easily... ~~And it would have been so funny~~

Ahem, okay, that must be all. (I'll only add that my castaweaver playlist has reached 191 songs and passed the 13hrs of length! Thanks to this one guest -who signs comments with what my writing made you feel- for the song recommendations cause they were so PERFECT! I almost cried with *Never Loved An Anchor* TT^TT)
See you next week!! I hope you enjoyed this!!

Just for a casual conversation

Chapter Summary

A week after resuming her daily activities, the Head Sorceress falls back into the usual flow of her everyday life. However, some things have changed in the last year, enough to have quite the impact in Castaspella…

»—Oh! Glimmer! Anything I can help you with?
»—Yes! I wanted to know if you would like to come and have a snack with me and my friends.
»Her tone and cheerful expression moved Castaspella almost to tears, she immediately halted and had to make a conscious effort to hold back a cry of joy.
»—Oh, my…— she began, but interrupted herself with a giggle. Smiling brightly, she replied — Absolutely! I'd be glad!
(…)
»Catra's words, about wanting to have a casual conversation instead of just going to her when they need something, still resonated in her head and it made her realize now that she missed her casual conversations with Shadow Weaver. (…)
»As the months went by, Castaspella had gotten so used to her constant company that she hadn't noticed how much they would talk about trivialities, and how much she enjoyed that.
»She had taken her company for granted, and now that she doesn't have it anymore, she can't help but feel melancholic.

Chapter Notes

Apologies if there's stuff I din't correct but the truth is I'm posting this a bit rushedly... I'll try not to do that again...

Still, I hope you enjoy <3

Edit: I forgot to hit "post" 12hrs ago, meaning this was TECHNICALLY finished on Wednesday here, but I didn't click the button I had to ._.

nevermind, go read, now yes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Thick clouds covered all of Mystacor, heavily reducing visibility, and making everything seem wrapped in a golden fog due to the afternoon sun. But even if he couldn't see anything, Sahm preferred to stare at those sun-tinted clouds taking over all his vision rather than look back at the guards standing behind him.

After being interrogated by the council, he was ordered to wait outside while they discussed his situation, and Queen Glimmer had the guards stay out at both sides of the door of the council room. The only thing that annoyed him more than the muffled voices speaking with such entitled tones, was the way the guards kept their sight on him as if he were a *monster*.

Behind the closed doors, arguments came and went at such a quick pace that Glimmer could barely follow, much less chime in.

—We don't have much to discuss. The boy used a *truth spell* on a member of the council. It calls for banishment.

—But he's just a child…

—He's a very impulsive and reckless boy; we cannot risk allowing him to continue here if he will use sorcery so indiscriminately!

—This is just *one* isolated incident!— a councilor tried to argue after being cut short before they could finish their argument. They brushed their messy red hair back, failing to dissimulate their frustration, as they continued —Impulsive or not, he isn't even a teenager yet! What he did is to be expected from someone his age!

—This is a bad omen! Don't you understand, Arden? If he already has such disregard for authority, how can we know he won't take it even further!?

—*Take it further*!?— Castaspella immediately interrupted, breaking the silence she had kept since sending Sahm out of the room. —Are you *seriously* implying what I think?

—We can't let this happen again— the councilman replied, with a calmer tone and as respectfully as he could.

—If you do this to Sahm… you *yourself* will make your fears a reality by leaving him no other choice but to be the same!— she began. Her words finally made Micah understand what the councilman was implying, and his expression was a mix of shock, horror, and disbelief, which Glimmer quickly noticed. No one said anything, letting the Head Sorceress continue —That's exactly why he did this! It was *my* mistake too. We refused to give him answers and he saw no other way of getting *this one thing* he had the right to ask for!—. A shadow of shame crossed many of the councilors' faces and she insisted —We should give him a *chance*, help him, show him there are other ways and that he *can* trust us! Did you learn nothing from what happened with Light Spinner? You're afraid of Sahm being "too similar" to Shadow Weaver, but you fail to see that it was also *your* responsibility how things turned out, and you're now making the same mistakes!

—I agree— Nolrem let out. He had also stayed silent from the beginning, and his agreement shocked everyone. —He shouldn't be punished. This whole discussion is unnecessary.

—But he attacked *you*.

—He didn't attack me.

—Well, he put a spell on you. It is still a severe transgression.

—I allowed him! I wanted him to know!— he finally admitted. He let out a sigh and explained —When he came to get answers from me, I didn't resist at all because I wanted to tell them all from the

beginning. I admitted as much to him, and then *I* told him to use the truth spell on me so he would know I wasn't just telling him what he wanted to hear. Sahm is *not* the one at fault.

A tense silence set and remained while several meaningful looks were exchanged. Nolrem kept the most solemn demeanor he could manage and the rest of the councilors all looked back at the one who was so adamant about punishing Sahm. But he only looked towards the Head Sorceress; even if he's the one left in charge when she's unavailable, he would never pretend to hold as much power as her, but rather preferred to act as the voice of his fellow colleagues, as the foreman-councilor he is.

Now, he was especially ashamed of having let fear get the best of him. By implying Sahm would turn out like Shadow Weaver, he offended Castaspella once again, making him feel exactly like the time she confronted him and Micah for sending Double Trouble to pose as her.

The Head Sorceress took a deep breath and finally broke the silence; she began —As I said before: we now have the chance to make better decisions. Sahm needs help, support, and guidance… Punishing him for this won't make him respectful of authority, especially of the council—. She looked away briefly but went on with the same determination —Currently, Sahm trusts me and Nolrem for being truthful, because we *showed* him we can be trusted. But everyone else here, in his eyes, is nothing but…

—A bunch of fools and liars— Arden interrupted. —I don't mean to say he *is* like she was, but rather that he's a kid who has the mentality Shadow Weaver adopted— they explained, frowning. —What he did isn't a "bad omen", it's a warning. The Head Sorceress is right! If we aren't careful, we will repeat history!

—So we do nothing about this?— Micah asked.

—Did *we* do anything to you for having helped Light Spinner with the Spell of Obtainment?— Nolrem questioned him back.

—N-no…

—The kid is about the age you were. In my opinion, if we had punished you for helping her, you would only be bitter at us, most probably, you would have blamed us for what happened because we turned her down…

—No! That thing- I didn't want to do it! She…

—This isn't the moment to discuss this again, King Micah— Nolrem interrupted. —I only meant to explain why I agree we should *not* punish the boy.

The room was silent once again until Castaspella decided to conclude —We shall give Sahm a warning, he goes unpunished now but if he does this again, he will receive what our regulations dictate. I will personally handle everything else regarding him. Meeting dismissed.

Shortly after, the sorceress walked down the halls, admiring how the clouds were covering all of Mystacor, and now gave everything a reddish-orange tone as the afternoon went on. She was lost in thought when Glimmer caught up to her and brought her back to reality.

—Oh! Glimmer! Anything I can help you with?— she asked her with a gentle smile.

—Yes! I wanted to know if you would like to come and have a snack with me and my friends.

Her tone and cheerful expression moved Castaspella almost to tears, she immediately halted and had to make a conscious effort to hold back a cry of joy.

—Oh, my…— she began, but interrupted herself with a giggle. Smiling brightly, she replied —Absolutely! I'd be glad!

—Oh good! Let's go then!— Glimmer let out before holding her arm briefly to teleport them both to Brightmoon's garden. As they walked towards the table, she added —I made some tea and buns; I used mom's recipe so I hope you like them!

The sorceress giggled before replying —I'm sure I will.

When they arrived, Bow stood up to open Glimmer's chair, while Catra and Adora set down their tea mugs to greet Castaspella as she took the only empty chair, already open for her to sit.

—I'm glad you could join us, Head Sorceress— Adora told her, visibly happy.

Surprised, she smiled brightly again as she admitted —Oh, really? Well, I'd never reject such an invitation—. However, she couldn't help asking —Did you need to discuss something with me?

Adora shook her head but didn't reply. Instead, she gave Catra an insistent look, which made her sigh and hesitate a bit before speaking up.

—We… never really talk if it isn't for something… like asking for help or the like— she began, slightly uncomfortable but making her best effort to be honest. —And you were… very nice to me, so I-I guess I wanted to just talk with you? More informally, I mean. Not because of Shadow Weaver, or because of any nerd thing— she continued, smirking slightly at the end. —I said you don't know me but… not like I've tried to get to know you either, and Sparkles here is really fond of you, so maybe I should have…

The sorceress' giggle interrupted Catra as it made her feel ashamed; she immediately looked away shyly and stopped her blabbering.

—I'm glad to hear it, thank you— Castaspella let out. Right after, she looked down, smiling sadly as she admitted —I am not usually approached but rather the opposite. You telling me you *want* to get to know me is- I-I appreciate it.

The beaming smile she gave her at the end only made Catra feel more ashamed and she quickly tried to dismiss it all, saying —It's not a big deal… It's just normal. You're a nice person, so why not? Anyone would do the same.

Pain briefly obscured the sorceress' expression before she could disguise it and Glimmer instantly flinched as she exchanged a concerned look with Bow.

—Um… well…— Bow began, hesitant, guessing that Castaspella wouldn't say it herself. He looked back at the woman, she gave him a nod, and he explained —More like… no one has done so… before Shadow Weaver.

Catra stared at him in utter shock, then looked back at Adora, as if needing the confirmation, and was met with a hesitant expression that only bewildered her even more.

—What!? How!? This woman is understanding, kind, honest, perhaps too much, and *clearly* overflows with patience to have put up with Shadow Weaver for so long. You can't tell me that *no one* noticed that before the *one person* who absolutely *loathes* such personality!— she exclaimed,

indignant. She looked at the sorceress with a puzzled expression and insisted —Why- Just… how can it be? You are just as smart as Shadow Weaver but at least don't have her nasty personality and you *actually* care for people!

Castaspella let out half a smile, fondly recalling how the woman had pointed out similar things. However, she only took a deep breath, collected herself, and returned her sight to them.

As she picked up one of the buns sitting in the middle of the table, she said —Well, never mind that. It isn't relevant… Why don't you tell me about your mission last week, girls?

The girls exchanged a glance, quickly catching up, and preferred to play along instead of pressing the matter.

—We spotted another planet that had been targeted by Prime and was left all desolate, so we went to take a look and make sure there weren't perhaps survivors somewhere around, like when we found Melog— Adora began. —And it was actually quite a successful mission!

—Right. We succeeded in *not* getting accidentally killed by debris— Catra commented, rolling her eyes.

—That too— she let out, giggling slightly. —But at least we found traces of potential recovery!— she continued with excitement. —The planets all look deserted, dead, and I remember how the Star Siblings told us that nothing could survive Prime's invasion. But *we* did, and now we found that perhaps those "dead" planets aren't fully lost. They can recover! Perhaps if we manage to restore them, life can start again and-and those who fled, like the Star Siblings, could finally return home!

—You really believe we can do it, no?— Catra asked, smiling faintly.

She found it *very* difficult to be as hopeful as Adora, but she wanted to. So, even when she couldn't trust they would succeed, she could always trust Adora would stubbornly try and do everything imaginable to make it happen.

—Of course we can! You saw how life returned here. We can do the same! But, perhaps… it won't be so quickly— she replied. —Here we had help from The Heart. So, maybe it's not as effective, but my healing powers can still help those planets.

—You tried to "help" the core there and it almost trapped us underground!— Catra reminded her, with a light-hearted reproaching tone.

—I wasn't expecting everything to quake like that just because I gave it a bit of a boost— Adora argued, letting out an embarrassed grin. —But we are fine! And now we know we just have to… um… take precautions.

Catra gave her such a dumbfounded look that Glimmer, Bow, and Castaspella had to put down their mugs and cover their mouths to hold back a laugh.

—"We are *fine*"? Barely! And we don't even know what I did!— she reminded her.

—Come on… You were great!— Adora insisted. She chuckled and addressed the Head Sorceress —Oh right! We didn't tell you. Catra shape-shifted! Like Melog does!

—Oh, really!? What happened?

—I'm not sure. It just happened… and Melog changed with me— she began. —I just- I panicked! And I wished I had wings to take us out of there and… before I noticed I was flying back to the surface with Adora and Melog following me, looking like some… gigantic… flying beast thing. I don't know— Catra tried to explain. —I didn't realize I looked the same until we landed. And then I panicked *again*! And went back to normal.

Castaspella stared at her, stunned, halfway through chewing a bite of her bun. She blinked a few times, swallowed, and stayed silent for a moment with a very confused expression.

—Um… Glimmer, this is delicious, really— she began, looking at her niece. Immediately after, she turned to Catra and asked —You are telling me you had *never* done something like that before!?

—Absolutely. Never anything magical like that— she insisted. —The most… magic-ish thing I've done is… understanding Melog when no one else does.

—Well, now you've clearly done more than that— the sorceress replied with a serious expression. —Actually, didn't you *ever* consider having some… magical affinity? Even after finding Melog… I mean, don't you wonder why you two can communicate like that?

—I- We *did* question that but… we suppose Melog just… likes me— Catra admitted, smiling faintly.

—I'm sure that's true— the sorceress giggled. —But perhaps that isn't *the* reason why you two can communicate; maybe there's something dormant inside you— she suggested. —I think I've read something on shape-shifting magic. It's just not that usual and, in sorcery, it is always preferred to create illusions around oneself rather than risking faulty shape-shifting.

The four of them stared at her as she casually ate her bun, oblivious of their reaction. They exchanged glances, silently telling each other to ask about it, until Bow gave up and did it.

—Erm… Could you… consider teaching Catra about that… kind of magic?

Castaspella opened her eyes, surprised, and spoke with incredulity —Me!? I- That's not… something I'm good at. I just… know the theory.

Despite the sorceress' utter disbelief, Catra insisted —But you could at least teach me *that*, right? I can figure out the practice if at least I *know* what I'm doing.

—I- Well, I suppose I can, yes— she hesitantly said. Right after, more resolved, she nodded and accepted —Why not? I'll gladly help you with that.

For a few more hours, they all continued talking amicably, sharing anecdotes until sunset. As nightfall arrived, the sorceress headed towards her room, walking down the halls of Mystacor's higher levels, uncomfortably aware of how alone she was. Catra's words, about wanting to have a casual conversation instead of just going to her when they need something, still resonated in her head and it made her realize now that she missed her casual conversations with Shadow Weaver.

Since finding out they can still see her at places like the magical groove, those past days she had only visited her when she needed advice or help of any kind, just as it used to be when they first summoned her. As the months went by, Castaspella had gotten so used to her constant company that she hadn't noticed how much she enjoyed it when they would talk about trivialities.

She had taken her company for granted, and now that she doesn't have it anymore, she can't help but feel melancholic.

Using potions to sleep could be effective but it made her feel *dull*, so to speak; their amusing bickering would usually make her fall asleep with a smile, or begin her day with one. But now there was just a bitter melancholy, the same that wouldn't let the sorceress tie her hair up in a bun.

It didn't feel right.

But what exactly kept her from going to see her *right that moment*? It was her decision, she had nothing to do other than have dinner on her own and go to sleep… So, why not?

The Whispering Woods were cloaked within the darkness of the night by the time Castaspella arrived at the magical groove, following the glowing specks of magic floating around.

—Well, look who's back— Shadow Weaver began, speaking as soon as she reached the surface. The sorceress immediately turned towards her as she added —And at such time? I see you now forget about me all day and only come when you need something…

—Oh, please!— she complained, approaching. However, a moment later she hesitated —Well, I mean… I suppose I've been… doing that. I… realized that now because your girls wanted to have a casual conversation with me instead of- Well, you understand what I mean.

Castaspella looked away and crossed her arms, considering that was, perhaps, a bad idea, yet she didn't move away when Shadow Weaver stepped closer instead.

—No, I don't. What do you mean?— the woman asked, making it obvious with her tone that she just wanted her to say it.

—I just wanted to see you— she let out, groaning. —You know, just… talk about trivialities like we did the past few months…

—You mean our arguments about how foolish your beliefs are? Or how incompetent the council is? Or perhaps when we would discuss my behaviour? How did you call me? "Bitch"?— Shadow Weaver enumerated, mocking as usual. —Yes, you seemed to enjoy that.

The Head Sorceress laughed sarcastically and mocked her back, beginning one of their usual friendly arguments.

After a few hours, late enough that they presumed it was around midnight, they were both sitting in silence, doing nothing other than observing the sky above them through the tree leaves.

Out of nowhere, and after a long time of hesitation, Castaspella asked —Would you… mind if I stayed here all night?

The woman smirked and replied, with a careless tone, —Not like I have any rush to return to the torture of my personal prison. Of course, I am not the one who needs food, or rest, nor can I suffer the cold, or be hurt by anything out here in the open. So go ahead, do as you please.

The sorceress scoffed sardonically before smugly replying —You can just express your concern openly, you know? I won't consider you to be "weak" for that, don't worry.

She barely held back a giggle when Shadow Weaver scowled and, taking that as permission, she decided to teleport some food she had left prepared for herself earlier, along with a blanket as, in fact, she was already shivering a bit.

She considered teasing the woman about having noticed that, hence mentioning the cold, but she could guess exactly what the reply would be, and instead added she could just cast a bonfire if the blanket wasn't enough.

Castaspella knew Shadow Weaver would *never* admit being concerned, but it didn't mean she wasn't genuinely worried, so she preferred to subtly ease her apprehension.

A bit later, having eaten and feeling sleepy as she stared at the small bonfire while leaning on the woman, the Head Sorceress yawned, too tired to help it. The both of them had been silent until then, but noticing how she was about to fall asleep, Shadow Weaver felt the need to verify that the sorceress *really* wanted to stay there as she could hardly believe it.

—Don't you… have to feed your pets or something?

Despite the sleepiness, Castaspella noticed her shy tone and realized the woman was trying to make it sound mean, which implied she intended to disguise real unease. However, she knew commenting on it would only make her loath sounding genuine, so she limited herself to solely letting out a faint smile.

—It's fine… I can feed them in the morning.

As the sorceress drifted into sleep, Shadow Weaver was left reflecting.

Had she missed these foolish moments when they would either bicker or exchange tauntings and mockings?

So it seemed, yes. But why?

It had to be because she enjoyed making fun of her, no? Or because she was, at least, intelligent enough to hold a conversation without getting offended with her small backhanded comments? Castaspella represented a challenge for her, an enigma she kept failing to solve as, every time she thought she had figured her out, the sorceress proved otherwise.

Yes, she missed this. But she didn't know why, nor did she want to know.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, this is the moment when I explain the tiny easter eggs I'm bringing from other fics of mine.
Today: "Arden", my dear oc introduced in *Times Past And Future*, one true cinnamon roll. So, here, I'm keeping their age around the same as Casta's, meaning they are -obviously- *not* one of Norwyn's pupils, hence, that reference to 80s Arden is gone. Here, they are just another councilor, and just as fond of Casta as in TPAF, plus a soft spot for kids I guess XD

ANYWAYS, yes, I need to keep building the council piece by piece, and I don't even have a name for the foreman-councilman (aka, the guy in charge who also was part of the DT fiasco), which is now becoming a problem.

I think that's all now so, (#^-^#) until next week it is!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: there is no shame in acknowledging a friendship
Status: fixing the label to bypass defenses and infiltrate the system

Chapter Notes

I am so very sorry for the delay, I mean it. I had a few issues for which I couldn't finish on time, and I would have posted it hours ago if it weren't because we had a D&D campaign that lasted around 6 hours and a half... (fun fact, I based my character on Light Spinner and *by mere coincidence* A lot of things went pretty much like in the show!)

Ahem, so… I'm struggling a bit here, trying to explain/summarize the lesson of this chapter, but I guess you'll understand (also, take into account this is what happened right before Casta went to see her at the end of the previous chapter, aka, this lesson was already in effect there!)

Oh, right. There's also a reference to a flashback that will come who-knows-when, based on a very funny Tumblr post, which I will link when it's finally posted

Now, ENJOY!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After that morning at the beginning of the week, when Castaspella visited her because she had to teach her pupils, the woman hadn't shown up again. Like before, she had to spend a full week lingering near the core of the planet, focusing on her cursed emotions to keep the pain at bay; it was still difficult, but she had managed to keep herself from reflecting at all.

As Castaspella could have returned any time she wanted yet she hadn't, not even to ask for help, it was easy for Shadow Weaver to convince herself that the sorceress wouldn't return because she no longer needed her. So it was better to forget. She *had* to forget about her.

With that in mind, cutting short any reflections her head would fall into became easy. Or so it was, until faint voices disrupted the absolute silence around her. Once more, she could hear clearly enough the conversations on the surface thanks to Castaspella, Adora, and Catra being together in the same place; it allowed her to reach the surface with her senses, and it was as if she were standing right next to them.

Apparently, the sorceress had been invited by them to eat something and talk, just a casual chat instead of the formal meetings or requests for assistance of the previous year.

About time they all realized how they were just *using* Castaspella.

Learning how it was Catra who invited the sorceress because she wanted to get to know her was quite amusing; of course she had softened up to the sorceress.

But the moment she learnt about her lack of friends…

She wanted to laugh at first, especially at Catra's naivety, but when she realized they both value the same characteristics in the sorceress, her mood got spoiled. The girl was right: *she*, of all people, has been the first one to actually *see* Castaspella's worth. While unexpected, it actually made a lot of sense that she noticed too and felt indignant.

Those fools are so ungrateful.

Ah… But the woman masterfully avoided the subject. How very quaint.

And then, she heard them say Catra had shape-shifted.

Impossible.

If there were at least a drop of magic in that girl, Shadow Weaver would have noticed it, wouldn't she?

But then again… Hadn't Castaspella reproached her plenty of times that she refused to see Catra's prowess solely because she herself wasn't acknowledged during her time as a tutor in Mystacor?

Ugh… She did *not* want to think about this at all…

Fortunately, once the sorceress agreed to teach her, they changed subjects and spoke about more mundane things, like how Glimmer had knitted a scarf for Bow, whether the upcoming New Year celebration should be hosted by Bright Moon once again or by another kingdom, which inevitably led to some teasing, reminding Castaspella not to forget the Hordaks this time.

But then, Adora asked her about the time she passed out, the morning before going to that magical groove.

That wasn't anything Shadow Weaver wanted to think about. On the one hand, because she had gotten immediately angry as soon as she heard that yet refused to question why; on the other hand, because she wasn't supposed to care. *Why* should she worry about it?

However, trying to distract herself from that issue, Beatrix let another one take over, so it was impossible for her to ignore the memory, especially because that little reunion was already making her think about it.

She happened to come across the Queen one morning, little after her father began avoiding Castaspella, and Shadow Weaver immediately took the opportunity to shame Glimmer, taking advantage of how little she knew about her aunt.

It had been so easy to ensnare her…

—You have *no idea* what it looks like when Cas is pissed.

—Oh, because you know her *so* well, no!?— Glimmer replied, rolling her eyes with an indignant mocking tone.

—Better than you, it seems.

The Queen had to make a conscious effort not to step back when Shadow Weaver loomed over her, smirking, and speaking in an aloof tone that seemed to carry an unspoken threat.

—You- How dare- Ugh!— she stammered, fighting her nervousness. She grunted in frustration and gathered the courage to finally say —I can't understand how Auntie bears having you around!

—Oh, your majesty. I assure you: out of us all, she is the only one who won with this deal— Shadow weaver began, straightening her back and speaking with a confident tone. —But if you think I'm being a nuisance to her, then allow me to tell you: Your *Auntie* is currently feeling so bad that I'm actually helping her. Not like you would know that, seeing how you're hardly around; as I said, I *do* know her better than you by now.

—Ho-how *dare* you!— Glimmer began, shocked at first. —That is *so* unfair! You weren't around before, you- I have been around far more usually than I used to! I am *really* trying to reconnect— she complained, her hands closed tightly in fists. —I-I don't know if she wants to, but I do— the Queen sentenced with absolute confidence. However, right after, she looked down, slightly ashamed, and admitted —I spent so many years just… avoiding her or escaping from her-her habits, her traits…

—You mean her endless verbosity? Her excessive cheerfulness? Her infinite energy and enthusiasm? Her never-ending optimism? Her obliviousness to how often she oversteps boundaries?

—Yes! Stop— Glimmer interrupted her, uneasy and unable to hear more. —I know what I- Ugh, she's always been quite a handful, but perhaps I was a bit harsh.

Something in her expression made Shadow Weaver recognize the same sorrow Castaspella would show when admitting mistakes that can hardly be fixed, and she couldn't help but think about how easy it would be to manipulate them both in such a state.

But…

What would be the purpose? Even if it were merely for amusement, the sorceress would only be more stressed than usual, in addition to her already-miserable situation.

So what if, instead of manipulating them into fighting, she manipulated the situation but for the exact opposite? After all, the Queen wanted to fix their relationship, just as Castaspella wished to do, yet the sorceress thought it to be impossible because Glimmer had never shown any real interest in being family, even when she had no one else.

Perhaps they needed a "gentle" push.

—I am not exactly someone who would judge you for this, your Majesty— Shadow Weaver began, speaking casually and gesturing with her hands. —I mocked you, yes, but I would have done exactly the same as you did and avoid her at all costs. However, as I haven't, I believe I can now provide some insight on how she's feeling, if you're really interested.

The Queen remained speechless for a moment, seemingly unable to understand why Shadow Weaver, of all people, would be the one to offer her help with something so mundane.

—I- Well, yes— she stammered. —You're around her almost all day, I guess you must know something.

The woman couldn’t help but let out a smirk, more amused than mocking this time.

—You certainly don't have her indiscriminate trust— she noticed, confusing the Queen a moment yet brushing it aside immediately. —Alright then, listen to me; she wants to reconnect with you too, but has no idea how to do so while also handling your father. Which means, some help from your side, some initiative, would in fact be what's necessary here.

Shadow Weaver was quite sure Glimmer would ignore her advice; after all, without Castaspella’s support, she was rarely heeded.

By the next day, her conversation with the Queen had entirely slipped her mind. After lunch, she had gone to the library with the sorceress, as they had a deal to fulfill.

—Just- No, no. Wait. Take it easy and don't grip the needles so tightly— Castaspella instructed, struggling to hold back her laughter.

—This is the most stupid, pointless activity I've been forced to do…

—A deal is a deal…

—Don't you dare come at me with that— Shadow Weaver interrupted, her angry sight focused on the needles and the thread. —You don't care about the deal, you're just having fun at my expense.

—No, I'm not!— the sorceress complained immediately. However, she interrupted herself as she saw the woman struggling with a stitch. —Wait, wait. Let me show you how to undo these stitches.

Castaspella carefully grabbed the thread and moved Shadow Weaver's hands to accommodate the needles.

—You are wasting all your patience on trying to teach me this instead of using the time for something worth it.

—I am on a *break*, meaning I can use the time as I please— the Head Sorceress began; she was, once again, guiding the movement of the needles. —And I decided to use it for this.

For a moment, Shadow Weaver attempted to knit a few more stitches, but her expression was so enraged one would think the thread was personally aggravating her.

—This is *impossible*! I'm useless for this!— she suddenly cried out. It seemed like she wanted to throw the needles and thread out of the window, but Castaspella held her hands in place. —I am *incapable* of doing this! I will *never* be able to properly knit and I don't even *need* to!

Castaspella's grip on her hands tightened a bit as she tried to call her attention. When Shadow Weaver looked back at her, she took a deep breath, silently telling her to calm down. While it was obvious the woman still seethed with rage, she was more controlled at least.

—Listen to me, Bea. I- I was expecting a reaction like this from you— she began, speaking with a calm tone but looking away shyly for a moment. —I- You just called yourself useless, incapable, worthless… The same things you taught your girls in the Fright Zone.

—What is your point?

—My point is: I had considered some time ago that you probably think the same about yourself, and… you just proved exactly that.

The way Castaspella looked at her made Shadow Weaver shiver; it was something so insignificant yet it carried such strength behind it that she wouldn't dare ignore the sorceress.

—Fine— she sighed. —Tell me again how this… stitch goes.

However, before she could explain again, Glimmer arrived at the place, looking for her aunt.

—A-Auntie!— she called out. When Castaspella looked back at her, she asked —Could you come for a moment?

The Head Sorceress seemed apologetic when she left the sofa, but Shadow Weaver simply put everything aside and stood up before her body lost its density.

She silently waited while they spoke at the entrance to the library, and noticed how extremely nervous Glimmer seemed. She realized they had only talked about official business, so when the sorceress was walking back, Shadow Weaver fixed her sight on the hesitant Queen and gestured towards Castaspella.

—A-Aunt Casta— she called out as soon as she understood. —Would you… mind teaching me too?

She took a step forward when the sorceress looked back, as if confirming she meant it.

Shadow Weaver easily realized how moved Castaspella was from the way her hands shook while she asked —You want to… learn knitting?

—There’s no problem if you don't want to teach me, don't worry, Aunt Casta.

—No, please! I'd be glad!— she immediately replied, approaching Glimmer to rushedly take her to the sofa. —I have plenty of needles and threads here, so I'll teach you both— she sentenced, immediately excited. —*But*, don't compare your progress to each other, alright?

—Your innocence can sometimes be so amusing…

She glared back at Shadow Weaver with a light-hearted scowl, watching the woman sit back in her place, and reproached —On the contrary, I know full well you *will* compare your progress to that of my niece.

—So?

—*You* can't relax, and the more frustrated you get, the worse it is; you shouldn't compare your progress with that of Glimmer who has learnt these things already!

She rolled her eyes before complaying and continued her attempt at knitting.

Looking back, it was almost amusing for Beatrix to realize how her malicious mockery had, unexpectedly, helped them to reconnect. Who would have imagined, or even *considered* in the slightest, that her wicked comments, solely meant to irritate the Queen, would instead kickstart a positive change and lead to them being now so close?

It was only fair, wasn't it? Castaspella had helped her so much… doing the same, even if accidentally, was the least Light Spinner could do.

She owed her far more than she would like to admit, but she had hardly been able to repay her. So, perhaps, this was unexpected, shocking even, but she *was* thankful for the outcome.

Ugh… *thankful*…

This was but a *triviality*! This had absolutely no repercussions, whatsoever, neither on her, the kingdom, nor Glimmer or Castaspella themselves. So *what* could make her be thankful!?

Yes, the sorceress now wouldn't break down while crying about how she's losing what little of her family she has left… but it was so *irrelevant*! She should *not* care at all!

But she does.

Just as worry had overtaken her for a fleeting moment when Adora and Catra were speaking about their mission, Beatrix then felt relief knowing the sorceress isn't alone against the world just because she's gone, but rather, Castaspella now has the best and most trustworthy allies in all Etheria.

Her reflections eventually made her realize just how monotonous and boring her existence was without the restless company of the Head Sorceress. From academic discussions to the most trivial and nonsensical discussions that led nowhere but made for an amusing pastime.

Had she missed those foolish moments when they would either bicker or exchange tauntings and mockings?

That would be ridiculous.

But perhaps it was only logical…

Beatrix wasn't sure, but before she could ponder on it, she felt the summoning spell allowing her to return to the surface once more.

She would soon get the answer to her question…

Chapter End Notes

Em, so…
The reference to a future flashback I mentioned in the first note would be the part about the new year and forgetting about the Hordaks (that last part is what the flashback is about), and I wanted to explain that "new year" would be like the anniversary of their victory over Prime. I suppose I'll explain it when the chapter arrives, but I wanted to say it now so it wouldn't be too misleading.

So, um… until next week, fingers crossed I'll be on time <("^_^)

To Risk It All

Chapter Summary

The Head Sorceress now wears her heart on her sleeve yet some people are unable to see it, and Castaspella is both too conscious of this yet too oblivious of what it means.
»(…) the sorceress forced herself to keep walking without looking back, suddenly regretting having stayed for the night, and feeling foolish for having forgotten the woman can still hear them when she's in the same place with Adora and Catra.
(…)
»(…) She just *needed* her brother to understand what she's going through, she wanted the truth to be known; even if he made it all public, she had come to feel choked by the secrecy to the point she would rather risk it all.

But can the sorceress risk it all? Can she accept what's she's feeling? The implications?
And if she does… can she handle everything it entails?

Chapter Notes

WELP! I'm late again…
All I can offer as compensation is the reminder that my castaweaver playlist keeps getting longer the more I find songs that fit my fics hehe. It's over 13hrs already! And has 198 songs!! XD

And em… It was "Friendship day" this Wednesday here in Argentina so I *could* have posted this on time, but I didn't want to be on my tablet all day while with my friends heh… (we watched 3 movies and had lunch out and all, so I did work on this a bit, but I couldn't fully pay attention).

And I think I had something more to say but lately my notes end up being bullshit because I keep rushing chapters and forget anything I wanted to say. Oh, but one thing I better not forget: I'm taking your suggestions, Riddl3, (including the hair thing from this chapter on) so this fic is now ALSO dedicated to you! XD

Hehe, alright, I hope you enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver was silently reflecting, going over several thoughts that would pour into her mind one after the other, and hadn't noticed the break of dawn, or that she was absentmindedly caressing the sorceress' loose hair.

She was thinking about those past days; she remembered that *unexpected* encounter with Norwyn, the bits of conversations she had managed to listen, the occasional feelings she could still get from the

sorceress, and the striking difference between her earlier memories and her latest ones, which was just as shocking as her conflicting thoughts when regarding situations now.

It was her doing, right?

Her beliefs, her established truths, everything that guided her actions… She now doubted them all because Castaspella made her question *everything*.

Why had she allowed that?

She had no idea *why*, but after that… curious encounter with Norwyn's shadow, she couldn't deny it had been for the best. At this point, she would even wish this all had happened earlier.

But realizing that only made her *furious*! Since *when* does she regret her life decisions like this!? How can she *possibly* accept she did wrong and wish for things to be different if she *can't change that now*!? It only makes her feel frustrated and just because she regrets it, no one will forget what she did!

So *why* is she now thinking like this!?

She was shaken out of her reflections by the movement on her lap; the sorceress stirred awake, having felt it when Shadow Weaver's hand on her hair closed into a fist and slightly pulled from her hair.

She whined weakly and groaned —Wha-what did I do?

The woman immediately cackled in all earnestness, unable to hold back; little by little she untangled her fingers from Castaspella's hair, consciously ignoring the fact that she was caressing it, and shook her head slightly.

—Nothing, nothing…— she began, still laughing, until an idea hit her. —Well, nothing besides falling asleep alone in the middle of the woods…

The sorceress pushed herself up with her left arm and rubbed her eyes while replying, with a groggy voice, —What do you mean? I'm not alone…

—I don't count, I'm dead.

—Well, but… still here.

—It's not the same.

—You *exist* here in the same space with me!

—But I am *not* alive!

—The point is!— Castaspella exclaimed, indignant, but interrupted herself to lower her tone. —I am not "alone" here; dead or not, you're still keeping me company.

—If you insist…

The sorceress glared back at her aloof expression, noticed her playfulness, and retorted —Yes, I insist. Stop being a baby…

—Right, of course…— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —*I* am the baby, yet you're the one who couldn't tie up her hair on her own now that I'm gone— she teased her, smirking smugly.

They both knew full well that's nowhere near the truth, yet it was precisely why Castaspella would have no option but to choose between accepting the insult or telling her the real reason why she's been keeping her hair loose.

However, the sorceress remained stunned for a moment, unable to decide whether to tell the truth or go with the lie.

—I- No, well, it's just…— she stuttered looking around nervously. She didn't notice that Shadow Weaver was already moving behind her and reaching for Castaspella's hair while she hesitantly went on, looking down as she fidgeted with her hands, —It's just… that I've been… busy and… it's quite irrelevant, it's just hair… I was… used to not doing it…

—I can only imagine how your *new look* was received— she interrupted, with a tone that pretended to be casual yet revealed how amusing she found that situation to be. —Of course I suppose you haven't told anyone what I said about your hair…— she added, pressing the sorceress a bit, right as she fixed the bun in place.

—What? No, no. I… haven't mentioned it… O-only Micah asked about my hair and I didn't… tell him.

When Shadow Weaver looked back at her and noticed her gloomy expression, she sat next to the sorceress instead of offering to help her up; it took the woman a moment to convince herself to speak so, at first, she was only staring at her hands with an angry grimace.

—I understand the… Micah situation isn't going that well.

—Not at all…

—Does that mean the- that time you fainted…

—What? How do you…— Castaspella interrupted. —Adora mentioned it. You must have heard…

—Precisely— she nodded. When the sorceress looked back, she stared at her for a moment before insisting —What happened?

She looked away, embarrassed, but still explained —I was… foolish. I forgot to eat on time and… I spent more than half the day without eating.

—Why would you…

—It was nothing. I was just… stupid, alright?— Castaspella dismissed her.

—But…

—I insist. I should just… return to Mystacor now. I should get a few things done before my- your- *the* class— the Head Sorceress explained, as she pushed herself up.

—Cas.

—What?

—It *is* your class, alright?

Looking away with a smile and a slight blush, she accepted —Fine… *my* class.

As Castaspella walked away, Shadow Weaver could only follow her with her sight until she was far away enough for the pull of the core to claim her back. On the other hand, the sorceress forced herself to keep walking without looking back, suddenly regretting having stayed for the night, and feeling foolish for having forgotten the woman can still hear them when she's in the same place with Adora and Catra.

Around lunch-time, king Micah walked down the halls of Mystacor, on his way to his next class, when he came across his sister.

—Oh, Casta!— he called out.

—Eh- Ah, Micah! Afternoon, Brother— she cheerfully greeted him. —Can I help you with something?

—No, no— he shook his head. —I'm just… glad to see you so…— he began, but hesitated and forced himself to finish the sentence. —So *well*! A-after the other week… I was worried bu-but you're clearly doing great.

Castaspella couldn't help but laugh at that.

—Oh, of course!— she laughed. —I'm feeling perfectly, don't worry.

—I can see you're getting back to yourself, so… I'm glad, Sis— he insisted.

Oh.

Oh.

So *that's* what he meant…

—Uh… R-right, of course— she replied, forcing herself to keep her smile. —Now I… believe we both have classes to impart, Brother. We should get going, no?

—Ah, sure! Yes, yes. Go— he agreed. — See you later, Sis!— he yelled as he disappeared down the hall.

The Head Sorceress walked down to the gardens with a more solemn expression now, not wanting to reveal the true sorrow within her. She knew she had to focus on the class she was about to give, but she couldn't help reflecting on what had happened in that first half of the day.

Perhaps it had been a bad idea to spend the night in the woods.

Perhaps she *looks* "well" as Micah had seen her because of the placebo effect that it had had on her.

Perhaps she was only making everything more difficult and painful by delaying the inevitable and giving herself hope that things could return to how they were those past few months.

And perhaps…

No. That was enough.

Such a line of thinking made no sense now and in this situation. Why spoil something that was making her feel so good? No, no. That was enough self-doubt. Reality check? No, that was sheer cruelty; she needed the comfort she had gotten that night, and letting these stupid thoughts ruin it would be the worst mistake of her life.

A couple of hours later, as her class came to a close, Sahm was approached by one of Castaspella's pupils.

—Our Master is in a… better mood, right?

—Uh? Yeah… It looks like it— he agreed.

—Heh… Then I suppose this is worth tolerating you, kid…

—Hey!— Sahm complained, playfully. He laughed and agreed —Yeah, it is.

As the rest of the pupils left, he and his classmates preferred to stay. They all seemed to have noticed the same, and lingered after the class had been dismissed.

Noticing them gathered around her once again, the Head Sorceress asked —Is everything alright, children?

—E-excuse us, Master— one of the teenagers began. —We noticed you're… um, happy today.

—What she means is…— the oldest pupil interrupted. —Tha-that you are in a better mood than the past few days… and we-we wanted to know if you had… news from our Master… maybe.

Castaspella noticed them all shyly looking away, and her heart immediately shrunk with sorrow.

—Oh, kids…— she muttered. —I suppose you would like to see her, wouldn't you?

Her expression softened as they all looked back at her with a spark of hope in their eyes. She didn't say anything else, just stood up and made sure everyone was close enough for her to teleport them all to the magical groove.

However, Shadow Weaver was already on the surface when they arrived, as Adora and Catra had gone to visit her.

—You all seem determined to surprise me today— the woman let out, mockingly.

—It is *just* a visit! What's the big deal?— Catra complained, crossing her arms in front of her chest as she looked away, shyly. —Maybe you just *want* us to "surprise you". So you could, I don't know, *say that*.

The woman immediately gave her an unamused look that said more than enough, but still asked — Who exactly would be so pathetic as to *request* being surprised? Do you believe me to be desperate enough to defeat the entire purpose of a "surprise"?

Catra muttered something under her breath that she could perfectly hear, yet before she could so much as build her anger, her pupils finally snapped out of their shock and called her attention.

—Master!

The kids ran towards Shadow Weaver, hardly paying the girls any mind, and began questioning what had happened, where she had gone, whether she would return, and many other questions.

—Head Sorceress— Adora greeted her, holding back an amused smile.

—I-I'm so sorry… Did I interrupt you?

—No… no. We were done already— Catra immediately replied.

Castaspella looked away to hide a soft grin for a moment before looking back at them to say —In any case, I apologize for bringing them here like that without a warning or… anything.

—I bet they missed her, huh?— Catra let out, her tone weak and her sight on the kids excitedly questioning Shadow Weaver. —She must have… treated them well…

—Relatively, yes…— the sorceress conceded. Right after, she shook her head a bit and looked down as she explained —But for the most part, she has only told them off. Every single one of them.

—What?

—Especially her favorite, Sahm— the sorceress continued, pointing at the boy who was at the front of the group, pestering her the most. —These children love her, yes, but she has been a strict tutor regardless. They know if they obey her every word they have nothing to fear yet, generally, they won't hesitate to face her, consequences and all… So, I still wouldn't dare leave them alone with her— she admitted, shaking her head in resignation. —She may not be able to touch them if I'm not around, but she doesn't even realize *how* she gets when things don't go her way…

—Same old Shadow Weaver…

As the three of them laughed closed-mouthfully, the excited pleas of the pupils filled the woods, growing louder each passing moment, until the woman couldn’t bear it anymore.

—That’s enough!— she cried out. —I have refused *repeatedly*!

—Wait, wait!— Castaspella interrupted when she noticed Shadow Weaver’s tensed stance, as if ready to take a swipe at them. The sorceress put herself between her and the kids, then asked —Can someone tell me what is happening?

—They want me to give them classes again. *Here*.

—What?

She opened her eyes wide, realizing she hadn’t even considered the idea at all. Part of her wanted to make it possible, so the children would be taught by Shadow Weaver once again, but a part of her felt hurt, lacking.

However, the woman wouldn’t even consider the possibility. Shadow Weaver immediately refused since the beginning.

—It will *not* happen. This place isn’t fit for magical training of such a large group— she explained with a severe tone. —Besides, if anything were to happen to you here, your parents could, and most

likely would, make *us* responsible for allowing you to train here instead of where you *should*— she added, gesturing at the sorceress and herself as she spoke.

The kids either looked down or away, but none of them dared insist further. Catra and Adora, seeing the situation, fully understood what Castaspella meant before, and preferred to silently retire. Shortly after, once the children complied and accepted they couldn't be trained there, the Head Sorceress took the pupils back to Mystacor, leaving Shadow Weaver to be pulled back into the depths of the planet.

While the little incident with the pupils was promptly settled, she still had to run up and down handling a series of different matters, all extremely taxing and time-consuming. Castaspella found herself so busy she spent another couple of days without visiting Shadow Weaver at all.

However, this time, the sorceress was feeling the distance with more intensity than before, and she had realized her gloomy mood and her hair being loose makes everyone around her easily catch up on how much she misses the woman, yet *one person* remains unable to guess as everyone else does.

After three insufferable nights, and having to use the sleeping potions, Castaspella sat in front of her terrariums once more, intending to fully write out the whole truth. She just *needed* her brother to understand what she's going through, she wanted the truth to be known; even if he made it all public, she had come to feel choked by the secrecy to the point she would rather risk it all.

Or so she thought.

After a while, just like the first time, she suddenly had no idea how to go on and decided to read everything she had written from the beginning, only to panic and fully burn the paper between her hands.

She couldn't risk it all as she believed… *not yet*.

In the darkest of the woods, glowing spores guided the sorceress back to the magical groove where Shadow Weaver appeared as soon as Castaspella stepped in. Her expression immediately stopped whatever mocking comment the woman planned to use as an introduction; instead, they silently held each other for a while before sitting down near a tree against which they could lean back to rest.

There was no need to speak in this situation: the sorceress needed support, and Shadow Weaver had absolutely no idea how to give it, so she merely allowed Castaspella to take it however she saw fit.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, okay. I feel like I perhaps needed more time to write this chapter and I hope I can write the next one of the main plot with more time (also, I hereby force myself to write 2 flashbacks in the next chapter because of how I wrote this chapter)

Ahem, okay. SO!
From now on I'll be making larger time-skips. In C-a-S, the action happened within almost 8 months, but here, besides the weeks that have already passed, the action takes place within a full

decade! So, yeah, this is already quite long but has much more to come, so I'll have to skip more and more time least I reach 100 chapters (TT-TT)

Erm… whatever, I'll stop rambling.

Until next week it is!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: admitting what you feel isn't weakness, turning everything into an insult isn't the solution
Status:
successfully bypassed all firewalls…
…
processing…
…
integrating…

Chapter Notes

YES! I'M ON TIME!!

Ahem... I mean...

Hello, hello
Please accept my humble offering as compensation for all these delays. Double flashback, some light angst, some wholesomeness, some reflection, long as a main-plot chapter. (>w<)

And
Whatever I had planned to write here, I forgot… apologies

Just, I hope you enjoy the chapter!! XD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Looking at the sorceress leaving like that reminded Shadow Weaver of the times she had gone down there to the Woods with the siblings, to help them *properly* handle the magical creatures that caused trouble to plumerians and other villagers around the area.

Castaspella was right to require her assistance with that, seeing how Micah didn't have the slightest idea on the matter and tried to solve everything with raw magic. While, usually, she would have used a similar plan, she knew better than to brute-force her way through those issues when they could be solved more smartly.

Come to think about it: the siblings embodied her two possible approaches to solving any problem Beatrix would face. Power, or brains. Micah, or Castaspella.

But back to the memories the sorceress caused her to recall, there had been one particular incident Shadow Weaver still remembered vividly.

It had happened before that fateful dance bound the spell to Castaspella…

A wild beast that woke up near a Plumerian settlement was running around the Whispering Woods, threatening to stomp all over the residents living there.

As it ran back and forth, Micah had been separated from them, and now Shadow Weaver followed Castaspella as she tried to stop the creature. It was clear the sorceress found it very annoying, but that wouldn't stop the woman; on the contrary, it made her all the more headstrong on continuing.

As she ran to try and anticipate where the beast would go, Castaspella fell down.

Angry at herself, she hit the ground with her fists and complained —I just *had* to do this with a dress…

The woman was standing right next to the Head Sorceress and looking down at her when the sound of the creature's galloping called her attention and she noticed it quickly closing in.

—Get up now. It won't have the courtesy to stop and wait for you.

—Yes, yes. I'm on it. But I could use some help, you know?— she complained as she tried to stand up.

—Well, there's not exactly much I can do to help you up.

—What's the point of bringing you along if you won't provide any assistance!?— Castaspella asked, indignant, as she fell to the ground once more.

—I have no power to do *anything* about this— she replied, right before lifting a hand without even looking at the creature that was almost over them.

An illusion rose from the ground like a wall and forced the beast to change directions. The sorceress stared in stupefaction as it ran away and then looked back at Shadow Weaver, even more indignant.

—Then what was that just now!?

—That mockery? I just bought you time— she replied, nonchalantly. She was looming right over her, yet Castaspella didn't move back at all, perhaps because she wasn't uncomfortable due to her being incorporeal. —Now, go. Be a good girl and put it to sleep.

—Don't you *dare* call me that ever again!— the Head Sorceress instantly retorted.

Shadow Weaver couldn't hold back the laughter her visceral reaction caused yet still conceded —Fine! But I mean it. Make haste, and try not to fall this time…

Grimacing, Castaspella muttered —Bitch…

Although the woman could hear her, she only grinned and let out —Fool…

Later that same day, they were back in Mystacor and walked together into the Lunarium.

—Do you really have to be so mean all the time?

—It's easy to annoy you… and I'm bored— Shadow Weaver replied, rolling her eyes. —At least that's a harmless way to entertain myself…

—*I* take it lightly, but no, it's *not* normally harmless!— the Head Sorceress reproached. She then thought for a moment before reflecting —Well, now I guess it's obvious why you couldn't see the damage you caused Catra…

—Don't be so innocent— she immediately replied, rolling her eyes again. —I know how cruel I was; wouldn't be so delusional as to believe *that* was harmless…

Castaspella was stunned for a moment before pointing out —Y-you simply admit that easily how much of a jerk you were!?

As they had just walked into the area of the spell, Shadow Weaver hooked an arm around the sorceress' waist to hold her close, intending to make her uncomfortable, and used a low tone as she asked —What's the point of trying to deny it now? I have nothing to lose.

However, she entirely ignored all those efforts to make her uneasy and only talked back, looking defiantly at the woman and refusing to back down or take any more of her bullshit.

—You haven't had anything to lose since the moment you "joined" the rebellion. Otherwise, you wouldn't have joined at all…

—I actually did…— she admitted, looking away.

—Besides your life?

—And here I thought you *did* listen— Shadow Weaver retorted, unable to keep herself from looking back at her with utter disgust, both angry and pained, which perhaps the sorceress could recognize.

—I do— she assured her with absolute resolve. —I just- Why do you- Back then you said you wanted to save Micah because you owed him that much… and I understand a similar thought is what pushed you to save your girls… so, why is it so difficult for you to keep that mentality?

—It's on *purpose*— she replied, rolling her eyes once more, clearly annoyed. Right after, she mocked her —Keep up, would you?

—Ugh, I won't even get offended at this point— Castaspella sighed. —It's *obvious* I struck a chord and you just got defensive— she added. Before Shadow Weaver could react to that, she looked at her with a gentle look and assured —You don't need to pretend apathy in front of me, you know? It's not like I will judge you.

—You have no idea what you're talking about.

—Then explain it to me.

—No.

—Come on!

—What's the point!?

—You *clearly* need it!— Castaspella exclaimed. They both fell silent and she seemed to have become suddenly aware of how Shadow Weaver had been holding her. As if the effect of her attempt to make her uncomfortable had been delayed, she blushed deeply and stammered —A-and… um… i-it's the least you can do if you plan to keep holding me like this…

However, instead of letting go, she only pulled her closer, once again using the same low tone; perhaps now she'd make her back down by increasing her discomfort.

—How can you be so predictable but at the same time prove me wrong whenever I make an assumption about you?

—How can you be so attentive and simultaneously a jerk?

So… she entirely ignored it again…

—Me? Attentive? Did you hit your head that hard when you fell?— she immediately asked, tilting her head to the side a bit.

—You pay attention to everything and everyone! You *are* attentive but don't care enough to act accordingly!— she replied, between amused and indignant. She then seemed to think better about it and added —Or… well… sometimes you do, but only if you find the *meanest* way to do it.

The sorceress rolled her eyes and couldn't help smiling a bit, wanting to laugh at her own words.

Shadow Weaver also felt like laughing at first, but the fact that Castaspella's statement was so accurate wasn't amusing in the slightest, so she only let out, sardonically, —Very funny…

Thinking about that exchange, her first thought was how she only let go of the sorceress much later. She couldn't make her uncomfortable! Or, perhaps, she did, but she was so stubborn she refused to let Shadow Weaver win with that.

It would make sense…

But that last comment had really hit her like nothing before. Back then, she ignored it, downplayed its effect on her, and promptly forgot about it as they continued to bicker. Perhaps it was a good moment to reflect on it.

How can you be so attentive and simultaneously a jerk?

Perhaps if she had said "observant" it wouldn't have sounded so strange to her. Because that was true: Shadow Weaver is too observant, and she *has to* if she wants to be in control of the situation at all times. What was she expecting?

But Castaspella was right when she said she'd be attentive as long as she could be mean about it. Like how she deflected the creature galloping at them: it wouldn't hurt Shadow Weaver, so she had no selfish reasons to do anything, but if she didn't, it would have run over the sorceress.

Then, why did she do it? Because she could. Because she refused to remain idle and see it happen. And she could use it to say "even I, who can't do anything, still do more than you".

Yes, the sorceress was right. She can be considerate as long as she finds a way to be mean too: *attentive and simultaneously a jerk*.

Beatrix's reflections were interrupted by a sensation of lightness as she felt the pull from the core weaken. She managed to easily reach the surface and, as she expected, it wasn't Castaspella who was there, but rather Adora and Catra.

—Well, well. What a surprise— she let out, smirking. —I know you don't miss me, so I can't wait to know what could have *possibly* brought you two to see me— she mocked them.

They both were a few meters away, having just stepped into the groove, and froze when they heard her; Adora turned around in place, merely startled at the sudden voice, but Catra jumped back a full meter, hairs standing on end, and eyes fully opened in fear.

—It worked!— Adora stated, right before noticing Catra's reaction. —Woah, a-are you okay?

—Perhaps I should have cleared my throat first— Shadow Weaver commented, unwillingly condescending. —I mean, I'm well aware of what I did and how, and yes, this must have felt like…

—…When you'd snuck up on me to bark at me back in the Horde— Catra interrupted. She took a deep breath and eased down her hair before carefully approaching. —It was a reflex.

—A *good* reflex, if anything. Keeps you alive— she replied, unsure herself of what to say or how.

It seemed like she was still speaking in a threatening manner as the girl remained jumpy; reluctantly, Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and stepped back, gritting her teeth as a part of her kept saying this was ridiculous and that Catra needed to grow a backbone.

—So…— Adora began, calling their attention. —I- We- The-there's something we wanted to discuss with you.

—Regarding?

—Erm… the…— she began, hesitantly. Looking away she finally said —The Head Sorceress.

—I can't *imagine* what you could need to…

—Shut up— Catra interrupted, apparently unable to bear the woman's mocking tone. —You- Just *stop* taking everything so lightly!

Curious, Shadow Weaver looked back at her and barely restrained the impulse to walk closer.

She tilted her head to the side and asked —And why exactly are you suddenly so defensive of her?

—I owe her, alright!?— she angrily replied, both hands tightly closed in fists. —If you *really* hear everything we talk about when the three of us are in the same place, then you should know.

—What? That she gave you a free pass for the privacy invasion?

—Shadow Weaver!— Adora interrupted, physically stepping between them. Seeing Catra almost growling at the woman, and met with nothing but further provocation, she must have thought it best to take over. —We came to talk. Like adults. Or-or young adults and… a spirit— she corrected herself. Realizing the triviality of the matter, she immediately shook her head and went on —The thing is: we need to know- we *want* to know if you're… playing with her. *Using* her.

She narrowed her eyes, dropped all the mockery, and asked back —What exactly do you mean?

—I- I mean… if you're just making her fall for you or…

—Making her *what*!?

—You didn't notice? But she *said it*— Adora pointed out, genuinely surprised.

—No. She said something she wasn't even sure about mere minutes later— Shadow Weaver pointed out, glaring.

—Oh, *please*! That woman *loves you*! *Somehow*!

—Don't be ridiculous.

—*You* are being ridiculous!

—Stop! Please!

Once again, Adora had to interrupt them before their argument escalated.

—To answer your question…— Shadow Weaver began, looking away and folding her arms. —No. I am *not* manipulating her in any way. I don't need to. And I *certainly* don't *want* her to love me. I wouldn't ever be so desperate as to require something so pitiable as manipulating someone into "loving" me.

—But that only means she *genuinely* loves…

—Of course *not*!

—Alright! Alright. We understand…— Adora promptly interceded. —Maybe we could…

Shadow Weaver entirely ignored the girls when she suddenly felt the pull of the summoning spell and, right then, Castaspella appeared in the groove, along with her pupils. She wasn't expecting her now, much less accompanied by them, so it caused her genuine joy to see them show up all of a sudden.

But she couldn't let them know they had provoked such feelings in her.

—You all seem determined to surprise me today—she said, mockingly.

—It is *just* a visit! What's the big deal?— Catra complained, crossing her arms in front of her chest as she looked away, shyly. —Maybe you just *want* us to "surprise you". So you could, I don't know, say *that*.

Unamused, she asked —Who exactly would be so pathetic as to request being surprised? Do you believe me to be desperate enough to defeat the entire purpose of a "surprise"?

—Stubborn, I'd say. You can't see that woman loves you…— Catra muttered, for Shadow Weaver's ears only.

That irreverent girl!

She was ready to purposely scare her this time, but she couldn't even think about it before the eleven pupils ran at her, entirely ignoring the girls.

—Master! Master!

—What happened to you!?

—Where had you gone!?

—Will you come back!?

—When will you teach us again!?

—Want to see how we have been practicing!?

—Did you know Sahm almost punched one of the nerds in the class of the Head Sorceress!?

—He also told us why you were gone!

—Yeah! He used a truth spell! On a councilman!

—Master! Did you know some of the kids don't want to return home!? They are staying with us in Mystacor instead!

All of them tried to speak at the same time, all shouting, wanting to be *the* voice that Shadow Weaver would hear. However, they weren't giving her space to answer and it took her a while to finally make them calm down so she could reply to all of them.

She was particularly interested in what Sahm did, and began asking about that; knowing *she* had trained him made her extremely proud, but she only told him it was good to know he actually listened to her. Afterwards, she moved on to the subject of the kids staying at Mystacor instead of returning home, and this time it was Ari who explained how they were told to hide their magic but, after she showed them all how beautiful it is, they don't want to hide it anymore, so the Head Sorceress offered them to stay and then several other kids chose the same for similar reasons.

She wanted to ask about those orders to hide their magic, who or why demanded so of Ari, but she simply couldn't bring herself to do so. However, she didn't even have the chance to think about the whys because, without hesitation, the kids began asking for her to teach them again, there in the woods.

Oh, how she wanted to.

But why?

Obviously because Light Spinner enjoyed teaching! And even more with such eager students.

Oh, but not there. Certainly not in the woods. She would *not* be responsible for whatever those reckless kids destroyed. Much less for any of them getting hurt.

No. Her days of assuming the blame for little kids under her tutelage are long gone. Shadow Weaver would *not* fall into that trap again.

However, no matter how many times she refused, no matter what she said, they *kept insisting*. She couldn't bear it for long and soon enough, she lashed out; Castaspella interceded without losing a beat, of course, and the pupils finally stopped insisting.

It surprised her at first that even the Head Sorceress considered the idea of the kids having classes there, but then she remembered how volatile her confidence is and it quickly made sense. Fortunately, the explanation as to why they shouldn't be trained there also convinced her.

And there was no mistaking the pain Castaspella felt, probably at the kids' desperation to recover *their* Master.

Beatrix never noticed when the girls left, only realized they were gone when, upon the sorceress' departure, the core of Etheria pulled her back.

The woman wasn't sure whether she felt glad or annoyed at the short visits she had gotten.

Perhaps both: pleased that they visited, but annoyed at the reasons why they did.

Ugh, she didn't even want to think about it. Being *glad* for something so paltry as someone visiting her, wanting to see her.

No. Not again.

Shadow Weaver refused to let them soften her so much.

She would *not* allow more memories to overtake her nor would she let herself feel anything else, not even what the spell would let her perceive from the sorceress.

And she managed as much…

For a day… two days…

Until she noticed that, once more, the sorceress wasn't going to see her at all.

Perhaps, and only perhaps, those visits were a bigger deal than she wanted to believe. Bigger than Catra believed.

Not like she would admit it, of course.

But then again, what exactly would Shadow Weaver *ever* dare admit!?

And if the girls were right!? What if, in fact, the sorceress *was* really in love with her. However ridiculous it could seem to her, that kiss *had* happened.

Ah, but then again, the woman said she wasn't really sure she did love her, nor did she seem to want to think about that kiss, seeing how she hadn't mentioned it at all.

Why would she *ever* acknowledge that to be true now!? It couldn't be, because if it was… then she had *already* lost it.

If it's only the girls' idea, then she didn't really lose anything, right? And *that* is more appealing to her.

Now, thinking about this, one conversation she and the sorceress once had came back to her mind, one which she decided to observe as it had ultimately led to her current issue: loss.

Once again, Shadow Weaver found herself in a heated discussion with Castaspella about the way they treat other people, and the woman couldn't stand it much longer.

Rolling her eyes dramatically, she let out —I'll have to disappoint you, but I'm not like you; you may be all nice and gentle with everyone since you meet them and never offend them, but I see no reasons to be "nice" now. What would be the point of apologizing and trying to be agreeable after already being nasty since we first met? So no, I'm just being realistic, this is how I am.

—You really have no idea, don't you?— the sorceress scoffed. —Tell me something…

—Ask away.

—That time you attacked Mystacor, trying to get to Adora…

—Oh no, here we go— Shadow Weaver sighed, rolling her eyes again.

—Oh yes; tell me: that time, did you see or hear anything that happened? Of what was said?

—What do you mean?

—When Adora broke the lunar crystals… Could you see or hear my reaction? How I shouted at Adora and shamed Glimmer for hanging out with her?

—Ah! Of course!— she laughed. Grinning, she recalled —Yes, that worked like a charm. After all, my aim was to make her feel rejected.

—Alright, say that again, but slower this time— Castaspella requested.

—What? That my aim was…— she began, but interrupted herself. She was pensive for a moment before continuing to think aloud, with a confused look, —What happened…

—Yes?

—*You* made her feel… rejected.

While Shadow Weaver stared at the ground, both confused and surprised, the Head Sorceress took a deep breath.

—Exactly— she let out, calling her attention. —I began that day welcoming Adora as I do with everyone: cheerful, happy, eager to show her around… Yet within hours, I was yelling at her, as if she could *somehow* know what she had done, and I was completely oblivious that it had been your fault, of course. I even tried to make Glimmer feel guilty for being friends with Adora— she summarized. She took another deep breath before continuing, with a nicer tone, —However, by the end of the day, I recognized my mistake; I realized she hadn't meant to break anything. She was so stressed she might not have noticed where she was. Oh, *and* she saved my kingdom *despite* your manipulation. You… put her through the same scenario you lived, yet she returned to save her friends, to save literally everyone, even if she had no obligation to. After all of that, I understood I had terribly misjudged her, so I apologized for what I had said— she concluded. Shadow Weaver was looking away now, trying to hide her shame, and remembering that a councilman had once told her about this, specifically about her lash out to Adora. As she wouldn't say anything else, Castaspella took a deep breath and added —I don't know what makes you think people are either nice or mean, but that's not the case, and there's no shame in admitting you were wrong and apologizing for it. *Shameful* is to realize you were wrong yet be too petty to admit it.

—I get it, I get it…

—Hiding behind the "this is how I am" can only last so long, Bea. I've seen you trying to be less mean, but it means nothing if you don't first apologize.

—You know full well…

—That for you, apologizing means admitting weakness— the sorceress interrupted. —Yes, I know you're *very* delusional for this matters— she mocked her, smiling a bit. —But, I plan on insisting until you forget that bullshit and finally learn the importance of admitting you were wrong and letting others *see* your regret.

—How can you be so stubborn!? *Who* would forgive a monster!?

Castaspella rolled her eyes and huffed —First of all: You're just a shitty excuse of a person, not a monster, otherwise we wouldn't be having this discussion. Second: How do you expect *anyone* to even consider forgiving you if you won't show that you regret what you've done!? And third: The *point* here isn't being forgiven; the point is to make sure your behaviour won't keep hunting those you have hurt. Letting them know you regret what you did or said lifts a great weight from them.

—They should just ignore all I've ever told them, like-like what I told Adora that day— she let out, laughing bitterly. —I told her you all wanted to use her, that you didn't actually care for her… But she knew I was manipulating her.

Slightly disappointed and mustering all her patience, the Head Sorceress shook her head as she let out a sigh.

—People can "know" someone is lying to them and trying to influence their view of things, but even so, it all leaves a mark— she began. Looking away, she went on —I mean, just like almost everyone else, I've mostly seen Adora more as "She-Ra" than as the teenager who first visited Mystacor. *Now* I can see the young woman who saved us all, and realize she was carrying a weight none of us could really comprehend. When you told her we only wanted to use her… she may have trusted her friends really care about her for who she is, not just She-Ra but, all in all, we *did* behave just like that. We have more regard for the living factor, perhaps, but that doesn't mean…

—Manipulation is using the truth to shift the focus in a way that will make someone see things solely the way you want— she interrupted, realizing where she was going. —So yes, I *did* point out something that was true, but in your case, it stemmed from a survival instinct; you mainly saw She-Ra because she's a beacon of hope in a world that couldn't remember the time before the Horde. I only saw the power inside her and cared little about her as a person because I so chose to. What I told her applied to both you and me, but you were definitely the only ones who could potentially realize as much and decide to care for Adora regardless of whether she's She-Ra or not. And she knew that well.

—But the damage was done— the sorceress insisted. —Why do you think she kept putting her life at risk after losing She-Ra? She felt like she *had to* be useful or she'd be ditched. We wouldn't ever… but I can't imagine how it felt to hear those words repeating inside her head and pushing her to prove her worth.

—It seems to me like you *can* imagine— Shadow Weaver pointed out, staring at her with a knowing look.

—This isn't about me— she sighed. —Could you *try* having a bit of empathy? I promise you can't die a second time— she requested, sarcastically. —But, seriously, you don't have to be a bitch about everything. Your view of the world is seriously flawed, so much that you now panic as it falls apart, don't you?— she asked, seemingly sure of the answer. The woman's expression must have confirmed it as she promptly went on —Then stop trying to hold it all together now that you can *see* it's pure bullshit! You were hurt? Fine, I suppose that made you bitter, but you let it poison you and repeated the same manners; now, you've hurt others like you were hurt and *worse*. Couldn't see or care about it before? Survival instinct perhaps? Alright, now you have *nothing* to lose. Just *try* changing this stupid behaviour! You have nothing else to forfeit. In fact, if you change, you *could* recover what you've already lost!

—As if I deserved that…

—Cut it— Castaspella immediately interrupted. —Thinking like that is what made you think Catra didn't deserve care and kindness; if I have to convince you that even *you* deserve it, so that you finally regret being a bitch to her instead of giving her what you would have liked to receive, then so be it. Even if it takes me the rest of my life, I *will* make you understand what you did.

—That sounds more threatening than it should…— Shadow Weaver muttered, genuinely surprised. Trying hard to hide it, she mocked her, —But congratulations on sounding threatening for once.

—Oh, fuck off!

Annoyed, the Head Sorceress turned around and began to walk away, but she grabbed her by the arm and stopped her.

When she looked back, Shadow Weaver hold her gaze as she assured her —I took it seriously, I swear.

Now she can't stop thinking about how, opposite to what they both thought, she actually had a lot to lose.

And it *is* all lost now so, little does it matter… But then again, Castaspella had also told her she could perhaps recover what she had lost…

Beatrix certainly wants to salvage as much as possible. But as long as she refuses to *admit* what she cherished, what she lost, there will be nothing to rescue.

So what if…

She had called it a threat, but perhaps the sorceress would have called it dedication or something similar; so what if that "dedication" to prove to her that she deserves all those things she keeps doubting to be worthy of…

Could that count as proof of any feelings Castaspella could have for her?

Who cares!?

Why should it matter at all!?

She knows full well this is all trivial when the facts remain: that sorceress is delusional if she thinks someone like Shadow Weaver can be worthy of love.

Right?

Then why would she think otherwise?

Could it be true?

Did Beatrix *want* that to be true?

Overwhelmed by longing, the pain managed to sip back into her chest, burning in such a way it completely overrode her thinking. But fortunately, soon enough she could feel the summoning spell guide her back to the surface.

As the pain receded, she realized that overwhelming longing was not *her* feeling. It was Castaspella's, and her expression confirmed it.

What could she do? She knows *nothing* about comforting others. Well then, what would the sorceress do if she were in her shoes? She didn't have the faintest idea, *but* she'd sure put a lot of emphasis on what the other needs.

Well… What did Castaspella need? She had catastrophically failed at figuring her out, so she didn't have the faintest idea, and this was *not* a good time to "guess" lest she'd fail again.

No one other than the sorceress could know…

Perhaps that was it: who better to know what she needs than Castaspella herself!? She only had to allow the woman to take whatever she needed.

That was, of course, so that Shadow Weaver wouldn't be razed to the ground by her intense feelings…

No ulterior motives…

Sure.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: The reason I believe someone can be as expertly manipulative as SW yet not necessarily be a bad person just because of that "skill" is because, full disclosure, I am. Technically speaking, yes, I did use this to keep control of my brother, in a way that I saw reflected on what LS did with Micah (aka, more of an accidental manipulation genuinely confused with "I am keeping you safe"). So, when SW says things like "Manipulation is using the truth to shift the focus in a way that will make someone see things solely the way you want" that's irl me speaking; yes, I can still manipulate people like puppets, *but I refuse to do so for my own gain*, that's what changed. I used to think I was "protecting" my brother by having him do exactly as I said because *I* knew what to do and don't do to make sure our father wouldn't punish me (u can see where this is going), but in reality, I was being the same kind of monster in a way. Mind you, this is why I project my brother on Micah and it fits so well, his animosity towards me perfectly aligns to Micah's animosity towards SW in S5.
Now, you see... the thing about being attentive/observant. As SW says, "observant" is more accurate in her case because she pays attention to everything but doesn't use that information to

be considerate, while being "attentive" means purposely paying attention aiming to be considerate. In fact, I was gonna add something more but didn't, yet I'd like to mention it here: Casta has boundaries issues because she's attentive in a way but not observant enough. While SW is extremely observant, only blind to what she's refusing to see or admit, and she could be more attentive if she wanted to. In fact, we see this in canon when she steps into someone's personal space: it's always as a means to an end, she *knows* she's trespassing, opposite to how Casta is oblivious.
And, well, my point is that you can use the same skillset for *good* things if so you want.
For instance: Someone who always means to be in control of the situation will quickly identify how people feel with each other, or with certain subjects, and exploit that to their favor. I, however, will use that to the others' favor, as I did this one time when I realized someone at a literary club I used to attend was uncomfortable with the author we were reading. He apparently didn't like him or his ideas, so when I saw the tutor of the reading circle press him into reading, I stopped him subtly hinting at knowing why, and read in his stead, then later explained it seemed to be an issue with the author of the poems.
Another thing I do is choose the best way to phrase things according to how the other is feeling, which has allowed me to manage some of my BFF's crises when her BPD was at its worst: I didn't lie nor did I manipulate her maliciously, but I low-key kinda *did* manipulate her view into what I wanted, which was to merely counter the bullshit her BPD was making her feel. If you tell someone in a full crisis "Things aren't like you're seeing them, that's on your head" it only worsens things; if, instead, you carefully explain what parts this person isn't seeing, if you carefully "shift the focus in a way that will make someone see things solely the way you want" - that way being more positive-, then you can help them out of the crisis.

Well, damn, sorry for so much unnecessary info but...
Now you know where all my writing's come from heh ("^-^)>

I hope you enjoyed and liked this chapter!! Until next week and thank you for reading!!

Our Best Shot

Chapter Summary

After one of the worst days of her life, yet being fortunately received the best possible way by Shadow Weaver, Castaspella discusses her plans with her, as she has decided to call for Entrapta's help with a single purpose: Get the woman back.

However, there are some remaining tensions between the ex-Horde members and the late sorceress, that will force Castaspella to intercede and mediate.

Can Shadow Weaver get over her past conflicts with Entrapta? Or will she remain far to bitter to accept her help?

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone! It's late this Wednesday, but at least not far too late heh.
Ahem...

I would have more to write here, but a little something happened today, which is also the reason I'm posting so late, and this is why I won't be saying much in these notes...

Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was early in the morning, enough for Mystacor to be enveloped within a thick fog and a dark purple sky. The Head Sorceress woke up suddenly, startled, and sweating so much she needed a bath.

At first, she was unable to speak, unable to think, and only after freshening up could she reflect, observe her feelings and thoughts, and understand what she was experiencing.

—I need to get her back— she muttered, wrapped in a towel and sitting in her bed, looking at the ground. Her eyes gradually filled up with tears, and soon she was sobbing, occasionally repeating —I *need* her.

It took her some time to calm herself down and finally have breakfast but, afterwards, she was resolved to find where exactly Shadow Weaver is. That way, she may also find how to get her back.

However, on her way to the archive, she came across Micah and his reaction to her gloomy mood triggered yet another argument once again; every time it seems like things are getting better, they soon get worse.

—You-you, what? Love her? I don't even care what you feel, because she *had died* already! Why can't you just grieve her and move on?— the sorcerer asked, indignant.

Staring in disbelief, Castaspella could only ask —*Grieve* her?

—I- I've had- I did the same with Angella!— he stammered. —I can't- I lost her and yet I'm not losing my head trying to summon her spirit or something! I'm trying to take care of those I love who are still around. Like you, Sis!

—You insist you care, but you hate her *more* than you love your own sister— she immediately reproached him. —So you don't understand… You *don't want* to accept that I am *not* grieving for her. I'm *coming for her*. No matter what it takes… It is either her back here, or I'll… just go wherever her spirit is… That's a promise.

—Now you want to- You can't be serious!— he exclaimed, alarmed and panicked. —Ho-how can you say that!?

She gave him a tired look as she replied —I have tried, so, so hard, to explain myself to you. But you do not listen. I won't keep trying—. With a bitter laugh, she added —Just… hah! Better start praying to the Stars that I can bring her back to me, because I swear: I will do as promised.

The Head Sorceress immediately turned around and walked away but still heard him as he said —You've gone insane…

She stopped on her tracks but did nothing. No expressions or reactions.

After a moment, she simply let out —Have I?

And continued on her way.

Castaspella yawned weakly as she woke up next to Shadow Weaver, having rested her head on the woman's shoulder all night. It hurt terribly, but she was too tired to pay any attention to her pain on the neck.

—Ah, you're awake… At least you got a few hours of rest.

—I think— the sorceress yawned once more. —And I… suppose I needed it.

—So it appears— Shadow Weaver agreed. —Was yesterday so bad?

—Ugh, since the beginning— she grunted, trying to sit up yet falling back on the tree. Preferring to just rest there, she went on —And the fact that I hardly found any information on where you are, where the core is supposed to be… Everything was so… frustrating…

—You haven't told me what happened, and I suppose there's nothing on where "the damned" are kept by the core because even I, being there, have no idea *where* "there" is.

—Well… it was nothing important… just another "conversation" with my brother that didn't end well… and it was the last I needed with how I woke up…

—I see… so that was the feeling of longing, eh?

—I guess, yes— she admitted, letting out a sad smile. —But… tell me something: what was that myth of the damned supposed to be? What did you know about it? A-and was it what you expected?

Shadow Weaver shook her head, looking away, and stared into the distance as she replied —The myth was related to the fate of the souls of those consumed by this parasite magic that is as ancient as the planet itself. The oldest information I could find said that a race of angelic beings had sealed away the parasite, along with all the souls it had consumed to increase its power, but that it didn't stop others from crafting ways to obtain that power.

—Wait so… the race of Angella. Others like her— she reflected. As the woman nodded, she continued —Meaning their power, which Glimmer also has, can subdue the parasite.

—I suppose. Although I only gathered stories. Perhaps it was a group of them, large enough that we'll never see so much power together at the same place ever again— she clarified. —And that is besides the fact that Angella was the only one who stuck with the Etherians instead of giving up on us all. If you wonder why, then I could pretty much be considered the embodiment of the reason.

—Our greed…

—Yes. Why would they protect people who decided to craft ways of undoing all their hard work and sacrifice? But then again, it was part of their nature to protect people, which explains why it was none other than an angelic being who created the rebellion.

—Now that explains it, yes— the sorceress laughed.

—And about what I thought it was… I'd even say it's more than I believed. I expected just nothingness, but I had quite enough of a body even before the summoning, and there's the pain…— she began, but hesitated. Looking away, she dared add —A true damned… would be Norwyn. Whom I saw at the core.

—You- What? Really?

—Yes… But I believe he's no longer there. Perhaps even the damned can… fix their situation and be set free— Shadow Weaver reflected. —He apologized to me…

—He…

—No, perhaps it was just because he was consumed by the parasite, not corrupted by it, like I was. He was just a shadow of the real him; nowhere near as corporeal as I am.

Pensive, the sorceress looked away as she thought aloud —Then that's a dead end. Perhaps I should directly go with Entrapta's plan.

—What plan?

—Eh?— Castaspella reacted, barely realizing she was thinking aloud. —Oh, I'm sorry. I meant to tell you: Princess Entrapta told Glimmer that she- I mean, after you were dismissed, it was her who suggested you could be summoned again because, well, the dead don't die again— she began, laughing nervously. —And she also mentioned wanting to run a few tests on you…

—What!? Do not *dare* allow that!

—But she may find a way to keep you here! And away from the pain!

—So will let her technology tinker with Etheria's magic again!?

—She knows what she's doing! And I'll be here the whole time! I-I mean, I *have to* for that. So I'll supervise everything. Trust me.

—You make it hard to trust you… very hard.

—Please— she pleaded, pouting exaggeratedly.

—*Only* if that Princess gives me her word that she will listen to you and stop if I don't want to go on — Shadow Weaver finally agreed.

—Thank you!— the sorceress exclaimed, throwing her arms around her and making them both fall down to the ground.

—Ouch.

—Sorry— the Head Sorceress laughed, as the woman tried and failed to hide an amused smile. —I-Do you remember when I told Micah that I have no friends?— she suddenly asked. When Shadow Weaver nodded, she concluded —Well, you're the closest to a friend I've ever had.

—We are *not* friends. *I* don't have friends. And what even is wrong with not having them. What do you want them for!?— she immediately reacted, looking away despite still being under the flighty sorceress.

—What!? Friends aren't "for something"; you just have friends, to spend time with, to help you when you need it, and whom you help too because, usually, you care about your friends, you know?— she replied, sarcastic at the end. —We both have been helping each other the past months and, as far as I'm concerned, none of it was manipulation but rather the both of us *honestly* wanting to assist the other— the sorceress insisted. She pushed herself up and sat on the ground —Am I not a friend to you? Am I not someone you can count on?

—I suppose I *can* trust you— she admitted, sitting up too but still looking away.

Giggling, Castaspella replied —So I'm your trustee? I like that! Sounds nice.

Shadow Weaver scoffed and gave her a gentle push, to which the sorceress replied with the same motion.

Following her plan, and after having spoken with Princess Entrapta for hours, several times, the day came for the first attempt at replacing the mask's function in the summoning.

—Recording number one! We begin!— the princess let out, talking to one of her bots while her helpers carried equipment into the magical groove. —It has been two months since the spiritual entity's anchor was broken.

—Anchor?— Castaspella repeated, confused, looking back at Shadow Weaver.

But the woman wasn't paying attention, too irritated by the coming and going of Entrapta's "assistants": Wrong Hordak, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. Yet the real problem began when she saw Hordak arrive.

—According to the planet's magical output, spirits are the magical residue of living individuals who have passed. Following that logic, *everything* on the planet is magical! If we can channel this spirit's

magic into a new object, it should serve as a new anchor to keep it on the surface!— the princess concluded. Right after, she noticed him arriving and exclaimed —Hordak! Quick! Connect everything!

Shadow Weaver immediately turned towards Castaspella and, speaking between her teeth, seethed —I will *not* trust him!

—He's only helping Entrapta.

—I do not care.

—But he's not doing anything, he's not in charge.

—I said…

—Alright, alright— the sorceress interrupted, gesturing with her hands for her to stop. —I will tell her.

However, before she could talk to the princess, Hordak stopped next to them, squinting, but said nothing.

Seemingly confused, the sorceress was about to speak when he addressed the woman —I see we both met quite lenient fates.

—Lenient… Hah! Speak for yourself, you're still alive— Shadow Weaver immediately replied, noticeably irritated.

—And you were *brought back* . It seems to me like you're in a far… *better* position— he insisted.

Before either her or Castaspella could reply, Princess Entrapta interrupted —Look at these readings! We have a *lot* to work with!

—What is that supposed to mean!?— the women immediately asked, accidentally speaking at the same time; the Head Sorceress sounded surprised, but Shadow Weaver seemed more angry, almost offended, even if slightly shocked too.

—That we got so much data we may be able to do it!— the princess explained, excited. She took Hordak by the arm and dragged him away, insisting —We have no time to lose! Come on now!

They were suddenly left alone, processing Entrapta's words in utter silence. Shadow Weaver glanced at the Horde Trio, thinking about what they may be thinking in this situation, knowing none other than the Head Sorceress of Mystacor is trying to keep her in Etheria.

And yet, their thinking was nothing like what she imagined. On the contrary, Rogelio found it quite adorable, as did Kyle. But he was also curious about why that was, so with Lonnie, they both began theorizing about it.

Was Shadow Weaver helping her with something important in Mystacor for which the sorceress needed her? Or perhaps the woman had somehow manipulated her to get more time in this world? Could the woman be hypnotized? They discarded the idea as ridiculous, but Lonnie found it even more ridiculous when Kyle suggested Castaspella liked Shadow Weaver.

How and why? It felt impossible, but then they saw them talking so amicably it felt a bit more likely.

—It's still hard to believe for me— Lonnie insisted.

—We could ask Adora and Catra about it. I heard they have been talking a lot with Castaspella- I-I mean the Head Sorceress— Kyle suggested, stammering a bit at the end, nervous for having accidentally spoken about her with such familiarity.

—Nah, it's not our business… All we have to do is help the princess and be done with it.

Just as Lonnie said that, Imp arrived flying and settled on Kyle's shoulder.

Right after, they heard the announcement, with Entrapta's voice, —Your work is done here. Feel free to return home!

Kyle thanked before Imp flew away and they all set out back to the castle.

About an hour later, Shadow Weaver was complaining about the princess still pestering her with tests to her magical body while Castaspella simply observed from a distance. However, Hordak interrupted the Head Sorceress' amusement as he wanted to ask her a few things, both curious and confused.

—Why is it that you're *so* insistent on convincing that woman to change her mind?

—I don't know what else you expect me to do. I believe she's being irrational by refusing to do this solely because *you* are involved— Castaspella explained. Utterly serious, she added —I completely understand why… but it is irrational when this is our best shot at keeping her here.

—That is because she does *not* understand unless her disobedience is punished.

The Head Sorceress' immediate reaction was an outraged look as his words justified Shadow Weaver's fear, but before she could say anything, Entrapta chimed in as she was, apparently, hearing their conversation while running her tests.

—Actually, my field studies of interpersonal behavior have shown that punishments entirely fail to correct wrong behaviors an 85% of the times and, in fact, only exhort rebellious behaviors, meaning it has zero effectiveness— she explained, still looking at the data of her test. She only looked up briefly to say —And further investigation showed the numbers are exactly opposite when someone is patiently explained and taught about right and wrong, as it only fails a 15% of the times, although any result takes quite long to be achieved—. Looking back at her notes, before preparing her tools for one more test, she concluded —So, while highly inefficient, it is still the only effective strategy.

Hordak was left pensive for a moment, looking at the ground, and after a while, he finally asked —Then *why* would Big Brother always use that strategy?

The princess paused before activating the device she had just hooked around Shadow Weaver's wrist and asked, surprised, —Really?

—He would *illuminate* us!— Wrong Hordak immediately said, arriving with a small box for Entrapta and joining the conversation out of nowhere. He then added —He would cleanse us from impurities.

—"Impurities" were all the individual thoughts and opinions we developed, and "illuminate" meant forcing us back to his point of view— Hordak translated, visibly angry.

While activating her device and plugging it into the box she took from Wrong Hordak, the princess pointed out —Then he couldn't have been that perfect if he used such ineffective means that were bound to fail.

As she casually continued her final test, both clones were left thinking; Wrong Hordak's expression was so troubled he seemed on the verge of a crisis, and Castaspella couldn't help but hesitantly reach for Hordak as she saw him staring at the ground, conflicted and frowning, perhaps angry or simply annoyed at his reflections.

He looked up surprised as he felt her hand on his shoulder, yet neither could speak as Shadow Weaver's angry yelling interrupted.

—What do you *think* you're doing!?— she exclaimed as she saw Entrapta nailing a set of rounded devices around the area of the groove. —I am *not* risking losing what little of the summoning spell still works being *ruined* by your untested technology!

Castaspella rushed to interfere, getting between the raging woman and the scared princess, trying to defuse the situation.

—There's no need for yelling, we're all adults and should communicate calmly— she said.

—You don't understand! This!? She has done it before! She first took my runestone, now this place too!?

—Oh, no. Hold on— Castaspella interrupted her, gesturing with her hand for her to stop. —First of all, the runestone was *never* yours to begin with, understand? And second, Entrapta is trying to help! Her only interest are the tests, yet she agreed to lend us her resources to help us!— she indignantly reproached her.

The woman couldn't help but fold her arms, trying to hide a certain shyness she couldn't understand, and barely muttered —I can't believe you *really* want me back in Mystacor.

The woman then took a few steps away without saying anything else and the Head Sorceress sighed, offended, before walking away while saying —Thank you, Princess Entrapta. Feel free to stay as much as you need until you're done with this and I shall visit you tomorrow so you can brief me on your findings.

Soon enough, she was sufficiently far away for Shadow Weaver's spirit to have sunk beneath the surface once more, and the sorceress returned to her kingdom by foot all the way, needing to blow some steam.

Chapter End Notes

So: if someone reading this is also in that discord server with me, now you know why there I'm using the nickname "Shadow Weaver's trustee" hehe

Sorry if you see any typos or spaces before/after words in italic, but I'm far too tired today and couldn't edit as many times as I would have wanted. And... Again, I'm not gonna say much more, just uh, the idea of the Horde Trio living with Entrapta and the Hordaks was suggested by

Cana <3
Thank you so much! It’s a lovely idea!

Thank you for reading and I hope you liked the chapter!!

Until next week!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

> The lesson: Everyone makes mistakes, the best you can do is accept and make up for them
> Status: 100% ~~Reluctantly~~ accepted.

Chapter Notes

> This episode is brought to you by this marvel of a post that gave me this wonderful idea that simply *fits* extremely well. Of course, as this was written by an entrapdak shipper, the tone is obviously shippy, yet, as per usual, I remain as neutral as possible so you all can ship or friendship at will. I have no place to give an opinion here, be free. However, for any Hordak fans, as said in the previous chapter, remember this is entirely SW's pov, meaning her opinion fully tinges the narration, showing her personal opinion and regard of Hordak and Imp, etc.
> AH
> Same goes for calling Melog an "animal"; that's SW's salty pov. *I* know full well that Melog is an individual of a different (alien) race, not an animal, but the woman doesn't know that and everyone sees Melog as Catra's pet.
>
> So um, now with all due disclaimers, please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once again she had had to bear Hordak's presence around her… Just her luck.

At least, that first time since her summoning, she had the chance to stay away despite having to remain in the room. But now? He's invading her *only* place.

Why had Castaspella allowed it if she knows exactly *why* Shadow Weaver doesn't want to be anywhere around him anymore?

Perhaps she still felt guilty for what happened at the anniversary party celebrating the first year since the war ended… It sounds like her, yes. Or perhaps she didn't want to offend Entrapta by asking her to leave him and only him out of it?

Ugh… Shadow Weaver could hardly believe she allowed the sorceress to convince her of letting that princess experiment with her.

Why!?

With everything that happened…

Everything she *took from her*!

Oh, but Beatrix wanted to give the plan a chance. What if they could really restore the summoning? Replace the mask? What if they could find a way to turn something into a strong… anchor, had she called it?

For once in her life, she wanted to believe.

Even though Shadow Weaver was sure it made no sense to be hopeful…

But enough what ifs… she needed to distract herself before her emotions let that pain invade her.

Knowing how to keep it at bay by means of observing her memories, she decided to recall that party and the amusing events of that month.

She had never seen Castaspella so ashamed before…

> A whole year had passed since the end of the war, yet she had only been summoned for less than four months; Shadow Weaver certainly didn't want to think about how long she had been dead, so it was better to focus on someone else's business.
>
> And the *lucky* winner: Castaspella, of course.
>
> After the grandiose Guild Dance the sorceress had thrown, she never thought there would be yet *another* party to organize mere weeks later. Nowhere half as big, more like a family and friends thing.
>
> *Why* bother!?
>
> They all had decided to gather to celebrate this first anniversary of the new era of peace, yet an emergency mission in space kept Glimmer away from Etheria right until the agreed date, meaning they should reschedule it. Oh, but everyone invited had been told to attend to the party in Brightmoon that day and it would *apparently* be too difficult to change the date now.
>
> And of course, Castaspella had already been appointed to help organize the whole thing, so she happily suggested moving it all to Mystacor so she could prepare everything while the Queen and her friends were away. After the experience with the Guild Dance, Shadow Weaver knew it would be impossible to dissuade her and didn't even try, mostly because Glimmer accepted with a bit *too much* excitement.
>
> The woman was almost sure she knew all along about the mission and that the whole "it's an emergency, what am I gonna do?" was a shameless lie to lure her aunt into her meticulous trap. And so, knowing Castaspella would once again point out not everyone is as devious as her, she confronted the Queen without telling her.
>
> Curiously enough, *Shadow Weaver was right this time*.
>
> —I can't host this, I didn't have time to prepare presents as agreed, and I know we said Auntie would be the host next year, but I *really* need one more year to prepare properly!— she excused herself. —I-it's just a… little rearrangement!
>
> —And why not tell her the *truth*? You see, your majesty, it could be said you're acting a bit too much like me; if she were to find out…
>
> —Don't tell her! Please!

—I won't. I'm sure she wouldn't believe me— the woman assured her, still sounding a bit mischievous. But the tone was mostly to make her feel guilty as she said —Your aunt trusts you wouldn't ever do something so… *similar* to my ways.

—I-I just…

—You're lucky she has apparently been knitting sweaters for all of you the whole year. Otherwise, I *would* tell her just to avoid feeling her panic for having to rush it all— she warned her, taking advantage of her nervousness.

—Please don't. I-I will make it up to her. A-and she can ask my staff for help if she needs it. Just convince her to do so this time instead of trying to handle everything like she did with the Dance — she begged. Shadow Weaver had successfully guilt-tripped the Queen and couldn't help smirking. —And I'll tell dad to leave you both alone or-or I'll…

—Calm down. I already said I won't tell her. And forget about Micah. We can handle him— she finally interrupted, surprising Glimmer.

Said and done, Shadow Weaver stayed true to her word, mostly because it would be useless to snitch on the Queen. And so, the day came for everyone to visit Mystacor: the princesses, their friends… even Hordak.

She should have known it would happen. Princess Entrapta was invited, it was obvious that she would bring with her not only Shadow Weaver's former wards but also the clones that now lived with her. Even that annoying pest that had spied on her so many times…

Apparently, many had tried to convince her of leaving him at the Crypto Palace, claiming he would probably feel awkward at the party, *and he was*. But she "would never leave her lab partner alone".

Fortunately for Shadow Weaver, his discomfort meant he'd only interact with Entrapta and his clone; perhaps with Adora sometimes as she had been the one to give him another chance.

And interestingly enough, Castaspella and her council, her people, didn't seem the least bit happy to have Hordak around; the woman was almost delighted to notice as much and didn't bother concealing her annoyance due to his presence. But they were tolerant enough, so they always pointed out whenever she'd go overboard.

Hours went by without any issue other than Shadow Weaver's sulking, which the sorceress tried to handle by keeping her company and occasionally dragging her to "enjoy the party". She couldn't eat nor did she want to interact with anyone, but Castaspella was relentless.

And then, it was time for her, as the host, to give away the presents: Sweaters for everyone. For her niece and brother, of course, for Bow, Adora, Catra, Scorpia, Frosta, Perfuma, Entrapta, Spinnerella, Netossa… even Melog and Swift Wind got something akin to a sweater. She had also knitted a little decoration for Glimmer and Micah to place at Angella's memorial, for Adora and Catra something similar to the mask, as a token of appreciation for the borrowing of the real one…

But Hordak didn't get *anything*.

Once again, Shadow Weaver couldn't help but feel a morbid delight, especially since no one seemed to have noticed it. Until Entrapta made it obvious for everyone.

—Hordak!— the princess approached him, with a little excited bouncy movement. She had put on her fluffy violet sweater and enthusiastically asked —Aren't you going to wear yours!?

—I don't… have one— he admitted.

Shadow Weaver's laugh went unnoticed; even if she could hardly hear him as, opposite to Entrapta's loudness, he spoke more shyly, the woman was close enough to understand his words.

—Huh… that's weird. You've been so quiet all day, she must have missed you!— the princess suggested, far too optimistic.

Oh, *of course not*.

Castaspella had "finished" with all the sweaters about a week before and not even *once* considered making one for him; it had also slipped Shadow Weaver's mind, yet even if it hadn't, she certainly wouldn't have reminded her.

But Entrapta seemed so sure it wasn't the case… After all, she had literally made some for *animals* and for those no longer in their world. *How* would she have forgotten him, no? Being the representative of her kingdom, a grown mature woman, known for her diplomacy, she couldn't have been petty enough to do that, *no*?

This was a party to celebrate the anniversary of their emergent peace, the whole year that had passed, during which Entrapta reminded everyone he had "worked hard" to help with Etheria's reconstruction, including those places destroyed by himself…

Right! He had even helped Mystacor's levitation fields to be stable enough after the incident with the Crystal of Arxia; this even Shadow Weaver had witnessed.

But she had also noticed the sorceress entirely brushed it away after formally thanking them *all* in general.

Hah! Poor innocent princess. It was hard for the woman to believe she was almost the same age as Castaspella.

—It's fine. Just leave it— he tried to say, but Entrapta was already on her way to ask the Head Sorceress about it.

—'Scuse me! I think you forgot someone!— she immediately exclaimed, addressing Castaspella and interrupting her conversation with a councilor.

The sorceress immediately turned around and, ashamedly blushing, stammered —Oh! Well, I-I didn't… That is, I…

Shadow Weaver could hardly believe Entrapta's bright smile, and much less how it made Castaspella squirm and stammer. But it also seemed to please Hordak; even if he tried to hide it, she could recognize that expression from her own amusement moments before.

That little…

Oh, but he wasn't the only one.

Before the woman could so much as growl under her breath, she realized the rest of the guests seemed to be purposely ignoring the whole thing, except for Catra who was evidently enjoying the uncomfortable interaction and smirking shamelessly. Perhaps she had a good reason seeing how much she seemed to hate her sweater with that tiny kitten haphazardly hanging from a tree branch.

From behind her and with an impish tone, Shadow Weaver asked the sorceress —What now, woman? Can't talk your way out of this one…

—Ah, of course! Silly me… Just a moment…— she told them, composing herself instantly and adopting her usual cheerful attitude.

However, it was evident she was still panicking; her *bright* idea was to run back to her room, possibly to get him some present out of the blue, and Shadow Weaver couldn't help but follow her, both curious and amused.

—Do you expect to produce a sweater out of nowhere or what?

—Shut up!— the sorceress immediately replied.

She anxiously removed a bundle of threads and grabbed something black that she tucked under her arm before rushing out of the room once again. Apologizing profusely, she handed him the "sweater"… more like a black mess of wool.

—Huh. It's…

—Yes! Well! I… ah… wasn't sure what he might like! What you, uh… might like, so I… ah-ha…

The sorceress simply couldn't stop moving her hands nervously, looking away ashamedly and occasionally looking back at Hordak somewhat frantically.

The thing had *nothing* special. No embroidery, or details, symbols, designs, or anything the least bit meaningful… and she knew exactly why.

That was intended to be discarded, according to the sorceress, because it's the worst mess she had ever knitted in all her life.

And yet…

The princess looked delighted and her smile brightened along with her optimistic attitude as she said —Oh, of course; you just didn't have his measurements and preferences! Makes perfect sense. I mean, it's not like you'd make something for everyone else, *including me*, and intentionally leave Hordak out.

Did she hear right!?

Perhaps it wasn't exactly optimism? Had Entrapta purposely acted so innocent to make Castaspella feel either guilty or to push her to get him at least *something* as she just did?

If that was the case, then her wits deserved Shadow Weaver's full admiration.

—No… no, of course not!— she quickly replied. Glancing back at Shadow Weaver for a second, she added —Everyone is welcome. Mhmm!

She forcefully smiled at him as he curiously observed *the thing*, first with a half-disguised frown, possibly thinking about throwing it away later or perhaps giving it to his little flying creature.

Until his face completely changed. Flabbergasted, the woman gaped at him as he ran the material through his fingers, seemingly enthralled. And after a moment, as if no one were watching, he put it on without hesitation.

What on Etheria was going on!?

—Oh, by the blissfully vanquished light, it is delightful— he muttered, in a tone so low it made Shadow Weaver believe she misheard. How could he *possibly* like it enough to have put it on so shamelessly despite how ugly and shoddy it is? What could it be? The warmth? The softness of the material? Perhaps the sorceress charmed it at some point? No, that's so ridiculous… Or so she believed until he turned to Castaspella to say —This garment is exquisite. The material, the craftsmanship; both are highly sound.

Highly sound!? What!? She *must* have charmed it! The whole situation made no sense. That poor excuse of a sweater is the worst garment anyone could imagine! Sagging one side, too tight the other, so big in the collar… Someone like Hordak having it on feels like a fever dream; but, being dead, she's certainly *not* hallucinating.

And yet he looks so *delighted*! Comfortable even! No trace of his previous annoyance can be seen in his face anymore, and Shadow Weaver couldn't help but notice that Castaspella was in disbelief like her, while Catra's loud laughter filled the silent room.

But, in his delight, he remained oblivious of it all, even of Entrapta's squealing and gleeful eyes.

—I- it- It's not… I didn't…— the Head Sorceress stammered as soon as she was out of her shock, but got interrupted by the Princess' shriek.

—You like it!— she exclaimed, clutching his arm joyfully.

While Hordak smiled down at Entrapta, Shadow Weaver noticed how, behind them, Adora was slapping Catra's back as she seemed to be choking on her food. Well, she certainly understood why.

—Yes— he finally admitted, before looking back at Castaspella to give her a firm nod. He entirely ignored her fully red face or how her mouth remained agape, and simply added —Thank you.

—You're- You're welcome— she hesitantly replied.

As soon as they turned around to return with Wrong Hordak and the three ex-horde cadets, Castaspella looked back at Shadow Weaver, still as shocked as her, and promptly grabbed her by the arm to drag her outside to a balcony, to speak more privately.

—That… was something I *never* thought I would see— the woman admitted, while the Head Sorceress seemed on the verge of a nervous attack.

—I cannot *believe* that just happened! And-and what- How- Why- There's no way I just walked out of that unscathed!— she let out, her voice strained and her face practically on fire all the way

to her ears.

No wonder she wasn't freezing despite the supposedly frigid weather.

—While I can't feel the coolness at all, you can… Don't you think it would be better to agonize about this back in your room instead?— Shadow Weaver resignedly suggested. —I refuse to take care of you if you catch a cold, and despite giving a present to your brother, I don't think he'll be fine with seeing you any time soon.

—No, no. I-I need to cool down. I… just made a fool of myself in so many ways and narrowly escaped the worst situation I've ever been in since becoming Head Sorceress…

The woman approached her and rested her arms on the edge of the balcony next to Castaspella.

—Don't you think you're exaggerating a bit, Cas?

—No. Just… think about it: I've welcomed you with such ease, I *brought you here*, yet-yet I've been treating Hordak as if he didn't deserve the same basic respect, and even… dismissed him to the point of forgetting about him.

—And I would have simply left things like that; you did more than any of those fools of the council would have done if they were in your place— Shadow Weaver pointed out, feeling more and more annoyed as Castaspella's anxiety invaded her. —Yes, you were quite petty, or perhaps just a hypocrite. Who knows. *But*, while anyone else would have offered an apology and expect him to accept it, you went to the extreme of exposing yourself and that ugly abomination of a sweater, *just* to try and compensate him.
—O-of course! A-and I'll ask Princess entrapta for his measurements so I can knit a proper sweater for him— she sentenced, shaking her head a bit to dispel the fogginess in her mind. —I can't leave things like this— she insisted.

Shadow Weaver let out a deep sigh, irritated, and uttered —Much as I enjoy seeing you panic for going against your own words and everything you scold me for, I *seriously* can't tolerate this feeling anymore. Control yourself, Cas. You're already making up for your mistake!

—But…

—You tell me to just accept my mistakes and try to make up for it, well then, do the same— she interrupted her. —You're already planning to make up for it, no? Now just accept you messed up, and stop panicking!

—Fine! Fine. I'm sorry.

—Don't be, just relax before I go insane— Shadow Weaver pleaded, rolling her eyes and making Castaspella laugh.

A few days later, the Head Sorceress received a package with something like a screen and a letter; while the letter was the expected measurements for Hordak's sweater, extremely detailed much to Castaspella's surprise and delight, the screen thing contained a very funny video apparently recorded in the Crypto Castle by Entrapta's bot.

It began with Hordak looking for the ugly sweater yet finding it under his little creature, used as a nest, of course.

—Imp, return my sweater immediately.

Imp looks at him, and opens his mouth, using a random soldier's voice to say —It's mine. The only way you get it is if I'm dead.

Frustrated but resigned, he sighed deeply while pinching the bridge of his nose.

—Oh, that's adorable!— Castaspella commented.

—Of course you would find that annoying pest "adorable"— Shadow Weaver retorted, rolling her eyes.

Finally, Hordak grumbled —I have to finish the blueprints for the Fright Zone *today* and I cannot work if I am cold. I need my sweater back. You can go curl up in bed with Entrapta to stay warm.

—Hmm, nope. I don't think that is going to work Hordak— the imp let out, using Entrapta's voice followed by her laughter.

Increasingly annoyed, he scowled and reached for his sweater while insisting —This is not a game Imp. Return my sweater—. But before he could so much as brush it, Imp jumped and flew away, clutching the sweater with both hands. He immediately followed behind, angrily yelling —Imp! Give me back my sweater!

—No! Mine!— an unknown voice replied.

—Aw! Imp really likes it!

—You can be so silly sometimes. Fitting for the leader of the fools— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

—Oh, shut up!

Next in the video, Hordak kept chasing Imp around the room for a few more minutes before Entrapta appeared on screen from the side.

—Hordak, what are you in a tizzy about?

—Imp stole my sweater and he refuses to return it.

Immediately, Entrapta wraps Imp with her hair and pulls him down before he can successfully escape.

Imp finally relinquished the sweater and, using Catra's voice, let out —Fine, here's your stupid thing back.

—Did- Was that…

—Yes. Um… Do you remember her ever saying that?

—Plenty of times— Shadow Weaver admitted. Briefly raising her eyebrows while closing her eyes, she added —I should have expected it.

They continued watching as Entrapta let go of Imp before handing Hordak his sweater, and the little one flew into a vent from where he watched back at them, pouting.

—Thank you, Entrapta. I shall keep a closer eye on it so this will not happen again.

—Of course!— she beamed, smiling brightly at his partial smile. Right after, she propped herself with her hair, approached the camera, and exclaimed —Do you have it, Emily? Great! Download the file to the first pad you find! We are sending it to the Head Sorceress!

—Wait, what!?

Hordak's indignant question is the last thing they hear before the video ends, and Castaspella can't hold back a hearty laugh. On the contrary, Shadow Weaver kept herself silent, despite finding it all extremely amusing, and preferred not to say anything.

—Oh, let me write a reply to send with the new sweater.

—You're writing it now?— she questioned her, raising a brow in utter disbelief.

—Before I forget what I want to say!

While the sorceress grabbed what she needed to write, Shadow Weaver gave up and simply stood next to her at the desk, glancing at the small spiders that tried to call their attention.

A few weeks later, the sorceress sent her reply, thanking Entrapta profusely for providing such accurate measurements, and for the entertaining video. She also added she's glad that Hordak liked his sweater and that she hopes he will enjoy the new ones even more. Along with it, she sent not one but three new sweaters carefully wrapped in a package. The first one was also black, but this time decorated with red accents; the second one, a deep rich blue, similar to the color Hordak's body had before the arrival of Prime; the third one, matching with Entrapta, a dusky violet.

The same day, Castaspella received a reply from Entrapta where she told her that the first sweater went to Imp who immediately took it to his little bed, looking delighted. Along with it, she sent Imp's measures, assuring her that Hordak would like one for him too.

—You sent *three*!?

—Why else did you think it took me two full weeks to finish and send the package!?

—I was half sure you had thrown away the others and began a new one twice— Shadow Weaver admitted.

—I owed them— the sorceress replied. —Besides, there's also this other clone, Wrong Hordak, and the little Imp seemed to want one too! If I can do it, I don't see why not.

—Aren't you going overboard with this? I get that you feel guilty but…

—Oh, this isn't about that anymore— Castaspella interrupted her. —As I said, I don't see why not do it if I absolutely can, and… of course, I owe them, but there are plenty of different ways to repay my mistake. This was- I *wanted* to do it, I didn't feel obligated, you know?

Rolling her eyes, Shadow Weaver pointed out —Yes, you also wanted to knit something *for me*. It doesn't mean it's a good idea.

The sorceress laughed and shook her head, not even bothering to answer her.

Well, she had to admit such amusing events had, in fact, lightened up her mood quite a lot. And, in fact, she hadn't noticed before, but she felt a certain relief when Entrapta exposed Castaspella's hypocrisy.

She recalled how, before her death, the sorceress admitted it was hypocritical of them to treat her like a monster while expecting her *not* to act like one…

She had even apologized for it…

Yet Shadow Weaver had crafted for herself a little idyllic image of Castaspella and saw her as a perfectly sound, perfectly polite woman instead of the real flawed person she is. Just like the last time, she was remembering these little moments when her illusion was shattered: *she* had made Adora feel rejected; *she* had ignored Hordak in the same way Micah would ignore Shadow Weaver.

Ah, but that's the difference.

The sorceress, opposite to her brother or to herself, would then agonize about having done so and swiftly accept her mistake to properly make up for it. With Adora, she apologized immediately, and with Hordak and Entrapta she apologized and compensated them.

But what even could Beatrix do to make up for a lifetime of mistakes?

Yes, apologizing was probably necessary- No. Not *probably*; it was a *must*.

To Catra, Adora, Micah, Glimmer, perhaps even to her other wards and to Castaspella herself? Trying to think like the sorceress, perhaps she'd have to apologize to all of Etheria!

However, she now knows she has to do it, at least try, because she simply can't ignore how much it helped her to get that… extremely late apology from none other than Norwyn himself.

But if it took him decades within the core of Etheria as a damned… just how long could it take *her*!?

Now Light Spinner wanted, *really* wanted, to do something… Saying "sorry" would hardly be enough, but that was probably what Castaspella would call "the first step". So, what else then?

Should she ask the sorceress? Would it be stupid?

She'd probably sound so ridiculous…

But she had repeated many times she wouldn't judge, and it was *exactly this* what she wanted from her.

Then she'll have to ask Castaspella for some guidance, no? And probably for a few suggestions on how to swallow down her pride as she did back in that party.

Chapter End Notes

Once again, all credits to this marvel of a post because I can't express enough just how *good* that masterpiece is!! Please! I laughed for so long! I still do!
And, I love that it's a perfect exposition of one of Casta's flaws: the occasional hypocrisy. Along with the occasional guilt-tripping and her absolute obliviousness of people's boundaries, this is a rarely-addressed issue of hers and it's actually a good way to show SW yet again that her belief that Casta is all perfect as a person, as if at a different level SW simply can't reach, is bullshit; aka, it shows SW that everyone has flaws and everyone can choose to be better and make up for that, learn to accept it, admit the mistakes, take responsibility. Casta doesn't go throwing accusations and blaming others, at least not in this case, which is what SW still need to learn.

Also also
If you read the Tumblr post, you may have realized I kept most of Hordak's thoughts there, but still from SW's pov and, well, the thing is, she's *guessing* someone else's thoughts or simply has the same opinion. But, funny enough, you may have noticed there are some thoughts she guesses as Entrapta's (like the disbelief at Casta's "oopsie"), which are Hordak's thoughts actually, aka, it was SW's mistake there heh
Point being: Instead of a mere copy-paste of the idea, I decided to make it canon within my fic, and this is how the situation would look like from SW's pov.

Memories - Part 1

Chapter Summary

With Princess Entrapta's help, little by little a new source of hope lights up for the Head Sorceress. However, there's something even more valuable for Castaspella, extremely annoying at times, but absolutely priceless.

»For the first time since her summoning, Shadow Weaver had explicitly requested her help with learning to apologize. At first, she thought it was a prank, yet she insisted it was “dead serious”.
(…)
»—Why were you asking if you knew!?
»—To annoy you, of course.
»The Head Sorceress huffed and finally managed to stand up; she immediately looked away and crossed her arms in front of her chest but, in an instant, the woman was standing right in front of her.
»—Stars! What- Bea!

Chapter Notes

Now yes, the actual chapter! Or half of it... at least.

I'm confusing myself with the timeline, even with the flashbacks, so again I'll be splitting the flashback too...
Ugh, I barely comprehend myself right now

Hopefully, you'll enjoy this chapter and its next part, and I *know* you'll like the flashbacks, it was someone's genius idea here heh... I just don't know if you'll understand the context because I myself keep struggling with that.

Sorry for the ramble, here you are! Enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Early morning in Mystacor. Clouds covered the sky, making the floor slippery with morning dew, and the air humid, filled with tiny droplets of a few clouds that surrounded the higher storeys of the buildings. The Head Sorceress promptly got ready to leave, and had a quick breakfast before teleporting directly to Dryll’s citadel. She was immediately welcomed by a few service bots and taken to Entrapta’s laboratory.

—Morning, Head Sorceress!— the princess exclaimed, waving from a distance. With her hair, she propped herself closer and added —Thank you for coming all the way here. We have all the data as promised, we just can’t move it anywhere else for the time being.

—It’s no problem at all, Princess— she calmly replied.

However, Entrapta was already working with the computers in front of her, tapping keys at the speed of light and looking from one screen to the other.

—Here we have the readings of the groove. In two months, my equipment has gathered enough information to calculate the exact frequency of the magical energy they store— she began. The princess then turned around and looked amazed, extending her arms over her head as she explained — The amount is insane! Huge! It's at least a quarter of the total strength the Heart of Etheria had!

—Is it… a channel?

—Exactly! Big enough it allows that massive energy to leak out onto the surface at a tolerable pace, opposite to how the activation of the Heart would have blown the whole planet by forcing it all out— she clarified.

—So… Can we *work* with this?

—Perhaps— Entrapta replied, pensive. —There's a chance this energy allows storing in other media, but unless I can isolate the frequency of the subject in question…

—The *subject* has a name— Castaspella interrupted.

—Of course! I was just speaking in general terms.

The princess's sheepish smile made the sorceress giggle and she allowed her to continue.

For a few hours, they discussed a series of theories, each pointing out either technological or magical restrictions, until they finally decided to collect a few more samples, specifically tailored to Shadow Weaver.

—How many chances…

—The probability of success has risen to seventy-eight percent since you gave me more specific data — Entrapta interrupted. —With the new calibrations, my devices should be able to collect more data from Shadow Weaver's magical firm and allow us to isolate the information.

—Perfect. You tell me when and we can go to install them.

—Then let's go! There's no time to waste!

—Actually— a voice interrupted behind them. They turned around to find Loonie and Wrong Hordak approaching. —We have a few problems and need your help *now*, Princess— Lonnie sentenced. —A few more minutes and we'll be freezing back there; Imp is throwing a tantrum about it.

Entrapta laughed nervously as she looked back at Castaspella.

—Perhaps I miscalculated— she let out, apologetic.

—Please, don't worry. As I said, just tell me when you can, Princess.

—I will! See you soon!

—Alright. From the beginning again.

The Head Sorceress was down at the groove for the twentieth time that month. The few people in Mystacor who knew why, were entirely unable to understand *how* she could be so perseverant, but she was.

And she had a good reason…

For the first time since her summoning, Shadow Weaver had explicitly requested her help with learning to apologize. At first, she thought it was a prank, yet she insisted it was “dead serious”.

—Fine…— she groaned. —To apologize to Catra, I have to…— she began, hesitating and gesturing with her hand while rolling her eyes, as if dismissive of what she was going to say. —Acknowledge that I was… projecting?

—Yes…

—And that she didn’t deserve it…

—Yes…

—Despite behaving like a disrespectful brat.

—Beatrix!

Castaspella’s annoyed tone had become normal for Shadow Weaver after so many times, and hardly had any impact, especially since she felt the sorceress was being too lenient with her.

—It’s a fact.

—It’s uncalled for! You’re supposed to be apologizing! Not reproaching *anything*!— she began, indignant. —Besides, I’ve told you plenty of times: disrespectful or not, we’re talking about a kid, a teenager; that so-called “disrespectful” behaviour is normal, to be expected from someone her age, and absolutely doesn’t justify threats or torture of any kind!

With another dismissive gesture, she looked away as she added —Empty threats to keep her obedient. I would have *never* disposed of her or let Hordak do so. But her behaviour was a sure ticket to Beast island!

—She thought you would kill her! You *explicitly* told her that, if it wasn’t for Adora, you would have…

—I know what I said!— Shadow Weaver interrupted, angrily approaching the sorceress with her fists tightly closed. —I recall every word I told them. Every threat, every lie, and everything I said to convince them they had to be the best or resign to uselessness!

—But why!?

—Because that’s how the Horde worked! Only if you’re perfect, useful, a necessary weapon, could you be safe from…

—I understand— Castaspella interrupted. —But you didn’t have to adhere to such thinking. You didn’t have to treat them like literal weapons… Did you really think of them like that? I- I don’t understand how you could see Etheria as a living creature instead of a weapon but couldn’t do the

same with Adora! Or Catra!— she continued, more pained than indignant. —I- Why!? You said it yourself! “Everything the Guild told us was wrong”, and so was the Horde! None of you were weapons that had to be perfect… O-only living beings with… all the mortal flaws we are subject to…

The sorceress looked down, her hands pressed over her heart, and a tense silence settled for a long moment.

—Because I was blind? Bitter? How did you call me? Petty? I suppose that applies too— Shadow Weaver admitted, looking away. —Because I didn’t care. Even now… I don’t know if I care.

Castaspella immediately looked up with a sorrowful expression and took a hesitant step forward as she pointed out —If you didn’t care now, you wouldn’t have asked for my help nor would you have put so much effort into it during this month.

—Yet I can’t accept the basics— she uttered between her teeth, furious at herself. —I am… useless for this.

—No, no— the sorceress immediately replied, putting a hand on her shoulder. —We’re just starting and… your mindset is *extremely* engraved into your whole personality now. To break free from it requires so much work, Bea, so don’t be frustrated just now; this is the first step of a long way and you’re bound to have plenty of obstacles— she insisted, keeping a gentle tone. —Please don’t give up yet. Allow yourself some more time to improve, and be patient. Could you… trust yourself just a bit more?

Keeping her back to Castaspella and her sight fixed on the ground, Shadow Weaver asked —Why do *you* have so much trust in me? How can you be so… *so stubborn*?

—Bea… I just know there’s no point in expecting immediate results. That’s unrealistic. And I understand this is part of your worldview, so I’m not giving up until you manage to shatter those stupid beliefs that keep bringing you down!

Suddenly turning back to face her again, Shadow Weaver grabbed the Head Sorceress’s arms tightly and exclaimed, in a shaky voice, —It’s useless! I am *not* worth the effort!

—Yes, you are!

—No one thinks so!

—I do!

—Then you’re a fool!

—Not more than you for rejecting the only person who believes in you!

—Then let me be a fool! Let me *die*!

—I am *not* abandoning you! I won’t let this stupid mindset of yours take you away from me again!

Immediately letting go of her, Shadow Weaver took a couple of steps back with an unrecognizable expression.

—Why?

—Why not?

—What if your brother is right?

—He's not— Castaspella sentenced, approaching her again with absolute confidence. —I refuse to believe that someone who doesn't know the first thing about you *or me* can possibly be right.

—His view just isn't biased as yours— she tried to argue.

—Oh no, no. His view is absolutely biased, and by the worst of reasons— she sentenced, finally stopping a breath away from Shadow Weaver. —Right now, you're the fool, the stubborn one. Jus- Just accept the fact that I will *not* give up on you unless you prove to be the monster you think you are!

Looking away, she placed her hand on the sorceress's shoulder instead and pushed her back slightly.

—Then stay away. Your stubbornness is contagious…

Castaspella couldn't help but laugh wholeheartedly and barely covered her mouth to hold back a cackle.

—Oh, no. If that's the case, I'll be sticking around. And you can't do anything about it— she replied, smiling smugly. Apparently satisfied with herself, she skillfully teleported a blanket and a box with some dinner she had prepared herself. —You're not getting rid of me.

—And here I thought you were about to leave…

—Not at all.

—I can't feel how chilly the night is, but don't you think this time of the year is still too cold out in the open? You'll freeze that little brain of yours— Shadow Weaver argued, smirking at the end.

—Well, this blanket should suffice. I mean, it's not exactly a warm night but it's nowhere as cold as a few months ago, especially because warmer nights will soon begin— Castaspella countered, entirely ignoring her mockery. Then, suddenly excited, she added —Oh! I'll be able to stay every night!

—Oh no…

—Oh *yes*!

—Please return me to the torture of the core…— she uttered, exaggerating a suffering tone.

—Very funny— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes as she approached a tree to sit down and have dinner.

In fact, Shadow Weaver wouldn't admit it but… she didn't want to return to the core.

Not yet, not any time soon.

But the pain that space caused her wasn't the reason, it had never mattered to her. The problem now was something she wouldn't dare mention to Castaspella. After all, it would be like a little kid going to their parents when they can't face and solve their own problems.

No. This was something *she* had to fix on her own.

And she would… once she saw that *princess* again.

Quite early the following morning, the Head Sorceress woke up at the groove, curled up under the blanket and resting on Shadow Weaver's lap, once again. Groggy, she raised a bit, struggling to open her eyes, and let out a groan as she felt her body aching terribly. With a smirk, the woman helped her sit up, solely to mock Castaspella.

—You just *had* to stay again, right? Despite knowing perfectly well that you're hardly fit to sleep on the hard ground.

—Yeah, yeah… I know— she grumbled. —I'm a fool…

—Yes. I swear I don't understand you sometimes…

—Then don't.

Surprised by her grumpy tone, Shadow Weaver stared at her, confused, but said nothing for a long moment. Upon noticing the sorceress remained unmoving, just sitting there and staring at the ground, half-asleep, she rolled her eyes and decided to speak up.

—Go, now. Have breakfast before your poor little brain melts.

—Shut up— she let out, before yawning. —I'm just… sore.

—With such a hard head one would think it was impossible— Shadow Weaver retorted, smirking once more.

—Can you *please* stop!?

—No.

—You're just trying to push me to leave, aren't you?

—Not quite, but that's a good idea— she replied, with a fake innocent tone and expression. Looking back at Castaspella, she keept smirking and added —It's good to know your brain actually remains intact.

—Bitch!

The sorceress immediately tried to stand up, only to fall back to the ground, making Shadow Weaver cackle in full earnest. It was such a rare event that she couldn't help but stare at the woman, noticing her so at ease for once. However, by the time she looked down at Castaspella again, she was still staring and it took her a moment too long to look away and pretend nothing happened.

—What were you looking at?

—Nothing…

—Don't take me for a fool… What were you looking at with that moronic smile?

—*Moronic*!? What on Etheria!? Bea!

Satisfied with the reaction she got, Shadow Weaver grinned smugly and folded her arms as she admitted —I know it's a rare sight to see me laugh but you could try to be more subtle, no?

—Why were you asking if you knew!?

—To annoy you, of course.

The Head Sorceress huffed and finally managed to stand up; she immediately looked away and crossed her arms in front of her chest but, in an instant, the woman was standing right in front of her.

—Stars! What- Bea!— she exclaimed, startled.

—Am I that scary?

—Please, I just wasn't expecting that.

—I won't be offended if you find me frightening…

Looking back at her, she raised a brow and asked —Do you *want me* to fear you?

—Why would I- I just meant… I wouldn't mind since I *purposely* try to be scary. So it wouldn't exactly be insulting— Shadow Weaver replied, turning around mid-sentence and gesturing dismissively with a hand.

From behind, Castaspella approached and grabbed her shoulder, only to stand tiptoe and whisper in her ear —Good luck with that, I haven't been scared of you in a long time now…

With a little giggle and pretending innocence, the sorceress finally farewelled and left the groove, promptly returning to Mystacor.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: Lonnie's interruption near the beginning was, in fact, for me to correct an insignificant detail I almost overlooked from my og plan for the plot. That is, I wasn't planning on writing about the installation, only about the recovery of the installed gadgets, so I needed some good excuse for the 1 month time-skip.
So it seemed like a good idea to insert an intervention similar to what my brain did when I reread the plot plan... ehe!

Erm, so, it may serve as a reference: the following chapter, the flashback, happens after the ending of the second part of this chapter, which you've yet to read <("^_^) So you may be a bit lost for a while...

I think that was all I had to say for this chapter, I actually can't remember, my head is in shambles...
~~Maybe because I'm an idiot and forgot to take my medicine, only to remember that now, at 3.30pm~~

Well! I hope you liked the chapter! Until next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: [ERROR]
Status: Extremely enraged

Chapter Notes

Well! Lemme begin by saying: the error message is because...
...
U will learn soon.
Hehe

Then, for reference, because I finally understood how the timeline works:
The first silhouettes appeared the first week of the month right after the beginning of the previous chapter, when Casta and Entrapta go to install the devices with the new config.
The following weeks mentioned there are all before Casta goes to see her again before the end of that same chapter.
That's enough explanation without spoilers, I believe...

Now, let the headcanons begin!! I hope you enjoy these little ideas of mine!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The immense nothingness around her had been quite off for the last few weeks. She couldn't understand what was happening, but it was *maddening*. And sure enough, it made these reminiscences unbearable for her, to the point it became increasingly difficult to stop the sporadic stings of pain from invading her.

She did not want to relieve these old memories, there was *nothing* to reflect on, nothing of interest, nothing to observe. Only her failures and suffering, experiences she knew would tempt her to justify her behaviour when, in fact, they don't. So she had absolutely no interest in them.

But this abyss made sure she'd recall these moments…

Silhouettes began appearing; running kids, tutors imparting classes… Her past in Mystacor. For weeks, that was all she could see and if she didn't observe the memory herself, the shadows would still represent it for her to watch.

She just couldn't do anything about it…

The figure of a pair of young pupils had appeared in front of her a few weeks earlier. They passed by her and approached their Master. Those were young Nolrem and herself, and their Master… was Norwyn.

It forced her to recall this moment: she was being tested and failed one basic spell she had forgotten. Beatrix was a very skilled kid yet sometimes she was so focused on more advanced sigils that she'd lose practice and mess up the basic ones.

And Norwyn couldn't be more pissed. The young man was quite adamant about following the class' rhythm, yet Beatrix kept aiming higher.

—Have I not been clear?— the silhouette spoke. Its voice sounded eerie, but it was undoubtedly his voice. —You do not *practice new spells until the most basic sigils are always, and I mean* always, *cast perfectly! Exam failed!*

Shadow Weaver's rage upon hearing him rose immediately. That man…

Of course, he had now apologized for this, but she couldn't help hearing herself in such words. She had become him, hadn't she? And, as she thought back then, she turned even *worse* than him even.

While the figure of young Beatrix stood there in silence, looking to the ground and focusing on keeping her composure, behind her, there was young Nolrem with a conflicted expression.

Beatrix had forgotten he had been her classmate, even though she recalled knowing him, this had completely slipped her mind.

His shadow hesitantly moved and his high-pitched voice asked Norwyn —Bu-but why? She-she's only trying to learn more… A-and her spell wasn't that bad…

—That's enough…

—But…

—Nollaris! I said that's enough!

He finally stepped back, looking down just like little Beatrix, and nodded resignedly. Shortly after, once Norwyn's silhouette walked away and vanished, her little self turned around to face Nolrem.

—Why did you try to defend me? He's never going to listen!

—Be-because you're… better than me— he admitted, looking down. —I- What will he say if I ever fuck up? I-I'm just a… mediocre sorceress… I- No. I'm no sorceress yet…

—But you will be. Only *if you start being more assertive! You're… ugh, so indecisive…*

Both figures sighed and walked away, promptly vanishing too.

A few days later, after more shadows appeared and vanished in front of her, the same two showed up once more, teenagers now. They seemed to be having a casual conversation which, once again, she could hardly recall. She genuinely forgot these interactions but, in fact, it now made more sense that he called her "Light Spinner" and held her in such high regard…

—So, Nol…?

—"Nolrem".

—Nolrem, fine. And… you now want a surname, no?

—Yeah— he let out, looking a bit shyer than before. —I've been asking everybody but… I don't know…

Young Beatrix couldn't help but laugh amusedly while saying —Always so unsure… You still haven't changed… Poor you—. Her teasing only made him even timider and she couldn't help laughing again. But then it seemed like she had an idea and suddenly said —Wait, that's it! You're always so indecisive, the perfect surname would be "Incertus"!

—That's- I- Oh, I like it!— he admitted.

Right after, she patted his head, giggled, and teased —Aw, little Inny…

Young Nolrem, increasingly ashamed, probably blushing deeply at being mocked by her, looked away hesitantly yet wouldn't dare say anything.

And before Beatrix could see what happened next, the figures vanished.

That week, she was left thinking about this memory and could only feel fond of it.

How had she forgotten him if they were, apparently, such good friends? And she had even given him his new surname! Why, then, couldn't she remember any of this? She only recalled him from the council as he was one of their messengers and had become Norwyn's favored acolyte and assistant.

So now, Light Spinner was, for the first time, wishing she could remember more.

That was the reason why, the following week, she eagerly watched as these shadows showed her the events she had forgotten. They appeared as always and set up a whole scene in front of her, which this time she carefully observed.

Nolrem was now a few years older and was walking past a room before suddenly stopping and returning to peek inside. There, a young-adult Beatrix was frantically studying a series of sigils from three different scrolls.

Beatrix saw his silhouette slowly approach hers from behind before clearing his throat to call her younger self's attention.

—What are you doing here, Inny?

—I- Excuse me, Light Spinner— he began, clearing his throat again out of nervousness. —I know we haven't talked in a while… I see you have been… busy.

—And I still am.

—I- Well… Wouldn't you prefer to take a short break? Clear your head…

—No, I can't. I need to perfect this.

—But you haven't left this place in so long… No one has seen you in days.

—I need *to practice! I have* no time *to waste! I* must *be perfect lest I disappoint my Masters!*

—You're already more than good enough, Light Spinner.

—"Good enough" won't do! I have *to be* perfect*!*

—I… understand…

He sighed and looked down, giving up. Perhaps he really understood, but it was clear in his expression that he didn't agree at all.

The figures then vanished and Beatrix was left thinking…

But she didn't like her reflections at all; they only made her extremely angry.

These cursed silhouettes…

Beatrix had no idea when they would stop, but their origin picked her interest. Perhaps she should mention them to Castaspella?

No, no.

These must be that Princess' fault… She had to discuss it directly with her…

But she couldn't help thinking they had been representing her memories in somewhat of a chronological order…

So what if…?

Hopefully no…

All Light Spinner could do was wish they wouldn't shove in her face *that* one event…

Chapter End Notes

Yes, you read that right

And, gotta thank (again) Bitzy Bee for the idea of "how was Beatrix's childhood?" for this heh After all, this was a perfect opportunity to explain a couple of things, I guess, like why Nolrem admires LS/SW so much, and the whys of his particular pov of the whole situation. You know, what he did for Sahm for instance. As he saw LS succumb, he now tries not to repeat his mistakes...

Oh, and the "focused on advanced sigils and failed the basic ones" is based on my own experience with like, school subjects, from math to sciences, even languages. I was good at those and usually tried to go faster than others, but many times I'd end up floundering with more basic stuff I was supposed to be learning at the time with the rest of the class...

As I've said before, I used to be a lot like LS...
Oh my, and before I forget, while it does look like Nolrem has a crush on LS, honestly it was more that huge admiration u may confuse with crushing on someone (it could count as an intellectual crush, if anything). The guy ended up being gay XD and you'll maybe know one of his exes one day... when I reach that part of the fic, ofc

AAAHH
I forgot:
Erm, while I've always disliked Tik Tok, my clone convinced me of opening one and, as I had it there, all empty, I decided to start uploading vids showing my art so... if you're interested...

Memories - Part 2

Chapter Summary

With Entrapta's little gadgets working at full speed, the tests are almost complete. There's just a final week to go, and it will be done. However, Shadow Weaver is still wary, and angry, which makes the Princess' work more difficult.
While the Head Sorceress can handle her, she also has her own problems to attend to, which have taken all of her time this last week…

» In the following days, while her classes had become quite complicated as Shadow Weaver's pupils advanced more, there were also a series of official matters that kept her awake several nights. Along with it, the woman felt even more stings of pain than the previous weeks but, no matter how worried for her she was, Castaspella had absolutely no time to visit Shadow Weaver at all.
» However, the week came to an end and the sorceress finally had a night of sleep after a taxing class. She felt drained and almost immediately fell asleep as soon as she hit the bed, thinking about how different the classes used to be months ago.

Chapter Notes

You guys!! I didn't have to rush this chapter either!! I'm so happy!! I even have time to continue working on the ending of Dark Temptation!! XD
Oh, and this Friday it's my b-day, hehe, so this is good, not having all the anxiety of previous weeks the very week of my b-day... (no joke, my b-date is 9/9/99... I kid you not)

Anyways, here you'll have the answer to why the previous flashback had an error message; after all, as SW said, she had nothing to learn from those memories replayed by the silhouettes, it was more like a walk down memory line... Oh, but why, u may wonder, is she seeing these figures? And are they the same as that shadow of Norwyn she saw? Well, not exactly, and no, it is not really explained in this chapter; perhaps the next one explains more, and only in the next flashback will there be a shadow like Norwyn's but it's someone else...

Okay, no more pseudo-spoilers. Please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After staying the night at the groove, much to Shadow Weaver's annoyance, as she had expressed, Castaspella woke up early, as soon as the sun shone between the leaves above them. First thing in the morning, they both had yet another light-hearted banter, until the sorceress decided to leave.

—I won't be offended if you find me scary…

Looking back at her, she raised a brow and asked —Do you *want me* to fear you?

—Why would I- I just meant… I wouldn't mind since I *purposely* try to be scary. So it wouldn't exactly be insulting— Shadow Weaver replied, turning around mid-sentence and gesturing dismissively with a hand.

From behind, Castaspella approached and grabbed her shoulder, only to stand tiptoe and whisper in her ear —Good luck with that, I haven't been scared of you in a long time now…

With a little giggle and pretending innocence, the sorceress finally farewelled and left the groove, promptly returning to Mystacor.

Less than an hour after her arrival, and just as she finished her breakfast, the Head Sorceress was informed that Princess Entrapta had arrived and was looking for her. She remembered they agreed to check on her devices that day in case any adjustments had to be made, so she quickly disposed of everything and went to meet the princess.

Soon enough, they arrived at the groove and Shadow Weaver didn't take long to show up.

—Back so soon?— she let out, her sight fixed on Castaspella.

The sorceress' unamused expression didn't betray how much it ashamed her that she said it in front of Entrapta, yet it seemed like the princess wasn't listening or, perhaps, hadn't understood.

—Enough with that, we have things to do here…

—And *I* have to speak with her— Shadow Weaver pointed out, gesturing towards Entrapta.

—You *better* keep it civil. She's…

—Helping, I know— she interrupted. Rolling her eyes, she approached the princess, who was tinkering with a screen between her hands, and asked —What exactly are your little trinkets here doing?

—Oh, you mean me!? Right! These devices are means to collect data for our investigation. Specifically *your* data, in an attempt to decode your specific magical firm and differentiate it from the core's magical firm.

Utterly confused, Shadow Weaver only said —Those things… are doing *what* to me!? Because since you installed them, weird figures have been haunting me down at the core.

—Is that so?— the princess asked. —That's an unexpected development! The devices may be influencing the magic here and causing it to condense images— she reflected. Right after, she looked back at Shadow Weaver and asked —Can you describe those figures?

—They are like shadows. And they project memories of mine, even things I can't remember, by means of said shadows, forming silhouettes to set where it happened and who was involved. They even talk.

—Huh… So they project memories. Yes, it could be related to my devices.

—It *must*! It didn't happen before, so do *not* try to fool me! What are you doing!?

—A-ah- No-nothing! I told you what my devices do!— Entrapta replied, noticeably scared as she partially hid her face behind her screen. While Castaspella approached from behind, she added —This is an unexpected effect, and it's nothing harmful! I-it shouldn't affect you further if I- Just allow me to make a few modifications…

—What's going on here? Didn't I tell you to keep it civil?— the sorceress reproached her.

—It's no use if this *princess* doesn't tell the truth! She hasn't told us everything!

—It's awful, no?— Castaspella let out, folding her arms and arching a brow.

However, Shadow Weaver only rolled her eyes and said —Don't start…

—Look. She only needs to collect data more specific to you in order to, perhaps, develop something that can keep you here at the surface without my presence or that of the girls… Something to, you know, replace the mask— she explained. —Just allow her. It can't hurt you more…

—Fine— she reluctantly agreed. After the sorceress nodded at Entrapta and the princess left, she looked back at Castaspella to add —So you have felt it?

—The stings of pain? Yes, they haven't stopped but now they feel stronger again…

—Because I *cannot* control my emotions at all when seeing those… things.

—Why didn't you tell me? If it's been happening the whole month…

—Not your business. This was to be discussed with that princess.

—Well, *that princess* is your best shot at finally being free of that pain and permanently returning to the surface. You could be a bit more respectful or, at the very least, less aggressive.

—There it is!— Entrapta suddenly exclaimed, approaching them from behind, jumping slightly by means of her hair. She then moved her mask down and looked at her screen, saying —All the devices have been adjusted. In a week I can return to collect the results.

—Perfect!— Castaspella immediately replied, smiling happily and joining both hands in front of her in a little celebrating gesture.

—I-I promise it's all safe— the princess added, wary.

—Right, right— Shadow Weaver uttered, looking away. —Then I suppose you can now leave.

—Of course. I won't annoy you anymore— she accepted and, without hesitation, propped herself up with her hair and practically run away.

When the woman looked back at Castaspella, the sorceress looked visibly angry, both hands firmly plated at both sides of her hips.

—What's wrong with you!?

—I believe we had already established that *a lot* is wrong with me.

—Don't try to mock me now. I'm being serious.

—Alright. I'm just pissed with all I've seen.

—Want to tell me about it?

—No.

With a grunt, the Head Sorceress turned around and attempted to leave, uttering —Nevermind then.

—Tell your councilman, Nolrem Incertus, that I remember him from when we studied together…

She stopped in her tracks and turned around with a shocked expression.

—You two studied together?

She nodded and explained —I couldn't remember before but we both were Norwyn's first pupils when the man had just begun teaching. I also had more Masters, but he was the first one.

—I see… Well, I'll tell him— Castaspella accepted.

After that, she finally left and began one of the most hectic weeks in Mystacor.

In the following days, while her classes had become quite complicated as Shadow Weaver's pupils advanced more, there were also a series of official matters that kept her awake several nights. Along with it, the woman felt even more stings of pain than the previous weeks but, no matter how worried for her she was, Castaspella had absolutely no time to visit Shadow Weaver at all.

However, the week came to an end and the sorceress finally had a night of sleep after a taxing class. She felt drained and almost immediately fell asleep as soon as she hit the bed, thinking about how different the classes used to be months ago.

> The class that day had been what Castaspella would call a catastrophic disaster. A vial had exploded, the pupils had been endangered, and it was all her fault.
>
> She should have been more attentive. After all, the pupils' well-being is *her* responsibility.
>
> She arrived at her room seething with anger and directly entered the bathroom, slamming the door behind her. She had been as calm as possible when handling the aftermath, had all the pupils leave, cleaned everything up with *some* help from Shadow Weaver and a pair of acolytes… But the frustration! It was unbearable.
>
> As soon as she arrived at her room, she dropped the façade and allowed herself to express that anger and frustration.
>
> A while after, once she was bathed and sitting on the edge of the bathtub, trying to collect herself, she heard a knock on the door. And only one person could get into her room just like that…
>
> —Cas? Are you there?
>
> —Don't come in. I'm naked.

—May I remind you I have the same body as you? You have nothing I haven't seen in myself— she insisted.

Exasperated, Castaspella replied –Fine! Do whatever the fuck you want!

The woman opened the door with a clearly surprised expression and didn't try to be the slightest bit gentle as she criticized her —Mopping on the floor?

But the sorceress wasn't exactly in the mood to be gentle either.

—What do you care?

—You *never* lose it like this. Or, apparently, just in private, I see— Shadow Weaver noted. —Still, it's clearly not normal, so *what* happened to you?— she asked, sounding genuinely concerned. —And think nothing about your state, I don't care about naked bodies in the slightest.

—Don't you see? You couldn't even respect my privacy here…

—Right now, I believe your *privacy* doesn't matter as much as you breaking down like this— she retorted. —I'm feeling it all here, you know?

—Well, congratulations!— she exclaimed, sarcastic. —You have *finally* learnt what empathy is like. Or, I'm sorry, I guess. Whatever…

—You're worse than I expected…

With a frown, she retorted —Just go back to being apathetic and leave me alone.

—Hah! I'd like to do so, but no. I suppose I owe it to you, so allow me to help— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Fine— she sighed.

—Erm… ho-how can… how do I- what can I do to help?— the woman hesitated.

Laughing slightly, Castaspella replied —It's clear you *really* want to help. I wonder if it's only because this is hurting you too.

In her expression, there was a certain conflict.

Perhaps she *did* care?

But if that were the case, then she just convinced herself it had to be because it hurts her too.

—Sure… But it can still benefit you, no?

—Alright— she sighed once more. —I just… when the vial exploded… Can you tell me what I did wrong? It is *very* frustrating… Failing like this and endangering my own people…

—Accidents happen. Why is this so important?

—May I remind you I couldn't even stop you from almost taking down our shield five years ago? I can't- I should be able to ensure Mystacor's safety. So what, just what am I doing wrong!?

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh, perhaps understanding, and explained —Let me first tell you: what happened with the shield was entirely out of your control. I know that ritual well enough; it meant your whole focus and energy was on handling the eclipse's extra energy, I knew you wouldn't be in shape to do anything about me even if you were as skilled as Micah. I'm not stupid, I took some precautions which, along with interrupting the ritual were *perfect*. As much as I like mocking you about it, it really wasn't your fault. Anyone would have failed there.

—And the vial exploding now?

The sorceress held her head in both hands, supporting its weight with her elbows firmly set on her legs. Such a picture may have made the woman a bit more lenient and so she put more emphasis on the incidental nature of what happened.

—That's… just an *accident*. Could have been prevented, yes, but I guess that's on me. I knew it could happen by leaving it unattended, but… I said nothing… perhaps I just didn't care, perhaps I wanted to see what you'd do in that case— she began, dismissive. However, Castaspella's furious look made her add —Or maybe it genuinely slipped my mind *despite* having the knowledge of such danger. This was *merely* an accident.

However the sorceress only looked away and mumbled —So this is just me not being skilled like Micah, no?

Castaspella looked back just in time to see her roll her eyes while groaning —How on Etheria can you be meaner at yourself than me?

Well, she was right about that.

—Ju-just… drop it, Bea. I don't think anything can help me right now.

—Perhaps it is you who has to drop the self-loathing…

—I can't believe you're actually trying to make me feel better yet still can't *not* be mean at the same time!— she retorted, straightening her back and glaring at her with annoyance.

—It would sound fake if I didn't, wouldn't it?— she let out, smirking. With a short laugh, she added —Come on, just make yourself presentable now; then I'll take you on a round of deck fights. Apparently you're *not* that sloppy at it.

Finally cheered up, she gave her a smug look and replied —Still won't admit I'm just better than you?

—You're… skilled at that, and *lucky* enough to beat me.

—I haven't lost to you even once!— she confidently reminded her.

—Perhaps today's the day— Shadow Weaver defied her, laughing again. She then left the bathroom while saying —I'll wait outside.

Once back in the room, Castaspella was still mulling over that phrase Shadow Weaver used as an excuse, not caring about naked bodies in the slightest, resolved to ask her about it. However, she sorely regret it shortly after: it began like a normal explanation of how she feels nothing in particular when watching naked bodies, but then she decided to elaborate on tiny silly particularities related to anatomy that immediately led to a more uncomfortable conversation which the sorceress had to interrupt before her face went redder than ever.

And yet, Castaspella had to admit she found it quite amusing; on her way to the door, she playfully bumped her hips against Shadow Weaver's, saying —Come on now, *I'll beat you on a round of deck fights*.

That morning, the Head Sorceress woke up happy yet crying.

She missed those simple moments, and the silly discussions, even the uncomfortable moments. Perhaps she should take the decks to the groove one day…

A few hours later, after having her breakfast, Castaspella met with princess Entrapta as they had arranged, and they both went down to the woods. But what awaited left them in utter shock: as soon as they were close enough for her summoned form to surface, Shadow Weaver charged at them, fuming.

—You, *Princess*, owe me an explanation!

Chapter End Notes

SO
Now you may wonder, why is SW so angry??
Well, here's the thing, the flashbacks of that last week in which Casta couldn't visit her will give you the answer, ehe

So, sorry for the suspense...
And, ofc, I cut the chapter there so you can understand their whole discussion after the next flashback.

Also, the "more uncomfortable conversation" right at the ending of Casta's memory, well, I planned on writing it but... It's seriously uncomfortable. It was SW talking about the curious effect simple stimuli can have on parts of the body and like... Just imagine...
I mean, with the fic's rating, I technically could write it, and it would make many of u uncomfortable as Casta, but I felt it was unnecessary, so I finally didn't...

So so, I hope you enjoyed the chapter and I can't wait for you to read the next one! I wanna know what you all think XD

Thanks for reading and until next week it is!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: ERROR
Status: New level of anger unlocked

Chapter Notes

So, here come more headcanons and the whys of SW's rage heh

Also the reasons for the error message hah

I can't say there's any lesson for her in these memories BUT, besides the rage, there is still SOME progress perhaps…

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Castaspella left that morning and the core pulled her back, Beatrix began recalling a time she was talking with the sorceress and some acolyte who made a *very* interesting question.

—But *how* could someone named "*Light* Spinner" turn into "*Shadow* Weaver"!? It makes little sense!

—Well, that's easy— the Head Sorceress quickly replied, catching both their attention. —See that? *Every* light will always cast a shadow, just like *only* in the darkness can we better appreciate the light. Look at how now, in the sun, we clearly see our shadows; in the same way, it is only at night that we can see our new starry sky— she explained, moving her hand and staring at the shadow it projected on the ground.

However, Shadow Weaver couldn't help but laugh bitterly and smirk. She could hardly believe what she heard.

—You're too naive…

—What are you afraid of?— the acolyte asked, looking back at her.

What!?

That wasn't what the acolyte asked next. That had *never* happened.

—*What are you afraid of, little Beatrix?*

As soon as her memory vanished, she saw a silhouette right in front of her, someone she recognized, and the one who had actually made the question.

It couldn't be…
Just as Norwyn had materialized and spoken to her, now an old Master of hers had appeared too.

But this time, Beatrix wanted to *escape*.

She couldn't face them.

Fortunately for her, Castaspella soon returned, allowing her to go back to the surface; she would question the Princess about those silhouettes, but… should she mention this too?

No…

It would be too much to explain…

But then, she was back at the core, and it didn't take long for the figures to appear.

As more memories replayed in front of her, along with the voices resonating inside her head, she could now see the shadow of her Master observing them too.

It maddened Shadow Weaver as it felt like the silhouette was playing with her.

How could she be sure that *was* her Master?

Perhaps the princess was wrong and there was something off with her machines, something *dangerous.*

Whatever the cause, it didn't matter now. Their shadow was there, it could talk to her, and it didn't seem like it would go away any time soon.

At some point, however, there was a memory that *included* her Master, and the silhouette joined the others to represent it.

This one she remembered: she was still young when she saw her Master and a newly graduated tutor arguing.

—It is too dangerous, you shouldn't risk yourself like that— the tutor said.

—Drop it, Zosia. I know what I'm doing— her Master replied, mildly annoyed.

—How can you be such a hardhead? Don't you understand it could kill you!?— she insisted, almost yelling.

—Why is it so difficult *for you to understand it is* not *up for discussion!?*

—But…

—I do not *care.*

The whole scene vanished except for the figure of her Master, who stood there and laughed.

How could it be?

She didn't know back then, but now she could recognize it: the scroll they were holding, what they so stubbornly wanted to perform, was the Spell of Obtainment.

The silhouette turned and approached Beatrix, who immediately panicked.

—Perhaps you learnt from me more than I intended…

Were they mocking her now?

How could this be happening!? And, why were they staying for so long!?

Once again, the shadow laughed but it soon receded, letting Beatrix relax for a moment as she saw them join yet another memory.

A young Beatrix had appeared and was now spying in the Lunarium.

Oh… she knew what this was about.

The figure of her Master had entered it and was now frantically drawing over the sink several sigils, one after the other, before a black amorphous thing appeared above her.

That parasite.

Her young self was frozen in place, watching as that thing dropped on her Master and slowly consumed them, leaving nothing behind once it finally disappeared.

It all vanished before the Head Sorcerer and a few councilmen appeared in the scene, as she remembered, and she thought the figure of her Master was finally gone.

—You don't seem surprised. I presume you recall this— their voice said from behind.

It moved to stand before her, and Beatrix could barely stutter —W-why?

—I could ask you the same question.

—I had *fixed it*! And if Micah hadn't backed down…

—Fixed it!? Whatever makes you think you did?

—You only summoned the magic, but you had *nothing* to contain it.

—If your… containment addition had worked, I presume you wouldn't be here.

—It could have!— she exclaimed. But then, realization hit and she let out —You're causing these projections of my memories, aren't you?

—Perhaps— they admitted.

—I… attempted to fix that spell *because* I saw what it did to you. But I- But… I wouldn't dare try it. When I did… I was *desperate.*

—I was desperate too!— they retorted. —I had lost everything and you know it!

—Can’t you understand the Spell of Obtainment was a mistake!?

Great. Now she sounded like Castaspella.

However, this let her see exactly why the sorceress repeated it so much.

Light Spinner felt such pain knowing someone she cared for had died for that mistake… She could imagine how Castaspella felt thinking the same could have happened to Micah.

—A mistake, you say…

—Yes. It has always been a mistake. Desperate or not, neither of us should have attempted it.

—I thought you were more clever than this.

—No! I used to *admire* you! I wanted nothing more than your recognition! Yet… you did that… and so did I…

It sounded *so* familiar.

Of course...

Beatrix finally understood: this is what happened with Catra too. The same desperation and frustration had pushed her to activate the portal, hadn’t it?

—Let me see what you did then…

No. Not this…

She loathed these memories, but she couldn’t stop the silhouettes.

Why wouldn't it stop!?

The pain had been so terrible, where was Castaspella? Why hadn’t she appeared in so long again!?

A scene was soon replaying in front of her. She saw Nolrem once again, watching her fumble with lots of scrolls he seemed unable to recognize. It was when she had just graduated; he was still a bit behind in his studies but wanted to congratulate her, yet he had been hesitating at the door for a good while before actually doing so.

It could be seen that he recognized how huge her project was, and that Light Spinner wouldn’t stop until she was satisfied with her work.

—But… this is consuming you! Yo-you just graduated, you have new pupils…

—That's enough. Retire. I am busy.

She remembered it took her several days and sleepless nights to finally stop working on it as she realized it was useless. Only with Micah's help did her modifications finally work. Before, she wanted to prove her Master was right, but she herself wouldn't dare test it and gave up; then the Horde gained terrain and the Princess Alliance fell apart so she once again tried to fix it. It was still impossible... until Micah appeared and gave her hope.

If only had she seen before how mistaken her Master was...

—I see your friend there couldn't dissuade you either.

—Stop this.

—Not until I see what happened.

—Don't!

But they were in full control of the silhouettes which soon set the whole scene: the Lunarium, Light Spinner and Micah in front of the basin, and their casting already in progress. She had to see it all again: their containment failing, Micah's sheer terror, her own fear as she realized how powerless she was in front of that thing, and then… her rise from what should have been her ashes.

She was sure it would consume her as it did with her Master, but she was still alive somehow. And it only made her far angrier when she saw Norwyn appear along with his faithful acolytes.

If only they had helped her… The containment was *perfect,* it only needed more power!

It was a mistake to do it with such little help.

No. It was a mistake *overall.*

Yes, Micah's power was enough, but she should have known such a young kid would be afraid and try to escape.

Then she saw, once again, how she obliterated Norwyn…

Both her Masters consumed by the same entity in the exact same way.

She could hardly believe it now.

—Well, well… You certainly did a number on those… Even your poor friend.

—Stop.

—Stop me if you can— they defied her.

—Leave! Vanish now along with my mistakes!

—You think you can get rid of your past that easily? What is this? Little Beatrix trying to be Light Spinner again?

—I can and I will- I-I will change. I… *can* do it— she retorted, hesitant but feeling the need to say it.
—I *refuse* to throw this opportunity away.

—What opportunity!? You're already dead!— they laughed. —You're no better than me.

—I *know.* But I was dragged back to the world of the living for a reason. And someone *very stubborn* is making sure I change, even now after death. So you *will* vanish… You *have to*.

The figure of her Master stared at her for a moment, silent, and squinting at her. It mouthed her name and receded, disappearing like Norwyn's shadow had.

Immediately after, she felt the summoning spell and returned to the surface, seething with anger.

That princess…

She had no idea what she had done.

And she would *regret it*.

Chapter End Notes

Ah yes, have I already said who Zosia is?
Gods, I'm now so mixed up...

Well, I looked it up and I haven't...
In any case: Zosia, Casta's late tutor Nolrem mentioned, knew SW's tutor and was the one to try and stop them from attempting the SoO
And well, I got this... *need* to make them have history, as in, being partners and this event affecting the way Zosia raised Casta... But I don't see the point seeing how they are both auxiliary characters who won't really appear again for the time being...

Anyways, if you like the obscure lore of my HC, here's that bit for you hah!

As always, thank you all for reading and I hope you liked the chapter!!
Until next week!!

She can't do it

Chapter Summary

Castaspella's day has just become the most difficult in a long time.
Between Shadow Weaver lashing out at Princess Entrapta, and the news about the collected data, the Head Sorceress finds herself in need of all her patience.

But her problems don't stop there as more trouble waits for her…
»He looked around, making sure no one had spied on him like he spied on the kids, and then walked away, resolved.
»However, the spy *was*, in fact, being spied on…

Chapter Notes

So, remember the ending of the other chapter, no? So much for being better and whatnot...

No well, but learning is progressive, so ofc SW still lashes out a bit.

AND, oh gods, you'll hate me for this chapter...

ANYWAYS here it is, in time, miraculously, and hopefully you'll still enjoy it <("^-^) I hope
At least you may enjoy my little Casta Headcanons which I'm starting to test here cause, well, I have a lot, like, her whole childhood and teen years… So here are some

Now yes! The chapter! Enjoy it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—You, *Princess*, owe me an explanation!

Shadow Weaver charged at Entrapta as soon as she surfaced, only stopping when Castaspella stepped between them.

—Spin, stop!

—No, no, no, no. *She* did something with her cursed devices— she insisted, enraged. —And if she doesn't explain herself immediately, I…

—You *what*?— the Head Sorceress interrupted, between defiant and reproaching. —Are you going to throw away all your progress just because of this!?

—You have no idea what she has done…

Matching Shadow Weaver's low and stern tone, Castaspella replied —Whatever it was, doesn't justify you lashing out, Spin. You can be angry, but you *cannot* hurt someone because of it—. Afterwards,

she looked back at Entrapta and calmly told her —You can retrieve your things now—. As soon as the princess nodded, the sorceress pulled Shadow Weaver to the side and asked —Tell me, what happened, Bea? I haven't seen you this furious since…

—It doesn't matter.

She folded her arms and looked away, refusing to answer, but Castaspella patiently insisted —If you're acting like this, then it *definitely* matters. Talk to me. You know I will listen.

—Cas…

—Please.

—Fine— she finally sighed. —I've been… seeing some silhouettes… down at the core. Like shadows. It-it had only happened once, a few months ago. And it was Norwyn— she began, surprising Castaspella, who remained speechless. —It was as if- Well. We talked, then he disappeared. But now… there were more figures, and they kept representing memories of mine. That was when I first confronted that princess— she explained. —But this last week… I've been seeing another mentor I had. Someone who- someone who attempted the Spell of Obtainment and got consumed by it— she finally let out, looking away with a defeated expression. Castaspella's hands were covering her mouth to hold back a gasp and she remained silent while Shadow Weaver concluded —As you *didn't* come at all, I've been forced to watch those memories of my failures, and the shadow of my mentor seemed to be controlling them. That princess *must* have done something because this never happened before she installed that rubbish tech of hers!

—Alright, alright. Calm down— the sorceress said with a gentle tone. —I'm sorry I couldn't come before. I had too much to do— she explained, looking away ashamedly. —And I… suppose that's why the pain became more frequent again, right?— she asked. Shadow Weaver nodded silently and Castaspella instinctively took her hands as she apologized —I'm sorry. I should have made the time to come check on you.

—Forget it— the woman grunted, jerking her hands out of the sorceress'.

Castaspella saw her turn around to walk away and her first instinct was to stop her. But before she could, Princess Entrapta approached her, hands full holding her devices, and walking by means of her hair.

—I have everything! Now it's time to get results!— she exclaimed, excited for the gathered data.

—Please go ahead, princess. I will visit you later and you can explain those results to me— Castaspella requested, not wanting to leave just yet.

—Alright. See you later!

Entrapta hurried back to the Crypto Castle, quickly making her way through the forest, but stopped for a minute as soon as she was far enough from the sorceresses. Her excitement died out and she hesitated for a moment, looking at the devices between her hands with a gloomy expression. After a moment, she sighed, shook her head, and continued on her way.

—Please talk to me— Castaspella pleaded, reaching for Shadow Weaver's shoulder. As if feeling her, she moved away before the sorceress could touch her, and took another step away from her. —Bea…

don’t do this.

—Why would you want to know?

—It’s troubling you. It will be better for you if you just…

—Talking about this won’t magically solve things.

—Just- Can’t you give it a chance? You said you could trust me… then do it.

—You won’t stop until I tell you, right?— Shadow Weaver asked, rolling her eyes before looking back at the sorceress.

—Of course not.

—I thought you were trying to be more… *respectful* of others’ boundaries— she reproached.

—I- No, well- I mean, I’m just concerned. You don’t have to tell me everything, just talk a bit about it.

Castaspella tentatively took a step forward, waiting to see whether Shadow Weaver would step back again or not. As she didn’t, the sorceress closed the distance and gently invited her to sit down.

—When I was young, I had several Masters. Most of us did. You can ask your councilman. I couldn’t remember before but he studied with me under Norwyn, when the man had just graduated as a tutor— she began, looking at the distance and leaning back against a tree behind her. —He was quite the perfectionist, as I am- *was*. But ultimately he was right. The problem is… I became increasingly obsessed with doing everything perfectly so I wouldn’t disappoint my Masters, and never heard him when Nolrem tried to point it out. I suppose that’s why I forgot about him— she admitted, shaking her head with a bitter smirk. —And I particularly admired one of my mentors, one who kept saying they saw great potential in me. But… they also ignored it when their friend told them not to do the spell. It wasn’t even the version I tried, so of course it consumed them.

—Then… why would you do the same?

—The rumors. Everyone spoke ill about them after that, so I wanted to prove they were right.

Shadow Weaver let out a bitter laugh and closed her eyes, internally fighting herself as she felt far too *vulnerable*.

Noticing her hesitation, Castaspella decided to reveal a bit about her own past, saying —My mentor, the woman who raised me, had a friend who… died with that spell. It was at least a decade before I was born so… maybe that was your Master.

—If her name was Zosia, then yes.

—Then yes…

—So both our mentors died when we were young…

Looking away, ashamed and pained, Castaspella added —But at least it wasn’t your fault.

—What do you mean?

—I made a mistake, trusted the wrong person, and… she got cursed. And suffered for a *very* long time.

—So that was what Nolrem meant— Shadow Weaver realized. Without even looking at the sorceress, she sighed and explained —Shortly after you summoned me, I had a little encounter with Nolrem and he told me that I must have caused an impression on you if you… trusted me. So he explained you were betrayed and that caused your Master's passing.

The woman smirked and looked back at Castaspella smugly.

—Oh please. I just- You proved I *can* trust you— the sorceress explained, blushing slightly and gesturing dismissively with her hand. —But yes, that's… all true. Part of it, at least.

That last comment caught Shadow Weaver's attention and she hesitated a moment before finally proposing —If you tell me the rest, I will truthfully answer whatever you want to know.

—Really? Another deal in this same spot?

Castaspella was serious for a moment before letting out a smirk and a short laugh.

—I'll take it that you agree?

—Of course— the sorceress sighed. She then leaned back like Shadow Weaver and began —Did you know it was her who originally kept spiders? She taught me never to name them… They don't live long.

—You told me, yes.

—Well… The curse didn't kill her. It was spider poison— she clarified, surprising and confusing her. —And *I* gave it to her.

—What? Why?

Shadow Weaver's calm questions, neither judging nor shocked, weren't exactly what the sorceress expected, so she felt a bit more comfortable explaining —Because she begged me, for a long time, to do so. As I said, she was suffering, and always said she'd do it herself if she could. But she couldn't move. And with each passing day, the pain worsened, to the point she constantly cried from it.

—I know only one curse that could cause that. I can't imagine why someone would do that.

—I don't know why either. All I know is that, eventually, she begged me with such desperation to… You know. So I had to— Castaspella concluded. —After everything that happened, after how mad I got, how violently I reacted, and what I was forced to do, I promised myself I wouldn't ever trust anyone easily again— she admitted. —Which is also why I got *so* angry at Adora when she- when *you* made her break so many lunar crystals. After all, it could have been the lenses, my people would have been endangered… All because, again, I had trusted someone easily— she added.

—I wasn't exactly counting on your trauma that day, but no wonder it worked so perfectly— Shadow Weaver laughed. —But more than trust issues like me, you only developed a more… mature approach to people. Somehow. Neither naivety nor absolute mistrust.

—That's…— the sorceress hesitated. —That's great praise coming from you.

—Don't let it get to your head— she teased. —Now go ahead and ask.

—Oh, right. Well… Um… What did the shadows of your Masters tell you when they spoke to you down there?

—I should have known you would ask that— Shadow Weaver muttered. —Well, Norwyn simply… apologized. As I said, he was very strict, and he admitted as much, recognized he… "created me", so to speak. And I- Ugh. I *suppose* that I became worse than him even.

—I'm shocked. How unexpected— Castaspella said, managing to keep a straight face for a moment before bursting out laughing. —Sorry, sorry. But it *is* really surprising that he appeared and apologized!

With her head tilted and squinting at the sorceress, Shadow Weaver asked —Do you want me to hold my end of the deal or not?

—Sorry, please, continue— she apologized, holding back her laughter with a hand on her mouth.

—Right— she grunted. —To begin with, my mentor wasn't even trying to be respectful at all. They only laughed at me the entire time. Made me review all my mistakes, said I didn't fix the Spell of Obtainment at all, and… insisted I'm no better than them.

—Bea…

—I don't mind the words of a dead traitor. I should have known better. Perhaps those rumors weren't as wrong as I thought.

—Bea, listen to me— Castaspella insisted. —The fact that you are trying to change, while they remain the same, if not even worse, shows that you're *definitely* better than them. Even *Norwyn* is better! He managed to see what was wrong with himself and apologized to you! And… I believe you can do the same. Alright?

—I told you: I became worse than him. I don't know if… perhaps they are right and I can't— Shadow Weaver finally said, feeling stupid for having believed as much. —It was ridiculous of me to think otherwise.

She immediately stood up and folded her arms as she walked a few steps away. Part of her was expecting, or rather *wished*, the sorceress would follow her and insist she can change, while another part of her kept repeating that Castaspella didn't care and would abandon the idea. Until the woman felt something on her back that immediately silenced that voice.

—Please— the sorceress muttered, holding Shadow Weaver in a tight embrace from the back. —If you give up- If you don't try… you'll let them win. And that poor excuse of a mentor you had is *not* worth that much, Bea. Please don't throw away your chances for someone who doesn't believe in you at all.

Hesitant once again, she asked —Why won't *you* give up? I don't understand…

—I'm not the only one who trusts you can change. The girls think so too. They hope you will… one day, be the person they always believed you could be. The person Catra wished you were to her, the person Adora trusted you must have been deep inside… The person who was so genuinely invested in saving Micah— Castaspella enumerated, her voice muffled by Shadow Weaver's back.

The woman tentatively placed her hand on Castaspella's arms around her and sighed —I see…

Later that same day, after having lunch, the Head Sorceress went to the Crypto Castle to speak with Princess Entrapta and learn the results of her experiments.

—Come this way, Head Sorceress— Kyle called her, shortly after she arrived at the citadel. —Entrapta is waiting for you.

They soon arrived at the lab, where the princess was hunched over a keyboard, typing at full speed. Even though she was *really* waiting for Castaspella, she still jumped a bit upon hearing her footsteps behind her.

—A-ah! Head Sorceress!— she exclaimed, fumbling with her mask. —I was just… finishing… with some calculations.

—Of course. Don't worry, Princess. I can always return tomorrow instead if you prefer.

—No, no— she immediately replied before looking down, between frustrated and apologetic. —The results won't change…

Castaspella raised a brow, confused, and took a step forward, partially fearing what that meant. Without a word, the princess turned around and typed a few times to open several graphs and data calculation sheets across several screens.

—What is this?

—The data I have collected.

—And what… did you uncover?

—Nothing.

—What!?

Now Entrapta's gloomy mood made more sense to the sorceress. She looked between the princess and the screens, increasingly nervous, unconsciously gripping the sides of her dress.

After a moment, Princess Entrapta finally explained —None of the data is of use. All the readings remain the same. I can't isolate Shadow Weaver's energy firm. It's… like she doesn't really exist there.

—But-but *why*!?

—I don't know! I tried everything! I even set the devices to maximum power!

Entrapta quickly covered her mouth immediately after saying that. She couldn't help but curl up, sitting on her hair with her knees against her chest, fearful under Castaspella's shocked stare.

—What did you say?

—I just needed the data; it seemed to be wrong so I needed better readings. I-I didn't mean to hurt her — Entrapta apologized, recoiled, speaking a bit muffled behind her mask.

—I know. But you should have told us the truth— Castaspella replied, stern yet calm.

The princess warily raised her mask, asking —Will you… tell her?

With a small smile, the sorceress shook her head and admitted —I won't. It makes no difference now and, with her attitude, it will only make things worse for you.

—Thank you…

—Just, please tell me— the sorceress sighed. —What do you mean when you say it's like she "doesn't exist"?

Turning around to her screens once again, the princess looked at them while typing and changing from one graph to another, then another, and explained —My devices have been returning data that indicates Shadow Weaver's energy is the same as the Heart of Etheria—. She finally looked back at Castaspella, her expression apologetic once again, and concluded —There is no "her" within the core of Etheria: there's only the magic of the Heart flowing to the surface. The- That parasite magic you have mentioned is composed of the same energy, so it gives the same readings, only more concentrated within the core.

Stunned, Castaspella barely managed to ask —What… does that mean?

—I can't… do anything to keep her on the surface.

What!?

The sorceress felt lightweight all of a sudden.

It couldn't be… Not even a genius like Entrapta could do it.

Meaning there was *no one* able to do it.

She couldn't be brought back.

—Then… the Heart and the parasite, the magic summoned by the Spell of Obtainment… it's all the same— the sorceress uttered, her sight fixed on the floor as she focused on staying on her feet. Entrapta nodded and listened as Castaspella continued to reflect —That technology… The First Ones' tech created the Heart… And it was one and the same with the parasite, but enhanced as it was siphoning Etheria's natural magic. So now that the Heart is gone, all that remains is the parasite magic.

—That's… right— the princess confirmed.

—And she's a part of it…

Back in Mystacor, while the pupils waited for Castaspella to return, both hers and Shadow Weaver's kids gathered in the gardens, some playing, some practicing, and some reading.

King Micah happened to be walking by when he noticed them and stopped for a moment to observe with a smile their joyful playing. Until he heard a conversation that completely changed his expression.

—… Perhaps in that magical groove where she took us— Sahm was saying.

The teen in front of him, one of Castaspella's pupils, seemed confused as he asked —But why does she go there so often?

—To see our Master, of course! She's only appearing there, and only when the Head Sorceress is near.

—Eh? Why?

—All we know is that the spell thing the Head Sorceress has, that let our Master teach us like any other tutor, also works for that.

She was…

What exactly had his sister been doing!?

King Micah continued walking, deep in thought as he reflected. He couldn't comprehend what that meant. A magical place in the woods? Where Shadow Weaver was back? Or rather, where the summoning spell within Castaspella could bring her back?

Why stay hidden in the woods? The kid said something about his sister's proximity being what brings her back, so perhaps she's confined there?

But then…

What about what the other kid said? Had Castaspella been visiting Shadow Weaver so frequently? What if they…

No. She wouldn't dare do it again, would she?

What even could they do out in the woods, in the middle of nowhere?

—That's it. I have to find that groove— he told himself, noticing he had arrived at an empty hall. —I can't let that woman corrupt Casta any further…— he uttered, looking down at the ground with his hands tightly closed in fists. —I have to find that place and bring my sister back.

He looked around, making sure no one had spied on him like he spied on the kids, and then walked away, resolved.

However, the spy *was*, in fact, being spied on…

Slipping through the halls of Mystacor, trying to sneak into the library, Catra and Melog carefully walked around, both under cloaking magic. Despite having asked for Castaspella's mentoring to try and explore that newfound power of hers, Catra was considerably ashamed of being seen there and only studied while Melog kept her invisible.

However, as they turned around the corner, they abruptly stopped to avoid crashing directly into a pensive King Micah. Catra pressed a hand to her mouth to stay as silent as possible and focused on breathing silently, which Melog noticed and copied. But it became difficult to stay quiet when he began thinking aloud.

—That's it. I have to find that groove. I can't let that woman corrupt Casta any further… I have to find that place and bring my sister back.

Oh, not again.

He would ruin it all a second time just because he can't believe Shadow Weaver isn't hurting the sorceress at all.

So what now!?

What could they do!?

They can't let him find the magical groove or he would *somehow* manage to mess up that place too; they would lose her for good this time.

She couldn't allow it. Not now, when she's finally letting herself have hope again… Not now, when the possibility of getting the only thing she wanted from Shadow Weaver is so close.

Back in Brightmoon, Glimmer and Adora were discussing their next mission out in space, when they got interrupted by Catra's sudden arrival.

—Guys! We have a problem!— she exclaimed first thing. Far from being exhausted despite the run, she was frantic. And just as Bow appeared at the door behind her, she explained —The King knows about the magical groove and wants to find it!

—What!?

—If he does- Oh, damn it, who *knows* what he's gonna do!— Catra let out, starting to pace from left to right in front of Glimmer.

—We can try to keep him away, right?— Glimmer suggested. She then looked at Bow and asked —Perhaps we can set some traps? Or- Wait, you were working on those tracker cameras, no? We could set some around the grove to see if he ever gets close enough to find it, right?

—Just- Whatever can stop him will do. Because if Entrapta manages to keep Shadow Weaver on the surface and that man ruins it again…— Catra let out, trying to hide her desperation.

However, instead of answering, he only looked away, troubled.

—Bow?— Adora called. She approached him and placed a hand on his shoulder, noticing he was carrying his trackpad and had a message from Princess Entrapta on display. —What is it?

—About that…— he began, scratching his neck and refusing to look them in the eye. —We won't have to worry about him ruining it…

—What do you mean?

Catra finally stopped pacing and looked back at him, anticipating what he would say yet refusing to accept it.

—I received a message from Entrapta. She… can't do it.

Chapter End Notes

Oh, did you know here in the Southern Hemisphere it's Spring day today?
For anyone in this hemisphere, Happy Spring Day!!
For those in the north, I dunno if you have something like Fall day, but I won't let you out, Happy Fall day (^w^)

Ohhh about my Casta headcanons... Wanna know a bit more about Zosia?
1- She was the one to teach Casta how to knit because, when she saw Zosia's box of threads she was super interested.
2- When Zosia taught Casta not to name her spiders, it was because so many of hers had died that she couldn't manage getting attached to them and, obviously, Casta was even more likely to deeply bond with them
3- Zosia was already quite old when she took care of Casta, and it was because, in her first years studying sorcery, plenty of other mentors gave up on her as she couldn't cast properly despite knowing so much; and Casta's entire personalty is due to her (she helped with chores and such, and learnt to be self-sufficient, knit, sew, etc -remember she refitted Glimmer's ceremonial robes-)

I could write more, but that will be it for now

I hope you don't hate me that much for this <("^-^) I swear it's all necessary...
And now, thanks for reading! Until next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The Lesson: trust is more complicated than just black and white
Status: fatal rejection

Chapter Notes

So… it took me longer to post today cause I had to install a shelf (it was a success), and it took part of my morning which I usually use to edit before my therapy session…

Anyways, it's here.

I wanted to comment that, this scene was kind of inspired by the song *Reason*, by Omnimar, that ofc I included in my playlist ~~Yes, I shall keep promoting it~~

Now, I hope you enjoy (^_^)/

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She didn't know how long ago Castaspella had left when she began hearing voices from the surface again.

So Catra and Adora's proximity let her hear bits of conversation once more. Although indiscernible, she managed to catch a few words: Micah, again, Entrapta, can't do it.

What even did that mean?

The last part was easy: she couldn't be brought back. That princess had failed.

But what about Micah? What had he done now for them to be discussing him?

She managed to hear more bits, but everything was so disconnected that nothing made *any* sense to her.

Perhaps, if it were important, Castaspella would tell her, right?

Oh, but Beatrix remembered that, at least once, the sorceress had promised to tell her something "later", didn't she? Perhaps that was a memory worth revisiting…

After the summoning spell got bound to Castaspella, Shadow Weaver found a new form of amusement by constantly annoying the Head Sorceress. With such particular properties, the spell allowed her to be impossible to ignore.

After a few months, Castaspella had gotten used to her bothersome behaviour, letting the woman do as she pleased without caring about it, even granting her free entrance to her room at whatever time.

So she *had* to find a way to irritate her regardless.

For that, Shadow Weaver would usually lay down next to the Head Sorceress, disturbing her rest and startling her. It was *perfect*.

Until she got used to it.

Castaspella would simply try to shoo her away and *try* to ignore her, only making Shadow Weaver double her provocation. Yes, she kept some distance, never laying right next to her but rather on the opposite side of the bed, keeping herself out of Castaspella's personal space, so the sorceress had no "arguments" to kick her out of it. But that distance was enough to bother her.

Yet somehow, she *also* got used to that. Even *comfortable*.

One night, when the sorceress arrived at her room extremely tired, she was apparently so drained, she flopped on the bed, right next to Shadow Weaver, closer than ever as if needing it.

—You must be *really* exhausted. You didn't do the usual number— she mocked her, trying to hide her surprise.

—Charging the Crystal of Arxia was terribly strenuous— the Head Sorceress began, with a tired tone. —I had to cover for a sorcerer who fainted in the middle of the charging process.

—So now you feel like fainting yourself. How *smart*.

—Shut up…

—You're one lucky fool— Shadow Weaver let out, returning to the book she had been waiting to read.

However, instead of focusing on her reading, she watched as Castaspella slowly fell asleep. She couldn't understand how she dared let her guard down like that; she's now *at her mercy*, she could do whatever she wanted to her, and the sorceress would be entirely defenseless.

Yes, she could do anything, even *hurt her*.

But, for some reason, the sole idea of merely scratching her with a claw suddenly felt *wrong*. Thinking about how Castaspella kept being kind, playful, gentle, and trusting enough to still support and patiently explain to her why this or that behavior was wrong…

Never had something so simple as a *smile* made her hesitate so much.

It was *disgusting*.

The sorceress had to be the greatest, kindest, most stubborn fool she's ever known…

She should have already obliterated her for having so much… *control* over her.

But why was she so scared of that control?

Before the woman could reflect any longer, the sorceress woke up, startled, and Shadow Weaver realized how, unconsciously, she had been holding Castaspella, tighter as she got tense in her reflections.

—I…

The sorceress tried to speak, but her voice trailed off; the woman was sure it was the proximity that had her in shock.

—What? Am I that unpleasant to you?— she mocked her. The woman had released her as soon as she noticed, but Castaspella continued to stare, stunned, without saying a word or moving in the slightest. It alarmed her the more the silence stretched and she couldn't help asking —Cas? What's wrong?

She moved her lips, trying to form words, but seemed to be struggling at first; it took her a moment to finally say —Can you… do that… again?

What did she even mean?

Unable to understand her, Shadow Weaver asked —Cas, what happened?

—Please… Can you?

The sorceress insisted, giving her a pleading look, right before moving to lean on her.

What was she even doing!?

Did she really want…

Of course. This is Castaspella here. Clearly, she'd needed… *hugs*.

As she finally understood, and feeling unable to reject her when she looked so mortified, Shadow Weaver embraced the sorceress like she had been accidentally doing before.

It didn't take long for Castaspella to hold her back, tighter as she began sobbing.

What on Etheria is she supposed to do now?

She never had to comfort someone in such a state.

She could only let her cry for as much as she required.

However, she eventually grew more and more uncomfortable with it and decided to ask again —Cas… *What happened*?

The sorceress shook her head slightly, denying —No-nothing…

Reluctantly, Shadow Weaver pushed herself to say, insistingly, —I won't mock you for whatever it is, alright? Just speak.

Castaspella took a deep breath and, little by little, she rose her head, sniffing. With another deep breath, followed by a long, shaky sigh, she seemed ready to speak, untill a knock on the door interrupted her.

She closed her eyes briefly and smiled apologetically as she said —I-it's fine, I'll get the door…

As she let go of her and left the bed, Shadow Weaver condescendingly said —You *do* know that you can simply stay here if you aren't feeling well, don't you?

—I'm fine— she replied, with a hand already on the doorknob. Before opening, she looked back to add —I'll just tell you later…

But she never did.

Either it wasn't important or she broke her promise.

It did seem significant, at least to her, that much was clear. So why would she tell her that if she wouldn't do it after all?

Whatever the reason was, it meant she could easily do it again.

Should she demand the truth from her?

Should she, instead, ask the girls about it?

In fact, Beatrix was sure they would tell her without being asked about it, with how mortified they sounded.

In any case, she felt… *betrayed*.

Realizing Castaspella would keep things from her when she *claimed* to trust her…

All her talks about "trust" and then she does that…

No, of course she won't ask. And if Adora and Catra tell her, she won't say anything either.

If that's how the sorceress will play…

Chapter End Notes

You know, at the end of the memory, I was about to write "But that was a fucking lie" instead, but finally didn't lsksjsjs

Oh, and, before anyone asks what it was that Casta didn't tell her, don't worry, it will appear ~~perhaps~~ in the next chapter. Casta will speak about it, just *not* to SW.

Also, yes, you technically can consider this a backward step in her progress but, you know, growth is not linear…

ANYWAYS, you're lucky and the next chapter will include Casta explaining what she didn't say, but also some more details! It's gonna be fun! ~~And long~~

Actually, I *hope* I can post it in time. We'll see. After all, I just began working again! I was accepted for a new project, hehe.
But don't worry, I'll find the time to write all as good as possible (>^<)

Until next week it is! Thank u for reading!

You have no right to hate her

Chapter Summary

The time for the festivities arrives and finds the Head Sorceress in quite a gloomy mood. No one has any idea of what could be the reason, but no one other than Glimmer and Micah would dare ask.
»—Hey, Auntie!
»—Oh! Hello, Glimmer. Everything seems to be running smoothly, isn't that right?
»—Yes! Absolutely! But it doesn't seem like you're enjoying it.
»—O-of course, I am. Whatever makes you think I'm not?
»—That you're sitting here alone, to begin with. And that you haven't interacted with anyone since giving Entrapta the sweaters for Hordak and Wrong Hordak!
»—I'm… fine. It's nothing. I'm just not in the mood for… mingling.
»—Is it because…
»—*Because* I am not in the mood, as I just said.
»—Auntie…

And new faces join the people of Etheria in this year's Guild Dance, making Castaspella's life a bit more difficult.
Or a bit easier?

Chapter Notes

I'm introducing a new OC wooooh!
At this point, I have more OC's than canon characters, seeing how all the council is basically my invention...

Anyways!
Guess who fucked up big time and is now trying to collect the pieces of my broken timeline?
Yes, I'm adding some bullshit about the guild dance being after the anniversary of the war's end because the way I planned the chapter was simply too good and I HAD to throw the og dates out of the window.
As in, I had said the gift exchange thing for the first anniversary of the war's ending happened a few weeks after the Guild dance, but now it's happening BEFORE because I say so lolz!
I'll go with: it's related to celestial phenomena and the date isn't fixed, just like the Lesser Sabbats of the Wheel of the Year (my paganism is showing). I'll try to be less inconsistent in the future, apologies. I'm saying this because I realized you can, technically, align the events with our solar calendar seeing how I mention Casta's b-day to be a few weeks after SW starts teaching. Anyways, better don't go through that torture, it took me hours to figure out when each thing happened, *and I'm the freaking writer*...

So, well, I hope you can enjoy this long, *long long*, chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As another couple of months went by, all issues in Mystacor having come to a lull, the Head Sorceress was able to visit Shadow Weaver more regularly. Even with the return of colder temperatures, she would still spend the night at the groove, especially when she had a bad day.

—Shouldn't you be back already? To prepare for that exchange of gifts thing?

—I don't have anything to prepare. I'll just go directly to Bright Moon tonight!

Shadow Weaver stared at the sorceress in utter disbelief.

—I've been here for, perhaps, half a year already, yet I *know* you have been knitting a few sweaters, haven't you?

—Birthday sweaters— Castaspella replied.

—Is that so? Didn't you mention this year you would make some proper sweaters for Hordak and the clone?— she reminded her, arching a brow, between teasing and reproaching.

—Fine, yes. I have a few gifts to deliver myself, even if I'm not the host this year— she admitted. —But I already left them in Glimmer's care yesterday.

—All carefully planned to stay here and annoy me— she mocked her. —You used to be a bit more open… I suppose you have been talking much less to me now that I'm not always following you around.

—What is that supposed to mean?

—Last year, you talked my ear off about your sweaters, explaining the patterns, the colors, and all that falderal. This year, on the contrary, I had to insist just now for you to admit you have knitted some gifts this year too— Shadow Weaver explained, with a tone that made it difficult for Castaspella to know whether she was just messing with her or if it was a serious reproach.

—How did you go from complaining about me talking *so much* about trivialities, to complaining because I don't?

She looked back at the sorceress, who intended to look offended, frowning at her, with both hands on her hips, and merely smirked.

—I don't know what you're talking about.

Later that night, it was time for the gifts exchange. The Queen took her task very seriously, making sure to have something thoughtful for everyone, and gave a speech, speaking about how that small circle of friends, who stuck together through the worst of times, had become akin to a family for her.

But it left her thinking.

Her blood family is currently *a mess*.

Her father seemed to be in quite a good mood, mingling with the princesses and eating. Her aunt, on the other hand, had been sitting alone in a corner the whole night.

—Hey, Auntie!

—Oh! Hello, Glimmer. Everything seems to be running smoothly, isn't that right?

—Yes! Absolutely!— she initially replied. However, she then hesitated and commented —But it doesn't seem like you're enjoying it.

—O-of course, I am— she immediately assured her. —Whatever makes you think I'm not?

—That you're sitting here alone, to begin with— the Queen pointed out. —And that you haven't interacted with anyone since giving Entrapta the sweaters for Hordak and Wrong Hordak!

—I'm… fine. It's nothing. I'm just not in the mood for… mingling.

—Is it because…

—*Because* I am not in the mood, as I just said.

—Auntie…

—Was there anything else you wanted to discuss, Dear?— the sorceress asked, suddenly changing her tone to a more cheerful one.

—I- Well, yes. Actually— she realized. —Remember that we found this planet, a month ago, that managed to stay hidden from Prime and all?— she began. When her aunt nodded, she continued —Well, an ambassador will be coming soon and, well, I wanted to know if, perhaps, we could invite him to the Guild Dance!

Oh.

The Guild Dance.

Good thing that year the Dance was a month later than the previous year because she had *completely forgotten* about it.

—Ri-right. I don't see why not, of course— she accepted, giving her a polite smile.

—If you don't like the idea, it's fine. I already had you open it for the whole of Etheria, it's…

—Don't worry, I mean it. Everyone is invited now.

—Alright then!— Glimmer sighed, relieved. —Thank you so much, Auntie! I'll… go find my friends now. I don't… see them— she nervously excused herself. As the Queen walked away, she continued to reflect while her sight searched for Adora and Catra among the people in the saloon. —Perhaps it wasn't a good idea… Or… Ugh, I don't know— she muttered, thinking aloud. However, failing to find her friends interrupted her musing and she angrily let out —Where the heck are they!?

Meanwhile, walking down the halls of the palace, the Head Sorceress was deep in thought, trying to understand how exactly something so important had slipped her mind.

What had she been thinking about instead?

Oh, *right*.

There's one little issue that had been nagging at her these past months: for some reason, Shadow Weaver had been acting very strangely. She couldn't figure out what it was, but it's evident that something was bothering the woman. Something for which she's been backhandedly reproaching her, yet nothing she had explicitly said.

What could it be?

It seemed related to "trust", seeing how she had been practically calling her a hypocrite, and just earlier she had said she "used to be more open".

Was there anything she hadn't told her?

Something soon appeared in the back of her mind and she suddenly realized.

Of course.

She once promised to tell her something, the reasons for her crying, but the moment had passed and, with more time to properly consider it, the sorceress realized it was for the best. It's not something to be spoken about with her.

As she continued to walk down the halls, a couple of voices called her attention and interrupted her pondering. She soon recognized Catra's voice and, when she heard Micah angrily replying, she rushed to find them.

—…Friends!? *Who* could be friends, least of all have *feelings* for that backstabber!?— king Micah argued.

—*You* dare call her a backstabber!?— Catra immediately reacted. —*You*, who got the best part of her, the time when she was loving and caring!? She *cared* about you, she never tortured or hurt you! She was *proud* of you! *Loved* you! You-you *never* had to go through what we had to live!

Castaspella arrived to find them discussing in a tone that, likely, had been the same in that argument Glimmer told her they had some months ago.

—What is going on here!?— the sorceress exclaimed, albeit totally ignored by them both.

Only Adora noticed her and approached while they went on with their argument.

—Perhaps we both should hate her!— Catra continued, gesturing at Adora and herself. —And I *do* resent her a lot! But I *can't help* caring for her even more than I could ever despise her! You!? You just hate her because you *think* you have to!— she accused him. Seething yet more controlled, she added —With what right do you hate her when you never had to deal with her cruelty? You got the long end of the stick, she *recognized* your prowess, and yes, in the end, it can be said that she used you, but we have heard how it happened. I don't know if she planned to use you all along, but it's clear that she *did* care for you at first and, maybe, she later saw you as a dispensable tool. But she did *not* regard you simply as that!

—You don't know…

—I know enough!— she interrupted, yelling once more before composing herself. —You were… her *favorite*. And-and when she got corrupted… she *left* to make sure she *wouldn't hurt you*— she reproached him, noticeably pained. —When she left *me*, it felt like being torn open! I really thought… for once she'd see me… as the person she raised— she admitted. Right after, Catra frowned and glared at him, concluding —Instead, Adora and I both were but tools from the beginning until right

before she died. Means to an end. And perhaps, I hope- I suppose, maybe against her will, at some point, she developed any semblance of care for us… But she *purposely* scared and manipulated us. For her, we were *tools*.

A tense silence settled between them.

Micah had never heard of the nightmares the girls had to bear, and couldn't even imagine what it was like. But knowing it now only made it worse.

—How can you three… know all of *that*, and still *defend her*!? Why am I wrong for hating her!?— he complained.

—Brother, I have to agree with Catra— Castaspella began, taking a step towards him, eyes closed and hands joined in front of her. She sighed and continued —At first I understood your hate. Especially since she had been walking free in Bright Moon, acting all smugly—. She let out a short laugh. —But, you know? She still tried to help you, tried to… protect you, despite having no more power. And when you were chipped, her first thought…

—Her first thought was looking for you to free me. Yes, you've mentioned it a lot— he interrupted, clearly annoyed. —You aren't seeing it. She only… couldn't stand the idea of someone *else* managing to control me when she couldn't— he argued.

With a sorrowful expression, the Head Sorceress replied —It's not like that, Micah. She said it was dangerous that you were controlled by the enemy, not only because you could hurt us, but because you could get hurt yourself! She… said she owed you that much at least. She was *actually* worried about you! She just… won't ever say such things aloud because of her… *stupid* belief that caring for others is a weakness or something.

—And how can you be *so sure* she was honest? How- Why- You *really* agree with her?— he asked, gesturing at Catra, who only squinted at him. —Why?

—Because, after everything we endured, all the struggles Shadow Weaver and I went through just for *you*, I *have* to agree with her. You have *no right* to hate her.

And with that, his resolve hardened.

The woman must have gotten into her head, right? *If only* he had been able to find that groove his sister kept visiting…

But it was impossible, it was as if it didn't exist.

Well, it had to, because her influence was evident, was it not?

The only solution was to banish Shadow Weaver for good, right?

It had to be…

King Micah held her sight for a long minute before finally walking away, visibly annoyed, and the three breathed out, relaxing their tense bodies.

Both Adora and Castaspella approached Catra, worried, and waited for her to give any sign of how she was holding up.

—I'm… just *so* angry— she finally let out, eyes shut and hands closed in tight fists. —Why is he so stubborn? And-and self-centered? And blind!?

—Catra…

—One would think he'd already understand! It's been more than a year!

—Catra— Castaspella interrupted. —It's alright. Don't burden yourself with this. It's not your duty to change his mind, alright?— she gently told her. —Why don't you distract yourself a bit?

—I- Yeah. I should…

—Do we return to the party?— Adora offered.

—No, I- I'm not in the mood— she replied, shaking her head slightly, looking at the ground. She then clenched her fists, and called —Adora?

—Yes?

—I… want us to get our own place.

—Our own… place?

—To live— she clarified, looking up at her. —I can't keep living here with him. Every time we cross paths, it's the same. It must hurt Glimmer to see us always fighting.

Adora was speechless for a moment, then her expression turned more understanding, although pained, and she placed a hand on her shoulder, nodding.

—Then we will. As soon as we can— she agreed. —What do you want to do now?

—I think I'll go study some magic for a while.

—Alright— she accepted. However, it suddenly occurred to her —Why don't you go with the Head Sorceress? Didn't you have some questions the other day?

—I don't wanna keep her from the party— Catra replied, yet the look she gave Castaspella implied otherwise.

—I don't mind. It isn't a problem— she assured her.

—Thank you.

—I'll find you later— Adora farewelled.

Later, in Mystacor's library, the sorceress had spent around an hour or two explaining a series of technicalities to Catra, yet struggled to help with the more practical aspects.

—Well, I'm sorry to say this…— she finally admitted. —But the only person that can help you with this is Micah.

—Well, I'm *obviously* not asking for his help any time soon— Catra replied, annoyed but mostly tired. —I'd rather figure it out myself.

—I see…

—This is frustrating— she grunted, dropping her head over the open book on the desk.

—Is… something else bothering you?— Castaspella tentatively asked.

—I- No. Well, yes— she admitted, turning her head to face her. —I don't really wanna talk about that.

—You *do* know you're allowed to feel like this, right? Frustrated, angry, annoyed… It's not wrong; you're not hurting anyone and, in fact, if you bottle it up, you *will* explode eventually, and then someone might get hurt. Even you.

—I- Yes, I… know. But I don't like it. Although… I needed to hear that. Thank you— she replied. —Perhaps I *should* tell you? I don't know…

—You don't *have to* tell me, it's alright. If I could give you some comfort, that's enough.

Castaspella hesitantly placed a hand on Catra's shoulder and, as she seemed fine with it, she finally allowed herself to smile gently at her.

—I feel like I should… you've been seriously helpful all this time.

—You don't owe me anything, Catra. Pushing yourself to speak about something…— she began, but interrupted herself with a sigh. —If you don't feel confident enough, there's no need. When the circumstances are appropriate, the right time and person, you'll know. You'll be able to speak freely about it, alright?

—It's just that… right now, you just gave me the comfort I needed, but I haven't even told you what's the matter… Isn't that weird?

The sorceress giggled and moved her hand away from her. She rested her arm on the desk and leant onto it while taking a deep breath.

—I promise it's not. Really. I've… been in the same situation, you know?— she said. Catra looked at her, interested, and raised her head from the book. —Once I… had a realization and felt extremely troubled about it. I needed comfort, I really needed a hug… and for some *odd* reason, besides me asking for it, Bea… Shadow Weaver gave it to me— she explained, laughing slightly. Catra remained silent yet couldn't help feeling a pang of sorrow upon hearing that. —I suppose it was obvious in my expression how much I needed that, and she asked several times what the problem was, but I never told her. I just- Truth is, she was not the right person to share that with, but because I know what her answer would be… Most people would answer similarly, of course; perhaps hers would have different reasons, yet it would still be… the same kind of answer— she continued, looking away. Her expression was a bit somber as she looked for the right words to explain it. —The mixed feelings that some things may provoke us are not easy to grasp, so we can't just talk about them with anyone; no matter how much they want to understand and help, it might still be out of their comprehension for reasons they have no control over…

Hearing that, Catra's expression became gloomy too, she sat back on the chair to raise her legs and hugged them against her chest.

—Yeah… I get that— she admitted. —It sometimes happens… when I try to talk with Adora about my mixed feelings, about the Horde. She always had it clear so, for her, I just need time and I'll figure things out. But I *always* knew the Horde was evil and still stayed, while she thought we were the good

guys and left as soon as she realized we weren't… To her, it was always that clear for all the same things I feel conflicted with— she explained. —She comforts me but, when we actually speak about it, it's a bit frustrating for me…

—Exactly…— the sorceress sighed. A silence settled between them while Castaspella thought for a moment. Catra's words reflected an understanding of certain emotions that may as well be just what she was looking for. —Would you mind if I told you about it?

Hiding her surprise, Catra rested her chin on top of her knees and uttered —Go ahead.

—I think you'll understand better than anyone… You've been on the receiving end of words that affected you greatly, right?— she began. —Things people said or did that influenced your later decisions, even if they didn't ever consider that could happen…

—Yeah…

—Everyone will say we shouldn't feel guilty and that we're not to blame for what others do and whether we had any impact on it, but…— she continued, taking a deep breath before letting out a long sigh. —I feel like- I realized… some of the things I said or did after we *thought* my brother had died… might have influenced Angella's decision to sacrifice herself— she finally explained. Catra's eyes opened in great surprise, yet she remained speechless. —Adora told us what she said before pulling out the sword to fix reality, and… *I* had called her a coward back then. I blamed her for Micah's "death"… Ugh, even Shadow Weaver did that; you should have heard that interrogation— she sighed. —I blamed her for his loss, for everything bad that happened afterwards… I *tried* to make peace later but, by then, she wouldn't want to speak with me; never answered my letters, and only the war had us work together again— she continued, with another sigh. —I really thought- It felt as if she had dismissed all the things that could have been affected by his absence, and I really felt like everything that happened in Mystacor from then on was partially her fault because she got him… *killed*— she elaborated. Right after, she scoffed in disgust and sighed, resigned. —And the fact that only recently I realized how wrong I was… Ugh. I stopped being so hostile to her when I realized I was being unfair, but I never actually apologized for what I told her, never took it back. Oh, and, after listening, several times, to what people can remember from the differences between that reality and ours… There were none, at least for me, for us on the island, there were no differences.

—What!?

How could it be?

Everything was different, "perfect". How could things in Mystacor remain the same?

—I've heard… Shadow Weaver was in the Horde with you, just less bitchy… And Micah was in Bright Moon, safe and sound. And Bow was a scholar…— she sighed, smiling for a moment. —But us? We had no changes: our general history remained the same, and even with Micah still there, he wasn't really in Mystacor at all, nor was Glimmer studying there either… We had the same usual problems, nothing felt any different. So I understood: not only had I been unfair in general for blaming everything on her, but I had also reproached her for things that weren't even related to Micah's supposed death at all!— she concluded. With another sigh, she looked away and added —I went to sleep with this realization and my dreams kept repeating what I had told her for years, and what Adora said Angella told her… And it was that. I don't think I was the sole reason, I *know* there are more important reasons she had to do it, like making sure you all could survive, enjoy your lives… but I know now how heavy my words must have been…

—Enough to have stuck with her and have some leverage in that final decision— Catra reflected, looking at the distance.

—Yes…

—So this is the part where most people would tell you "it couldn't be your fault", "that was *her* choice", or "you couldn't have known it would affect her like that".

—Or "if she took it so personally, that's on her, not you; you just spoke your mind" if you're Shadow Weaver— she commented, rolling her eyes and smirking.

—Yeah… But, regardless of whether you should feel guilty or not, the fact that you care about how you may have affected her decision is… It's very admirable of you— Catra admitted, hugging her legs more. —We're the only ones to blame for our choices, but someone acknowledging we can, and usually are, affected by what others say… it's really comforting. Perhaps we should be able to make decisions without thinking of what we've been said, or what others did to us…— she continued, despite her voice breaking. —But that's not easy… We're not robots or machines. We don't act on command, our emotions have so much strength…

—And they are heavily affected by the world around you. Indeed…

—I don't think you should blame yourself for her current state; not more than me, that is… But, don't forget how your words could have influenced her decision— she told her, finally letting go of her legs and a bit more serious. —That way, either you don't make the same mistake again or, if you do, this time you'll be able to take it back before it's too late— she concluded, with half a smile at the end.

—You're right… Thank you for listening.

—I- Thank *you* for trusting me…— she replied, surprised. Catra then looked away and uttered —And the change of roles was quite refreshing.

The sorceress laughed daintily, unable to hold it back.

—Agreed.

After some weeks, the Guild Dance was ready to welcome everyone. Castaspella managed to prepare everything on time, despite her emotions being all over the place, and narrowly fit some time to visit Shadow Weaver in between her classes, the preparations, and all the kingdom's official matters.

She had been in a terrible mood, and *for once* allowed Glimmer to help more than she'd usually accept, which further concerned the Queen. She had had to interfere on multiple occasions, so that her aunt wouldn't lash out, and finally saw fit to tell her father about it, hoping he would be able to help.

—Are you ready, Sis?

The sorceress nodded in agreement, without turning to look at Micah, and sighed deeply.

—Everything is running smoothly. There shouldn't be any issues— she replied.

—I wasn't talking about the event.

—I'm fine— she sighed.

—You don’t look like it— he insisted. —Are you sure you’re alright?

—I am.

—So you will dance? I hope.

—I *don’t* dance at these events. Ever. You know it— she replied.

—You told me how you danced with…

—I mean *this* Dance— she interrupted.

—My point still stands. That’s exactly what you told me you danced with her! Is that what has you in such a bad mood?— he asked, genuinely concerned.

—Of course not!

—Casta…

—Please, Micah.

—Alright. I just… want you to enjoy this. You deserve it— he let out, resigned.

—I will, don’t worry about me.

With that, Castaspella joined the party, closely followed by him. Both went to greet the party-goers, talk with friends, and enjoy the food. That year, people from all over Etheria, but also from different planets, joined the festivities. The missions led by the Queen and her friends earned them numerous acquaintances that had come to visit and were promptly invited to the Guild Dance.

The Head Sorceress made it her mission to greet everyone, yet after the first hour, her mood had only worsened. She would keep a semblance of a smile for whoever approached her and behave as cordially as possible, but inside, she felt *lifeless*.

She promised she would enjoy the party, but she couldn’t even listen to the performers, nor taste the food. She was numb to all stimuli, as if in a trance, and focused solely on appearing composed.

—Excuse me— an unfamiliar voice called, shaking her awake. —The Head Sorceress, I presume.

A tall, white-haired man had approached her; his clothes, extremely light-cyan skin, and fully dark-blue eyes indicated he wasn’t Etherian.

—Yes, that’s me— she replied. —Can I help you?

—Perhaps— he smiled. —My name is Delwyn Zhaleh, I’m a dignitary from Ak’kelon. We recently began diplomatic relationships with Etheria— he presented himself. Right after, with a courteous bow, he extended a hand, asking —Would you, perchance, concede to me a dance?

—No.

Her answer, immediate and dry, took him aback, but he skillfully hid it.

—Oh, that’s unexpected. Did I catch you busy? Perhaps later…

—I said no— she repeated, respectful but stern.

—But you are the head of this guild! Surely it's only natural that you dance, at least, the traditional dance— he insisted.

—I don't know where you got such an idea from, but no. I *never* dance, much less the traditional guild dance, as I couldn't ever learn it— she lied.

—Well, I happen to know it pretty well and can guide you through it, if you only allowed me…

—I believe I have already refused enough times— she interrupted him, starting to lose her patience.

—Ah, but you wouldn't like to make Mystacor seem unwelcoming by refusing a dignitary this way… Or should I take it that you have a specific problem with me?

Castaspella opened her eyes widely, indignant, and replied —Quite egocentric from you to presume so. I simply do not *want* to nor do I have time.

—Just one dance, I beg of you…— he pleaded, changing his tone to a humbler one.

—If I give you one and *only* one dance, will you stop pestering me!?— she retorted, frowning and almost growling.

—Absolutely— he immediately promised. —You don't have to see me ever again if so you wish.

—Alright…

Rolling her eyes, she gave up and took his hand, allowing him to lead the dance. However, she kept staring at the ground with a dark demeanor. Uncomfortable, Delwyn gulped and sighed. He tried to start a conversation several times, but her replies were monosyllabic when she *did* reply.

—…I imagine it must be hard, managing a whole kingdom on your own— he let out, as his last attempt to chit-chat. —I know you have a council helping you, but it must be quite taxing regardless…

—Yes.

Delwyn sighed and stopped. He let go of Castaspella's hands and shook his head.

—I give up. Please excuse me, Head Sorceress— he let out, his sight on the ground. When he looked up again, his expression seemed pained. —I shall now be completely honest with you: it was your brother who challenged me to get a dance from you, lest I grant him a place as a diplomat of Etheria in my kingdom— he promptly explained. The sorceress' utter surprise was exactly what he expected, so he began speaking faster to explain himself before she got angry. —I'm sorry to say I simply cannot do such a thing without proper merits, so I couldn't help but press you— he admitted, sighing. —Normally I would never be so disrespectful, for which I apologize.

—And what exactly do you get, now that you won the bet?— she scoffed, disdainfully.

—Nothing— he replied, with a serious tone. Castaspella finally looked at him with less hostility and even more surprise than before. —As I said, it's simply a challenge I didn't want to lose, and I already knew, as he proposed it as a challenge, that you would refuse and it would most likely annoy you greatly. For which I am now ashamed— he admitted, bowing respectfully with a hand on his chest. She said nothing, so he continued —You- This dance… is important for you, isn't it? Meaningful… You *do* know the steps, just didn't want to dance with someone else, isn't that the case?

She immediately took a step back, frowned, and turned around to leave. He watched as Castaspella walked out to a balcony, hesitated a moment, and finally went after her.

Behind them, from a distance, queen Glimmer had been watching the whole scene, confused and concerned. Knowing Delwyn, she couldn't believe what he had done and, if he hadn't left too, she would have asked him about it.

However, she noticed her father had also been looking at them the whole time and something rubbed her the wrong way, so she walked across the room up to the table where he was sitting.

—What was that?— she asked with a casual tone.

—What was what, baby girl?

—Why was Delwyn dancing with Casta?

—Oh, I challenged him to get a dance from her— he replied, laughing slightly. —I didn't think he'd manage. But he did!— he laughed. —I lost.

—Wait, what!? Why did you challenge him to that!?

Her bewildered look entirely went over his head as he casually explained —I'm trying to help her.

—*That* is your idea of "helping"? She's even more upset now!

—I hoped it would lift her mood a bit!

—What made you think- No. You know what? This is my fault for asking you to help— Glimmer let out, frustrated.

—So… that's what you think of me?

He looked away and sounded hurt, and she immediately regretted it.

—D-dad, no. I-I didn't mean…— she stammered, taking a step forward, hesitantly, unsure of what to do. However, she could only sigh and apologize while explaining herself. —I'm sorry. But your… view of things isn't helping. I-I know you only have the best intentions in mind, but you're not seeing how you only hurt her.

—Then what am I supposed to do!?— he exclaimed, almost tearing up.

—Just *listen* to her!

—She's not in her right mind. I can't trust her words are her own. And you shouldn't either.

Glimmer was stunned for a moment, speechless, and could only stare at him.

He *really* meant it, didn't he? It's not malice, but rather an authentic fear.

How could he be so paranoid?

—Why are you so stubborn?

—I know what we're dealing with! Why does no one trust my judgement?

—Have you ever considered that your judgement may not be right? I understand you knew her before us, but is it so hard to believe she has already changed enough for you to *not know her* anymore?— Glimmer argued, sorrowful.

—It is— he stated. Micah folded his arms and remarked, still sounding quite hurt, —If you find it *so difficult* to trust me, then you must understand it's also difficult for me to trust your judgement.

Crossing her arms in front of her chest too, she replied —Alright then. Don't trust us. But stop bothering Auntie.

—I'm trying to *protect* Casta.

—Keep telling that to yourself, dad.

With that, the Queen turned around and walked away, leaving him alone at the table. He knocked his drink back, almost smashed the glass on the table, and stood up to go for some more food and drink.

Meanwhile, outside on the balcony, Delwyn had neither said nor done anything since walking in a moment after Castaspella; he only rested against the edge of the balcony and sighed. After a while, the sorceress decided to finally break the silence, speaking without looking back at him.

—Why are you here?

—I'd like to talk, but I wouldn't dare disrespect you again.

—Why?

—I don't want to disrespect you because you don't deserve it; you've done nothing to offend me, and even if you had, the most basic respect is a *must*, not something to be earned— he began. —But I wanted to talk about… whatever your brother wanted to test.

She finally looked at him, confused, and asked —What do you mean?

—As I said, it seems like this dance is meaningful for you, most likely something you associate with someone… *significant*— he replied. —And, if that's the case, I suppose your brother challenged me to that specifically, because he believed it's impossible to achieve— he explained.

She looked down at the kingdom and began —We discussed it just earlier… He thinks- A while ago, I told him, that time I danced with her, it was simply because I never had the chance to do it, not because… I felt something—. Then, she looked back at him and continued —And, at that time, I didn't… I *don't think* I felt anything other than admiration.

—Now…

—I-I'm not sure yet… But yes, I associate it solely with her— she finally admitted.

—And where is this mysterious woman?

—She…— the sorceress sighed. —She's actually a spirit. I- Well, it's complicated…

—I don't need specifics or explanation— he interrupted her. —The woman is a spirit, meaning she's dead, but that also means these feelings developed *after* her passing but when she was around— he

reflected. —So, what happened that she's no longer here?

—My brother dismissed the spell that kept her on the island.

—I see…

A short silence settled between them while he remained pensive.

After a moment, Castaspella looked down at Mystacor extending under her and continued —And I've yet to find a way to bring her back. Besides, she was helping me so much with a lot of things in the kingdom, that now everything feels much more difficult… Before the war ended, we were secluded, and it was easier to handle official matters. Now, we provide help to all of Etheria, and "official matters" include double, if not thrice, the work!—. She hesitated, but still went on —A-and there's the issue of the newly awakened magic that causes problems I can't solve without very obscure knowledge; she knew what I needed, it was much faster than looking for that information myself, which is why things are so difficult without her!

Castaspella was trembling, her voice betrayed just how anxious she was, and Delwyn didn't know what to do. But after a moment, it occurred to him that he could assist her.

—If you don't mind… may I offer my help?— he asked. She looked back at him, confused, but he simply smiled before going on. —One of my abilities is getting information from certain sources immediately, as I did to learn the traditional dance after Queen Glimmer invited me to this festivity— he explained. —If you have that knowledge stored in books, archives, scrolls, parchments, or even inscriptions on walls or carvings, I can easily get that information for you.

—Why- I don't understand why you'd help me… And don't you have to return to your planet?

She gave him a questioning look that made him nervous.

Looking away shyly, he explained —Oh no, my parents are the regents of my kingdom, that's why I am a dignitary, an ambassador, if you may—. His expression then changed, somewhat apologetic but more confident as he added —I've yet to tell the Queen that I plan on settling on your planet.

She held back a laugh, seeing him so nervous, and only assured him —That's- Well, I'm sure Glimmer will be glad.

Surprised, he immediately questioned —You… address her by her name?

—She's my niece. Unless we are at some important meeting, we rather not use titles.

—I see. So you are *the* aunt. Then… I believe I know who your… *significant other* is.

Now it was Castaspella's turn to be nervous and blush shyly.

—Wha-what?

—The Queen's friends spoke to me about her, and how you had been… of great help to make her more *approachable*— he explained. Then, looking away with a fond expression, he revealed —I knew someone like that… So please allow me to help you with whatever you need; you'll have more time to search for a way to bring her back and visit her.

Castaspella looked down, smiling, and let out —Thank you. I'd appreciate the help, yes.

He bowed once more, farewelled, and walked back inside, leaving the Head Sorceress alone on the balcony.

Perhaps Micah *did* help her in a way.

Chapter End Notes

Well, what do you think? Quite a ride, no?

I had to finish that one discussion Catra and Micah had when the girls had just returned, and I also wanted an excuse for Adora and Catra to move out, plus I needed an excuse to have Catra and Casta speaking alone, and I also needed to introduce that new guy that will trigger SW's jealousy (if it wasn't obvious enough)...
Meaning every single word of this chapter was necessary! I swear!!

Whatever. I just hope you could enjoy this chapter despite it being so long, and until next week it is! Thank you for reading!! <3

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: How can you trust someone when they can't trust you
Status: Successfully assimilated

Chapter Notes

I don't know if I have anything to say this time so...

Please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Voices and pictures of the surface reached her in the depths of Etheria's core, letting her see and hear the heated discussion between Catra and Micah. Everything was so clear, as if she were standing there, that she wouldn't dare make a sound.

Micah's presence must have a similar effect to that of Adora, Catra, and Castaspella together, and is now enhancing that effect with all four of them there.

In any case, recalling how she had caused that incident with the mirror because Castaspella could hear her, she preferred to stay silent during the whole thing lest someone, or everyone, heard her.

Although at first she was surprised by Catra's words, it soon became obvious to Light Spinner that she was still *hopeful*, which explained her arguments with Micah. Furthermore, the decision to move out must have been motivated by a desire to get away from the constant arguing, the perpetual anger, and the emotional sorrow that probably reminded her of the Horde.

Ah, but refusing to learn from him…

Shadow Weaver couldn't believe Catra chose to hinder her learning progress because of something so petty. How foolish must one be to sacrifice perfection like that!?

However…

Wasn't it *her* fault?

They argued over *her*; if anything, Catra was choosing *her* over her progress.

A part of Beatrix perfectly understood that, which was exactly why the other part of her was already repeating: "to care for someone is a weakness".

Before she could dwell on it too much, the subsequent conversation caught her attention, even if she could only understand some loose parts and barely see anything.

She could feel the sorrow in the sorceress before she even spoke, and when she admitted what had made her cry that day, Beatrix was left in utter disbelief.

To begin with, she was surprised to know that she had comforted her so much, and shocked as she finally learnt what had happened. But when she heard Castaspella's opinion of what Shadow Weaver would have told her, she couldn't believe the sorceress knew her well enough to say exactly what she was thinking.

Perhaps Castaspella had been right to keep it from her, choosing what to speak with her and what not to. After all, her reactions to certain things could be *explosive* and *out of proportion* according to her.

Hadn't she once lashed out at her in the same way she'd done with Catra?

That had been… quite a moment.

Castaspella's reaction was similar to Catra's in a way, retreating and wary, but the boldness… The sorceress made her recall how Catra used to talk back at her years before, opposite to how now she'd make her jump at her mere touch. Castaspella had shown some weariness, and perhaps she *was* scared of her wrath, but she looked ready to brave her regardless.

Yet that wasn't all.

Shadow Weaver suddenly remembered she had also kept something from Castaspella that day, albeit for different reasons. Perhaps even for *petty* reasons.

It was a memory worth revisiting…

> The woman couldn't even remember why they began arguing, only that her wrath rose until she was towering over the Head Sorceress, intimidating and ready to lash out at her.
>
> However, similar to when they were in the Whispering Woods, Castaspella stood her ground, wary and careful; she quickly retreated and took a more defensive stance, this time, readying a protection spell.
>
> She genuinely thought Shadow Weaver would attack her, didn't she? And she *would have*, at least, yelled at her; Castaspella kept boldly talking back at her, and it didn't help ease her rage.
>
> Years before, she would have made sure the sorceress *regretted it*.
>
> But instead, the woman froze in place, and retreated. Without thinking about why, she lowered her threatening hands and took a step back, looking away from the sorceress who slowly approached.
>
> Pity…
>
> She certainly didn't need it.
>
> Shadow Weaver gestured dismissively and brushed Castaspella away as she turned around to leave, passing through the wall without looking back.
>
> However, thanks to the summoning spell bound to the sorceress, she managed to find the woman rather quickly.
>
> —What are you doing here!?— she barked, still angry.

—You can't just walk away from all your problems, you know?

—What!?

—Face it! You wanted to hurt me, didn't you? Instinctively reached for your power and couldn't feel it? Did that stop you?— the Head Sorceress questioned her.

—No.

—Then what was it?

—Why do you want to know!?

It only infuriated her even more how nosy Castaspella could be.

—I want you to reflect on what happened! Stop being stubborn and answer the question!

Not that again.

She was quite adamant about cultivating Shadow Weaver's morals, wasn't she?

Ugh. But she wouldn't stop unless she replied…

—I saw your defensive stance. That you recoiled…— she began. Unsure herself, she shook her head and admitted —But I don't know why that stopped me.

—Then focus on that. You stopped. Why? Don't know? Then think about it— Castaspella told her, speaking gently but sternly. —If you want to be alone now, I'll take my leave. Just think about it, can you?

There it was.

That tone.

Why couldn't she just ignore her, hate her, as everyone else did?

There had to be something for her to gain from this, right?

—Why are you being nice to me after that? What do you want from me?

—"Want from you"?— she repeated, shocked. Her expression reminded Shadow Weaver of her surprise when they spoke in the Woods; the same look of disbelief followed by an indignant reply. —I'm not- Whatever makes you *think* I'd be that manipulative!?

Right…

That was a stupid thought.

—Forget it. Just leave.

Right after, she turned around, frowning angrily as she did *not* want to do as Castaspella told her, despite knowing she should.

The sorceress's steps could be heard as she left the room, and the woman was left on her own.

Just as she wanted.

To be left alone…

But alone with her thoughts.

Now they had become impossible to ignore, and all were focused on those questions she didn't want to answer.

Why did she stop?

Why did it have such an impact on her to see the woman take a defensive stance?

Why did she begin appreciating Castaspella's trust so much that seeing it on the verge of being shattered froze her in place?

Didn't she *want* to break that foolish idea of hers?

And, of course, why did she think someone like her would be as manipulative as herself?

Shadow Weaver growled lowly as more and more questions overwhelmed her until it became impossible to ignore them.

Soon, she had made her way down to the beach of Mystacor, where she allowed herself to dwell on all those enquiries, which little by little left her mind the more she attended them.

Perhaps she stopped because, after spending some time with the sorceress, it was easy to see she didn't follow the crowd, that she didn't see her as a monster because everyone else does. No, this woman had made it clear several times that she wouldn't believe it unless Shadow Weaver herself demonstrated it. And if she was there, summoned back into the world of the living, then it had to be because Castaspella meant it.

Perhaps that was also why seeing the sorceress retreat caused such an impact. Even back in the forest, although uncomfortable, she hadn't shown fear at all, much less the need to protect herself like that.

And, Castaspella had even protected her, hadn't she?

Shadow Weaver had decided this sorceress was deserving of her respect and consideration, so she was being a hypocrite.

That is why she stopped.

How many times in the past had she borne having all her efforts thrown away and dismissed by her superiors and equals alike? She couldn't now go and do the same.

Or rather, she could, and she had done so for a long time. But *now* she was conscious of this.

That is why she stopped.

It could also be how, in her expression, for a second she saw that young scared Micah staring back at her when she got corrupted, no?

But that would mean she had a weak spot.

No, that couldn't be. She immediately dismissed that idea.

And thinking she was manipulating her… What could that have been? Fear?

No, no. How ridiculous.

It had to be because no one would put so much effort into something if there were nothing for them to earn out of it, right?

This was frustrating at best…

In any case, Shadow Weaver finally had some answers for the sorceress, so she would finally leave her in peace.

By means of the spell connecting them, she found Castaspella in one of the balconies of the upper floors and was about to walk in until she heard Micah's voice.

—Well, you seemed more concerned than anything, Sis.

—I'm telling you. It is *dangerous* to leave her alone when angry— the sorceress replied, her tone insistent. —I had to make sure she would be calmer, so I went after her.

—Fine, I guess you're right. But it still seems like you care for her far too much— he replied, reproaching. —If you say it's to protect everyone else, I believe you, but it looks like something else.

—Look at it however you want, but that is *not* the case. So can you *please* drop the matter?

—Alright, alright. I will. I just wanted to clarify it— he finally accepted.

She was a fool.

The sorceress *did* see her as a monster from whom everyone else needed protection.

How foolish she had been for believing otherwise.

Forget giving her the answers she wanted. It was ridiculous.

What was the point if Castaspella didn't really care?

She only summoned her to assist and nothing else. Just like she would have done.

And what was in it for her? Making sure no one would have reasons to dismiss her helper, of course.

Shadow weaver couldn't blame her. She would have done the same…

She still felt foolish.

But her reflections were all true.

She stopped because the Head Sorceress had been the first one to trust her since that young and eager Micah, and she almost ruined that again.

She stopped because she was finally conscious of how much of a hypocrite she had been for decades.

And she stopped because she was about to lose the only person that trusted in her by doing the same things Castaspella believed she could grow from.

Oh, but Shadow Weaver had been trying to crush her trust for so long… She wanted to “prove to her” that she was, in fact, a monster, yet when she had the chance, when she *almost* did it, she only proved the sorceress was right.

Ah, but now she wouldn’t tell her any of this…

The time for it had passed, and didn’t want Castaspella to know she had eavesdropped on her conversation with Micah.

Or how much it hurt- no, *angered* her…

It had been long ago.

Things had changed…

She should forget it…

Chapter End Notes

Don't worry, there will be more about these events in the next chapter <("^_^) I promise

And I don't think I have anything else to say
Sorry, I'm "silent" today heh

Erm, I hope you enjoyed the chapter and until next week!!

The things we do - Part 1

Chapter Summary

King Micah has finally understood the pattern of his sister's hair and now knows exactly when she's gone to see Shadow Weaver. As his concern rises, his attempts to find the magical groove become more frequent, and the Best Friends Squad struggles to keep him away.

Meanwhile, Delwyn's help allows Castaspella to take more breaks, take the pupils to see Shadow Weaver, and gives her more time to search for a way to keep the woman on the surface.
But despite it all, not everyone is fond of the idea.

Chapter Notes

I know I said there would be more about the events narrated in the previous chapter, but I kind of forgot to add it, so I'll say it here and MAAAAAYBE manage to add it in future chapters: SW only heard a fragment of Micah and Casta's convo, where Casta was actually trying to get him off their backs a bit, hence having totally lied. Normally, SW would have easily realized she was lying, but because of the mood in which she was, she took those words as real. Perhaps and only perhaps, one can say that, later on, with them more in-sync, SW wouldn't have misinterpreted at all.

ANYWAYS, this chapter is still important and, if you thought SW was jealous before, then you'll be quite surprised by this chapter, hah!

Alright now, please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—Good morning— the Head Sorceress greeted, walking into the Library.

As she approached one of the desks, where Delwyn waited for her with a couple of scrolls, he noticed her hair up in a bun and smiled softly as he replied —Good morning. I see you're in a good mood.

—Very funny— she let out, rolling her eyes yet unable to hold back a grin and a faint blush. —To the matter at hand, if you don't mind. What do you have here?

—These are about the affinities you mentioned the other day. It's the last idea I have. If this doesn't work…

—Two months of failed training. I swear, this better work or I will go insane— she grunted, resting her hands on the table and looking down.

—I can't guarantee it, but it's worth a shot, no?

—Alright, yes. What do you have?

—Well, to begin with, you may have to start classes at sunset. That way, you can spare half the class to train those with daylight affinity, and the other half for those with moonlight affinity— he began. —Or, alternatively, you could divide your class to train at the usual time but later too, perhaps?

—She also told me I should have classes at night for those with an affinity to nighttime, especially because Sahm has both and needs better training— she admitted.

—All the more reasons, don't you think?

—But as I told her back then— she continued, raising her head to look at him with a resigned expression. —Training at night has been forbidden. Both classes and pieces of training, because they are considered dangerous.

—Can't you appeal to the rule, perhaps? It sounds unfair for any magician with moonlight affinity— he suggested.

She shook her head and, looking away with her arms folded, explained —I wasn't the one to ban them. It's usually seen as… disrespectful to undo what previous Heads of the Guild have done…

—You wouldn't be disrespecting anyone. If anything, you're respecting the pupils and guaranteeing the best tuition for them. That is a part of your job, is it not?

—But…

—Just try.

—Fine, fine. I will.

—Good— he said, tilting his head forward in approval. —Now, if you don't mind, I have some important duties to attend to, but please don't hesitate to call me when you need this information for your classes.

—Of course. Thank you.

As he left the Library, she sat down on a nearby couch and noticed that Delwyn came across Micah at the entrance. After he politely bowed at him and continued on his way, she saw the King look in her direction and hesitate to approach.

Ultimately, he decided against it and walked away. He had noticed her hair and. It seemed stupid but he couldn't keep denying it.

There was only one explanation as to *why* she had her bun only sometimes…

It was always after she had gone to see her, wasn't it?

It had to be, nothing else made sense.

The following day, at her usual class time, the Head Sorceress announced that nighttime classes were now available but optional, and that two acolytes would be there to supervise in case anything happened. That was the agreement reached by the council that, surprisingly, seemed eager to get rid of the ban.

However, while everyone looked astound, both hers and Shadow Weaver's pupils, Sahm wasn't. In fact, he wore a smug expression as he looked around at his classmates' shocked expressions.

—Sahm— she called, curious. —Something to share with the class? You don't seem surprised in the slightest.

—I- No, well… I was- I was at the Library, yesterday, and accidentally heard when you were talking with that guy about this…— he explained, now looking more nervous than anything.

—*That guy* is Ambassador Zhaleh, you should be more respectful— she reproached him, serious but gentle. —And remember he's helping with your classes. Including this new schedule.

—It was fine with our Master's help— Sahm uttered, folding his arms and looking away.

With a pained frown, Castaspella leant down to his height, saying —I understand what you mean, but this was also something we were discussing with her before she was dismissed, alright? You can ask her the next time we go to see her. She wanted this.

Still looking away, he reluctantly replied —Fine. I'll ask her.

She smiled cheerfully at him before standing up, and finally started her diurnal class.

That night, as promised, the Head Sorceress offered the pupils a nocturnal class that only some kids took, with some help from Delwyn. He did his best despite the animosity they showed, and promptly retired as soon as the class was over. Castaspella tried not to get angry at them as she understood why they behaved that way, but when she left to see Shadow Weaver, the sorceress couldn't hide her annoyance.

—If they don't like him, just keep him out of the classes— Shadow Weaver argued.

—I can't do this alone, Bea— Castaspella reminded her. —I need the help…

—Never mind— she interrupted, waving a hand dismissively. —How has the *other* issue been?

—I don't know. I just know they are handling it, so I don't have to.

—Good…

With that, the women changed subjects once more and continued their chat for hours, entirely unaware of what happened with "the other issue" outside the magical groove.

The Best Friends Squad closely followed king Micah through the Woods, careful not to alert him. Bow remained at the back, constantly checking his tracking pad, while Adora led the group.

—We shouldn't worry much, the Woods aren't letting him find the groove— she assured them.

—Let's keep following him until he gives up— Glimmer suggested. —Just in case.

—I agree— Catra nodded. And so, they settled at a safe distance to keep an eye on the King. After a while, she called Glimmer's attention. —Hey, I… saw your aunt, talking with Delwyn again. At the

Library.

—Again?

—Yeah. And there are more rumors about it… How he's "taking up" the post Shadow weaver left— she continued, squinting in disgust. —Can't people leave your aunt in peace?

—I don't know. I don't get it— Glimmer admitted.

—Now I understand why she's so desperate. I mean, it's Shadow Weaver we're talking about. Of course, she's gonna be… jealous and angry, and petty, about all of this…— Catra reflected. —I wouldn't expect her to be fine with that, but… I guess I understand why she's being like this. All paranoid and irritable…

—You don't have to justify her, you know?— Adora reminded her.

—Yeah, but I mean it. I say it because I'm sure its true, but she just won't admit it.

—Not a chance she will— Glimmer agreed.

—We have movement— Bow interrupted.

The four fell silent and watched as the King finally gave up and walked away, with a defeated expression. But the way he kept his fists tightly closed, and his sight fixed on the ground, was something Catra easily recognized as hardened resolve.

He was giving up now, but not for good.

After a few weeks, in which the Head Sorceress grew increasingly wary, she arrived one night at the groove in a terrible mood. She was received, as usual, by a very mocking Shadow Weaver, but wouldn't follow her game this time.

Arms fold and back straight, she asked —Anything you haven't told me, Bea?

—Anything about…

—About a certain favour that you may have asked a number of people?— she replied, checking her nails to look aloof despite being clearly annoyed.

—I don't know what you're talking about.

—You know perfectly well what I'm talking about— Castaspella retorted, squinting at her. —One last chance: What did you do?

—What if I don't tell you?

Taken aback for a second, the sorceress thought quickly and, pretending aloofness once more, she answered —I suppose I will be *too busy* to come…

Shadow Weaver immediately glared at her, not even trying to hide her irritation.

They had perhaps spent too much time together, for Castaspella to be able to do exactly what she would have done in her place.

How dared…

Oh, but she had to admit it was a good move after all…

—Fine then. Sahm, Adora, and Catra. Only them, and only when you're around that… *ambassador*— she finally admitted.

—Why have you asked them to keep an eye on me!?

—Because you have that guy around you all the time!

—What!? Are you trying to control who I'm friends with!?—Castaspella exclaimed, shocked. —Wasn't it *you* who didn't want to be friends even with me? What *is* your problem!?

—I'm no longer around so now you have replaced me with *him*!

—*Replaced*!? You sound like Micah! I am *not* replacing you!

—Then why, *why*, do you have that man around you all day!?— Shadow Weaver inquired, raising her hands as she got angrier, opening and closing her claws.

—No, no. Stop this madness— the sorceress denied, shaking her head and gesturing with her hands. —First, it's not "all day". You're *literally* the only person who has *ever* been around me the entirety of the day— she began. Somewhat calm yet noticeably indignant, she went on —Second, dragging others into this lunacy of yours and basically spying on me just because you're *jealous*, is not what you think it is! Nothing justifies it, and it's actually what Micah did! You *are* behaving like him in every sense!

—But…

—And third, you're an *idiot*!

—Cas!

—Save it!

The sorceress immediately stalked away and left the groove before Shadow Weaver could reach her. In the short time before she sank under the surface, overwhelming regret gripped her, making the woman feel sick.

That was the price of caring for someone.

The price of aggravating someone you *love*.

More reasons to despise such feelings…

The following day, Castaspella took Adora and Catra to the magical groove before noon. The moment Shadow Weaver emerged, she knew what it was about. But she didn't know the Head Sorceress hadn't told them.

—Now. I need you three to explain exactly what you thought you were doing when you agreed to… spy on me— she began, arms folded and stern expression. —Wasn't it enough with all the spying you

two had already done? Or with all the times *we* were spied on or deceived in different ways? I can understand Sahm agreeing to this, he's a kid, will do *anything* his Master tells him to do, and particularly dislikes Ambassador Zhaleh. But you three doing this circus!?

—I-I'm so sorry, Head Sorceress— Catra began, taking a step forward. —I- Yes, it was stupid. We shouldn't have… A-and there's no excuse for it… I just- We wanted to… I just wanted to help— she explained, nervous and apologetic. —I didn't allow Glimmer or Bow to get involved, and, Adora and I just- We wanted to help her. To- Just to prove nothing is happening with Delwyn!

—And *nothing is happening*!

Castaspella's exclamation left them speechless, and a tense silence settled for a moment. The one to break it was Catra as she apologized one more time.

Anxious, she uttered —Please, again. I'm sorry for doing it again. It won't happen again.

—No, no. Go ahead, continue— the sorceress let out, with an ambiguous tone. —Perhaps you will finally convince her of how ridiculous this is— she added, making it obvious how annoyed she was. —As long as this jealousy show ends…

Jealousy!?

No, no, no, and no.

It was absurd… She was *not* jealous!

Or, perhaps she was?

Ah, but not like she would let them know that.

Before she could say anything, Catra spoke up again, less nervous but ashamed, stammering a bit.

—I-I'm sure we can do that. Please accept my apologies once more.

And Castaspella did accept them, but before she could tell her, the three looked back at Shadow Weaver as the woman scoffed and let out a bitter laugh.

—This is perhaps your fourth apology already. Are you unable to bear the guilt of something this little?

—Spin…

—I don't understand how you haven't made the same scene about everything you've done during the war— she reproached her.

That woman...

She wanted to jump on her.

Catra closed her fists tightly, clenched her jaw, and felt her body grow tense with rage.

But she remembered what she had reflected weeks ago: she understands. Shadow Weaver *is* jealous. This is just an act to deflect, isn't it?

Surely.

So what would be the point of jumping into an argument over this?

No, she had to calm down.

Catra took a deep breath and eased down her hair as she said —No. It’s not the same. It would mean nothing. And the guilt won’t suddenly vanish. It will take time. You’re too impatient.

Shadow Weaver squinted at her, until she began slowly approaching while saying —Impatient!? You clearly have *no idea* what it is like to be constantly bombarded with memories and regretting things that happened *so long ago* they are now irreversible! Being forced to relive those events, noticing everything you did *wrong*, but having *no power* to fix it!

She did not…

Damned be her efforts to avoid confrontation.

All the crippling fear she felt when the woman approached suddenly turned into pure rage.

—Are you *insane*!? I literally can't sleep because of that! Every night! Every time I try to go to sleep, I remember all the shit I did, even after you left the Horde, and how much I hurt everyone!— she began, yelling angrily. —Do you *really* think you're the only "poor soul" suffering for the shit of her past!? I even managed to virtually "kill" an immortal being as is Glimmer’s mother! Don't you think that keeps me awake!? Don't you think I feel excruciating guilt because of that!?

—Because it *is* your fault…

—Stop it— Castaspella interrupted.

—…I mean, just as it's my fault that you activated the portal in the first place— Shadow Weaver continued. —It was because I abandoned you, wasn't it?

—I…— Catra hesitated. After a moment, she shook her head and tears began falling down her face. —Why did you!? Why… why did you play with me like that!?

—I have no answer to that.

Her expression betrayed nothing. It was difficult to understand what she meant.

—Why!?

—Because there is none! I had no reason, I just did it. Never thought of it as "abandoning you", it was just…

—Going for Adora— Catra interrupted her.

—Yes. And the information I had was my bargain chip— Shadow Weaver explained.

Both of them had finally calmed down and neither Castaspella nor Adora had to interfere, so the latter dared to chime in.

—Other than the information, why were you looking for me? You didn't know I could heal you.

—I didn’t *want* to be healed, I didn’t want to be saved, that was… an additional benefit— she began. —No. I only wanted revenge on the Horde, to ruin Hordak’s plan, and the only one who could do so,

was *you*. I intended to tell you what he planned, so you could share it with the rest of the Rebellion, and that would be all— she explained, nonchalantly. —I wasn't counting on a full inquisition and the prohibition to see you— she added, sparing a glance at the Head Sorceress. —*That* is why I didn't just say it from the beginning, even if it was my initial idea.

—So she also toyed around with you, eh? Never straightforward…— Catra let out, folding her arms and smirking slightly.

—Only Adora would believe me, or so I thought…— Shadow Weaver replied, as if anticipating what Adora and Castaspella were thinking. —What would be the point in telling those two if they would just dismiss my words?

Understanding what "those two" meant, the sorceress folded her arms and glared as she muttered — Charming…

Although she could hear it, the woman ignored her and told Adora —While the part of "I miss you" was obviously too fake, when I said I could only trust you, I meant it. And you proved as much when you trusted me to teach you, didn't you?

—What? What happened there?— Catra asked, confused and surprised.

—I-I wanted to heal her because… she was dying from using her powers to go to Bright Moon— Adora explained, looking away. —But I didn't know yet how to heal. She taught me and I… saved her.

—She almost died for *you*. To see *you*. While I… rot in her cell…

Catra's realization hit them all equally, but Shadow Weaver refused to show it and remained mostly impassive.

—How was I even supposed to know you would take my place? I thought you were smarter than that — she decided to say, trying to hide the sorrow Castaspella could feel through the spell.

—She *is*. Stop with that. And she was only…

—It doesn't matter, Adora!— Catra interrupted, angry again. —She won't care! It will be the "I don't need your pity" or "caring is a weakness" all over again!

—And was I wrong?— Shadow Weaver asked, pretending more indignation than she actually felt. — If you didn't care, you wouldn't have…

—Well, I did! Because I hoped you cared for me too!

A tense silence settled. No one dared speak after that.

But Castaspella felt what Shadow Weaver was feeling, the regret and anger clashing inside her.

—So many years and you didn't learn…

And she did it…

Castaspella hoped she wouldn't, but she let her stupid beliefs win once more.

She was so close…

—You!— Catra exclaimed. She was furious, angry tears formed in her eyes, and frustration took over her. —Ugh, why do I even- *Why* do I keep trying!?

She cursed herself internally and ran away before anyone could stop her.

—Ca-Catra, wait!

Adora immediately followed her, barely holding back tears.

Castaspella, on the other hand, looked back at Shadow Weaver with a look of disappointment and, before leaving to find the girls, she reproached her —You just *had to*, no?

Oh, the things some people do to keep up a façade…

The things some people do out of love…

The things… some do out of pain…

Chapter End Notes

I won't lie: I feel like I rushed the spying thing a bit BUT, tbh, I decided to give that matter a different treatment, I'll just handle it another way. Instead of building it, I'll just develop the aftermath.
Like, Casta said "whatever, keep spying" and both Catra and Adora know it's better to keep reporting to SW just so her jealousy doesn't grow into something worse ~~and toxic~~.

But well… perhaps I could have built it for a chapter or two…
Never mind. I rather have it this way now, it gives the feeling that Sahm messed up and that had Casta noticed far too quickly, no? Heh

Well! Thank you all for reading! I hope you enjoyed, and see you next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Dropping the façade won't harm you
Status: Being seriously doubted

Chapter Notes

I am so sorry for the late posting. I've been busy beta-testing a videogame (ver6.1 of Honkai Impact 3rd, if u play it, u'll love it) and just yesterday finished with the whole deal, so I wasn't done writing this chapter.
Now, after a whole day of doing stuff and having to wait so much to correct it, especially since I had class earlier, it's finally ready, so I hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

How *weak*.

Who?

Catra, or Shadow Weaver?

Both maybe?

One couldn’t bear the cold treatment, which she should have been expecting. The other couldn’t bear her own emotions, which were to be expected too.

She had disappointed Castaspella and hurt Catra once again. So much for regretting what she has done…

However, seeing Catra’s anger before she ran away, not mere sorrow but rather an angry frustration, reminded Shadow Weaver of herself once more.

Hadn’t she been in her place months ago?

That acolyte who spoke to her in the same manner she usually does, condescending and belittling… They maddened her beyond imagination, and she almost attacked them before Castaspella stopped her. While Catra, having apparently developed more self-control, stopped herself without help, and ended up crying out of frustration. Wasn’t that the case?

In a way, the sorceress saved her. Otherwise, she would have been dismissed right there and then.

Instead, seeing how she behaved in such a similar situation, Light Spinner had to admit she was proud of Catra.

Although she had told her so before, this time she wouldn't dare. It would mean nothing after saying all of that…

It was… *conflicting*.

And so, as she allowed the memory of her issue with the acolyte to return, she wondered what Catra would have done in her place…

She had been teaching for almost four months now.

Four months of eager tutoring.

Four months of being obeyed by her pupils, and no incidents had ever happened.

But now this acolyte *had* to interfere, no?

Potion-making had always been practically a game for Shadow Weaver, and she knew perfectly well the dangers of improperly handling their preparation.

Yet the acolyte kept objecting to her instructions. Why were they even there?

To help, according to the Head Sorceress, but the destroyed phial proved otherwise.

After being refuted so many times, she decided to leave them to instruct as they pleased, knowing perfectly well what would happen. Although she didn't expect Castaspella to be enough of a fool to protect the kids but not herself when the vial exploded…

—How much does your brain charge you for thinking?

Shadow Weaver had gotten between the sorceress and the flask right before it shattered, and all the shards that were supposed to hit Castaspella were stuck in the woman's summoned body.

Fortunately, it means nothing; that body is pure magic, she can't bleed and felt a mere sting. But the same couldn't be said of the *very much alive* sorceress.

Almost immediately, Castaspella dropped the shield she had cast over the kids and turned around to find Shadow Weaver *technically* protecting her.

—I- No, I…

—Save it.

It seemed like she wanted to retort but, instead, she only turned around and addressed the kids.

—Please, everyone, return to your rooms calmly; those who don't live here, please remain with your classmates until further notice— she ordered.

—They are kids…— Shadow Weaver mumbled, rolling her eyes upon hearing Castaspella's vocabulary. However, she ignored her and approached the acolyte instead, mustering all the strength she had to stay calm when talking to them. When she stopped in front of them, they watched in shock how, as she was sufficiently far away from the sorceress, all the glass shards dropped to the ground, and it left them speechless. She also ignored their expression and calmly said —May I ask *why* you were so… adamant on refuting my instructions?

—You have no authority over me— they simply replied.

Clenching her jaw for a moment, she reminded them —She is *my* pupil. And *I* clearly have far more knowledge than you; I'm older and have dedicated my life to learning.

—If you are *so* knowledgeable, then why didn't you do something before the vial exploded? Uh? — they questioned her. The acolyte then folded their arms and added —I suppose you must have known this would happen.

—If you had let *my* pupil follow *my* directives…

—No kid should follow *your* orders. *Any* order— they finally said, their tone acid, while squinting at her in a way that apparently called Castaspella's attention.

—You…

—Wait— the sorceress stopped her, just in time.

Shadow Weaver hadn't noticed how she raised her hands menacingly and was almost growling; she wanted to kill them right there.

How dare they!

That dimwit!

—They are…

—I know— Castaspella calmly interrupted her, gesturing at her with a hand to stop talking. —I have to disagree with your assessment of the situation— she told them both. —If anyone is to blame for this incident, that's me. I am supposed to supervise the class, including what either of you instructs the kids, and I should have noticed the phial wasn't stable.

—Tha-that's not…

—*Now*— the Head Sorceress continued, purposely cutting in on the acolyte's nervous attempt to contradict her. —Help me pick up this mess… Both of you.

Reluctantly, the two of them complied and, with the help of a second acolyte that arrived shortly after, before long they were done.

However, as soon as Castaspella was out of earshot, the acolyte went to speak with their colleague, sparing quick glances at Shadow Weaver, which made her pay attention to their conversation.

—...A menace, I'm telling you.

—Then why…

—I don't know what our Head Sorceress was thinking.

There it was again. The unbearable urge to end that poor excuse of a magician's life.

The woman closed her fists tightly, took a step forward, but immediately stopped herself as she saw Castaspella approach.

No, no.

She was *not* going to let this all be blamed on her.

She wasn't the one to be told off this time.

Without waiting for the sorceress to speak, Shadow Weaver turned around and left, seething.

—I- Ugh, fine— Castaspella sighed behind her.

The woman could still hear them all for a moment while walking away, but it only angered her even more.

—You will just let her go!?— the acolyte questioned.

—How I handle her is *not* of your concern. And it is *you* with whom I have to talk now…

—How is this my fault!?

Oh, *of course* it was their fault.

Why did they have to be so nasty!?

Well, she usually was too…

Ah! But this was different!

This fool ruined it!

Before long, she was at the beach once again and slowly walked further and further away from the buildings. After a while, she found a spot to sit down, closed her eyes, and muttered her complaints.

She wasn't sure how long it had been but, eventually, her angry mumbling was interrupted by a sudden hug from behind. She saw Castaspella's arms wrapped around her torso and pushed back slightly.

—What are you doing?

—I want you to calm down.

—Why? I did *nothing*. I have the right to be angry!

—I know. It was a valid question…

—Then why- Never mind.

—What?

—Leave it!

She practically barked back at her, and regretted it immediately, but she was *not* going to apologize.

However, instead of being offended or having literally any other reaction more fit to the situation, the sorceress simply hugged her tighter and took a deep breath.

—Breathe, Beatrix. Calm down.

—I cannot really breathe anymore, you know?

—It's not about the actual air intake, you know?— she countered. —It's just a… psychological thing. You just need the effect of taking a deep breath.

—It's ridiculous! I won't- It's stupid! And that acolyte…

—I know, I know. It's fine. It wasn't your fault this time— Castaspella interrupted, still hugging her. —Let's think about it, alright? Yes, he was mean, you hadn't been disrespectful, your question was only logical, yet he was almost violent in his reply. But tell me, if you hurt him or someone else because of that… what do you think it would fix? Your hurt ego? Your hurt feelings?

—I don't have…

—And it would make you the villain once again— she interrupted. —You've done nothing wrong lately, Bea.

—I don't give a damn about that anymore. Everyone but *you* still sees me as a monster, and that's probably because you're too stubborn or simply won't admit I have no hope. Ah! And I'm *dead*. Why should I care?

—Just do me a favor and *try* to breathe, please.

—Fine— she sighed. She leant back on the sorceress and closed her eyes while taking a deep breath as she would have done when alive. She felt nothing, no air being inhaled, no sensation of her lungs being filled with air, but she did feel her mind clear a bit. —Alright, it… does work.

—Good to know— Castaspella replied, with a tone that made it obvious she was smiling. —Do it a few more times.

—Don't you have somewhere to be?

—Yes, I have to explain what happened in class, but I'll do so after you're calmer.

—I'm not a baby…

—It's just something I want to do— the sorceress replied, sighing deeply. —I need this too, if I'm fully honest.

—I see…

She still couldn't believe that Castaspella dared to stay even when she was at risk of being hurt because of how angry Shadow Weaver was.

But it was the norm with her.

And that had been… quite a day. Especially since, after "explaining what happened", she had returned to her room practically fuming.

She had felt her frustration through the spell and, when she found her, the woman was pretty much moping on the floor of her bathroom. The least she could do was help her like Castaspella had done earlier, no? One good turn deserves another.

Yes, the sorceress deserved it…

Now, comparing that situation with what had just happened… She wasn't going to complain like the acolyte.

No.

She knows it was her fault.

Ugh, but she couldn't help it.

Or could she?

Not yet.

A part of her wanted, but… thinking about it, wouldn't it look fake from her?

Well, if anyone believes she can change, that's the three people she just disappointed.

How idiotic of her.

No…

How *normal* of her. The behavior everyone else expected from a *monster*.

Yes, everyone but Castaspella sees her as a monster, while Adora and Catra seem on a limbo, wanting to believe she has *some* good within her yet unable to trust as much as the sorceress due to everything Shadow Weaver put them through.

But if she keeps choosing to behave the way everyone else expects, of course she will be seen as a heartless monster.

Why did she try to prove Castaspella wrong when she should have tried to prove everyone else wrong?

Why can't she drop the façade, at least for the girls, when she's been working on understanding and regretting how she wronged them?

Great question.

What would she do if she were the one trying to teach her that?

Another great question.

Following her logic, she would probably be punishing herself every time she did something like what she did to Catra just earlier.

But Castapella's logic is *much* different. The sorceress believes punishment breeds resistance and resentment.

And, curiously enough, that was exactly what happened to her, what happened to Catra, and what that princess had mentioned months before.

What had she said? That 85% of times it resulted in- No, that it failed to correct the behaviour was it? Something like that.

But then, what about that 15%?

Perhaps…

Well, punishments *had* "corrected" her behaviour for years. But then she completely changed when she realized it meant nothing and that she was still punished regardless of what she did.

Right. Just like it happened with Catra.

That princess was right.

Castaspella was right.

Ugh…

Why was everything so difficult!?

Chapter End Notes

Well... I mean, it's kinda logical, no?

Nvm, it's difficult to show progress already, but there's the seed of regret and change that I need to show.

I'll just roll with it for now and hope you guys like it, heh.

Aaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaand, I don't have much to say other than the apology for posting so late. Oh well, maybe that, as u can see, here u have a bit more about the vial incident.

Erm, well, until next week it is!

The things we do - Part 2

Chapter Summary

After the failed conversation with Shadow Weaver, Castaspella tries to speak with the girls, help them calm down, and some difficult truths are laid out along with unexpected news.

»—She's… trying to learn to apologize to you. *For you*.
»—She never does anything for me! Why!? It's all always for Adora!
»—Not this time… That much I can promise you. But, as to why…— the sorceress sighed. —I suppose… it's just… difficult for her to do things for you.
»—Why!?
»—She sees herself in you and no one ever did anything for her— she calmly explained.

Furthermore, Delwyn learns about the little spying thing, and his reaction is *not* what anyone would have expected…

Chapter Notes

While editing I got the feeling this chapter is a bit rushed but, idk, you tell me…

In fact, I was falling asleep while editing, I so hope nothing is too wrong, oh mein…

Erm, and I think it's a bit shorter than anticipated? I'm so sorry, it's been an hectic week…

I'll stop writing like that.
Please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After walking through the woods for a good while, the sorceress was already arriving at the edge of the Whispering Woods, trying to find Adora and Catra. More sunlight reached her the further she walked, and her surroundings became clearer as the trees reduced in number.

—So much for wanting to apologize…— she mumbled angrily between her teeth. However, her fury was quickly replaced by relief when she finally found the girls seated against a tree nearby. —Oh, girls! There you are.

As she approached, she saw them so focused on their conversation it didn't surprise her that they hadn't noticed her.

—She *hates* me!— Catra exclaimed, frustrated, leaving Adora disheartened as she realized Catra was giving up again.

—No, no. She doesn't— Castaspella let out as she arrived, casually chiming in.

—Of course she does!

She knelt next to Catra and in front of Adora, concerned, and carefully placed a hand on Catra's shoulder.

—No, no. Listen. She's… *trying* to learn to apologize to you. *For you*.

—She *never* does anything for me!— she immediately exclaimed. —Why!? It's all always for Adora!

—Not this time… That much I can promise you. But, as to why…— the sorceress sighed. —I suppose… it's just… difficult for her to do things for you.

—*Why*!?

Catra was trying really hard not to cry, but at this point, it was either that or snapping at the sorceress, and she didn't want to do either.

—She sees herself in you and no one ever did anything for her— she calmly explained.

—And that is *my* fault!?

—It isn't… you were just- It was a coincidence that you ended up under her care— Castaspella replied, with a pained look.

—Just *why* did she have to be there!? If she hadn't joined the Horde… if we hadn't been trained by her, at least…

—I believe there was a reason for that too— the sorceress hesitantly said. After considering it for a moment, she added —Would you like to know?

—If you say something cheesy, I'm not talking to you again.

Castaspella did *not* expect that response, nor her deadpan expression, so the Head Sorceress was taken aback for a moment, just processing that. It wasn't annoying, but rather a bit offending that she thought like that.

—Do you want to hear it or not?

—Well, fine! Say it!

—Sometimes, people come into our lives to teach us what love is not— she began, sighing and easily catching their attention. —This is what she did to you. She may not have loved you, but at least you could appreciate true love because of that.

—You say we *had* to suffer her!?— Catra exclaimed, shocked.

—No! No, no, never— Castaspella immediately replied. —If I could turn back time to make sure that never happened, I would— she sincerely assured them. —But, the things that happen in our lives aren't- It's not the universe hating us; you can always learn something from everything that happens to you. In this case, learning what true love is, and what mere manipulation is.

While Catra just looked away, frowning, Adora remained thoughtful. It made sense to her, and she was looking for a way to explain it.

—Well, it was easy for me to realize hers had all been manipulation after meeting Bow and Glimmer — she commented. —And… she told us she wouldn't let herself love us— Adora hesitantly let out, remembering their first conversation after her summoning.

—I'm aware— the sorceress admitted. —But that is exactly what it means: she didn't let herself love you, she *decided* not to give either of you any love. Which, sincerely, makes little difference. In the end, the effect it had on you remains— she explained.

Bewildered still, Catra asked —But I don't understand. *How*? Why would we have any need for *that* "experience"?

—That's the tricky part— she replied, catching their attention again. —You see… When someone is favored by an authority figure, like Adora was, their equals will feel envy and even hatred for them, especially someone who is treated worse than their equals by that same authority figure— she elaborated, looking at Catra. —And yet, did it happen? Was she hated by your peers? Did *you* hate her?

—Of course not!— she exclaimed, indignant. —She's always been the most gentle person in the Fright Zone, too gentle for the Horde. Like Scorpia.

—And you were able to see it. In spite of all you've gone through, you could see that people like Adora, or Scorpia as you said, offered true love— Castaspella pointed out.

—So… If it weren't for her cruelty… No, no! I would have appreciated them regardless!

—With time, yes— she agreed. —But, initially, you would have thought they were faking it, trying to win everyone over… In a place like the Horde, you're meant to think that.

—How do you know that?— Adora questioned, confused.

—Wait. She *actually* said that?— Catra asked right after, in utter disbelief.

The sorceress nodded before explaining, with a smirk and a hint of irony, —Supposedly to… "encourage competitiveness" and avoid the "fatal mistakes" that sentimentality brings. Not a surprise coming from someone who thinks being in love is a distraction…

—Don't tell me she still insists on that…

—You should have heard her in class! Those girls were so sad after she mentioned it, *every time*; but the idea of proving her wrong motivated them, so it absolutely backfired!— the sorceress told them, a bit too amused. The three of them laughed wholeheartedly for a moment, and she went on —You see, girls. There's something I will always admire about you two, and that is how you were able to heal and grow after all you've been through. And I know there's more healing to do, for both of you, but you have so much potential and gave your all when the world needed you. I'd even say it *still* needs you. So here I'm hoping you won't give up.

Castaspella gave Catra a gentle look, which Adora mirrored, and finally moved her hand away from her shoulder.

However, the girl only curled up, hugged her legs in a way the sorceress had already seen, and muttered —It's difficult to heal from never being… chosen. It was always Adora for her.

Castaspella felt the need to place her hand back on Catra's shoulder and exchanged a concerned look with Adora.

—If her not choosing you, made you choose yourself… I'd say you won more than you lost, dear.

After those words, Catra leant back on the tree again and silently cried for a moment. Adora, holding one of her hands, also let a tear fall as she stared at her.

—I-I'm sorry. I'm just… a bit sensitive right now, I shouldn't be crying…— the girl finally said, brushing away her tears before placing her free hand over her abdomen.

Oh, could it be?

Castaspella hesitated for a moment before asking —Is it… what I think it is?

Adora giggled and nodded.

—I'll suppose so— Catra laughed, looking back at her with a faint smile.

—Ah! I'm so happy for you two!— the sorceress exclaimed with great excitement. However, her expression immediately changed, and she looked at them with a sad look. —But wait, you haven't married yet, right? Or did I miss your wedding?

—No, no. We… haven't yet planned it— Adora replied, barely holding back her amusement.

—Oh, perfect!— she exclaimed, suddenly standing up and extremely excited. —It must be the *greatest* event ever! The saviours of Etheria getting married!— she laughed, thrilled. —It will be splendorous!

At that, Catra raised a hand and opened her mouth to say something, wanting to stop her, but Adora grabbed her hand and shook her head, whispering —Let her ramble.

Later that week, Delwyn was, once again, helping the Head Sorceress at the library. They had been speaking about the pupils and their performance, until he suddenly changed subjects.

Smirking a bit, he commented —It seems like I've upset your significant other, haven't I?

—Oh, no. You noticed?

—In fact, I just had a feeling and wasn't sure. It was Catra who confirmed it the other day— he explained.

—I-I am *so* sorry— she stuttered. —Ho-honestly. She just…

—No need, please don't worry. I understand— he interrupted, calmly gesturing at her to stop talking. —And I don't mind. I've told Catra she can keep reporting to her if that will ease her mind.

—I- Well, that's… unexpected. Still, I'm sorry.

—Don't be, I insist. My… spouse was like that too. It's for the best.

Oh.

—Ah… I see— she sighed, looking down but letting out half a smile. —In that case, I should thank you.

—It's no trouble at all.

She certainly didn't think he'd react that way, nor could she have imagined what he would say.

"My spouse was like that too".

It left her thinking.

No wonder he had been so adamant on helping her, and what he did after forcing her to dance with him suddenly made more sense.

That thought led her to think about how he was right: that dance was *special* for her, and having danced it with someone else was… She couldn't even find the right words.

Besides, all of this had been caused because Shadow Weaver was jealous yet wouldn't admit it; if she knew about the dance, what would she do?

Hours later, the Head Sorceress found herself back in the magical groove. The sun had set shortly before, she had taken with her everything needed to spend the night once again, *and* she had caught Shadow Weaver in a good mood.

—In any case, whatever it is that has you like this, I'm grateful— she said, both teasing and genuinely happy.

—Of course you are. I should have known you'd make a fuss about it.

—It's just a rare occurrence!

—Well, your reaction certainly doesn't encourage me to be "in a good mood" more often…

—Sorry, I-I hadn't… realized— the sorceress stuttered. —But, yes. I suppose… messing with you is less than encouraging. I was just… happy.

—Why would you be *so* happy about something so insignificant?

—Never mind, it's not important— she dismissed her, looking away. After a moment, she turned back and extended a hand at her. —Do you mind? We… haven't danced in a while now.

Castaspella smiled gently, although she was internally screaming. She couldn't believe she had dared ask her for a dance.

At the same time, Shadow Weaver found herself in absolute shock, and unable to choose.

She wanted to accept.

But she didn't want to let the sorceress know just how much she wanted it.

She had been thinking about their dancing for a while now, but refused to admit so, even to herself.

And there was nothing on Etheria that could make her admit exactly what Shadow Weaver was feeling at that exact moment.

However, as dignified as possible, the woman finally grabbed her hand with a firm grip.

—And you will find no better dancer than me, dead or alive— she assured her, smirking.

—Right. How could I forget…— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes yet unable to hold back a smile.

And so, slowly, they began dancing as if they were back in Mystacor, swaying to some imaginary melody. But their steps seemed to be mirrored by their messy thoughts, which they both tried to ignore.

They couldn't help but think about that kiss and how they hadn't mentioned it again. Unaware that the other was thinking about the same, their reflections led them to the same conclusion: if she didn't mention it, then it didn't matter to her, and it's better not to bring it up lest their fragile relationship gets ruined.

Castaspella considered herself to be cursed, metaphorically speaking, as she had fallen for the one person in Etheria who wouldn't ever accept love. Shadow Weaver, on the other hand, kept telling herself that the way the sorceress pulled away from their last kiss and quickly changed subjects, must have meant she regretted having kissed her in the first place.

But as they danced, Castaspella's thoughts kept going over their interactions and the subtle changes as time went by.

So much had changed, yet so much still remained.

They continued to dance in absolute silence, oblivious of what the other was thinking, yet enjoying the quietness and their enthralling dance.

Chapter End Notes

"If I could turn back time to make sure that never happened, I would." That may or may not be a foreshadowing of what some other fics (drafts) of mine are about lol

Oh well

Ah, in case you wondered, yeah, here you have Catra carrying Finn.
And just a detail no one will realize because only I have the actual chronologically detailed timeline, Finn will be born within 7 months, not 9. There will also be a Glimbow kid, but I have yet to plan when that girl is born, I think she was like 2 or 3 years younger than Finn, perhaps a bit more, so not just yet.

Well now! I hope you enjoyed the chapter and see you next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: loving, just like losing, is not as terrible as you feel
Status: acceptance process 50% complete.

Chapter Notes

Ugh, I don't like how I wrote this chapter… and it's so short… tho these are meant to be short but, I don't know… for a filler chapter, it could be better…

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this little introduction to deck fights!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What love is not" she said.

Well, she wasn't wrong, was she?

Shadow Weaver had put all her efforts into *not* showing love. And hearing that, she realized she had, in fact, succeeded. But…

Doesn't she regret it now?

Maybe… only maybe. Not quite yet, or at least not entirely.

She regrets a lot of the things she did, but she can't regret never giving them love because, in fact, it was their own love and care for her that doomed them.

With Adora, it made her gullible, susceptible to everything she told her until she learnt what true love is. But with Catra, even when she made her suffer so much, it had her make bad decisions. Or rather, what Shadow Weaver considered bad decisions.

If she hadn't cared for her, she would have escaped with Adora.

If she hadn't cared, she would have confronted and defeated her far earlier.

If she hadn't cared, she would have let her be sent to Beast Island, keeping Hordak's trust and her new position of power.

If she hadn't cared, she wouldn't have returned to the Fright Zone and activated that portal.

Love made her break reality, because loving so much yet not being loved in return broke her, did it not?

It must have felt like losing, right?

Yet another thing Shadow Weaver had taught Catra was reacting badly to losing because of what it meant…

Neither of them could bear it, they would suffer to the point of rage. In the Horde, it meant deserving punishment, and it frightened them, but instead of letting that be known, they would show pure wrath.

For Shadow Weaver, it would bring back plenty of nasty memories. So, what did it do to Catra?

Taking into account everything she had said, it must have made her fear the punishments, yes. However, that wasn't all, was it? Along with that, it would make her feel yet another step further from being in the woman's good graces, one step further from making her feel proud, which was something Catra craved, did she not?

And another losing game for her had been getting Adora to listen to her. Especially if the one she'd listen to, instead of her, was Shadow Weaver.

She could imagine nothing must have hurt her more than that. No wonder she left right after what happened with the failsafe…

But now Catra seemed very changed. Had she learnt to lose? Had she found people truly loving?

Certainly…

And Light Spinner had to admit, once again, that she was proud of her…

These reflections made her think about how she herself was being taught how to lose.

Yes, the sorceress put a lot of effort into that. She couldn't teach her to love, that was probably impossible. But losing? That was easy to teach…

And, perhaps, Castaspella enjoyed it a little too much.

A bit touched by the memory, which she reluctantly admitted, Beatrix allowed the memory to come. One of the many times they had played a funny little Mystacor game…

—Woo-hoo! I win again!

The Head Sorceress practically jumped from her seat after winning another round of the game.

Castaspella and Shadow Weaver were practically alone in the library, seated at a desk and playing a popular Mystacor game called "deck fights".

A simple cards game where you're handed ten cards with different sigils representing spells, and have to play either defense or offense until the one can't counter the spells anymore. When all ten cards are played, if no one won there's a tie, and the round doesn't count. But when one wins ten times, that needn't be consecutive, the game ends.

That had been the ninth round Castaspella won, again, and Shadow Weaver couldn't hold back.

—You *must* be cheating! It's impossible!— she yelled, slamming both hands on the table.

—I am not!— the sorceress replied, indignant.

—And you keep rubbing it in my face!

—Sorry, sorry! I didn't mean to!

—You *never* mean to, no?— Shadow Weaver let out, rolling her eyes.

—Oh, come on! Just learn to lose, or we'll never play with stakes…

—You don't want to play with stakes because you're a coward— she accused her, folding her arms.

—Oh really? You think so?— Castaspella asked, slowly leaning forward, both hands firmly planted on the table. She moved her face closer to Shadow Weaver's and, with a low voice, reminded her —I have nothing to fear. I always win.

And that, *that* caught the woman by surprise.

She couldn't help but blink a few times, shocked, and quickly hid her fluster with yet another angry reaction.

—You're just cheating!

As Shadow Weaver looked away, arms still folded, and face turned to the side, Castaspella couldn't help but giggle and move back.

—I am not… It's impossible to cheat in this game. It's all about strategy and luck, and *you* should know better than anyone that, sometimes, no matter how good of a strategist you are, it just isn't enough— the sorceress told her, eyes closed as she shuffled the deck once more. —Ready for the next round?

—Of course not! This is stupid!

Castaspella rolled her eyes and put down the deck, smirking slightly.

—Coward.

—Shut up!

—I'm about to win the game, you're a coward for backing down…

—You're a cheater!

—*I* have played this game for thirty years since I was *very* little. I don't cheat, I'm just good— the sorceress replied, finally fed up. —Haven't you played this before?

—I have…

—I sense a "but".

—I never lost.

Castaspella barely held back a laugh and shook her head, looking down.

—Of course…

—You can't be *that* good…

—Well, I am. I haven't lost in years; no one wants to play with me anymore— the sorceress replied, raising her head. Her expression darkened for a moment, but she quickly pushed it away and added —So better get used to the idea; you won't be winning any time soon…

That had been around their first games.

It was just so easy to accuse her of cheating…

Far more comfortable than admitting defeat.

But, eventually, it became easier.

Absolutely not because she enjoyed seeing Castaspella so happy. No, never.

It just became easier because it was expected. As she told her, she got used to it.

And once she managed to calmly accept defeat, she could pay more attention to what she had done, which allowed her to start winning some rounds.

Unfortunately, she never won any game, but once they began playing with stakes, winning a round was enough for her.

Before, she had considered asking Castaspella to take the decks down to the groove, and now she *definitely* wanted her to do so; she needed to keep playing until she could win a game.

Beatrix felt that those moments they shared were some of the best memories she had.

Especially because, to be completely honest with herself, she couldn't remember the last time she had played with someone…

Chapter End Notes

Oh gods, now I wanna include SW teaching Adora and Catra how to play deck fights! But I don't know how to introduce it organically… I don't wanna force it, and I don't know yet at what point SW will be in sufficiently good terms with the girls for that to happen…

In a different note, I feel like I couldn't properly establish the parallel between loving and losing… hopefully future filler chapters of this kind will be better (yes, there will be more of their games in future chapters)

Well, I still hope you could enjoy the read and see you next week!
Thank you for reading!!

Teaching

Chapter Summary

The Head Sorceress once again finds herself at an impasse, but this time, with with no possible way around it. With Ambassador Zhaleh out of Etheria, the only option is to have Micah teach Shadow Weaver's pupils and Catra if they want to improve.
However, they are all quite opposed to the idea as he is still getting in the way of Castaspella's relationship with Shadow Weaver.

Will they come to a truce? Or will they rather sacrifice their studies?

Furthermore, Shadow Weaver is hit with the fact that her spying of everything the Head Sorceress does with the ambassador isn't as innocuous as she thinks…

Chapter Notes

Welcome to: SW realizes she's having a very toxic behaviour but hadn't noticed.
I mean, for real, she had no idea. I'd even say Delwyn didn't notice it's not normal, far too in love with his late spouse, who was a lot like SW…
Damn, this was an accident, I didn't plan it, but it fits lol

Anyways, as I've said before: growth is not linear and requires time, requires failing, requires wake-up calls… so she's gonna have to fail a lot, otherwise she won't grow at all, you know?

Well, without further ado, I hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Only the faint light from the myriad of magical spores illuminated the groove as the women danced around to an imaginary melody. Even after dancing for so long, neither knew exactly why they were doing so, but both enjoyed it and couldn't find a reason to stop.

Occasionally they would speak, like when an idea suddenly came and had them comment something, sparkling a short conversation.

—I just remembered…— Shadow Weaver began. —I've been meaning to ask you to… bring the decks to play someday— she finally let out, still dancing gracefully but noticeably awkward.

—Oh, I- Really? You want to play?

—Well, I have to keep playing if I'm going to defeat you— the woman replied, smirking.

—Hah! Good luck with that…

Being met with a similar smirk, Shadow Weaver leant forward until they were but a breath away, and whispered —You better believe I will…

Oh.

That line…

Castaspella blinked a few times, almost missing a step, and stared in shock as she recalled having said the same words in a *much* different context.

Had she done so on purpose?

It was impossible to guess, and she wouldn't ask…

Time went on. The Head Sorceress continued imparting classes until she could no longer teach the pupils anything else. The same happened with Catra as her tutoring eventually stalled, and she once again refused to be taught by Micah.

Meanwhile, she and Adora moved to a cozy little cabin amidst the Whispering Woods and continued with their missions in space along Glimmer and Bow, despite Catra's pregnancy becoming more obvious.

After a month, Castaspella resignedly gave up. The classes were going nowhere, and even with Delwyn's help, there was nothing else she could do. So when he had to leave, return to his planet for a while, she saw no other choice but to step down as tutor of Shadow weaver's students, and continue solely with her pupils.

—I am so sorry, but it makes no sense to keep trying.

—But…

—I've delayed this as much as possible— she interrupted, looking away, ashamed and sad. —I wish I could be… the mentor you deserve, need. But I'm no longer fit for that. You will make no further progress under my tutoring— she explained.

—But-but can't we…— Ari began, stammering a bit.

—We can just practice more! Perfect what we already learnt!— Sahm interrupted, his tone pleading. —We-we may not progress, but we can improve!

—I don't… think so. I'm not that good with the practical aspects of spellcasting, I can't help you perfect your technique. Only my brother can do that— she reminded them.

—But, what about Ambassador Zhaleh? He was helping!— Ari asked, increasingly desperate.

—He will be gone for a good while, can't help us until he's back, and I don't know when that will be — she calmly explained. —Please understand. The best I can offer is my brother's assistance.

—We are *not* interested!

—Sahm…

—No, no! We…

He tried to reply, but seemed out of breath. The rest of his classmates looked at him with concerned expressions yet said nothing.

After a moment, Ari spoke up instead.

—If we agreed… would you still be with us in the classes?— they tentatively asked.

—O-of course! I am in charge of supervising your lessons. That was the deal made with your parents.

Ari nodded and approached Sahm. They placed a hand on his shoulder and waited for him to turn around before speaking.

—We can make our Master proud. If we can… cast perfectly, she will be proud of us.

—But he would be taking her place— he complained, hands tightly closed in fists.

—He is *not* our Master. He's just… helping— Ari argued.

—I… Fine— he finally sighed. Sahm glanced at his classmates as if asking for their approval, and once they all nodded, he finally let out —Fine. Let him teach us.

Later that day, when the Head Sorceress announced their decision, the news greatly surprised everyone, and king Micah was immediately appointed tutor assistant to begin the following day.

But their new tutoring came at a price…

At the end of the week, Castaspella was down at the magical groove playing deck fights with Shadow Weaver while they conversed about the classes.

—It must be hilarious…

—Try *annoying*— the sorceress retorted. —I can't explain just how difficult it is. Always, it's *always* a fight. They hardly listen to him. I'd say this is even worse than when Sahm hated you— Castaspella explained.

—That sounds *terrible*.

—Very *funny*— she complained, putting down her last card. —And I won again.

—Curse you…

—I told you: I play better when I'm annoyed.

—You make it harder to believe you're not cheating.

—Come on! That again!? How is one supposed to cheat in this game!?

—I don't know. You must be using something…

—I'm not…

—Like me, I know— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —But I can't believe you're just that lucky.

—I know the game. I know the cards. The strategies, the possible combinations… and I know *you*— Castaspella explained. —Luck only helps me win with more or less ease.

—Ah, leave me alone…

—Should I go?

—Just stop pretending that you know me *so well*.

—I believe I know you well enough…

—You know *nothing*— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—That's it. I'm leaving.

The sorceress rushed to pick up all the cards and stood up, but before she could so much as take a step, a hand firmly gripped her arm.

—Don't. I shouldn't have… said that— the woman let out, her tone ashamed as she looked down. However, she couldn't bear feeling like that and quickly pushed herself to be a bit cockier. —Don't be a fool and stay. You already brought your blanket and dinner.

That was *almost* adorable.

The sorceress quickly realized what was going on inside Shadow Weaver's head and preferred not to push the matter. She simply sighed, smiling gently, and sat down again.

—Alright. Thank you— she said. Right after, a tense silence settled; Castaspella tried to ignore it by grabbing her dinner and silently eating, yet that only made it worse. Unable to bear it anymore, she finally commented —You know… At first, it was only your pupils that didn't want Micah to teach them. Mostly because they felt like he would "replace you". But… now my pupils are- Well, they show some animosity too. It seems like they grew sympathetic to your pupils.

—Hard to believe after what you told me…

—Right!? They were so aggressive at first! They were at each other's throats!

—The enemy of my enemy is my friend?

—No, no. It doesn't make sense— Castaspella sighed, shaking her head and looking at the ground. With a confused frown, she wondered —What would my pupils have against my brother?

She couldn't be for real now, could she?

How oblivious…

Shadow Weaver laughed bitterly, and questioned —You haven't noticed how much he affected you, have you?

—What do you mean?

—In *every* possible way, this ordeal with Micah has had a terrible impact on you— she began. —Everything that has been happening with him affects you more than you imagine, all because you care

for him so much— she explained. —You two discuss usually, and you aren't just angry at him, you're pained. The kids see that. Your pupils may have no issues with him for the same reasons my pupils do, because I wasn't their master. But you? They must be seeing this and identify him as the root cause of your sorrow.

—Since when are you so insightful?— Castaspella asked, after a moment of shock.

—I am just stating the obvious— she dismissively replied. —This is why I say caring is a weakness.

—Oh, please, not again…

—If you didn't care, it wouldn't bear on you at all. The kids under your tutelage wouldn't have any issues with your brother, since *you* wouldn't have any issues with him. If they didn't care, same principle— she explained, looking away.

—I hate that it makes so much sense.

—It does, doesn't it?— Shadow Weaver smugly replied, smirking.

The following day, right as the nocturnal class was ending, problems arose again. This time, however, it felt more *justified* in a way, as the King's correction contradicted one of Shadow Weaver's indications.

—No. I will not— the girl said.

One of the teenage girls, who had improved significantly since being called a "distraction", was perfecting her fire spell, following the hand position she had been taught. Not only was she used to it, but also, it had taken her about a month to properly place her hands as per Shadow Weaver's indications. How was she now supposed to change that again? *Why* should she, when her technique was supposed to be right already?

—I'm just trying to…

—*That* doesn't need changing.

—If you just moved your hand a bit to the left…

—*Why*? It is *fine* like this! It took me so long to manage this!

—But…

—That's enough, old man— her friend interrupted before Micah could say anything else, and stepped between them. The talented girl Shadow Weaver had praised. She hadn't tolerated anyone telling off her friend since Castaspella encouraged them to help each other. —We learnt this spell long ago, and it doesn't need correction. We just have to practice it more, but the hand position is right.

—Alright, alright, please stop— the Head Sorceress interrupted. —First of all, I've already said this: be respectful— she told the teenagers. —Second: they are right, Micah. This is not what you're here for. Others may need corrections, but this isn't wrong.

—But…— he uttered, changing indignation for a more pleading tone and look. —It's easier to position her hands to the left.

Castaspella shook her head and explained —They don't care about easier. They care about correctness. And you work more with… intuition, I suppose. But not everyone is as talented as you, alright? Some of us have to stick to the books.

—And the books say the hands have to be positioned at ninety degrees— one of her pupils commented, unafraid to chime in.

—Casta, I'm not…— he began, but interrupted himself. —Alright, I'm sorry. I won't… do that again.

—Thank you. Now, class dismissed— she sighed. —I'll see you all tomorrow.

The pupils all retreated and eventually left, despite wanting to stay, as they knew Castaspella wouldn't allow the fight to go on. Soon, only the Head Sorceress and the King remained.

—I mean it, I'm sorry— he said, after a moment of silence.

—I know…— the sorceress sighed, exhausted. —Just, please, listen to them. It was very difficult to convince them to let you teach them, and they are still very sensitive.

—Alright.

—And next year, I'll see if I can convince them to let you teach them new things, but for now stick to practice, alright?

—Shouldn't they begin with more complicated sigils next year?

—Yes, and I can only teach them the theory; I myself still have some issues with the casting, so I'll have to convince them of letting you teach that part— she replied, walking to return inside. —I can handle the defensive spells, but the rest is… a bit… *sloppy*.

—Those are complicated, Sis. Don't burden yourself— he replied, falling into step next to her.

—Micah… You practically mastered those, at least the practice, when you were fourteen. It's alright, you don't have to comfort me.

—Ho-how do you know that?— he asked, shocked. However, before she could answer, his expression changed, and he asked, with a lower tone —She told you?

—Yes. You even corrected her sigil…

—Why do you spend so much time with her?

His sudden change of subjects made her stop in her tracks. He halted a moment later and looked back at her, mirroring her wary expression.

—Why do you still care? Why are you still so afraid?

—How am I supposed to ignore that you go to who-knows-where and spend a long time with her doing who-knows-what!? Or-or that whenever you come from *spending the night* there at the Woods, *with her*, you come with your hair up in a bun like now? How- Why wouldn't I care if every time there's a feeling of normalcy, it's somehow tied to the fact that you spent the night down there?

A tense silence settled for a moment after his rant. He felt out of breath and could only stare at his sister, who remained stunned, speechless. It took her a moment to regain her composure and she

looked away, between ashamed and annoyed, brushing her arm in a gesture of self-comfort.

—While I owe you no explanations… I'll still answer a few things— she began. —First, the "feeling of normalcy" you describe should be a good thing, should it not? So I don't understand why you're so indignant about it— she said, genuinely confused. Looking back at him, she continued —Second, if you have such an imperative need to know what we do, then know that we only talk, play deck fights, and she helps me to sleep. It's not much. And, about the bun, I just… like it when she does it instead, alright?

—Don't you find that concerning? I-it's a daily routine thing and you- and only if she does it…

—Please, it's just a preference, Micah. Right, and about where? You have no business going there, so I better never see you…

—I can't find wherever you go— he interrupted.

—Good— Castaspella stated, folding her arms and pretending she didn't know what her niece and friends had been doing. —Now, if that's all, I have places to be.

With that, the Head Sorceress walked away, leaving the King alone in the dark corridor.

Later that night, as she had agreed to go help Catra with her studies back at their home in the Whispering Woods, the woman found herself sitting at their table. She kept admiring the nice cozy cottage, filled with little trinkets from other planets, furnished with presents from their friends, and painted by the girls themselves.

—Hello?

—Um, yes, sorry— Castaspella apologized to Catra, as she snapped out of her trance. —What is it?

—I was saying… I don't understand this part about psyching. Like, "psych yourself to take the form" as in picturing myself as the animal? Or… more like mentally preparing to change my body form? I don't get it.

It greatly amused the sorceress to see her so confused, but she only giggled slightly and tried to find the best way to explain it.

—Well… Imagine you- No, wait, I know— she tried to begin, but interrupted herself as she changed her mind. —The first time you transformed it must have come as a huge surprise, right? I imagine you probably freaked out a bit, no?— she asked. Catra nodded, and she continued —Well, when it comes to magic, one has to concentrate fully on the spell. With time one might learn to divide attention but, usually, if your magic shocks you, the spell is likely to falter.

—Then it's… Like handling a weapon. Taking aim needs your full attention or the shot might fail. Or fighting. If something diverts your attention, you're open to getting hit.

—Interesting comparisons. But yes. Pretty much like that— the sorceress agreed. —But that's not all. Your feelings also affect magic, and one can't be expected to be in full charge of what you feel and when. So, if you mentally prepare, even a bit rushed, the transformation won't have such an impact on your emotions, and will let you focus fully— she explained, beaming cheerfully at the end.

—I see… But, I always do that, and it's still difficult to transform at will.

—I- Well, I can't really help you with that part…— Castaspella admitted, smiling apologetically. — You know what I will say.

—Yeah. But I can't. At least for now, I simply can't accept his teaching— Catra replied, shaking her head and keeping a serious expression. Calmly, she explained —I've spoken about this a lot with Perfuma, and I realized I can't expose myself to this, at least not now. Perhaps… after some more time, I might…

—I understand. I'll try to help you with anything you need until you're ready.

Another month went on like that before Ambassador Zhaleh returned to Etheria, finally relieving the weight on Castaspella's shoulders. And with his return, Catra, once again, had to "report" to Shadow Weaver, to keep her imagination from going wild. However, after having mentioned this in one of her conversations with Perfuma and Scorpia, she realized it feels quite wrong, not only because it is still *technically* spying, but also because they are indulging the woman in a rather… nasty behaviour.

Yes, Delwyn himself allowed it, but… why were *they* allowing it.

—Can't you see how wrong this is?— Catra questioned her.

—I don't. Now, what did he do? I presume you don't have all day to be here.

—You know what!? That's it— she exclaimed, notoriously angry. Adora, who was just a few steps away, moved to stop her from approaching Shadow Weaver, but it was unnecessary. She simply uttered —He brought his kids to Etheria and presented them to the Head Sorceress. That's what he did.

—Kids?

—Yes. He has children. He had a spouse, apparently someone with your personality, seeing how that's exactly why he's allowing this to continue, and why he's trying to help with you being brought back!

Catra let out a deep sigh after her outburst and walked away, but the woman spoke up before she could leave the groove.

—Why are you only telling me this now?

She sounded too calm for what she was feeling, so the girls had no idea how much that information had affected the woman.

—Because it was none of your business! But I still- But I did all of this, for you, for so long… I can't believe I was so…

—Catra— Adora called, placing a hand on her shoulder.

—I won't do this anymore. Leave the man alone. Let the Head Sorceress have a friend— she said, shaking her head in disappointment. She then looked back, frowning in disgust, both at her own actions and at Shadow Weaver's behaviour, and added —Stop being so stupid.

"Thank you", she thought. She should have said it, but wouldn't dare say a word, and the girls eventually left.

Alone with her thoughts, the woman returned to the core, realizing she had been, in fact, quite stupid, and finally understanding Castaspella's aggravation when she found out Shadow Weaver had been spying on her.

The following day, when the Head Sorceress took her pupils down to the magical groove to see the woman, Sahm found a moment to speak with Shadow Weaver without anyone else hearing.

—Yeah, it's true— he confirmed. —The boy is tall, and the girl is a bit shorter. They have blue and red hair, and their clothes are strange, like the ambassador's but in black, blue, and red. Even their eyes are like, all blue and red, one and one— Sahm explained. He then commented —I don't know why they have everything in those colors. They don't look like him at all. Just have the same white marks under the eyes.

—I see— Shadow Weaver let out, pensive. —Anything else?

—I heard the girl is called Nami- No, Namai. And the boy is, eh, Kharyn.

—Alright.

—The Head Sorceress looked very happy meeting them. She was all smiling and offered to make them sweaters— Sahm added.

—How expected— she laughed. —That's all, I don't need more information.

—Okay.

—No. I mean… in general. You don't have to keep spying, alright?— she clarified, her expression neutral to hide the shame she was feeling.

—But…

—No buts. You stop. That's it— Shadow Weaver ordered, more seriously.

—So he's not a threat?

—Threat?

A threat? Why would he call him that?

Unless…

Was she really giving the impression of feeling threatened by him?

Why would she!?

Or perhaps…

Oh, not a chance.

—Of course he is not. What makes you think that!?

—I-I'm sorry, Master— Sahm apologized, looking down. —A-and I'll stop spying on him then.

—Good.

Chapter End Notes

Hehe!
See?
This is what I meant.
SW was told her behaviour wasn't right but it wasn't enough. She had to be hit with how stupid it was to do the whole spying thing and how much she had misinterpreted the situation.
Like, damn, Delwyn has kids, she was really an idiot for considering him a threat.
And yes, she did consider him a threat because of *that* which she won't admit heheh

Oh, and yeah, you got a first look at Adora and Catra's new place!
Hint about what's to come: the place is down at the Whispering Woods, so guess who's gonna be closer to the surface whenever the girls are at home? (^-^) hehe

Anyways, oh goodness, I enjoyed writing this chapter, I hadn't enjoyed myself so much in a while now…
So I hope you liked it and thank you for reading! See you next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: unrequested help is not help, and you need to really listen to what you're told…
Status: processing…

Chapter Notes

Oh goodness… this chapter feels rushed too…
But well, it's just that I have a final exam tomorrow, so I may have had to rush it a bit.
Never mind

I offer you: stubborn Shadow Weaver.
Like, rock-head stubborn, utterly in denial, purposely oblivious, Shadow Weaver.

Hehe, I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once again, she felt like she could reach for the surface, albeit not as usual, but the possibility was there. However, unsure of what it was, she hadn't tried to follow that sensation to see how far she could go.

Until now.

For some reason, this kept sporadically happening and, eventually, it picked Beatrix's attention. And so she sought the surface and *almost* reached it.

So close…

And yet, somehow it was enough.

Where she was, she could see images of a cottage. A small place, around 3 rooms, or that much she could see, modestly furnished. Along the images, there were a pair of voices she could recognize as belonging to Adora and Catra, whom she then saw too.

So their proximity to the Woods must be creating this rare opportunity for her to reach this far…

Not as strong as within the groove, of course, as the girls couldn't see her in the room, but perhaps that was for the best; they probably wouldn't be happy at all if they knew…

And so she simply watched them as they laid on a couch, discussing a new mission in space. She could easily see Catra's prominent belly, yet she told herself it must have been… *something* that happened to her, perhaps some issue with unknown substances from another planet…

It could be anything!

Right?

Right!?

Those rumors about her being pregnant couldn't possibly be true…

No, no.

Never mind.

She decided to ignore this and focused on paying attention to their conversation, their plans to go to a new planet that had some strange readings they could pick up the last time they were nearby.

Ah… same as always…

Their talk made her recall that one time she decided to stick around while they discussed a new mission, and neither they nor their friends liked that decision one bit.

Beatrix retired back to the core of the planet, and allowed the memory to return.

> Queen Glimmer was sitting at the table in the war room, laying down a plan with the help of Bow, Adora, and Catra.
>
> They had been discussing for half an hour already, and Shadow Weaver had decided to stay and see what they planned. However, after interrupting and commenting several times, it was evident she was getting on their nerves.
>
> Eventually, Adora very explicitly tried to defuse the situation, not even bothering to pretend nothing was happening, apparently having noticed that Catra's patience was wearing thin.
>
> Even Glimmer kept diverting attention, but it was *her* who finally exploded.
>
> —I swear, I *will* call Aunt Casta to drag you back to Mystacor— she first warned, with what little self-control she had left.
>
> —You can do so, I suppose. A shame you have to run to your dear aunt's arms to handle something this small— Shadow Weaver replied, taunting.
>
> —*This small*!? You're getting on everyone's nerves here!
>
> —Just because I made a few comments?— she asked, condescendingly. —I am only pointing out the obvious so that your plans don't blow you all into bits…
>
> —Our plans aren't going to blow us up!
>
> —*Now* they sure won't. As I've highlighted the flaws…
>
> And that was it.
>
> Between her all-too-calm tone and her proud stance, Glimmer couldn't bear it anymore.
>
> With her fists tightly closed, she stood up abruptly, pushing her chair back, and yelled —Ugh! *Fuck off*, Shadow Weaver!

Silence.

Then a burst of loud laughter.

The woman was laughing in a way that was both shocking and bloodcurdling.

After all, she was trying to get a reaction, and the one she got *fascinated* her.

—Well, well. You seem to have grown a spine, *your majesty*— she finally said, not as mockingly as they thought, despite the sarcasm. —Alright then. I will leave— she said, before turning around. —But don't come to me if your plan fails.

—Oh, we absolutely won't— she heard Catra mutter.

She chose to ignore her, returned to Mystacor on her own, and forgot about it.

Until…

—What *exactly* happened!?

—Why do you care?

Castaspella looked her in the eye with the most annoyed expression she had, but Shadow Weaver still kept her aloof demeanor and tone.

—Just *what* do you think you're doing!? Do you have any idea how angry Glimmer is!?

—Quite a shame. I'm here to "assist", am I not? That's what I was doing.

—To assist in Mystacor; you're not even supposed to go to Bright Moon— Castaspella reminded her.

—I just happened to be around and couldn't help hearing they were *struggling*.

—Why do I feel like that's a lie?

—Because you're feeling wrong…

—Never mind— the sorceress said, shaking her hands to cut short the digression and return to what they were talking about. —Glimmer also said you were taunting every time you could, and that they told you to leave several times, yet you didn't.

—I was offering help— she insisted. —If they find my speech provoking, that's on them. I was just *helping*.

—Unwanted help, is *not* help!— Castaspella immediately replied. —If they say they don't need your assistance and tell you to leave, you *leave*.

—Even if they are making an unwise decision, a mistake, or something that might even blow up in their faces?— Shadow Weaver asked, arching a brow defiantly.

—Yes! That is *their* problem!— the Head Sorceress replied, almost yelling, and greatly surprising the woman. —If they wanted your help, they'd have asked for it!— she insisted. She then took a deep breath and added —Look… They know far more than you and me about these things, they have already carried out plenty of missions in space.

—Fine then. So I shouldn't give unprompted assistance to anyone? Including you?— she asked, a bit more annoyed now, taunting again.

—No, *I* told you to feel free to chime in and indicate whatever comes to your mind anytime, because *I* want that. Alright?— Castaspella clarified. —That's a boundary *I* removed. *But they didn't*!

—Alright, alright. I get it— Shadow Weaver finally conceded. —I won't go suggesting things to them if they don't ask for it. Happy now?

—I would be if you went there and apologized, but we both know that won't happen.

—No, it won't happen any time soon— she agreed.

That had been… an interesting day if anything.

Only now did she realize the irony behind what happened.

She had brought up so many times how Castaspella was irrespective of boundaries but, wasn't she doing exactly that too?

In fact, they both were quite disrespectful in that regard, although each for different reasons; they didn't trespass on the same boundaries and, furthermore, it could be said each was on opposite extremes of it.

Castaspella was too nice, unable to see when her generosity was too much. While Shadow Weaver was too proud, unable to see when she had gone too far.

Not just that…

Castaspella was also too welcoming and couldn't realize that, sometimes, her hospitality would make her guests uncomfortable. In the same way that, like back then, Shadow Weaver would be too full of herself, believing her assistance was pretty much an invaluable privilege.

Now who is the fool?

Both, yes, both…

Of course…

Chapter End Notes

Soooooooo?

As you can see, she's just… well, stubborn. Both with Catra's pregnancy and with her new-found magic, she's doing this. It's like a "if I don't see, I don't believe" but even worse! She *is* seeing it, but still denies it.
She'll have to learn the hard way… and she will, of course. It will be fun as heck, I promise!

Oh, and don't worry. Their plan didn't fail.
Also, about that, I later remembered that Casta was supposed to make SW admit she was worried

for the girls, hence why she kept "correcting" their plan, but like, I cant find the note about it, perhaps I never wrote it. It went something like Casta saying "if you're worried about them, why not tell them so?" and SW "uhu, sure". But, again, I suppose I never wrote that note and, with this chapter already finished, I couldn't find where to insert that bit so... ugh...
Anyways, have this extra piece if you're reading this note ^_^

Alright, that’s all for now. See you next week!

Regrets

Chapter Summary

The awaited day arrived with rain and the Head Sorceress is sought after for help. Afterwards, she gets a much deserved rest at the Magical Groove.

Now, the girls have something very important to tell Shadow Weaver, yet the news will get delayed, and delayed, and delayed…

»—I don’t understand. You-you wanted to tell her. Since the beginning! And then you went exclusively to tell her, so many times. So why didn't you?
»—I just can’t, Adora. I’m not… ready. I- What if she- What if- I don’t want her to mock me, us… Or to be mean about this, or… you know, say something that makes me… feel incapable. (…) I can’t…
»—You can.

Chapter Notes

I'm writing this before the summary because I don't even know what to write for a summary of this chapter...

Sorry, today is not the best day ever. Fortunately, I had already written this chapter and the next one...

Oh, and I almost forgot today was Wednesday so I'm posting it late cause of that oops!

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was an extremely rainy day down in Bright Moon.

The Queen had called for Castaspella’s help so the Head Sorceress wasn’t in Mystacor, from where the storm clouds could be seen, flashing occasionally along with thunder. Instead, a pair of councilors were enjoying the view as they rested against the edge of a balcony, mostly in silence.

Sometimes, a comment or two would pop up and spring a short conversation, only to go back to silence quickly enough.

—Quite a bad day for them…

—They are inside the palace, not out in the open. The weather doesn’t matter.

—It *does* matter. Such rainy days affect people’s moods. It’s not a good day for a kid to be born… Besides, imagine the pain it must be with this humidity.

—Since when do you know so much about that?

—My kid was born on a rainy day. It *hurt*.

—Oh, I see…

Both looked back at the storm clouds extending under Mystacor and took a deep breath almost simultaneously. No one expected the Head Sorceress to return soon that day, but they couldn't help waiting impatiently, afraid she would return suddenly, in distress.

No. Everything would go right and Castaspella would be back by midnight, or the following day.

Back at the palace, queen Glimmer and her aunt patiently waited for *any* sound to come out of a room with a pair of guards standing at each side. Bow arrived to find them both with their ears pressed against the door, fully focused as if trying to hear breathing.

—Um…

—Shh— the Queen interrupted, gesturing with a hand.

Bow arched a brow and stared as the two pressed even harder against the door.

—Are you two for real now?— he asked.

—Bow, shush— Glimmer insisted, whispering angrily.

But they would hear nothing.

And so, before they decided to pull away, the door began to move and, the next moment, the Queen and the Head Sorceress had fallen face-first on the floor.

Inside the room, a few meters away from them, the girls sat in companionable silence, holding a small bundle of clothes that kept their child hidden.

—Oops! Sorry, sorry— Glimmer apologized, standing up as fast as she could. —We're leaving— she added before grabbing her Aunt and teleporting outside. The guards closed the door, and she sighed, frustrated. —They are just there in silence!

—Maybe they are tired— Castaspella suggested. —But it seems like they are doing fine.

—Maybe! But maybe not!?— Glimmer exclaimed, distressed. —What if they need something but don't wanna ask for it? Or-or…

—Glimmer— the sorceress interrupted, placing both hands on her shoulders. —If they require something, they will ask for it, alright? They just have to call the guards, and they will assist them or fetch us if necessary.

—But…

—Calm down, Love— Bow stepped in. —She's right. They will be fine. Don't worry.

The Queen sighed and relaxed a bit.

—Alright. I… suppose we can just leave them alone until they are ready.

—Come on, Dear, I'll make dinner, alright?— Castaspella offered, smiling brightly.

—You'll be staying tonight?

—I'll leave after eating.

It was already past midnight when the rain stopped and the sorceress arrived at the magical groove in the Whispering Woods, yawning and brushing back her loose hair. Shadow Weaver appeared in time to see her yawn and couldn't help smirking mockingly.

—Tired, *Head Sorceress*? I wonder what *demanding* activities consumed all your energy…

—As a matter of fact…— the sorceress began, but interrupted herself. —Never mind. I'm just tired, alright? But I preferred to visit you instead of going directly to bed.

—You mean you want to sleep for real.

—Hey! Don't twist my words!

—You didn't deny it…

—Well, it's not wrong— she admitted, looking away shyly. —But the way you put it, sounds like I'm using you.

—Which I wouldn't mind…

—I…— Castaspella once again interrupted herself, surprised this time. —What do you mean you wouldn't mind!?

—You give me a rest from being at the core of the planet, in exchange for merely helping you sleep. I don't see the issue…

Shocked, the sorceress shook her head and approached, saying —You really feel like I'm using you?

Shadow Weaver immediately smirked and rolled her eyes. With a laugh, she placed a hand on Castaspella's shoulder and helped her take off her cape.

—Relax, you fool. Of course I don't. I'm just messing with you— she assured her. Right after, curious, she asked —What has you so sensitive, eh? What happened?

—Nothing. I'm just tired, that's all.

—And what drained you so much?

Right.

She had promised not to tell…

—Nothing, nothing. I just went to assist Glimmer with something, and it took a few hours.

—Alright…

Shadow weaver could tell the sorceress was hiding something, but preferred not to press the matter. She invited Castaspella to rest on her lap and promptly used her illusions to give her a calm sleep without interruptions.

However, the woman spent the entire night thinking about the matter. What could it be that the sorceress wasn't telling her?

She tried to recall whether she had heard something earlier, but there was nothing.

True. A lot of intense emotions from her side had overwhelmed her, meaning whatever happened wasn't exactly relaxing. But despite being able to get some sounds and images, she had nothing about *what* occurred.

Perhaps nothing important or the sorceress would have told her, no?

A few days later, back in the Woods, the women were about to start playing deck fights. Shadow Weaver, having gotten better at losing yet also better at winning, insisted they play with stakes. The sorceress, however, had a few reasons to *reject* her.

—To begin with: *those* stakes aren't fair here. It is one thing to play for truthful answers, like usual, and another completely different to play for *pieces of clothes*!

—Afraid?

—I said it's *not fair*. Why? Because you're a summoned entity, you *don't* have clothes…

—I can always…

—I'm not done— Castaspella interrupted, raising a hand. —Second: I'm expecting the girls will arrive soon. The idea is to play for a while until then, remember? And seeing how you've gotten better, I can't risk being found *half-naked*!

—Afraid. I get it.

—Bea!

The woman only laughed wholeheartedly for a moment while the sorceress returned to shuffling the deck.

—Alright. No stakes this time. Let's leave it for another time.

—Thank you…

That day, when Adora and Catra arrived, began the weirdest dance, metaphorically speaking, Castaspella had ever seen between the girl and Shadow Weaver. The sorceress and Adora had to bear three months of Catra twisting and turning around the truth *she herself* wanted to tell Shadow Weaver; the truth she had decided, since day one, that she would go and share personally. And, if that wasn't enough, the woman's obliviousness only added to it.

Catra was *so nervous* that day, *something* made her backtrack on her decision, so she didn't mention Finn at all, contrary to what Castaspella and Adora were expecting. And that went on, and on, *and on.*

—I don't understand. You-you wanted to tell her. Since the beginning! And then you went exclusively to tell her, *so* many times. So why didn't you?

—I just can't, Adora. I'm not… ready. I- What if she- What if- I don't want her to mock me, us… Or to be mean about this, or… you know, say something that makes me… feel incapable.

Shivering a bit, Catra looked down after confessing what she felt, eventually leant onto Adora's embrace, and they stayed silent for a moment that felt like an eternity.

—You're not alone, alright? I doubt she will say something like that but, if she does, I'll be there, and we can have the Head Sorceress there too. You shouldn't be afraid of her anymore…

—I can't…

—You can.

Meanwhile, that same night, in Mystacor, Castaspella was sitting in her room, looking out through the window, enjoying a go of sake. She slowly exhaled while looking at the moon, and it brought up a sudden memory.

> The sorceress took a sip of sake and enjoyed it for a moment. Right after, she playfully blew on Shadow Weaver's face and let out a laugh. However, the woman entirely ignored her, and so she recalled her sense of smell is now very numb.
>
> —Rough day?— Shadow Weaver decided to ask after a moment of silence.
>
> —Not really. Can't I just be enjoying a cup of sake because I want to?

Castaspella smirked and took another sip. She liked to consider those memories "good times", and while seemingly insignificant, they had been breaths of fresh air for her.

Now, every time she went down to the Whispering Woods, it felt like escaping her life for a while. But that was exactly the problem. She didn't want to escape her life. She wanted those moments to be *a part* of her life like they had been for, at least, a few months.

Now, a full year had gone by, and a lot had changed. Perhaps, too much had changed.

—What does one have to do… to live in peace?

Just what?

There was no war anymore.

There weren't factions anymore.

There were literally no real conflicts out there!

Yet some people, like the girls, like herself, simply couldn't be allowed to live in peace. With whomever they want, doing whatever they want, enjoying whatever they like…

No. There was always *something* happening.

Yes, it meant there was not a day of boredom, but sometimes, a little peace and tranquility would be nice, wouldn’t it?

Chapter End Notes

Well, you can imagine what the next chapter will be about...
Or not. ksjsj

Actually, I'm just not sure what the lesson is supposed to be in the next chapter, I've yet to realize...
Good thing I have a week for that

And, everyone, say hello to Finn!
For the glimbow kid you'll have to wait a bit longer, cause she will be like 5 years younger or perhaps a bit more, I don't recall.

ANYWAYS, I hope you enjoyed this chapter and, just as a color note: I'm working on my Swan Lake AU, that is written like a play, so I may or may not post it during the festive season, or simply next year, we'll see...

Actually, one last ps: I'm thinking of taking a break during January and continuing with this in February instead... I kinda don't want to, but kinda do because I would like to have more of this written, so I have more time to think it through, revise it, edit it, etc...

Anyways, it's not decided yet. So just, I hope you enjoyed this chapter and see you next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: One can have a greater impact on others than you realize
Status: Loading… loading…

Chapter Notes

Oh gods please
I had such a morning…
Rushing since early and had to fast for a medical appointment ugh…

Anyways, it is here! I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For months, although she wasn't sure just how many, she refused to return to the girls' new home.

It all had to be a deception. Everything she heard… was impossible…

They would never… Or would they?

No. How could they be mothers if…

Never.

Right?

How would they even *consider* being mothers when the closest thing they had to one was but a monster?

Shadow Weaver was convinced it couldn't be possible, and yet, every time something tried to prove her wrong, she'd escape from it, pretend it didn't exist, or find an excuse to make it about something else.

She didn't know, but it had been at least three months like that. Three months of soft baby cries reaching her ears and the woman dismissing it as any random kid crying near them…

Until one day, she couldn't ignore a conversation Catra and Adora were having. Adora's question was simple: why had she gone so many times to speak to Shadow Weaver, only to never tell her the *one* thing she was supposed to say?

And Catra's reply? Fear.

Of course. *Fear*.

So… Was it true?

Was there a kid?

Would Shadow Weaver say something that might make Catra feel incapable?

Was it true?

Would she mock them?

Would she somehow be mean about it?

Who knows…

Beatrix truly didn't know what she would have done or said if Catra had actually mentioned it any of the times she went to speak with her in the past few months.

But the truth was one, and it was crying faintly right there, meters away from the girls.

A small creature, cat ears, mismatched eyes, blond hair.

A months-old baby.

She left.

Back at the core of the planet, she couldn't stop thinking.

How?

Just *how*?

And why was Catra so scared?

No, well, she *knew* why.

But why was she so sure she would…

Ugh, *why* was she surprised at all?

Of course the girl would be scared half to death.

As she once told Castaspella: "she made her feel like she was never good enough" and that she had to be perfect at everything.

It would be only natural for her to believe she would be told she's not good enough of a mother…

And, well, didn't she herself think it was impossible for them to have a kid because of how bad of an example they had?

This was so frustrating for Beatrix…

Should she let them know that she's now aware of their kid? Should she, perhaps, tell Catra how she's *not* her and will surely do a better job? Or perhaps…

Actually, would they even believe her?

Once again, so frustrating.

She really wanted to fix this. Light Spinner wanted to do or say something that would, for once, make things better instead of worse. But what?

And how to make it genuine enough for the girls to take it to heart?

How, indeed…

The only person who could tell when she was genuine and when not, was Castaspella, but it was, apparently, something only *she* could do; something only she was *willing* to do.

Others, namely her brother, never believed a word she said, many times making evident efforts to convince themselves it was all manipulation of some kind.

And she couldn't blame them…

Perhaps she had to begin by believing so herself?

Or, at least, hear her own advice?

Had she ever been honest with herself? Genuine with herself?

Lately she had, little by little, been something close to honest with herself, enough for it to be enraging even.

The irony…

Between this and the thoughts about Catra, she recalled when she had expressed both opinions to the Head Sorceress on one of the *many* occasions she had angered her…

> —You want me to be angry at you!?— Castaspella suddenly yelled, fists tightly closed as she glared back at Shadow Weaver. —Fine! Here it is! I *am* mad at you! Why wouldn't I be!? But if you think that I have to actively let you know how outraged I am at you, then maybe you're just being a jerk that believes me to be exactly like you!— she accused her. —Just how many, *how many* times have you "realized I am not like you" yet still expect me to behave like you!? You consider that "never deceiving me" is you being respectful or something, but then keep ignoring what I actually do, or how I actually treat you…
>
> —I don't.
>
> —Yes, you do! Why else would you think I'm "pretending" when I don't lash out at you!? Why else would you *want me* to lash out at you the way you do!?— she retorted, seemingly about to cry from rage.
>
> —I don't want you to explode and yell at everyone for everything! I want you to *express that anger*!— the woman exclaimed, disgruntled at being so misunderstood. —I may go overboard with it, but you're on the opposite extreme! You're always about to go off, but the worst I've seen you do is indignantly cry out and then leave the room. You give yourself no space to express yourself!
>
> She didn't even know *why* she was saying that, but it was inevitable. Castaspella's behaviour had become frustrating for her, almost as if she herself were the one keeping it all inside like that. Perhaps it was just the spell connecting them, but it felt like her own.

—I don't *need* to let out such anger!

—Oh, really? Then tell me: how do you feel now?— Shadow Weaver scoffed, folding her arms as she calmed down, and changing her tone to a condescending one.

The sorceress was shocked for a moment. She could see her anger slowly vanishing as she took a moment to observe herself, and her posture relaxed significantly.

—I- It's not… that I don't- I do feel more… relieved— she admitted, although she remained a bit annoyed. —But this is not… *nice*. I don't like yelling, at anyone. *Including* you. I mean, even when you deserve it, yelling at you the way you do is… hypocritical.

—Go easier on yourself, woman— Shadow Weaver immediately replied, rolling her eyes. —What's the point of trying to get *me* to "grow without punishing me" if, simultaneously, you keep punishing *yourself*?

—I am not…

—Yes, you are— she interrupted. —You're just… *used to it* to the point you just deem it "necessary and the right thing to do". Don't you think I'm pretty much an expert in such a mentality?

Her grin and raised eyebrow took Castaspella by surprise but the sorceress only mirrored her posture and smirked back.

—Is this you admitting you've purposely made any of your girls feel this way?

—Perhaps. Not exactly like you, but that "righteousness", or feeling like you *have* to be perfect at all times… Yes, both of them, with different results— she explained. —It made Adora put everything before herself, and made Catra feel like she wasn't enough… because that's how I treated her— she admitted, looking away. However, right after, she looked back at the sorceress, smirked, and tilted forward as she added —I'm not trying to blame it on her this time.

—That's new— Castaspella let out, looking away slightly, perhaps ashamed to have, apparently, pushed Shadow Weaver to such a point. —And what part of that are you… seeing in my mentality?

She warily looked sideways back at her, and waited patiently for her assessment.

—You always try to be perfect, as if you weren't allowed to make mistakes just because you're the "Head Sorceress"— she began. —And let's not forget, you feel like you aren't "good enough" just because you're not naturally talented like Micah.

—Thanks for the reminder…

Her expression became somber and, once again, she looked away. Shadow Weaver could barely believe how she was feeling almost guilty now, but simply buried it deep down and pretended nothing happened, gesturing dismissively.

—It was easy to anger you with that because I immediately noticed how much it affects you— she continued. —That's exactly why now, instead of mere mockery, I'm trying to make you see exactly *how* it's impacting you, alright? You want me to be more respectful and "mindful" of others? Fine, I'll try. But you? You need to be more mindful of *yourself*— she added, glaring

slightly. —Believe me: being more selfish, in your case, will only help. You've been alone for such a long time, you've forgotten you can rely on others.

That had been weird to say, but she still meant it. Perhaps it was that guilt she was feeling, but it wasn't far from the truth either.

And the Head Sorceress was just as surprised of hearing that, to the point her voice trembled a bit as she asked —What? What do you mean? What makes you say… that?

—First, the obvious: that council can't even handle itself without you, and… How many years was Micah missing?

—Shut up.

—You asked, now listen— Shadow Weaver reminded her. Castaspella sighed, and she continued —Now, what's much less obvious: you've said it yourself, you don't have many friends, and I have seen people purposely avoiding you, or crafting any excuse to make sure they can leave as soon as they are done getting your help… And they aren't even creative, because they *know* you'll just accept their excuse.

The woman held her sight defiantly, and both remained quiet for a moment, arms crossed in front of their chests in silent challenge.

—Again the "too nice" bullshit?— the sorceress asked, her tone calm.

—I'm serious. They take advantage of that, you let them, and you prefer to be alone than ever…

—What? Than ever have to… deal with the ups and downs of a friendship? Or personal relationships?— she interrupted, increasingly indignant. —What are you trying to "teach" me now? *You* purposely made sure to never forge any kind of relationship with anyone…

—Says the woman who made sure I couldn't simply ditch her in the Woods— she reproached her, keeping her defiant look for another moment. —Listen, Cas. You can do this; I *won't* repeat that. But you seem to think you're "not made to have friends", as I overheard the other day— she commented, tilting her head to the side. —But that's not true. You think you annoy people, don't you? But you wouldn't mind annoying me— she laughed. —No need to deny it.

The sorceress' expression and posture relaxed a bit as she allowed herself to let out half a smile.

—Fine, yes. That's perhaps the case. Which doesn't… mean I don't…

—What? Enjoy my half-company?

"Half-company"!? Where did that stupidity come from!?

Castaspella's smile only widened, and she rolled her eyes as she replied —You seem to have no trouble putting up with me, and those "competitions" to see who annoys the other the most… Can't say they aren't interesting.

—Likewise— she admitted. —After all, most prefer to walk away, with or without insulting or barking at me first, it's all the same. So, having someone actually talk back no matter what I say, it's refreshing; bickering with you is amusing, at the very least— she commented, smirking knowingly and making the sorceress laugh.

Oh, she felt so stupid for a moment there.

But she hadn't lied.

And what's more, she had spoken genuinely and without reservations.

She realized she felt quite comfortable when talking to her, enough to speak… from the heart.

Ugh, why…

It was starting to make her uncomfortable, like admitting a weakness.

Because that was exactly what this was.

Admitting Castaspella had become her weakness.

But… didn't it feel nice to speak so freely? Not having to think her every word through? Not having to carefully measure what she said, how she spoke?

Perhaps…

But she doubted she'd reach such *comfort* with anyone else any time soon…

Chapter End Notes

Okay okay, I'd say this was THE chapter (for now), and I really like it heh

A note: I once read somewhere an interaction were an imprisoned SW mocked Catra and told her she'd fail as a mother, and it was just *so wicked*, the way SW was written. The woman is spiteful, yes, but the level of wickedness I read is even beyond Horde Prime. Did we even watch the same show?
Nah, even a SW with no progress at all wouldn't be that cruel; she'd be dismissive, say a kid is too much to handle and that they made a mistake… But being so particularly vicious with Catra just because it's Catra, entirely dismisses episodes in which SW showed her twisted concept of what she "did for Catra"(like the time she said she was "preparing her for the world", for instance). Nah, the woman is just a bitch, not the Wicked Witch of the West!

Aaaaaaaaanyways, this is a SW with some progress on her, enough to even recognize being dismissive would be wrong…
Whatever, you get it.

But also, I wanted to say, today I'll finish posting this other fic that I wrote for a challenge of a "5 parts fic, each named like the 1st five songs of my spotify wrapped", basically
It's about Beatrix as a double agent hehe

In any case, you're invited to read it, and I hope you enjoyed this chapter! Thank you all for reading! <3

Ghost Lady

Chapter Summary

While the kingdom of Mystacor faces a bit of an overflow of help-requests, the saviors of Etheria enjoy as their domestic life goes without a hitch. Eventually, Queen Glimmer invites them all for dinner, trying to give her aunt and her friends a bit of a rest… and some unspoken issues briefly arise.

»—(…)And, where is Finn now?
»—Oh, well…— Adora began but interrupted herself, looking at Catra. —Come on, it's not that bad…
»—I didn't agree…
»—But we had no other options! And Melog is with them.
»Finally, Glimmer explained —Dad is taking care of them. When he knew we were organizing this meal and invited you, he said it'd be better if he looked after them while we ate.
»—I see. But, it doesn't seem like Catra is very… *happy* with the decision.
»—It took a while to convince her.
»—She doesn't look convinced, Dear.

With a bit of time and reflection, all their issues will slowly untangle. But until then…

Chapter Notes

Today I give you: wholesomeness

Kind of

I mean, it's more wholesome than anything else heh

Well, please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was a hectic day in Mystacor. Although requests for magical help were common now, sometimes said requests would flood Castaspella's desk, on top of all her day-to-day duties. In this case, it was the Kingdom of Snows that, for the second time since they opened to the whole of Etheria, had been sending far more requests than can be handled, and the Head Sorceress was on the brink of a nervous breakdown.

Fortunately, after noticing as much in one of her visits, Glimmer invited her aunt to have a meal with her and her friends, which gave Castaspella a moment to relax. Or so it was supposed to be. But the woman was far too restless.

—Please, Auntie. Stop thinking about that and just enjoy dinner— Glimmer asked. —Why don't we talk about something to distract you?

—Alright— she sighed. —You're right. Let's see… Girls— she called, drawing Adora and Catra's attention. —How are things with Finn going?

—All fine— Adora smiled. —We've been quite lucky. Melog helps a lot, and whenever there's a problem, they cry and we can go fix anything in time.

—Yeah. It's been going quite fine. They behave well and, like she said, they cry at the slightest issue, so there have been no incidents at all.

—That's great news!— the sorceress exclaimed, beaming happily. —And, where are they now?

—Oh, well…— Adora began, but looked back at Catra and interrupted herself when she saw her annoyed yet resigned expression. —Come on, it's not that bad…

—I didn't agree…— she interrupted.

—But we had no other options!— Adora interrupted too. —And Melog is with them.

Catra huffed and frowned, suddenly too focused on her food, and Castaspella felt like she was missing something.

Finally, Glimmer explained —Dad is taking care of them. When he knew we were organizing this meal and invited you, he said it'd be better if he looked after them while we ate.

—I see. But, it doesn't seem like Catra is very… *happy* with the decision.

—It took a while to convince her.

—She doesn't look convinced, Dear.

—I know— Glimmer let out, looking down.

—I think it's a good thing— Bow commented. —It's progress, wouldn't you say?

—And *how* is it "progress", Arrow Boy?— Catra asked.

—Well, from him, it's progress because he's doing something nice for Casta and you. At long last! After so many fights— he began, blushing slightly hearing his thoughts aloud. —And, you know, from you, it's progress because you'll now see you *can* trust him.

—I trust Melog, not him— she quickly retorted.

—Close enough— he replied.

Castaspella couldn't help but let out a smile and shook her head slightly. Perhaps Bow was being too optimistic, but it was true that, one way or another, it could be called progress.

Shortly after, dinner was finished and both, the girls and the sorceress, retired and returned to their homes, leaving Glimmer, Bow, and King Micah in Bright Moon. The Queen, after giving it some thought, decided to talk seriously with her father, and asked Bow for help; between the both of them,

they explained to the King how his behaviour had been affecting Castaspella, Adora, and Catra, which left the sorcerer thinking all night.

Having realized that the nice time he had looking after the little baby almost didn't happen, he couldn't help but feel extremely down. Understanding how he had been pushing away both important friends of his daughter, and his own sister, kept him awake, reflecting on the whys.

But it was just *so difficult* to change his mind. They were both essentially *defending* Shadow Weaver. From all people! They were choosing *her*. And he couldn't comprehend why, or how they had such faith in her. How they could believe so firmly that she would change at all.

Back in Mystacor, the Head Sorceress was restless too. From her bed, she could see the stack of requests piling up on her desk and decided to take the sleeping potion once again, knowing she would need to rest more than ever.

However, going to sleep with such worries, only made her dream about the last time this had happened with the Kingdom of Snows, and how much Shadow Weaver had helped her back then.

—Head Sorceress— an acolyte called from outside the room. —Another request from the Kingdom of Snows.

As soon as that was said, a scroll appeared on Castaspella's desk and they heard the acolyte walk away.

—See!?— the sorceress exclaimed. —They keep sending requests I cannot reply yet! Most of that stuff is entirely unrelated to magic! And I simply *can't refuse the help out of nowhere*!— she went on, increasingly frenetic. Still panicking, she explained —First, I can't because we promised to help now, opposite to how we refused to do so for so many years during the war! And second, I am *extremely afraid* of offending Princess Frosta!

Shadow Weaver's immediate reaction was to scoff at that, and she didn't hesitate to mock her —Of course. We wouldn't want another incident like what happened with Hordak and the gift, no?

—Shut up! This is serious!

She was far too distressed, walking back and forth, shaking entirely, and her lack of self-control evidenced just how bad her state was.

—Head Sorceress— they heard, along with another knock on the door. —I bring another request.

Just like before, a scroll appeared on her desk and the acolyte simply walked away. Castaspella seemed about to scream when Shadow Weaver grabbed her face tightly and turned it to look back at her.

—Calm down. Now— she first said. —I can't do "reassurement", but you need to stop panicking over this.

—Then start by letting go of my face!

—And you better stop vibrating— Shadow Weaver reproached, releasing her. The sorceress took a deep breath and seemed about to speak, but she beat her to it, saying —Look. I know you have

kept a straight face until now that you're finally in private, hence why you're letting this out all together. But do *not* let it overwhelm you like this, you fool. Lest you want to collapse.

The Head Sorceress was left speechless for a moment and, before she could say anything, they heard yet another knock followed by —Head Sorceress. A request.

They both stared at the desk as another scroll appeared, and it seemed to have finally hit Shadow Weaver with the full gravity of the situation.

—Enough— she sighed, and pulled Castaspella by the arm. She had her sit on the bed next to her, their backs against the wall, and the sorceress couldn't help but bury her face on Shadow Weaver's shoulder. The woman chuckled and let out —How quaint.

—Ugh…

With another laugh, she told her —You better keep ignoring those until you have an answer.

Another knock, and another notification.

—Agh, I should really attend them… It's my duty…— she groaned.

—No, no— Shadow Weaver stopped her. —Didn't you hear me? You still have no answers for those.

—Right— she sighed. She tried taking a deep breath but, once again, tensed up as another notification arrived. —Oh, please!

—Alright. It's obvious you won't relax until this is dealt with. So, rest here while I go do *something*— she told the sorceress, more like an order than a suggestion. —And continue ignoring those notifications. Am I clear?

And so she did. It took Shadow Weaver quite some time to do whatever she had gone to do, and several notifications arrived before she was back.

Finally, another knock was heard, but it didn't come with a request.

Instead, a voice said —Excuse me, Head Sorceress. May I come in?

She quickly recognized his voice and knew it was the councilman who usually handles diplomatic affairs.

Right as the sorceress lifted her head, Shadow Weaver passed through the door, saying —Go on, open the door.

—Right, right— she let out, pushing herself up. She rushed to open it and tidied her dress a bit. —Please come in— she invited him.

—Excuse me, Head Sorceress. If you don't mind, I could help you revise all those requests and separate the relevant ones from the irrelevant ones— he offered, right before another notification arrived. —And write appropriate replies for them, of course— he added.

—That would be… much appreciated— Castaspella immediately replied, walking him to the desk.

His eyes opened wide when he saw the *many* scrolls piling up, and they quickly got to work.

In the meantime, Shadow Weaver only observed with a fond expression that only Castaspella noticed yet made no comments on it.

That way, after a few hours, a much smaller pile of relevant requests had formed on one side of the desk, while the rest were piled on the other side, all with their respective replies. The councilman took all the irrelevant ones and retired with a bow.

—Finally…— the sorceress sighed. Feeling much calmer, as soon as she saw Shadow Weaver approach, she sincerely told her —Thank you *so* much.

—See? I may not have the faintest idea how to help you with something that requires respect and tactfulness…— she began, a bit mockingly, making Castaspella laugh. —But I sure know how to find you proper help, wouldn't you say?

The sorceress was so pleased with how much Shadow Weaver had improved since she believed herself to have the absolute truth and know the best way to handle everything.

—I really mean it, I'm very thankful— Castaspella insisted, speaking kindly, and taking her hand, which she placed on her face and briefly kissed.

That had been a bit out of nowhere, she then realized, upon feeling the woman get suddenly tense. When she looked back at her, Shadow Weaver was visibly shocked, and it made the sorceress giggle.

—Taking the teasing to the next level, I see— the woman let out, trying to hide how stunned she was.

But Castaspella had already seen it, and continued to laugh daintily.

When the Head Sorceress woke up, the memory she dreamt about had enlightened her.

Of course.

She only needed to ask for help once again.

And so, two months went by. Once again, Castaspella was invited to eat with the Best Friends Squad and, this time, Catra was a bit more willing to allow Micah to look after Finn.

—You know…— she began, after swallowing a piece of food. —It seems that Finn has an imaginary friend— she commented.

—Oh, right!— Adora seconded. —They call it "Ghost Lady"— she giggled. —Isn't that cute?

—Oh, that's charming!— Castaspella replied, smiling brightly. —So they speak already?

—Just a few words— Catra clarified. —Generally, it's Melog who tells me what Finn means.

—And mostly words that they heard from our stories. Like the name of that imaginary friend— Adora laughed.

—I see. It's still very charming— she insisted. —They grow fast, right? I still remember when Glimmer was just a few months old…

—Auntie…

—You were such an adorable baby!

—And there's no need to comment on that now— she replied, already flustered. —Please…

—Alright— the sorceress laughed and continued eating.

Later that night, the girls returned home, and went directly to sleep. After crying for hours, Finn was allowed to rest between Catra and Adora, and slept soundly for a good while. However, they woke up in the middle of the night and started wandering around the bed.

Eventually, they got too close to the edge, and with the girls asleep, it was impossible for them to know; not even Melog noticed. However, as soon as the baby peeked down, the floor got pitch black, and they backtracked, whining. A moment later, Melog woke up and carefully placed Finn back between Adora and Catra.

—Ghost Lady— Finn giggled, waking up her moms.

—Huh?— Adora groaned as she woke up.

—Not now, baby— Catra let out, dragging the words.

—Sleep, Finn.

Adora gently wrapped an arm around them and went back to sleep, but the baby kept looking at the spot where a supposedly invisible Shadow Weaver stood. As it was clear they wouldn't sleep until she was gone, she decided to return to the core of the planet.

Even after these two months, she simply couldn't understand how it was possible. Why was Finn able to see her and the illusions?

Well, she'd never known, but at least she was able to do *something* when the restless baby got into potential trouble.

One can't expect the girls to be awake at all times, or to be omniscient.

Shadow Weaver remembered her own time as caretaker and how difficult it was to take care of so many rowdy kids.

Those two were in for quite a ride, weren't they?

But they had chosen this, so it would probably be a nice one for them.

Chapter End Notes

I wanna clarify: I began speaking when I was like 2 or 3 months old, according to my mother, saying some words and names, like my pet's name and commands (I had a cat named Isis and I would say things like "Isis, come" hehe). So here, Finn speaking a bit with just 5 months is more than likely.

With that said…
How did you like the chapter!?
It was kinda difficult to write because I wanted to keep the mystery of who the Ghost Lady is until the very end, but I also wanted to make it obvious that since even before Finn named her, she had been helping, hence the initial "they always cry when there's an issue" and etc
Very *SW* of her to do, no? Help by making a baby cry lol
But think about it: she can't interact with reality except, somehow, by means of her illusions because Finn somehow sees all of that. So what else can she do but take advantage and make the baby cry for help? I mean, if the others could see or hear her, she would still have to go call for someone because she *still* can't interact with reality! And it's all harmless what she does. She didn't make him nictophobic or anything, the baby is scared of darkness and she uses that 😅👉🏻👈🏻

Aaaaaaaanyways, I made this a bit longer than expected…
SO! I hope you liked the chapter, and see you next week!!! I know you'll find the next flashback quite interesting at the very least…
Thank you all for reading!!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Investing time and energy on someone is not a waste
Status: Under observation.

Chapter Notes

Well, I'm gonna tell a little anecdote about this in the ending note, because, turns out, this is based on something that happened to me <("^-^)

Aaaaaaaaaanyways, I hope you enjoy!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The months of doing mundane activities and observing Adora and Catra's daily life reminded Beatrix of the times she would accompany Castaspella to run simple errands outside Mystacor.

It was so… *refreshing*.

Simply different.

It wasn't the usual official duties, nor was it assisting somewhere with magic-related issues. It was merely going for a few things down at the surface, be it groceries, essentials, or little luxuries the sorcerers allowed themselves sometimes.

In fact, she could recall pretty well this one time they had gone for some utilities to a market right under the floating island, and how they had an… *interesting* encounter.

In reality, the events weren't anything unusual; the intriguing part was Castaspella's behaviour, which she couldn't understand back then.

Perhaps now, allowing the memory to return, she'd have a different view on it…

The sorceress and her ethereal companion had been walking for, at leat, ten minutes, back to that cliff where floating boulders could take them to Mystacor, when they came across someone in the middle of the Woods.

—Excuse me, Lady— the man called, making Castaspella stop right next to him. He was an old anthropomorphic ram that immediately reminded Shadow Weaver of Norwyn. —Do you happen to know this area?

—Oh, of course— she carefully replied.

—Would you know how to get to the Hidden Market?— he then requested.

—Yes, of course. In fact, we come from there— Castaspella told him, smiling gently. —I can show you the way, it's close by.

—Much appreciated, Lady— he thanked her, and they began walking back down the path the women came from. —You know…— he began, as they slowly walked. —I got lost because I haven't been here in years now. I've forgotten the directions— he laughed.

—Oh, I understand— Castaspella replied. —Don't worry, it's easy to remember once you get there again. For reference, it is right under the floating island— she added.

—I see…

—Cas— Shadow Weaver called, speaking in a low tone, guessing the man wouldn't be able to listen. —Why exactly are we retracing all the way we *just* walked, only to accompany a complete stranger?— she complained. —Not to mention this man walks *incredibly* slowly.

—Look— the sorceress began, taking a deep breath and speaking in a hushed tone too. —*I* decided to accompany him, alright? Nothing forces you to come with us. You're free to choose *not* to come along if you're so bothered by this— the sorceress replied, trying not to draw the man's attention.

That had been… bold of her; the woman didn't expect it at all, so she struggled to hide her surprise which she couldn't be sure whether the sorceress had noticed.

However, Shadow Weaver only grunted and continued to follow them without participating in their friendly conversation. Once they arrived, the man bowed respectfully and thanked the sorceress profusely, in a manner that made Shadow Weaver roll her eyes.

—Thank you very much— he said. —I hope I didn't importune you too much, making you walk all the way back here.

—Of course not— Castaspella replied, smiling gently. —It was a pleasure to help you. The thread seller is right there, I believe she's still working. I don't relly know when she closes— she added, thoughtful at the end. —I hope you find what you're looking for.

—Once again, thank you. Have a nice day— he farewelled.

Finally…

The women didn't linger and walked back to the cliff, mostly in silence, until Castaspella decided to speak up.

—Go ahead. Say it…

—It took us half an hour to get back there— Shadow Weaver began. —And that man walked *very* slowly. You should have given him directions and nothing else.

—He's old. And I lost nothing accompanying him and making sure he wouldn't go off-track again— Castaspella argued as they finally arrived at Mystacor.

—In fact, you did lose time.

—Oh, please…

—I just don't understand why you would do that for a complete stranger— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Because I wanted to? And had time to spare?

—Or because you're too nice and give out your time and energy to just anyone?

—Like I'm giving my time and energy to you right now?— she mocked her. As they entered the building, the sorceress sentenced —Look. I do *not* care whether you think it's a waste. This is *my* energy and my time, alright? I'll dispose of it as I please.

Oh…

She was… *right.*

—Fair enough— the woman sighed.

What an infuriating woman.

But at the same time, she *was* right.

She had given Shadow Weaver almost all her time and energy. Invested so much despite having no guarantees she would change at all. Not even guarantees she would be heard…

Perhaps, and only perhaps, that was one of Castaspella's good qualities. One of the things that made her the sorceress she is, and that led to them having that… *relationship* of mutual trust.

Right.

In any case, she had to admit, it was quite admirable how Castaspella stood her ground and didn't let Shadow Weaver influence her decisions.

Her personality was far stronger than one would think, no?

And perhaps, only perhaps, Shadow Weaver was the insecure one in this scenario.

Of course not! Why would she!?

Maybe because she allowed a tiny issue to annoy her enough to drag the subject for more than half an hour? Or because it took her so long to stop pestering the sorceress? Made her give explanations for her explanations?

Just how insecure does one have to be to ask for so many justifications? Why did she *need* the sorceress to defend her every action like that?

She now felt so ridiculous.

Wasn't she the one who considered Micah childish for wanting Castaspella to justify everything she did regarding herself?

What a hypocrite.

But perhaps…

Perhaps it was a good thing that she realized this now, right?

And, of course, she could now more consciously appreciate this characteristic of hers.

She *should*…

Chapter End Notes

SO! ANECDOTE TIME!

Well, one day, when I was going to the gym, which takes me aprox 10 minutes walking, an old woman stopped me and asked if I lived in the area, and I admitted as much. So she explained she was looking for a thread store that was around there, but couldn't remember where because she hadn't gone there since before the pandemic! And what's more, that place is *right in front of my house*!
So ofc I accompanied the woman all the way there, and checked the place was still open. As you may be guessing, the woman walked incredibly slow, so it took us longer to get there that it takes me walking alone, and by the time I finally arrived at the gym, about half an hour had gone by. So guess who said "I'm making this a scene in the fanfic"? This idiot hahaah

Anyways, ofc when I was walking, half of me was arguing what SW said here, while the other half, which I followed, argued what Casta said here. I just *had* to do this. It's just so perfect XD

Anyways, that was all for the anecdote today! I hope you enjoyed! See you next week!!

(okay, just one more thing... That thing SW thinks, about being childish for asking Casta to justify her explanations, give explanations for everything etc, may or may not be just my catharsis because my brother always makes me explain and justify everything I do, even give explanations for those justifications, which is unbearable. Ngl, I wish I had Casta's personality to simply stand my ground and say "because it's my decision".)

The Guild Dance

Chapter Notes

> Well hello!! I'm saying it now, this will be the last chapter of the year and I'll take January as a break and resume posting in February. Just in case people don't read notes, I'll also add that as "next chapter" here...
>
> ANYWAYS, I wanted to say, in case you only read this, that this week I'm posting *Times Past And Future* again, like last year, AND I'm including Delwyn there! There's even a bit of lore I haven't included here: his spouse's name!
>
> Ahem, that's enough self-promotion.
> Well, I hope you enjoy this chapter, and see you next year! Have a gentle New Year!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

What a headache.

A month flew by fast and, now, the Guild Dance was once again upon them. Queen Glimmer had taken the precaution of sending more than enough help to Mystacor, so her aunt wouldn't have to handle everything alone, even more alone than the previous year, yet the Head Sorceress was in utter distress.

With how much she loved organizing parties, having this one thing ruined was a nightmare.

And the reason? A certain theater manager who wouldn't stop pestering her.

—…I'm just saying— she insisted. —Shouldn't we, as the main company always hired for this event, have the *main* stage?

—For the last time— Castaspella sentenced, stopping in her tracks and turning around to face her, trying to remain as calm as possible. —The Queen has decided that it will be Double Trouble's company this year. Besides, I don't know what makes you think *I* have any interest in contradicting Glimmer's decision. It's just a performance.

—Perhaps if, now that your *friend* isn't here to interrupt, you came for the private show I offered you two years ago, you'd see it's not *just* a performance…

—As I said back then: you're very generous, but I am very busy with preparations and don't have time to sit and watch your skit. So, if you allow me…

The sorceress could barely stand another moment and turned to leave, but the manager stopped her by the arm.

—Come on, Head Sorceress. It won't take long— she insisted. —And I could perhaps invite you for a drink afterwards? I'm sure you need to rest a bit from the stress of organizing this.

Castaspella felt on the brink of exasperation, but removed her hand as gently as possible, and calmly replied —I said I am very busy. I do *not* have time to spare for a drink and, I'm sorry, but I'm not interested either.

—I see…— the manager let out, with a tone that sent a chill down the sorceress' spine. —The offer remains, however, in case you change your mind…

With that, she finally walked away, and Castaspella breathed out deeply. She hadn't even noticed she was holding her breath or how she kept her fists tightly closed.

She couldn't deny it: she missed having Shadow Weaver around to help her out of these situations. That and, apparently, it was her absence what had emboldened the theatre manager.

How annoying.

The Head Sorceress needed a break, she sure did, but she *really* couldn't afford it, and immediately rushed to check on the food preparations.

—Alright, it's on, my darlings— Double Trouble said. Looking from one princess to the other, they wrote down a few things and then read the notes. —I bet it will be our dear sorceress the one to confess first, *but* that will earn her a rejection of the "oh, I don't deserve you" kind— they began, dramatically at the end. —Meanwhile, we have our Queen betting it will be Shadow Weaver who confesses accidentally in a fit of rage— they continued, smirking. —I won't lie, that's quite likely— they conceded, looking at Glimmer with a knowing expression. —And… because you consider your aunt wouldn't dare admit it. My, my… have some faith in her, darling— they laughed. —Now: Adora and Perfuma here bet that the sorceress will say it first and that… uh… Shadow Weaver will cry— they read, in utter disbelief. —I have no idea what woman you met, but even if she seems to have softened a bit, this is quite a stretch— Double Trouble commented, looking at them with an expression that showed just how unlikely they consider it.

—Oh, come on. By the time it finally happens, it may be possible!— Adora argued.

—Did you hit your head recently, Love?— Catra asked, holding Finn in her arms, and just as shocked as the shape-shifter. —The day that old hag cries is the day I entirely shave my head— she said, mockingly.

—Alright, alright ladies. Let me finish— Double Trouble requested, before clearing their throat. —The rest of you, Scorpia, Bow, Mermista, Frosta, Nettossa and Spinnerella, bet that they will subtly confess and argue about it until both understand what the other meant— they read. With a laugh, they added —Oh well! I like this one! It would be *hilarious*!

—My bet…— Catra began, looking at Finn and smirking. —Is that my baby here will have learnt how to read before either of them dare confess…

A collective laugh burst out while Double Trouble wrote down Catra's wager, and quickly saved the piece of paper all rolled up inside a case.

With an exaggerated bow, they said —Well, my dears. It is always a pleasure to make business with you all. We shall revisit that little scroll once the miracle happens.

—I'm saying it now: don't hold your breath, princesses— Catra immediately commented. —That's not gonna happen any time soon— she laughed.

—Now, if you excuse me— Double Trouble began, grinning. —I have a show to prepare. I suppose I'll see you all at the party!

—See you!— Adora farewelled.

The princesses left together, led by Queen Glimmer who had asked for their help with the party too, and soon, they all were handling a different aspect of the preparations, significantly alleviating Castaspella's load.

The following day, the floating island was swarming with people from all over Etheria; the Head Sorceress lost count of how many people she had greeted. And, although she was busy as the host, she dropped her duties when she found Delwyn and his kids, sitting on a table set at the corner of the main hall, visibly uncomfortable.

—Hello there— she greeted them. —Aren't you enjoying the party?

Despite how shy the children seemed, her gentle tone managed to ease them and the girl, Namai, carefully replied —I-I'm sorry. We… don't really fit.

—We look… *weird*— her brother added, looking away. —Everyone was staring— he added.

—Oh, Kharyn— she let out, pained. —I promise no one will make fun of either of you. I understand all this unwanted attention is overwhelming, but try to pay them no mind. No one means any harm. Most are just… not used to having people from other planets yet. It will pass soon enough— she assured them. —And you don't look weird— she added. —You look beautiful, and I'm sure many are interested in meeting you.

—That's what I've been telling them— Delwyn commented, smiling shyly too. —But I couldn't even get them to greet Adora and Catra.

Surprised, the sorceress sat with them, ready to try and reassure them further, but before she could speak, the girls approached them as if summoned by Delwyn's words.

—Hey! Namai, Kharyn, you're here!— Catra happily exclaimed.

—Hi!

The siblings' shy reply softened the girls' expression, and both sat at the table too. Adora set Finn on her lap and looked at them with a gentle smile.

—Have you tried the food? You don't need to mingle if you aren't comfortable, but why don't you try to enjoy the party? There's a lot to eat and drink, and I'm sure you'll love our food!

—There's just… a lot of people around the tables— Kharyn replied, looking down.

—Dad, can you get us something?— Namai asked, pulling from Delwyn's sleeve.

He laughed and stood up while nodding, promptly followed by Castaspella. Both went to get some dishes for the siblings and left the girls with them, sure they would be fine.

However, in the short time it took them to arrive and return from the food tables, at least a dozen people stopped Delwyn to ask about his kids. At first, he didn't mind, but everyone seemed more interested in why they didn't look like him at all, and it quickly annoyed both the ambassador and the sorceress.

No wonder they felt so uncomfortable.

They were truly being stared at like some sort of exotic animal.

At least Adora and Catra treated them well. And soon enough, when Glimmer and Bow joined them, the kids looked like they were enjoying themselves a bit more.

With the Best Friends Squad keeping them company, Kharyn and Namai had fun the rest of the party…

—I'm sorry about what happened— Castaspella apologized, once the Guild Dance was over. —I mean, all the guests questioning your appearance, pointing out you don't look alike… I never expected people to be so rude— she told them all.

—I understand— Delwyn said. —I just… never thought they would *actually* ask when it should be obvious my children just look more like… *them*— he uttered, visibly pained.

—But it is!— Catra immediately said. —Those pricks just like sticking their nose in other's business.

—I'm sorry they all kept bringing it up and, well, perhaps caused you some bitter feelings— Castaspella insisted.

—Please, it wasn't your fault— Delwyn denied, shaking his head. —And the memory of my spouse could never be bitter. It saddened me, yes, but I can't expect everyone to know my story and have such considerations. It was a logical question.

—No, no— Bow interrupted. —Logical would be to ask about your partner or about the parent of your kids. People usually did when I was accompanied by just one of my dads— he commented. —But the way they said it, sounded like they…

—…Questioned whether you were really their dad— Glimmer cut in, annoyed. —Perhaps I should say something. We don't have any kind of rules that can protect people from outside Etheria.

—Oh, right! We totally forgot about that!— Adora exclaimed.

—Please, don't feel obligated just because of this— Delwyn said, surprised.

—But it's necessary— Bow assured him. —Actually, I'm thinking we should have done it before, especially after knowing you would bring your kids.

—I could use your help drafting the new rules for visitors of other planets, starting with proper treatment— Glimmer told him.

—Yeah. People should know you are friends of Etheria that have to be respected— Adora agreed.

Delwyn couldn't help but let out a smile; he knew he could trust them, but witnessing their fierce reaction and drive to protect them was heart-warming.

—Thank you all. I'll be glad to assist you.

Chapter End Notes

Like I said in the initial note, this is the last chapter of the year, and I wish everyone a gentle New Year!

Posting shall resume in February, so I hope you enjoyed this chapter (^-^)
Thank you for reading me this year!!! <3

Notice

Hello everyone! To begin with, Happy New Year! (if you follow the Gregorian calendar, that is)

Second: Thank you so much for accompanying me this whole year! I've been posting this fic since February and, frankly, I enjoyed every moment of it, all the comments I got, the theories, the ideas… everything!

So thank you all for this wonderful year, and I hope you like this fic so far.

Well, now, this is far from over, you know? But ***I will be taking a break until February again***. I need it, mostly because I've been terribly blocked and don't want that to affect my writing… I feel like I've reduced the quality of my writing, so I need to take this month to rest and write with more calm and a fresh head. I think you all deserve my best quality writing, so that's what I aim to give you.

Hopefully, the wait won't be that long <("^_^)

In any case, once again, thank you all for the comments, the kudos, this whole year reading me (bearing with me lol), and have a Happy New Year!

~~Oh right. Remember I'll be deleting this "chapter" once I resume posting, so try not to comment in this one, alright?~~

Ahem, forget that, I'll just make this an

Interlude

This is your rest stop, specially if you've been reading since chapter 1 in one go (yes, I know people who did), so go rest a while, eat, drink water, and come back later. This fic isn't going anywhere (–_^)



Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: It's never too late to grow and become better
Status: Labeled "ridiculous"

Chapter Notes

Welcome back, everyone!

I hope you enjoy the new chapters to come, and I hope these are also better quality that the last few, heh

Erm... I don't know what else to say, except thank you all for staying with me (#^_^#)

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Ah… The thrill…

Beatrix felt excited still from their last game of deck cards.

Why, if it was a pretty good match for her. Much better than the ones they had back in Mystacor. This time she managed to win around five times, even if she still lost in the end.

And playing with stakes always added to the thrill it made her feel.

But they were back to the “answer a question truthfully”, which wasn’t as much fun as the stakes she’d like to play with.

Oh, but that was still a great game.

It made her just a bit nostalgic for their earlier games, and Beatrix couldn’t help but recall one of those times…

It was quite annoying how Castaspella always won and always asked the same kind of question. But rules were rules and she agreed to them…

—Ha! I win again! Woohoo!

The sorceress cheerfully celebrated in the same manner as she constantly did, which everyone found quite bothering. It felt like she was rubbing it on their face, but Shadow Weaver unwillingly smirked. Opposite to everyone, she found that celebration of hers quite amusing.

—Yes, yes. Funny how you're not tired of winning at this point.

—*Tired*!? Of *winning*!?— Castaspella exclaimed, before letting out a laugh. —Never!

—Right. Well, stop fooling around and ask your question, will you?

—Yes, of course— she replied, clearing her throat. —So, remember when you told me about smuggling food into the Fright Zone to feed Adora?

—Oh, I can guess where this is going— Shadow Weaver immediately said. —I bet you want to know why I stopped doing so when Adora began sharing the food with Catra, no?

—Yes.

—Why do you always have to ask about Catra?

—Is it bad that I want to learn more about the girl?

—Now, don't you lie to me— the woman countered. —You want to know about what I did to her…

—Interesting how you made this about yourself… *again*.

—Do you want to know, yes or no?

—Yes. I just don't understand why you couldn't let them both share the food!

—Do you know how difficult it is to smuggle enough for two people?

—Still, at least *some* real food would have been better than only plain rations. How old were they when you stopped?

—Less than five, I reckon.

—I can't imagine how much they enjoyed the food when they finally tasted it again. Probably didn't even recall having eaten it before.

—Most likely, I'd say— Shadow Weaver agreed, leaning back on her chair.

—So? Do you want to play another match?— the sorceress eagerly proposed.

—Aren't you out of questions already?

—Hardly! And I can still ask about other topics, although I haven't exhausted my questions about Catra, you know?

—I think your obsession with her is quite weird…

—I am not obsessed. I want you to revise what you've done. It will help you reconsider those decisions.

—And why on Etheria would I want to do so?

—Don't you want to apologize to her? Or, you know, at least learn and grow?

—That foolish head of yours is filled with curious ideas… I am *dead*. What growth do you expect?

—Oh, come on!

—I don't want to hear it.

—Sore loser.

—How is that even related?— the woman asked, confused.

—Because you still can't accept defeat! "Oh, I died. I can't do anything anymore"— she mocked her. —Well, you're here now. You can do whatever. Why can't that be becoming a better person?

—Why would I want that, and what use is it now?

—You don't have the first idea how needed it can be, do you?

—Alright. What's the obsession with the girls' healing process now?

—Why do you call my interests "obsessions"!?— Castaspella asked, indignant now.

—Because you only focus on that and pester me with it for months!

—Maybe because you're stubborn and hard-headed?

—Alright. I get it. But why bother?

—Why not? I believe it's worth it.

—And that makes you a fool.

—Stop calling me a fool!

—No— Shadow Weaver replied, smirking.

—Ugh…

—You said I'm stubborn? Here it is— she taunted her.

—You can be such a bitch sometimes— Castaspella uttered, raising from the table. —As you don't want to play anymore, I'll just go handle my duties…

And so, the sorceress walked away, leaving the woman alone in the library, feeling ghostly again.

—I suppose I am…

Well, she had to admit that was quite an eventful afternoon in a way.

And now, looking back, she had been really bitchy, *that* was true.

Beatrix wondered whether Castaspella recalled that conversation when she asked for help learning to apologize to Catra.

How very ironic, however. She was so resolved back then. So sure it was pointless…

But now that she thought about it, the sorceress probably did recall that conversation, seeing how one of the questions in the last game was what made her want her help to apologize to Catra…

If anything, Castaspella had proved her faith was well-placed after all…

But Shadow Weaver couldn't help finding it ridiculous still.

Chapter End Notes

Edit:
Oops! I'm an idiot, I forgot the final note...

I just don't know what to say...

Maybe some self promo: so, during January I took the chance to post a fic I had written (like a play instead of a normal fic) of a Swan Lake AU! With, like, SW as the villain and Casta as her opposite, specifically a lovers to enemies to lovers again XD
If you wanna give it a chance, it's here

Well, that's about it...
See you next week!! ^_^

Sigils

Chapter Summary

With the start of a new year, some progress is bound to come. And not only will Shadow Weaver's pupils further advance in their studies, but also, King Micah will slowly improve his damaged relationships.
»—I won’t force Catra to accept your mentoring, but I do think it’s high time you two made peace. Work things out.
»—She doesn’t even want to see me!
»—At the very least, try!
»—Alright! Alright! I will! But I don’t know what you expect from this.
»—Not much. But if you can be on good terms with her like you are with Spin’s pupils, it’s more than enough for me.

On the other hand, all of Shadow Weaver's progress seems to hit a wall as one issue still remains: learning to accept rejection. How can a woman that won't tolerate losing, avoid reacting violently to her apology being dismissed?

Chapter Notes

Erm, about this chapter, u can imagine this opens to SW learning to accept rejection from some flashback…

Ngl, I don't yet know if I'm doing that through a flashback, BUT, the thing with losing in deck fights kinda plays into it. When I was little and went to a psychologist for the first time, it was mostly because I got super violent when I lost. And the ways of the psychologist to help me (that I can remember), included playing tabletop games every session so I would learn to lose and HANDLE IT.

Anyways, I hope u enjoy this chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Three months went by, the Gift Exchange passed without a hitch, and the Queen set into motion her plan to draft a set of rules and regulations that can protect their friends from afar. In the meantime, Delwyn continued to help with the sorcery classes in Mystacor, not only assisting Castaspella, but rather any tutor that needed theoretical help from books or scrolls.

Now, two weeks into the new year's classes, Shadow Weaver's pupils are learning sigils with help from none other than King Micah.

—Alright, class. You know how this goes. Everyone, stay back— she requested. As the Head Sorceress finished drawing one on the floor as a demonstration, she let out —And that should be… it?

Confused, Castaspella stood up and looked down at the sigil that was supposed to have lit up. She realized something must have gone wrong, but before she could say a word, her brother's sudden movement called her attention, and she saw him promptly fix a corner where the trace wasn't clear enough. Only then did it light up.

—There!

—Oh, that- Right! Thank you, Micah— the sorceress said, fearing how the pupils would react. But there was no reaction at all. They were so fascinated with the sigil… It made the sorceress smile gleefully. —I see you're all *very* interested, aren't you? Who wants to tell me what it does?

—Me!

—Me!

—Me! Me!

—Me!

—No, me!

Castaspella couldn't help but giggle as she tried to calm them all down. She could never get tired of their enthusiasm, but it was impossible to impart class in that chaos.

—Alright, alright! I see you all know, so… why don't you discuss it between yourselves first, then assign one of you to tell us what the sigil does and everything you know about it?— she proposed, smiling at them, both hands joined at the front.

After the class was done that day, the siblings took a walk together through the halls, mostly in silence, as neither knew how to start the conversation.

—So…

—So.

They kept walking, looking at anything except each other, with expressions that quickly changed from forced indifference to sorrow.

—You know, when you said you wanted to talk, Sis, I expected this to be more… conversation-ish.

—And I expected you to ask *what* I wanted to talk about.

—Well, it's obvious. Must be about *her*.

His casual reply made the sorceress halt abruptly and turn to look outside.

Resting her arms on the edge of one of the round arched openings of the corridor, she sighed —It sounds more like *you* want to talk about her…

—What- Why-why would I- What are you- No!

His nervous, indignant stammering made the sorceress close her eyes while taking a deep breath. After all, it wasn't a good idea to start a new fight.

—Micah…— she let out, turning around to face him. —What do you *think* I want to talk about?

—I-I don't know! I just- It's just that it usually *is* related to her!

—My life doesn't revolve around her!

—Then what is it?

—This time, it's about Catra. Her training.

Oh.

He had almost forgotten.

It took him aback and, for a moment, he simply stared at her, blinking.

—What… about it?

—I'm not enough to train her any further. And she still refuses to learn from you, which is… a huge *problem*— she began, measuring her words. —I won't force her to accept your mentoring, but I do think it's high time you two made peace. Work things out.

—She doesn't even want to see me!

—At the very least, try!

—Alright! Alright! I will!— he quickly agreed. —But I don't know what you expect from this.

—Not much. But if you can be on good terms with her like you are with Spin's pupils, it's more than enough for me.

That term again.

"Spin".

He couldn't help but eye-twitch hearing his little sister speaking like that, referring to Shadow Weaver with such a friendly term.

—Right.

The sorcerer looked down and attempted to go on his way, but he felt a hand on his shoulder and reluctantly stopped.

—Micah. Please.

—I said I will. I'll… apologize and try to… "make peace", as you said.

—Thank you.

He finally left and directly returned to Bright Moon, first aiming for his room before changing course towards the kitchen instead.

He knew he had to apologize, and he would, as promised, of course. But there was only one thing in his head, and it was Castaspella saying "Spin".

And the hunger. He was quite hungry.

A while after, the King was sitting at a table, eating some noodles soup with a pair of chopsticks, while silently reflecting.

He felt like he was missing something. There was something he wasn't seeing. Something he couldn't understand.

A part of him entirely refused to believe a single word of what Castaspella had told him over the past year, while another part wanted to believe his sister had unearthed something Shadow Weaver had buried deep within her. That same "something" he was missing.

A "something" that would mean Light Spinner was still there.

No, but… What could that even be?

And why, of all people, would it be his *sister* the one to make this surface?

Ugh, it was maddening for him.

His sister wasn't exactly a miracle-worker. There was simply nothing about her that could make Shadow Weaver "grow" so much. So a genuine change of heart from the woman was unlikely at best.

No. It had to be pure pretending.

It could only be it!

For whatever reason, Shadow Weaver was creating this whole situation… this whole… pretense.

For some reason, she was trapping Castaspella in this elaborate lie…

But why?

This was the only thing he simply couldn't figure out.

Why would that woman want to catch his sister in her web of falsehood?

What does Shadow Weaver want from Castaspella?

This was the one question that haunted him since the beginning.

He sighed and brushed his eyes, tired. In a few motions, he finished the noodles and then picked up the bowl to sip the soup. When he put it down, it surprised him to find Glimmer standing at the door.

—Oh! Hey, baby girl— he greeted her, suddenly energized.

—Hi dad. What are you- *were* you eating?

—Some noodles soup… I cooked it myself!

—You… did?— she asked, surprised, holding her staff with both hands. —Can I try?

Shocked, the King remained frozen for a moment before reacting.

—Oh, yes! Here, I'll serve you some— he offered, standing up from the table. He promptly filled up a bowl with soup and set it on the table with a clean pair of chopsticks. As the Queen took a seat, he clarified —It may need salt for you, seeing how I didn't add condiments, so tell me if you need some. But I hope you like it!

Curious, Glimmer took the chopsticks and tried the noodles, immediately flinching at the lack of flavor.

—Um, yes, it… needs some salt— she let out, as soon as she swallowed. —But… it's well cooked, dad. And there's some… taste I can't place— she continued, pensive.

While handing her the salt, Micah replied —Yeah. I cooked them with some mushrooms I found here in the cupboards. This kitchen is quite packed with all manner of ingredients.

—Oh well, I'm gladly surprised you learned to cook something, dad— she admitted, about to taste the noodles again. However, suddenly realizing how it had sounded, she stammered —I-I mean it in a good way, dad. I'm glad! A-and perhaps you can ask Auntie to teach you how to give the soup some more flavor without using salt, you know…

Glimmer smiled nervously and tried the food again, only to nod contentedly, signaling it tasted better.

—I get it, Dear. Don't worry. Thank you— he replied, smiling softly. —And I'll… consider asking her for some tips, yeah.

Later that night, after the nocturnal class, Castaspella calmly walked into the magical groove, expecting Shadow Weaver to appear any second, and yawned, exhausted. Behind her, the woman showed up, arms crossed in front of her chest.

—Well, good night. You finally returned.

—Oh, sorry, I hadn't…

—I'm just taunting you— Shadow Weaver interrupted, raising a hand and smirking. —I reckon with the new classes you must be quite tired.

—I am, yes— she admitted, with a weary smile. —Speaking of which, I wanted to let you know your kids are quite proficient in sigils too! I'd say they'll end up graduating in less than ten years…

—Now, *that* would be a record— the woman noted. —I won't lie. I'd like to be there for those classes. But I trust you've been handling them well enough, right?

Her tone was condescending, to say the least, and Castaspella couldn't help but squint at her.

—Of course I am!— she initially replied, offended. However, right after she looked away, ashamed, and admitted —I, of course, have Micah helping with this… But yes, I'm handling it. Requesting help is not…

—I know— Shadow Weaver interrupted, raising a hand again to stop her. —That's exactly how I expected you to handle this.

—Oh. I didn't- Right. Um, thank you.

—What are you thanking me for?

—Ne-never mind.

—Right…— the woman sighed. —In that case, I'll suppose my kids are on better terms with your brother, is that so?

—Yes! Actually, I'm glad they have progressed so much with this! It's far easier with his help, and without the fights, we can make the most of the whole hour of class.

—Good to know neither of them is being stubborn about this.

—Yeah— the sorceress sighed, approaching a nearby tree to sit against it. —And I also convinced Micah of apologizing to Catra so they can be on better terms too.

—I'm still surprised they'd fight over me— the woman bemusedly said as she went to sit by Castaspella.

—Oh, sure— she replied, rolling her eyes with a small smile. —You're thrilled, admit it.

—Please. I am *actually* surprised. One would think they'd ally *against me*.

—You know how the girls feel…

—Still…

—Alright— the sorceress sighed. —And speaking of apologies… Don't you think it's already time you apologized to Catra too?

—Not quite yet— she replied, looking to the front and resting her hands on her knees. —I can't say I'm ready.

—Okay… Can you tell me what you still blame her for?

—It's not that, but rather… knowing she won't accept my apology— she explained. Concerned, Castaspella turned to the side and gave her a worried look. —I am… not ready to accept rejection yet, alright? Now stop looking at me like that.

—Bea, I…

—I just don't know what my reaction could be and that would only make things worse. It's nothing to pity me for.

—I don't pity you. I'm proud— Castaspella assured her.

—Hah! Why!? I have made no progress at all!— she angrily argued.

—That's not true— the sorceress immediately replied. —First of all, you decided to look critically into your actions. Second, you put great effort into recognizing you were wrong. Third, you asked for *help* learning how to be genuine in your apology! And now, even though you can't accept rejection yet, not only do you recognize as much, but also, you don't want to hurt Catra for it!— she listed. —It's incredible progress!

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes and couldn't help letting out a smile.

—You *really* want to cheer me up, don’t you?

—I’m just trying to make you see what you don’t— she replied. —And it’s alright. I won’t pressure you to apologize for the time being. We can wait until you feel confident enough, alright?

Moments like this made the woman feel undeserving of the sorceress, but only for a second before something inside her metaphorically slapped her across the face and banished the feeling.

—Alright.

Chapter End Notes

Well, so... As u can see, I am kind of trying to make Micah and SW progress a bit, but like, it's still gonna take quite some time, u know...

Oh, but, even if Micah progresses in the Catra front, there's still not much progress in the SW front, while the Casta front is bound to meet more setbacks lol

Sorry, I shouldn't laugh but, it's just so funny how I keep projecting my own relationship with my brother, and rn we're in better terms but, it just never lasts… I'm sitting here, waiting for our problems to return… Ugh, it's exhausting, but at least writing all of this helps a lot.

Well, thank u all for reading and see you next week!! <3

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: expressing your feelings is for the best
Status: suspicious, quarantined.

Chapter Notes

Yes, that summary is mimicking an antivirus finding a suspicious file XD

So, um, I feel like this is an important chapter, although short, and despite the lesson not being accepted, you can imagine it's quite important that she can *observe* it at least! Eventually, she'll come to accept it…

The thing with her is how she will evade certain topics, fearing the feeling of weakness they can cause her, cause she refuses to understand that everyone can be vulnerable sometimes, and that it's healthy to allow that, at least without letting anyone know. But she pretty much treats herself like she treats others, which is why she won't allow herself to have any moments of weakness *at all*!

So! Enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Quite a few eventful days went by…

Just a few hours before, the girls had paid the woman a visit but, again, refused to tell her what was going on with Castaspella. And all because, in turn, she refused to tell them why she asked!

She was feeling something off through the spell, but Shadow Weaver didn't want to admit she was worried.

Oh, she'd *never* admit to that.

It was just one of those feelings that made her so utterly helpless and weak that her only instinct was to bury it as deeply as possible.

Which reminded her of this one time she discussed with Castaspella about expressing her feelings…

She could guess what the sorceress would be telling her now if she were there to witness her argument with Adora and Catra.

—Come on— Castaspella insisted. —I can see *and feel* something is bothering you!

—Why are you so insistent!? If I say it's nothing, then it's nothing!

—Why don’t you try to express what you feel!? Just this once at least!

—*Express* what I feel? And cry like an imbecile whenever I’m hurt by your brother's behavior towards me!? Hah! I will *not*, ever, be *that* weak. Forget it!

The sorceress hesitated for a moment, concerned, and couldn’t help reaching out to her.

—Bea… cry? Is that… what you…

—Stop it— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

Arms folded, the woman turned to the side, frowning.

—Please! Just tell me…— Castaspella pleaded, gently placing a hand on her arm.

But she only replied, with a trembling voice, —Just. Leave. Me. Alone.

This time, the Head Sorceress didn’t hesitate to hold onto her arm, firmly yet still gentle, and stepped closer.

—Don't do this…

—I said… I won't be that weak. I do *not* want that— Shadow Weaver uttered, angry. —Leave me! Stop pestering me with that sentimental bullshit!

—A-alright. I won't speak about that anymore— Castaspella sighed. —But please, don't push me away now just to wallow in this… anger.

—If you're so *adamant* in keeping me company one way or another, then do so in *silence*— she replied, rolling her eyes and still quite annoyed.

With a nod, the sorceress agreed and followed Shadow Weaver into the library, where they both took a seat. Despite the tension, Castaspella still dared to lay against her while the woman read a book. After a while, she felt the need to read aloud, guessing the sorceress probably wanted that but wouldn't ask for it, as she had promised to keep quiet.

Truth be told, Shadow Weaver didn’t know why she was doing this for her, and she *refused* to think about it.

She still didn’t know why she had decided to read aloud for Castaspella back then. Why she had felt compelled to take her into consideration like that, after rejecting feelings of a similar nature…

Wasn’t she letting the sorceress be her weak spot?

Yes.

No.

Perhaps…

It was just… difficult for Beatrix to understand or accept.

And that was exactly why she couldn't tell the girls *why* she was asking about Castaspella. Because she would not dare *think* about the matter enough to come up with a conclusion. She had no answer to give them.

She just didn't want to feel this.

Shadow Weaver would never allow herself to feel any of this. She *couldn't*.

She couldn't…

Chapter End Notes

I know, it was really short. I apologize <(“^_^)

But, as I said in the initial note, this one lesson, although dismissed for now, is really important, and the seed has been planted. It just needs time to grow within her, and will be key to her finally apologizing!
Btw, the moment is close! If I recall my plans correctly, around chapter 60 or so it should be happening \(^0^)/

But that isn’t the end… it’s just the beginning of a longer journey to heal.
Gods, so many characters need to heal…

Aaaaaanyways, I hope you enjoyed the chapter, and see you next week! Thank you for reading!!

When the World Grows Cold

Chapter Summary

New problems knock on Mystacor's door and carry with them even more trouble for the Head Sorceress and Shadow Weaver, whose patience will be put to the test. Adora and Catra refuse to give up on the woman, and their faith will prove to be well-placed.
»—Always such an impertinent child! This is not a game! I'm getting tired of your impetuousness!— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, increasingly angry and seemingly ready to threaten her.
»But she did not.
»Instead, she turned around and groaned, which the girls recognized as an effort to restrain her violent impulse. It was unexpected, so much that they were stunned for a moment. But it was the opportunity for them, so Adora decided to give it a shot and play one last card.
»—Can't you just admit you're worried? Scared? Concerned?

Growth can come in many ways, and only a select few will truly appreciate every tiny step in the right direction…

Chapter Notes

Well, well, how's everyone doing?
It's the last Wednesday of the month, meaning it's already been a month since restarting!
Look at you all! Still here, wow… ~~I'm not crying, you are~~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Another day, another problem.

A couple of months passed in fair calmness, Mystacor's only concerns being their daily activities, until their help was urgently requested by princess Perfuma. They had, once again, a feral magical beast on the loose. This time, however, it was one that possessed some kind of freezing power and had been affecting plumerians and their houses all around.

No doubt it was a dire situation, they couldn't afford to lose a second.

The Head Sorceress quickly gathered a group of acolytes, the ones best suited to handle such an issue, and promptly departed along with her brother.

Unsure where the creature could be, and knowing that several people had been affected by the creature's freezing power, Castaspella decided to divide the group: two acolytes would stay with her and Micah to find the beast while the rest went to treat the plumerians.

It didn't take them too long to find the creature, and the sorcerers had to craft a plan on the fly. They decided the acolytes would close in on the creature from behind while the siblings cut its path ahead.

Soon, Castaspella and Micah were waiting for the creature with their spells ready, but they weren't expecting the tremor caused by its charge towards them; while the King managed to stay on his feet, the sorceress lost her footing and her spell vanished. So when the beast was over them, she got knocked back before her brother could stun it.

The acolytes rushed to find them and helped Micah restrain the creature before attempting to calm it down. Only then could they finally check on the Head Sorceress, who had fallen unconscious, presumably affected by the freezing magic too.

Castaspella couldn't feel them lift her up and carry her all the way back to Mystacor; all her senses were numb after the hit that made everything around her grow cold in mere seconds.

Utter coldness and darkness enveloped her immediately and didn't let go of her for days.

Later that same day, Catra and Adora left Finn with Melog after the kid fell asleep, and walked through the woods until they found the magical groove.

They weren't exactly expecting anything from it, but their conversation with Shadow Weaver still managed to surprise them. It was after a while of arguing, solely because of how condescending the woman was being, when the unexpected happened.

—Alright now. Tell me: what's going on in Mystacor? What happened to that sorceress now?

Although the question was quite casual, both the change of subject and the fact that she *asked*, took them by surprise.

—Why are you asking?— Catra questioned her.

—None of your business. Answer.

—Not until you tell us why you want to know— she retorted, arms folded.

The situation was confusing, to say the least, and Adora was a bit disconcerted at first. She wanted to tell her regardless, but now that Catra asked, curiosity picked her, and she preferred to support her.

—Come on. It's a simple question— she said.

—It is *none of your business*— the woman insisted.

—Oh well. Then what happened is none of your business either.

With that reply, Catra turned to leave and Adora followed.

—Don't you dare!— Shadow Weaver managed to yell before sinking below the surface as the girls left the groove.

While they walked back home, Adora couldn't help asking —So… why do you want to know why she's asking about Castaspella? We both know she won't admit it but, you know, she *does* care.

—Well, I want her to *admit it*— Catra explained. —I want to know if she… recognizes she's concerned, that she cares… and realizes it's not *wrong*.

—Is there… any reason in particular why you want that?

—Because, well…— she sighed. —If that's true, then it would mean… she *can* care about us too.

—Catra…

Adora stopped and pulled her into a tight embrace. The girl froze at first, but eventually gave in and hugged her back, letting her sorrow out.

—I feel so stupid… still having hope.

—It's not stupid. I also want to know that she does have a heart deep inside…

—Deep, deep inside— they both said in unison before letting out a laugh.

—Yeah…— Catra sighed. —Alright. Let's go home now. We can return tomorrow and see if she's less stubborn next time.

—Alright— Adora giggled.

Oh, but she was not.

If anything, the next time the girls went to speak with Shadow Weaver, she was even more adamant, getting increasingly irritated, and absolutely refusing to give her reasons for asking.

Adora had to admit a part of her found it quite childish, but also amusing.

It was the first time those two bickered in a pretty civilized manner, she reckoned.

But, also, it was the second day the sorceress was unconscious. It *was* concerning, and whatever was making Shadow Weaver ask probably made her restless. So perhaps… it wasn't right to play with the subject so much.

Meanwhile, back in Mystacor, Glimmer and Delwyn had been taking care of Castaspella to the best of their capabilities.

Last they knew, the plumerians hadn't woken up either, so they were completely in the dark. They didn't know what to do, nothing had worked so far, and there was no way of knowing when *or if* she would woke up any time soon.

That was, until that night.

It was past midnight when they got news from Plumeria that people were slowly waking up.

Finally.

So now, it was a question of time until the Head Sorceress woke up too.

Some hours passed, the sun was about to rise, and Glimmer was almost falling asleep. Catra and Adora had gone to keep her company, even offered to take her place so the Queen could go to rest, but she refused to leave her aunt's side.

—She will be fine, Sparkles. They all are waking up. She just needs some more time.

Catra sat next to her and stared at the sorceress. Glimmer shook off the drowsiness and nodded.

—I know…— she sighed. Trying to keep herself awake, she decided to ask —How is it going with Shadow Weaver? Have you told her already?

—No— she replied, without looking back at the Queen. —She still won't tell us why she's asking, so… Yeah.

—I don't know what I was expecting…

—Me neither.

As the girls sighed, a grunt called their attention, and the three of them rushed to Castaspella's side as she slowly woke up. She still didn't have the strength to move, but at least made a sound and attempted to open her eyes.

It took the sorceress a good while to fully recover, and another while to remember what had happened, but with the girls' help, things were clear soon enough.

And then, hunger struck.

After so long without eating, it was no surprise that Castaspella felt famished and weak, so Glimmer offered to go for some food, and promptly left the room, accompanied by the girls. As they walked down the hall, the Queen sighed in relief, and thanked them for the help. Then, a long silence settled between them for a while until they reached the kitchen.

—I think we should definitely tell Shadow Weaver what happened now— Adora suddenly told Catra, her expression regretful.

—Fine— she sighed. —Ah, but before I forget: hey, Sparkles, do you think you and Arrow Boy can look after Finn for a few days?— she asked Glimmer, who was busy putting together a plate for her aunt. —Tomorrow we're taking Delwyn's kids back to their planet.

—Oh, sure!— the Queen gladly accepted. —We'll take good care of them, don't worry. Now you two go tell that woman what happened, or Auntie will have to deal with her next time she goes to see her…

—Ah, damn! You're right. She'd sure take it out on her if we don't tell her, ugh…— Catra lamented. —But yeah, I already agreed to tell her anyways…

—Then go! Shoo!

Giggling, Adora took Catra by the arm and both left the palace.

A while after, with the sun fully illuminating the sky already, the girls arrived at the magical groove that was full of shiny spores. More than usual, Adora noticed.

Soon, the spirit rose from the ground, arms folded, and squinted at them as she asked —What do you want now? Are you done torturing me?

Surprised, Catra raised a brow as she replied —Good morning to you too. And that's an interesting way of putting it. Why don't you tell us why it's "torture"?

—Very funny— she mocked her. —I said it's none of your business. Now stop being so irreverent and tell me what happened!

Hearing her yell with such rage, Catra tensed up immediately and had to make a conscious effort to stay put. She hadn't seen Shadow Weaver act like that since her obsession with getting Adora back in the Horde.

Once again, she wondered why she was doing this.

Why was she still so hopeful?

And why did she keep giving the woman more and more chances, if every time it would be like this?

But she found an answer and her resolve hardened.

It all was because she now knows she *deserves* it. And after hearing Shadow Weaver's last words before she died, it became obvious to her that the woman could make the choice of caring for her.

So she wouldn't stop until that shell of stubbornness finally fell.

—No.

—You *will* tell me what happened!

—Not until you admit what you're feeling!— Catra insisted, raising her voice too, while mentally repeating to herself that the woman can't hurt her now.

—Always such an impertinent child! This is not a game! I'm getting tired of your impetuousness!— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, increasingly angry and seemingly ready to threaten her.

But she did not.

Instead, she turned around and groaned, which the girls recognized as an effort to restrain her violent impulse. It was unexpected, so much that they were stunned for a moment. But it was *the* opportunity for them, so Adora decided to give it a shot and play one last card.

—Can't you just admit you're worried? Scared? Concerned?

—I am not.

—You are! But you're also a coward and won't say it!— Adora retorted, losing her patience.

—I am not that weak!— the woman exclaimed, turning around to face them again. —Whatever makes you think I could *possibly* feel that way!?

—Cause you *do* have a heart! You can't repress it forever!

—Watch me!

—I take that as an admission— Adora let out, suddenly changing her tone, and smirking smuggly.

It shocked Shadow Weaver and left her speechless for a moment.

She had to admit defeat. She didn't like it one bit, but it made no sense to keep fighting it when it was clear the girls could see right through her.

—Fine— she growled, looking away with both hands closed on tight fists. —I've been feeling an ominous coldness through the spell that only now appears to have receded, but there's still a lingering sensation, something uncomfortable; it *has* to be something serious that happened to her— the woman honestly explained, without looking back. When she did, with rage in her eyes, she ordered —So stop this ridiculous game and tell me what happened.

It was a plea disguised as an order. That much was evident to them.

—Alright— Catra nodded. She exchanged a look with Adora and began —It was a weird magical beast that appeared near Plumeria. It hit her when they were trying to restrain it, and affected her with some bizarre freezing magic.

—Near Plumeria? Freezing magic? I know the creature, yes— she let out, thoughtful. —It's very dangerous and shouldn't be approached head first. It's better to ambush it and you always have to stay at a safe distance, for its whole body can *and will* freeze you upon touch.

—We don't know exactly what happened, but apparently the King wasn't able to stop it in time, so Castaspella was hit— Adora continued. —She woke up about an hour ago.

—That fool…— Shadow Weaver sighed, pressing her hands against her temples. —I cannot *believe* he was unable to keep his own sister safe!— she indignantly said.

—You- Did you just…— Catra began, stunned. —You just called your *star pupil* a fool!?— she finally exclaimed. With a loud laugh, she admitted —I *never* thought I'd hear you say something like that! It would be like you insulting Adora!

—Hey!

—Come on! Since when does she consider her golden kids to be anything less than perfect!?— Catra insisted, laughing again.

—Fine, yeah. That's… true— Adora admitted, rolling her eyes and reluctanctly letting out half a smile.

—I don't see what's so funny about this— Shadow Weaver complained, squinting at them, hands joined behind her back. —If you have nothing else to say, better leave now.

—First tell me something— Adora requested. —Don't you feel better now? Like, relieved?

—I- Perhaps— the woman admitted, looking away.

—Next time, just tell us what's wrong from the beginning— she suggested, taking a step forward. —That way we won't "torture" you, as you said before— she added, giggling slightly. —There's nothing wrong with caring. It's actually… a sign of strength! Not of weakness.

—Sure…

—I’m serious— Adora insisted. —Just think about it.

With that, the girls farewelled, turned around, and walked back home hand in hand.

Chapter End Notes

Soooooooooooooooooooooooooooooo…
So…
It *is* progress, alright?
Baby steps first.
Or, well, it's actually a lot when you compare her to S1 SW, wouldn't you think?

Anyways, as someone who struggles with violent impulses, it could be said I draw from personal experience a tiny bit, and fr, I would have loved it if people around me, at least some, appreciated my efforts as much as Adora and Catra appreciate SW's…

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: the chance of rejection shouldn't stop you from apologizing
Status: being considered…

Chapter Notes

I particularly like this flashback
Despite the, uh, detail of what you're gonna read, and I won't spoil in this note

ANYWAYS, I hope you like it and understand why this HAD to happen…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The silent nothingness felt so uncomfortable this time…

She didn’t want to think about it.

She didn’t want to reflect on this…

But it was inevitable.

And Beatrix wondered why it felt so difficult to even try this time, if she had once apologized to Castaspella despite expecting her to reject it.

Yes, it had been an accident, but the sorceress was in all her right to hate her for it, yet Shadow Weaver never feared she’d react violently if Castaspella pushed her away and never forgave her.

Perhaps, and only perhaps, it was because she understood the gravity of her actions was of a completely different level. Or maybe, it was because she had developed enough *trust* with the sorceress.

She had felt… vulnerable. Guilty. Immediately regretful. All feelings she would have buried deep inside back in the time she raised the girls.

Ugh, and it had felt so bitter, especially since the connection through the spell only made her feel an absolute void. Something she had rarely felt from the sorceress; only when Micah was nasty at her for being close to Shadow Weaver.

That was the worst part, the realization. And she wanted to get rid of those feelings as soon as possible, but couldn’t. Her somehow desperate attempts to amend her mistake were the only thing she could do to alleviate the bitter feelings eating her from the inside.

And she could recall how gently she had behaved. For a moment, she felt like Light Spinner again, making her wonder, for the first time, how it would have been to raise the girls with that same behaviour.

But the past is the past, she can't change it, and it didn't even matter. Micah only knew her as Light Spinner yet now hated her even more than the girls, didn't he?

This was too much for her…

However, she was almost sure that remembering the event could help her see what exactly she was missing now. Why had she been able to apologize before but not now…

A few gasps followed by absolute silence snapped Shadow Weaver out of her blind rage.

And when she saw what she had done… words left her.

When had the sorceress stepped between her and that annoying acolyte!?

Why had she done so!?

Why didn't she step *away* from her so she'd become ghostly again!?

Now, nasty scratches extended through Castaspella's face and chest.

Scratches caused by Shadow Weaver's hand.

She stared at her claw-like fingers and looked up at the sorceress again, trying to say something, *anything*.

But she spoke first.

—Nobody say a word— she began, talking in general. Then, she turned to address the infuriating acolyte behind her. —You, leave now. Do not, *ever*, talk to her again. Am I clear?— she ordered him. Right after, as the acolyte left, she turned to look at the tutors that happened to be passing by right that moment, one of them also a councilor. —You two: I expect you to handle this matter with utmost tactfulness— she began. Then, she gestured at her face and chest and concluded —*This* is only *my* business. If I hear any rumors raise here in Mystacor, you two will have to answer for that. Am I clear?

As the cuts slowly started to bleed, the tutors nodded and immediately left without saying a word, perhaps out of respect, perhaps out of fear, as it was extremely rare to hear her speak like that.

And then it was Shadow Weaver's turn.

—I didn't mean…

—Don't— Castaspella interrupted her, raising a hand. —Come. We'll go to my room. Now.

As the feeling of guilt took over, accompanied by bitter regret, the woman felt more vulnerable than ever, needing the sorceress to forgive her.

She had never longed for forgiveness with such intensity, especially since she'd usually dismiss that feeling due to her crimes being unforgivable. But now…

—Allow me to hide them so no one sees— she finally managed to say.

However, Castaspella wouldn't let her speak any further as they walked back to her room. Still silent when they walked in, the Head Sorceress stepped in front of her mirror and took a deep breath as she looked at her reflection.

Shadow Weaver simply stood there, far enough to feel ghostly, and perceived nothing but that void through the spell. She couldn't help but remember that Castaspella had felt like that before, and it increased her guilt as it was that silent anger she'd feel towards her brother whenever he aggravated either of them.

—Do you realize what you did?— the sorceress suddenly began. —Did it ever occur to you that acting so violently could end with someone hurt? Don't you remember the many, *many*, times I've told you if you ever hurt someone you'd be immediately dismissed!? Did you think about any of this!?— she went on, reproaching. —What were you thinking, Beatrix!?

But she wasn't thinking. And Castaspella knew that. So when Shadow Weaver tried to speak, she didn't let her and only walked to the bathroom.

However, the guilt and regret were now corroding her from the inside, and it made her increasingly desperate. She wanted those feelings gone, and her instinct was to make the cause of them disappear. So she had to fix what she did.

Shadow Weaver grabbed the sorceress by the arm, pulled her back and had her sit on the bed.

—Allow me.

—Why?

—I did this. Just let me… help.

She saw hesitation at first, but felt relieved when the sorceress finally agreed, and promptly grabbed a towel to clean the cuts.

She began with the shorter scratch on Castaspella's face, right on her cheek under the eye. Afterwards, she cleaned a pair of larger ones under her collarbone, running across her exposed skin over the dress and under the cape. And then, the final one, on the left side of her breast, that went right through her dress.

For a moment, the woman could see surprise on her expression, possibly because she wasn't expecting the tenderness with which she cleansed the blood. It was a gentleness she hadn't had since her time as Light Spinner, and she thought of the times she'd patch up the girls without much care. What if she had been like this?

But her musing was cut short as Castaspella's expression quickly returned to utter seriousness.

—There's a box in my closet. It says "terrarium" and it has parchments of silk from my spiders. Use that to close the cuts— the sorceress ordered, her tone flat.

—Alright— Shadow Weaver agreed, despite wanting to argue it would be better to use healing spells.

Having thoroughly cleaned all the blood, the woman applied the little silky parchments on Castaspella's skin and took a few steps back.

—That will be enough— the Head Sorceress said, standing up to look at herself in the mirror again.

—I… didn't mean to— the woman shyly began. —I wasn't… thinking. I- All I saw was… red.

—You wanted to kill him— she said, her tone still flat.

—I don't know. I just… wanted him to *shut up*— Shadow Weaver admitted. —And I suppose hurting him was… an instinct. That would silence him for good.

—How do I know you won't do it again?

—I won't! I… swear— she immediately replied, hesitating to step closer. —I wouldn't… do it again.

—We don't know that.

—I won't, I swear! Believe me!

—I believe you don't *want* to do it again, but I can hardly trust your reactions— Castaspella clarified, before turning to look at her. —Do you want to know why I stepped between you two?

—I've been wondering that— Shadow Weaver admitted.

—I knew you were blinded by rage. And I guess I was stupid enough to believe I could wake you up in time before you hurt someone— she explained, serious, disappointed perhaps, and the woman couldn't help looking down. —And while it didn't work, at the very least I see you do regret it. If you weren't so dominated by your impulses, you would have stopped.

When she looked up, Castaspella had walked up to her and they were now face to face.

—I… apologize.

—And I'll forgive you as long as you promise to get ahold of yourself— she replied.

Looking down again, the woman whispered —I'll try. But I don't know how.

—Are you willing to listen to me?

—You know I am.

—Then we'll make that happen. If you put in the effort. Understood?

—Absolutely.

—Good.

—I don't know how you could forgive me…

—Because…— she began, but interrupted herself with a sigh. —You've done unforgivable things, but this? It was an accident. This is not like the things you did on purpose.

—I am just surprised. I expected you to send me away— Shadow Weaver admitted.

—If I wanted you gone, I would have dismissed you for doing this. But I rather you learn…

—And how do you know I will? How can you trust I'll keep my promise?

—Because I saw in your expression, and understood from your feelings, that you genuinely regret what happened— Castaspella explained. —I do have my doubts about whether you'd regret it this much had you harmed that acolyte instead, but… I don't care if it's your bias towards me. It's enough.

—I don't have a bias…— the woman retorted, folding her arms.

—Yes, you do, and I've been exploiting it.

—Learnt a few tricks, I see— she mocked her.

—And now I turn them against you, yes— the sorceress replied, smirking. —I got you to apologize. Next, I'll make you say "please"!

—Keep dreaming.

That sorceress was something else.

And perhaps, yes, she did have a bias and that was why she never feared rejection. Or maybe, that bias made her desperate for forgiveness, to the point she didn't care whether the apology was accepted or not. She'd beg for it if necessary.

But a part of her always knew Castaspella would forgive her. Just like a part of her always tells her she's undeserving of forgiveness.

So now, she needed that part to be drowned again by her desire for forgiveness. That would be the only way to banish the fear.

However, it wouldn't guarantee her reaction would be any less violent. It was one thing to be vulnerable and weak in front of Castaspella, but in front of the girls…

She'd never be able to apologize unless she allowed herself to be vulnerable in front of them too…

And that… is quite unlikely to happen.

Chapter End Notes

So, the detail I mentioned: the violent reaction. Hurting Casta.

Look, as someone with that same issue, these accidents can happen, and it's absolutely not the same as being violent/aggressive on purpose.
That's also why I had Casta tell her that this was an accident and could be forgiven.
I have been in situations like that, and haven't been forgiven. I wish people had seen I never meant for those things to happen, that it wasn't a decision but merely a reaction, so I suppose this chapter can be considered wishful thinking.

Well, I hope you liked it, and understood it.
See you next week!

One More Sip

Chapter Summary

Sometimes, strained relationships with people we care about get the worst of us. And for the Head Sorceress, that means drinking her pain away.

Fortunately, Shadow Weaver has learnt to handle this particular issue. Yet she would never guess the little surprise that awaits them the following morning.

» *Something* entered the magical groove. Something that felt like a tiny disruption in the place's magic; as if a small vacuum point had suddenly appeared. Shadow Weaver could feel it gently pulling from her.

Chapter Notes

Eek! Posting this in a rush but well edited, I believe.

I hope you like it cause it's a chapter I particularly put lots of effort in.

And I don't know what else to say...

Anyways, happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A couple of weeks went by. The girls sporadically visited, and *sometimes* returned to the conversation about caring and being honest about what troubles her. Of course, it would usually end with Shadow Weaver dismissing everything.

However, after three months, even Castaspella noticed a bit of a shift in the woman. Just a tiny bit. Enough to tell the girls had had an impact on her, but perhaps not as much as they would have wanted. Yet the sorceress couldn't help but express how proud she was.

But not that night.

Oh, no.

That night, Castaspella arrived at the groove completely out of sorts. The first things Shadow Weaver noticed when she resurfaced, was the way she almost tripped with every step she took, and the bottle she held in her hand.

—Not this again— she muttered, approaching her. Immediately, she wrenched the bottle of sake from her hand and held the sorceress up by the arm. —Enough of this.

—No!— she complained, her pitch raising a bit. —Mean…

—I swear, I will pour this on the ground if you try to take it back— the woman threatened her. —Now, sit down and explain what this is all about.

—Come on… *jus'* one more sip…

—No— Shadow Weaver sentenced, pushing her down. —Stay there— she ordered, before sitting down next to her, leaving the bottle as far as possible from the sorceress. —What happened now?

—Nothing…

—Bullshit…

—Yeah, bullshit happened…— Castaspella uttered.

—Elaborate.

—Why?— the sorceress asked, her voice lower than usual while leaning forward, closer to Shadow Weaver.

It made her… uncomfortable, in a way. Or rather, alarmed.

It was happening again.

Trying to ignore it, she replied —Because you don't get this drunk without reason…

—Aw… So you do care— Castaspella mockingly said, dragging the words and moving even closer to Shadow Weaver's face.

That was enough.

—Stop it— the woman ordered, visibly angry, holding the sorceress by the shoulders to push her back. —You're *not* doing this again. It's unfair.

—*Wah*… Do what?

—*This*! Behaving all flirty and kissing me because you're too drunk to know better! I *refuse* to be your plaything for when you're drunk!— she retorted. —You're *lucky* you won't remember this tomorrow, or you'll be too embarrassed to ever return.

With that, Castaspella sat down, looking disappointed. For a long moment, they were silent; Shadow Weaver looked at her, expecting, while the sorceress only stared at her hands.

—You're so… so… unfair!— she finally said, squinting at the woman with an angry frown, yet still sounding too drunk to be taken seriously. However, her expression changed to a sorrowful pout in an instant, and she uttered —Sorry.

—What a fool…— Shadow Weaver sighed, before turning around to get the bottle, seriously considering to simply throw it away into the woods. However, before she could even touch it, she felt a hug from behind. —Why don't you just sleep it off? You can tell me what happened in the morning.

—No, no, I'll *tel'ya*— Castaspella said, her voice muffled against the woman's back. —Please don't be mad…

—I am not mad— she assured her, letting out a sigh. She waited until the sorceress let go of her and turned around to look at her. —Sit back and go ahead…

—No, no… If I'm so- so *annoy* to you, I'll *jus'* go…

—Of course not— Shadow Weaver stopped her, grabbing her arm again. —You better stay here where I can keep an eye on you.

It didn't take much convincing for the sorceress to stay; she barely hesitated to sit down. Both rested against a large tree trunk and sighed deeply. There was silence again as Castaspella closed her eyes and looked for the words, and strength, to explain herself.

—I was… thinking. It's… been two *yers* now since *mah* brother *disimissed* you… And… and… it'll be *mah* birthday in one- No, two days… And… and I have to- It'll be bitter, *'cause*… *'Cause* he'll be there, and… and what if I- What if he's mad at me!? We're still… in this… in this… silent war. I- What if I… lose him again?

—Everything he has done, and keeps doing, is solely to protect you— Shadow Weaver began. —He's probably not doing it the best way, I'd even say he's doing it the worst way possible, but it's all because of how much he cares for you. You'll never lose him— the woman assured her. —He behaves like a kid sometimes, but he adores you, Cas. He'd never let this quarrel come between you.

—I don't know…— she sighed, resting her head on Shadow Weaver's shoulder. —I'm *jus'*… so afraid…

—Of course you are. You're…— she began, but interrupted herself before saying "too nice". —Caring. You care for him as much as he cares for you. This must be a nightmare for you.

—Yeah…

—Now you see why I don't like caring for others— Shadow Weaver added, smirking.

—Oh, *shush*— the sorceress immediately retorted. —Don't be a *bish* now…

The woman laughed, amused, but still said —You need to stop drinking so much when things with Micah don't go well.

—I'll try— Castaspella groaned, starting to doze off.

Drowsy, she mumbled unintelligible words before finally falling asleep, leaving Shadow Weaver alone with her thoughts.

The woman spent all night thinking, reflecting, and internally struggling.

She had caused this, hadn't she?

It wasn't merely a siblings' dispute. It was, as Castaspella named it, a silent war. And it was her fault.

Shadow Weaver didn't ask Castaspella for her support, that much was true, but it didn't exactly make her any less guilty. She had barely made any efforts to either apologize to Micah and make things right, or push Castaspella away to end all that drama.

Doesn’t it make her responsible for the consequences?

But what could she do now?

Trying to push Castaspella away proved increasingly impossible as time went by, and Micah would never accept an apology, much less after everything that happened since she was dismissed. If there was any chance they could make peace, it was utterly gone since the moment he saw his sister kiss her.

Ugh, *that*.

She didn’t want to think about it, no.

It wasn’t worth it.

It could be considered the root of Castaspella’s troubles with Micah, so she imagined the sorceress regretted doing that.

Yes, she surely did. That must be why she never mentioned it again… or why she changed subjects so quickly after she herself-

Never mind…

None of that mattered anymore. Shadow Weaver dismissed all those thoughts, refusing to revisit that annoying subject.

Who cared!? She didn’t. Of course not.

Why would it matter?

It changed nothing…

A dead woman shouldn’t get her hopes up with foolish things like that.

She was so engrossed in her thoughts that she didn’t notice when the sun came up. It was morning now, and the sorceress remained soundly asleep on her lap. They would have remained that way if it weren’t for a funny little thing that happened.

Something entered the magical groove. Something that felt like a tiny disruption in the place’s magic; as if a small vacuum point had suddenly appeared. Shadow Weaver could feel it gently pulling from her.

Immediately, she was shaken awake from her musing as her sight was drawn by a group of small spiders walking their way.

The woman tensed up, startled, and instinctively grabbed the sorceress. But right after, she recognized Castaspella’s pets and relaxed.

Although strange, it was a relief to know the disruption was just the tiny magic-consuming insects. Nothing to worry about. However, it meant something was wrong, so she’d have to wake up the sorceress.

—Time to rise and shine— Shadow Weaver mockingly said, slightly shaking Castaspella by the shoulders. —You have visits.

—What?— she said, her voice groggy. Her eyes felt too heavy to open yet, and her whole body was still numb. The sorceress groaned as she felt the woman shake her again, and mumbled —Stop, stop… I'm awake.

A yawn briefly interrupted her, and she brushed her eyes a bit before finally opening them. Of course, her spiders forming a little crowd right in front of her were the first thing she saw.

Noticing her eyes suddenly open fully, Shadow Weaver repeated —See? Visits.

—What's going on here!? I-I don't even recall coming here…

—Does this explain it?— the woman asked, gesturing at the ceramic sake bottle beside her. Castaspella's expression immediately changed, and Shadow Weaver couldn't help smirking as she added —And I must say, how you managed to arrive here unscathed still evades me, so don't ask.

—I can't believe I did it again— the sorceress groaned. —Never mind. I should focus on *why my pets are down here*! Why would you all- Oh…

She interrupted herself when she saw a small bundle on the back of one of the largest spiders. One of them died, and they had wrapped it as they would always do. But instead of waiting for Castaspella to return, they went to look for her.

—What is it?

—Remember how they need my help to bury their fellows when they die?

—Yes. But that doesn't explain why they are here or how they managed to come all the way from Mystacor— Shadow Weaver replied, almost reproaching.

—I don't know. They are quite intelligent but… Pe-perhaps they came here because they couldn't find me last night— she guessed. Then, it looked like an idea occurred to her and, with a shy expression, she asked Shadow Weaver —Would you mind if they bury the spider here?

—What?

—They already came all the way here, so just… please?

—I don't think I'd like that— the woman said, squinting.

—They are magical creatures too! It's a good resting place…

—Fine— she sighed, closing her eyes.

—Thank you!

—You do realize you behave like a child when it comes to your spiders, don't you?

As the sorceress happily turned to open a hole in the soil next to the tree they had been leaning on, she replied —Oh, come on! What do you mean by that?

—You should have seen your face just now. Your eyes shone!

—Really?— Castaspella giggled. —Funny that you notice…

—From this distance? I should be blind not to notice— the woman retorted, squinting at her. —Don't give it any more meaning.

—Right, of course— she laughed. —Now, I… should go have breakfast and take my babies back— she sentenced. However, before standing up, she hesitated and asked —But… would you tie my hair first?

—Alright— the woman sighed. —I almost thought you would forget…

As she handled the sorceress' hair, Shadow Weaver couldn't help reflecting. She still found it difficult to believe how much Castaspella loved those things.

It was endearing, and to be expected from her, yes, but weird all the same.

However, in a way, it made her feel that she was like those spiders. Something no one would ever like, except for this one odd sorceress…

Chapter End Notes

Hehe, I love those tiny babies. I wish I could have terrariums with spiders too.

Erm, well. That was it for today. I hope you liked it!
See u next week and thank u for reading! <3

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: even the littlest of creatures deserves compassion
Status: Loading…

Chapter Notes

I must admit, I'm unsure of today's lesson… I don't know if the flashback properly represents it, and I don't know if SW actually got the message from it.

AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAANYWAYS, u can judge after reading.

Ofc, before I forget: This song from my playlist is basically this chapter lol

Be my guests…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When the woman returned to the darkness of Etheria's core, she couldn't stop thinking about the spiders.

Those little insects had, somehow, left their terrarium, made their way out of the floating island and down to the surface, and then found the magical groove, all while carrying the body of a dead spider wrapped in their web.

Now *that* sounds impossible just thinking about it. Had they spent the whole night walking all the way down there? Had they used some kind of magic to make their trip not only possible, but also safer for little creatures like them?

Beatrix even wondered whether Castaspella had taught them to do as much. It wouldn't surprise her… She could imagine the sorceress patiently teaching them to channel the magic they consume. That is, supposing those creatures don't have innate powers they can instinctively use.

But who knows?

It was irrelevant, wasn't it?

Shadow Weaver came to the conclusion it was an absolute waste of time to dwell on that.

However, this reminded her of the first time she saw a spider out of its terrarium.

She had to admit, that night she questioned Castaspella's sanity…

The night was rainy. It was a strange sight in Mystacor, but it would occasionally happen. And yet, the light of the moons found its way through the clouds.

Shadow Weaver stared at the window while lost in thought, sitting comfortably on the bed while keeping a few illusions on Castaspella so she could sleep. The night was considerably cold, but the woman could barely feel it; she only knew because she could see the sorceress shiver occasionally.

But then something caught her eye.

A medium-sized spider was crawling over the bed, not exactly slowly, and headed directly for Castaspella.

What was it doing outside!?

How did it leave its terrarium!?

—Cas, wake up— Shadow Weaver ordered, removing the illusions and shaking the sorceress not very gently. —Wake up, now!

—What's going on?— Castaspella asked, her voice like a groan as she slowly opened her eyes.

—How *exactly* did your pet escape the terrariums!?

—Oh, wait… wait— she uttered, struggling to sit up. —Something… must have happened— she explained, interrupted by a yawn. As soon as she was up, she extended her hand towards the spider, and it crawled onto her palm. —What is it, little one?— she asked with a tired voice.

—You call that "little"?

—Shut up— she dismissed her, gesturing with her free hand. The spider lifted its front legs and shook them frantically, which seemed to be enough for Castaspella to understand. —Alright, I'll go— she told it, groaning a bit as she moved to get up.

—Are you serious, Cas?

—Stop being such a jerk…

The sorceress yawned again as she approached the terrariums, carefully carrying the spider. She checked the three of them before opening the one hovering closer to her desk. Then, she left the spider inside and began drawing a spell, which confused Shadow Weaver even more.

—What *are* you doing?

—I'm digging a small hole— she began, casting the spell that carefully removed some soil to open a deep gap. —See that white thing?— she then asked, gesturing at a bundle held by the biggest of her pets. —It's a spider wrapped with a thick web. It died and, well, they were taught to bury their fellow, so I always help them with the hole because they never managed to do it on their own.

—Who taught them?

—My… late tutor. I inherited them from her— she hesitantly explained.

—Is that so?— Shadow Weaver uttered, rhetorically.

—I don't know how she did it, but… well, she was a wonderful teacher. No wonder she could tutor *me*. If she could teach spiders, she could teach anyone…

Castaspella kept staring at the terrariums as she spoke, her hands resting on the desk, supporting her. It was evident the subject affected her.

—You say that as if it were impossible to teach you— the woman pointed out, trying to change her focus.

—It was— the sorceress immediately replied. —I couldn't make any progress, at all. I had several tutors. They gave up— she continued, sighing. —But she didn't. She tutored me, and took care of me like… a mother. And these terrariums are the only thing I have left from her.

—What…

"Happened to her?", she was about to ask, but got interrupted by Castaspella's sudden movement.

—I don't want to talk about this. I should go back to sleep.

—Right— Shadow Weaver sighed, giving up. —I'll set up the illusions again.

—Thank you.

And that was it.

The sorceress refused to say another word and forced herself to sleep.

Everyone has their secrets, the woman knew it well. And she had hers too. So she didn't hesitate to let go of the subject and bury her curiosity.

It didn't matter to her.

It shouldn't.

But, in fact, the question remained for a long time, sporadically returning to the front of her mind.

Until that day, when the sorceress told her what happened with Zosia.

So unexpected.

But she wasn't exactly the best person to judge, was she?

After all, opposite to her, Castaspella's doing was only merciful.

However, she'd probably say only Shadow Weaver would see it that way… and while she wouldn't be wrong about that, wouldn't that be her being too hard on herself *again*!?

Maybe… but this was all hypothetical, of course.

Once more, there was no point in dwelling on such matters…

Except that she wanted to keep thinking about this!

Just *how* did Castaspella's mind work!?

Or should she be wondering how her *heart* works?

Whatever. Just what, be it mind, heart, or spirit, made the sorceress behave the way she did?

How could she have hope in others, yet be hopeless herself?

How could she have *faith* in others but be so insecure at the same time?

And what was probably more important: how could she take such good care of others, how could she care so much for others in general, but not herself?

It just drove her crazy. It confused Beatrix. Now she wanted to ask her about all of this.

Perhaps she could use her questions when winning at deck fights? She would be in all her right to ask whatever and Castaspella would have to reply honestly… but for some reason, she felt hesitant.

She wanted to know, but remembering the sorceress' expression, and the feeling she got through the spell, made her doubt… Their games were just for fun, for leisure, and asking something like that would be both inappropriate and a treacherous move. Something Castaspella didn't deserve.

Perhaps they could make another deal, like the last time, exchanging information of equal value. But what could she tell the sorceress? She would surely ask Shadow Weaver the same thing she wanted to know, but the woman didn't have the first idea what makes her behave the way she does…

In any case, Castaspella probably knew that better than her, and if she told her, Shadow Weaver would deny it.

Of course she would…

Chapter End Notes

See?

Well, perhaps u *do* find it to be what the lesson says.

I frankly don't know myself…

Perhaps if one ties it to the phrase from the previous chapter, about SW feeling like one of the spiders, and like Casta sees her the way she does for the same reason she loves her spiders so much…
But never mind...

Also Also! Important message!!
To begin with, the time is near!! The oh-so-awaited apology is nigh! And I hope u find it in-character, convincing, and organic enough <("^-^)

Lastly, guess who has the title for the next part!? We are nearing the end, I have already written up to chapter 60, and I think this will end by chapter 70, perhaps. That's the current calculation… (Actually, yeah, ends by Chapter ~~70~~80, I already have all the notes for the last 10 chapters. So,

~~June 28th~~September 6th, will be the last update. -*edited*-)
So the other night I was wondering: What shall I title the next part!? Like, I had never thought about that!! And I said, "Let's take another Persona 5 song title!". The second song I saw turned out to be the perfect title: *Life Will Change*
Hehe, so now you know what the last part of Path 1 will be called!
~~Oh goddess, I can't believe this is so close to the end…~~

In any case, thank you for reading!!!

Apologies

Chapter Summary

After years of friction in their interpersonal relationships, the time has come to soothe it. The long-awaited apologies are ready to be said, but will they be well received? Will they be *worth the effort*.

It is said that, with time, everything is possible. So perhaps, and only perhaps, good things shall come out of this...

»Soon, it was time for the gifts, and everyone's attention got caught by Micah and Catra's exchange. Just a pair of weeks before, the King had organized a reunion with the girls, with help from Glimmer, of course, and very sincerely apologized to them for the way he had antagonized them. Having expressed his regret and promised never to dismiss their feelings again, regardless of his disagreement, their relationship improved significantly.

Chapter Notes

You guuuuuuuuuuuys!! It's time!! Finally!! I've been so excited to post this chapter!
TT^TT I can't believe it's been so long, ngl, but it was all necessary to bring us to this point, I swear.

So, now, I hope you enjoy it, and that you find the apology organic enough and in-character ofc.

Happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A couple of months went by, and the gift exchange was once again upon them. This year, it was Princess Perfuma's turn to host, and a large bonfire was prepared for everyone to gather around. The night was quite warm, although a chilly breeze would occasionally blow.

Soon, it was time for the gifts, and everyone's attention got caught by Micah and Catra's exchange. Just a pair of weeks before, the King had organized a reunion with the girls, with help from Glimmer, of course, and very sincerely apologized to them for the way he had antagonized them. Having expressed his regret and promised never to dismiss their feelings again, regardless of his disagreement, their relationship improved significantly.

As their discussions had been quite loud, it surprised everyone to see them chatting amicably after having exchanged thoughtful gifts like everyone else.

—I'm so glad— Castaspella told Adora, as they both observed them, sitting on a tree trunk in front of the bonfire. —I knew they could come to an agreement.

—Yeah. Catra didn't have anything against him. It was just… difficult to deal with his attitude— Adora replied. —She has this… inner struggle. We often speak about that with Perfuma and Scorpia. And her discussions with the King made it more complicated for her. She already felt guilty for holding onto the hope that Shadow Weaver will… you know, grow a heart. So his… I don't know what to call it… His constant *disapproval* made her feel like that hope and longing for Shadow Weaver's care was a crime or something.

—I suppose he simply can't conceive the idea of someone caring for her and wanting to be cared for in return— the sorceress reflected, looking down. —But if at least they agree to disagree, that's a huge step.

—It really is— Adora agreed. —Oh, there she comes.

—Hey, guess what!— Catra exclaimed. —I'll be training with King Micah!

—Oh, that's wonderful!

—That's great, Love!

The three of them sat to keep chatting, clearly excited by the news, and caught up on each other's lives. The sorceress asked them about Finn, their missions on other planets, and those on Etheria, aimed at handling the aftermath of the war that still affected many towns and villages. On the other hand, Adora and Catra asked Castaspella about Shadow Weaver's pupils, Delwyn's help in Mystacor, and the collaboration with other kingdoms.

Later into the night, before the party ended, Princess Entrapta went to find the girls to discuss some secret project they had been working on, and they farewelled, leaving the sorceress alone with her thoughts.

Castaspella looked into the Whispering Woods and sighed. Since her brother apologized, she had been thinking about insisting to Shadow Weaver it was a good time for her apology, but she had promised not to press the matter so, once again, she discarded the thought.

She would do it when she was ready.

The time came soon, however, and barely a month later, the woman herself told the sorceress she felt ready now.

—But?

—But what?

—I sense a "but" there— Castaspella honestly said. —I feel your hesitation and anger. What's the problem?

—You don't have to be gentle with me. It's nothing— Shadow Weaver retorted. —A part of me just won't… won't accept it yet.

—You still have doubts…

—But I can't keep delaying it. It's eating me from the inside. It's *maddening*!— the woman admitted, grabbing her head with both hands, seething.

—You're angry at yourself because of that?

—I'm angry at myself because I *want* to apologize!

—I…— the sorceress hesitantly began, but interrupted herself. She was so confused. —Why is that?

—I did what I thought was right. I shouldn't have regrets!

—But, Bea, it's normal— Castaspella assured her, stepping closer. —We all do what we think we have to do. No one would willingly do something they don't want to do.

—I don't think you understand— the woman uttered. —And don't take it the wrong way. It's just a fact. You *can't know* what it was like to be a part of the Horde— she explained. —I now think that… I always said I wanted to get rid of Catra because… she was *my weakness*, and I couldn't afford that at a place like the Horde, where you have to be absolutely strong or resign to be mediocre and disposable.

—I… may not have the experience *per se*, but besides feeling what you're feeling right now, I've also spoken with both the girls and Hordak about this— Castaspella replied. —I won't pretend to know what it was like, but I understand what you mean. They all went through the same. They all had to suppress their feelings, identify and try to discard their weaknesses, do whatever was necessary to gather strength, and each had a different experience— she elaborated. —I believe, you all had this idea that strength was necessary to survive, that it was a must worth giving everything for… and it's difficult to unlearn that.

—Much as I dislike you comparing me to Hordak, I can't deny you might be right— Shadow Weaver admitted, looking away. Right after, she squinted at Castaspella and threatened —But if you tell anyone I said that, I will deny it and call you crazy, understand?

The sorceress let out a loud laugh and immediately covered her mouth to try and hold it back. But she couldn't help doubling over with laughter still.

—Sorry, sorry. I get it— she finally managed to say. —I won't tell a soul.

—You better.

—Then… When do you want to speak with Catra?

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and slowly sighed.

—Tell her to come in a week or so…

With a small smile, the sorceress nodded —I will.

Two weeks later, having just returned from a long mission, the girls showed up in the magical groove, curious. It was the first time Shadow Weaver *requested* their presence, or rather Catra's, and they didn't know how to feel about it.

—I wasn't expecting you both to come.

—I…— Catra began, nervously rubbing her arm. She then cleared her throat and said —Whatever you have to tell me, you can say it in front of her.

—I suppose, yes— she admitted. —Would rather not make a fool of myself unnecessarily in front of anyone else, but it's clear I don't have a choice— she continued, hands joined behind her back as she faced away from them. —I should have known you wouldn't dare come alone— she concluded.

—I wonder why…— Catra uttered, rolling her eyes, arms crossed in front of her chest.

—Yes, yes. Of course— Shadow Weaver let out, notoriously dismissive. —But you have nothing to worry about. My only intention is to give you what you have been waiting for…

What she had been waiting for?

Catra tensed up, confused, and felt her heart accelerate. She had no idea what the woman meant, and anticipation made her hold her breath.

However, she pushed herself to stammer —I-I doubt you know what that is.

She couldn't possibly know, could she?

—I expect it to be. It was *not* easy to decide to do this— Shadow Weaver replied, finally turning to look at her, although squinting. —And you have the sorceress to thank for this…— she added. Ah, but she kept digressing. She brushed her face with both hands and sighed. —I… want to apologize. For everything— she slowly began. —For how I raised you, for what I taught you, for *how* I taught you. And for… how I made you… feel…

—Wha-what?

—I treated you the way I thought I had to treat you, the way I thought I would have been treated in your place, the way I thought would make you stronger— she continued. —I was sure it was *necessary*. And I thought it would… prepare you for the world.

—You…

—I… am sorry— Shadow Weaver sighed, looking down. —You don't have to forgive me now or ever. I don't think the things I did are forgivable. But… I know how I felt when I… got the apology I never thought I would have; the impact it had on me. So now… I'm convinced you deserve it too— she concluded, with notorious effort.

—I…

Catra looked from the dejected woman to Adora, who was just as shocked as her. Speechless, she stared at her as if she could tell her what to say, then looked back at Shadow Weaver.

It couldn't be true. She couldn't believe what had just happened, and the tension in her body only worsened, urging her to run away.

With a final, panicked look at Adora, the girl turned and fled.

—Ca-Catra! Wait!— she cried out, but it was useless. She had to go after her, but couldn't bring herself to leave without saying —Tha-thank you for… the effort.

On the brink of tears, she ran after Catra, knowing the spirit of the woman would sink under the surface as soon as she left the groove, and feeling extremely conflicted.

If she was like that, she couldn't imagine the turmoil that must have been boiling inside Catra's chest. She couldn't leave her alone now of all times.

After a while, Adora found her at the edge of the Woods, sitting against a tree, holding her head, and muttering —Why? Why now? How?

—Catra…

As Adora went to sit next to her, she hesitantly placed a hand on the girl's shoulder. It startled Catra, who looked up at her with tears falling down her cheeks, her expression still panicked.

—What was that!? Did-did I imagine it!?

—No, no. It was…

—It can't be real!

—It was, Love… It was.

—I-I need to go home…

Adora hugged her, staring at the moons high in the sky, and took a deep breath.

—Then let's go— she finally said, helping Catra up. —I'll make dinner, alright?

However, it was well past midnight and the girl couldn't sleep.

Adora woke up as she heard crying, but it wasn't Finn as she thought. Instead, she found Catra sobbing faintly next to her, sitting curled up in a ball, hugging her legs, and felt her heart shrink a bit. She pushed herself up and hugged Catra carefully, silently, not knowing what to say.

—It was all I ever wanted…— the girl sobbed. —But… I feel like I just dreamt it…

—You didn't dream it— she reassured her. Adora gently stroked her hair and kept hugging her for a good while, until it occurred to her —Why don't we talk about this with Perfuma and Scorpia tomorrow?

—Maybe— she replied, sniffling. —I don't think they will believe it either…

—Hey, we were both there. It happened, it really happened— Adora reassured her once again.

—I… Yeah— she uttered, interrupted by a sniffle. —Let's talk with them tomorrow— she finally accepted.

—Alright. But you need to sleep first.

—I'll try…

—Shadow Weaver did what!?

Scorpia's expression of disbelief was unseen before. Never had the girls seen her so shocked.

Just as expected.

On the other hand, Perfuma let out a wide grin as she exclaimed —That's wonderful!

—That's insane!— Scorpia shouted. —But, like, a good kind of insane. You know… sounds unbelievable, impossible, but it did happen!— she nervously added.

—I know! I-I didn't know what to do! I just… ran away!

—And didn't say anything!?— Perfuma asked, disgruntled.

—What could I say!?

—Well, you don't have to forgive her, but, speak your mind? Tell her what it made you feel?

—I-I don't know what I'm feeling! I'm so confused…— Catra stammered.

—How not!? We're talking about Shadow Weaver *apologizing*!— Scorpia agreed. —It's like… I don't know… the most impossible thing you can imagine! Oh, what would I have given to be there!

—Catra, I just think you should say something— Perfuma insisted. —If anything, ask her why she's apologizing. What made her change her mind— she suggested.

—She… said it… So-something about receiving an apology she thought she'd never get— the girl stammered. Rubbing her arm and looking away, she explained —She said even though what she did is unforgivable, she knew I deserved the apology because of how it made her feel… I-I don't know what she was talking about, but she… was right. About the feeling…

Tentatively, Perfuma placed one of her hands on top of Catra's and nodded reassuringly when she looked up.

—You do deserve it, Wildcat. She's right about that too— Scorpia sentenced, smiling fondly.

—I don't know what to do now…

—Look. You don't *have to* do anything— Perfuma began, changing her mind. —Yes, I do think you should say something, but don't feel pressed to do so. If you have nothing to tell her, then better don't force it. For now, just… process it. It was shocking, obviously, so it's okay if you need some time to really accept it happened.

—I suppose— Catra sighed. —Thanks, guys.

Later that night, the Best Friends Squad gathered to have dinner together, and the girls once again left Finn to Micah and Melog's care. They hadn't eaten together like that in a while, and the girls wanted to tell them about Shadow Weaver's apology the previous night.

However, just a few hours before, the four of them had to intercept King Micah on his way to the magical groove once more, and the conversation was mostly taken over by that.

—Remind me: What did he say?— Glimmer asked.

—He and your aunt argued again— Bow began. —Your aunt told him that Shadow Weaver apologized to Catra and, well, you know… your father doesn't believe that's progress.

—And what does he think it is?— Adora asked, confused.

—He's convinced it's all a setup to deceive Auntie— the Queen sighed, pressing her temples.

—So that's why he wanted to ask Shadow Weaver what she wants from Castaspella— Catra reflected.

—Exactly. He thinks- I-I don't know what he thinks at this point!— Glimmer grunted. —Why, after all these years, would Shadow Weaver be trying to, how did he put it? "Ensnare Casta in her trap"!?

—He *really* used those words?— Catra asked, brow raised in absolute disbelief.

—He did!

—Wow— she sighed. —He believes it… He really does— she reflected.

—At least we stopped him again— Bow said. —I imagine your aunt would get furious at him if he ever finds the groove.

—Ugh, I should have made him promise not to look for it again— Catra groaned.

—Maybe we can speak about this tomorrow at the Guild Dance?— Adora suggested.

—I don't know… I rather avoid conflict now…

—Maybe *we* can talk to him instead?— Bow suggested, looking at Glimmer.

—That could be— Adora agreed.

—Yeah, you do that. I… think I'll talk with your aunt, Sparkles— Catra said. —I still don't know what to think about the apology and… I think- No, well, Shadow Weaver said she was to thank for that, so… Yeah.

—Sounds like a good idea, Love— Adora gently assured her.

Catra let out a small smile and held her hand. She still felt a storm of emotions inside, but talking with her friends little by little eased her.

Chapter End Notes

Sooooo!?!?!?!? What do you think!?!?!?

Ofc this doesn't mean SW won't fuck up again, expect it soon lol

So, uh, what do you think about Catra's reaction? I'm pretty sure no other reaction would fit this scenario. Like, I suppose I would react the same, that is, if I don't simply faint heh.
Oh, but we know that won't happen. This is fiction after all...

Anyways!!! See you next week!! Thank you for reading! <3

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Respect, plain and simple
Status: *Fine! Whatever*...

Chapter Notes

Well, guess what?
The project I'm working for is getting serious, and I basically have no time to do shit this week. Monday I couldn't write a word because I had to label 200 cases at least, which took around 8hrs or so... Yeah, that's what I do for work. But also, I spent an hour doing house-chores. That was my freer day, and I finished almost at midnight!
Imagine now that classes have started; Tuesday I had the first class, so even less time to work and all… A pain. But, as work is mandatory, I can only sacrifice writing time or sleep… Guess which one wins!? lol

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this chapter which, fortunately, I had already written long ago…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Respect.

Had she actually managed to be as respectful as the sorceress insisted people should be?

Ugh… apologizing had been far harder than expected, and having to remain respectful, avoid any manner of insult or mockery… an absolute nightmare.

It felt… weird. Ridiculous. Hypocritical even, seeing how she had always been quite dismissive of Catra's prowess.

Taking it all back now… the girl probably thought it was a joke.

But who knows what she thought? She didn't say a word!

That was, in fact, quite frustrating. But she managed to redirect her wrath, at the very least, keeping it all inside until the girls left.

And that had been another nuisance. According to Castaspella, that was a sign of strength, but then, why did it feel like absolute powerlessness?

Thinking about this, she could even hear the sorceress lecturing her again about respect and how everyone, even her, deserved a minimum of respect.

She could still remember the first time they discussed it, even before the summoning spell got attached to Castaspella. It had been quite amusing to be defended by her like that.

And all because the sorceress believed that the acolyte's disrespectful behavior was a severe affront or something…

—The problem with these, is that they contradict each other— Castaspella explained, opening a book and a scroll on a desk.

The Head Sorceress had requested Shadow Weaver's help with a few issues she encountered upon reading another of the investigations she did as Light Spinner, so both went to the library to sort it out.

Leaning over the table to take a closer look, Shadow Weaver squinted and ordered —Turn the page.

—What?

—Pass to the next page. I can't do it myself— the woman pointed out.

—Oh, right…

Little by little, the sorceress showed her every statement that her investigation differed with, and Shadow Weaver calmly explained each time whether she was missing a variable that changed the circumstances, or if her research simply proved the information in the book was wrong.

—This is a very old tome, it's only natural that newer material contradicts parts of it. There are *some* decent researchers on this island— the woman nonchalantly said.

—Are you really insulting the skills of my people again!?

—I am simply stating a fact…— she replied, before getting interrupted by an acolyte who casually walked through her. —Charming— she seethed, frowning.

The woman didn't care much and intended to return to their business, it wasn't worth her time. But the Head Sorceress had a different idea. When Shadow Weaver looked back at her, Castaspella was glaring at the acolyte, who had stopped to get a book from the nearest shelf.

—Excuse me— she called, her tone severe. The acolyte visibly tensed up before turning around to see if she was calling him. —Yes, you, Acolyte. Are you aware of what you just did?— she asked, serious and stern. —Don't you think it is a bit disrespectful to walk through someone like that?

—But…

—No buts! Regardless of who she is, whether she's dead or alive, I expect you to exercise proper respect. It is the *bare minimum*. Am I clear?— she reproached him. —Just the smallest degree of regard, at the very least!

—Ye-yes, Head Sorceress— he stammered. —E-excuse me— he uttered, bowing slightly before retiring deeper into the library.

After he left, a silence settled for a long moment until Castaspella let out a sigh.

Shadow Weaver was in utter shock. What had just happened!?

—Why would you do something like that?— she suddenly asked, calling the sorceress' attention.

—What do you mean?

—Antagonizing your own people and defending me for something so inconsequential as walking through me?

—It doesn't matter how relevant it is— Castaspella replied. —As I said, it's basic respect, regardless of who you are. I won't tolerate anyone being so disrespectful out of spite.

—It's still foolish in my opinion…

—Probably because you would do the same— the sorceress uttered, folding her arms.

—You misunderstand— Shadow Weaver quickly replied. —I just consider such insignificant acts to be unworthy of any attention. Reproaching him only gives it more gravity than necessary, wouldn't you say?

—I do consider it to be a severe matter.

—You shouldn't.

—So you'd rather I let everyone treat you like garbage?

—You can't police everyone's behavior— she replied, dismissively.

—I don't try to- Ugh! I just think that such treatment is unfair, and can't simply allow my people to act like that— Castaspella explained. —Not in my presence. So I will *always* point out disrespectful behavior, be it towards you or anyone else.

—Suit yourself…

Well… She still had no idea whether she had been respectful or not.

Her concept of respect seemed to differ from that of the sorceress. So perhaps she had been respectful? It was difficult to know when she was still so overwhelmed by the feeling of powerlessness left in her.

However, why was she so focused on this now? What did it matter if she was respectful or not? It was done, if she was disrespectful, what then?

Would she have to apologize again!?

Of course not. No way.

If the girls took offense, then there was truly nothing she could do about it.

She had literally pushed herself through the most tortuous feelings to manage that apology. She couldn't do it again, much less after how frustrating it felt.

So she just dropped the matter.

Whether she was respectful or not, it was inconsequential now.

Chapter End Notes

And that would be all for now! What do you think?? hehe

I believe everyone agonizes a little when apologizing, especially when one has to humble oneself, cause, u know, hurt pride and all. So someone as proud as SW would really have to *push herself through the most tortuous feelings*, as I put it there.
But that's my opinion <("^_^) Based on irl experience, but still too subjective...

Anyways! Thanks for reading, and see you next week!!

Unloving Woman - Part 1

Chapter Summary

After a conversation with the Head Sorceress, Catra finally feels ready to give Shadow Weaver an answer. But before that, Castaspella will pay her a much-needed visit.

»—Will it be like this every year?
»—Tired of your own party?
»—What? No, no. I'm tired of that woman, the theatre manager from the company we have always hired. Why did the old manager retire? This is- ugh! I can't keep dealing with her! And last year was terrible!
»—I see. Come here, you need to relax before all this stress fries your small brain.
»—Ha, ha. Very funny…
»—I mean it— she insisted, before pressing her shoulder blades with her thumbs. Castaspella immediately let out a wail, and Shadow Weaver smirked, mocking her —You're getting old…
»—Well, *some of us* are still alive.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to another week of this ^_^

Today I've got you a surprise!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Adora and Catra arrived at Mystacor, the Guild Dance was already in full swing. They passed by Double Trouble's company performing outside, and stayed a while to watch before Catra left to find Castaspella. She didn't want to waste any more time, so she quickly made her way through the crowd inside until she spotted the Head Sorceress.

But she seemed to be… in a tight situation.

Catra didn't need to be connected to her through any spell to realize Castaspella's current conversation with the theatre manager was making the sorceress uncomfortable, so she didn't doubt a second and approached them.

—Excuse me for being blunt, but shouldn't you be working right now?— Castaspella asked the manager, folding her arms.

—Oh, no, no. They know what to do, I have time for a friendly chat— she replied, keeping eye contact and completely ignoring the sorceress's attempt to end the conversation.

And that was when Catra decided to intervene.

—Good afternoon, Head Sorceress. Can I speak with you for a moment?

—Oh, of course! Excuse me— she immediately replied, as soon as the theatre manager opened her mouth.

—But…

—Sorry, it's really important— Catra insisted, promptly walking away with Castaspella.

—Thank you *so* much— she sighed. —She's so… persistent.

—You mean she's annoying.

—Fine, I suppose I find her quite annoying— she admitted. —It's been, what? Three years? She won't let me be, especially since Spin isn't here.

—You should be clearer, I guess. Assertive— Catra suggested.

—I should try… something like, you know, what Spin would tell her to get rid of her— the sorceress laughed.

—Perhaps a notch less assertive— the girl replied, laughing too.

—Oh well… Thank you for the help, but I suppose you did have something to speak with me about, right?

Looking away, Catra nodded —Yeah. It's about… well… Shadow Weaver… apologized to me the other day…

The sorceress halted abruptly and stared at her in shock.

—Oh, right! Princess Perfuma told me she did!— she exclaimed. She then placed a hand on her chest and sighed —Trust me, it was heartfelt. That was the odd feeling I got from her the other day. Oh, my! I still can't believe it! That's perfect!

—I don't know if I'd call it that, but… yeah, it was… good— the girl let out, smiling faintly. —But I- I just- I ran away— she admitted, closing her eyes.

Castaspella carefully placed a hand on Catra's shoulder and gave her a gentle look. She understood perfectly what she was feeling, and it was exactly what she was expecting.

—It's alright. You didn't have to give her an answer right there… And I'm sure she knows this is something you need to process before you can do so.

—But… what if that made her regret apologizing!?

—It didn't. It seems to have frustrated her a bit, but she doesn't regret it— Castaspella assured her. —The feelings I told you I got the other day are… tumultuous, to say the least. There's some rage, yes, there's that frustration I mentioned, and there's also a deep sadness, great concern. If anything, I'd say she's worried she had the opposite effect of what she intended.

—The… opposite effect?

—That she hurt you again— Castaspella clarified, looking away.

—What!? No, no! It- O-of course she didn't!

—Well, I'm sure that's a good starting point— the sorceress suggested, smiling softly. —Go to her when you're ready, and be honest about what you're feeling. That's all you both need.

—I'll… try. And… I should- I should also tell her about Finn— she reflected. —It's been so long, and I never dared…

The sorceress giggled and replied —I'm quite sure she'll understand your reasons.

—What if she gets angry at me for that?

—I don't think so. She'll probably, you know, be cocky about it.

—That would be very in character for her, yes— Catra agreed, smiling a bit. —I'm just a bit scared.

—And that's completely understandable.

—But I will. I- Yeah, I will— the girl sentenced, resolute.

—I am so glad to hear that…

—Thank you, Head Sorceress.

—It was no problem, Catra. Good luck. And enjoy the rest of the party!

For the remainder of the afternoon and until nightfall, Castaspella tried to enjoy the Dance as much as she could, now avoiding the theatre manager with help from Delwyn and Glimmer. But as soon as she could, she left Mystacor, immediately aiming for the magical groove.

She arrived groaning —Will it be like this every year?

—Tired of your own party?— Shadow Weaver mocked her, right as she appeared.

—What? No, no. I'm tired of that woman, the theatre manager from the company we have always hired— she clarified. —Why did the old manager retire? This is- ugh! I can't keep dealing with her! And last year was terrible!

—I see— she replied. Approaching, she told her —Come here, you need to relax before all this stress fries your small brain.

As the woman held Castaspella by the shoulders from behind, the sorceress retorted —Ha, ha. Very funny…

—I mean it— she insisted, before pressing her shoulder blades with her thumbs. Castaspella immediately let out a wail, and Shadow Weaver smirked, mocking her —You're getting old…

—Well, *some of us* are still alive— she grunted.

The woman only laughed and continued to massage the sorceress, which felt both relaxing and painful for her. But it was evident she needed it.

After a while, however, Shadow Weaver had an idea, something she wasn't sure whether it would offend the sorceress, yet she decided to propose it regardless.

Teasing the rim of Castaspella's dress under her cape, she asked —What about something *more* relaxing?

—What… are you doing?

—You seemed to like it last time…— she insisted, smirking.

A part of her was internally screaming in rage, but another part was hoping the sorceress would accept, so she told herself it was nothing but lust, and tried not to give it much thought besides that.

—This is not a great moment to tease me, nor is it an appropriate subject— Castaspella uttered, her face reddened.

Amused, Shadow Weaver whispered in her ear —It's not a tease, it's an *offer*.

An offer…

Castaspella tensed up for a moment, quickly relaxing again, and closed her eyes as she sighed.

Perhaps, only perhaps, it was a good idea. As she gave in, she couldn't help thinking that, this way, she could *pretend* this unloving woman… loved her.

The next morning, the sun was barely up and shining through the leaves of the trees above them. Covered by nothing but a blanket, Castaspella was sleeping soundly, hugging shadow Weaver by the waist. Meanwhile, the woman reflected silently, recalling that last time, before she was dismissed.

But then, a voice ringing through the forest shook her out of her thoughts.

—Auntie, are you here!?— the Queen called out, arriving at the groove that moment. But as soon as she saw them, she halted and turned around, saying —I… can come back later…

However, by then Castaspella had been awakened, and all traces of sleep vanished as soon as she realized what had happened.

—Just give me a moment!— she nervously requested, fetching her clothes. —I just need a minute!

Glimmer brushed her face with both hands several times, red with embarrassment, but not as much as her aunt, whom she could hear arguing with Shadow Weaver about how she should have wakened her up earlier.

Soon, Castaspella joined the Queen, tidying up her cape over her shoulders. Glimmer stared for a moment at her aunt as she noticed the bun, and let out a soft smile at the gesture.

It was a genuine gesture this time. Nothing like the time that woman had put a rose behind her ear; that had been a fake "nice" gesture to earn her trust. Hadn't it?

But this? It was evident she cherished the detail of tying her hair up as much as Castaspella did.

Yet the Queen was shaken from her reflections when her aunt said —Alright. Shall we go?

And so, they both teleported back to Mystacor. They appeared at the entrance of the island and, as they walked, Glimmer hesitated for a moment before speaking up.

—So… Are you two together as a couple now?

—Absolutely not.

—Then why were you…

—We're both adults- wait, no, scratch that. She's dead, *I* am an adult— Castaspella interrupted, before Glimmer could finish her question. —These things can happen.

—Not with Shadow Weaver— the Queen uttered, looking away with an expression of disbelief.

—Especially with her. I can't imagine someone else actually falling for her to have such a relationship — the sorceress replied, keeping her sight on the way ahead as they continued walking.

Opening her eyes widely in shock, Glimmer asked —So you *love* her!?

—I didn't say that!— she immediately stated, her steps noticeably firmer as she tensed up.

—You said someone *else*!— she pointed out, insistent.

She had, in fact, said that. Yes. But… she simply didn't want to continue this conversation.

—Don't confuse lust with love, Glimmer— she concluded, stalking away.

The Queen was itching to tell someone. She needed to speak about it and, in the end, she caught Bow and told him privately. Knowing Catra and Adora would later go to speak with Shadow Weaver, she preferred not to tell them just yet.

—Isn't it wild!?— she asked him, frantic.

—I don't know. I agree with your aunt. It's not necessarily love, Glim— he remarked.

—But we *know* there's something going on!

—No. What we know is that they have a close relationship— he reminded her. —Whether they love each other or not is *our* speculation…

—But…

—Listen, Love. I think you're a bit excited— he told her, holding Glimmer by the shoulders. —If Casta says it was just lust, then don't make it a bigger deal. You'll upset her.

—Alright— she sighed, lowering her head. —It's just that… she's so stubborn! Or was it maybe dad that made her doubt now?

—Glim…

—I know, I know! But, think about it! Dad crushed the mask because Auntie kissed Shadow Weaver, but now they are like this!?— she pointed out, looking up at him again. —Also, Catra and Adora said Shadow Weaver kissed her too when they first went into the groove!

—Perhaps they haven't talked about it— he suggested. —I don't think she's ashamed or that your father made her hesitate. Perhaps she has feelings, but maybe she doesn't understand those feelings— he continued, looking away. —I don't know when exactly I realized that I love you, but I know it was a difficult feeling to figure out…

—I… get it— she finally agreed, looking away. —I guess it's more difficult for her… you know, all in all…

—Give her some time, alright?— he advised her. —And maybe announce yourself *before* going into the groove when she's there— he then added, laughing slightly.

—Yeah— she laughed too.

That evening, Adora and Catra left Finn asleep and walked to the magical groove, hand in hand, giving each other reassuring looks. It was time.

But first, Catra would finally reply to Shadow Weaver's apology.

She felt both ready and unsure, yet she wanted to do it, so she pressed through her doubts and expressed herself as honestly as she could.

—I… cannot forgive you. Not just yet— she began. —I don't feel… ready yet. But I-I appreciate your apology— she continued, taking a deep breath. —So, thank you for that.

—I expected… your rejection— the woman admitted. —But I wasn't expecting you to thank me.

—I didn't reject your apology, I accept it. But I can't pardon what you did. At least not now. And, you didn't- When I left the other day, I wasn't hurt— she went on, holding Adora's hand tightly. —I was just overwhelmed because… I thought you'd never… say anything like that…

—I didn't think I would either…

—And that's why I'm thanking you— she explained. —The Shadow Weaver we knew would have never apologized. If anything, you would have justified everything again— she sighed. —So I… realize it took effort. It took me a great deal of effort too. We're still working on repairing all the damage we caused during the war. So I… appreciate your effort.

The woman turned around, unable to look at them, and joined her hands behind her back as she replied —I see. I suppose it was worth it then.

The girls could hear the grin in her voice. Adora took Catra's hand to her lips and briefly kissed her, encouraging her to go on.

—Now I… have something else to tell you.

Shadow Weaver raised her head but didn't look back, and asked —Do you? What would it be?

—I- We… have a child!— she began, cheerful despite feeling quite scared still. As the woman turned around to look at them, she continued —Their name is Finn and… they are already a year old. But I was scared of telling you. I tried! Many times! But…

—I made it difficult, didn’t I?— the woman chuckled. —Well, I thought you would never tell me— she admitted, tilting her head slightly.

—Wait— Catra uttered, shocked. She tensed up again and asked —You knew about them!?

—You’re living near the surface and when you’re together I’m drawn from the core, enough that I could take a look at your lovely place— she explained, conjuring a few illusions that made them see as if they were at their house. —And your lovely kid? Let’s just say I’ve been helping you a bit with them— she then added, creating another illusion, of Finn crawling around this time.

—You… what!?

Chapter End Notes

Oh yes, my dears, there's another eliminated scene here!!!!
~~Also, yes, another traumatized character~~ haha, ok no... I promise to you that Glimmer is fine.

Oh, but what's more important! They now know SW is the Ghost Lady!! hahah

Also, before I forget... Remember back in C-a-S when Casta was hesitant to even place a hand on Catra's shoulder, fearing her reaction? Not like Catra would ever react to scratch her for that, but that was what Casta feared back then... And now she didn't even hesitate!
I dunno, I think that's also growth worth pointing out...

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: simple intimate moments aren't instances of weakness
Status: reluctantly accepted, relatively admitted

Chapter Notes

I won't lie, I'm not sure about the lesson, BUT it's the best I could come up with. Cause no, I don't have the lessons decided, only the flashbacks. SW's reflections and the lessons are stuff I have to come up with after the flashback is fully written heh...

So, anyways...

I hope you enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Well, that had been quite funny.

She certainly didn't expect Glimmer to show up so early in the morning, so she never even considered raising illusions to hide the sleeping sorceress or, at least, make her *look* dressed.

Oh, but it gave her the chance to tease Castaspella for a while… It had been so entertaining.

Yet now she thought… Would she have reacted the same way if, once again, it had been Catra who found them?

No, no. That time, the girl was *spying* on them. This time it was an accident…

Right?

Or was she just trying to justify the fact that she would have been harsher with Catra?

Quite hypocritical of her to condemn the girl's spying when Shadow Weaver herself had always spied on basically everyone with her shadow spies.

Well, she already admitted she was quite the hypocrite, didn't she? This shouldn't surprise her…

Hypocrite and petty, in fact.

She wouldn't even admit to herself that she liked those little moments, quite intimate, with the sorceress. Wasn't it true? It always felt so… nice.

Yet she always dismissed them as mere teasing, just like earlier, when she told herself it was only lust.

It wasn't. It really wasn't.

In fact, she craved that intimacy. It didn't even have to be like that night, it was enough with the little moments they would occasionally have, close together, enjoying each other's company.

A memory of one such time suddenly came to mind, and the woman allowed herself to fondly observe it, despite the part of her that saw it like a moment of weakness…

> It was a cold afternoon in Mystacor. Some clouds covered the island, hiding the sun, and the temperature dropped suddenly. They were entering the cold season, yes, but it was still unexpected and no warming spells had been prepared inside the buildings yet.
>
> So when the Head Sorceress retired to her room to read in the comfort of her bed, she put a blanket around her shoulders before settling down next to Shadow Weaver.
>
> It was the perfect opportunity to tease her.
>
> Pretending to be offended, the woman reproached her —You'll just leave me out? Aren't you supposed to be "teaching" me to be more "mindful" or some foolery like that?
>
> —I- Well, I hadn't…— the sorceress began, stammering. —Ugh, you know what? Fine, just…— she uttered. Grunting, she struggled a bit to try and put the blanket around both of them but it left her a bit uncovered. —I almost have no blanket left, I- Wait a minute— she complained, but interrupted herself as realization hit. —Why do you even want- You can't be cold!
>
> Immediately cackling, genuinely amused, she replied —I wanted to see how long it would take you to remember!
>
> —I cannot *believe* I fell for this— Castaspella indignantly said, in a manner that reminded Shadow Weaver of the time she said the same at the Woods, back when she was taking her to investigate the failsafe. Shaking the memory, she couldn't help but smirk as the sorceress continued —You're so mean, I'm baffled. How do you manage to *always* surprise me with a new level of bitchiness?
>
> —Says the person who does the same… with naïveté in your case— she mocked her.
>
> —Just shut up and make some space for me— Castaspella cut her, still sounding annoyed.
>
> *What*!?
>
> Shadow Weaver was left speechless for a moment. She was expecting the sorceress to remove the blanket from around her… yet she was leaving it on!?
>
> —You will… leave the blanket…
>
> —Yes. Bear the consequences of your actions— she replied, playful, yet pretending seriousness.
>
> Castaspella squinted at her, seemingly holding back a laugh as her serious demeanor quickly transformed into a mocking smirk.
>
> That grin was just a palm away. The woman held her breath, despite not even needing to breathe, glancing at her lips with hidden nervousness.

But after a moment of just staring, Castaspella finally broke and laughed lightly against her shoulder.

Shadow Weaver's tension immediately disappeared now that she was *not* an inch away from her face; she'd be breathing easily if she were alive.

Finally, they settled, each with their book, and silently read the rest of the afternoon.

Shadow Weaver cursed at how pleasant those moments were.

She hated how much she liked that, hated how easily the sorceress managed to disarm her, because she shouldn't relish such moments.

But it was… relaxing, so relaxing, to lower her guard.

It was impossible to deny how much Light Spinner missed that. Or how much she enjoyed it every time. How she wished it could still be possible…

It was, sometimes, but it wasn't the same.

Back there, those moments would happen spontaneously, which made them quite… *special*. Now, the sorceress only visited either to consult her or to spend time with her, so it felt more like a routine.

Beatrix's feelings were suddenly all over the place.

After how Castaspella kissed her just a few weeks after that, she regretted not having kissed her when they shared the blanket.

Ah, but, wouldn't that have been a mistake?

Castaspella had *not* mentioned neither the kiss at Mystacor nor the kiss at the Woods, at all; most probably, because she regretted what she did.

After all…

One shouldn't confuse lust with love, right?

Right?

Perhaps…

However, she couldn't dwell much on the matter, because she felt suddenly drawn back to the surface. Apparently, Adora and Catra had gone to see her.

Ah, yes… the girl had told Castaspella that she would tell her about Finn, hadn't she?

Well, finally…

Beatrix felt relieved, much to her surprise.

It was as if a burden had been lifted.

Was it because this meant Catra trusted her enough? Even if she had said nothing about the apology, this proved it hadn't been in vain, right?

Indeed.

Chapter End Notes

I think it's a really cute scene heh

In any case, what do you think?

Gods, I thought I'd have more to say here but now I literally have *nothing* to say other than that...

Well, whatever. I hope you enjoyed the chapter! Thank you for reading and see you next week!!

Unloving Woman - Part 2

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver's shocking statement makes the girls shiver. What does she mean and what is she doing? Should they fear for her kid?
Of course, they would never, *ever* allow her to hurt Finn, but… Perhaps it's not what they think.

However, their conversation will reveal something else. Something Shadow Weaver would have preferred to keep a secret… And so, all the anger and violence returns… The old Shadow Weaver returns.

»—Bea, what happened? You're seething with rage!
»—Nothing…
»—Please, just tell me. It's a really good thing that you haven't lashed out at Catra, so…
»—I said *nothing*! Just go away! I was right. Fondness is but a weakness…

Chapter Notes

We're in chapter 60, you guys!! Only ~~10~~20 more to go heh

Oh my gods, I can be so dramatic sometimes...

Like in this chapter... Which is also MEGA long lol

Anyways, I'm sure you'll like it hehe

Also, on an unrelated note, I'm a tiny little bit super mega arch angry this week because of something that happened with work. Like, so SO angry, I feel insulted
So your comments since today will be very well received (no pressure to comment, ofc, but I needed to say it, I guess)

Now, to distract you from that sour note, I found this on Tumblr, and I think it really applies to SW. It's literally her.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—You… what!?

—Don't fret, it's not what you think…

—Help? Really? And how exactly are you doing that!?— the girl asked, suddenly defensive. —I *so* wanna know…

—Your kid is quite restless so, usually, helping consists of merely keeping them from falling down wherever elevated place they are— Shadow Weaver casually explained. —Especially the stairs.

—What the- Are you serious!?— Catra reacted, increasingly frantic. —You're incorporeal! Actually, you're obviously invisible there because we have *never* seen you! So, *how* could you possibly be doing that?

—It's actually quite easy. Scaring them does the trick.

—Scaring…— the girl repeated. She visibly shivered and, instinctively, took an angry step forward. However, Adora stopped her by the shoulders, so she only exclaimed —You're *scaring* Finn!?

Raising her hands, Shadow Weaver replied —Catra, it's not what you think! It's nothing like what I did to you. I…

—You *what*, huh!?

Looking away, she uttered —Not like I would repeat my mistakes now that I know they were so wrong. I'm trying *not* to do so.

—Oh, really!? Because you're miserably failing!

Catra wasn't just furious, she was so enraged she heard a ringing in her ears.

No one would touch her kid, much less *her*.

But her rage only made Shadow Weaver furious too as she yelled back —I know! But I am *still trying*!

—You're clearly not trying enough!— she immediately retorted. But right after, all her anger faded along with the tension in her body. She regretted saying that. She didn't mean it. Looking away, ashamed, Catra let out —I-I'm sorry. I know it's… difficult.

Calmer too, Shadow Weaver raised a hand, gesturing at her to stop.

—Don't apologize. If anything, I'm the one that should do so…— she said. —I "helped" without ever asking for permission, once again. I just went and did what I pleased, as if I had any right— she recognized, looking away with a scoff.

Realizing both had calmed down, Adora let go of Catra and the girl sighed as she asked —So, if it's not how you scared me… How are you- *What* do you do?

—Well, turns out Finn is quite scared of darkness or just anything dark in general— she began. —They are the only one who can see me or my illusions at your house, so I use that. For instance, when they wake up while you two are sleeping, and start wandering around the bed, sometimes they near the edge. In that case, I just have to make the whole floor look pitch black, and they immediately retreat, afraid, right back into your arms— she explained. —That works every time, but neither of you are aware because, even if you were awake, you can't see those illusions— she added. —In nature, fearing the dark keeps one safe. But I… I had simply misused the shadows, solely to induce fear as a means to… break your will— she admitted.

At first, Catra was shocked at her admission, but after her apology, she should have expected it. Behind her, Adora was equally surprised, and took a step forward to stand next to Catra.

—You…— she began, but interrupted herself. A nervous grin appeared in her lips for a moment, and she shook her head before a cackle escaped her. Covering her eyes with one hand, she laughed loudly, her head tilted back, and for a moment, neither Adora nor Shadow Weaver understood what was going on. A bit interrupted by her laughter, Catra finally said —You managed to- You seriously- *Of course* you would find a way to make that shit helpful! No fucking wonder that sorceress has believed from the start that you could "grow" despite how you *always* resort to those damned shadows!

—Catra…— Adora called, placing a hand on her shoulders.

The girl calmed down, took a few deep breaths, and her serious expression returned. Once again she advanced towards the woman, angry, and this time Adora didn't stop her.

—But if I find out you traumatized Finn, I swear, I'll find a way to hurt you— she threatened, more worried about her child than she was scared of the woman.

—Don't you *dare* hurt Castaspella!

—What!?

Catra took a step back and looked at Shadow Weaver with a mix of confusion and disbelief.

Her rage at that moment was unmistakable, but…

Why would she think…

—Why would I ever- I would *never* hurt someone else just to "punish" you!— she immediately sentenced. —And why- Wait… Why would hurting *her* be a way to hurt you?— she then asked, glancing back at Adora to see if she was as confused as her. —You don't exactly feel her physical pain, so this is *not* related to that spell thing.

Ah, right.

Perhaps she should have controlled her reaction a bit.

But she didn't even have time to *think* about it.

In fact, she couldn't help it.

—It's not what you think— she said, dismissive. —It's just that… Back in Mystacor, one of my pupils…— she began, but hesitated. —Em, Sahm… He hurt her in the first week of class, trying to make it seem like I had made him do it— she continued. —And, some months later, when I pointed out how, even when I could interact with reality, he wouldn't be able to hurt me, he threatened to hurt her again…— she explained. —Of course, Sahm is a lot like me; just like you remind me of myself, now he reminds me of you— she admitted. —It was…a reflex.

A reflex…

A feeling of dread, a void inside her chest, overtook her, and the woman looked away, ashamed and angry at herself.

Whispering at Adora, Catra smirked and let out —Mhmm, sure…

And right that moment, as if summoned by the conversation, Castaspella appeared at the groove, apparently having teleported there in a rush.

—What's- Bea…— she began, but interrupted herself when she saw the girls. Fear immediately gripped her chest and she asked them all —What happened!? Are you alright?

—Head Sorceress! What's…— Adora began, surprised, but interrupted herself when she saw Castaspella immediately go towards Shadow Weaver, perhaps ready to reproach her.

Yet, far from what the girls thought, she was worried, which meant the woman was somewhat in emotional pain, enough that the sorceress had to show up like that. So they decided to listen carefully.

In a low tone, Castaspella asked —Bea, what happened? You're seething with rage!

—Nothing…— she replied, turning away.

—Please, just tell me— the sorceress begged. With a small smile, she added —It's a really good thing that you haven't lashed out at Catra, so…

—I said *nothing*! Just go away!— Shadow Weaver interrupted her. She walked away, putting some distance between them, and uttered —I was right. Fondness is but a weakness…

Despite the distance and her quiet tone, Castaspella could perfectly hear her, and immediately looked down, frowning angrily.

She was pained, and Shadow Weaver could feel it.

The sorceress huffed and didn't hesitate to teleport away, muttering —Indeed. And unloving woman she is…

Gone the sorceress, silence settled in the groove for a tense moment.

—Sha-Shadow Weaver?— Adora finally called out.

Catra was holding her left arm tightly, and gave her a pained look. They were both thinking the same, and they knew it wouldn't end well if they showed pity.

But they couldn't help it.

—Leave me alone!— the woman retorted, without looking back.

Despite her aggressive tone, they hesitated for a moment.

They didn't want to leave but, it was clear she needed some time alone.

—We'll go but… She looked really hurt— Adora pointed out.

—I know!— she yelled, turning back to look at them. Her expression said enough about what she was going through, yet she continued —I feel her damned feelings! I *cannot* ignore that even if I want to! Don't you understand!? Caring is a *weakness*, even for her!

—It's not like that— Adora insisted. —The way you put it, sounds like the Head Sorceress can't take care of herself, but she's not defenseless— she remarked. —If she were attacked, like you said, to hurt *you* instead, she can keep herself safe; just like she wants to do the same with you— she assured her. —Caring for someone- *Loving* someone isn't a weakness, it's a reason to keep going on— she dared add, glancing at Catra.

—You have no idea what you're talking about…— the woman uttered, looking down. —Now, leave — she ordered.

And so they did.

The day that followed was a nightmare for the sorceress.

It felt eternal.

When she arrived at her room that night, the first thing she did was angrily loosen her bun. Then, she sat to write several pages destined to be burnt, and spent almost all night awake.

Ever since morning came, she couldn't wait for nightfall again. Castaspella didn't want to deal with her daily duties, and absolutely didn't want to deal with anyone. She just wanted to stay in her room for as long as possible.

In fact, the sorceress had set on her desk a vial of sleeping potion, which she was staring at when someone knocked on her door. Whether she would drink the whole thing or not was left unanswered as she stood up and received the acolyte who went to request her assistance.

The hours passed so slowly, so painfully slowly, that she spent all day regretting not drinking at least the usual bit of the potion to sleep until nightfall.

But she had classes to impart, two meetings to attend, and different issues to settle all over the island, which seemed to make time go extremely slowly for the Head Sorceress that day.

So, yes. The day was a nightmare. Yet it would end soon. What could possibly go wrong before bedtime?

—Head Sorceress— a voice called her as she walked back to her room.

She *so* wanted to ignore him and go on her way, but she recognized the voice of her councilman.

Damn it.

—Yes?

She approached him, clearing her throat slightly, until they were standing face to face in the middle of a large room. There was something in his face that Castaspella couldn't decipher, but it wouldn't be long until she understood.

—Good evening, I suppose. I'm not interrupting anything, am I?

—No, I was just on my way to my room.

—Were you? Ah, my bad, I thought you were, maybe, going down to the Whispering Woods…

—What makes you say…

—I don't mean to pry, of course— he interrupted her. —But, you see… earlier during the meetings we noticed you were a bit… distracted.

—I am just very tired. I didn't sleep well— Castaspella explained.

—That's why you had Geldirik oversee the meetings?

He was fishing for something, but the Head Sorceress still couldn't guess what.

—No. Councilman Sielnor is more than fit to preside over our meetings and, in this case, I believed it would be better for everyone if he were in charge of the particular matters we discussed— she calmly replied, trying to keep it all respectful.

—Just because Geldirik is the foreman-councilman…

—Yes. *Just* because he's your foreman— Castaspella interrupted, already guessing what he was about to say.

She had been so angry all day, angry at herself and struggling to stay in control… She needed to take deep breaths to maintain her composure at all times. But now…

—I'll have to disagree, Head Sorceress— he insisted. —You see, I'm under the impression your… little friendly relationship with a certain dead woman is clouding your judgement.

—I beg your pardon!?— she exclaimed, indignant.

But he shamelessly continued —How can we trust you're still able to rule and make sound decisions if you're so blinded by Shadow Weaver!?

—You can't be serious!

—But I am— he concluded, right before pulling from Castaspella's cape, enough to show a couple of bruises just above her collarbone. —Am I not?

The sorceress immediately took a step back, pushing his hand away, and put her cape back in place, but several people who just happened to be in the room had seen the marks already. Rumours wouldn't take long, that much was evident.

What if Shadow Weaver was right? This time, at least, it did seem like she was… Caring is a weakness, one this councilman was determined to exploit. What's more, one he can in fact use as much as he wants without ever suffering for it. Because if Castaspella stripped him of his status as councilman for his disrespect, it would make her look like a tyrant. Wouldn't it?

She took a deep breath. That day simply refused to end, didn't it? What else did she have to bear today!?

Looking down, the Head Sorceress took another deep breath to calm down. A moment later, she looked up again, having gotten an idea, and silently walked away. Her expression betrayed neither her anger nor the turmoil brewing inside her.

The sun was finally setting by the time Castaspella found her brother. Without even saying "hello", she approached him and called his attention.

—We need to talk.

—What did I do now!?— he asked, scared as he recognized the expressionless demeanor of his sister.

—You? Nothing— she simply replied. —I just need your help with *something*— she explained, urging him to stand up. —It's time we do what you've been waiting for…

After a few hours, because Micah managed to convince Castaspella of having dinner at least, the siblings stepped into the Lunarium, carrying several things.

As they approached the center, the ghost of that first summoning spell gripped them tightly, and for the first time, they both noticed something. The lingering question was who had cleaned that summoning spell from the ground, along with the pieces of the shattered mask.

What had happened?

They wouldn't know, for neither wanted to ask…

As they silently settled everything on the ground, the sorceress couldn't help reflecting: she didn't know when her feelings had developed. She still wasn't fully sure what those feelings were. But now she felt… stupid. What if her brother's concern had been right all along?

Perhaps… the woman really couldn't change.

No. She definitely could.

But she was clearly unwilling to do so, wasn't she? What use was it to continue trying? If she stubbornly wanted to remain the monster everyone believed her to be, if she'd rather throw away all her progress, then there was no point in keeping her in this world.

Like this, she would never give the girls what they so longed for. She would only bring them more pain, wouldn't she?

She had apologized, yes, but that was only the beginning… She would have to be willing to keep moving in the right direction, yet that was exactly what she refused to do…

In any case, the decision was made. So the siblings spent some hours preparing everything, and the sun was rising when they finally began.

Early in the morning, while Finn still slept, Catra and Adora decided to visit Shadow Weaver again. They had noticed that night that, when the kid bumped against the table and a glass fell down, "something" made them backtrack and crawl away from the shattered pieces. Something that also made them cry, so they guessed it was because Finn had been scared by an illusion they weren't seeing…

—So it *was* you last night— Adora concluded.

—Who else?

—Alright, alright. But what did you do? 'Cause they cried for hours after that— Catra questioned her.

—Well… I just…

—You *what*?— Catra insisted, her tone warning.

—I extended the shadow of the table, raised it a bit, and made it advance towards them, so they would get away from the glass.

—Don’t you think that was a bit of an exaggeration!?— Adora asked, disgruntled.

—Before you arrived, they were about to place one of their little, obviously fragile, hands on a piece of glass— Shadow Weaver replied, condescending. —Finn is too curious for their own good.

—Bold of you to presume all kids aren’t like that.

—Of course, you two were too. But we were willing to lock you all in empty rooms if necessary, which I know you wouldn’t do with Finn— she argued.

—What!? No!

—I recall that— Catra admitted. —And I recall scratching the door for *two hours*!

—Maybe if you stopped munching on wires when told…

—Wires!?

—I was a kid!

—You were a danger to yourself. Don’t say I never did anything for you— Shadow Weaver retorted. Although her expression then changed a bit as she admitted —Maybe that wasn't the best way, of course.

—You think!?

Catra’s indignation was tinted with some amusement, yet their conversation was cut short as Glimmer suddenly appeared in the groove, distressed.

—Glimmer!?

—Woah, Sparkles! What’s happening?

—I can’t find Auntie!

—Alright, alright. Slow down— Catra interrupted her. —What do you mean? Did anything happen?

—Last night… Or, well, I don’t know exactly when, but it was kinda late— the Queen began. —A-a councilman- Well, I heard that there was a discussion, some people were talking about it, and that he… um… accused Auntie of being, you know, blinded by Shadow Weaver, and then…— she explained, and interrupted herself to gesture at her neck. —He showed that…

—What’s “that”?— Adora innocently asked.

—You don’t want to know…— the woman warned her.

—Sparkles, what aren’t you telling us?

—Never mind that! He exposed her, and now she’s nowhere to be found!— Glimmer exclaimed.

It didn't take too much for the girls to put two and two together, so they finally understood that *something* had happened, leaving enough of a mark for the councilman to expose her.

—Tell me what exactly happened— Shadow Weaver requested, thoughtful.

—I was told she didn't do anything to him, just… walked away expressionless— she replied. —The acolytes that saw it were so shocked…

—Oh, of course!— the woman laughed. —The last time she was like that in front of a councilor was when your father and another councilman sent Double Trouble to pose as her to test me— she recalled. —Suffice to say, *I* had to calm her down so she wouldn't explode in rage.

—Oh, Auntie…

The girls exchanged a concerned look as they understood just how furious the sorceress must have been, then looked back at Shadow Weaver.

—Tell me, Your Majesty— she began. —Where have you looked for her?

—I've been everywhere I could think of! This was my last chance to find her!— Glimmer replied, her tone agonizing, as she covered her face with both hands.

—Did you ask your father for help?

—N-no. I didn't want to get him involved… I rather he doesn't know about anything that happened— she admitted.

—Of course. He better not know— Shadow Weaver agreed. —Then perhaps I can see if I sense something through the- Ugh!

Just as she focused intently on the spell to see if she could find her like she'd do back in Mystacor, immense pain surged through it and forced the woman to her knees.

—What's happening!?— Adora exclaimed, exchanging an alarmed look with Catra.

—What is she doing!?— Shadow Weaver yelled, a hand on her chest while the other supported her on the ground, somehow. —What…— she tried to say again, but seemed breathless, which only scared her more as she didn't even need to breathe.

In front of her, the girls knelt and seemed to want to help her. Catra was fearful at first, recalling Shadow Weaver's reaction whenever she worried about her, but Adora gave her a reassuring look and both tried to help her.

—Breathe— Adora told her. —Please…

—I don't…

—Even if you don't need it! Try!— Catra interrupted her.

Shadow Weaver could barely focus, but when she saw one of Catra's hands over hers, or rather, through hers, as if wanting to touch her hand to calm her down, she finally found something she could hold onto. It surprised her, shocked her even, to realize that, after all this time, Catra could be so concerned for her. This seemed the best thing to anchor herself.

—Ugh…— she groaned, “breathing” as told.

—Why don’t you… uh… lay back on the tree?

—But she’ll go right through it— Adora pointed out.

—She can make an illusionary one, right? And that…

—Yes— Shadow Weaver interrupted, her voice hoarse.

She made the effort to conjure the illusion and sat back, a hand still on her chest and the other like trying to dig into the ground. The girls went to sit at each side of her and kept trying to calm her down, while Glimmer panicked even more, seeing the woman bear an indescribable pain that likely came from her aunt and was making her cry.

However, her expression suddenly changed to something that could be despair.

—Sha-Shadow Weaver?— the Queen suddenly asked, as she noticed it. —Did… something happen?

Oh, something did happen. Yes.

Realization hit.

She finally understood what was going on. And, somehow, that hurt even more. The physical pain was nothing next to the ache she felt from understanding the meaning behind it.

She now cried tears out of a different pain but, fortunately for her, the girls couldn’t know that.

All they needed to know was one thing.

—The Lunarium… Go there… Look for Micah…

—I-I went there! It’s empty!— she assured.

But Shadow Weaver shook her head immediately, and uttered —Must be an illusion.

—What do you mean?

—They… are trying to remove the spell… forcibly— she began explaining. —But it… Ugh… it clings to her heart— she continued, straining. —It can kill her… The-the spell is tied to me, to… my mask… to our dance… The-they need me there for this…

—But, wait. If they remove the spell, you…— Catra reflected, hesitating at the end.

—Don’t look so betrayed— the woman told her, with a rather soft expression. —Glimmer. Stop them. I… don’t care what happens to me, I… I’ll help her remove it if so she wishes. But, *please*, she doesn’t have to die for this.

She said "please"? Now that was even more concerning for them… After all, last time she said it…

—I will— Glimmer assured her, before disappearing in a puff of sparkles.

Catra and Adora remained, each at one side of Shadow Weaver, visibly preoccupied.

—I never thought you two would worry so much for me…

—You know Catra always cared for you and always wanted to help when you were in pain— Adora reproached her. —But you wouldn't let her!

—I felt… so weak when that happened…— she explained. —Accepting her help… would be accepting my weakness, which I refused to do. But that was petty of me… I should have valued you both more— she admitted.

—At least now you say it— Adora pointed out.

—Hah! Too late— Shadow Weaver let out, with a bitter laugh.

—Yeah… I can't believe this is only happening now that you're dead…

The sorceress had no idea where she was, what time it was, or what had happened to her. She slowly woke up somewhere slightly cold, yet felt the sun on her skin, so she had to be outdoors.

And when she opened her eyes, there was the opaque figure of Shadow Weaver, staring right back at her.

But that wasn't all.

She could also feel her hand being held tightly, and sure enough, it was the woman again…

What had happened?

Struggling to get up, once Castaspella managed to push herself up and sit, she pulled her hand back without hesitation. Then the feeling of pain came, the same which the sorceress could see in her expression. But she was still hurt too, by her words and actions…

—P-Please…— Shadow Weaver began. —I'll-I'll help you remove it. But don't attempt that again— she pleaded.

—Why do you *suddenly* care… after what you said?— Castaspella questioned her.

—Because I'm an idiot, Cas…— she replied. Hesitantly, she reached for her hand again, but instead grabbed her wrist. —I was afraid… of what I felt when thinking how- Of someone hurting you just to hurt me because I cannot be physically hurt now— she admitted, shocking the sorceress who had no context. —The feeling was awful, I can't even… I *hate* feeling that— she continued. Looking down, Shadow Weaver released her wrist, only to move down and hold Castaspella's hand between both of hers. —Now *I* almost did that! I swear, I'm genuinely sorry! I am!

If she thought she was surprised already, this certainly made her reconsider. She knew the woman had already apologized to the girls, but she hadn't seen her apologizing this much since the little accident they had in Mystacor.

She was hurt, yes, but she couldn't stay offended after this.

Carefully, the sorceress knelt in front of her, holding her hands too, and gave her a soft look.

—I believe you— she began. Her eyes crinkled a bit as she smiled and continued —This was great progress, Bea. Even when you fell back into that mindset… At least now you regret it. I'm- Oh…

Shadow Weaver let go of her hands and suddenly hugged her, briefly interrupting Castaspella as she muttered —Sorry…

She sighed and let out —I'm proud. Thank you…

—For what? Not being a jerk?— the woman scoffed, laughing slightly.

—For trusting me. This must have been difficult.

And it was.

So, *so* difficult.

Castaspella had no idea how much effort it took her to ignore the disapproving screams inside her. But nothing was worse than the feelings she had been experiencing, the realization, the heartache…

It was a good sign to be speaking with the sorceress like this again. Relief washed over her, soothing the woman's concerns.

—Already teasing me?— she mocked. —Next time you want to die, better let *me* do it; I'll be far quicker.

Both laughed at that, and Castaspella hugged her tighter, relishing the very unusual moment.

—And I don't think I said it, but I'm so proud of you for apologizing to the girls…

—Right. However, it didn't happen as soon as you wanted.

—It was when you were ready. It never mattered how long it would take.

—No matter how long it took… I owed them that much.

The women continued to hug for a long moment while, from a distance, Adora and Catra observed, still a bit concerned.

However, having heard them, Catra's expression turned hopeful, and she said —She's really trying, isn't she?

Adora smiled and hugged her from behind, resting her head on the girl's shoulder, and agreed —Yeah… Now let's go home.

Chapter End Notes

Have you ever heard the phrase "growth is not linear"? Well, welcome to the valley of "oh, shit, she's reverting". You shall visit it plenty of times. I mean, same happens with Catra, but she has had support for more time, her heart remained despite, well, SW, and she has therapy; SW only has Casta (a guide not a therapist) and all of this is actually quite a hinder for her progress, as this chapter has proved.
Now, notice how I make reference to this AMAZING song, *Again*. Let's be real, most of the Lyrics is pretty much Beatrix, and I write her name like that because the "seeing nothing, nothing but myself (...) and I'm the one with the lighter" is literally what happens with LS, when she

becomes selfish after being rejected, and ends up corrupted, and it's her own fault. Which connects to "Every inch of me is charred, god what happened to my heart, I'm about to fall apart, again, again", and "What am I supposed to say, when I end up driving everyone away?"; for me, they are literally her at the end of S5.
This chapter is basically SW thinking the last two parts of the lyrics I just quoted, while ALSO Casta's mind is going "And you're never coming back, and I'm not okay with that, and I should have never let myself get attached".

So, what do you think? Was it too dramatic?? hahah

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Loving someone isn't a weakness, it's a reason to keep going
Status: Under review

Chapter Notes

I have 4 more chapters written to post after this one, but after that, I'm really stuck! Ugh...

I do have a few more flashbacks, but I'm stuck in the flashback number 34 (would be chapter 69), and actually, I don't have chapters 66 and 68 written even!!!

I have the notes but I can't elaborate on them TT^TT

Anyways, I hope you enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Loving someone" she said…

How could it not be a weakness? After everything that happened…

But then, that would mean perhaps she does have a certain… infatuation for Castaspella.

That would be the root of her problems.

Hers and the sorceress', that is.

She knew well enough that Castaspella had been struggling significantly since their relationship became friendlier; it was evident in her expression, her actions, her issues with Micah, but also her words and the feelings the woman got through the spell which the sorceress tried so hard to keep inside.

Ugh…

She knew well… Since *when* did she know Castaspella "so well"!?

It was impossible. It couldn't be…

But it was, wasn't it? And it wasn't even something new…

She had gained this insight long ago…

A few hectic weeks had gone by since the Guild Dance, and Shadow Weaver couldn't help noticing that the sorceress was worse with each passing day. In fact, she had become exceedingly proficient at hiding how badly she was feeling, but it didn't fool her.

—Anything you need to talk about?— Shadow Weaver asked, now that they were alone for a moment.

—Talk? Not really. I'm perfectly fine!— Castaspella replied, giving her an obviously fake smile.

—Save that for the rest of the people. I don't need the spell to tell you're *not* fine— the woman pressed her, towering over her.

—I'm- It's… alright. Really— the sorceress insisted, looking away with a faint blush before taking a step back.

—Bullshit.

—Why do you care?

Castaspella looked back at her, squinting in suspicion.

—I said I don't need the spell to realize you're not fine, but it doesn't mean I don't *feel* you're troubled. It's an annoying feeling…

—How nice of you to worry— she uttered, sarcastically, rolling her eyes.

—Just go ahead and verbalize it before your anxiety kills me again…

—Fine! It's… Micah again.

It was always him lately, wasn't it?

—What happened now?

—I overheard him talking… about how he feels, you know, betrayed— she explained, embracing herself. —He said you're undermining his relationship with me, and that I'm just letting it happen… That I'm abandoning him.

—You do know none of that is true, right?

—Yes! But… What am I supposed to do to convince him?— Castaspella let out, expression defeated. —I know I have the right to express myself, and I've been as respectful as I can, tried to make this situation as easy as possible for the both of us, yet there's so much tension right now… It's impossible to discuss at all when he's being so critical!

—It makes no sense to argue with him in this matter. He's convinced of every word he says— Shadow Weaver reflected.

—But I have to try. I know we can reach an understanding! Or… I hope so.

—Then take your own advice and walk away from this matter for now— the woman replied, tilting Castaspella's head up to make eye contact. —Give it time. Don't put up with his criticism.

The sorceress closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and nodded —Yes, I should give it more time…

It was strange for Shadow Weaver to be the one giving such kind of advice, but feeling how calmer Castaspella was now meant it was exactly what she needed. And good thing, because that was one of the worst feelings the spell had transmitted to her.

However, after a moment of silence, she recalled something and said —Speaking of Micah… I have a question.

—Say— the sorceress allowed, seemingly unbothered.

—Why didn't you jump to the same conclusion as your brother?

—About?

—Having charmed you.

—Oh, that!— Castaspella exclaimed, before letting out a hearty laugh. —Are you serious!? Please, if anything, I would have needed to charm you, not the other way round— she said, laughing again.

—Why would you charm me? It's not like that would make me any less mean— Shadow Weaver inquired, curious.

—Wa-wait, really?

Castaspella's look of utter disbelief shocked the woman for a moment. She *actually* didn't know!?

—I suppose you don't know that much about charming spells…— she sighed.

—Not like I've ever needed them— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes again.

Completely ignoring her tone and the eye roll, Shadow Weaver adopted her tutor-like stance to explain —When you charm someone, they are still their usual self; nothing changes in their behavior or attitudes. What *does* change, are their priorities. Whomever they are infatuated with will be their main priority, as it happens with actual foolish admiration or passion for someone —. Her tone was of absolute disgust at the end of the phrase, which only amused Castaspella. Yet she let her go on without interrupting. —Furthermore, the spell only induces the feeling when this person doesn't have it or ever would, but it looks pretty much the same as what the real feeling would be. You'd only differentiate it because the charm is built on *nothing*; a real infatuation will have huge emotional support behind it. Even if it's pure nonsense, it's enough for the person to justify those… *feelings*.

Her tone was once again of utter loathing, but it went right over Castaspella's head.

—Really? That sounds…

—Stupid, I'd say— she interrupted. —So, no, charming me wouldn't change anything. I would still react in the same way to everything. The change of priorities would only mean that, if you're hurt or aggravated, my reaction is aimed at defending or avenging you first and foremost— she explained, before letting out a laugh. —It would be so amusing, however, because you would feel guilty of my actions, and it *would* be your fault, as a matter of fact.

The woman laughed again, obviously finding the idea quite hilarious, yet Castaspella was deep in thought and never registered it.

—Wait, but… didn't you… No, well— she stammered, interrupting herself and shaking her head.

—What? Go ahead, say it. I'll mock you regardless— Shadow Weaver taunted her.

But she immediately regretted it when the sorceress raised a brow at her, staring defiantly.

—Oh, really? Well then: you just reminded me of your reaction when your *favorite* student burnt my arm the first week— she began, much to the woman's horror. —Oh! And when Double Trouble posed as me!? Now, looking back, that was interesting…— she continued, letting out a smirk. —Perhaps I *did* charm you?— she concluded, looking smugly at a bewildered Shadow Weaver.

—Nonsense— she finally managed to reply, trying to hide her distress. She gestured dismissively and tried to walk away, not even wanting to think about the matter. —You know full well you've earned my respect, like I seem to have earned yours— she argued, as she heard the sorceress follow her. —I may not have the same attentive behaviors you have, but it doesn't mean I won't show my respect in some way.

—If you say so, I guess…— Castaspella replied. Her tone continued to be quite smug as she pressed on —Although I hadn't thought about it at all until you now mentioned this; it just called my attention that you were actually describing attitudes you've already shown.

—Think whatever you want. I've already explained myself— the woman sentenced, speaking more severely and hurrying her step to get away from her.

She wanted that conversation to end right that instant.

Well, curse her.

Castaspella was right that time.

Shadow Weaver had trapped herself with her words.

But if the sorceress hadn't charmed her…

Ugh, she had to forget this. Forget it!

It was a senseless topic.

What did it matter!?

What did it… matter?

And if it did?

Now she wished Micah had been right. A charming spell could simply be undone.

But this!?

Curse her…

Yes, it was like a curse.

One she had to admit had taken over her.

And maybe, only maybe, the same was true for the sorceress.

After all, Castaspella had dropped whatever she was doing to check on Shadow Weaver when her rage reached its highest point.

But…

But?

Exactly that was why the sorceress felt so hurt at her rejection. It had been so easy to do it… Castaspella's heart seemed to be as fragile as glass, and that's what Shadow Weaver despised the most.

In herself, that is…

Perhaps she had made a mistake…

She had been vulnerable in front of her before. She had even allowed herself to be vulnerable in front of the girls… Why couldn't she do the same now!?

No, she just *had* to be a jerk and push away Castaspella the same way she had pushed away Catra. All they did was show concern but, for her, it felt like disgusting pity…

Maybe she was the real fool…

Chapter End Notes

evil laughter

Yes, I'm getting into the topic...

Not like she'll accept it any time soon, tho...

As the status says, it's "under review", she's considering it but doesn't like it...

Oh, there will be more situations to make her reconsider, tho. In exactly 7 chapters she should be ready to accept it hehe
Oh gods, just 7 chapters for chapter 68 where the culmination of all this lessons reaches it's climax!

Imma cry brb...

Anyways, I hope you enjoyed the chapter and thank you for reading!!!!!

Edit: Dismiss the "7 chapters till culmination" because I messed up the calculations and initially thought this would be ending in chapter 70 when actually it ends in chapter 80. But I can't correct the numbers because I forgot what I meant in this note, so simply dismiss it, thank you.

Rumour Mill

Chapter Summary

After a few months with no signs of the King, Castaspella and Glimmer grow worried. What is happening with Micah and why has he isolated from the whole world?
»How could it be?
»How could he endanger his sister without knowing?
»Yes, he had always wanted to get rid of the summoning spell bound to her heart, as she had said, but he never thought that would put her at risk!
»He should have investigated more… He should have read more on the subject.

However, his absence from Mystacor has kept him oblivious of the running rumour mill. He's blissfully unaware of everything the acolytes whisper about a certain summoned spirit and the Head Sorceress…

A few months went by. The incident at the Lunarium remained a secret that only the council ever learnt about. Meanwhile, King Micah, after being told why Castaspella almost died, decided to take some time for himself, leaving his pupils to be tutored by councilor Arden in his stead.

He spent that time mostly in his room, reflecting and reading more on the subject, as he felt immense guilt. He would only leave the room to eat, and then returned immediately, refusing to tell anyone what was going on. Yet after four months, even Glimmer had no idea…

He was just *so* distraught.

How could it be?

How could he endanger his sister without knowing?

Yes, he had always wanted to get rid of the summoning spell bound to her heart, as she had said, but he never thought that would put her at risk!

He should have investigated more… He should have read more on the subject.

And now that he did, there it was: Being bound to her heart, the spell would resist any form of forced banishment. Such a spell had two ends. Without the help of the spirit bound to the other end, the spell would cling to her heart, causing terrible pain and even death if taken too far.

How could he be so stupid!?

This was all because his knowledge of ancient spells was practically zero.

Did Shadow Weaver know that it could happen?

Probably…

But… did she know Castaspella would attempt to remove it?

Perhaps no. She would have warned her, right? If they were “so friendly” with each other and if, supposedly, she actually helped his sister, then she should have…

But then again, he had no idea why Castaspella suddenly wanted to remove the spell, much less if the woman knew she would.

His sister looked so… angry, troubled, and sad.

And instead of asking her *why* she wanted to do that, he simply went along with it and almost got her killed…

What a brother…

Meanwhile, in Mystacor, the Head Sorceress walked down the halls towards the classroom that would usually be occupied by Micah and his pupils, and knocked on the door. She knew he wasn’t there, but she wasn’t looking for her brother.

—Come in— a voice said from the inside, so she opened the door. —Ah, Head Sorceress— Arden noticed. —Please give me a moment. Delwyn, could you watch over them while I’m gone?— they asked, glancing back at the ambassador, who was assisting them that day. After he nodded, they left the classroom and closed the door behind them. —Head Sorceress, I promise I’ll return Delwyn soon…

—Please, don’t worry. I’m not here for him. I just needed to speak with you— she clarified.

—Oh, I see. What can I help you with?

—Well… Glimmer and I are a bit worried. We don’t know what’s going on with Micah. Did he tell you anything when he asked you to cover for him?— she asked.

—Unfortunately, he only said he would take some time off. Nothing else.

—It’s been *months*… Perhaps we should…

The sorceress trailed off as a group of acolytes walked through the corridor and stopped just a few meters away from her. They were murmuring a bit too loudly and she couldn’t help hearing what they were saying behind her back. *Literally* behind her back.

—…Of course something is going on…

—With her!?

—Didn’t you see the scandal a few months ago?

—And the mark…

—Exactly…

Castaspella closed her eyes and tilted her head as she tried not to react, yet Arden noticed her tightly closed fists. They could also hear them, yet lacked the context to understand. Until one was a bit more specific.

—I can’t believe she’d get involved with *Shadow Weaver*…

—Enough!— she snapped, turning around to face the group of acolytes. The sorceress couldn’t take it anymore. This wasn’t the first time she caught wind of those gossips, yet she had hoped they would die down soon. But they didn’t, so this time she had to speak up. —I'll make it clear, here and now: you want to gossip? Go ahead, do as you please— she began. —But you all better make sure I don't ever hear that *bullshit* again! I won't pretend to control what you talk about, you can gossip as much as you want, speculate, make up theories, invent whatever the heck you want about me, about Shadow Weaver, about *us*. But keep all of that to *yourselves* as long as I'm within earshot!— the sorceress requested, more like an order, her voice breaking. —I do *not* want to hear it! Have some *respect*!

—So-sorry, Head Sorceress…

—Excuse us…

—We won’t do it again…

The acolytes lowered their heads as they apologized, and soon walked away, noticeably ashamed. After that, Castaspella slowly calmed down and turned back to Arden, who looked hesitant. They didn’t know whether they should speak or not…

—I am sorry for my outburst— she said.

—It’s completely understandable, Head Sorceress— they assured her, shaking their head. —Perhaps we should have made a statement after your discussion with…

—No, of course not. We can’t control what people talk about… And, as I told them, we shouldn’t attempt to do as much either. I just hope these rumours don’t reach my brother— Castaspella admitted.

—And speaking of him, what do you intend to do?

—I’ll see if I can talk to him and find out what happened…

—Then I wish you good luck— they let out, before bowing respectfully and returning to the classroom. However, once inside, Delwyn and the pupils asked about the yelling they heard. —No need to worry. There was just an issue with some acolytes gossiping about our Head Sorceress, which, as you must know, is highly disrespectful. I imagine how it may have sounded, but it wasn’t violent, I assure you— they explained. —What you should know is that our Head sorceress wasn’t telling them off for gossiping, but rather for doing it in front of her so shamelessly. Please make sure you *never* do that.

The whole class immediately agreed, yet Delwyn got a bit worried, and pulled Arden aside to ask them —Gossip? About Castaspella?

—Do you know what happened? At the Lunarium?— they asked, and the ambassador nodded. —Do you know *why* it happened?

—I was told she had a loud discussion with a councilman.

—Precisely. Now the acolytes are speculating that the Head Sorceress and Shadow Weaver have something going on— Arden explained, shaking their head. —It doesn’t matter if it’s true or not. What matters is that this got out of hand.

—Let me guess: she insists we can't do anything about it.

—Which is why she only asked them not to gossip in front of her— they nodded. —But I don't understand *why* they would do that. Who stops to speak behind someone's back within earshot?

—With all due respect, some people are simply stupid— Delwyn commented, rolling his eyes.

Arden let out a hearty laugh and patted the ambassador on the shoulder.

—I have to agree…

That same afternoon, Castaspella visited Bright Moon to speak with her brother. Apparently, King Micah had been rejecting everyone who went to knock on his door, yet this time, when the sorceress said it was her, a crashing sound was heard before the door burst open. Micah rushed outside and immediately hugged Castaspella, sobbing.

—I'm so sorry…— he let out. —Sorry, Sis…

—Mi-Micah— she stammered, shocked, and hesitantly hugged him back. —Brother, what happened? — she then asked, her tone gentle.

—I never thought- I didn't know… it would be so risky…

—Micah, what are you talking about?

—The Lunarium… When we tried to remove the summoning spell from you— he clarified, sobbing more, and Castaspella's expression darkened. —I didn't know… I should have known… I should have investigated before doing it— he insisted.

—That was months ago! And it wasn't your fault. I asked you to do it— she reminded him, her tone stern yet gentle.

—Still, I'm sorry… I'm sorry…

Castaspella took a deep breath, closed her eyes, and sighed while hugging him back a bit tighter. The siblings stayed like that for another while until Glimmer found them. After they explained to her what had happened, the Queen decided to invite them to dinner.

For the first time in a long time, they ate together again.

After dinner, the sorceress farewelled and teleported away to her room, they supposed.

Except that she didn't really go to Mystacor at all.

She appeared directly at the magical groove, so suddenly that it took Shadow Weaver a long moment to appear, which was like an eternity to Castaspella. And when she did, the sorceress felt a pang on her chest; *she ached to kiss her*.

Oh… she really wanted to. But she couldn't…

—Alright, that hurts— the woman immediately pointed out. —What happened now?

—Just… Can you…— she began, approaching. —Can you turn around?— Castaspella requested, her voice weak.

—Ah… A hug, I see— Shadow Weaver realized. Although rolling her eyes, she complied and turned. The sorceress instantly hugged her, so tight she could *feel it*. Whatever happened had to be terrible. But at least this time she hadn't done anything stupid, so the woman decided she shouldn't mock her. Not too much. —I see you found something healthier than drinking to help you… *cope*.

—Shush…

—What happened? You're hugging me so tightly I can actually feel it, you know?

—Sorry…— she muttered, yet only hugged her tighter. —But I don't want to talk about it.

—Fine then… Keep your secrets.

—You really don't want to know… You'd be so mad.

—Now I'm more curious. Anything related to Micah or that council of fools?

—Not this time.

The Head Sorceress couldn't stop thinking about the gossip she had been hearing for the past months. And now, she had reached her limit.

Was it because she wished they were true? Or because it meant people would judge her if it were true?

She didn't really care about the opinions others could have.

What if they judged her?

What if they didn't like her relationship with Shadow Weaver?

What did they know!?

Nothing.

They knew nothing…

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: it is normal to care for others
Status: considering whether jealousy represents a weakness or not

Chapter Notes

Bruh
I am so sorry
I've had an hectic day and totally forgot I had to post today 🙃

Also, I had no idea what to write for the lesson!
Aaaaaaanyways, here's the chapter 😅 enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castaspella almost dying was no joke.

Now she felt guilty, and probably, she was.

She had hurt the sorceress, *again*, but this time, it was enough to push her to the extreme of getting rid of the spell.

Or trying to, at least.

As the girls would say… she fucked up.

Normally, she would dismiss it, but this time, the consequences were too serious to be overlooked.

It was… frustrating, in a way. It made her realize how much she cared, how much she *should care*, in fact.

And it also made her long for the simple moments, domestic moments, when the women solely enjoyed each other's company. When they read books together, when they imparted classes, even when they knitted or went down to the surface to buy some necessities.

She would complain a lot in all of those situations, yes, but she couldn't keep denying she enjoyed every single one of those moments. They were so casual, so informal. She was relaxed, without a care in the world… Yet took them for granted.

Now she had come to appreciate them, no? Just her luck…

Well, at least she could remember those moments still… Like that one time when a shopkeeper pardoned Castaspella from the money she was missing. Something Shadow Weaver found so strange

that she even returned to ask him about it…

The sorceress was loaded with bags full of a variety of products which, apparently, count as bare necessities up in Mystacor. Shadow Weaver would have called most of them "luxuries", but perhaps she was too used to the Horde after so many years.

—Here's the… payment— the sorceress said, struggling to move up her arms carrying the weight of the bags.

—Thank you, let me count it…— he replied, emptying the pouch of money that Castaspella gave him.

The sorceress watched closely as he counted, but was apparently faster than him.

Before he could finish, she noticed —Oh, wait! It's not enough…

—Let me see, let me see— he requested. Once he had counted everything, he looked up again with a smile and told her —Just a bit short, don't worry. I'll take it.

—What!? Are you sure?

—I insist, Head Sorceress. It's alright.

—Oh, my… Tha-thank you so much— she replied, her expression conflicted.

—You're more than welcome— he cheerfully farewelled.

The sorceress left the shop tailed by Shadow Weaver, and walked quite slowly as she struggled to carry everything.

—Wouldn't it have been more *intelligent* to make two trips and buy just half of this each time? Or at least, you should have brought someone to help you— the woman reproached her.

—Why did you follow me all the way here? Just to criticize me?

—Annoying you is easy and entertaining— she replied, smirking.

—If I'm going to provide you with entertainment, at least help me with this!— Castaspella complained. —You *can* carry them as long as you walk besides me.

—Ah… You finally noticed— Shadow Weaver let out, with a fake lamenting tone, yet laughed silently. —Only so you don't pester me later with how much your arms hurt— she accepted, relieving her of the weight of some bags.

—Ah… That's *much* better!

Shadow Weaver couldn't help laughing loudly this time, and kept on mocking her all the way back.

However, once the sorceress busied herself stashing everything away and setting aside some things for her councilors, Shadow Weaver traveled back to the marketplace they had visited earlier, and went to speak with the shopkeeper.

—Remember me?— she asked as soon as she reached the counter. The shop was empty, so she could freely speak with him without anyone overhearing. —I was here about an hour ago— she added.

—Of course, of course. Quite a critical woman. A difficult customer, had you bought anything— he replied, somehow more cheerful than she expected.

—I probably would be, yes. But I'm not here to buy anything, especially not in this state— she said. —I'm here because I find it… curious that you so *easily* pardoned the Head Sorceress when she owed you money— she explained.

—Ah, that? It was nothing! Is she still concerned about it?

—She agonized the whole way back— Shadow Weaver admitted, rolling her eyes.

—I imagine— he laughed.

—But I'm curious. Why would you do such a thing? It's not exactly good for the business, is it? — the woman asked with that tone of hers that is both condescending and criticizing.

—Ah, please… It's nothing. She's always very nice and gentle. A loyal customer. She even helped us once, out of pure selflessness…— he explained.

—Just because it was the right thing to do— Shadow Weaver uttered, hearing the sorceress saying it in her head.

—Precisely! That's exactly what she said!— he exclaimed, still cheerful.

—She repeats it quite a lot…

—Tell you what: Let's consider it a repayment for her help back then— he proposed. —Go tell her that so she doesn't worry anymore— he requested.

—I shall— Shadow Weaver accepted. —That will be all. Farewell.

—So long!

Looking back… Had she simply found it strange that the man was so nice to her? Or was she… *jealous*?

Ugh! How stupid.

It had been so petty of her to go back to that man, asking for explanations like that. And all because, apparently, a part of her suspected, or rather feared, that the man fancied the sorceress.

How stupid.

Stupid!

Such behaviour was unacceptable for Shadow Weaver, yet she hadn't even… *thought* about it.

It was an impulse.

An instinct.

Oh, well…

Who would have thought?

Chapter End Notes

Now you understand the status 😂

Anyways, I think this is kind of a cute chapter in a way, even if sparkled by tragic events...

I dunno, what do you think?

And again, sorry for the delay, my gods, I really almost missed the day...

Denial

Chapter Summary

A certain someone in utter denial is confronted with the truth in a way impossible to ignore. Now, like it or not, Shadow Weaver will have to admit… that she was wrong.

And while her reaction is less than ideal, the girls will still go ask for an expert's opinion on what happened.
»(…) Adora and Catra decided to take Finn with them, while leaving Melog at home, and soon arrived at Bright Moon's palace, where they asked Glimmer to call her aunt. (…)
(…)
»The girls left upon seeing the Head Sorceress arrive, and the three went to Bright Moon's gardens to speak privately.
»Catra explained to her why they went to the groove, how the conversation then changed, and how Shadow Weaver went from almost gentle to the same old Shadow Weaver from the Horde. Then Adora explained what happened the previous night, and how Finn can see the woman, somehow.
»—…That's a lot of information in one go— Castaspella began. —Oh, but first of all, it actually means exactly what she said…

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the valley of "Oh fuck, she's reverting" once more. I promise it's necessary for the plot.

Hopefully you'll like the chapter. Also, a note, you'll see I wrote the same event twice with a little difference, and that's because I accidentally wrote two versions of the same event, wanted to use one but the other made more sense in the context, and finally resolved it like you'll read it, thanks to my clone helping me figure out what to do lol

Anyways, I hope you enjoy! Happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Morning arrived soon. Castaspella woke up in a pretty uncomfortable position, her head resting on Shadow Weaver's shoulder, and couldn't help yawning.

—You're awake— the woman noticed. —On a scale from "I'm fine" to "You were right", how much does your neck hurt?

—You were right…— the sorceress grumbled, annoyed. —But I wanted… to stay here— she reminded her, interrupted by a yawn.

—Yes, and I'm still waiting for an explanation— Shadow Weaver retorted.

—Which I'm not giving you— Castaspella mockingly replied. —Now tie my hair so I can go to have breakfast— she requested.

—I should refuse until you tell me what happened, but I suppose you're too stubborn for that to work…— the woman sighed, resigned.

The Head Sorceress was still sitting on the ground, her back towards Shadow Weaver as she tied her bun, when Adora and Catra arrived at the groove.

—Oh, girls!— Castaspella exclaimed, noticing them first. —Good morning!

—Morning, Head Sorceress— they replied in unison.

—We can return later…

—No, no. It's alright, I was about to leave— Castaspella interrupted Adora, before standing up. Once she put on her crown, she turned around and thanked Shadow Weaver. —Now, goodbye!

The sorceress disappeared before they could reply, and the three of them were left alone in quite an uncomfortable silence. As it stretched on, the woman shook her head and stood up, deciding to speak first.

—Well, what brings you two here so early in the morning?

—I… Eh— Adora began, hesitant, and let out a nervous laugh while scratching the back of her neck.

—Just ask her— Catra encouraged her.

—Alright, alright— she replied, nodding. The girl took a deep breath and finally inquired —Can you tell me everything you know about the First Ones?

—The First Ones— Shadow Weaver repeated, pensive. —And why the sudden interest in your people?— the woman asked, her tone between curious and condescending.

—They are *not* my people— Adora clarified. She looked away and cleared her throat before explaining —I just… Want to know more about them because of Mara.

—The previous She-Ra.

—Yes. We are… Erm, you know the Crystal Palace, right? Where the Heart was— the girl continued. "Where you died" she almost said. Shadow Weaver nodded, and Adora told her —Well, I decided to turn it into a Temple, to commemorate Mara. To honor and remember her. But I don't have any idea how the First Ones commemorate their people.

—An interesting project— the woman admitted. —And tell me, what exactly are you planning to do?

—Well, the surrounding area will be cleaned from those vines that have covered everything— she began. —After the magic was freed, nature overgrew there, though everything is still a wreck, you know? But I think we can restore the buildings with help from Bow's dads. They know a lot about First Ones' ruins. And it has this… path of crystal that leads to the entrance that can then be decorated with pretty flowers! I saw from Light Hope's memories that Mara once brought her some, and I think Perfuma will know which those were if I describe them to her— she continued, noticeably excited. For a fleeting moment, Catra and Shadow Weaver exchanged a glance, both smirking, yet pretended it never happened. —Perhaps we can let people leave flowers there too, or something. Or, like, if Bow

or Entrapta have time, we could reprogram the holograms from the Crystal Castle to show people the history of Mara!

—It seems like you have great plans— the woman laughed. —Why, then, would you want to learn the customs of the First Ones?

—I thought it would be better for Mara…

—What do you know about her? Because, from what I've heard, she went against the wishes of her own people, did she not? She chose Etheria, I'm sure she would be pleased with an etherian commemoration— Shadow Weaver assured her, her tone strangely gentle.

—How do you know all of that?

—I've always had my sources— she replied, now sounding more ominous.

More like the Shadow Weaver they know.

—Are you sure?

—I am.

—Adora— Catra called, whispering. —Did you hear how she said it? If that isn't approval, I don't know what it is— she pointed out.

—Alright, yes. Thank you— the girl let out, smiling. —So, I guess that's all!

—Then feel free to leave… I reckon you have a lot to do.

—Just another mission in space, not much— Catra replied, folding her arms with a smug expression.

—In space?— she repeated, surprised. —And tell me, Catra. How exactly do you plan on protecting yourself?

—What?

—How… will you… protect yourself?— she repeated, slower, taking a step closer.

—What do you mean by "how"?

—What if Adora isn't there to help you?— she began, as the lights of the groove started to dim. —What if your *pet* isn't there to help you?— she went on, stepping closer as the bright floating spores faded. —How will you face the *darkness of space* on your own?— she concluded, completely surrounding the girl with her illusionary shadows.

—I-I…— Catra stammered, eyes closed. —You can't hurt me, you can't— she muttered. —I… can *do it*!— she finally yelled, opening her eyes again.

A bright illusionary beast suddenly leaped forward, a fanged creature Adora had occasionally seen around the planet, and literally crushed the shadows around her. It was a magical projection, and the caster… was Catra. In all her rage and frustration, she had manifested an animal form instead of turning into it, which meant it could interact with other magical manifestations like Shadow Weaver's illusions.

—What is this!?— the woman asked, stepping back as she observed the projection with a mix of fear and reverence. —Impossible.

The lights returned to normal around the groove, and the illusionary beast faded along with Catra's rage. Now she was simply hurt.

Adora immediately took her hand and gave her a reassuring look before addressing Shadow Weaver.

—I will *always* be by her side— she began. —Don't ever doubt that. But if I weren't, it's time you accept Catra *can* protect herself. She's stronger than you ever gave her credit for…

—I can… see that— the woman let out, as if the illusion were still in front of her eyes.

Pushing back her sorrow, Catra managed to reproach her —So what!? Only *now* will you admit I'm not mediocre!?

—I shouldn't have…

—What!?— she insisted, on the brink of tears, which made Adora place her free hand on her shoulder to comfort her. —Say it…

—I had heard… you were learning magic… I shouldn't have dismissed it…— she finally admitted.

The girls exchanged a surprised look for a moment, then looked back at a conflicted Shadow Weaver.

Inevitably hopeful, Catra asked —But?

—I was so sure I would have known if you had magical potential…

Expected. The girl knew she would say that. So she gathered all her confidence before speaking up again.

—It appears you just saw what you wanted to see…

—Didn't I?— she laugh bitterly. —I could hear it… that you were training with Micah. Even before, I heard when you told Castaspella about it… I always knew but refused to… believe it.

—Now you can't deny it— Catra sentenced. —And you can't subdue me with your shadows anymore.

—I wasn't trying to…— she began, but interrupted herself with a sigh. —Forget it.

—We must go— Adora decided. —Don't do that again. Ever— she warned Shadow Weaver.

—I… will try not to…

—That's enough— Catra sighed, looking down. Coming from her, yes, it was enough. —Let's go.

Everything was fuzzy. The girl felt confused as her ears adjusted to the sounds around her, and for a moment she could only focus on the bright spores floating around her.

She was in the magical groove.

Turning around, Adora was there, awkwardly talking to Shadow Weaver who was just a few steps away from them.

—Alright, I… Thank you— the girl let out, smiling. —However, I would still like to know whatever you can tell me about the First Ones.

—I would tell you, but… only to you— the woman decided.

—Hey!

—Why can't Catra hear it!?

—Because I say so.

—What's with the mean attitude all of a sudden!?— the girl complained, taking a few steps forward before Adora could stop her, hands tightly closed in fists. —What? Had a moment of softness and needed to compensate for it by being a bitch again!?

The lights in the groove suddenly dimmed. The magical spores gradually faded, and illusionary shadows surrounded the girls. Adora took a fighting stance, ready to turn into She-Ra if necessary, while Catra closed her eyes a moment and reminded herself the woman can't hurt her. Not anymore.

—I do not owe you answers— Shadow Weaver seethed.

—This is bullshit! You're just doing this on purpose!— Catra exclaimed, opening her eyes again. Frowning, she added —We know you have a heart so, for fuck's sake, grow a backbone and stop drowning it!

A bright illusionary beast suddenly leaped forward, a fanged creature often seen roaming around Etheria, which literally crushed all the illusionary shadows…

—Ah!

—Catra?— Adora asked, groggy.

The girls sat up on the bed, Finn now awake between them too, but for a moment neither said a word. Catra was sweating terribly and gasping for air, which made it obvious to Adora that she had a nightmare, yet she wouldn't dare ask what it was.

Instead, she gave her time.

—Why did she do it!?— she suddenly yelled. —It was going so well! With-with that apology and all! So *why*!?

—Ca-Catra…

—Tell me the truth, Adora. Am I doing something wrong!?

—No, no, no. Not at all!

—Then what happened back there!?

—I think she just… Eh… No, I don't know what happened to her… That was awful— Adora admitted, giving up. —But it was entirely on her, not you. Alright?

—Alright— Catra accepted, taking a deep breath.

She closed her eyes for a moment and calmed herself down, until Finn spoke up.

—Ghost Lady!

—What?

The girls exchanged a surprised look and stared at Finn, who crawled towards the feet of the bed.

—It… must be…

—She's here!?— Catra interrupted.

—Whe-where are you going, baby?— Adora asked Finn, realizing they were trying to get off the bed with help from Melog.

Speechless, they observed as their kid managed to reach the ground and started crawling towards the corner where their drawings lay all over the floor. Wailing happily and occasionally letting out a brief but loud laugh, Finn reached for a crayon and clumsily started drawing.

Curious, the girls approached and realized Finn was "drawing" letters.

After a few moments, Catra read aloud —"I'm sorry"?

—No way…

—Is Shadow Weaver seriously teaching Finn how to write!? For this!?

—Wait, wait, there's more…— Adora realized. —"I was…" what?— she anxiously read.

—"Wo…"

—"Worried"— she finally read out, immediately looking back at Catra.

—It actually says… Never mind— she sighed. —Well, I guess Finn can't really write for now. But… Um… I'm even more confused now— she admitted.

—Well, why don't we, eh, go ask the Head Sorceress for a… *translation* of what happened at the groove?

—Oh, yeah. That sorceress is the only person on the whole planet who can understand Shadow Weaver— Catra agreed, pressing her temples. —Now…— she began, picking up Finn. —Time to go back to sleep— she sentenced, returning to the bed and carefully placing Finn on the mattress. Gently, she told them —Tell "Ghost Lady" to let you sleep, alright?

She then followed Finn's line of sight and stared for a moment, controlling her breath.

—Ghost Lady, sleep— the baby repeated.

—Good kitten— she let out, patting their head.

Morning soon arrived, and the girls had a quick breakfast before leaving the house. They decided to take Finn with them, while leaving Melog at home, and soon arrived at Bright Moon's palace, where they asked Glimmer to call her aunt. Until her arrival, the Best Friends Squad discussed the matter for a moment, as the Queen and Bow were curious.

—She… You mean- What you're saying is she can see your house!? And you three!?— Glimmer asked, shocked.

—And she's probably listening to this conversation now. Something about me and Adora being together in the same place.

—But…— Adora added. —The weird part is that Finn can see her too!

—So that's how they wrote that… uh, message— Bow reflected.

—We don't know what she did, but yeah.

—You said Finn can see her illusions, so maybe something with that?

—Perhaps— Catra agreed. —Anyways. You guys take care of Finn while we speak with your aunt, yes?— she requested, carefully passing them to Bow.

—Sure! Whatever we can do to help.

—Oh, and maybe we can eat later! Seeing how we're here…— Adora suggested.

—Of course!— Glimmer nodded. —You have to tell us more about the projection thing.

—I will— she accepted.

The girls left upon seeing the Head Sorceress arrive, and the three went to Bright Moon's gardens to speak privately.

Catra explained to her why they went to the groove, how the conversation then changed, and how Shadow Weaver went from almost gentle to the same old Shadow Weaver from the Horde. Then Adora explained what happened the previous night, and how Finn can see the woman, somehow.

—…That's a lot of information in one go— Castaspella began. —Oh, but first of all, it actually means exactly what she said: she was worried— she began, smiling at them, looking too cheery for the girls' taste. —I imagine it was… more terrifying than anything else but, actually, this isn't the first time she has expressed her concern in the… *worst* way possible— she explained, looking away for a moment. —Remember that time before she was dismissed, when she was, uh, annoying you all as you prepared a mission here in Bright Moon?

—That time she kept criticizing our plans?— Adora asked.

—That time Glimmer told her to fuck off?— Catra clarified.

—Yes— Castaspella sighed, pressing her lips together to hold back a laugh. —She was being quite annoying, of course, but she admitted to me that, in fact, she was concerned for your safety— she explained. Then, looking away and with a lower tone, she added —But the idiot is too stubborn to say it.

—She is…

—In any case…— the sorceress went on, clearing her throat. —I believe the same happened here. It was completely unnecessary to scare you like that, but if her words really were "how will you protect yourself?", then at least this time she was making emphasis on your safety!

—You mean she could have worded it worse!?— Adora exclaimed, incredulous.

—Of course! Years ago she would have said something like "you can't face the darkness of space alone" or "you're not prepared or good enough to carry out that mission", or some other bullshit that sounds mean enough that you wouldn't even *suspect* she's worried deep inside— Castaspella exemplified.

—Are you *serious*!?

—That did sound a lot like her— Catra admitted.

—But… it's not *that difficult* to say "I'm worried you'll get hurt"!— Adora argued.

—For *us*. But for her it's… agonizing, it seems— the sorceress sighed.

—It's insane…

—I know… I won't try to justify it, but I'm glad you asked me for an explanation. Understanding why she does the things she does will help you both be less affected by these… unfortunate outbursts of hers— Castaspella told them, giving them a gentle look.

—Thank you, Head Sorceress— Catra sighed, eyes closed. —In fact, it does help.

And how much…

This meant Catra *wasn't* doing anything wrong as she feared, but rather, that she was doing things right.

Right enough that the woman had softened just the tiniest bit.

It gave the girl some peace of mind, she visibly relaxed, and let out a sigh with a relieved expression.

Later, after their meal together, Catra left her friends to go speak with king Micah about what happened with her powers.

—…I'm not sure how it happened, like, I don't know what I did. I just know I was very stressed and felt the need to protect myself— she explained.

—From?

—Nothing relevant, just… something that felt dangerous.

—Well, it's great progress— the King said, quite glad. —It means we should now focus on activating that power at will— he explained, pensive. —Your powers don't require sigils to be used, which has complicated everything, especially this. But you *can* do it, so we just have to find out how *you* cast.

—We said it's all emotional, so this checks out— Catra reminded him.

—Of course, and for us, it's the same. But we channel those emotions by means of the sigils, while you have to do so… erm… mentally— he reflected. —Look, here's how I cast an illusion like that— he said, moving his hands to draw a sigil that made a light-blue ram appear next to him. The fleeting memory of him crushing Light Spinner's illusion with it, only to be crushed right after by her phoenix made Micah flinch, but he simply shook his head and the smile returned to his face. —I focus on the form, keep my emotions in check so it won't get out of control, and use the sigil to command it— he explained.

Although Catra noticed the change in his expression, she preferred to ignore it and focus on his demonstration. Indeed, she didn't need those sigils, everything was her force of will alone.

—So, how do I focus if not with a sigil?

—How have you done so until now?

—I read… Well, from what the Head Sorceress taught me, magic requires one to fully focus and mentally prepare so that any emotions I might feel won't affect what I do— she replied. —So I've been paying attention to how I feel, keeping it under control, and then willingly using it to shape-shift when I need— she explained. —But it wasn't working to project an animal form instead of simply turning myself into it— she added.

—Well, with training your prowess increases, so maybe you just… eh… need more practice?— he suggested. —When I was about fourteen I could already cast these illusions— he began, dismissing the ram. —But, in my case, I did it instinctively. I didn't know the theory of magic that I later studied. I watched others draw the sigil and then copied it— he went on, with the same cheerfulness Catra had seen in his sister. —But we can't do that with you, so the best I can recommend is that you recall the event that triggered your projection and focus on the feelings. Eventually, you'll manage to channel the magic with more ease.

—I… don't think I want to recall it— the girl admitted, hugging herself. —It was… unnerving— she let out.

—Oh, right— the King sighed, ashamedly looking away. —I should have… known.

—But I'll see what I do next time we train. I should return with my friends now— she finally said, feeling a bit nervous. —Um… Thanks.

With that, the girl left and Micah found himself alone with his thoughts.

He couldn't help but wonder what it was that triggered her powers, but it seemed to have affected her greatly. That made him think that, if she didn't want to tell him, it was probably related to Shadow Weaver, but he couldn't understand why she wouldn't say it.

Perhaps because she feared his reaction?

Probably… And that was his fault.

The King sighed, feeling guilty, and decided to drop the subject. He needed to stop thinking about this before he did something he would later regret.

Chapter End Notes

Notes: The animal that Catra projected looks like the orange and red one in this picture:



Unfortunately, it has no name and no way of being described without using references that make no sense in Etheria's world. So better the visual, no?

Also, post-traumatic syndrome goes brrrr.

Hehe, until next week it is!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: You learnt, you're different, but you're still yourself
Status: under careful review…
…80% accepted…

Chapter Notes

Well, so, I decided to add what SW did after the girls left, and show the apology sequence from her POV too
Originally, the chapter started with "She heard them" and the rest remains the same, but everything before "She heard them all" was added for your sake, as some of you wanted to know how the heck SW made Finn write the apology, and why.

Anyways, I hope you enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Great. Just *great*.

As the girls would say: she fucked up, *again*.

The feeling of guilt revolving within her was nauseating. Shadow Weaver wanted to rip her chest open and crush her heart with her own hands. But what heart? What chest? She wasn't even alive yet feeling… feeling *like this*!

Ignore it.

She could only ignore the feeling until, with any luck, it disappeared.

But it wouldn't go away, and before she could think about it, she was seeing the girls' house. For a moment, it reminded her of when she'd go watch the girls sleep in the Horde. Back then, it was because she believed they stayed up all night, affecting their performance the following day, but they were always asleep as the obedient cadets they were.

This time, she watched them sleep because she had the feeling things weren't right. Perhaps she was being egocentric, but she firmly believed Catra was just as affected as she was, but in the exact opposite way.

Seeing the girl asleep, she told herself it was all her imagination, indeed, she was being egocentric. But suddenly, there was a loud cry and Catra violently woke up. Shocked, the woman only observed until the girl herself confirmed her suspicions.

And it was a good question: why did she do it?

Just like Adora, she had no idea… But she didn't need the girl to say how it was only her fault. Of course it was, she knew it well.

Perhaps it was guilt, perhaps it was something else, something Shadow Weaver refused to acknowledge… whatever it was, it made the woman decide she had to apologize, much as she hated it.

But how!? They would probably avoid the groove for now, wouldn't they?

So how, how…

The little kid sitting in the middle of the bed gave her the perfect idea when they called out that silly nickname.

Of course!

It was worth a shot…

Resolved, Beatrix created an illusion to attract little Finn, who took quite a while to reach the corner of the room where she was standing. But once there, she only had to carefully indicate them what to do. First, she pointed at a random crayon, then dragged her fingers across the sheets of paper, leaving marks with her illusions, and beckoned the kid to draw that.

Saying they were sloppy would be an insult to Castaspella's sloppiness. No, the kid was *very* messy and wrote "worryed" instead, but at least they got the message.

And before they went back to sleep, the moment Catra looked her way following Finn's sight, she couldn't hold her stare, even though she knew the girl couldn't really see her. Much to her later consternation, she lowered her head, ashamed, and left…

The following day, which took an eternity to arrive, Beatrix couldn't help paying attention to their conversations.

She heard them all.

When they discussed with Castaspella and she explained to them how Shadow Weaver's mind works…

When Catra refused to tell Micah what triggered her powers…

It surprised her greatly to realize the girls actually *want* to understand her instead of thinking she's still the monster they knew. Perhaps because they never saw her as a monster? Or rather, because they always wanted to believe she had a heart?

In any case, it made her recall that one time Castaspella told her that she'd be a monster if, knowing now what she did is wrong, she simply walked away like nothing happened.

That was the only time she ever threatened with dismissing the woman herself.

> —…I will *not* tolerate you talking to me like that!— the woman was yelling, just as Castaspella passed by.
>
> She was towering over a trembling acolyte, furious, until she felt a hand grab onto her arm. Suddenly shaken awake from her blind rage, she stepped back, albeit still fuming.

—That's enough! Come here!— the sorceress ordered, dragging Shadow Weaver away. —Calm down, alright?— she gently said. —Whatever he did is *not* worth reacting like this…

However, before they could leave, the acolyte spoke up.

—Wh-why are you- Are you blaming *me* for this!?— he asked, having heard her.

—No…

—Why are you protecting *her* when she attacked *me*!?— he interrupted.

—You are unhurt, Acolyte. So you should leave now, and *I* will deal with her. Understood?

—What will you do?— he questioned her.

—That's none of your business. She's *my* responsibility, not yours— Castaspella sentenced, severe, and decided to take Shadow Weaver away before the acolyte could challenge her again. —Come with me…— she ordered again.

—What if I don't want to?— she defied her, mostly wanting to test her.

—You are coming with me, and I'm *not* accepting your teasing or mocking this time— the sorceress countered, dragging her to a more secluded place.

However, the woman yanked her arm out of her grip, insisting —You can't make me, nor can you stop me from walking away…

The woman did, in fact, try to leave, but Castaspella grabbed her arm again, tight enough that she could feel her touch.

—If you don't come with me, I will go to the Lunarium right this instant and dismiss your summoning spell. Am I clear?— she threatened.

—You wouldn't…

—I am *not* letting you escape again— the sorceress sentenced, more serious than ever.

Right, "escape again"… Meaning like when she died. Of course.

—Why?

—You *have* to start assuming responsibility for your actions. Before *and after* your death— she replied. —And either you do, or I will dismiss you permanently.

—You wouldn't. You *need me*— the woman defied her again.

—Oh, trust me. I would rather make mistakes I could have avoided with your help than allow you to keep being a *literal bitch* with everyone around you!

—So now you plan on blackmailing me with that?— Shadow Weaver asked, raising a brow, incredulous.

—It's not that— she denied, shaking her head while looking down, seemingly disappointed. —I understand you used to think you were doing the right thing but, now, you're actually learning to distinguish right from wrong. So, if you choose to walk away like that, *knowing* what you just

did is wrong, I will have to understand you are really a monster who refuses to become better. And again, I am *not* going to let you be around anymore if that's the case— she explained.

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh.

Well, she'll be damned… The sorceress was right.

It was so *annoying*.

—Fine, as you wish— she finally accepted. However, as they walked away to wherever Castaspella wanted to take her, Shadow Weaver couldn't help smirking and teasing —That was quite bold of you, Cas…

—What? Are you impressed?— the Head Sorceress asked back, smirking too.

—Perhaps…

—Good. I meant every word, so you better take it seriously— she said with a proud stance as she continued walking.

—I do, I do…

So, maybe, apologizing for what she did was proof of her progress?

Hah! That sorceress was so glad to hear it. She felt it…

And how not? She had changed so much since that event; she could barely believe it herself.

In fact, she could hardly recognize herself now. That was *not* Shadow Weaver anymore. Or was it?

No… The Shadow Weaver everyone knew would have never…

So, could it be said that what Castaspella wanted was to make her a different person?

No, she once said she didn't want her to change, but rather become better…

But, wouldn't that mean being less like herself and more like the Head Sorceress?

Being honest, she could *never* be like Castaspella, so of course not. But, still, she no longer seemed Shadow Weaver either.

Yes, she was still cocky, smug, condescending… But, doesn't she *care* now?

She's still violent, aggressive, dismissive, but now she doesn't *want to*…

And, this time, she's not trying to walk away like nothing happened…

Chapter End Notes

Oh gods, this is the last chapter I had already loaded here to post...
Fortunately, I finished next chapter just yesterday! And I have the next flashback too, so I have 2

weeks to write the following chapter...

Oh gods, just two weeks...

ANYWAYS I hope you liked it and thank you for reading!! <3

Marriage

Chapter Summary

With the passage of time, the moment for important, life-changing decisions comes.
The Best Friends Squad aren't kids anymore, years have gone by, and they have grown into adults, with their respective responsibilities.
So now might be the right time to take things to the next level, right?

»Adora was wearing a long white dress with golden details and a diadem, her hair loose and a long white cape. Next to her, arm in arm, Catra wore a red shirt, black pants, a white and golden jacket, black fingerless gloves, and her long hair tied up.
»In parallel, Bow and Glimmer wore matching outfits, light blue capes and new undercuts, the Queen with a pink dress with golden details, and Bow with a pink shirt under a white and golden jacket, and black pants.
»Nobody knew, but they had become what Adora saw in that beautiful dream that Prime used to trap her. The girl almost cried when she realized the beautiful future she had seen wasn’t an unreachable dream, but rather her current reality.
»It had become true.

Chapter Notes

So, I'm posting this pretty early, it's just midnight here, because it will be a very loaded day for me…
In any case, I'm really excited to post this chapter so, all the more reasons!

I hope you enjoy the chapter! Happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The girl brushed her hair back while taking a deep breath, nervous.

—Come on, you can do it— Catra said. She sighed deeply and began saying —Adora, would you like to…

—Catra?

—Ah!

The girl jumped back as she turned around to find Adora behind her, who giggled as she saw Catra's hair standing on end for a moment before she calmed down.

—Sorry, I didn't mean to scare you— she said. —I thought I heard you calling me. Did you have anything to tell me?

—I…— she began, but interrupted herself to clear her throat and take another deep breath. —Yeah…

—So do I!— Adora smiled. —What is it?

—I, well… I just… Um…

Catra's hesitation made the girl a bit impatient, and she couldn't hold back, blurting out the words right as Catra gathered the strength to say it too.

—Would you like to marry me!?— they both exclaimed at the same time.

Right after, they let out an amused laugh.

—I didn't think…

—I thought you…

They were speaking simultaneously again, so Catra paused and gestured at Adora to speak first.

—I'm sorry, I got excited— she apologized.

—I was really nervous…

—I can’t believe we had the same idea— Adora laughed.

—So you also thought proposing on Finn's birthday was the best idea? And here I thought I was being original— Catra mocked her.

—I thought it'd be romantic— she shyly replied.

—Oh… I- Well, yeah.

They both laughed again and stepped closer to embrace each other.

—So, I'll take it that you accept?

Catra immediately nodded, saying —Of course, silly.

Adora couldn't hold back the tears of joy as she kissed her, and even after breaking the kiss, they stayed in each other's arms, smiling lovingly.

—So… wanna plan our little rascal's birthday?

—Yeah, let's do that— Adora agreed, giggling.

Later that day, when Glimmer and Bow showed up at the small gathering with the princesses to celebrate Finn’s birthday, the Best Friends Squad sat together to discuss the news.

—You both proposed at the same time!?— the Queen exclaimed, laughing. —Eh, it doesn’t surprise me… With how competitive you both are— she further stated, giggling.

—It wasn’t on purpose, Sparkles— Catra pointed out.

—Let's not waste time with that, guys— Bow interrupted. —Now we should focus on planning the wedding, don't you think?— he reminded them. —Oh, I'm so happy for you guys!— he added, eyes almost sparkling.

—Bow, you look more excited about this than us— Adora laughed.

—It *is* exciting!— he emphasized, gesturing with his hands.

The three girls chuckled, amused, and Glimmer commented —You're acting like Auntie.

—Don't say it like it's something bad…

—It isn't!— she quickly denied. —But am I wrong? I'm sure she'll react like that when she hears the news.

—Speaking of her…— Catra said. —How is she doing? For the past two weeks your father has completely avoided speaking of her, you know?

—Really? How odd… She's doing pretty fine and hasn't argued with Dad lately— Glimmer replied.

—Oh, that's good to know— Adora sighed. —We've… been meaning to visit but we've been busy with the restoration work of the villages and the Crystal Castle.

—Of course, guys! Don't worry about that. She'll be glad if you drop by sometime, but there's no rush, alright?

—And… did you mean the "Temple of Mara"?— Bow jokingly said.

—Ah, yes. I-I really need to get used to that— Adora timidly replied.

—Perhaps by the time it's done you'll get it right— Catra mocked her, smirking.

—Hey!

—It was a good decision, Adora. I'm sure Mara would have loved it— Glimmer told her, knowing how much the girl still doubts it.

—Yes! With everything you have planned for it, we know it will look awesome!— Bow supported. —With the buildings restored, the flowers decorating outside, and the vines gone, it will look so beautiful— he went on, until an idea struck him. —Perfect to celebrate a wedding there— he told them, his tone musical.

—What?

—Wait, that's… not a bad idea— Adora reflected.

—What!?— Catra and Glimmer exclaimed.

—Love, that's gonna take months to finish.

—And it's in the middle of the Woods!— the Queen pointed out. —With all those magical beasts roaming around, don't you think it would be a bit dangerous?

—Of course not! They aren't dangerous…

—Unless you scare them— Catra reminded her.

—Guys, I just like Bow's idea. We have all the time in the world to plan this. So… perhaps we decide on something else later on, who knows?— Adora reflected. —I just want it to be a happy ceremony, that we both can enjoy.

—Yeah… We have time. I-I don't really care where it's done. But, if you really wanna go with the Temple, then get ready to wait like… half a year.

—Catra is right. We estimate it will take between five and six months to finish all the renovations— Bow assured them.

—If that's what she wants, I suppose the wait will be worth it. And, as she said: we have all the time in the world— Glimmer concluded.

Two days later, the Queen had gathered a group of wedding planners from different kingdoms of Etheria to start planning the wedding based on the blueprints of the Temple. Led by Castaspella, of course, the team would craft the perfect celebration, start gathering the necessary funds, and prepare the lists of guests with their respective invitations.

Two months later they had the first draft ready to be presented, yet it had to be delayed, for the Best Friends Squad were on a mission in space. The past three days, they had been coursing the galaxy until they found another planet ravaged by Prime's forces, but were surprised to find its population remained.

From what they gathered, they were all chipped and working for Prime, providing resources, until his fall a few years before. So they surely were glad to meet their saviours, right?

Not really…

Catra was sustaining a projected beast to protect them four from the attacks, while Glimmer helped Adora who was on the ground, out of breath.

—I can't… go on… without hurting them!— she let out, gasping for air.

—We know, Adora, don't worry— Bow immediately replied, while shooting net and gooey arrows.

—Sparkles! Get us out!

—Come closer!

After a moment of hesitation, Catra let the projection fall and jumped towards them, holding Melog between her arms. They immediately disappeared in a puff of pink sparkles, right before the attackers reached them, and appeared inside Darla, welcomed by absolute silence.

Now they all gasped for air, their hearts racing.

—That was close!— Catra exclaimed, falling on her back.

Closing her eyes, Adora let out a long sigh, feeling more recovered, and said —I'm sorry I couldn't protect us…

—Don't worry, Adora, you did your best— Bow assured her, with a gentle expression. Right after, he looked back at Glimmer to check on her and noticed she was in shock, staring at a single point on the ground. —Are you alright, Love?

His concern made the girls glance back at the Queen too, right in time to see her look up at him and ask, almost yelling, —Bow, would you marry me!?

Silence.

For a long moment, no one said a word, until he hesitantly uttered —Erm…

But he didn't know what to say, and the atmosphere became tense.

Whispering, Adora asked Catra —Where did that come from?

—I-if you need a minute, ju-just sit down and rest— Bow finally said, suddenly reacting and taking Glimmer's hands with a gentle smile. —We're safe here.

—I-I'm fine! I'm *more* than fine!— the Queen blurted out.

—You… mean it?— Bow stammered in disbelief.

Glimmer didn't know if he meant whether she was fine or her proposal, but still, she smiled and assured him —Yeah! I do!

His expression changed to a fond look, and he pulled her closer, accepting —Of course, Glim…

—Ah!— she squealed, immediately jumping to hug him.

—Well, damn. Congrats, you two!— Catra let out, giving Adora an amused look as she helped her sit up.

—Great! Now we can have a double wedding!— Adora joked.

—Yes!

The three of them looked back at Glimmer once again, shocked like before.

—I-I was joking…

—But it's a great idea!

—You really…— Bow began, but she interrupted him.

—Of course! You guys, we just *survived* a full-on attack! It's the first time since defeating Prime!— she pointed out. —They were so brainwashed, it was like fighting the chipped all over again! It made me realize so much…

—Well, that's true— Adora admitted.

—You are serious about this…— Catra realized, expression conflicted.

—Think about it! We can make it a great event!— the Queen excitedly proposed. —We deserve it! And I know that's what the people need!

Conflict resolved, the girl immediately denied —But it should be for *us*, not for them!

—It can be for both!

—I see you're really excited, Love— Bow began with a sigh. He then looked back at Adora and Catra and said —I don't see why we couldn't do a double wedding, but only if you both agree.

—I'm totally in— Adora replied, before glancing back at Catra with a questioning look.

—I…— the girl began, hesitant. She liked the idea too, but not the part about making it for *the people*. Sighing resignedly, she insisted —It sounds fun, yeah… but I want it to be *our* day, alright?

Well, it was a reasonable request.

Looking away, ashamed, Glimmer said —I understand. We don't have to make it a double wedding if you rather the day be special for you two…

—No, no, I meant- I mean "our day" as in, for *us four*! I get it, you're the Queen, the people are your priority, but… I just…— Catra clarified, hesitating a bit.

Bow let out an understanding smile and placed a hand on Catra's shoulder as he assured her —We get it. Don't worry. It will be.

Now recovered, Adora managed to stand up without help and rushed to hug Glimmer, then pulled in Bow too.

—Congrats, guys!

Happily laughing, the four of them prepared everything to depart before the angry people of the planet found them, and finally returned to Etheria.

—Ah!— Castaspella squealed, exactly like Glimmer did. She hugged her niece tightly, congratulating her —At long last! This is wonderful news!

—Thank you, Auntie.

—You need to tell me *all* about the proposal. Who was it? How was it?— she asked, after releasing Glimmer.

—Oh, I… I proposed, and I think it was a bit shocking. I just… blurted it out— the Queen told her, blushing a bit.

—Aw, I would have loved to be there— the sorceress replied, delighted. —How long had you been planning on proposing? Tell me the truth.

—Actually… I didn't plan it, I just…— she began, looking away, and interrupted herself with a nervous giggle. —We had just escaped an awful situation, we were attacked, and I thought we wouldn't… make it. I was- it made me rethink everything, and so I… did it— she explained.

Castaspella was covering her mouth, shocked, and hugged her once again.

—Oh, Dear. I'm glad you're fine— she began. —And even if it was in the heat of the moment, I'm sure it was the right decision. I know you two will be very happy— she continued, looking at her with a fond expression.

—Thanks, Auntie— she replied, her eyes watery. But then it occurred to her —Oh, I still have to tell Dad…

—I thought you already had…

—I have to tell Dad!— the Queen repeated. —Oh, no… how will I do it!? He'll go nuts!

—Glimmer, just tell him like you told me!

—No, no. He'll hunt Bow down!

—Wha-what!? No, why would he?— the Head Sorceress asked, confused.

—You know Dad still sees me as his baby girl, I just *know* he will go berserk.

—Don't think like that, Dear. I'm sure he'll be happy for you!

—I don't know…

—Tell you what: why don't I accompany you? And if he does react badly, I'll just knock some sense into him— Castaspella proposed, giggling a bit.

—Speaking seriously, I'd really welcome the help, yeah— Glimmer replied, looking down.

—Alright— the sorceress sighed. —Whenever you're ready.

—Thank you.

—Now! We have more plans to make, don't we!?— Castaspella exclaimed, excited. —We'll present you with this first plan we did, and then we'll add everything to make it a double wedding as you want.

—Oh, right! You had a draft plan to show us!

—Yes, we do! Now, let's go!— the Head Sorceress rushed her.

After another four months, just as anticipated, the Temple of Mara had been restored to its former glory. The past few weeks, Perfuma and her people had been decorating the place with those flowers Adora described from Light Hope's memory and, between Bow and Entrapta, they reprogrammed the holograms of the temple which finally worked as intended. The Project was a success.

So, that night, when the Head Sorceress arrived at the groove, the topic of the imminent marriages took over their conversation.

—Why is it that you don't look as excited as you were the past few months?— Shadow Weaver suddenly asked, her tone suspicious.

—Is it that obvious?

—For me, yes.

—Ugh, fine— she grunted. —You see… today we were discussing the final details with Glimmer, the ceremony is just a week away, and she told me *I* have to officiate! Well, not "have to", but she wants me to officiate and insists I have the same authority as any of the princesses. And, normally she should be the one to officiate, as she's the Queen, she can't do so for her *own wedding*!— Castaspella ranted.

—Are you done? I think you forgot to breathe again…

—Shut up, this is serious! I can't do this!

—Why not?

—I've never done it!

—Who officiates weddings in Mystacor now? Because, when I lived there, and until… I killed him, Norwyn did— Shadow Weaver commented, slightly ashamed, which she tried to dissimulate with a nonchalant tone.

—Your shamelessness knows no boundaries— the sorceress let out between her teeth before raising her tone again. —The couples choose who officiates. It can be a member of the council or the Queen of Etheria. In the past forty years, they have always picked the Queen.

—I see. But, Glimmer has a point. You *are* an authority like any of the princesses. Be a bit prouder and behave like the queen of Mystacor you're supposed to be.

—What!?

Castaspella let out a loud laugh and bent forward, holding her belly as she couldn't stop laughing.

—I'm serious. Or is the crown just decorative?

—Don't mess with me. I'm just the head of the Guild, not the queen of the kingdom!

—As the head of the Guild, you rule over the *kingdom*, as you just said. And what do we call the rulers of a kingdom? Queen, king, prince or princess. I believe "queen" fits you better than "princess". Unless you prefer to match titles with your brother…

Castaspella blinked in surprise, and stared at her, blushing furiously.

—Wha-what do you mean? "Fits me"?

—It's just an opinion. Don't give it much thought.

—I-in any case: whether I have the authority to do it or not doesn't matter. I have never officiated a wedding, so I have no idea what to do. And I can't learn how to do it in just a week!

—Want to bet on it?

—Huh?— Castaspella let out, raising a brow.

—I know exactly what Norwyn did back then, and the proper lines should be recorded in some book in the Archives.

—Are you offering to teach me!?

—If you rather let Glimmer down…

—Don’t be a bitch now, you don’t have to be so condescending with me. I won’t shame you for doing something nice, but shame on you for being a coward and hiding it behind your wicked speech.

—If my speech is so *wicked* according to you, why are you still listening to me?

—Because I see through it.

—You’re insufferable.

—If I’m so insufferable, why do you put up with me?— Castaspella asked with a smirk.

—Now you use my own words against me?

—You opened the door…

—Well, if so you want, I’ll tell you exactly why, Cas— she began. —As I’ve said before, you can be quite entertaining for me. But, of course, there’s the tiny detail of you being the bearer of the summoning spell that gives me a solid magical body, and the fact that no one else has the guts to bicker with me like you do.

—You know what? Forget it…

—Now what did I say?

—You’re still being a jerk!— Castaspella complained, aiming to leave. —If you’re so stubborn you can’t accept you *like* my company, then I rather leave!

—Wait!

Shadow Weaver grabbed her by the wrist and stopped her.

—What?

She couldn't let this happen again, could she? So why not be honest this time? Regret tastes more bitter than expected.

—Fine. I admit I enjoy your company.

—So you want me to stay?—Castaspella asked, smirking. —I won’t stay unless you say it.

—Ugh. Yes. I… want you to stay.

—And you want to teach me how to officiate a wedding?— the Head Sorceress pressed on.

—Yes— Shadow Weaver uttered, rolling her eyes. —Is that enough?

—For your sake, yes— she giggled.

Finally…

The woman let out a sigh and pulled Castaspella a few steps back before sitting down with her.

That night, she explained to the sorceress precisely what the ceremony implied, the different steps she should follow, and gave her instructions to find the book with the speeches she would have to pronounce.

The subsequent nights were spent carefully practicing every step of the ceremony until Castaspella was ready.

—I'll be there listening, so if you fuck up, I won't let you hear the end of it— Shadow Weaver told her, the night before the weddings.

—How supportive of you…— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes. —But you *better* be there, don't let the girls down again.

—I doubt they would want me there if I were visible…

—You keep misjudging them, you know?

—Forget it and go to sleep now— the woman insisted.

—Alright, alright… I should. Tomorrow will be a long day— Castaspella admitted, letting out a yawn.

Early the next day, people from all kingdoms were rushing to finish preparing the Temple of Mara for the ceremony. The way they ran up and down reminded the Head Sorceress of Glimmer's coronation day.

Soon, everything was ready. The couples were about to arrive, so everyone took a seat at each side of the Crystal path leading to the entrance of the Temple. Before long, everyone looked back and saw the Best Friends Squad arrive.

Adora was wearing a long white dress with golden details and a diadem, her hair loose and a long white cape. Next to her, arm in arm, Catra wore a red shirt, black pants, a white and golden jacket, black fingerless gloves, and her long hair tied up.

In parallel, Bow and Glimmer wore matching outfits, light blue capes and new undercuts, the Queen with a pink dress with golden details, and Bow with a pink shirt under a white and golden jacket, and black pants.

Nobody knew, but they had become what Adora saw in that beautiful dream that Prime used to trap her. The girl almost cried when she realized the beautiful future she had seen wasn't an unreachable dream, but rather her current reality.

It had become true.

Oh, but she was so overwhelmed she nearly missed a step when they walked down the crystal path towards the improvised, but not less elegant, altar. Catra caught her subtly enough that no one noticed Adora had tripped, and smiled gently at her, reassuringly.

It was time.

—Everyone, be welcome!— Castaspella began, once the couples stopped before her. She gave them a proud look, both hands joined in front of her, barely able to contain her excitement. —We have gathered today to celebrate…

Chapter End Notes

SO
This chapter is dedicated to AO3 user RainbowLake for the idea of them marrying at the Temple of Mara!!

Btw, the part about SW not wanting it to "happen again", referring to Casta leaving offended because of her behaving like a bitch, will be clearer in the next chapter as it's a flashback related to that <("^_^) hehe

It was just a coincidence, which I realized when rereading this, so I thought I'd clarify that…

ANYWAYS! I hope you enjoyed, and see you next week! Thank you for reading!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Excessive ignorance, deliberate ignorance, is indistinguishable from malice
Status: Reloading…
…
Rebooting… loading…
…
Process ended unexpectedly|

Chapter Notes

I COMPLETELY FORGOT TODAY WAS WEDNESDAY! SORRY! I ALMOST DIDN'T POST!
Now the actual chapter note:

The lesson could have perfectly applied for the last flashback if I'm totally honest...

But, as it was already posted and this one needed a lesson, then the choice was simple...

Now, now, why the "Process ended unexpectedly"? Simple, because it kinda did.
I was writing and suddenly lost the idea. I was writing "The point was", got interrupted, and literally lost the point. So my brilliant idea was: SW lost the point.

In any case, I hope you enjoy the chapter!!! And I can't wait for next week so you see what happened heheheeh

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Alright. The sorceress had done it alright.

The weddings were… nice. Like a normal wedding but double… and in the middle of the woods, of course.

How convenient for her, it was easier to be “present”.

But it wasn’t like Beatrix hadn’t argued with herself before finally deciding to go.

A part of her was thrilled to go, *proud* of the girls and how far they had gone. Yet another part was reluctant… She felt like a hypocrite.

Feeling insecure, even if she wouldn’t admit it, she followed the girls around, listening. She told herself she was just trying to prove a point: that they didn’t want her to be there watching, even if invisible. But Beatrix knew deep down that she actually *feared* the possibility of that being true, and that was why she *needed* to hear their conversations.

Fortunately for her, Finn was with Perfuma, who wanted the girls to enjoy the party. Otherwise, they would have given out her presence there.

In the end, it turned out that her fears were unfounded. They never said a thing about her. They didn't express happiness for her absence, but didn't mention wanting her to be there either.

Maybe it was for the best…

Well! That was enough eavesdropping. She had nothing else to do there…

However, when she was about to leave, something called the girls' attention, and they rushed away. The woman could see almost all around, but she could only hear the voices near Catra or Adora, so she only heard what was going on when they were close enough.

Ah, but it shouldn't surprise her.

Once again, the siblings were arguing. The girls stayed back and let Glimmer handle it, but the woman didn't think for a second and approached, knowing no one would notice.

Micah left at that exact instant; had she been closer to them just moments earlier, she would have heard the discussion. But hearing Glimmer try to comfort her aunt was enough to get an idea.

And then Castaspella said that phrase… "I appreciate the effort but just drop it. Just leave me alone".

Now, *what* could have happened that she rejected her own niece's attempt to comfort her?

Oh, she could remember that one time the sorceress had told her that same phrase, but it made sense as she was also the one who offended her.

The woman returned to the solitude of the planet's core, musing about the subject.

Thinking back, she had been so stupid, and merely a week ago, she almost made the same mistake…

> The sorceress had joined Shadow Weaver at the gardens once more. It was lunchtime, so Castaspella sat with her lunchbox to eat under the sun. She looked relaxed, happy… and Shadow Weaver couldn't understand that.
>
> For starters, she couldn't comprehend why she'd be there almost every day.
>
> Ah, but it didn't matter.
>
> The woman continued weeding the garden in silence until she got a bit of a wicked idea.
>
> Smirking and with her head slightly tilted to the side, she asked the Head Sorceress —How come you do *everything* with needles?
>
> Castaspella looked back immediately, a brow raised in confusion, and blinked a few times, probably because of how out-of-the-blue the question had been.
>
> —What do you mean "everything"!?
>
> Shadow Weaver couldn't help grinning even more, anticipating the malice of her comment, and replied —Knitting, and eating…

—What the- These are *chopsticks*!— she immediately interrupted, obviously offended. —There's a *huge* difference! Can you just *stop* making a mockery of everything I use and do!?

Ah, but it wasn't enough for her.

—Just look at the shape! I don't see how you couldn't use them to knit— she insisted, knowing perfectly well she was pushing Castaspella's every button.

—If I *ever* see you attempting to knit with *chopsticks,* I'll find a way to kill you again! Or to chop off your hands! That's a threat!

And she did it!

Shadow Weaver let out an amused laugh and, grinning sardonically, asked —That's supposed to be a threat!? You should sound less cute for that…

—Did-did you just call me "cute"?

Castaspella stared with a brow raised again, genuinely confused.

—The tone. The way you *said* it— the woman immediately clarified, deadpan. But it was too late. The Head Sorceress was already smirking smugly. —A baby sounds more threatening than you!— she added, trying to cover her slip of the tongue.

Six months of being around Castaspella seemed to be affecting her…

—I'm just surprised that word is even in your vocabulary at all— she commented, with a mocking expression.

What now!?

—Are you serious!? I have already used that word before!— Shadow Weaver argued, indignant and purposely digressing to further deviate the sorceress' attention.

But it backfired fantastically.

—Oh, right…— Castaspella grinned, eyeing her knowingly. She clearly didn't doubt a second to push the matter, remarking —Funny you remember that; I thought it was a mere tease.

—It *was* a tease— Shadow Weaver insisted, squinting at her.

—Yet you remember that well enough!?

—Oh no… you're learning— she murmured, genuinely fearful. What was happening and when had things reached this point? As the Head Sorceress laughed loudly, probably having heard her, she immediately complained —This isn't funny, nor good.

—It's *very* funny! Your face!— she further laughed. —Please, is it *that bad* to have your own weapons used against you?

Oh, no. Of course not.

—Is it that bad to know you-

—Don't— Castaspella interrupted, her tone suddenly severe.

Her lack of expression was enough of a warning, but it didn’t stop Shadow Weaver.

—I didn't even say…

—No need. I know *exactly* what you were going to say— the sorceress assured her, interrupting once more.

—Do you?— she asked, tilting her head as her mocking tone only intensified. —According to your logic…

—That trick is mine, get your own!

So it was that!

Shadow Weaver couldn’t help laughing in full earnest.

—You won't give up, will you?— she defied her.

—And let you win? No way, I have the upper hand this time. You can't always manipulate your way to victory.

—You're taking this too seriously— the woman pointed out.

—Says the one obsessed with having a way to counter *everything* and have the last word!— Castaspella reproached.

Oh, really?

She crossed her arms in front of her chest and let out —So this is you being annoying beyond comparison…

Castaspella’s expression darkened in an instant.

Perhaps that was a mistake.

Angry, the Head Sorceress stood up and yelled —Fuck off! You just *had* to say that… There you have it, you won, I'm out!

—Wait!— Shadow Weaver reacted, catching her by the arm. —I didn't want you to give up, this was just getting interesting— she told her with her usual tone, which maybe wasn’t a good idea either.

Castaspella only pulled away her arm and retorted —I said fuck off. I *don't care*. If you find me *so annoying*, like everyone else, do just like them and *stay away*!

—That's ridiculous. I don't want to— the woman replied, without even thinking.

—*Why*!?

Yes, why?

She had no idea what to say and simply defaulted to a playful response.

—How else will you keep learning my ways?

Her anger vanished with a sigh. However, the Head Sorceress only shook her head and told her —I… appreciate the effort but just drop it—. Turning to leave again, she said —Just leave me alone.

—Cas…

—No.

And with that, Castaspella left the gardens, forgetting her empty lunchbox on the grass.

So, perhaps she hadn't replied like that back then because she felt aggravated or offended, but rather because she *really* needed to be left alone…

Of course.

Now she understood.

It's the limits. People have boundaries.

She'd be so quick to point out how Castaspella has issues respecting them, but then she herself would do the same… And on purpose.

The sorceress never intended to be disrespectful, she entirely ignored those limits, hence not respecting them and making people uncomfortable. But it was ignorance, not malice.

Shadow Weaver, on the other hand…

It could be ignorance to a certain point but, beyond that? No one can be so ignorant if not deliberately and maliciously…

In fact, back then, she *had* been malicious. That was her whole point! It wasn't ignorance yet Castaspella didn't treat it as malice, didn't tell her to fuck off. She said "There's a huge difference", as if she didn't know!

But she pushed it, continued to be malicious, and then the sorceress couldn't overlook it anymore. *That's* when she told her to fuck off.

And she deserved it.

She probably deserved it every time she was told to fuck off…

But the point here was…

What was the point?

She had no idea. She had gotten a bit carried away by the memory…

Whatever she was thinking about, whatever the point was, she couldn't catch it again.

She felt the pull from the core weakening and knew someone had arrived at the groove.

Ah, of course, the girls.

If they asked… would she tell the truth? Or would she pretend she didn't attend the ceremony?

Would they even ask?

Chapter End Notes

Ocean_galaxy, if you're reading this, here are your answers! Finn wasn't a bouquet, and couldn't see her because they weren't around; about Micah's reaction, it was the normal reaction any father would have, probably, and far less visceral than his reactions to anything involving Casta and SW together lol

Oh wait, actually that last point is clearer next chapter <("^_^)
Nvm, I'm leaving it anyways, it's not a spoiler…
See you in the comments XD

For everyone else! See you next week! I hope you liked the chapter!!

In Love with My Sorrow

Chapter Summary

All nice things must end, but perhaps it was a bit rushed the way the weddings' day ended. Without so much as a warning, a simple argument triggers a tragedy once more, and the Queen is lucky to have such reliable friends.

»Covering her face with both hands, Catra groaned and lay down across the couch, having kicked her shoes off. Her mind was going over everything that happened that night, and not only was she still in disbelief at her own actions, but also, she couldn't help thinking about Glimmer's feelings with all of this.
»It was supposed to be a happy day for them… It was going so well…
»But first that discussion, then whatever the fuck the sorceress did…
»It was supposed to be their day! A perfect day!
»But no… those two couldn't keep it civil for a single day…

Chapter Notes

If you noticed, YES! The title is a reference to *Lithium* by Evanescence, which ofc is here in my playlist. I just think it fits a bit too well, and while, ofc, it is unhealthy to cling onto your own grief like that, it isn't any less real. It happens to many of us, so why wouldn't it happen to Casta too?
In other words, I'm not trying to romanticize something that is, as I said, unhealthy; I'm just projecting my own stuff on this fic, by means of her character and SW…

But enough of that! Please enjoy the chapter...
~~After this, there's a whole year time-skip~~

PS: If u read with a screen reader, there's a chance some words sound odd. For instance, there's this phrase "Yet now, you won't let me live!" that, when read with the ! at the end, pronounces "live" as /'laɪv/ instead of /'lɪv/, but without the ! pronounces it correctly as /'lɪv/. Sorry for that, I can't fix it...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As the sun went down, the celebrations continued. The weddings were simply delightful. They had organized such a grand party that Castaspella was overjoyed. And the fact that her niece had married was the cherry on top.

—I'm so proud…— she sighed, watching Glimmer from afar as she chatted with some princesses.

—She grew so quickly, my baby girl…— Micah commented.

—And she looks so happy!

—But if that boy does anything to hurt her…

—Nonsense— Castaspella interrupted. —He's a good boy and completely in love with Glimmer. He would never hurt her— she assured him. —So stop pestering him, alright?— she added, looking back at the now King Father.

—I have to keep an eye on him!

—No, you don't— the sorceress quickly replied. —You're scaring him. Do I have to knock some sense into you again!?

—Fine, fine— he reluctantly said, folding his arms and rolling his eyes. After letting out a long sigh, he decided to change subjects and asked her —So, tell me, Sis. When will *you* settle and marry someone, eh?

—I don't want to talk about that— she immediately replied, serious.

Letting out a shaky sigh, she picked up her glass and took a sip, looking away.

—Listen, Sis… I think- You-you shouldn't keep losing time with people like Shadow Weaver— he began, making the Head Sorceress tense up from head to toe. She remained speechless and looking away while he continued —Not only because she's dead, but also because she's the last person to deserve you!

She put her glass down right away with a bit too much strength and scoffed before saying —So now you imply I love her?

Daunted by her defiant glare, he leaned back and rushed to clarify —N-no, no! I-I mean, you're… you're infatuated with an idea of her that is simply… *fake*! A-and that's keeping you from meeting new people!

—Micah…

—You're better off with people like Delwyn as your friends!

—Micah! Stop it!

—You- Don't you see? You're always melancholic, a-and like grieving… You seem to be in love with your sorrow! I-I just want the best for you!

—Whatever makes you think you know what's best for me!?— she retorted, standing up from her chair and slamming her hands on the table. Silent for a moment, and ignoring that Glimmer, Adora, and Catra approached them, she shook her head and uttered —When will you understand, brother?

—I could ask you the same question.

—What's going on?— the Queen tentatively asked.

—Nothing. I was just leaving— her father severely replied, standing up.

With a final look that was a mix of anger and pain, he turned and left, jaw clenched and fists tightly closed.

—I'm sorry for the scandal— Castaspella apologized, looking back at the girls. —I didn't mean to yell.

—What happened, Auntie?— Glimmer asked, stepping forward. —I'll go speak with Dad if necessary.

—Don't worry, there's no need. It was just the usual… I know he wasn't trying to hurt me— she replied with a gentle expression.

—It was about her again, right?

—I- Never mind that, Glimmer. Please don't let this interrupt the party— the sorceress told her.

—But I want to help you! I- Why don't you come with us and tell us what happened? It might help you feel better— the Queen suggested. —And I'll talk with dad later, alright?

With a sigh, she shook her head and told her —You don't have to do that, I just need some time alone…

—But…

—Glimmer— Castaspella interrupted, looking back at her. —I appreciate the effort but just drop it. Just… leave me alone— she requested, before finally walking away.

The Queen hesitated for a moment, looked back at her friends, and saw Bow shake his head. With a defeated expression, she resigned and let her go.

—Why is it always like this?— she lamented, walking back to join her husband. —It's been years!— she pointed out.

—Their disagreements won't magically disappear, Love. And we can't do anything about it. This is between them, and only them— he reminded her.

As Glimmer looked up at him, sorrowful, Delwyn slowly approached them from the side.

—I don't mean to meddle, it's not my business, but if there's something I can help with…

—I wish there were, but Bow is right, we can't interfere…— the Queen lamented.

—Then we'll simply support her. Now she needs time, but then we'll help her however we can.

—Yeah…

—Guys?— Catra asked as she and her wife approached.

—Is everything okay?— Adora asked. —That looked…

—Intense, I know— Glimmer sighed.

—Listen, I understand where your dad's coming from, but he's being a total bitch— Catra commented, folding her arms. —I think I should talk to him again.

—Guys, we can't keep meddling in their business!— Bow told them. With a sigh, he admitted —I want to help too, but we can't just do whatever we want. We'll only help by doing what Casta *needs*.

—He’s right— Delwyn supported the new King. —Otherwise, we might make things worse for her.

—Fine, I won’t speak about that…

—Perhaps we should… speak with Shadow Weaver? So that *she* doesn’t make things worse?— Adora suggested.

—Oh, absolutely. I can totally picture her saying *exactly* what she shouldn’t say— Catra agreed.

—Tomorrow?

—I think it’s better if we go after the party…

—Alright.

—Now, I think I should go speak with my dads, they look worried— Bow said, between ashamed and nervous.

—Yeah, we have an audience— Adora realized.

—We better deal with this before rumours start— Bow recommended.

—Yeah, the last thing we need is gossip about this all over Etheria— Catra sighed.

—Auntie…— Glimmer muttered. —Alright, let’s go.

Having wandered through the Whispering Woods for a while, the Head Sorceress finally decided to teleport directly to her room. The sky had darkened and she was feeling… *furious*.

She was so mad at Micah that it made her cry for a moment. She didn’t want to feel like that, not for him, but it was more and more difficult with each passing year.

Like every time before, she sat at her desk, grabbed a sheet of paper, and began writing angrily.

> Is there anything you will allow me to do!?
>
> I can't love her! I can't miss her! I can't trust her!
>
> You won't even let me enjoy having you back!
>
> You have no idea how much I suffered when we thought you had been killed!
>
> I was so glad of having you back! But with all of this, you're making me loath your return!
>
> And I'm supposed to call you "brother"!? You're supposed to be the person for whom I suffered for so long!? The reason why I let my relationship with my own niece and your wife go astray!?
>
> You call me a traitor when I've given you everything!
>
> All my life! Yet now, you won't let me live!
>
> Why should I need your permission to feel one way or another!? Why should I get your approval to have or not any relationship at all with someone!?

What if I'm in love with my sorrow!? Perhaps I am!

But *you*!? You're gripped by your hate!

You want me to let go, but you won't do the same! Not even for me!

Just what do you want from me!?

When will you stop!?

You're pushing me to choose between you and her, and you've done nothing to make me choose you, and everything to choose her!

You think I betrayed you!?

I swear I haven't nor do I want to, but if you're so convinced I have, maybe I should! If you're going to behave this way regardless…

But I don't want to… I could never…

I still hope you'll understand one day, but whenever you seem to have dropped the matter, it isn't long until you do it again!

We had been so well these past few months! So why!? And why today!?

This is maddening! I can only bear it for so long!

All the self-control in the world isn't enough anymore!

I need to scream!

I need to scream!

I need to *scream*!

And so she did.

After rereading her rant, Castaspella stood up, let out a loud yell with her eyes closed and burnt the paper between her hands.

But the feeling wouldn't go away.

She was breathing heavily, her hands itched as the ashes fell on the table, and the lump in her throat felt suffocating.

She needed… She needed sleep. Yes.

Seeing the vial of sleeping potion on her desk, she didn't think a single second and immediately drank it all in one go. The full vial.

It took a moment too long to take effect, but when it did, terrible dizziness struck her, and she fell on her chair.

She felt like floating. Everything around her looked blurry. Her mouth felt strange.

And the next moment, she fell forward on her desk, her face resting over the ashes, and the empty vial discarded on the floor.

Back in Bright Moon, the Queen had just arrived, accompanied by Bow.

—…They will be cleaning the Temple all night— he was commenting as they walked to their room.

—Probably, yeah.

—Queen Glimmer!— a voice suddenly called from behind.

They both turned around to find an acolyte from Mystacor running their way, clearly distressed.

—Do you know him?— Bow muttered, but didn't get an answer.

In fact, she didn't recognize him and was confused for a moment, but it quickly turned into concern when she thought better about it.

It could only mean one thing.

—Please, come quickly! It's the Head sorceress!

Just as she feared…

As he stopped in front of them, trying to recover his breath, she asked —What happened!?

—I… was walking by… by her room— he began, panting. —I heard a cry… I mean, a *really*… loud outcry. I-I've never… heard such a thing before.

—So!?

—I knocked, but… she didn't answer— he concluded.

Alarmed, the Queen looked back at Bow and he nodded, serious.

—Take my pad just in case.

Without a word, she took it and disappeared in a puff of sparkles, then reappeared at her aunt's door. She didn't want to intrude, not again, but after knocking several times, slamming her fist against the door and calling out to her, she teleported inside.

In the darkness of the room, she heard clinking sounds that called her attention to the desk, where Castaspella's spiders were frenetically hitting the walls of their terrarium.

That's when she saw her…

Down at the Whispering Woods, Adora and Catra were busy talking with Shadow Weaver. Having explained to her what happened with the siblings, they tried to make it clear to her that she shouldn't bring up the subject or tease the sorceress for the time being, to avoid rubbing salt on the wound.

But the woman seemed determined to contradict them.

—You're making this more difficult than it should be— Catra let out. —Why is it so difficult for you to *not* be a bitch!? Just for, like, a few days!

—I don't see why I should "watch what I say" as if she couldn't handle my…

—It's not about that!— the girl interrupted, exasperated. —Yeah, we know she can deal with your bullshit, but this is serious!

—It is *always* serious…

—Not like this! I- She looked so… forlorn.

—I know, I was watching…

—Then you should understand that she may not be able to bear your mocking this time— Adora insisted.

—Don't just pretend nothing happened… Don't ignore this— Catra pleaded, deep down hoping she had grown enough to understand. If she had, if she could simply be considerate, it would mean that, one day, she'd also become supportive even. Right? The girl longed for her understanding and support; if she could do it for Castaspella now, perhaps in the future she'd do it for her too? —Please…

The woman sighed and pressed her temples, resigned.

—I shall…

Satisfied, the girls returned home, hand in hand, to find Finn playing with Melog and Perfuma. They thanked the Princess and saw her out, then went to cook dinner while discussing how to fix Swift Wind's barn the next day.

—If he keeps piercing the walls with his horn, we'll run out of wood…

—It's not like he does it on purpose— Adora argued.

—I know, I know. He's asleep and moves his head, blah, blah, blah.

—Come on— she giggled.

—But what about the holes in the roof? He knows he can't fly inside the barn— Catra pointed out.

—He… miscalculates?

—Stop excusing him, Adora…

—I…— she began, but was interrupted by Finn, who began crying loudly.

Both rushed to see them hugging Melog, eyes tightly closed, and tears streaming down their face.

—What happened, baby!?— Catra asked, concerned, as she knelt in front of them.

—Scare!— they yelled.

—Oh, for fuck's sake!— she let out, picking them up and trying to calm them. Frowning, she angrily said —If we go, will you stop!?

Adora gave her a confused look, but almost immediately, Finn stopped crying and calmed down, only grizzling slightly. Catra washed away their tears with her thumb and kissed their forehead with her eyes closed.

Her intuition was right.

They rested on her, sucking their thumb, but then looked at a fixed point and said —Ghost lady?

—Oh!— Adora realized. —It was her?

—Calling our attention like that is gonna get on my nerves— Catra complained. —But we better return to the groove before she does it again…

Trusting Melog could take care of them for a while, the girls left Finn in their crib and rushed to the groove.

The woman appeared on the surface with a hand on her chest and gasping for air as if she needed it.

—I don't… know what's happening— she managed to say.

Something inside her felt like breaking.

She didn't know how to explain it, but she could only think about them. She wasn't sure why, not like they could help her, but she didn't give it much thought.

Her head was focused on figuring out what was happening, and it suddenly hit her.

The sorceress had disconnected.

Not like the last time. She was *fully* disconnected, and Shadow Weaver could already feel her summoned body lose strength.

—Sha-Shadow Weaver!?— Adora stammered, noticing it.

—You're… fading— Catra let out, shocked.

—She's gone— the woman managed to say, still clutching her chest.

—What do you mean!?

—Just check on Castaspella…— she pleaded, falling to her knees.

—I'll call Glimmer, she'll be faster— Adora said, remembering she was carrying her pad to call Bow. —Pick up, pick up, pick up…

—Adora! Great timing! Something happened to Aunt Casta!

—Wha-what is it!?— she quickly asked, exchanging a concerned look with Catra.

—I don't know! She's all passed out here in her room, and I don't understand!

—Is there anything around?— Shadow Weaver asked, voice strained.

—What do you see around?— Adora repeated for Glimmer to hear.

—There's… ah… ashes, and… an empty vial…

—A vial? Like the sleeping potions?— Adora realized, looking back from the pad at the woman, as if asking her.

—Exactly!— Glimmer exclaimed, sounding more and more alarmed.

—That fool!— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, straining. —Must have drank a full vial!

—What does that mean!?— Adora immediately asked.

—She's intoxicated! Could even die!— the woman yelled, feeling increasing pain. —Might have already… I'm weakening— she admitted.

The girl looked down at the pad again and said —Can you come for me to the groove? I-I'll try to help your aunt.

—Going!

—I-I'll stay— Catra said, seeing the woman in panic, and Adora nodded in agreement.

Glimmer appeared right that moment, frenetic. In a second, she grabbed her and disappeared, leaving Catra alone with an agonizing Shadow Weaver.

Seeing her fading, Catra began panicking too and didn't know what to say or do.

—Jus-just calm down, will you?

However, the woman only uttered —This was a mistake. I told you all… How can I- No, I am *not* this weak!

Concerned, the girl approached hesitantly.

—Stop it! You're not weak!— she began, but took a step back, frightened for a moment when Shadow Weaver looked up, enraged, grabbing her head with both hands. Catra had to remind herself that she can't hurt her, and realized that anger wasn't directed at her, but rather that she was angry at herself. With that in mind, she gathered strength and insisted —Stop saying that, and don't take my concern for pity. I-I'm *really* worried, alright? Can't you just abandon those stupid beliefs of yours for like ten seconds!?

—Look at me! Undone and in cursed pain!— the woman yelled, gesturing with her hands before grabbing her chest once again. —I'm not even alive anymore! If this isn't utter weakness, what would you call it!?

—You're just concerned for her, like the last time! You're worried she may not wake up!— she replied, making Shadow Weaver open her eyes wide, as if she were just realizing. —It's- This is actually a good thing! You're *genuinely* concerned for someone other than yourself!— Catra insisted, making the woman stop her racing thoughts to focus on this single idea. She was *concerned*. She stared at the ground, shocked, as Catra added —But you're panicking because you haven't *ever* been worried about anyone, have you!?

Now, had she?

In fact…

—I have…

With a suspicious look, but noticing Shadow Weaver was calmer, she spoke calmly too, shaking her head as she said —If you say for us at the Heart…

—What if I say that?

Catra looked away, sorrowful, but continued the conversation as she realized it distracted the woman from the pain.

—It was too late, and it… it would have meant more if you hadn't…

Noticing how the girl managed to calm her down, she admitted —I'm starting to lose the notion of what being dead means. How… can I- How can it be? I behave as if I were still alive…

—I too… I mean, I sometimes forget you're dead… and only remember when I start… hoping you would… treat me better— Catra replied, still looking away, arms folded.

With a sardonic laugh, Shadow Weaver said —Even now I keep hurting you, how ironic…

—It's not funny…

—It's not on purpose either. It's not like I chose to… care for her— she let out, resigned.

She had admitted it. Not only to Catra. To herself.

—You chose not to care for us… for *me*— Catra reproached her, holding back tears.

—I was convinced I had to. That it was the only way. And, believe me, I didn't care for her either at first. She just…— she began, but hesitated, looking disgusted. —…She got into my head. It was as if she could see exactly how my mind works and kept pointing out every flaw in my world-view. Made me see I was ignoring my flaws, which doesn't make me flawless, but rather… even more flawed— she continued, fighting herself to be honest just this once. —I tried not to care but, just like, only at the end, my resolve broke and I cared for you enough to give up myself rather than see you die… she managed the same, over and over again— she explained, finally looking back at Catra. —I can rebuild my apathy a few times, but it's impossible now… and I *hate* feeling like this— she seethed.

—Why?— the girl asked, wanting to understand, once and for all, what this woman was thinking.

—I feel weak, mediocre…

Of course. What else could she expect from Shadow Weaver?

—Ah, right… you won't settle for mediocrity *like me*, right?— she reproached her, unable to hold back. She was expecting the woman to react angrily or something, but she didn't, so she continued —You're now using your own bullshit against yourself. Normally, it would be amusing, but now… I don't- I guess I need to believe you're really learning but resisting it because of those stupid ideas of yours… Meaning it wasn't just that you hated me…

—I told you…— Shadow Weaver began, but Catra cut her off.

—Yes, yes. But it's not the same— she told her. —The thoughts in my head don't care about what others say. I need proof that even those thoughts have no arguments against, or I'll just…

—Keep thinking you're deluding yourself? Of course— the woman interrupted, letting out another sardonic laugh. —How quaint; she said that too.

—Did she?

—She said most people have these… self-sabotaging thoughts, but some struggle more than others with them.

—She really understands…— Catra sighed. —I hope she's fine.

—I think she is now.

—Really? Oh, wait, you're not fading any more!

—The pain is gone, but she still feels disconnected.

—Do yourself a favor and don't punish yourself for being concerned. I- Well, I think she… needs you now. Just… help her out— Catra told her, being as gentle as possible.

—I will, if you promise not to tell a soul what I've told you— Shadow Weaver accepted.

—I won't, alright? I have no reasons to do that.

—Alright. Feel free to leave now.

—Will you be fine?

—Of course. Just leave before I see your "concern" as "pity" and we both regret this— the woman warned her.

When Catra arrived home, she immediately went to check on Finn upstairs. They were soundly asleep along with Melog, so the girl could breathe easily. She smiled fondly as she watched them for a moment, returned downstairs, and flopped down on the couch, suddenly exhausted.

She had no idea how tense she was until that moment.

Covering her face with both hands, Catra groaned and lay down across the couch, having kicked her shoes off. Her mind was going over everything that happened that night, and not only was she still in disbelief at her own actions, but also, she couldn't help thinking about Glimmer's feelings with all of this.

It was supposed to be a happy day for them… It was going so well…

But first that discussion, then whatever the fuck the sorceress did…

It was supposed to be *their* day! A *perfect* day!

But *no*… those two couldn't keep it civil for a single day…

Well, in fact, she didn't really know what happened. She couldn't just go blaming everyone without knowing.

Ugh, but it was so frustrating!

Why! Just *why* today!?

Could the wedding be the trigger of the discussion? But how? And *why*!?

Now Glimmer had to go deal with her father and was probably worrying about her aunt being possibly dead, instead of enjoying her special night!

Catra herself was laying there, exhausted, emotionally drained, while her wife went to heal the Head Sorceress, instead of being together at home, happily enjoying their night with their child.

Ah… But she knew it hadn't been on purpose. No one tried to ruin their night or anything…

And that's exactly why it was so frustrating! She felt angry! But she also felt guilty for feeling angry! Wasn't she in all her right to feel like that!?

She was, yes… what she couldn't do was take that anger out on those who caused it…

Of course, of course.

She just had to breathe.

Eventually, she managed to calm down and rested a bit on the sofa until Adora arrived.

—A-Adora— she stammered, sitting up on the couch. —What happened?

—The Head Sorceress is alright— she began. Good, that was good. —We left her with Shadow Weaver. She was holding her on her lap, it was so cute!

Catra had to hold back a snort.

—Please— she let out, clicking her tongue in utter disbelief at what she said. —Be thankful she's not around to listen…

Giggling, Adora went to sit next to Catra, and said —Right, she'd go nuts again… So, how did it go when I left?

Her tone was both hopeful and careful. Understandably so.

—It was a bit weird but… fine.

—Really!?

Adora's eyes practically shined with enthusiasm, and Catra couldn't help letting out half a smile seeing that. She felt strangely shy now and looked down at her hands for a moment as she thought back.

Perhaps Adora was right to be so excited about it. After all, things *had* gone quite well.

—She was panicking, but I made conversation and she calmed down— she explained, looking up at her wife.

—That's great! What did you two talk about?

Of course she'd want to know…

But, should she tell her?

She had promised not to, yet Adora's look was difficult to resist.

—The past, for the most part— she nonchalantly said. —And some things we have in common. Not much…— she added, looking away, feeling shy again, and blushing a bit.

—Aw, Love!— the girl exclaimed, leaning forward to hug Catra. —I'm glad. Really…

—So…— Catra sighed, as they broke the hug. —It wasn't exactly the best end for our special day, huh?

—I suppose not…

—I was wondering how Glimmer was feeling with all of this— she admitted.

—She's pretty worried. After all, her aunt *really* looked… you know…

—Dead?

—Yeah. And she probably was; it wouldn't be the first time I've managed to save someone in that state.

—Bow, right?

—Yes.

—Sometimes I remember that and… I never intended for that to happen. I thought he had only been knocked out— Catra let out, looking down.

—Hey, it was war— Adora reminded her. —I'm not trying to excuse it, but… war has casualties. We all were just lucky enough not to have any.

—You actually did— the girl uttered. —And it was also my fault.

—You couldn't have known…

—Adora, I almost killed everyone when I activated the portal. And I-I actually *knew* that could happen! Entrapta warned us!

—Catra…

—I can't stop thinking that Glimmer almost lost all her family. I-I know this time it wasn't my fault, but… you know…

—Yes, I know— Adora sighed, hugging her again. —But that's also why we're working with Entrapta to fix things.

—You think it will work? She hasn't made that much progress in the past few years.

—She just needs time. I know she'll manage— she assured her. —Is there anything else troubling you?

—Is it that obvious?— Catra asked, looking back with half a smile.

—I think you're focusing on these things you did, just to avoid what's actually bothering you— Adora replied, concerned. —Why don't you tell me?

—I… suppose it's a bit connected…

—Go ahead.

—You know how…— she began, but interrupted herself with a deep sigh. —It's not an excuse but most of the things I've done were because I was… mad at you for leaving me… and then, also at Shadow Weaver for doing the same— she explained. —Before I activated the portal, she tried to convince me to leave the Horde but… you know, it's Shadow Weaver. She basically tortured me to achieve that, and in the process almost drained Glimmer. All when they were trying to save you— she went on. With another sigh, Catra brushed her hair back and concluded —All I wanted was for her to care for me, and she didn't until the end. So now I- When I think about how much she now cares for that sorceress, I can't help feeling envious.

—Catra…

—Is it wrong that I envy Castaspella for that? Is it selfish?

—Love, it's only natural— she assured her. —As you said, you've always wanted her to care for you… It would actually be strange if you *didn't* feel like this— she commented, letting out a sad smile. —And perhaps you should talk to them about this…

—I don't think I can… I feel like I'll only get angry at them.

—Look at it this way— Adora began, shifting her position a bit to face her straight. —This only means that, maybe one day, she'll also let herself care for you too. Just like when she made sure that monster wouldn't kill you.

—That was *one* time, Adora. It won't erase her threats about disposing of me, her torture, or the times she actually almost killed me— Catra pointed out. She then raised her legs and hugged them against her chest as she added —And still, I just want her to… worry about me and care for me as much as she does for that sorceress… But she's already dead, so what's the point? I don't know why I feel like this.

—Well, I insist, Love. At least she's here, she's not alive and isn't a threat, so now there's a chance she will learn to care for you, actually care for you, because she's… I think she's learning, and growing. That goodness I always thought she had deep, deep inside may be closer to the surface now — Adora told her, hopeful. Like it or not, I mean, she may not like it, but she's making an effort.

—She is, isn't she?— Catra sighed, looking back at her wife.

Later that night, the Head Sorceress slowly woke up back at the groove. Sitting against a tree, and half asleep, the Queen nodded off for a second before raising her head suddenly and glancing at her aunt. As she noticed her moving, she opened her eyes wide and stood up.

—A-Auntie!

—Ah… finally— Shadow Weaver let out, shaken awake from her reflections. —Your niece here refused to leave until you woke up. Stubbornness runs in the family— she mocked her as the sorceress gradually attempted to move her limbs.

—What?— she asked, groggy and confused.

—Auntie, how are you feeling?— Glimmer asked, kneeling beside her and entirely ignoring Shadow Weaver's mockery.

—Like that time… I was knocked out by… that freezing beast— she replied, speaking with some effort.

—Yeah… I imagine. I'm just glad you're fine— the Queen let out, relieved. —Never do that again, Auntie. Please— she pleaded.

—I… am sorry— she muttered, unable to look at Glimmer.

—Talk to us next time, alright?— she insisted.

The sorceress only looked back with a sad smile and closed her eyes, feeling tired.

—Should she take you back to your room? Or are you willing to stay for a little chat?— Shadow Weaver asked. —It's *not* a nice chat, I warn you.

—It's *you* we're talking about… You'll just insult me for my foolishness, I know— Castaspella replied, keeping her eyes closed. —Never mind, I'll stay.

—Alright— Glimmer accepted. —I'll go back home then.

—Sorry for worrying you on your special day, dear— she apologized with a strained voice.

—It's okay, Auntie. I understand— she assured her. Before leaving, she addressed Shadow Weaver —Take care of her.

—I can't harm her more than she harmed herself.

Glimmer only rolled her eyes and disappeared in a puff of sparkles, leaving them alone in the groove.

—What part of "next time you want to die, let me do it, I'll be quicker" did you not understand?— the woman immediately said.

—Actually, I had also considered drinking that full vial last time before the discussion changed my mind…— she admitted, still lying on Shadow Weaver's lap as she felt weak.

—Normal people would be concerned. *I* am disappointed.

—Because I'm a fool? Hah…

—Weren't my instructions clear? Only in small doses!— she reminded her.

—I wanted it to act faster!— she excused herself, opening her eyes.

—It doesn't work like that!— the woman replied, indignant.

—I'm sorry, alright? I was just… so troubled again.

—Was it, perchance, related to what I overheard you and Micah discussing?— Shadow Weaver asked, her tone condescending. As Castaspella nodded, she reproached her —So you went from getting drunk to almost dying… I can't leave you alone for a single day, can I?

—What am I supposed to do!? I can’t bear it sometimes!— she replied, her tone miserable.

—Talk it out like a sane person?

—Says the one who won’t admit how she feels…— Castaspella reproached her, looking away.

She wouldn’t say it, but it was more of a complaint, as she was sure that she’d never get to know what the woman feels for her. Not like she herself had figured out how she feels, but it upset her to think about it, knowing that Shadow Weaver probably would reject whatever it is.

However, much to her surprise, she replied —I’m *working* on that, woman… But the more I “improve” according to you, the worse you get.

That was both unexpected and true.

—I… usually just write how I'm feeling on a sheet of paper and then burn it— she explained. —That always helped me before, but this time it wasn’t enough… Even screaming wasn’t enough…

—Then you come here and I’ll distract you. Or you go to talk with someone else you trust, perhaps? — she suggested, trying to sound mean yet failing.

—I needed something faster.

Now *that* was exasperating Shadow Weaver. How stubborn could she be?

But then, realization hit and she thought aloud —Sounds a lot like my fits of rage… So, I insist. Come here, or go to the beach, to the steam grotto. Distract yourself.

—Fine! I will!— she finally accepted, raising her hands in exasperation.

With a groan, she tried to push herself up, but if the woman hadn’t helped her, she wouldn’t have managed.

—You better have recovered now, the sun is about to rise— Shadow Weaver said, instead of asking *how* she’s feeling.

—A bit… I don’t know how I’ll be able to work today— she replied, groaning again.

—It would be sensible to take the day off, wouldn’t you say? Unless you’d rather go explaining why you look like shit…

—Shut up…

—You were stupid beyond compare, I will *not* shut up about it until you get that.

—Always such a nice person— the sorceress sarcastically said, rolling her eyes.

—What did you expect?

—Frankly? Nothing— she lied.

Chapter End Notes

The bit about “losing time with SW” is a bit of a sublimation of what I had to hear from my mother and my cousin, about my long-distance relationships with my partners. They literally said I’m “losing time”, and I’ve had little occasion to vent this, so I chose to use this as a let out. I didn’t do anything as drastic as Casta but I did think about it. It’s just so frustrating to have people comment on your relationships…
Anyways, enough of that.

Here's a funfact:
Remember the sentence "she mocked her as the sorceress gradually attempted to move her limbs"? Well, originally, I mistyped and it said "her sorceress" 🤭

So, I hope you enjoyed the chapter and see you next week!! Hopefully I'll have the chapter finished by then <("^_^)

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Feelings make a huge difference
Status: ACCESS DENIED.

Chapter Notes

Sorry, I kind of had to rush this chapter, and I'll be rushing the next one too, so... Yeah, I just hope this is good enough, albeit short...

Oh, but I really hope to have the next chapter ready in time because I so wanna post it!!

Anyways, please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had happened once more.

Beatrix was starting to think the sorceress had a death wish or something.

This time it wasn't her fault, or at least not directly, but then again, she had begun blaming herself for everything that happened to everyone around her.

How not? Most of the time it *was* her fault. And perhaps this time too, seeing how her discussion with Micah was, of course, about her.

This further convinced her that it would have been better to keep Castaspella away.

Everyone who gets close to her suffers.

Everyone.

She always causes that, even without intending it…

She just kept reverting so easily back then, and now, despite her efforts, *something* happens related to her and it's like she manipulated everything again.

Funny… If she had tried to pit the siblings against each other, it probably wouldn't have worked…

Just like when she tried to manipulate Glimmer and failed miserably. Quite ironic seeing how everyone, even Glimmer herself, thought she *was* manipulating the Queen into using the Heart of Etheria.

Yes, she later wanted to use it, but before the first activation, she was trying to do the opposite.

Not to avoid the planet's destruction nor for any noble reason, but still, if she had succeeded, the Heart wouldn't have been activated that first time.

They had discussed that matter a long time ago, she could still remember…

—No matter how you put it, it's still manipulation!— Glimmer exclaimed, exasperated. —That is not what I need! I need people to trust me as their Queen!— she insisted, indignant.

—*You* call it "manipulation". *I* call it a change of perspective— Shadow Weaver clarified, hands joined behind her back as she kept an elegant posture. —It is not about lying, it's not about convincing people of what you think. It's far more subtle— she went on. —It's about portraying the truth from your point of view and making others adopt that point of view on their own— she further explained. —You don't have to convince them of anything, they will convince themselves.

—Oh, no. Stop right there… You're speaking *just* like back then! I'm not falling for your games again!

—Funny that you say that, seeing how you were probably the only one who thoroughly resisted my manipulation from the beginning— the woman scoffed, now crossing her arms in front of her chest and looking away.

—What do you mean?

Right…

With a sigh, Shadow Weaver answered —It was, of course, for selfish reasons, but I *did* try to manipulate you into abandoning the idea of having Scorpia reconnect with the Black Garnet. It's the only runestone I've ever managed to tap into… As soon as she connected with it, I fully lost it.

—It was *never* yours to begin with— the Queen pointed out. The woman simply agreed silently, so she asked her —And what about my power!? You only helped us teleport to the Horde to rescue Adora and such because you aimed to get the power of my mother's- *my* runestone!

—Oh, please. As if I could possibly steal Angella's source of power— she scoffed. —I won't deny it was a tempting idea when it was just you, especially seeing how you refused to claim all the power for yourself. The Moonstone was practically disconnected, much like the Black Garnet had been, but… No. Everything related to you and your family is just so… unsettling. I have to admit I hate how you all have an effect on me. Teaching you magic brought back memories, reminded me of my weakness— the woman went on, her tone more and more bitter. —And offering to enhance your power had been my last attempt to prove I was still powerful, so I had nothing else to counter that damned feeling— she clarified. —It wasn't manipulation back then. Afterwards… I suppose it was— Shadow Weaver admitted, confusing Glimmer even more. The woman then scoffed, looked away, and let out —I repeated the same patterns, how pathetic…

—You have to be kidding me…— Glimmer uttered, calling her attention. The Queen pressed her temples with both hands as she said —How can you try to pass that event as such an innocent attempt at proving your… worth? I guess? Or, your might, I suppose. But, *how* can you say that, when you literally almost drained me of power *and* used said power to almost kill Catra, huh!?

—I wasn't trying to kill her, obviously.

—No, no. It's not "obvious"— she quickly countered. —Do you even recall what happened that day?

—Of course.

—Then what were you thinking!? What did you think would happen if you drained me of my power? Or if you killed Catra with that stolen power?

—I just said I…— she began, raising her tone, but interrupted herself upon seeing Glimmer's expression of fear, immediately followed by a defensive stance. Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and explained —As I just said, I wasn't trying to kill her. No, I suppose my convincing method wasn't exactly subtle, but I wasn't… thinking. I just wanted her to abandon the Horde, and I tried to convince her the only way I knew.

—Which only convinced her to stay, you know?

—I realize.

—And what about what you did to me in the process?

—I never noticed what was happening to you. I was too focused on Catra— Shadow Weaver argued.

—Wow… Catra would love to know you were actually focused on her and only her for once, if it wasn't because you almost killed her that same moment.

—*Point is*… if your boyfriend hadn't stopped me, no, I wouldn't have realized what was happening to you, what I was doing. As soon as I did, I stopped because, once again, I wouldn't ever hurt you or your family… on purpose.

—So you *are* conscious of the many times you've hurt us, right?

—I suppose…

—Look, I- We have different opinions of you, different experiences with you— Glimmer began. —My experiences lead me to avoid your counsel, even if what you're saying makes sense and isn't malicious or anything. I just… don't care. I'll do what I can and however I can— she explained. —So, thank you for that attempt at helping me, but I rather you *don't* help me.

—I see…

—I have a lot to do now, but… the chat actually helped a bit, I could ask what I'd been wondering for a while now— Glimmer admitted, surprising herself with how satisfied she was. Before leaving, she remembered something and turned to look at her as she pointed out —Oh, and, I said we have different opinions and experiences with you… But, mine's making me wary of your counsel doesn't mean it's the same for… say, my aunt.

—Your point?

—Don’t just stop offering advice just because I rejected it.

—How can you know I will give her *good* advice?

—I don’t. I just trust Auntie is smart enough to see through you— the Queen replied. —Now, yes. I’ll leave— she sentenced, starting to walk away.

—Where exactly are you going, your Majesty?

—I… Oh, fuck you! I don't have to leave! You do!

Laughing wholeheartedly, the woman gave up and retired from the throne room…

That day, as if to prove her point, she had been unusually honest with Glimmer.

It was *not* funny starting to realize all the weaknesses she has. Micah and his family, the girls and, little by little, her old self…

Yes, she may still revert occasionally but, as Castaspella had pointed out, she now feels guilty when that happens.

How could they all see that as a strength? How exactly could they draw courage from what she feels as weaknesses?

She had once told Adora that, if she cared for Catra, she had to focus on protecting her, but she herself didn't believe Catra would give her strength as she did; she was only trying to get her to shift her focus *away* from the girl.

It incredibly backfired, didn't it?

But still, Shadow Weaver would never be able to understand that…

Chapter End Notes

I swear! SW *really* told Adora that if she cares for Catra she has to focus on protecting her! She said it right after saying Catra distracts and confuses her! Look here! (Scroll down until you find the highlighted sentence)

Well, besides that, I suppose I just wanted to explore this little bit of an issue that remained unaddressed in the series, but I wasn't even sure what the lesson was supposed to be... heh Whatever, I just hope you enjoyed the chapter! And until next week!

Anniversary

Chapter Summary

After a pacific and uneventful year, the Best Friends Squad gathers for their anniversary celebration. Under the influence of some good wine, their conversations drift back to the past, and they will remember some funny events...

»—I mean, who would have thought we would ever be drinking such a good wine courtesy of the woman we punched!?
»—Oh, remember that!?
»—I'm surprised that mask didn't break back then!
»—Yeah! I couldn't even dent it!— the Queen recalled, indignant.
»—I did crack it a bit, but it didn't fall off.
»—It was quite sturdy, huh? What even was it made of?— Adora asked.
»—If she ever tells you, I'm changing the guards' armor for whatever that thing is— Glimmer joked.

Chapter Notes

This one is quite the chapter. Yes, I make a whole year time-skip because we're 10 chapters away from the end. This is about year 5 and the end is during year 10, so imagine...

Expect more time skips!

Also, there are some surprises!! I hope you like the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—And… I win?

—Uh… Yes, you win.

A tough round of deck fights had just ended with Shadow Weaver the winner.

—You let me win again, didn't you?

—I didn't!— Castaspella immediately replied, indignant. —You were just lucky… Or rather, I'm having a strike of bad luck.

—If you say so…

—Yes, I say so. Now go ahead and ask your question— the Head Sorceress insisted, arms folded.

—Alright. I do have a question I've been meaning to ask for a while now: if you had been Head Sorceress back then, when I attempted the Spell of Obtainment, and had walked into the Lunarium to

find your brother on the ground, scared half to death, and me wielding dark magic after submitting to the corruption… Wouldn't you have attacked me on sight?

Her look was defiant, sure that this question would put her between the sword and the stone. Or so it should, but Castaspella didn't look conflicted at all. On the contrary, it seemed like the sorceress found the question rather interesting.

—First, I need to ask: did he attack first?

—If by "he" you mean Norwyn, yes, technically he did, but not without a reason.

—Explain that, please— she requested.

—Alright— the woman sighed. —I think that, at first, he only intended to defend himself and the others. But with how the dark magic around me grew, he must have felt threatened, so he and the two acolytes that accompanied him finally shoot— she explained. —If you want to know, I knocked back those two, which you can corroborate with Nolrem; he was one of them. Then I fought a bit more with Norwyn.

—Why did you kill him?

—I won't lie and say it was self-defense, even if he *did* attack first. I was just… so angry at him, felt betrayed, and didn't even think about it. I just obliterated him— she admitted.

—I see. Then I guess I have my reply now; the question isn't as difficult as you may have intended it to be, but the answer will certainly be long— Castaspella stated.

—Go ahead. I have all the time in the world.

—To begin with, *now* I know you wouldn't have harmed Micah, like you didn't back then— she began. —But in that hypothetical situation, without knowing that, I would begin by protecting him, even if he were older like right now. He'd probably be in shock, so all the more reasons to do it; I would tell him to run away if he could, and I'd do what I could to help him into safety. If others followed me inside, as it happened with Norwyn, I would tell them the same and then seal the Lunarium once everyone was out. That way, you wouldn't be able to escape, to teleport away, nor would you harm anyone outside. I know how to do that in theory— she explained, always speaking with a hypothetical tone, although not any less seriously.

—Locking me up would have been your solution?— Shadow Weaver asked, raising a brow in mild surprise.

It shouldn't really surprise her, of course she'd choose a rather pacific approach, but the woman thought Castaspella would be more radical in this specific situation, seeing how she always reproached her for risking her brother's life.

—Locking *you*? I didn't say I'd be outside myself— the sorceress pointed out. Genuine astonishment took over Shadow Weaver and she couldn't hide it. Seeing her expression, Castaspella decided to elaborate —I would lock myself with you and, if necessary, only protect myself from your attacks. I wouldn't attack you at all because that would give you reasons to retaliate, and it would be no surprise if you obliterated me too.

—So, what? You'd just hope I would eventually give up or something? Remember, that was my moment of maximum power. I could do anything I pleased— the woman said, condescending, as she

approached the sorceress until they were just a palm away.

—Well, yes. I would just stand my ground, defend myself until you wore yourself out, and perhaps even manage to talk you out of your rage— she assured, fully confident.

—You're a fool like they were— Shadow Weaver whispered, grabbing Castaspella's chin to tilt her face up and look her in the eyes.

Without pulling away, the sorceress defiantly asked —So you think I'm just like Norwyn?

—Obviously no— she denied, trying to hide something akin to sorrow.

It actually hurt, to think about how different things would have been.

The woman let go of Castaspella and turned away, hands joined behind her back. Castaspella immediately reached out, but it seemed like Shadow Weaver guessed what she was doing.

—Stay away!— she quickly warned her with a loud tone and seemingly angry.

But the Head Sorceress could feel she was only angry at herself, and couldn't help calling out —Bea…

—And stay silent!

Regardless, Castaspella approached and placed a hand on her back, fully aware of what her reaction would be. And just as she thought, the woman turned around, furious, as if about to attack her. Immediately, the sorceress caught her wrists and gave her a pained look, but Shadow Weaver yanked her arms free and turned around again.

—I don't want your pity!

—It's not pity!— she yelled back. However, she instantly regretted it and once again approached to place a hand on her back. —I'm sorry.

—Why are you apologizing this time?— Shadow Weaver asked, with a disgusted tone.

—I… noticed your sorrowful expression. I'm sorry if I reminded you of something hurtful.

—You're just playing me.

—Of course not! The only time I tried to do so, you immediately saw through me and called out my manipulation, remember?

—When?

—When I was trying to convince you of teaching the kids— she replied, looking away, feeling guilty.

—Ah, yes…

—I assure you I'm genuinely concerned. Just… tell me what's wrong— the sorceress pleaded.

Shadow Weaver let out a resigned sigh and admitted —I wish it had been you back then. So many things would have been different had it been you instead of that man.

—I see…

The woman turned around to look at Castaspella and, having her so close once more, she grabbed her chin again, wanting to look into her eyes as she said —I am so unfortunate it wasn't that way… I didn't even know you back then; only knew you existed because Micah occasionally mentioned you…

—Maybe that's for the best— the sorceress let out without thinking, far too flustered.

Shadow Weaver let go, turned around once again, and walked a few steps away, uttering —I suppose so.

They couldn't know, but both were thinking the same. Whatever messy feelings they were experimenting and refused to acknowledge wouldn't be possible had they met when Castaspella was little. So yes, it was for the best.

That's why, curious, the sorceress asked —Why do you agree?

—Why did you say it?— Shadow Weaver asked back, not wanting to admit it.

—I asked first!

Fair enough.

Well, it was time to lie.

—It would give Micah more reasons to be angry at our current relationship, wouldn't you say?

—I… suppose— Castaspella muttered, blushing.

—Your turn.

—I-I think- Well, don't you think it would look… inappropriate? Maybe? Most would think you had me manipulated since I was little, especially considering… well, some things of my past related to how I used to admire you, and all— she decided to reply, perhaps too honest, albeit not completely. —The council was so displeased, you know?

—I'm sure they were. Nolrem told me a bit about that.

—I'm just glad it wasn't the case. It would make everything more complicated. And I mean *everything*.

—I agree. If we had met back then, no one would believe I didn't somehow prepare you to be biased in my favour— Shadow Weaver commented, her back still towards the sorceress.

—Your words, not mine.

—You really think I'm not twisted enough to do that had I remained in Mystacor after my corruption? — the woman asked, mildly surprised but mostly curious.

—Yes, I think so!— Castaspella insisted, starting to get angry.

—That tone… Did you suddenly realize you're not that special?— Shadow Weaver taunted her, smirking as she finally turned around.

—Shut up!

—Not so polite anymore— she laughed.

—So now you want me to stop yelling, no!?

—On the contrary, please shout more.

—What?

—You always bottle it all up. Scream now, yell at me, you'll feel much better— she told her.

—I told you how I vent, I don't need it.

—It's an alternative, seeing how it wasn't enough almost a year ago, don't you think?— Shadow Weaver pointed out, reminding her of the incident with the vial of sleeping potion. And so, just as she requested, Castaspella started yelling in frustration. However, she looked like she wanted to hit something, so the woman couldn't help joking —If you want to hit the trees it's fine, but try not to set them on fire this time.

—Wha-what? Ho-how did you know I almost cast…— she began, stammering, but then interrupted herself and folded her arms. —Did you interrogate that Plumerian about this!? How did you even know!?

—Calm down and maybe I'll explain it to you— the woman replied.

—Fine— Castaspella agreed, taking a deep breath.

The women sat against a nearby tree and once the sorceress fully calmed down, Shadow Weaver began talking.

—For starters, that wasn't a Plumerian— she first revealed, confusing her. —Think about it. Who could it have been that told me?

—Oh my… You mean it was actually Double Trouble!?— she realized. As the woman nodded, Castaspella complained —That's so unfair, you weren't supposed to know!

Amused, Shadow Weaver grabbed her by the chin like she did several times during their previous conversation, and asked —And why exactly wasn't I supposed to know?

—I-I… We-well… No-no one was supposed to know!

The woman smirked and let go, snickering.

Meanwhile, back in Bright Moon, the Best Friends Squad were having breakfast together. Seemingly tired still, Catra flop down on her chair with a cup of steamy tea in front of her.

—Aren't you hungry, Love?— Adora asked, curious as she heard her sigh deeply.

—Yeah, yeah. It's just that… I've been meaning to return to the Fright Zone for more than a year now, yet it's gonna be our anniversary tomorrow and I'm still here, *not going*.

—Why haven't you?— Glimmer questioned her, curious too.

—I… don't wanna go alone— she replied, looking away.

—I suppose it's difficult for you— Bow commented, understanding.

—Yes, well… It's… bittersweet.

—I would go with you but I'm really busy these days. Barely made time for our anniversary gathering tomorrow— he lamented.

—Yes, same here— the Queen seconded.

—I- Well, I don't want to lie to you— Adora began. —I really don't want to go there again— she admitted.

—I get it, don't worry— Catra assured her, letting out a sad smile.

—There must be someone who can accompany you. I mean, you could always take some guards with you, maybe? Or we can ask, perhaps, Scorpia? O-or just any princess!— Glimmer suggested.

—I wanna go with someone I can trust. Oh, and I asked Scorpia, but same as Adora, she doesn't want to return. Even though it's literally her stolen kingdom. Only Entrapta has been going there occasionally, but I don't think she'll want to accompany me after how I treated her there— Catra explained, grunting in frustration.

—Oh, yeah…

—Someone you can trust…— the Queen repeated, pensive. —Alright, I know. Why don't you ask my aunt? Honestly, I think she's curious about the Fright Zone but won't dare go alone either.

—What makes you think that?

—Well, after she learnt I was kidnapped by you guys at Princess Prom, she asked a lot of questions about there— she laughed. —Of course she was worried, but she seemed more interested in that than anything. After all, she could *see* I was alright.

—Plus, she did ask a few times if we would try and recover the territory, didn't she?— Bow added.

—True! But she's a bit hesitant when it comes to talking with Scorpia— Glimmer pointed out. —I'm not saying she's scared of her, of course not, but she may have mentioned thinking it might be a sensitive topic— she recalled.

—Well, I suppose it wouldn't hurt to ask if she could accompany me— Catra concluded.

—Besides, with her help, you can simply teleport there! Wait, no. You can only teleport back, actually. Without being able to visualize the place…

—I guessed as much— the girl interrupted.

—I can take a moment to help with that, though.

—Hah! Yes, please. I don't wanna walk all the way there— she replied, letting out a laugh.

—Why don't you take Darla?

—It could be— Catra considered. —But I don't think it's worth wasting the fuel.

—Don't worry. I'll take you both there.

—You’re already assuming your aunt will agree?

—Trust me! She’ll be thrilled!

Later, just after lunchtime, the girl went to Mystacor looking for the Head Sorceress, and accidentally came across her just as she was leaving the kitchen. Catra didn’t lose time and briefly explained the situation to her.

—Oh, it’s completely understandable that you can’t return there alone. And I heard it was pretty wrecked before… um… Prime abducted you and Glimmer— Castaspella replied. —Oh, but I’m so curious! If you do go, would you mind if I tag along!?— she asked, excited, her eyes almost sparkling.

—I- Hah! Well, I actually wanted to ask if you could go with me— she stammered, surprised at how right Glimmer was.

—Oh, splendid!

—Don’t expect much, though. It’s just a wasteland.

—Not any less exciting— the sorceress laughed, gesturing dismissively with a hand.

—Right— Catra sighed, shaking her head in amusement. —And… Glimmer offered to take us there, so, when are you free?

—Hum… Let me think. Today we have to recharge the Crystal…— she began, thinking aloud. —Oh, well, I’ll ask someone to cover for me and we can go whenever you’re ready.

—Right now, maybe? So we can return before it gets too dark, I mean.

—Absolutely!

—Alright. Then go to Bright Moon when you’re ready, Head Sorceress— Catra agreed, laughing slightly. —And thank you.

—Oh, it’s nothing.

The Fright Zone was cold and silent. Catra didn’t remember such silence. Without the robots and cadets walking around, without the forge and the armory working, it was but a desolate wasteland, just as she said. And yet, curiously enough, Castaspella was in awe.

—Everything alright?

—I can’t believe you two grew here. All your childhood in this place, training for a war older than you… And in the middle of these machines… It’s- I can’t help noticing the stark contrast with my childhood in Mystacor.

—I bet it was quite comfortable, huh?

—Compared to how yours must have been, yes. I'm starting to appreciate it more— the sorceress admitted.

Catra laughed loudly, covering her face.

—At least you admit you had a privileged life.

—Of course. I can't pretend my poultry struggles are comparable to what you two must have lived here.

—Well, we had different experiences, but yeah, it wasn't what you'd call "comfortable" for either of us— the girl sighed. —Let's go this way.

—I've heard a lot of things about your childhood, but knowing it all happened in a place like this… I don't know. Somehow, it feels like one couldn't expect anything else— she reflected. Catra stopped in her tracks, shocked, and the sorceress quickly clarified —I'm not saying you *had* to be put through all of that! But one can't expect a kind environment in a place like this.

—No, with commander officers like Shadow Weaver, never— she replied, rolling her eyes and starting to walk again.

—I'm sorry. None of us knew they were taking kids— the sorceress lamented.

—Well, if you were struggling to keep the Horde at bay, I doubt you could have done anything even if you knew— Catra pointed out. —So, relax.

But Castaspella still felt… ashamed. Every time she remembered how they stayed indifferent to the war for so many years, she felt the same. Now, knowing this, the feeling only worsened. However, she then reminded herself that, currently, things are different; the same girls who suffered here now enjoy a happy life together.

—So… Are you looking for something in particular?

—I-I don't really know— Catra admitted. —I checked my old locker but I didn't really leave anything relevant there. And… it's not like I had many belongings either. But… I don't know…

—It's alright if you only wanted to take a look.

—Well, yes. I've always wanted to peek into some rooms and couldn't. Others… well, I've only seen in certain circumstances that weren't happy.

—Like?

—That chamber where we saw the Black Garnet, for instance. Or the lab— she replied.

—Both looked pretty ruined— Castaspella noted.

—And both are *technically* my fault— Catra laughed. —Oh, I know where we should go! Follow me.

The girl led the sorceress down a poorly lit hall until they reached a closed door. Struggling a bit, Catra pried it open after a few hits, and they both walked into a rather fancy room.

—Wow. I wasn't expecting to find someone with so many commodities— Castaspella let out.

A large bed occupied the middle of the room. A *real* bed, not like the barren bunk beds that Catra and Adora used to have. There was also a tall mirror to its right, and a narrow closet against the left wall.

—That bitch…

—Oh, my. Don't tell me this is *her* room!

—It is. She really had quite the comforts here.

—She mentioned smuggling food and wine; I suppose she also got her hands on some furniture— the sorceress reflected.

—Why the closet, though? She always used the same robes.

—Let's see.

Curious, Castaspella approached it and slowly opened the wooden closet. Inside, there was a crate on the floor and a pinkish robe hanging right over it.

—She had… another one in a different color?

—No… Wait a moment— the sorceress uttered, picking it up. The "robe" could hardly be called that. It had been cut unevenly, a sleeve was missing, and also half the chest. —This is the lighter garment she used.

—You mean she…

—Made her clothes, using this old robe— Castaspella interrupted. —In fact, it looks a bit like what her statue has… You know, the one in Mystacor. So, I think it's safe to suppose this is actually what she was using when she arrived here.

—Why keep it if it's all… torn and completely unwearable?

—I'm wondering the same.

Confused, Catra rose her brows momentarily but quickly dismissed her curiosity and decided to check the crate. Without a word, she picked it up, took it out of the closet, and crouched to pry it open.

—Let's see what's in here— she muttered.

—Ah!

Castaspella let out a loud yelp that startled Catra, and the girl flinched, falling back on the floor.

—What!?

—I heard…— she began, but trailed off as she looked around.

The girl saw her slowly walk back as she focused on the mirror and got anxious, if not alarmed even.

Just what was going on!?

—What is it!?

—There's no way.

—He-Head Sorceress, you're scaring me— Catra stammered.

—She's here! I-I'm seeing her in the mirror and I heard her speak— she finally explained.

—What the fuck!?

It couldn't be.

The girl immediately stood up and went to look, only to see hers and the sorceress' reflection.

—Let me guess: you don't see her— Castaspella sighed, understanding what was going on. —I think this once happened in my room too. I was with Micah, and he couldn't see her either. But he thought the mirror was enchanted or something— she told her. Then, having heard Shadow Weaver speak again, she addressed her directly. —No, I don't think this is an invasion of your privacy. She will open that crate and you can't stop her.

—Oh, of course I will— Catra quickly agreed. —Tell the old woman she owes me this— she smugly said.

—Oh, come on, Spin. She's just curious. It won't hurt.

—Yeah! Chill!— the girl let out, right before managing to take off the top of the crate. With a loud laugh, she reached inside and took out an unopened glass bottle. —Look at this!

—Oh, so that's the wine she said she'd smuggle.

—I'm taking this back— Catra decided.

Castaspella giggled for a moment until she looked back at the mirror and, apparently having heard the woman speak again, she said —Yes she will, and you can't stop her. Yes, I know I said that before…

—Don't tell me she doesn't want me to take it— the girl scoffed, rolling her eyes. —Not like she can drink it anymore.

—Exactly— Castaspella agreed. She turned to the mirror again and added —Better let her have it than let it go to waste!

—That's it! We're opening this tomorrow.

—Oh, right. Your anniversary— the sorceress remembered. —Seems fitting. Oh, I know! This can count as an anniversary present from her!— she laughed.

—We don't want any presents, but I guess we can accept this one— Catra agreed.

She carefully put the bottle back inside, closed the crate again, and picked it up without much effort, surprising the Head Sorceress.

That girl certainly had some muscle…

—Alright. Anything else you want to see?

—No, I think this is enough.

—Shall we go back, then? She won't stop complaining and it's making my head hurt…

The girl chuckled and nodded, so Castaspella farewelled with a dismissive tone and they both left the Fright Zone.

The following day, each couple had a private anniversary lunch separately around midday and later gathered for dinner at Bright Moon's gardens. Just as she had said, Catra uncorked one of the wine bottles she brought back and the four enjoyed their meal with an impressively good wine.

While having dessert, they went through several subjects, laughed together, and reminisced about the past. After visiting the Fright Zone, Catra was rather melancholic and, as they asked her how everything went, the discussion inevitably went there.

—I mean, who would have thought we would ever be drinking such a good wine courtesy of the woman we punched!?— Catra exclaimed, already tipsy.

—Oh, remember that!?— Glimmer laughed.

—I'm surprised that mask didn't break back then!

—Yeah! I couldn't even dent it!— the Queen recalled, indignant.

—I *did* crack it a bit, but it didn't fall off— the girl replied, laughing more.

—It was quite sturdy, huh? What even was it made of?— Adora asked, also tipsy yet less excited than her friends.

—If she ever tells you, I'm changing the guards' armor for whatever that thing is— Glimmer joked.

—Now that you mention it…— Bow began, being the only one who hadn't drunk that much. —How come you two couldn't shatter it but then your dad smashed it completely?— he asked, pensive.

Calming her laughter, Catra shook her head and said —Oh, I wonder the same.

—Now I *really* want to ask her what that's made of…— Adora thought aloud.

—Woman, if you're hearing this, you better have an answer ready next time we visit!— her wife exclaimed, before laughing again.

Lifting her glass to take another sip, the Queen hummed and looked away as she commented —Hmm, I don't think she's here listening…

—Why not?

She put down her glass and replied, with a rather mischievous tone, —I believe she's… busy.

—Your aunt went to visit her?— Adora asked, completely missing Glimmer's tone.

—Yeah, "visit".

As the Queen snickered, Bow took a deep breath and warned her —Glim, I don't think you should be speaking about your aunt like that…

—You know that I don't mean it in a bad way… In fact, I'm happy for her!

—As long as you don't say these things in front of her, it should be fine…— he sighed. —You know how much she detests gossip about her— he pointed out.

—Yes, yes, I know…

—If she knew about our ongoing bet…— Catra reminded them, before taking a sip of her glass.

—She'd go nuts!— Glimmer laughed. —Hm! Speaking of which, you've already won your bet, haven't you?

—I did!

—No, you didn't!— Adora refuted her.

—Finn read the note!

—It just said "Mom"! Nothing else. Finn can't read yet…— she insisted, her voice a bit uneven.

—Oh, come on…

Glimmer couldn't help gesturing dismissively at that and pointed out —Meh, don't worry about it… Those two are light-years away from confessing—. She shook her head, resigned, and added —Auntie still denies knowing what she feels, and Shadow Weaver… is Shadow Weaver. I'm sure she tells herself every day "You don't love her". You know, fake it till you make it.

—Sounds like her, alright…— Catra scoffed.

—Alright, alright. Enough about this— Bow interrupted. —Let's talk about something else…

—Like what, Arrow Boy?

—Like… Uh…— he hesitated. —Oh, Entrapta's project! Have we told you how it's going?

—No— Adora replied, extending the word, and rather curious.

—Compared to last year, she made huge progress!

—Oh, right! We're helping with some tests and it's actually quite stable— Glimmer agreed.

—As long as this new portal doesn't break the world…— Catra uttered, suddenly less enthusiastic.

—At least this time there's no traumatized girl to activate untested portals— Adora joked, too drunk to notice her wife's expression in time. —So-sorry— she awkwardly apologized.

—Nah, you're right. This time you're doing things right.

—Yes. Entrapta is taking a lot of time to fix all her calculations and wants to craft a whole system to control the portal's destination, integrity, and… what was the other thing?— Glimmer told them, confused at the end.

—The agreement with space-time fluctuations.

—Yeah, what Bow said.

—As long as it's safe… I don't want this world to be destroyed after everything we did to save it— Adora replied. —A-and… there's Finn now. I want everything to be safe for them.

—Oh, we didn't ask. How are they doing?— Bow inquired, leaning forward over the table.

—There they are… Bigger each day, a bit naughty, speaking a bit better…— the girl told him, smiling fondly.

—Just *a bit* naughty?— Catra scoffed. —That kid is gonna give us a heart attack one day— she sighed.

—Why?— the King asked.

—I found them munching on a cable the other day. Well, no. A-actually, I found them crying next to a cable with teeth marks. I guess that woman scared Finn to stop them— she explained, huffing. —I do *not* like it when that happens, but I don't know what I would have done if they got electrocuted, so I can't even complain…

—Oh, and they learnt how to leave the cradle! We can't even keep them there!— Adora recalled.

—I suppose they are making your dad's life impossible right now, Sparkles— Catra laughed.

—Yeah… They are a handful but… *our* handful— her wife sighed.

—Speaking of which… When do *you* guys plan on having children?

—U-us!?— Glimmer stammered, blushing furiously. She barely glanced at Bow to see him equally flustered and hesitated —We-well, it's- I mean… we haven't discussed it yet.

—We hardly have free time these days. We need to settle a lot of things before we can plan something like that— Bow told them.

—Yeah. A child needs care and time. I don't want to have a kid only to leave them in someone else's care because *I* have no time…— the Queen argued, her face still red.

—Better that way, Sparkles. Take your time.

After dinner, on their way back home, Catra and Adora decided to visit Shadow Weaver, despite being slightly drunk, simply to ask about the mask. They were too curious and, as they had decided to return on foot, they didn't have to go off their way.

As they arrived at the groove carrying a sleeping Finn, they found the woman playing a card game with the Head Sorceress; her cape was folded on the side, right next to a bundle of what seemed like a blanket and a lunchbox. It briefly reminded them of Glimmer's comment, but they dismissed it as it wasn't their business.

—Oh, girls! Good evening!— Castaspella greeted them.

—Hello, good evening.

—Evening.

—What brings you here this late?

—We have a question— Adora began, giving out her tipsiness. —It's about your mask.

—Uh?

—What about my mask?

—What was that thing made of?— Catra asked, patting Finn's back thoughtlessly.

—Why the sudden interest?

—Well, we were talking with Glimmer and it's funny how we both punched you in the face but didn't break it— the girl explained. —Well, I cracked it, but nothing else. *And* it stayed in place. So *what* was it made of?

—Haven't you considered maybe you two just aren't that strong?— the woman replied, her tone condescending.

—Spin— Castaspella warned her.

—Alright, alright— she sighed, resigned. —It was made of the same material the Horde's armors were made, but reinforced with magic, of course— the woman finally replied.

—Huh… Makes sense, I guess— Catra commented. —That thing, iridu-something.

—Yes, that *thing*. I suppose it's still quite… commendable that you could crack it— Shadow Weaver finally admitted.

Meanwhile, Castaspella looked far too confused to even ask…

Chapter End Notes

So! Here's this tumblr post that I found and gave me the idea of having Glimmer and Catra discuss when they punched SW in the face and all. Which, in this context, also opened the door to asking how the fuck Micah smashed the mask because, wow. Man's strong.
Which reminds me of this fic I wrote, *Nice Punch* where She-Ra punches SW and DOES break the mask! It's based on a really good short what-if written in a twitter thread I credit in the fic, in case you're interested. Indeed, gotta be quite strong…

On another note, YES! Entrapta has been working on a better version of the portal, so guess where's that's gonna go! This is the project foreshadowed in chapter 17, when Glimmer warned her not to activate anything without permission. Basically.
I hear theories, and I'll try not to spoil because my plans for that portal are like A HUGE THING for the next part of this series. With that I'm already telling you the portal won't be completed before this fic ends, but you'll see more about it in the next part (^v^)

Anecdotally, I low-key rushed this chapter and actually finished writing it in four hours this Monday hah!

Last note: As the only mention of whatever material they used for the armors in the Horde is when Scorpia tries and fails to read it, I can't properly name it. And whatever the material is, it's not a reference to the 80s She-Ra, cause there the only material that appears is something called "Ethernium" that they mined in Dryl, which was Horde territory, so, likely what they used for armors and weapons etc.

Anyways! Enough rambling! I hope you liked it and thank you all for reading!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: You should put effort into the relationships you appreciate
Status: Dismissed like a morning alarm

Chapter Notes

I'm still laughing at my own writing!! Haha
That status!!! XD
It's the first thing that came into my mind!

Sorry, sorry, I'll be serious now...
This lesson is maybe a callout to myself...
I don't mean to say I act just like SW, not anymore at least, but like, even my best friend will sometimes reproach me that it's difficult to get a word of appreciation from me. Much less a hug or anything of the like; I just don't do that, perhaps because I have hugs associated to negative feelings, but the point still stands.
At this point, I don't know whether I put any effort into my relationships or not; maybe my love language is not physical touch or loving words but rather actions and considerate details, however, what if my love language isn't enough?

So, well, call out to myself I guess!

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this chapter, even if it's a bit short...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was driving her crazy.

Her… strange relationship with the Head Sorceress.

She knew she'd be visiting her soon; she had learnt to recognize the feeling, so she could even guess *why* she would be going to the groove that night, but… that was exactly what drove her crazy.

She wanted to… to what? Ask her? About *that*!? And then what?

No, no, no. Their particular relationship was already quite fragile, sustained by nothing other than the summoning spell bound to Castaspella and her stubbornness. So the last thing she should be doing was questioning said relationship.

Oh, no. She wanted it to remain exactly as it was, without having to put any effort at all. If she were to question it *that* way, perhaps even the sorceress' stubbornness wouldn't be enough to keep it all together on its own.

Well, perhaps it was time for her to put in a bit of effort? Or maybe she should at least admit she cherishes this very relationship she refuses to call a “friendship” at least?

But then again, when did she become fond of her relationship with Castaspella?

Being completely honest, with herself at least, since long ago. Not like she would admit it *at all*.

However, when exactly did she realize it was a worthy relationship? Because Shadow Weaver would never *ever* hold on to a relationship, least it had something unique to offer her…

Well, it was certainly long ago but, in fact, she could remember the exact moment she realized she was being given a final chance to prove she’s worthy of all the effort the Head Sorceress had been investing in her. All the effort she still invests in her, after so many years…

—What!?

—You, with me. Now— Castaspella severely ordered.

—What if I don't want to!?

—Well, too bad for you! Now, move!

Shadow Weaver wasn’t used to being yelled back at, but after four months of being around, she already knew better and reluctantly decided to follow the Head Sorceress.

She knew what this was about: she had been yelling at everyone all day, for even the smallest things.

So what!?

She’s angry!

And she’s not stupid, she also knows Castaspella told her niece to keep the girls away from Mystacor that day. Hah! The sorceress is scared.

As she should…

—Why have you brought me here of all places?— the woman asked, her tone disgusted, as she found herself walking into Mystacor’s Beach.

Finally halting before turning around to face Shadow Weaver, Castaspella placed her hands on her sides and, instead of replying, she ordered —Tell me what’s your problem today.

—Oh, you want to know!?— she began, yelling loudly again, hands positioned as if ready to attack, all her body tense from head to toe. —Fine! Here it is! You have no idea what my current condition feels like! I *loathe* the fact that I either have to be around you or stay within that spell at the Lunarium to *feel more like a real person*!

Castaspella flinched at first and seemed about to take a step back. Instinctual reaction. Perfectly understandable.

However, when she heard what the woman said, her expression completely changed. Instead of yelling back like before, she silently took her hands and dragged her further into the beach and away from the buildings.

Now *that* was a confusing reaction Shadow Weaver couldn't understand.

Despite her annoyance, the Head Sorceress managed to convince her to sit down and then sat behind her.

—Come on, don't be a baby and do as I say… Now, lay down— Castaspella insisted, covering her eyes with her right hand.

—What on Etheria do you think you're doing!?

Uneasy, the woman stubbornly stood her ground, letting her anger hide her anxiety.

—Do you trust me?

—Of course not. I trust no one, and neither should you— Shadow Weaver replied, grunting as she felt the sorceress pulling from her. —Ugh…

In the end, she had to resign and lay down; she knew Castaspella could be far more stubborn than her, so it was better to comply and be done with it.

—Listen to me… If your problem is the feeling of this summoned body…— she began, delicately caressing one of Shadow Weaver's hands with her left hand. —…All you have to do is close your eyes and focus on the memory of being real and having your own body. It is still there…

But if the woman was already anxious, this little… experiment only worsened it. Castaspella could feel her stiffen under her touch and understood she wasn't really helping, so she decided to let go.

However, when she was about to apologize, Shadow Weaver herself grabbed her hand back and kept her eyes closed on her own.

—Just… grip it tighter. Otherwise, I don't feel anything.

She didn't have to see her to know that the sorceress was smiling as she clutched her hand tighter as requested.

But why?

Why was she doing that?

Why was Castaspella being so gentle to her when all she had been doing was yelling violently?

Only one way to know…

—Why… are you doing this, Cas? Why are you so… *nice* to me? I was shouting at everyone, even you.

—Well, I can't simply shout back at you, that would make you angrier…

—Fair enough— Shadow Weaver conceded, smirking. —So?

—I just needed you to calm down, take a break, and a deep breath, of course…

—We discussed this: I don't breathe anymore.

—We discussed this: I mean it for the psychological effect— Castaspella countered, smirking too.

—Are you sure you want to have someone like me teaching children again? How can you know I won't… explode like this in front of them?

—I can't know that. I'll just have to make sure you stay calm and, if you do explode, I'll take care of you like I just did— the Head Sorceress replied, confident.

Take care... of her?

—What a fool you are…

—Well, *this fool* just handled you pretty well, wouldn't you say? Trust me a bit…

—I trust no one and neither should you…

—I heard you the first time…

Yes… Castaspella was her final chance.

She proved as much at that moment and multiple times since then.

Ah… Yet Shadow Weaver thoroughly refused to see that.

Oh, well… It was far too early for her to understand.

But what about now?

Now, maybe it's too late for it to count…

Chapter End Notes

So, as you can see, this was a case of "the character who sees herself as a monster being treated gently for the first (?) time", and pretty much represented a watershed for SW, but it's only now dawning on her.

So, I suppose we can agree that SW has actually put a little bit of effort into the relationship on certain occasions, right? I mean, she even hugged Castaspella (willingly!) after she tried to remove the spell forcibly… And she showed real concern for her several times!

So why this chapter? Because of what I put near the beginning: she still won't label the relationship as anything, not even as a friendship. She won't allow herself to care for that relationship.

In any case, I just think she needs more time to actually manage it, to let herself care more for her different relationships, and eventually she'll soften up. I mean, she did start calling her pupils "her kids", and I don't recall now, but I think she's also referred to Adora and Catra as "her girls", at least she doesn't correct Castaspella when she calls them that.

So, anyways. 🎶 Progress! 🎶

Normal

Chapter Summary

A casual gathering will trigger memories from the past once again, and Catra will reveal her true feelings about certain events that transpired in her time as Second in Command during the war. Following that, she and Adora will take the conversation to Shadow Weaver, with less than ideal results, for which they will immediately resort to Castaspella.

» —(…)But even if that's the case, you still care for something other than yourself!
»—You're so stubborn!— she yelled, exasperated. Without thinking, she began —I only care about you because…
»—Because?
»Shadow Weaver hesitated for a moment. She wasn't sure what she was about to say, but still blurted out —Because of how you make me feel!
»Castaspella opened her eyes wide.
»What could she mean?
»Warily, she asked —That is?
»But the woman wasn't sure what to say. She didn't want to think about it, and only one word formed inside her head.

Chapter Notes

Hehehehheeh that summary is bait. Here comes the game: did u guess it right or did u let wishful thinking fool you? XD

Anyways… I feel like this chapter is a bit short, but it's quite important. Specially the beginning and the end.

So, I really hope you like it!!

Happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

About half a year quickly went by.

The Head Sorceress had been very busy the past few months, but she had managed to find time for her duties and some leisure. This particular night, she had been invited to have dinner with the Best Friends Squad, and was thrilled to attend.

Castaspella was so excited that she managed to tell them everything she had been doing the past few months before the food arrived. She told them about her duties, the classes, the requests Mystacor would sometimes get asking for magical aid… And, of course, she told them a bit about her visits to Shadow Weaver and what she considers "progress".

The Head Sorceress enumerated one by one all the small details she had noticed, the things she had felt, the things that the woman tried to hide, and together, they all represented great progress for someone like her.

Fair enough…

The Queen then shifted the focus to her and Shadow Weaver's pupils, as she was curious about how that was going.

They already knew that, occasionally, she would organize trips to take them to see the woman down at the magical groove; those had to be carefully organized with Glimmer and her friends, so they made sure her father wouldn't follow them. What they didn't know, however, was that the kids, who weren't so little anymore, were a bit upset with all the rules surrounding a simple visit. So Castaspella told them how the woman made it clear to them that either they obeyed or they wouldn't ever see her again, and that was enough to make them the most obedient children ever known.

Eventually, the food arrived just as the sorceress was telling them about Delwyn's help with several issues since he returned to Etheria. And speaking of him…

—I'm just glad we decided to set those new rules for visitors from outside Etheria because we've had a lot since he established here as an ambassador— Glimmer commented, tasting her dish. Once she swallowed, she added —It made my job much easier as he takes care of most stuff regarding that.

—That's good to hear— Castaspella replied with a smile. —I know it wasn't easy for you to take over the kingdom's duties, and something tells me it's even more difficult since the war ended, isn't that so?

—You're actually right— the Queen admitted. —But now it's all administrative, I think that's what makes it worse… It's *boring*— she complained, stretching the last word.

—Of course— Castaspella giggled.

—I swear! You guys have no idea how taxing it is! And I had no idea being Queen included so many desk chores!

—Oh, I may have an idea…

They all looked at Catra, nonchalantly taking a bite of food.

—Really?— Adora asked, confused.

—Well, yeah! I mean about the administrative stuff… After Shadow Weaver's demotion in the Horde, I was made Second in Command, and *damn*! I had no idea she handled so much boring paperwork!

—You have to be kidding me! They have- had paperwork at the Horde!?— Glimmer exclaimed.

—Yeah, quite a lot… But I recall Entrapta telling me something about the overall productivity since I took over… I don't know, something she told Hordak to convince him not to dispose of me— she tried to recall, thoughtful. —Whatever, it means I did manage to take over that woman's responsibilities, or that she was too lazy handling them. But it wasn't easy at all so, I feel you there, Sparkles…

—Well, if something I learnt from her, miraculously…— Castaspella began speaking, rolling her eyes. —Is that sometimes you have to delegate— she concluded. —Just like Delwyn took over part of

what would otherwise be handled by you, try getting some more help with other tasks— she added, addressing Glimmer.

—I always offer her help, but she says she doesn't want to bother me— Bow commented. —So, there you have it. You should let me help, Glim.

—Yeah, listen to them, alright? I also had Scorpia help me with all that paperwork… Um, before she left too, that is— Catra agreed, looking away at the end. —Then it *really* became a nightmare.

—Fine, fine, I will— Glimmer finally resigned.

—Good to hear!— Castaspella celebrated.

They continued to eat in silence for a moment until Catra sighed, having recalled something.

—Now that we speak about it… I realized something, you know?— she began, looking down. —I… recall this one time, after Entrapta joined us, when Shadow Weaver had the gall to say she had been hard on me to "prepare me for the world". You know, bullshit…— she explained. However, after a deep sighed, she continued —Or, so I thought but… I think I did the same to Entrapta.

—What? Ho-how?— Adora asked, shocked. —What do you mean?

It was obvious everyone wondered the same, so the girl took another deep breath and searched for the words to explain herself.

—What I mean is… I was hard on her, trying to protect her from Hordak, but she never listened to me. Ironically enough, she was *welcomed* by Hordak!— she replied, never looking back at her wife. —So now I get it… When Hordak praised me for doing exactly what Shadow Weaver told me *not* to do… no wonder she was so pissed! So was I at Entrapta! I felt like she was stealing the power and status I worked so hard to achieve!

She then laid back on her chair and started laughing nervously, which concerned her friends and the sorceress.

Adora carefully reached out, recognizing she was having a bit of a crisis, and told her —Hey, calm down… It's alright, Love…

—But is it, Adora?

Silence settled as no one dared answer, until Castaspella let out a sigh with her eyes closed. She understood.

—Yes, it is— she confidently said.

—How?— Catra questioned her, not looking back, and sounding defeated.

—It is normal to have behaviours that mirror those of the person who raised us— the sorceress explained, looking away with a shy expression. She then looked back, more confident again, and went on —This goes for everyone. It is normal, alright? What you should remember now, is that you realized what was wrong with that.

—I suppose…

The girl still seemed overwhelmed, depressed, and even refused to take Adora's hand, so Castaspella dared add —If it somehow helps, let me tell you this: knowing that someone, like you, who didn't mean to be so harsh, ended up behaving that way because of the threats of your environment, you can be sure that it *wasn't* your fault.

—What do you mean?— Catra asked, finally looking back at the Head Sorceress.

—I've told you several times that you did nothing to deserve the way you were treated, and *this* is proof of it.

—I… think I get it— she sighed, leaning forward. —Not only this, a-also what you said last year at the Fright Zone… I hadn't thought about it before but… now it seems ridiculous to have expected "kindness" from Shadow Weaver in our situation— she admitted. —I-I mean, even the slightly nicer treatment Adora got was motivated by the potential power that woman saw in her, so- It's just that… I wasn't any different with Scorpia or Entrapta! I was only nice to them when they did things right. And I *wanted* to be nice! But whenever they made the smallest of mistakes, I would- I felt like it was my fault for being too soft with them— Catra reflected, letting out a scoff. —Damn… I even recall yelling at Scorpia "How can you possibly be so useless", which is *literally* what Shadow Weaver always told *me*!

—Love…— Adora muttered, rubbing her wife's back to comfort her.

—None of that makes you like her, understood?— Castaspella assured her.

—I- Yeah, I know I wasn't really like her. I mean, opposite to how she threatened to dispose of me, I tried to keep her safe. I didn't want Hordak to send her to Beast Island…— she recalled, staring at the ground. However, she immediately sat up and looked back at the sorceress to counter —But, still. I was so *eager* to take revenge on her! Wasn't that what motivated that woman to join the Horde in the first place!? Or what then made her rejoin the Rebellion!?

The girl laughed again, indignant at the irony.

—But that isn't all, is it?— the Head Sorceress gently asked.

—I suppose not… I mean, Scorpia quickly picked up on how much I cared for Shadow Weaver, despite everything, and questioned me about it. And when she left me… I think I understand now. I always thought my worst was when I opened the portal and broke reality; that she left too because of that. But, in fact, I had been slowly turning into another Shadow Weaver since before…— Catra reflected, staring at the ground again. —Looking back, I can't help but notice that, after Scorpia left, I was scared to death because I knew Hordak would want my head! And I began to behave *exactly* like that woman, if not worse… I would talk like her, give orders like her, the cadets were scared of me like we were of her… I kid you not when I say I actually see her instead of myself when remembering all of this.

Concerned, Glimmer and Bow exchanged a glance, not daring to speak, and set aside their dishes. Adora then looked back at them, silently asking for help, but none knew what to do. It was obvious Catra needed to let all of this out, but how to comfort her now?

—I see…— Castaspella sighed, looking down at her hands for a moment.

—I say it like this now, I can even laugh it off, but this isn't the first time I realize that I behaved like her. The first time I did, I couldn't sleep for days, but I guess I'll be fine now— the girl said, letting out a sad smile. —And that's not all… There's another thing I did just like her: after Adora left,

Shadow Weaver tried to get her back desperately and disobeyed Hordak, she got punished and finally demoted; in the same way, I disobeyed him as I was trying to keep her from being sent to Beast Island, until the truth came out and I got punished and demoted too. I suppose I would have left the Horde like her… if it wasn't because I didn't want revenge on the Horde but rather on her and Adora for… leaving me. So there I was, redoubling my efforts at the Horde…— she concluded, scoffing again.

Once more, there was silence. This time, however, Adora didn't hesitate to hug Catra tightly. At first, the girl didn't move and kept looking down, yet it wasn't long before she finally gave in, closed her eyes, and leaned onto her wife's hug.

—Thank you for sharing all of this with us, Catra— Castaspella eventually said, after giving them a moment. As the girls broke the hug, she went on —I think it's important that you recognize all of this, that you admit it to yourself, but don't overlook that your motivations were far from cruel. Just as you see all the similarities between you two, remember to weigh the differences as well.

—Yeah… I-I think that's the only thing keeping me sane— Catra admitted, with a sad chuckle. —I should thank you, guys. Sorry for unloading all of this on you.

—It's fine, Catra— Bow immediately replied. —It's better if you let it out— he assured her, with a gentle look.

The following day, the Head Sorceress was having a tranquil day; something quite unusual in the past few months. However, there was a feeling she couldn't quite place making her uneasy. Whatever it was, she decided the best idea would be to take a relaxing bath at the steam grotto, so she didn't hesitate to take the afternoon off to unwind.

The place was empty that day. Simply perfect.

Castaspella chose her favorite pool and got in, already feeling much more at ease. With a sigh, she leaned back and sank all the way to her neck, and before she knew, she was drifting into sleep.

Her dreams, however, were tumultuous, so to speak.

Perhaps it was because the anniversary of Shadow Weaver's summoning was just a few days away, or perhaps she was unconsciously thinking about her; whatever the reason, she dreamt about the woman, and about her brother.

They were arguing at the Lunarium, the summoning spell was drawn on the ground, the pieces of Shadow Weaver's mask were inside the basin like back then, and she could see the moons aligned through the oculus.

The subject of their discussion was, obviously, the sorceress.

Micah was telling her to stay away, to keep her distance from Castaspella, while the woman argued that she tried but couldn't because it was her who insisted on being close. Incredulous, the sorcerer argued it was her fault, that she was manipulating his sister, but Shadow Weaver only rolled her eyes and accused him of being paranoid.

It seemed like they didn't notice Castaspella's presence, so she tried to approach but couldn't move. Confused, she looked down to her hands and noticed she was opaque, just like Shadow Weaver, as if

she were summoned too. And that was when Micah said something that shocked the sorceress: that he didn't bring Castaspella back just to lose her again.

The Head Sorceress woke up startled, gasping for air as she sat up, and immediately looked over herself. Seeing she was very much alive, she looked around hoping no one saw and sighed in relief as, fortunately, the place was still empty.

—What was that?— she wondered, brushing her hands down her face. —I… feel so dizzy. How long did I sleep?— she then asked herself.

Realizing she had overstayed her visit to the grotto and now the steam was affecting her, she carefully left the pool and wrapped herself in a towel. However, she barely took a step forward before falling to her knees as her vision became black.

She could feel herself about to faint and made one last effort to draw a spell before completely passing out.

It was a distress spell; something easy to draw, designed for situations like that where the caster required urgent assistance.

Luckily, two of her councillors caught the signal and rushed to find her at the grotto, still wrapped in her towel, albeit completely unconscious.

It was already nighttime when Catra and Adora arrived at the floating island. They were looking for the Head Sorceress, and were surprised to find several people at Castaspella's door.

—What happened now?— Adora wondered, stopping a few meters away.

—Only one way to find out— her wife replied, approaching. —Um… Hey. What's going on here?

—Ah, apologies. If you come to see the Head Sorceress, I'm afraid you'll have to return later— Nolrem politely said.

—And what happened?— Catra insisted.

—Don't worry, you can tell her— Delwyn assured the councillors, who decided to trust him.

—Alright— Arden began. —About half an hour ago, we found the Head Sorceress passed out at the steam grotto— they explained, surprising the girls. —Both her brother and the Queen are inside now, helping her recover, as she just woke up.

—Is she alright?— Adora asked, taking a step forward.

—Yes, of course. It seems like the steam affected her; there's nothing to worry about— Nolrem assured them.

—However, it's better not to bother her now— Arden insisted.

Catra glanced back at Adora with a disappointed expression and let out a resigned sigh. However, before they could so much as think about leaving, the door opened and Micah stepped out.

—She's fine. And stubborn. She wants to get up already— he explained, shaking his head. —Glimmer is trying to convince her to stay, but I don't think she will…

—When can we speak to her?— Catra tentatively asked.

—There's no point in waiting, I guess. So, if you want to go in now… Talking with you, she'll at least stay in there instead of going to…— he replied, but interrupted himself before finishing the phrase. —Never mind.

With a sigh, he excused himself and walked away before the councillors or Delwyn could say anything. The three looked at the girls for a moment before reluctantly letting them pass, and stayed next to the door after they closed behind them.

—Hey, Sparkles. Head Sorceress— Catra said, announcing herself.

Both she and Adora approached warily and seemed surprised to see Castaspella so awake. They couldn't believe she had fainted not long ago.

—Guys, what are you doing here?— Glimmer asked, standing up from where she was kneeling next to the bed.

—We needed to talk to your aunt but were stopped at the door— Adora explained. However, she then gave the sorceress a look and commented —But she really seems quite fine.

—Because I am, I swear— she quickly replied, sitting up.

—No, no, no, no. Stay there— the Queen told her, stopping her aunt from standing up.

—Glimmer, I'm fine!

—No, you're not!

—Please…— she complained, closing her eyes. —At least let me hear what the girls needed to talk about, alright?

—Only if you stay here in bed— the Queen bargained.

—Alright, alright. I'll stay here— she agreed. —So, what happened?— she asked, addressing them.

—Well… You're not gonna like it…— Catra began, looking away.

—I'll leave you three alone— Glimmer decided. —Just make sure she stays here— she asked, before waving and teleporting away.

—We may have made the wrong decision, but we went to talk to Shadow Weaver just earlier— Adora explained, looking at her wife with an encouraging look.

—About?

—What we talked about yesterday.

—Oh…

—And, at first, it was going great! She even apologized again! But then she… got angry, really angry, and lashed out at me— Catra went on. —Perhaps it was because of the apology, I don't know.

Something just made her start muttering about weaknesses again, and about influence…

—I think she remembered when I told her she… only ruins people— Adora admitted, looking away. —I- It was long ago. I yelled at her that I would never forgive her and that she only ruins people and any chance they have of being happy…

—I see…

—It was after I took the failsafe. I was so angry, I meant it back then, but… even if I try to take it back now, she's already… giving up— she lamented.

—That's understandable, Adora— Castaspella assured her, giving her a gentle look. —Back then, she was… an awful person. You have all the right to feel like that, and if you no longer think that way, if you really want to take it back, that's completely valid too— she went on. —I suppose she won't accept it right away, and it's easier to give up, but that doesn't mean she will throw away all her progress.

—She reverted, again— Catra reminded her, frowning, more sorrowful than angry.

—Which is normal. But I think that anger is directed at herself, not you. And now, even if she reverts, she feels regret and guilt. It's not like before— the sorceress argued. —Tell me, Adora. What did she reply back then?

—That she did what she had to.

—I imagined. And now?

—I didn't say it again. She just… started yelling that she doesn't understand why she's trying if I already decided never to forgive her— Adora explained. —That's why I think she remembered what I said. I told her I don't think so anymore, but…— she added, yet didn't finish the phrase.

—It sounds like she wants to give up, you're right. But it's not your fault— Castaspella insisted. —And I'm sure I can help with that. She only needs some support— she considered. With a sigh, she concluded —Leaving her alone now won't help. It will consume her until she's convinced there's no point in trying.

—Do-do you plan to go *now*?— Adora asked, surprised.

—But you just…

—I told you all I'm fine!— the sorceress insisted. —So, yes. I need to go now… Especially with the feeling I'm getting from her— she added, placing a hand on her chest. —It may be difficult to believe, but you must trust me: she's not trying to justify it now, she's agonizing about this.

—Glimmer will kill us— Adora told Catra.

—Yeah. But we can't stop her, can we?— she replied, shaking her head.

—No, you can't— Castaspella agreed, grinning. —I shall go now. Please close the door when you leave.

With that, the sorceress cast a teleportation spell and disappeared, leaving the girls alone. As instructed, they closed the door when they walked out, making sure no one had time to peek inside and see she was gone.

—I imagine she's still there, right?— Nolrem asked with a warning tone.

—Of course! She just wants to rest now. It's late— Catra lied, letting out half a smile.

Needless to say, they didn't believe her. However, they couldn't do anything about it, so the councillors let the girls go without much questioning, and offered to walk the ambassador to the entrance.

When Castaspella appeared at the groove, she couldn't deny she felt dizzy for a moment. However, it passed quickly, and the sorceress instead focused on the fact that Shadow Weaver wasn't showing up.

What was happening? She couldn't really be *choosing* to stay down at the core, could she?

Well, Castaspella wouldn't leave until she could speak with her.

Decided, and mildly offended, the sorceress sat down against a tree and stubbornly waited there. The woman always knew when someone showed up there, so she *had* to appear at some point…

Just as she thought, it took a good while but, finally, the spirit of Shadow Weaver rose from the ground.

—What are you doing here!?— she immediately asked, seething.

Castaspella pushed herself up and approached the woman as she replied —Catra told me you lashed out at her…

—And what!? I know! I don't need your reproaching, I'm enough on my own!

—I'm just trying to help!— the sorceress argued.

—Just go away! Leave me! They are right! I only ruin people!

—That's not true!— she immediately denied. —Yes, you've hurt them so much it left a deep scar on them; but do they seem ruined to you!? Even if Catra became such a threat to us after you left the Horde, isn't she recovered now!? Didn't she *choose* to do better despite her past actions!?— Castaspella pointed out. —Doesn't it mean you can do the same!?

—Stop talking nonsense! You're too naïve! You just see what you want to see!— Shadow Weaver accused her.

—I did not hallucinate your sacrifice! They didn't either!

—Yet you fail to see it was selfish!— she argued. —I did it for myself! For my own peace of mind! Finally did something for them and died so I wouldn't have to face the consequences!

—Oh really!? Then what do you think you're doing here!? Huh!? Because I've literally pushed you to face the consequences of everything you've done! Beginning with Micah himself!— the sorceress reproached her. —Still think I'm naïve!?

—Please, you're too gentle to have done that on purpose!— the woman mocked her. —You noticed just now that you've done it!

—Of course not! My original idea was to help you face and try to fix the consequences of your choices!— she assured her. —You know, before I knew you had *died*! So guess what!? I summoned you and made it happen regardless!

—And achieved nothing!

—Didn't I!? Then why did you apologize to the girls!? Why were you agonizing about lashing out at Catra!?— Castaspella questioned her.

—I was not!

—I can feel what you feel!

—Fine! I was! But only because I knew you'd react like that!— Shadow Weaver admitted, still trying to pretend it wasn't what the sorceress thought.

—I don't believe you. But even if that's the case, you still care for something other than yourself!

—You're so stubborn!— she yelled, exasperated. Without thinking, she began —I only care about you because…

—Because?

Shadow Weaver hesitated for a moment. She wasn't sure what she was about to say, but still blurted out —Because of how you make me feel!

Castaspella opened her eyes wide.

What could she mean?

Warily, she asked —That is?

But the woman wasn't sure what to say. She didn't want to think about it, and only one word formed inside her head.

Without giving it much thought, she uttered —Normal.

Chapter End Notes

See what I mean? There's an important cathartic moment for Catra at the beginning, and an important progress moment for SW at the end.

Goodness, I forgot what I wanted to say here… just sorry I'm posting a bit late today, hehe <(^-^)

I hope you liked the chapter, and see you next week!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

> The lesson: loving someone is a reason to keep going
> Status: *cursing…*
> *swearing…*
> *initiating crisis state…*

Chapter Notes

> I think you will like this chapter. And I also think it represents great progress, even if kinda silent.
> I don't know how to explain it, but like, she does accept this lesson, yet it doesn't change much for now. So it's like silent progress.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castaspella makes her feel normal, she said. What did she even mean?

Whatever it was, the sorceress seemed to have understood it, as she didn't question her about it.

In any case, it was now undeniable how much Beatrix cared for her relationship with Castaspella, to the point she became afraid of hurting her in *any* way. This wasn't a new thing, but she was realizing it only now.

Thinking back, her fear of hurting the sorceress was actually very old now; of course, she could connect it to her apparent weakness for anyone related to Micah, combined with the events that occurred in Mystacor before her dismissal. That would explain why her worst nightmare was physically hurting Castaspella.

Thinking about this, she couldn't help but reflect on the memory of the first time she was confronted with that fact…

> Shadow Weaver was but a spectator. She couldn't control anything as her shadows scared Castaspella, pushing her around, making her run away in fear. It wasn't even herself but rather one of her shadow spies, exactly like when she attacked Mystacor years ago.
>
> The shadows continued to persecute the sorceress with relentless force. Rushing down the halls, several tendrils went after her, and Shadow Weaver couldn't stop them.
>
> Finally, they caught up and, in a blink, they stabbed Castaspella in the abdomen, making her gasp.

—What the fu- Cas!?— the woman yelled, a second before finding herself inside the sorceress' room.

Almost immediately, Shadow Weaver looked back to see her leaving the bathroom, hair down, drying her face with a towel.

—What's going on? Why the screams?— she simply asked, confused, her voice muffled by the towel. However, as soon as she actually *saw* the woman, she pointed out —Wha-what is it!? I've never seen you so scared before. I-I don't think I've seen you really scared at all!

—What was that?— Shadow Weaver muttered, stunned.

—What happened, Bea? A-and when did you come in?

—I… wasn't here?— she asked back.

—I woke up just a moment ago and you weren't, no.

Forcing herself out of her shock, Shadow Weaver cleared her throat and composed herself before explaining —I-I think I had a dream… A nightmare may be a more appropriate term in this case.

—That's impossible but… wha-what was it about?

—I was… I wasn't in control, and I killed you. Then I just found myself here— the woman told her, shaking her head.

—What!?— Castaspella gasped, shocked. —Bu-but it's impossible! You can't have dreams, or nightmares, for that matter.

—I am *not* making this up! I found myself chasing after you, and I wasn't in control until right after stabbing you! That was when I yelled and saw I was in your room— Shadow Weaver insisted. —I can't even remember where I was before…

—A-alright. First of all: don't be so nonchalant when speaking about stabbing me, that was extremely uncomfortable— the sorceress began, shaking her hands in front of her. —Second: this is *not* normal. We should look into this, because you *definitely* can't dream anymore.

She was being quite sensible about this.

—What is your plan then?

—We should probably start by checking the summoning spell, wouldn't you say?

—Clever.

Yes, sensible indeed.

Perhaps it wasn't "nice" to mention how she stabbed her in that nightmare without the slightest hint of remorse, but who cares!?

In any case, she was simply stating a fact… Nothing worth dwelling on. Specially not *now*.

Without losing time, the women headed for the Lunarium, carefully stepped into the area of the spell and, immediately, their attention was drawn by the basin in the middle, as it gave out a faint

light.

—What is that?— Castaspella asked, approaching.

—Let me see— Shadow Weaver said, curious, walking past her. As soon as she looked into the stone pool, she frowned and reached inside. —I should have known.

—What? A plant?— the sorceress noticed, the moment the woman took it out of the water. —How did it end here?

—Do you know what this is?

—I suppose it's one of your plants.

—Yes, but I meant what plant is this, what it does.

—I have no idea.

—To put it simple, this part of the plant, this white and cyan flower, is usually used to induce nightmares. Other parts, like the dark purple and red leaves, induce the sweetest dreams— Shadow Weaver explained.

It was technically true.

However, she omitted the part about the nightmares being specifically your *worst* nightmare.

Something made her hold back that tiny detail, and she preferred to completely disregard the thought.

—I suppose that explains it. Is it fixed now that you removed it?

—It should— the woman replied, frowning as she crushed the flower inside her fist.

What a nuisance…

After that, Shadow Weaver elected to dismiss the whole event; she didn't care enough. But the Head Sorceress tried to find out who put it there. To no avail, of course.

They never learnt who did it.

She refused to dwell on it back then, but hurting Castaspella was her worst nightmare, it couldn't be denied.

After all, hadn't it caused a great impact on her when the sorceress woke up from the nightmare of Shadow Weaver digging her claws into her throat? Didn't she begin her little attention of tying her bun as a way to "make up for it"?

She never allowed herself to reflect on why she decided to do that, but now it was inevitable.

Well, she'll be damned…

Much to Shadow Weaver's horror, the woman had regrown her heart… for Castaspella. Hadn't she?

Then, what now?

Beatrix didn’t have many options: she could accept it and curse herself, or she could deny it and pretend none of it was true. The latter, however, would mean betraying Castaspella’s trust, treating her coldly from now on, and even reverting to her old self.

But how would she *ever* accept having such a weakness!? It was enough with admitting both Micah and Catra were her weaknesses, both influencing her behaviour towards them, albeit in opposite ways. And now the sorceress!?

No way, it was too much…

But, perhaps, there was more to this?

Maybe she wasn’t a mere weakness, but rather a new source of strength, of purpose. Once, Adora told her that loving someone is a reason to keep going. So, maybe…

Ugh, but how?

How!?

How!?

It made no sense to Shadow Weaver. It was ridiculous.

Yet there was no other explanation. What else could be driving her to go through the most tortuous feelings in order to “grow”? What else, if not the sorceress, could have helped her bear the weight of learning to apologize? And how exactly would she have arrived at where she’s now without Castaspella’s support every step of the way?

She’ll be damned, indeed…

Chapter End Notes

I have to say, I don't like how I wrote the flashback; it's like two different people wrote the chapter. I am satisfied with the first and last parts, but the flashback in-between? I just don't like how I wrote it yet I don't know how to fix it!!

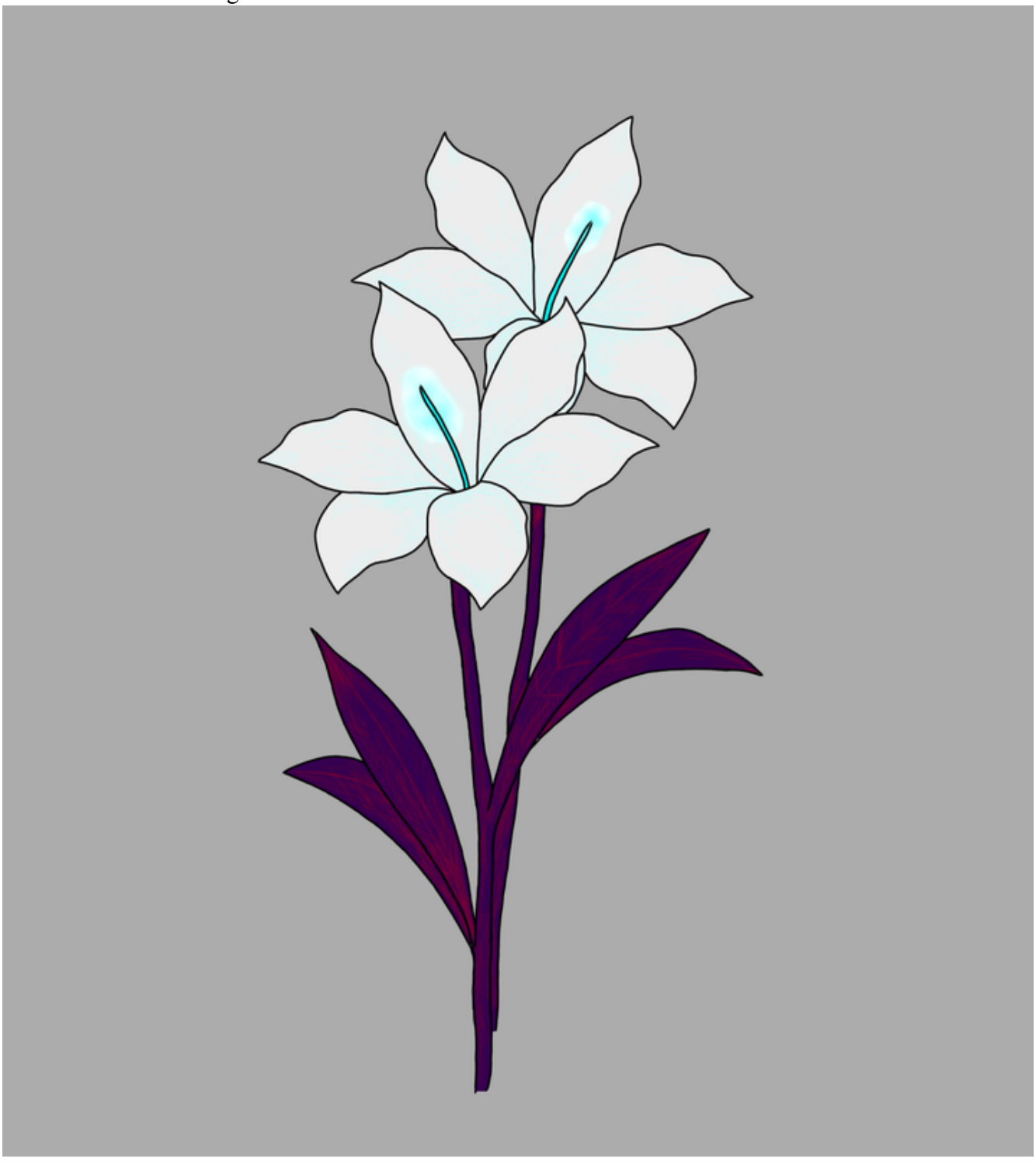
Anyways...
On another note:
I am completely making up that plant. Don't ask me why, but I had to, hehe

Tbh, I am really interested in all those plants SW cultivated, and it would have been interesting to know more. So, ofc I headcanon the effects of some of them. In plant-based medicine, different parts of the plants work for different things and have different effects, some being toxic and some being safe, edible maybe, even in the same plant. So I applied that concept to this plant, but made it so the most ominous-looking part was the inoffensive one, while the most beautiful/good-looking part was the dangerous one.

Now I wanna draw that plant... As I write this, I'm planning on doing it, so you can expect an edit with the drawing if I actually do it.

Anyways, thank you so much for reading, and I hope you enjoyed the chapter!!!

Edit: Here's the drawing! I did it!



Jack of All Trades

Chapter Summary

As time goes by, Catra's powers keep developing beyond the siblings' imagination, and Micah will resort to Castaspella for help. In turn, the Head Sorceress will request Shadow Weaver's assistance, only to be confronted with her good old perfectionism…

However, Catra's newfound skills won't be the only news this year. Queen Glimmer and King Bow have some of their own, and wish to share them with their families.

»—If you guys don’t mind… I’ll bother you just for a short message— Glimmer said. As everyone, even Finn, looked at her, she put down her glass and took a deep breath. —Great! Now, I wanted to tell you all why I organized this gathering, you know? I’m glad you all could come because I wanted to share this news with all of you first— she explained. —I… Well…— she then hesitated. The Queen glanced back at her husband, taking in a deep breath, and gathered the courage to speak. She grabbed his hand firmly and finally announced —Bow and I…

Chapter Notes

SUSPENSE!
Hahah

Ok, I think you'll like this chapter and might find the ending a bit heart-churning, ngl

I don't know what else I wanted to say here, so... Enjoy!!

PS: Oh, I know. I apologize for posting so late. I almost entirely forgot I had to update today (x-x)
Now yes, please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A few months went by and the Guild Dance quickly arrived. The usual issues returned to ruin the day for Castaspella, but she still managed to enjoy the event as much as possible. With some help, the sorceress could keep away the obnoxious theatre manager until the end of the night.

As everyone began retiring, Castaspella was ready to leave too, but her brother stopped her at the door of the main hall. He took her to a more secluded area and let out a long sigh.

—Did something happen, Brother?

—Nothing bad, don’t worry. I just wanted to talk to you about Catra’s training.

—Please don’t tell me you hit a roadblock too…

—No, no. It's actually the opposite! The more she practices, the more abilities she develops!— he explained, now excited, his eyes shining with enthusiasm. —I still don't know if it's innate from her or related to her connection with Melog, but shapeshifting isn't her only skill! The same things Melog can do… she has the potential to do them too!

—Are you serious!?

—I swear! It's been by accident for now, but she managed to turn herself invisible when scared, and levitated some rocks when angry. Oh, *and*, when she was spacing out, she conjured some illusion around her and didn't even notice!

—What!? When did that happen!?

—It has been happening for the past few months. I didn't see the thing with the rocks, she just told me she accidentally shot some rocks at a pair of trees when she was blowing off some steam in the woods — he explained, oblivious of the fact that, actually, those rocks were shot at Shadow Weaver when she pissed off the girl. —But the illusion thing, I saw it. I left her studying a text and when I returned, everything around her looked like… like a gray desert. I'm not sure what it was, because it disappeared when she noticed my presence.

—And turning invisible? Are you sure it's the same Melog does? I remember how it felt and it was similar to illusion magic; we could see each other while invisible…— Castaspella pointed out.

—That was actually a funny accident; I'll only say I scared her and she disappeared for a moment. It was Catra who compared it to Melog's power— Micah explained.

—Alright, I see. So, we can presume she has all the abilities Melog has, and that her projection of an animal form is part of the illusion magic she can wield?

—So I think, yes.

—But?

—But… I can't really teach her how to control her powers. The shapeshifting and projections are easy, very similar to our sorcery, but I don't really understand how Melog's powers work. It was already difficult to teach Catra to control the only two abilities we knew about— he explained, lamenting the situation.

—There must be something about those powers. At least some general information we can use as basis…— Castaspella thought aloud.

—That's why I'm talking with you. If you can help me with that, I'll be glad.

—O-of course! I'll do my best— she promised, stammering a bit as a thought came to mind. A good idea, but not one she could share with him. —I'll get right to it now. Do you know where Catra is?

—I think she was about to leave…

—Alright, I'll go find her.

—Thanks, Sis.

—It's no problem at all.

The Head Sorceress rushed to intercept the girls before they left the island, and quickly explained what her brother had told her.

—He said he can't help with this. Is there really a way for me to learn how to control these new powers?— Catra asked, hopeful.

—Well… There's someone who might know…

—Oh— Adora immediately realized. —I suppose it's worth a shot. She did help *me* control She-Ra powers that no one else knew how to handle.

—Oh, wait. You mean Shadow Weaver?

—Yes…— the sorceress admitted, looking away.

—And how would she know about powers from an alien race like Melog's!?

—Her understanding of magic is… unfathomable. I swear, I don't comprehend how she knows so much— Castaspella began. —Perhaps she doesn't really know, but she may have an idea. I just think it's worth trying.

—Alright— Catra sighed, rolling her eyes and folding her arms. —But don't be surprised if she refuses…

—Well, she has all the right to refuse, but we won't know if we never ask.

However, Catra rejected it at the last minute and didn't go to the groove that night.

In fact, she didn't go to speak with Shadow Weaver for a whole month.

No one wanted to pressure her, of course, so the girl could have all the time she needed to gather strength.

A week after their anniversary, she finally made up her mind and went for the Head Sorceress.

It was time.

—What a surprise… Look who decided to pay this old woman a visit again— Shadow Weaver said, as soon as she surfaced.

—Why can't you simply say "Hello, glad to see you again"?— Castaspella reproached her, hands on her hips.

—Where's the fun in that?

—Why do you enjoy annoying people so much?— Catra asked, genuinely confused albeit a bit irked.

—Not just anyone.

—Alright, let me rephrase— the girl quickly said. —Why do you enjoy annoying the people who care for you so much!?

—Ah, now *that* is more like it. And the answer is simple: it's easier to annoy you *because* you're foolish enough to care— she replied, condescending, her hands joined behind her back.

—You're really insufferable, you know that?— the Head Sorceress muttered, rolling her eyes.

—I heard you.

—Alright, enough. We came to discuss something important— Castaspella sentenced, already fed up. She gestured at Catra to encourage her to speak, and only added —Be a decent person and hear her out.

—As you wish— the woman sighed, resigned.

—Okay, so… You know how I've been studying magic for the past few years?

—This is about your new powers, I reckon…

—I- Ho-how did you know!?

—Spin, didn't I just ask you to *listen*!?

—I heard it when your brother told you, Cas. What's the point of making her repeat it all?— she nonchalantly excused herself.

—Oh, my. Just *please* listen to her!

—What else is there to listen to? You both want my help, no? Well, you'll maybe get it when you're ready— she argued.

—Can't you just tell us if you'll teach me?— she requested. —I *am* ready— the girl confidently stated.

—Are you? Really? You should focus on one at a time, Catra. You must perfect one skill before attempting to develop another one— Shadow Weaver replied, her tone still quite condescending.

—But I can't- I-I just can't focus on one only, I get bored! Can't you just answer me?

—Fine. Then here's my reply: I am *not* helping you with this. Jack of all trades, master of none; it's senseless.

—Enough! Stop that— Castaspella interrupted, severe, before Catra could react. She then took the girl a few steps away and told her, in a low tone, —Don't listen to her. If she won't help you, then I'll do my best to try instead.

—What the…

—No! What the heck are *you* doing!?— the sorceress interrupted once more, angrily stalking towards the woman. —Poisoning her head with your bullshit again! Why!?

Equally angry, Shadow Weaver retorted —I am *not*! It's a fact!

—Damn you, it isn't!— Castaspella rebuked. —If you don't want to help, fine by me! But that shitty reason is *not* true! What did you say? "Jack of all trades, master of none"; that is *not* a bad thing at all. She may not be perfect at everything she's learning, *but* she can at the very least do it. If she's average

at all things, what does it matter? At least she can try, at least she *can* do it. Even if not perfectly!— she argued. It was quickly starting to exasperate the woman, who couldn't help but admit that the sorceress was right. —"Jack of all trades" is way better than "master of *one*". That cursed perfectionism of yours… If you don't want to help because it doesn't interest you or whatever, just *say so*.

—Stop it! I got the message— she cut her off, resigned.

With a grunt, Shadow Weaver folded her arms and was ready to agree as, in fact, a part of her *did* want to help, yet Catra's nervous laugh called both women's attention instead.

—She's right— she said, with a shocked expression. They weren't sure who she meant, but it became obvious as she questioned —Why did it always have to be that, if it wasn't perfect, then I was useless!?

—Catra…

Angry but also sad, the girl went on —Did you know I then told the same to Scorpia? To Loonie? Literally everyone!? I- You just- *How* did I not realize!?

—Yes, I know. The same happened with Adora— Shadow Weaver admitted, looking away.

—Exactly— Castaspella sighed.

—Then just drop the bullshit! Please!— Catra pleaded.

—Fine, fine. I said I got the message— she let out, eyes closed and hands slightly raised in a surrendering gesture. With a sigh, she finally said —I'll help you out. Both of you. I reckon I'll need your help with this too, Cas…

—You really don't have to do it if you don't want to— Castaspella uttered, looking away as she now felt like she was forcing the woman to agree.

—I… suppose *do* I want to. I still think it's too early… but if you're so eager to learn, then I shall teach. Would you assist me?

—I plan on doing whatever I can— the sorceress assured her.

—Good— the girl sighed too. —I can't believe it took me a month to prepare for this and I still wasn't prepared for your bullshit…— she complained, tired, brushing her hands down her face.

—You should already know that you'll *never* be prepared for everything— Shadow Weaver reproached her.

—But she can *try*— Castaspella talked back. —And *that* is why you should share *all* the information you have, not just what you *think* is relevant.

—You can't seriously be talking about the failsafe again…

—What if I am!?

—We have discussed it many times. I don't see why you keep bringing it up— Shadow Weaver complained.

—I feel like I saw this before— Catra uttered, realizing this was exactly how they bickered when they were *on their way* to the failsafe.

—Just…— Castaspella began, and interrupted herself with a sigh. —Don't omit anything this time. Especially if it could endanger her life. Even if you are "sure" she can handle it or whatever, *don't omit it*.

—Alright, alright…

A week later, Queen Glimmer organized a small family reunion to which she invited her friends with their kid, her father, Bow's too, and her aunt. They all gathered in a large room with several couches and a table in the middle; there was food and drinks for everyone, and different conversations were happening simultaneously.

To the left, the Best Friends Squad ate and chatted amicably, Melog laying at Catra's feet; to the right, Castaspella took care of Finn while knitting a bit, and listened to George and Lance as they narrated some shenanigans of their kids when they were little.

It had begun early in the afternoon, and now the sun was coming down yet they had hardly noticed…

While the youngsters discussed plans for the future, new projects, and missions, the four oldies couldn't help but talk about how much Glimmer and Bow had grown.

Suddenly, the Head Sorceress was distracted by little Finn playing with the ball of yarn.

—Aw, do you like it?— she asked them. —Come here— she then said, sitting the baby on her lap. She grabbed their hands carefully, making Finn hold the needles, and guided their hands to "teach" them how to knit. —Move them like that, loop the thread, and pass the needle through it…

—That's so adorable!— Lance squealed, his eyes almost shining as he saw Finn laser-focused on the needles' movement.

Of course, the little kid completely messed up, which made everyone laugh.

—I'll teach them how to knit… Eventually. For now, it's okay for them to play with the yarn— Castaspella smiled.

Completely charmed, Lance added —You're the cutest baby I've seen since my kids…

Having overheard them for a moment, Bow blushed and looked away, while Glimmer giggled along with Adora and Catra.

—Hey, Sparkles, is your aunt seriously trying to teach our kid how to knit?

—Are you surprised?

—We leave them an hour with her and this is what happens…— she sighed, smiling fondly while shaking her head, quite amused. —So we can expect some ugly sweaters in a few years— Catra laughed.

—Oh, please. You'd wear them at all times if Finn made them— Adora playfully reproached her.

—Ah… It's a nice reunion…— Glimmer sighed, looking around fondly, especially happy to see her dad and her aunt sitting together. —Everyone is here, right? I didn't miss anyone.

—Of course you didn't— Catra assured her. —A shame your brothers couldn't come, Arrow Boy—. She then snorted and added —'Cause I bet even Shadow Weaver is around.

—Then remind me not to diss her— the Queen replied, raising her brows.

—As if you hadn't told her to fuck off to her face…

The four laughed together and continued eating and discussing their business.

Meanwhile, George and Lance had changed the focus of their conversation to the siblings. Concerned, they asked about some rumours of them not getting along, and asked how things were going.

—I… don't know what to tell you. I-I mean, we argue like all siblings— Micah began, hesitant.

—Normally, this isn't something I would openly discuss with anyone, but I see you're concerned— Castaspella sentenced. She let Finn fumble with the piece of knitting and the yarn, set the needles aside so they wouldn't have any accidents, and went on —I suppose it's true that we haven't had the best relationship the past few years but, as you can see, it's nothing serious.

—We don't mean to pry, but is it true that your disagreements are… related to that woman? Uh…— George began asking, but hesitated as he couldn't remember the name.

—Shadow Weaving— Lance said.

—*Weaver*— Castaspella corrected. She then sighed, avoiding her brother's sight, and resignedly explained —Yes, technically, that's true. Again, this isn't something I feel comfortable talking about as it's all private business, but I realize you're not just indulging in gossip, so… Well, we have our differences because I believe she has changed, improved, while my brother insists it's all manipulation.

—I just think this… project of yours, reforming Shadow Weaver or something, is pointless! Why would you invest so much time in someone who did so much harm while she was alive!?

—We're not discussing this now…

—Sorry, sorry— Lance quickly said. —We didn't mean to make you two argue.

—It's nothing.

—I must say I'm actually interested in your point of view, Castaspella— George said. —Our boy told us a bit, and I believe your values are admirable.

—I just think everyone deserves the opportunity to learn and change— the sorceress explained. —I know it sounds insane when referring to her, but had I not seen her growth myself…

—So she *has* changed?— Lance quickly asked.

—A lot. I swear. I don't know if Bow told you how her relationship with Catra and Adora is, but she has even apologized to them for everything she did!

—A simple "sorry" can't undo everything she put them through— Micah mumbled.

—But that isn't the point, either— his sister remarked.

—I must agree— George stated, folding his arms. —A simple apology can't fix things… but that isn't what it should do either— he went on. —When we discovered Bow had actually joined the Rebellion and wasn't studying but rather pretending, we were confronted with a hard truth: we weren't the fathers we thought we were. In a way, we had also put him through hell— he elaborated. —He had been living a double life, he couldn't be himself around us… and who knows how much he suffered because we created an environment where he didn't feel safe being honest.

—Yes, I see your point— Lance agreed, understanding where his husband was going. —We couldn't undo the years of fear and shame he went through, but only because we apologized, from the bottom of our hearts, did we fix our broken trust and strengthen our relationship. I know we did what our son needed, not to erase what we had caused, but so he could feel safe at last.

—But that's the difference— Micah replied. —You *do* have a heart. You never intended to cause your son any trouble. What you did wasn't putting his life at risk!

—Micah— Castaspella interrupted. —I know the experiences aren't comparable, but did you listen to him? Apologies have an effect on people that go beyond mere fixing faults and what has been. Sometimes people need to hear an apology from those who hurt them because… it soothes the deepest scars engraved on them. Someone who gets an apology is someone who will no longer blame themselves for the pain they suffered.

—King Micah— George called. —I understand that what happened to you, what she did to you, put your life at risk, as you said before. Correct?— he began. When the sorcerer nodded, he continued —How long have you carried the weight of that event?

—Decades…

—So you were a child.

—A teen.

—Your expression reveals betrayal. Haven't you ever longed for an apology, too?

—What would I do with an apology? It won't change the fact that the person I looked up to, not only betrayed me, almost got me killed, and obliterated the Head Sorcerer in front of my eyes, but also left me scarred for life— the King Father replied. —No apology can heal that scar. Light Spinner is *dead*. And she never cared for me…

Castaspella kept her sight on the ground. She wasn't sure what to say, or if she should utter a word. She couldn't even look at him. However, her eyes found Lance's, who encouraged her to speak up.

—Brother, I'm sure she did. I *know* she did, even if you don't believe it— she dared say. —But I can't convince you it's not manipulation, so I won't try anymore.

—What do I have to do to make you see it, Sis!? She never cared for me, she just had my prowess in mind. In the same way, she only cared for Adora's power. The same way she now seeks… I-I don't even know what she's after now! But whatever you have that is of her interest, it is the only thing that woman focuses on. Not you as a person. She *doesn't* have a heart.

—Can't you stop!? I said we're not discussing this now! Glimmer didn't invite us for this…

—Right, right…

—Sorry— Lance apologized. —Maybe we shouldn't have asked. And we have no right to comment on this, we didn't know her. But… whatever she has done isn't worth ruining your relationship over. Don't let her win a game she isn't even playing.

And how right he was.

He left the siblings reflecting; one too focused on his drink, the other now focused on the little baby on her lap.

However, before the silence stretched any longer, and partially because Glimmer had overheard, the Queen clinked her glass to call everyone's attention.

—If you guys don't mind… I'll bother you just for a short message— she said. As everyone, even Finn, looked at her, she put down her glass and took a deep breath. —Great! Now, I wanted to tell you all why I organized this gathering, you know? I'm glad you all could come because I wanted to share this news with all of you first— she explained. —I… Well…— she then hesitated. The Queen glanced back at her husband, taking in a deep breath, and gathered the courage to speak. She grabbed his hand firmly and finally announced —Bow and I… we have decided to have a baby!

—Ah!

Both Castaspella and Adora immediately squealed, Catra folded her arms and let out an impressed smirk, Lance covered his mouth while on the brink of crying, and both Micah and George exchanged a look, shocked. The sorcerer went pale, merely stared as Adora hugged her friends tightly, and only came out of his stupor when Castaspella stood up to go hug her niece, leaving Finn to his care for a moment.

Eventually, he pulled himself together and joined the rest in congratulating his daughter and Bow.

The reunion lasted until late, and the conversations seemed endless. There wasn't a moment of silence.

—So you finally took Melog to the groove yesterday?— Glimmer was asking, as Adora arrived carrying Finn.

—Yeah. It was insane. Melog loves that place, it's like a playground. It said something about the magical groove reminding it of Krytis. And, of course, its reactions to Shadow Weaver were…

—Bad?

—Strange— Catra corrected.

—How?

—Well, it would go from fairly friendly to angry in a second; I mean, when she was in her tutor mode, explaining stuff, Melog behaved friendly, even letting her pat its head. It was… shocking— she explained. —But then she behaved like a bitch again, and Melog didn't hesitate to growl at her, obviously.

—Sounds a lot like you…— Glimmer uttered, barely holding back a grin and looking away.

—Very funny, Sparkles.

—Speaking of her…— Adora suddenly said, pensive. She looked down at Finn and smiled brightly before asking —Hey, baby. Is the Ghost Lady here?

They nodded and let out a giggle.

—Ghost Lady!— they called, extending their arms towards the wall behind Adora, opening and closing their hands in a way they would usually do when wanting someone to carry them.

Glimmer and Catra immediately exchanged a look and gulped, seemingly scared for a second before finally laughing it off.

However, the others in the room heard Finn and seemed both curious and confused.

—Who-who's this "Ghost Lady"?— Lance asked, nervous.

—Oh, don't worry. That's just… eh… Finn's imaginary friend— Adora lied, glancing at her friends as she hesitated.

—That's so cute!— he exclaimed, suddenly excited.

—And creepy— Micah commented, observing Finn reach for an empty space as if someone were standing there.

—Yes, that seems like the appropriate term— George agreed.

—It can be sometimes, yes— Catra agreed, for different reasons, of course.

—I suppose it's quite spooky, no?— Castaspella had to admit, despite knowing the truth, and let out an awkward smile.

But Lance still found it cute, they couldn't convince him otherwise.

The gathering finally drew to an end right in time for everyone to return home for dinner, and the Queen and King personally saw everyone out, once again receiving congratulations on the news.

For Micah, however, it was… bittersweet.

He still saw Glimmer as his baby girl, despite her being the Queen, despite her having married, and now, despite her decision to have a baby of her own.

He was stuck in the time before being sent to Beast Island, and no matter how hard he tried, he couldn't bring himself to live with the present.

And so, on his way to his room, the King Father wondered whether he'd be able to accept that his daughter would soon be a mother…

It didn't take long for the news to reach all of Etheria, but as for the plans to come to fruition…

A year passed before, early one beautiful day, the awaited baby was born.

At long last!

And so, later that joyous day, the family gathered once more. The Queen had recovered quite quickly, in Castaspella's opinion, and decided she was ready to share a dinner with them all.

However, when it was time, she was quite hesitant to leave her newborn alone in someone else's care, even if for a few hours. But, as she watched the baby sleep so soundly, she finally made up her mind.

As soon as she appeared, both hers and Bow's fathers begged her to see their granddaughter, as only her husband and friends had seen her.

—Please!— Lance implored, extending the word.

—Let us see her, baby girl— Micah pleaded too.

—It's our first grandchild, after all— George added, trying to remain stoic.

—Alright, you three. That's enough— Castaspella interrupted, arriving just a few minutes later. —I'm sure Glimmer will let us see her when she's ready, right?— she said, giving her niece a gentle look. —At least wait until *after* we eat.

—Aw… Then-then… Can you tell us how she looks, please?— Lance negotiated.

—O-of course!— the Queen finally agreed. —Why don't we sit so we can tell you about her?— she suggested, grabbing Bow by the arm.

—Yeah, let's join Adora and Catra— Bow concurred, helping Glimmer to her chair.

Everyone sat around the table, greeted the girls who were already sitting there with Finn, and waited for their meal while questioning the Queen.

—How does she look!?— Lance excitedly asked.

—Well, she's… so small— Glimmer began, looking away with a soft smile. —But her eyes are huge, pink… her skin, purple. Reminds me a lot of Mom— she admitted. —The tone is a bit darker, but… still. Looks a lot like her.

—Except for the hair— Bow pointed out, smiling fondly too. —It's curly and a mix of dark violet and orange. I have no idea where that came from— he giggled.

—Your hair had orange strands when you were little— George commented.

—And yours was purple at first, Glim— Micah chimed in.

—Oh, that's true! It turned pinkish when you were about Finn's age— Castaspella recalled.

—Five? Are you sure?

—Yes, because I was just graduating at that time— she argued.

—So we can expect a lot of changes, eh?— Bow noted.

—Welcome to parenthood, Arrow Boy— Catra said with a smirk. —They change a lot, and quickly.

—I want to see her too!— Finn suddenly exclaimed, slamming their hands on the table.

Far more talkative now, the child had also been begging to see her, but Adora didn't want them to disturb the baby, being so excited and all.

—Finn, we told you: not now— she reminded them. —Glow needs to rest.

—Aw… please!— they insisted. —Auntie! Tell Mom to let me!— they begged, now addressing Castaspella.

The sorceress let out a giggle and replied —Don't worry. You will see her soon, alright?

Before anyone could say anything else, the food arrived, and everyone immediately dug in as they all were quite hungry.

Of course, it wasn't long before curiosity piqued Bow's dads, and George asked Castaspella —Excuse me. Why does Finn call you "Auntie"? Shouldn't it be…

—No, I refuse to be called anything else— she interrupted, eyes closed as she shook her head.

—So you won't let Glow call you grand-aunt either?— Lance asked, chuckling.

—Of course not! The only grannies here are you three— she joked.

Between laughs and more conversations, the dinner went by fast and, by the end of it, they had convinced Glimmer to let them see Glow before leaving.

Needless to say, Micah cried.

Just as Glimmer had said, Glow looked a lot like Angella; he couldn't help caressing her hair and carefully kissing her forehead, without disturbing her sleep.

Looking at her with loving eyes, he muttered —We did it, Angie. She's beautiful.

Chapter End Notes

Everyone! Please welcome Glow!

I've had the concept of Glow for almost a year, I think, so I'm excited to finally introduce her!!
Oh, oh, and the thing with Casta teaching Finn to knit was inspired by my aunt trying to teach her granddaughter to crochet despite her being like 3 or 4, so... hehe
I just found it so cute, I had to do it XD

Finally, thanks everyone for reading! I hope you liked this chapter!!

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation…

Chapter Summary

The lesson: For the last time! Caring isn't a weakness!
Status: *Fine*! I got the message!

Chapter Notes

I like this chapter's implications, tbh, and I hope you see them too…

On a sad note, last Friday my cat Magia passed, and I'm still grieving her. Every time I remember her, I can't help crying… For me, she was basically my daughter.
This is exactly why Casta doesn't name her spiders: she loves them, ofc, but without a name or an identity, without the closeness of feeling like those pets are your her own children, their deaths are easier to accept.

Alright, enough sad stuff. I'll be more than happy once I get to read your comments, if you leave any, so I better let you read the chapter…

Enjoy it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time was certainly flying, wasn't it?

Micah is now a grandfather.

When did time pass?

She didn't even want to think about it…

Instead, she focused on the fact that, most likely, the Head Sorceress would visit her that night.

It was a hunch… or perhaps wishful thinking.

Ah, who cares.

Ugh…

Alright, alright… She cares.

There's no point in further denying it.

So what!?

Who cares about whether *she* cares or not!?

Hmm… well… Castaspella maybe did. She had once asked her, specifically, what she cares for.

But, what had been her answer again?

Ah, yes…

It was a stormy night in Mystacor. Thunder rumbled and lightning flashed haphazardly close to the windows.

However, the Head Sorceress only let out a mischievous giggle as she dealt the cards. She actually loved this weather.

—Are you *sure* you're ready?

—I am— the woman replied, squinting.

—Alright, then…— she sighed, dealing the last card. —Let's begin!

One final round of Deck Fights was played and, unsurprisingly, Castaspella won.

—You little…

—Woohoo!— the sorceress exclaimed, thrilled. She laughed loudly and bent backwards in her chair. —Ha! Yes! I won again!

—I'm starting to see why no one wants to play with you…

—I suppose *losing* isn't for everyone, eh?

—Now, don't get cocky or I won't answer your question.

—Alright— Castaspella giggled. —My question is simple: do you… care for anything at all? I mean, besides yourself… is there *something* you really care for?

—Bold of you to presume I care for myself…

—What are you trying to say?

—When you care for something, it becomes your weakness. Care for nothing, and *no thing* will ever hold any leverage against you.

—Spin, that's ridiculous…

—I didn't ask for your opinion— Shadow Weaver quickly pointed out, leaning back on her chair.

—You can't be serious. There's no way you don't care for anything!

—I don't… not anymore. I have no reason to.

—Then why did you sacrifice yourself?

—Not this again…

—Why did you help us when Mystacor quaked?

—Cas…

—O-or why were you so encouraging to me that time *before* you died!?

—*Cas*…

—Or the time Sahm burnt me!? If you didn't care you would have… I don't know, you'd probably just laugh it off!

—Are you *done*?

—No. I have another one: if you didn't care for anything, you wouldn't have those angry and violent reactions towards anyone. You wouldn't care enough to react, to waste your breath and energy threatening people or…

—Alright, that's enough— she decided to interrupt. —Why make that question if, apparently, you already had the answer?

—I just asked this because I want to know what you *consciously* care for!

—Then, in case it isn't obvious, the answer is still "nothing". If I *do* care for something, then that's just… a moment of weakness. The fact that my fits of rage, which you so much despise, are caused by that only reinforces what I say: weaknesses should be eradicated.

—Don't be senseless now…

—You think I'm senseless? So if something doesn't fit your view of the world, it's nonsense?

—I-I didn't say that!

—It seemed like it, seeing how you find it so "senseless" that I'm right and you're wrong this time.

—What an insufferable piece of- Do you know what's your most appalling trait?

—I'm sure I'll be baffled by your insight— Shadow Weaver mockingly replied.

—This stupid attitude of yours, always thinking you're above everyone, hiding what you're truly feeling… even from yourself! Ugh!

"Even from yourself".

That was… a bittersweet reply. Part of it was expected, but the final part…

She hadn't thought about it that way before.

The sorceress said nothing else. She only stood up, leaving the cards abandoned on her desk, walked into her bathroom, and slammed the door shut.

In turn, the woman had to conjure an illusionary chair to sit on as she lost density, and stared at the sprawled deck, reminding herself she can't even pick and tidy it up.

Castaspella's question lingered in her mind, so she shook her head and made an effort to push it aside, not wanting to think about it…

Beatrix now felt ridiculous.

It wasn't just a question of being honest or not. It wasn't even a question of being *genuine*.

It was, as always, a question of feeling weak and exposed.

The feeling wasn't so overwhelming when it came to Castaspella, perhaps because the sorceress' reactions to her displays of "weakness" weren't mockery nor exploitation of said weaknesses.

On the contrary, she would always give her a gentle look and a smile…

It didn't make things any better, it was far too similar to pity, but it wasn't *undesirable*.

So, yes, she had to admit she cares for some things, and yes, Castaspella might be one of the said things.

Chapter End Notes

I feel like this one is too short, like there's little reflection from Beatrix, but… I don't know. My brain said "that's all".

In any case, keep this chapter in mind next week because there will be a little reference/connection to one of the things Casta said hehe (^_^)

Well, that's all for now. Thank you all for reading and I hope you enjoyed it!!

Graduation

Chapter Summary

The royal good news is followed by lesser good news; in just a month, the prodigious sorcery students can graduate! The Head Sorceress is overjoyed, of course, but not everyone shares her enthusiasm.
First, she must get the council's permission for the graduation ceremony, which opens quite a debate. Will she be able to convince them? Or will this only spell more trouble?

But it doesn't end there.
The King Father is back to his old ways, attempting to find the magical groove. What is he planning this time? And will he succeed for the first time in almost eight years?

»—(…)Come on, let’s go, we should return.
»—I can’t. Not yet. I…
»—Is there anything you need to do first?— Bow guessed.
»—I have to speak to Shadow Weaver. I sound crazy, I know. But, please…
»—Why would you want to? We’ve told you, we are not letting you anywhere near the groove— Bow reminded him.
»—I swear I don’t have ill intentions. I just… I really need to speak to… to Shadow Weaver.

Chapter Notes

I was particularly restless when I wrote this, which gave me the idea for this beginning.

Also, this is quite a loaded chapter:
- There's more Entrapta!
- There's the end of that one councilman who exposed Casta back in ch 60 >:)
- There's a ~~confession~~! (not what you think, not yet :P)
- There's another apology...
- And there's a graduation! :D (this should actually be at the beginning of the list lol)

Oh, and a note: I've been reading a fic by an anonymous author with whom we have a lot of coincidences in headcanons XD one of them being that there's at least one councilman that actively antagonized Casta; in their fic, said councilman is called Orion, and I've considered calling mine the same, but I'm not really interested in the guy, and he meets his end today so... I suppose he'll still be unofficially referred to as "Prime-colyte" as Ocean_galaxy likes to call him hahah

Without further ~~spoilers~~ ado, please enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After the family dinner, the Head Sorceress decided to spend the night at the magical groove. She was so happy about Glow's birth that, as soon as the woman surfaced, she immediately began rambling about the baby.

However, after a whole five minutes, Shadow Weaver admitted —If you're done expressing your excitement, let me tell you: I was there; I already saw her.

—Then why did you let me annoy you with my rambles?

—Because I was suffering your excitement a bit too much; it's clear you needed to let it out.

—Tha-thanks— the sorceress said, finding it quite nice of her yet refraining from saying so.

—Remember to send my congratulations to the Queen.

—I will, of course.

With that, the women decided to sit down and play some Deck Fights for a while. Shadow Weaver managed to win again, with quite some effort, and elected to offer Castaspella some help "relaxing" before going to sleep.

Regardless, it wasn't enough; the Head Sorceress remained restless.

—Cas, if you don't stop moving, your blanket will fall off— Shadow Weaver warned her, after the tenth time she shifted positions.

—Sorry, sorry. I swear, I'm tired, but I can't fall asleep.

—I'm trying to help you as usual, yet you're still too excited, it seems— the woman pointed out.

—I'm just so thrilled about Glow! I can't stop thinking about it. Glimmer is a mom!

—At long last… She's almost thirty.

—Not like there was any rush, you know?

—Right— Shadow Weaver sighed.

—Speaking of rushing… Have I told you your pupils can graduate next month?— Castaspella asked.
—I've yet to get the council's approval but…

—No, you didn't *tell me*. However, I overheard as much— she admitted.

—I should have known— the sorceress reflected, smiling faintly. —You should be proud. No one has graduated in less than a decade since Micah!

—When I was a tutor, I only mentored the best of the best. I'm actually used to early graduates… Or *was*.

Castaspella sighed.

—That only reinforces what I always say about you being the best tutor Mystacor ever had.

—Do I have to remind you it was you and Micah who did the most? I only settled the basis for their mentoring— Shadow Weaver reminded her.

—That's part of the point. In less than a year, you taught them so much that all we had to do was help them perfect their knowledge and technique— the sorceress explained. —Introduction to sigils was just *practice*. Normally, no one has the faintest idea until they are in their second year, yet your kids already knew all there was to know. Micah and I just helped them memorize patterns and merely fixed some details when necessary.

—I see…

—Just tell me: are you proud of them?

—I… suppose I am— the woman admitted, closing her eyes. —But if you expect me to tell them…

—I know, I know— Castaspella interrupted. —It would be nice, though.

The next morning, as the Head Sorceress woke up in the magical groove, an idea struck her the moment she slipped back from her oneiric state.

Had she dreamt something related to that, maybe? Or was it just an idea that finally grabbed ahold of her after years of musing?

She hadn't consciously thought about this before, but yes, she did occasionally wonder whether it would be a good idea.

So, after seven, perhaps eight years, Castaspella decided to ask princess Entrapta for help once again.

Without telling Shadow Weaver anything, she excused herself and teleported to Dryl, completely forgetting to have the woman tie her hair up. She was just so excited to test her idea… So much, in fact, that the Princess had to ask her to calm down and explain herself again after the sorceress blurted out her request.

—I'm sorry, I'm sorry… I'll rephrase. If you have time, I would like you to repeat the experiments you did at the magical groove years ago, remember? I-I think… maybe, isn't it possible that the conditions have changed? Pe-perhaps, after all this time, something can be done now to keep her permanently on the surface.

Castaspella gave her a pleading look, which Entrapta completely missed as she looked down, considering, and then glanced at Wrong Hordak behind her. He seemed pretty confused; in fact, he had been trying to recall the experiments performed there, to no avail.

On the other hand, Lonnie was sitting nearby, listening carefully, and could perfectly recall what they did. She couldn't forget it, as she found it so terribly bizarre. They had put so much effort into trying to help none other than *Shadow Weaver*, and let's not forget her little confrontation with Hordak. It also made her think, once again, how the fact that she and her friends now work *with* Hordak as *equals* still feels like a fever dream.

—What makes you think something has changed?— she decided to ask, standing up and approaching them.

—If my calculations are correct…— Entrapta began, before Castaspella could reply. —Etheria's natural magic has been evolving since the Heart's release. But I fail to see how you could know that— she explained. —There's a… twenty percent chance that your theory might be correct, though.

—I… don't know why I thought about this, but I just- I *feel* it— she admitted, shyly looking away.

Lonnie clicked her tongue and looked away too as she commented, with an incredulous tone, —"Feel it", you say… A simple hunch might be enough for you, magical folks, but we can't waste time and resources based on that.

—Oh, no, no— Entrapta disagreed. —Science isn't just calculations. Presentiments are what spark our investigations in the first place! Hunches lead to experiments, and experiments lead to progress in scientific research!

—So, what you're saying is that research starts with… a feeling?— Lonnie questioned her.

—Exactly! That's what theories are!

The Princess was now excited too, and held her pad close to her chest as she suddenly left the room, supported by her hair. Castaspella, Wrong Hordak, and Lonnie exchanged a glance, confused at her sudden leave, but she quickly returned with Hordak in tow, walking backwards as she explained the situation to him.

—I see…— he sighed, closing his eyes and pushing back his glasses. —We're still quite busy calibrating the portal, but… perhaps updating our readings on Etheria's magic can also help us with the calibration.

—Precisely! And we have permission to do it!— Entrapta pointed out, energetic as ever.

—Hmm… Very well— he hummed, frowning thoughtfully. He then looked back at Castaspella, cleared his throat, and told her —Head Sorceress, we need to prepare our equipment, but if you give us a few minutes, we will be ready to go now.

—Didn't you say *just yesterday* that we don't have time for side projects?— Lonnie reproached him.

—You did! I remember— Wrong Hordak innocently agreed, a bit too cheerful.

—This is *not* a mere side project— he countered, closing his fists tightly. —This will contribute to our current work and may be the key to progress— he argued, irked by her tone.

—Fine, fine— Lonnie surrendered. —I'll go fetch Rogelio and Kyle.

—Tha-thank you so much— Castaspella let out, certainly glad to hear it. —I'll wait here as you prepare everything— she accepted, smiling gently.

As agreed, they all went down to the magical groove, ungladly surprising Shadow Weaver, who simply observed them all from a distance, arms folded and frowning.

The Horde Trio and Wrong Hordak were busy setting up all the tools and gadgets around, just like they had done years ago; Castaspella was speaking with Hordak, wanting to know what they were going to do; and Entrapta was focused on her pad, checking that everything was connected and correctly transmitting the data.

However, the Princess couldn't help overhearing as the woman complained between her teeth —Why bother carrying out these faulty experiments if they are destined to fail? The stubbornness is baffling…

—Huh?— Entrapta let out, looking up from her pad. Supported by her hair, she approached Shadow Weaver, completely unafraid and, ironically enough, wanting to cheer her up. —Hey, failure isn't a bad thing. It's just an unreached objective! It means we can always try again and explore new methods!— she told her, smiling despite seeing the woman frowning angrily at her.

—There is *no point* in working with imperfect methods— she argued, her tone reeking with disgust.

—But imperfections are beautiful! They teach us and let us improve!

The Princess was still too cheerful for Shadow Weaver's taste, so she immediately countered —Imperfections lead to mistakes, mistakes lead to failure, and failure can be life-threatening. So tell me, *Princess*, how can one forgive oneself for making such mistakes?

"Forgive oneself"?

Her wording surprised Entrapta and made her smile vanish as she realized something.

The woman wasn't really complaining about the experimentation this time, was she?

Concerned now, the Princess lowered her tone as she began —How can we… forgive ourselves?

—Yes.

—By looking forward. Everyone makes mistakes, especially when experimenting. I can calculate possible outcomes, but I can't predict them— she replied, looking down at her pad. —Forgiving ourselves is… important. If not, we get stuck— she pointed out, daring to face Shadow Weaver again. —I'm never a hundred percent sure my results will be successful, but I'm *always* a hundred percent sure I can keep trying!

—Nonsense…

—I… I'm not always understood— she sighed, looking away shyly. —What I say is considered nonsense at least ninety percent of the time— Entrapta went on, thoughtful. —But I have talked about this with the Head Sorceress, and she agrees with me! Imperfections *are* beautiful! She said that's your most appealing trait!

—*What*!?

Shadow Weaver looked shocked, scared even, but the Princess completely missed it and went on speaking excitedly.

—Yes! She said it's because they are natural, that they manifest when you let your guard down, that it's you letting yourself be truly free!

Of course she said that.

The woman could even recognize the sorceress' speech, so different from Entrapta's way of speaking.

Not any less shocked, she couldn't help glancing back at Castaspella for a moment. She was still chatting amicably with Hordak, who held his glasses in one hand as he explained something to her.

Normally, the detail of Hordak using glasses would make it quite an amusing scene for Shadow Weaver.

But she wasn't amused now, she was astonished, looking at the sorceress with new eyes…

About half a month later, the day after the Guild Dance, Castaspella was on her way to the council room, having called for a meeting. The results of Entrapta's experiments showed she was right and the conditions at the groove *were* different but, unfortunately, it meant nothing. Shadow Weaver still couldn't be brought back to the surface permanently.

However, and perhaps related to the results, Castaspella inferred, the woman seemed… changed. Even more changed. She was unusually interested in her pupils' progress and seemed willing to admit how proud she was of them without the sorceress' insistence.

The kids had grown so much… Not only were the teens now adults and the kids, teens, but also, they had grown in skill and knowledge faster than anyone who set foot on the island.

It meant only one thing, and the women agreed on it: it truly was time. They were ready to graduate.

That's why Castaspella called the meeting. All they needed was the council's approval.

—Graduation!?— a councillor repeated, disbelieving. —They haven't studied for more than eight years yet! Graduation before a decade of studying hasn't happened since king Micah's graduation!

—And I'm well aware— the Head Sorceress nodded. —But we all know these kids are far more skilled than we first thought. The magic that awakened within them is… it's somehow connected to the power She-Ra released from the Heart. Our sorcery has been weakened by the First Ones' so-called enhancement, while theirs is a result of our planet's magic full restoration!

—Do you believe they fulfill the requirements to graduate already?— Nolrem asked, curious.

—Yes, I do.

—I see…— he sighed. —Then I support your decision, Head Sorceress— he nodded, eyes closed.

—I appreciate that.

—So do I— Arden agreed.

—And I— a councilwoman said, nodding too.

—I apologize, but I don't— another councilman then refused.

—Neither do I— Micah finally said, folding his arms. —Prodigious or not, we can't allow it, it would show favoritism…

—Exactly!— the first councillor exclaimed.

It exasperated Castaspella how cocky he looked. This was the same councilman who exposed her once, pushing her to try and remove the summoning spell from herself. In fact, he had been antagonizing her since Shadow Weaver was first summoned and, as the years went by, he only got bolder in his hostility.

In a way, it pained her. She had always trusted her people, she relied on them all, so this situation was far too bitter.

Oh, but it was just so enraging too! She *wished* she could simply expel him from the council since that day when he dared move away her cape like that. How *dare* he touch her!?

But that would make her a tyrant, wouldn't it?

—I see we can't reach an agreement…— Geldirik sighed, calling everyone's attention. —As the foreman-councilman, I propose we all share our reasons to either agree or disagree.

—That seems like a good solution— queen Glimmer nodded. —No one here is psychic, and I'm sure no one is making a decision based on nothing…

—Well, I have already exposed my reasons, so I will just hear you all out— Castaspella told them, expression calm.

—In that case, I begin: As I said, it would look like favoritism— Micah began. —They are too young, some of them are the age we normally *start* studying magic.

—No one is showing favoritism, king Micah— Nolrem denied. —We are talking about pupils who fulfill the conditions to graduate, conditions that are completely objective. Them being Light- Shadow Weaver's students is completely unrelated…

—Precisely— Castaspella concurred. —Besides, I honestly don't see how it would be favoritism. She used to be *the* tutor who trained only the best. I believe it would be normal that her pupils graduate earlier than usual— she pointed out, recalling what the woman had told her.

But perhaps that comment was too much.

With a scoff, that belligerent councillor began —Enough! This is getting out of hand. We have supported you this long, Head Sorceress, but now I can't stay silent: Your fixation with Shadow Weaver is affecting your judgment. Or did you think we wouldn't learn about your most recent attempt to bring her back?

Silence.

For a moment, no one dared speak, not even Castaspella herself.

But then Nolrem confidently stated —I disagree. There have been no problems caused by our Head Sorceress' interest in bringing her back. On the contrary, Light- Erm, Shadow Weaver has provided indispensable aid several times; recovering her may not be a priority, but it's certainly a matter of importance.

The Head Sorceress was glaring at him, serious and silent as Nolrem spoke.

Ah, but that councilman wasn't the littlest bit intimidated.

—Of course you'd say that, *Inny*— he rebuked, sardonic, rolling his eyes.

He couldn't help but let out a scowl at the nickname, not only because of the tone, but also because it had always been used by *almost* everyone to belittle him since he adopted his name. He could hardly name someone other than Light Spinner who would use it as a friendly nickname. Ironic…

However, he remained respectful as he argued —I am just pointing out facts… I'm trying to be objective…

—Objective!?— the councillor cried out, indignant. —You can't even say her name right! Do you take me for an idiot, Nollaris!?

—Enough!

—Silence!— Castaspella ordered, expressionless. Nolrem yelled because that councilman had gone too far, yes. However, for a moment he feared he had *also* gone too far, raising his voice like that. But the Head Sorceress didn't tell them off. Instead, she walked up to the councillor and extended her hand as she ordered —Your badge.

—What!?

She couldn't be serious…

Except that she was. Far too serious in fact; both Glimmer and Micah couldn't help but stare in shock, as they weren't used to her anger yet.

—Hand in your badge, right now, and leave the room— she ordered once more, keeping her severe demeanor. —Do not make me repeat myself, *acolyte*.

But the man wouldn't give up…

Scoffing again, he sounded offended and indignant as he questioned —Will you kick out everyone who points out your bias!?

That cockiness again; it was extremely difficult for Castaspella to keep her cool, but she somehow managed.

—Do not confuse things. I can tolerate being questioned, and I encourage debate. But I will *not* tolerate such disrespect to your fellow councillors— Castaspella began, mustering all her self-control. —You are all perfectly aware of Nolrem's name. You have no excuses for your behavior, so you will give me your badge, right this instant, and leave the room— she insisted, with a chilling glare. —Consider yourself *lucky*; I'm letting you keep your residence in the kingdom— she then added, her tone almost cynical. Resigned, yet making a show of how angry he was, the ex-councilman gave her his badge and stalked out of the room, grunting as he purposely ignored the eyes of the council. Followed by everyone's shocked stares, the sorceress approached Nolrem and addressed him with a softer tone and a gentle look. —I apologize… This will not happen again.

Nolrem wanted to brush it off, but he could barely take in a deep breath with his eyes closed before calmly replying —Please, don't worry, Head Sorceress. And… I appreciate it.

With that, Castaspella walked back to her place and resumed the discussion, encouraging everyone to voice their opinions. They were still quite far from reaching an agreement, until Arden shared his opinion based on the evaluations the pupils had successfully passed.

Everyone was impressed by the results Arden shared with them, to the point they had to admit the students were, in fact, ready to graduate.

In the end, even Micah had to agree; after all, he had been teaching them too, hadn't he?

Finally, two weeks later, their day arrived.

The Head Sorceress woke up very early to start preparing for the graduation ceremony; it would only take place later, right after dinner, but she wanted it to be perfect.

Her brother found her running up and down, personally supervising everything. He tried to stop her and take her aside to speak, but it was impossible.

Eventually, as everything was going as Castaspella intended, he managed to steal a few minutes.

—I just… think it's too soon.

—What do you mean "too soon"? They have already passed all their classes, all their courses, learnt everything we had to teach and even began their own investigations, most of them— the sorceress argued, indignant.

—They haven't been here for a decade yet. This is insane!— Micah insisted.

—How can you say that when you also graduated in eight years!?

—Casta, there can be a prodigy or two in a class. But all eleven students!?

—Brother, what *is* your problem?— Castaspella asked, serious, wanting him to tell her the real reason behind his complaints.

—I don't- I just- Look, I am as proud as you of their achievements, but it's just that…— he began, stammering.

—Your problem is that they are *her* pupils.

—So they say! Bu-but she hardly taught them!— the sorcerer pointed out.

—I can't believe I have to tell *you* how wrong you are…— his sister scoffed, folding her arms.

—Why!?

—You know perfectly well we taught them close to nothing, only helped them improve. They already had the knowledge, Micah— the sorceress reminded him.

—You can't really mean…

—Of course I mean it! She taught them a lot in the few months she was around— she interrupted. —Damn it, Micah! She would have taught them even more if you hadn't…

—Not this again— he huffed, interrupting her.

—Brother, I'm tired. I just want this ceremony to go flawlessly. So let me do my job, and *please* behave tonight— she pleaded, before turning around to leave.

He didn't reply, just watched her walk away.

That night, however, when the council was gathering for the ceremony, they received a particular request from the students: they didn't want king Micah to be at the ceremony at all.

Obviously, he was indignant, and yet, they had a *good* reason for their request: they had somehow overheard the siblings' discussion earlier that day, and argued that the King Father didn't respect their Master, so they preferred not to have him in their ceremony.

They were in all their right to make such a request seeing how the obvious, having Shadow Weaver present, couldn't be granted.

Hence, Micah was forced to stay outside the chamber.

Obviously offended, he sat down with his arms crossed in front of his chest and looked angrily at the front while listening to his sister's speech coming from inside.

She spoke about being proud of them, and knowing that Shadow Weaver is proud too…

Sure. Of course. That woman… *proud of someone*…

Micah couldn't help letting out a huff. A part of him wanted to believe that; it would mean Light Spinner had been proud of him too… maybe still was…

But who was he kidding!? She wasn't *proud* of them! His sister was simply delusional!

He shook his head and went back to listening to her speech, how she mentioned they are the fastest group to graduate and that they are all welcome to be tutors too if so they wish…

Would that be a sound idea?

Having such young tutors…

After musing for a while, his thoughts were suddenly interrupted by the group of newly graduated pupils leaving the room, followed by Castaspella. He immediately stood up, ready to chase after her, but she halted and turned to look at him before he could so much as take a step.

—Brother…

—Sis, I…

—Don't hold a grudge against the kids, alright? What they did was actually pretty mature, they only wanted to avoid unnecessary conflict with you.

—I don't… I wouldn't hold a grudge for this…— he said, not entirely sure whether that was true. —You… You're now going to… see her, aren't you?

Castaspella nodded.

—And you *can't* follow us, is that clear?

She turned around and was about to walk away when he reached out to her, calling —Wait!

—What is it?

Micah hesitated, just staring at his sister while, behind her, the parents of the graduates could be seen leaving the room. Not wanting to call their attention, he lowered his tone and stepped a bit closer.

—Can you just… just tell me?

—Tell you what?

—Why you trust her so much. What makes you support her… What you feel.

What she feels…

She inevitably thought about it, it was immediate, and it hit her. But… how to put it?

—Suddenly so interested in how I feel? After years of ignoring it?

—Tha-that's why I'm asking. You've told me several times that I don't… listen to you. And I'm really sorry, but I *can't understand*.

—I think you don't want to understand what I mean, what I feel— she began, with a sigh. —Because I didn't understand before either, not fully— she explained, making his expression change from pain to surprise. —But now, as you once again question me, I finally get it.

Her expression went from a conflicted frown to a soft smile. She looked up at him and let out another sigh.

Yes. She finally gets it.

But would he?

—Then tell me, please…

His plea was loaded with sincerity.

Normally, Castaspella would be hesitant to reveal her true feelings, especially when she had no more than a few seconds to process what she had *just now* allowed herself to admit. But something in his expression and the way he said it made her trust him enough to say it aloud.

She approached him, took a deep breath, and gave him a gentle look as she finally admitted —I love her, Micah.

—Yo-you… Ho-how?

—She's always been a real pain to bear, she's proud, egocentric, literally a bitch; she's a jerk who doesn't care for others' feelings— the sorceress began, looking away and rolling her eyes. —But that's exactly why I feel like... like she's perfect for me— she explained, finding Micah's eyes. She kept that soft look and moved closer to grab his hands between hers as she elaborated —She's far from being a perfect person, barely nears being a decent person now, but she's someone who never faked niceness, so I learnt to trust her. I realized she *does* listen, that she's more attentive than we think, and that she simply doesn't act on it because she doesn't give enough of a fuck!

—So-sounds… like her…— he mumbled, too shocked still, and feeling like he was actually dreaming.

—But I earned her respect, just like she earned mine, and I knew I could trust her because she's not trying to be plain rude, but rather, she's honest, brutally honest— Castaspella went on, looking away again. —I started calling out her bullshit since our investigation of the crystal of Arxia and the failsafe, and she's been responsive. She listened to me and has been fixing her many problems since we summoned her— she continued, smiling fondly. —Likewise, she's done the same for me! Calling out my bullshit, she helped me see and confront my issues, so I could solve them too. I've grown

thanks to her and, like it or not, she's grown too— she concluded, before her expression darkened. The Head Sorceress looked down and loosened her grip on her brother's hands. —But you refuse to see this, you refuse to listen to me, and you've made me… miserable, really miserable. I've been trying to keep our relationship afloat despite your antagonism, despite you never giving a single fuck about how I feel— she admitted, barely holding back her tears. Taking a final deep breath, she let go of his hands, straightened her back, and concluded —So yes, Micah. I can say now that I... I love her. And I'm not putting up with your bullshit anymore.

—Sis…

—Now, if you excuse me, I'll be joining our new graduates…

Micah was far too shocked to react.

He wanted to stop her, to grab her hands and say something, anything.

But he couldn't.

Frozen in place, he could only watch as she teleported away, leaving him alone in the corridor.

A chilly breeze finally shook him awake as realization hit.

His sister had essentially told him three things: that he has made her miserable, that Shadow Weaver isn't how he thinks, and that she *loves her*.

He wasn't sure what was worse…

Bow was comfortably sitting in front of his desk, tinkering with a gadget, while waiting for his wife to return from the graduation ceremony. He checked the time and knew she would be back soon, but the next second, an alarm went off and his tracker pad began flashing.

—Not again…— he sighed, tired. Those were his traps in the Whispering Woods. It could only mean one thing… —Let's see where you are, king Micah— he let out, checking the coordinates in his pad. —Alright. Time to go.

However, as soon as he reached the door, Glimmer appeared in the room, having just teleported.

—Bow! I'm back! You have no idea how beautiful the ceremony was! Auntie's speech almost made me cry!— she began, still thinking about it. However, a moment later she finally saw him at the door with his tracking pad in hand, and asked —Were you going somewhere?

—Well… yes— he sighed. —Your dad is trying to find the groove again.

—Oh, not again!— Glimmer groaned. —It has to be because they didn't want him at the ceremony! He must know they all went to the groove with Auntie!

—It's alright, we'll just intercept him as we used to— Bow calmed her down. —Can you take us here?— he requested, showing her the spot in his pad. —He's like half-way there already.

—Yeah, let's go— she immediately agreed, before taking him by the arm and teleporting them to the approximate location. —Dad!— she immediately yelled, hoping to stop him before he got away.

—Baby girl?— they heard, and turned to find Micah stumbling forward, having almost tripped on a bush. —Wha- Ho-how did you find me!?

—King Micah, my traps are still functional all around. Why are you here tonight?— Bow calmly said.

—I…

—Dad, you *can't* be here. I'm not letting you ruin the night for those kids…— Glimmer stated, severe.

—Love, let me handle this, yes?

—A-alright, I'll go warn Auntie and the graduates— she reluctantly agreed.

To avoid giving him the general direction of the groove, the Queen teleported there, despite being about ten meters away, leaving Bow and Micah alone, barely illuminated by the moonlight coming through the trees.

—Please, king Micah. Listen to me: this is a mistake. There's a reason why we've kept you away all this time. Don't ruin this for Casta…

—I… I'm lost anyways…— he replied, feeling defeated, and sat on the ground.

Bow moved to sit next to him and gently told him —Please, return to Bright Moon with me. Forget about Shadow Weaver…

—But I can't! I-I- My sister just told me she- that she- I don't understand how it can be, but she said she *loves her*!

—She… said it?

—Just earlier! I-I don't understand!

The King Father was basically having a crisis and Bow wasn't sure what to do.

—King Micah…

—You should stop calling me that, kid. You're the king now.

—A-alright. Micah. Why don't we go over what she told you? What did she say?

—That she basically hates me now!

—Are you sure she used those words?

—She-she said she won't put up with my bullshit anymore…

—That sounds more like it— Bow accepted. —What do you think she means? What could you have been doing that she finds unacceptable?

—You mean trying to literally keep her safe from Shadow Weaver!?— Micah indignantly cried out.

—Why do you think she needs someone to keep her safe?— the King asked, keeping as calm and gentle as possible.

—She's my little sister, *of course* she does!

—She's not a little girl anymore. She's the Head Sorceress of Mystacor, has been for over two decades.

—Yeah, but this is Shadow Weaver we're talking about!

—Which changes *nothing*!— Bow insisted. —There's only a small group of people who can handle that woman, and the second, if not the first one to have managed it is your sister.

—Or so she's making everyone think!

—Micah… Please…

—How can we know it's true!? She could literally turn around anytime and backstab her! Ma-maybe literally!

—Can't you see how incoherent that sounds? This is what Casta means… You've pushed her away with all of this!

—If she weren't so stubborn…

—Haven't you thought maybe *you* are being too stubborn?

—What will happen the day she gets hurt!?

Bow let out a sigh as it reminded him of something Catra and Adora had told them.

—You know… My friends had a similar conversation with Shadow Weaver. So I will tell you what they told her: Casta can protect herself if it were necessary.

—Why would they have to tell her that? As if she cared…

—She won't admit it, but it seems like she does. She was… Ne-never mind.

—I don't get it, it's ridiculous!

—Micah, it is not. What's ridiculous is that you can't see how much you have in common with Shadow Weaver!

—Like what?

—What about neglecting other people's feelings, arguing you're doing "what's best" for them?

—But…

—Believing no one but you holds the truth?

—That's…

—Obsessively trying to separate two people because you *think* one is harmful to the other? While, simultaneously ignoring what they each feel, of course.

—I am *not* like Shadow Weaver…

—No, but you've been behaving like her in certain aspects, which is exactly why Casta is so fed up!

—But I'm not… I-I'm not… Wha- What?— the King Father stammered, suddenly breathless, looking around disoriented. If he were standing, he would have ended up on the ground but, fortunately, he was already sitting. —Am I really behaving like her?

—Your sister would say it's only normal to mirror her behaviours because she was your mentor and who you looked up to. In the same way, Catra mirrored some of hers because Shadow Weaver raised her…— Bow replied. —You know, you behave like Shadow Weaver in some things, but you're also very similar to Catra in other things. If you could just… I don't know, *see* what you're doing and how you're affecting others, especially the people you care for… it would help you understand. You don't have to agree with her, but understand Casta's point of view, her feelings, and maybe things will get better.

—You think all I've done was a mistake?— Micah asked, looking up at the moon. He then turned to look directly at Bow and insisted —Do you think I shouldn't have returned?

—I would never think so. We're all so relieved to know you're still alive. And we're glad to have you back! E-even Shadow Weaver! But… About the things you've done, well, most were… if not mistakes, at least ill-advised decisions. Like trying to spy on your own sister… That was such a Shadow Weaver move, man!— the King replied, serious.

—I didn't… I wasn't… I-I didn't know… Never thought about it— Micah admitted, looking down. —What am I even supposed to do now? I'm sure Casta won't speak to me ever again…

—I'm sure she will. Come on, let's go, we should return.

—I can't. Not yet. I…

—Is there anything you need to do first?— Bow guessed.

—I have to speak to Shadow Weaver— he revealed, giving him a pleading look. —I sound crazy, I know. But, please…

—Why would you want to? We've told you, we are *not* letting you anywhere near the groove— Bow reminded him.

—I swear I don't have ill intentions. I just… I really need to speak to… to Shadow Weaver.

Micah lowered his head with a defeated expression, supporting himself with his hands on the ground, while Bow slowly stood up, shaking the soil from his pants.

—If I allow it, and you do something to the groove like you did to the mask, it will be my fault, Micah. I don't know if I can let it happen…

—I won't, I won't! I just… need to talk with her— he insisted. —You are… right. You all were always right… I shouldn't have dismissed her, I've… almost become like her, and I was so wrong for treating my own sister so harshly over… over Shadow Weaver— he lamented, digging his nails into the soil. —Your father was also right. I was letting that woman win a game she wasn't even playing. She wasn't trying to pit us against each other… it was all my… my paranoia! Wasn't it!?

The King Father looked up at Bow with tears streaming down his face. Since Castaspella told him that she loves that woman, something inside him had shifted. But it was Bow's words that finally shook the very foundation of his mindset. It all crumbled to the ground as he realized he had harmed

his sister more than the “terrible” Shadow Weaver. He had become the monster from which he was trying to protect her…

Now he had to make things right.

The King kneeled next to him, helped Micah stand up, and finally agreed —Alright. I’ll take you to her.

On the way there, Bow explained to him that Shadow Weaver only appeared for certain people, like Catra and Adora, because of their connection to her, and for Castaspella because of the summoning spell that is bound to her heart. From what they knew, perhaps Micah alone was enough too but, at first, she wasn’t showing up, and they thought she wouldn’t.

—Mi-Micah?

The men turned around at the same time and looked in surprise at the opaque figure. It was her expression of shock that called their attention; neither was used to seeing her maskless. Bow had seldom conversed with her, and Micah hadn’t seen her in almost eight years.

—I’ll leave you to talk privately— the King sighed. —But I’ll be back in half an hour, and this place better be exactly as it is now— he threatened.

—I-I promise I won’t do anything— Micah assured him.

After Bow left, he looked back at the woman again, only to find a more composed Shadow Weaver; she had schooled her expression while they were talking, and now looked like the woman he knew.

—What are you doing here, Micah, and how exactly did you convince the boy of bringing you after years of them keeping you away?— she asked, suddenly severe as everything he had been doing came back in an instant.

Maybe he was one of her weak spots and she couldn’t deny it anymore, *but* it didn’t mean she would simply forget all the pain and suffering she had been feeling through the spell. All the pain and suffering he made *her* feel.

So she was now more angry than anything.

—I-I just came to talk, alright? I had to beg him to bring me to you.

—I imagine. Now, don’t lose time and speak already.

—Right, right. I’m…— he began, but interrupted himself with a sigh, covering his face with his hands. —I’m so…

—I’m sorry, Micah— Shadow Weaver interrupted, guessing he would say exactly that. —For all the pain I must have caused you to earn your animosity— she added.

—I was going to say…— he uttered, yet felt speechless for a moment. She apologized!? His sister wasn’t delusional, after all… He tentatively took a step forward and said —But I’m sorry too, for dismissing you.

—Yet I reckon a simple apology won't make the past go away and won't fix what I did to you in any way, just like it won't make me return permanently to the surface— she replied.

—I suppose that's true…

The King Father looked away, pensive, and remained silent as he considered an idea.

Was there truly no way of fixing what he had done?

—Do you need anything else?

—N-no, but… I have to ask: why are you here? How can it be? And, Bow mentioned you only appear for some people, but I don't understand why.

Shadow Weaver squinted and took a deep breath. The tutor in her was itching to explain it all, but then she remembered that Micah understood the true nature of the summoning spell, and that was exactly how he knew how to dismiss her instantly.

So, was it really safe to tell him?

—Why do you want to know?

—I-I'm curious. I… Look, I swore I wouldn't do anything to this place, so I promise it's nothing to hurt you. I just *really* want to know— he insisted.

—I shouldn't trust you after what you've done, but I know you're not stupid; you could simply get this information from books or even ask that innocent tech Princess about her experiments… So I shall tell you— she finally decided, letting out a long sigh. —This groove is like a magical conduit from the core to the surface, and my spirit is, as you know, attached to the core. Without the mask, which the Princess called an "anchor" if I recall correctly, only the core pulls from me, keeping me under the surface.

—Then how are you here?

—Patience— she light-heartedly reproached him. —Because the summoning spell is still active within your sister, I'm still in this magical body that becomes solid near her.

—But that only explains why her presence here allows you to emerge.

—Indeed. The so-called "anchor" is no more, so nothing else should pull me back to the surface. Which leads me to believe that, while not strong enough, certain people who had a significant connection with me while I was alive also work as anchors…

She decided to omit the little detail about being able to see and hear what happens on the surface when those "anchors" are together; it wasn't relevant and would probably freak him out…

—So… I am one?

—You, Catra and Adora. That we know.

—It… would mean…— Micah began, pensive. —That if the core weren't, well, at the core under the surface, you would remain up here.

—Not the core itself but rather the… parasitic magic I tried to summon which, as you may or may not know, resides at the core— she pointed out.

The… parasitic magic.

It couldn't be…

How could it be!?

Micah slowly lowered his sight to the ground as his thoughts spiralled.

—Do you want to be back on the surface permanently?— he asked, pensive, without looking at her.

—Yes. For… no particular reason…

—For my sister.

Shadow Weaver sighed.

—Yes, I suppose that much is true.

—What do you… feel for her?

This time, he looked up with a complicated expression that may or may not hide some hope.

—I don't know what you expect to hear, but I can only say I am unable to describe that. For what it's worth, I… should say… tha-that I…— she hesitated.

Closing his eyes and seemingly bracing for impact, he asked —Love her?

Was that the right word?

Shadow Weaver remained silent for a moment before finally replying —If that's what you think it should be called… I just feel that she's someone I *want* around me; not just someone I tolerate, but rather someone whose presence puts me at ease.

—You enjoy her company.

—I didn't at first. It was insufferable, like everyone else. But it soon became… stimulating. And eventually, it became a little pleasure of mine— she admitted. —I don't like it but… I must admit she has… opened my eyes. I don't know what she thinks but, from my side, I can say she's had an impact on me; perhaps enough to make me a decent person, after all— she added, chuckling at the end.

—I… see— Micah sighed, looking at the ground again.

—So, my final answer would be "perhaps". Why did you ask?

—I should… return now. Tha-thank you…— he uttered, still deep in thought, and walked away, ignoring her final question.

He got everything he needed to know. It all became clear to him.

Resolved, he made his way back to Mystacor.

It was time to dust a certain old project…

After Bow left the groove, he went to look for Glimmer and told her what happened.

She was so indignant! It reminded him of how Angella would get when Glimmer disobeyed her during the war.

Her husband had to stop her from teleporting to the groove right that instant, and eventually talked her out of her rage.

Nevertheless, the Queen refused to keep this from her aunt.

—Bea!?

—I knew you would return. Learnt that your brother was here, didn't you?

—What happened?

—You can calm down. It was just a chat— Shadow Weaver assured her. —You needn't agonize over it…

—How can I not!?

—I understand your distress, I think, but again: it's completely unnecessary. We just… conversed.

—May I ask what about?

—You can ask whatever you please, doesn't mean I will answer…

—Bea!

—Cas…

—Don't you "Cas" me now!

—If it were relevant, don't you think I would tell you?

—I'll be frank: no, I don't think so. In fact, the more important it is, the lesser the chances you will tell me without me asking— Castaspella replied, hands on her hips.

—Curse your insight… Can't we just change subjects?

—Bea, please— the sorceress pleaded, approaching the woman.

—We have talked about this: boundaries. I don't want to talk about it.

—Fine— she sighed, lowering her head. —Then what do you want to talk about?

Castaspella tentatively looked up at Shadow Weaver once more and waited for her answer.

After a moment, she reminded her —Would you be interested in the answer to your question from earlier?

—You mean why would you take care of kids but crush their spirits and dreams while at it?

—That exactly. I believe I have the answer now.

—I'm all ears— the Head Sorceress said, sitting down against a tree as usual.

The woman joined her and let out a long sigh. She looked at the front, refusing to meet her eyes; her demeanor was serious, which told Castaspella she meant every word she was about to say.

—Simply put, looking after children is a demanding job, far more demanding than protecting their dreams…

—But that's exactly why it's so fulfilling to see them grow up, wouldn't you say? Because it's a demanding job into which you've invested part of your life.

Shadow Weaver looked back to find Castaspella giving her a gentle smile.

—I suppose you could say so. It should be fulfilling, rewarding… and I suppose I now feel that way.

—That wasn't the case before?

—No.

—Would you say now that protecting their dreams *is* important too?

—I still think that's accessory. I believe you mean whether I think purposely crushing those dreams is justifiable. I must admit I did think so, yes…

—Not anymore?

—It proved to be counterproductive, I suppose. So, I wouldn't put any effort into protecting their dreams, but if they can do so themselves, I wouldn't stop them— she explained. —Not like I'll be taking care of children ever again— Shadow Weaver added, smirking.

—On that we can agree— Castaspella giggled.

The sorceress closed her eyes as her laugh died down and leant back against the tree.

Alright, the woman was in all her right to demand she respects her privacy; if she didn't want to tell her what she talked about with Micah, she shouldn't force her. However, she couldn't stop wondering whether her brother had mentioned what she told him.

What if he revealed Castaspella confessed her love? What if the reason why Shadow Weaver didn't want to talk about it was to avoid the awkwardness of having to reject her?

Or it could be even worse…

It was always difficult to know with this woman…

Chapter End Notes

So, you guys...
Did you know the Japanese author Yasunari Kawabata says something similar to Entrapta? I'm reading a book about 15 Japanese philosophical concepts, and one of them is "wabi sabi", about which the author says is the attitude that leads us to discover, quoting Kawabata, the beauty in the imperfections. (PS, I can't find the exact quote nor from where it would be, but it is true that Kawabata's writings portray the wabi sabi concept a lot)

Speaking of that book, it's called (originally) *Il Pensiero Giapponese*, by Le Yen Mai (I'm reading the Spanish translation). As I said, it explains 15 concepts of the Japanese lifestyle, and I'm mentioning this because I've discovered I actually had Casta manifest many of these (accidentally, cause I didn't know), which fits her asian-coding from the show! I love it!

One example is, obviously, the Wabi Sabi, but there's also **Kaizen** (which would be represented by her appreciation of every little step SW makes towards change and improvement), **Omoiyari** (which is the importance of taking into account others' feelings; being able to imagine the feelings and troubles of others in their circumstances. This would be exactly why Casta is able to understand SW so much), **Nintai** (literally being patient and perseverant because the most valuable things come with time, aka Casta's perseverance with SW!), and there may be more but I'm only half-way through the book... (and may have forgotten somethings)

Anyways, just a funny little thing I find interesting because *wow*, I had no idea...

To conclude, well, I hope you liked this chapter, and yes, so close already... so so close... I promise it will be soon enough :3
But tell me! What do you think of Micah being the first one to know how those two feel for each other??? Isn't it ironic!?
Oh, and what do you think he's planning? >:D

See you next week! (^w^)

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: Love is *not* a scam
Status: Accepted.

Finally!

Chapter Notes

Well, I consider this chapter to be quite interesting.
I hope you like it, and understand it.
Well, it's not super complicated or obscure either, it's just that... let's say SW isn't just being stubborn...

...Or maybe a bit, but it's not just *that*

Anyways, go ahead and read! And more importantly, enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Why didn't she tell her?

How could she tell her!?

If Micah was right, if it could be called "love", shouldn't she… tell her?

But it was ridiculous. Castaspella would probably laugh at her, or think she's joking, or both even…

After all, someone like Shadow Weaver doesn't know what "love" is, does she?

They had talked about it once… And damn, didn't she make the sorceress cry.

—You are *impossible*!— the Head Sorceress cried, drenched from head to toe as she stood under the rain.

—Yes, yes. Everyone knows that. Now get inside before you catch a cold…— Shadow Weaver dismissively replied.

—No! Fuck off!

—Really? Are you throwing a tantrum because I said love is a scam?

—You don't know what love is! And I wouldn't be surprised if you never know!

—Whatever, I don't care about that. Just *get inside*, woman!

—I told you to fuck off! Leave me alone!— Castaspella yelled, before turning around to leave.

This was probably the first time Shadow Weaver saw her lose her composure like that. And as the sorceress walked away, she couldn't help thinking it was probably better to follow her.

Castaspella went into the Whispering Woods, right under Mystacor, where the rain was milder and partially stopped by the trees; at least she wasn't under direct rain anymore.

However, her tears were more evident now.

The woman cursed under her breath as she stealthily followed the sorceress through the woods. Eventually, she stopped and sat on a large boulder, until it snored and startled her, making Castaspella jump away from it; that was actually a sleeping beast. It didn't wake up, fortunately for her, but the little incident only made the sorceress cry even more.

Shadow Weaver simply couldn't understand it…

Just *why* was she crying!?

All because of what she said? Ridiculous. Castaspella knows what she thinks about love and care since before her death, so why would it upset her now?

Nevertheless, observing the Head Sorceress' breakdown, she felt something akin to guilt. She rolled her eyes and let out a sigh before leaving.

She couldn't do anything, but perhaps her niece could…

—What is she doing at the Whispering Woods with this rain!? And what do you mean she's crying!?

—Your Majesty, we can discuss this *after* you fetch your aunt, don't you think?

—Right, right. She might catch a cold— Glimmer realized, concerned. —Wait here, we're not done talking— she then ordered, right before teleporting away.

About ten minutes later, the Queen was back in Bright Moon's palace, right where she left Shadow Weaver.

—Back at last— the woman said.

—I had to convince her to return and have a bath in the Steam Grotto to relax and avoid falling ill. Although I don't know if it will work— Glimmer explained. —Now, tell me: what the fuck happened!? She was crying so much! I-I don't think I've seen her cry since we thought Dad died! I actually don't think I saw her cry back then because she wouldn't cry in front of anyone! — she added, indignant.

—I only said that love is a scam… Nothing surprising coming from me, wouldn't you say?

—Context, I need *context*— the Queen pointed out, pressing a hand to her forehead, frustrated.

—Nothing special, just a conversation about whether dancing under the rain is romantic or not— Shadow Weaver replied, rolling her eyes.

—How the heck did it come to love being a scam?

—Because when I pointed out all the reasons why dancing under the rain is stupid and shouldn't be romantic, she asked whether I had ever been in love, to which I replied that…

—Then how did she end up crying?

—How am I supposed to know!? I'm as surprised as you.

—Are you sure you didn't say anything else? Or maybe she did?

—No, your Majesty, nothing else— she assured her. —She got angry at me, started yelling, and I only realized she was crying because her voice broke; I didn't see her tears until I followed her into the woods…

—Look, I know it sounds ridiculous to you, but some people do believe in love and want to find it someday. Auntie is… she's almost forty already and hasn't ever… you know…

—Shouldn't that make her more prone to believing "love" isn't a real thing?

Glimmer's expression of utter disappointment was enough of a reply, yet after a moment she spoke.

—You can't be serious now… With how evident it is that she wants to have someone who loves her, to love someone in the same way… when all her family has found love… How can you think she wouldn't believe in love!?— the Queen indignantly argued.

—And what if she never does? Is she supposed to live the rest of her life miserable because of something so stupid as not finding love?— Shadow Weaver countered, her tone condescending. —Don't you want her to be happy? Don't you think if she gives up the idiotic dream of finding love, she'll be able to enjoy her life a bit more?

—How can you be so right and so wrong in the same sentence!?

—I don't see where I'm wrong…

—Of course you don't…

—This conversation is senseless, I only needed you to convince your stubborn aunt to return to Mystacor, and you've done that. So I shall now leave— the woman concluded.

—Fine, leave. But don't you dare go bother Auntie unless you're planning on apologizing to her! — Glimmer warned her.

—Right…

With that, Shadow Weaver left Bright Moon and returned to Mystacor; the Head Sorceress' room was empty, meaning she was still down at the Grotto. However, as she conjured an illusionary chair to sit and wait, she suddenly changed her mind and left the room.

That night, the woman returned to the Lunarium for the first time in a long while and spent her time reading a book she had left there, comfortably sitting on her illusionary couch.

She had been harsh. But she was just being honest…

She perfectly knew that wasn’t what the sorceress wanted to hear, and she suspected it would anger her, yet she never expected to make her cry, to push Castaspella to her limit the way she did.

So no, she couldn’t now tell her something like… like *that*, but because she wouldn’t believe it. She’d think she’s mocking her, she’d probably remind her of that conversation and perhaps even get angry at her for making fun of her in such a cruel way.

Yes… Cruel…

It would be *cruel*…

Chapter End Notes

So!?!??! What do you think!?!?

Did you notice the detail of "You don't know what love is" followed by "I don't care about that" all while SW is literally worrying about Casta possibly catching a cold for standing under the rain?

That may not be romantic love, but it is a form of love; at this point, it was just friendship love, but it was there and it evolved to become the romantic love these two stubborn women are now experiencing.

See what I mean? It's not just SW being stubborn XD

Ok, ok, enough... I'll let you go.

Thank you for reading!!

Hate So Many Things about You

Chapter Summary

Time keeps on flying fast, faster than Castaspella would like it to pass…
And yet, it's like it hasn't passed at all, as the same old issues from two years prior keep assailing her mind.
But she's not the only one; it has come to the Best Friends Squad's attention that the King Father is just as troubled as his sister…

»—Alright, I'm done with this— Glimmer stated. —Bow, go check on Dad and distract him for a while. Girls, we're taking Auntie somewhere relaxing right now— she decided.

And somewhere relaxing they go.
But will it be enough for the Head Sorceress to finally settle her *real* struggle?

Chapter Notes

My dear readers:
The day has come!!
Be not afraid; the title is a bit ominous, but I promise, it really is time!!!!!
I'm actually so excited! I can't believe we're almost done!! Please!! In two weeks, this is actually ending! Omgs…

TT^TT Well, it had to, at some point…

Oh, but before I forget, I added this new song to my playlist (yes, the same playlist I have shared here plenty of times), and it fits exactly this chapter so damn well!! There are parts of the lyrics that just… well, *fit*.

Whatever, don't let me delay you any longer.
Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

So much happened since that night…

Almost half a year later, it was Finn's birthday and, as always, there was a cute little gathering with the princesses…

Then another four months passed and it was time for the Guild Dance. The usual problems rose and passed, with only one difference: Micah learnt how that one theatre manager has been pestering his sister since Shadow Weaver's gone, and got seriously pissed… It was actually entertaining for everyone to see how he got overprotective of Castaspella.

Then two weeks passed, and it was time for the Gift Exchange, hosted by princess Frosta, who declared herself Glow's godmother and had a special gift just for her. A cute perma-ice diadem.

Then another two weeks went by and the Best Friends Squad celebrated their anniversary, closely followed by Glow's birthday just two weeks later…

That way, after a month, Castaspella found herself exactly where she was the previous year. Back in the magical groove at night, covered by her blanket alone, unable to sleep as she couldn't stop thinking about how fast the year had passed.

And just *how* would she be able to fall asleep!?

Her little daring confession to her brother returned to her mind, and so did her fear that *maybe* he mentioned it to Shadow Weaver.

Nothing seemed to have changed between them, but knowing the woman, it was possible that she simply… dismissed it.

—Restless again? You should perhaps drink a sleeping potion if you have any left…— she suddenly said, startling Castaspella. With a laugh, she added —Did you forget I was here or what?

—No, no. I was just… deep in thought— she seriously replied.

—What about?

—Something old, to be honest.

—That's very unspecific…

—Well, just like you refused to tell me about it, now I refuse to tell you about it.

—You technically just told me what it was while refusing to do so, do you realize?

—Ugh… Fuck you.

Shadow Weaver laughed again, louder this time, and replied —I can't believe you're still thinking about it even after a year.

—Well, it was the day the pupils graduated so, as today is the anniversary, I couldn't help remembering— she explained herself.

—It wasn't so transcendental to be remembered, woman. Why are you still dwelling on it?— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Be-because… I-I…— she hesitated, before suddenly changing her mind. —No, no. I said I wouldn't tell you!

—Suit yourself— the woman finally sighed, giving up. —Now get back to trying to sleep, will you?

Castaspella grunted but made herself comfortable, closed her eyes, and tried to empty her head. Eventually, she fell asleep, albeit not deeply, but thanks to Shadow Weaver's illusion, nothing woke her up until sunrise.

Time continued to fly by fast.

Before she realized it, Sahm and Ari were presenting their joint investigation on magical affinities, based on theirs and their classmates' affinities, and crediting Shadow Weaver for the discovery.

That last part was very discussed as, in fact, the affinities are an old concept that the woman must have known about from her studies. However, they both argued there have been no sorcerers with affinities since the creation of the Heart and until its release, making the resurgence of affinities Shadow Weaver's discovery.

In the end, they had to modify their wording, but their investigation was finally accepted, and that same day, they went to present it to their Master.

—You chose quite an interesting topic, indeed. Although I'm surprised there's nothing on your mixed affinity, Sahm— she commented after skimming the investigation.

—Oh, that's- Well, we wanted to include it, but it was out of the defined scope of our investigation… Or that's what Micah told us— he replied. —I still think it's related and a huge oversight not to include it in this investigation.

—But Micah was right, much as we don't like it— Ari argued. —Without defining a clear area of investigation, it becomes difficult to give enough attention to all relevant subjects.

—That much is true. But this means that, now, you have a second investigation planned, don't you?— Shadow Weaver inquired, suspecting they hadn't thought about it.

—That's…

—Oh, absolutely!— Sahm quickly exclaimed, excited.

—Are you sure? You'd be the only subject of study— Ari reminded him.

—But are we *sure* of that?— he asked back. —We should start by checking on the new students. We only proved all sorcerers *before* us have no specific affinities; but what about the new generations?

—That's a great point, indeed— Shadow Weaver recognized.

—Does that mean you'll ask to be a tutor assistant for the new kids?— Ari asked.

—Huh, could be… I haven't yet decided who to start my tutor training with— he replied.

—I heard the new ones are under councillor Arden— they commented.

—Good thing they're among the reasonable ones in the council— Sahm laughed.

—Have those old fools been giving you a hard time?— the woman asked them both.

—Quite— he replied, rolling his eyes and folding his arms.

—Who would the "reasonable ones" be, may I ask?

—Well, councillor Arden, councilman Nolrem, foreman-councilman Geldirik, and…

—And some councilwomen— Ari completed. —When they actually dare speak. Besides them, only the Head Sorceress has the guts to speak up for us.

—Of course— Shadow Weaver laughed. —In any case, congratulations on your first investigation. And I expect to hear good things about your tutoring.

—Thank you— Sahm replied.

—You too, Ari— she added.

—Me!?

—Yes, you— she insisted.

—N-no, no. There's no way— they stammered, in a manner that reminded Shadow Weaver of the little kid to whom she taught the bird illusion.

—Do I have to convince you to give tutoring a chance? I believe you're more than fit…

—I don't know… I wouldn't even know what to focus on teaching, cause I definitely can't go for general magic formation.

—I recommend you focus on illusion magic.

—Why?

—*Because* you could perfectly cast an illusion, a complex one with movement and all, when you were just five or six years old. And in your first try!— she pointed out, almost indignant at how obvious it was.

—Oh, right— they shyly replied, scratching the back of their neck. —A-alright, I'll give it a try.

—Good to hear— she sighed, joining her arms behind her back.

—We should get going now, but we'll totally return with our new investigation— Sahm promised.

—I expect as much. Now, go.

Eventually, and before Castaspella could process it, their graduation's second anniversary arrived. The former pupils organized a gathering and begged her to join them so they could have their reunion with Shadow Weaver.

Normally, the Head Sorceress would have been thrilled, but this time she simply wasn't feeling in the mood. However, she didn't want to let them down, so she accepted, but only for a while.

Hence, the reunion was brief yet cheerful. And perhaps it was a good thing that Castaspella limited the time so much, because Shadow Weaver could hardly handle so much excitement around her. Deep down, yes, she was proud, but it was still quite difficult for her to admit it, and even more difficult to feel comfortable in this kind of situation.

For the group, Castaspella's odd mood went unnoticed, but for Shadow Weaver, it didn't. In the same way, Glimmer noticed as much and asked Adora to accompany her to the groove to interrogate the

woman.

—How would I know why your aunt is all gloomy? I can feel what she feels, not the reason— Shadow Weaver pointed out.

—Did you tell her anything!?

—Absolutely no— she quickly denied.

—Then why isn't she excited about the anniversary of your pupils!?— Glimmer insisted. —Last year she was the same!

—Last year…— the woman repeated, pensive. —Ah, I know… She's so ridiculous.

—What is it?— Adora asked.

—It's not what I said, but rather what I *didn't* say— she began. She then scoffed and clarified — However, it was *two years ago*.

—What!?

—She's been upset about your father's conversation with me because I refuse to tell her what we talked about. I simply don't understand what is so relevant about it— she explained, rolling her eyes.

—She's probably afraid of what he might have told you— Glimmer uttered, looking down as she recalled what Bow told her. —I can't tell you much but… she admitted something to Dad and might be scared he told you. But- Why would she still fear that after two years?

—Stubbornness?

—Hey, it's normal for some people— Adora argued, innocent. —If the anniversary of the graduation reminds her of it, of course she'll be like this.

—I think we should speak with her— Glimmer commented.

—That will probably be more useful than talking to *me*— Shadow Weaver reproached her.

—Yes, yes. I get it.

—Alright, then— Adora sighed. —Let's go. Bye.

However, much to their surprise, when they reunited with Bow and Catra to explain what might be happening to Castaspella, they were told something very similar about Micah.

—I don't know. Your dad is acting seriously suspicious, you know? I mean, he'll have me practice my illusions but be completely distracted by some scrolls…— Catra explained.

—He seems to be working on some secret project he won't let anyone see or know about, and he looks, well, gloomy— Bow added.

—Alright, I'm done with this— Glimmer stated. —Bow, go check on Dad and distract him for a while. Girls, we're taking Auntie somewhere relaxing right now— she decided.

—Alright, Love. I'll see you later then— he farewelled, smiling, and rushed away after giving her a quick kiss.

—Where do you want to take her, Sparkles?— Catra asked, curious.

—Is Darla available for a ride?— she asked back.

—I can get the ship ready in a few minutes— Adora assured her.

—Then we're going to those hot springs we found in our last mission— the Queen told them with a smirk.

—That's quite smart— Catra agreed.

—You want to take me where!?— Castaspella asked her niece, brow raised in confusion.

—Just come with us and you'll see! I'm sure you'll like it, it's better than the Steam Grotto!

—Better!? I don't believe you…— she quickly replied, folding her arms and looking away, pretending to be offended. —I suppose I'll have to check that for myself.

—Yay!— Glimmer celebrated, before holding Castaspella by the arms to teleport away with her.

—Wait!

As soon as they appeared inside Darla, the Queen asked —Everything ready here, guys?

—Yeah— Catra replied from the pilot seat.

—But I didn't bring any bathing suit!— the Head Sorceress reminded Glimmer.

—Oh, don't worry, Auntie. We have that covered.

Well, she didn't have any other complaints… And it was clear they only had good intentions, so why not?

This would surely be interesting!

Without further excuses, the four departed in Darla, and soon were coursing through space…

As they arrived on the planet, everything looked so strange to the sorceress that she felt a bit overwhelmed. In complete awe, she followed the girls into a large cave just a few meters away from their landing place, and couldn't help gaping upon her entrance.

—Well… I can't say it's *better* than the Steam Grotto, but it's certainly more beautiful— Castaspella had to recognize.

—Oh, you're gonna love this place, Head Sorceress— Catra assured her. —Now let's go, choose a pool.

She was looking around in complete admiration. The cave was massive, the walls covered in glistening crystals, the waters clear and steamy, and the bottom of each pool looked glassy, as if a polished version of the same crystals of the walls covered them.

She then saw the girls wave at three people she didn't know…

Unbeknownst to her, they were the Star Siblings whom Adora and Glimmer had met long ago; Catra met them a few years later when the Best Friends Squad came across them on a near planet.

However, they didn't tell any of this to the sorceress, and she preferred not to ask.

Instead, she continued to look around. People of a species unknown to Castaspella were lazily soaking in some pools, others just walked around offering towels and swimsuits, and some even offered food.

Having changed into the bathing suits provided by them, the four women settled for a large pool and got in.

—This is so relaxing, I love it— Adora let out, leaning back.

—The floor is so smooth— Castaspella noticed. —But it looks like the walls, I expected it to be pointy.

—Oh, no, it was, but the people here polished it— Catra explained, crossing her arms behind her head as she rested back.

—Alright, Auntie. Time to relax— Glimmer told her, kneeling in the middle of the pool in front of her. —Just sit back and enjoy the steam.

—Alright— she sighed, complying. —But… Why did you bring me here?

The girls exchanged a glance, their expressions falling, and both Catra and Adora nodded at Glimmer.

—We think you need this, Auntie. You seem… troubled— she explained.

—Oh, Dear, I'm fine. You didn't have to— Castaspella replied, grateful. —But I appreciate the gesture.

—Are you sure you don't want to talk about anything? We're not in Etheria, you can speak freely. And we promise not to tell…

—That's very nice of you— she giggled. —But I shouldn't bother you with my silly problems.

—It's no trouble at all, Head Sorceress— Adora assured her.

—Yeah. You've listened to our silly issues enough times, it's only fair— Catra added.

—My, my. You really want to hear my thoughts, don't you?

—There must be a reason why you're so gloomy, Auntie.

—Fine, alright. I guess I can… think aloud for a while…— she finally accepted, leaning back on the edge of the pool. The three girls settled back in silence, ready to hear her out, and she looked up to the colorful crystals above her head, trying to order her thoughts. —Two years ago… I realized something, and decided to admit it to my brother. And just an hour or so later, you told me he had

gone to speak with Shadow Weaver, and that put me on edge because I fear he told her… about *that*. But she refuses to tell me what they spoke about, so I can't possibly know if he did— she began, letting out a sigh or two occasionally. —Knowing her, there's a chance he told her and she just dismissed it, which would be… hard for me to accept. But if he didn't tell her… I don't know, maybe I should— she reflected. —As for what I mean… Well, I… told him that… I love her— she finally confessed, closing her eyes. —I *do* love her, but I understand this is a kind of love, or maybe yearning, that allows me to deeply appreciate Spin despite all her bad deeds, *without* ignoring what she has done. Moreover, it's a kind of love that stems from recognizing what she has done, both the good and the bad, and acknowledging the path she has finally decided to take. The responsibility she accepted for her life choices at long last— she elaborated. —I can see her flaws, I really do; that's part of why I love her, because she also allows me to see *my* flaws without fear or shame. Thanks to her, I know I can always work on fixing them and making up for them to the best of my potential— she concluded.

Castaspella closed her eyes again and let out a deep sigh, unaware of the shock on the girls' faces.

—Auntie…

—I never thought I'd hear someone say something like that about Shadow Weaver, but I must admit… that was beautiful— Catra let out, looking back at Adora.

—When I said I believe that woman has a heart deep, deep down, I never imagined someone would actually manage to… reach it— she commented, eyes wide open. —Will you tell her, Head Sorceress?

—Should I?

—I believe so, yes— Adora nodded.

—Can I ask… what made you believe she could… "choose the path" you mentioned? What made you think someone like her would ever… you know, grow?— Catra dared ask.

—I think my hope in her potential to be better sparked when- Yes, when she told me to stop her if she tried to get the power of the Heart for herself— Castaspella replied, unsure at first. —I doubted her intentions until that moment.

—She really said that? Well, then I suppose that makes sense— she reflected.

Seeing her wife deep in thought, Adora added —I think the final step for her is accepting love. Years ago, I would have told you *not* to mention a thing for your own safety…— she admitted, looking away with a grimace. —But now, I think she has evolved enough to, maybe, accept it?

—We have seen how much she cares for you, Head Sorceress— Catra finally said, looking back at her. —Adora is right. *Now* she may be in a position to accept it. Mentally, I mean…

—I… hope so— Castaspella sighed. —But I don't know if I'd dare do it alone— she considered, looking down.

—I would think you'd want to tell her in private, but if you prefer, maybe we can be there for moral support?— Glimmer proposed.

The sorceress let out a laugh and replied —I suppose that would help me, yes…

—Then it’s settled! Would you dare do it when we get back?— Glimmer asked her, with a cheeky expression.

—Better do it before I regret it, so yes— she decided, taking a deep breath.

—We’ll be there for you— Adora promised.

—And I’ll kick her summoned ass if she rejects you for her shitty beliefs— Catra added.

That made the sorceress laugh again, finding it amusing but also endearing.

She couldn’t help thinking about how close she had become, not only with her niece at long last, but also with her friends.

Meanwhile, back in Etheria, Bow found Micah at Bright Moon’s gardens.

—Oh, Bow. What’s up, boy?— the King Father greeted him.

—Uh, hi, ki- Micah— he replied. —Are you busy?

—Just taking a break. My head is killing me.

—Is it perhaps because of the… uh… secret project you’re working on?— Bow asked, failing to be subtle.

—I suppose— he admitted, rolling his eyes. —But I won’t tell you about it.

—Alright, alright. I wasn’t asking. It’s your stuff— Bow conceded. —But are you sure you’re alright? You seem a bit discomforted as of late.

—I’m fine, I promise. It’s nothing to worry about.

—Talking about it might help you— Bow insisted. —You don't have to tell me any details, of course. I’ll just listen.

His tone was gentle enough to convince Micah, who let out a deep sigh.

—I suppose you’re right— he accepted. —I’m just… conflicted. About what I’m doing, about my sister, what she told me two years ago… About the fact that I’ve been working on that project for two years, despite swearing I would never do it again!— he began, increasingly frantic. —I don’t understand why I’m doing this! But I feel like I have to… Does it make any sense!?

—Why do you feel like you have to? What would happen if you just… abandon the project?

—I can’t- I shouldn’t— he replied, brushing his hair back with a hand as he sighed. —I suppose I feel… guilty.

—Is this about what you told me two years ago?— Bow asked, approaching.

—Yes. Exactly. I have to fix my mistakes, and… this might be it, but I’m- I feel like a hypocrite…— he admitted.

—A hypocrite? For trying to fix your mistakes?

—For *how* I'm trying to do it— he clarified.

—Alright, I get it. What you're working on isn't just a simple project. But if you think this is the right thing, then I think you should go ahead despite everything— Bow encouraged him.

—I suppose you're right, boy— he said, letting out a breathless laugh. —No wonder you make for such a good king.

—Tha-thanks— he uttered, suddenly shy.

—Thank *you*— Micah immediately replied. —I suppose I did need to talk a bit.

—Glad to help— Bow smiled.

A few hours later, as night fell on the Whispering Woods, the four women returned from their journey to the hot springs and went directly to the magical groove.

—What a quaint group. To what do I owe the pleasure?— Shadow Weaver greeted them, with her usual condescending tone.

—Good evening, no?

—Yes, yes. Good evening, I guess…

—Why am I doing this?— Castaspella muttered, massaging her temples.

—You feel relaxed, that's strange— the woman noticed, curious.

—It won't last long if you start with your usual bullshit— she let out between her teeth.

—Oh, what a shame. I was looking forward to messing with you— she joked.

—And there you are…

—Ahem!— Glimmer exaggeratedly cleared her throat, and gestured at her aunt to stop digressing.

—Yes, yes. I know— she complained. —I- Well, I have… something I need to talk to you about— she began, looking away.

—What's with the audience?— Shadow Weaver asked, looking at the three girls with a raised brow.

—Moral support— Castaspella answered, deadpan. —Just let me speak.

—Go ahead…

—I just need to… find the right words…— she hesitated.

—Have you forgotten how to string a sentence together?— the woman mocked her.

—You're impossible. I don't know why I'm trying— Castaspella huffed, getting angry and aiming to walk away.

—No, no, no. Don’t you dare leave now, Auntie— the Queen stopped her. —We know she’s a bitch, but don’t let that stop you now!

—Come on, Head Sorceress… Just say it— Adora encouraged her.

—Alright— she grunted, returning to where she was standing in front of Shadow Weaver. Looking back at her, she took a deep breath and said —There's something I need to tell you, whether you like it or not, whether you accept it or not. It's been too long, so I need to get it off my chest before it kills me.

Something to tell her before it kills her?

Could it be?

No, impossible.

She refused to acknowledge the little hope of it being… a confession, and instead went for a mocking reply.

—You had enough encounters with death the past few years, so better go ahead…

—I…— she hesitated, before tightly closing her fists and eyes, letting out a grunt. —I hate so many things about you!— she finally exclaimed. Everyone stared in shock; what had she just said!? —Starting with how much of a bitch you can be, or the way you purposely behave like a jerk even when you're giving a compliment. I hate how skilled you are at twisting the truth to manipulate people without even needing to lie, or the fact that you're so good with kids yet consider you're just manipulating them. Even if you're really doing what's best for them this time!— she went on. —I-I hate how knowledgeable and talented you are, your perfectionism, your charm. I hate how our bickering makes me laugh, and how much I enjoy your company, even if you're being a bitch, calling me a fool, harshly criticizing everything I do, or mocking me for anything I say or do! Why! I hate that you're possibly the only person who understands me on the deepest level, the first one to have seen me and respected me despite finding me annoying. The one person who acknowledges my smarts despite calling me a fool, the one who gives me courage and confidence when I don't trust myself!

Silence. Utter silence.

For a moment, only the rustle of leaves could be heard.

Confused, the girls exchanged fleeting glances and looked between the women. Castaspella breathed heavily, and Shadow Weaver just looked in complete shock.

—I see…— she finally sighed, barely hiding her dashed hopes. —And I suppose it would make no difference to apologize for that.

—No. But… because that's exactly why I… value and appreciate you more than anyone I know— she replied, further shocking them all.

“Value and appreciate”.

There went Shadow Weaver’s last hopes.

No, not hopes. Just stupid wishful thinking.

She knew she shouldn’t have thought about it even…

But then again, “value and appreciate”?

Has she gone insane?

Hiding her disappointment, the woman stammered —Wha-what!? You were hating on me just a second ago!

In turn, Castaspella’s expression softened as she argued —But you don't get it… What I truly hate… is the extent to which I cherish all of that from you. You're not a perfect person, and you've barely become a decent one… But I feel… I-I believe you're *perfect* for me. It took me too long to gather the courage to say all of this, and even longer to actually realize it and accept it myself.

—I don't understand how you came to this conclusion. It's ridiculous.

The girls wanted to facepalm. She couldn’t be serious…

How can someone be so oblivious?

How could Shadow Weaver, of all people, be this oblivious?

But also, why won’t the sorceress just speak straight!?

Still talking in riddles for the woman, Castaspella “explained” —Because, from the beginning, you've been someone genuine. You don't fake niceness, don't pretend I'm not insufferable sometimes, nor do you try to be in my good graces just because I'm the Head Sorceress. You call out my every flaw and have helped me see and solve my problems on my own. In the same way, I've called out your bullshit and you've listened and finally faced it too. I don't know if you can see how much you've improved, but you *have*.

—What do you mean by all of this?— Shadow Weaver asked once again, increasingly confused.

—Don't you understand?— the sorceress chuckled, stepping forward. —Beatrix, I love you!

Oh…

So it *was* a confession…

It had to be a joke…

Incredulous, the woman reacted a bit unexpectedly.

—Love?— she scoffed. —It's clear you have no idea what that even means. You're confusing your admiration and care for everyone around you with "love".

Why did she say that?

Even she herself had no idea why her first instinct was to dismiss her like that…

Why did she say that!?

No, no. It was true.

There was no way in Etheria that sorceress actually loved her.

—You just have to be so mean about this, no!?— Castaspella yelled, angry again. —What *even* is your problem!? Why is it so hard to believe!? Or am I just not enough for you!?

—You are the one who just expressed all your *hate* for me! You clearly have no idea what you're talking about.

—Then tell me!

Shadow Weaver let out a low growl before finally deciding to reply —You never had to consider whether you deserve love or not, have you? Or whether you deserve kindness or not… Whether you're a monster or a very mistaken person… Whether there is *any* good at all left within you.

Still in shock, and starting to worry a bit, the girls remained silent, barely exchanging glances. However, those words made Catra clutch her chest. She actually understood what she meant.

Yet she'd be damned if she said anything at that moment.

—But you never doubted whether you deserved the position or power you had. You have always considered it your right— Castaspella eventually retorted, after hesitating for a moment.

—And it only led to questioning everything else!— she yelled back. —With everything I have done to get what I felt was my right to have… being now faced with the damage I did believing it was the right thing… how can you expect me to think I'm not a monster!?

—I know you think so, that's why I've told you several times you are not— the sorceress replied, with a calmer, gentler tone. —Being a horrible person doesn't make you a monster; continuing to be so, after being given a chance, after being confronted with the damage you did, like you just said, *that* would turn you into a monster— she insisted. —But if you're so convinced I'm "confused" if I think I love you, then you're definitely not a monster.

—How wouldn't I think so!?— the woman indignantly exclaimed. —I do not deserve to be loved by someone as… *remarkable* as you. It's not right.

"Not right"!?

She couldn't be serious…

—And you're suddenly such a good judge of what's right and what isn't? Having experience with being wrong doesn't give you any knowledge of what's right…— Castaspella argued, equally indignant.

—Suddenly so funny. I can't believe you're actually teasing me now— Shadow Weaver scoffed, folding her arms.

—And I can't believe this dramatic self-loathing speech was your reply to my love confession!— the sorceress exclaimed. —Do you have any idea how hard it was for me to even *dare* think about this enough to craft a coherent way of expressing it!?

The woman stared at her, speechless. So did the girls.

After a moment, she managed to ask —How did you manage to make that more wordy than necessary?

—That's it. I'm out. This time for real— she decided, and turned around to leave once more. However, she was immediately stopped as Shadow Weaver grabbed her arm. —What!?

She held her sight for a moment, yet looked down before saying —Thank you.

—For?

There was a glint of hope in Castaspella's eyes, and this time, she wouldn't let her down.

—Not giving up on me. And being *so* honest— she smirked, rolling her eyes. Immediately, she pulled her nearer and wrapped an arm around her waist, keeping her close. The sorceress couldn't help but look away, blushing shyly. —You have *very* specific feelings for me. And curious, I must say, after hearing everything you "hate" from me…

—Then why did you have to be such a real jerk about it?

—Easy: I like how daring you get when I am— Shadow Weaver grinned.

—Oh, for fuck's sake! Kiss already!— Glimmer exclaimed, bold as ever.

They all laughed at that, especially amused at the Queen's utter impatience, but the woman seemed pretty serious when she replied —Then turn around…

—What? Are you shy?— Castaspella asked, giving Catra a quick glance as she smirked.

—Come on! Don't be ridiculous!— Glimmer insisted.

—This is not an entertainment show!

—Bea… If you don't want to kiss me, just say it… No one's forcing you.

—I don't want them to stare…— Shadow Weaver told the sorceress, rolling her eyes to hide her sudden shyness.

Giggling, Castaspella asked her —Do you trust me?

—Yes, why?— the woman replied, seemingly bothered by the question.

—Good.

With an amused smile, the sorceress held Shadow Weaver, turned her around so her back was to the girls, and pulled her in for a kiss.

At long last!

The three immediately cheered, practically relieved it *finally* happened.

Catra couldn't help reflecting on how happy she felt for them. The women were actually kissing, yet instead of finding it gross like years ago, she found it endearing.

It was such a different feeling…

Yet it was also… bittersweet. Feeling *happy* for Shadow Weaver, after everything she did to her, to them…

No, no.

She was happy for Castaspella.

Even if that meant being happy for Shadow Weaver by extension.

She wouldn’t be as petty as that woman, she would never do anything to hinder her happiness out of spite…

Besides, she no longer held such resentment. It was not worth it.

In any case, she could see it as some form of poetic justice: the final kick in the right direction, irrefutable proof that all her anti-love mentality was utterly wrong…

—Hey— Adora quietly called her, pulling Catra from her thoughts. —It seems Double Trouble won the bet too.

She chuckled and agreed —Yup… They totally nailed it.

Chapter End Notes

Now, yes! I really really wanna know your thoughts!!!

Gods, I'm just so excited, this is unbelievable…

I know there's yet another sequel to this but like, this is actually ending now! For real! I wanna scream!! I'm so happy and sad! \(^o^)/ (/^\)

Finally, for *the* thing everyone is waiting, well, you guessed it, that's gonna happen in the final chapter. Many more things will happen once she's back in the surface, but like, that's all for the sequel *Life Will Change*!

So, I really hope you enjoyed this chapter as much as me, and see you next week!! ^_^

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver back in eternal damnation...

Chapter Summary

The lesson: it’s never too late to apologize
Status: successfully integrated to the system|

Chapter Notes

Man, I'm getting a lot of questions about next part already!! Wooohhh!!

First of all, sorry this is a short chapter, even for a flashback, it's just so short... But it's important, there's an important detail.

Second, to anyone who reads the comments of every chapter, sorry for how +18 those comments are getting... <("^_^)

Third, next week will be the last chapter and we won't be back until *checks calendar* the first Wednesday of Feb 2024, which is the 7th!
I promise you'll like *Life Will Change*, I'll make the wait worth it!!

Finally, can you believe this will end the week of my b-day!? Literally three days before aaaahhhhh
Your comments on that last chapter will be my early gifts (#^_^#)

Anyways, more about that on the notes of the last chapter!
Without furhter ado, please enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She felt so at ease…

Even after her little discussion with the sorceress that morning, she simply felt like everything was *right*.

She hadn’t felt so well since her death.

Ironic.

She couldn’t help thinking about how different everything felt, despite it all remaining the same, as Castaspella argued.

How could just a few words change her reality so much?

Well, this wasn't the first time she thought about "a few words changing someone's reality" so drastically.

She recalled when, years ago, at the gathering that the Queen organized to announce her decision to have a baby, she heard Bow's fathers talking with Castaspella about apologizing, about how much a simple "sorry" could help.

And yes, she had experienced it for herself.

Well, she has apologized a few times already, and a part of her hoped those apologies had the effect Bow's fathers described, but there's one particular apology that may not have been quite enough…

Although she always thought she had no reason to ask Micah for forgiveness, it became evident to her that she had, in fact, caused him great suffering, and that was why she said "sorry" before he could. Him apologizing before ever getting an apology from her felt simply *wrong*.

Ah… But that pathetic speech of hers was far from sufficient.

Light Spinner felt like she owed him more; to prove she meant it all the times she expressed concern for him, she had to, perhaps, begin by being honest to herself about what she feels.

Thinking this brought back a bitter memory from one of the times Castaspella won at Deck Fights. Her question had touched a nerve, which was common, but this particular time Shadow Weaver had refused to answer…

How dared her!?

Of all the things she could have asked…

She just *had to*, no!?

Shadow Weaver left Castaspella's room, directly stalking through the closed door. It took the Head Sorceress a moment too long to follow her, yet she managed to catch up before the woman turned around the corner.

—Bea! Wait!— she exclaimed.

—Don't call me that out here— Shadow Weaver hissed, turning around to face her.

—No one heard, it's the middle of the night…

—I don't care.

—Just, please… I-I'm sorry— Castaspella stuttered. —Did- Was my question too invasive?

—What do you think?— she asked back, her tone acid.

—I'm really sorry…

—I don't care if we have an agreement, I'm *not* answering that stupid question.

—Yo-you don't have to, don't worry. Just… I'm sorry…

—Regardless of how many times you apologize, I won't answer…

—I said you don't have to. I apologize because I didn't mean to make you feel like this.

—You’re saying you didn’t mean to be a little backstabber, no?— Shadow Weaver retorted, increasingly angry. —I give you a single millimeter of trust and this is what you use it for!?

—Bea, please!

—Enough with your “please”! I’m sick of your fake niceness!— the woman yelled, with that tone she’d use to threaten Catra. She didn’t know why that comparison crossed her mind but, the second it did, her anger vanished and she composed herself. —Leave me alone.

—A-alright— Castaspella sighed. —When you’re ready to return, I’ll be waiting.

—Don’t stay awake…

She did, in fact, stay awake waiting for her. And apologized again, and swore she wasn’t trying to hurt or betray her trust, etc. The sorceress sometimes spoke too much…

She argued she just wanted to know what she truly felt if, as she insists, she really cared for Micah… And the question?

Just remembering it hurt her again…

Castaspella had dared ask whether she ever felt like a mother to him.

And damn her, she did.

As a tutor, she knew she shouldn’t get attached to her students, and that she shouldn’t show favoritism, but in the end, that was exactly what she did. It wasn’t on purpose, of course, but it happened.

Perhaps that was why she refused to answer. Because admitting it would have been recognizing her poor judgement.

And she refused to do it.

But maybe she should? At least to him?

Once again, she owed him a better apology; as the sorceress said, it is never too late to apologize.

But would she have the chance?

Chapter End Notes

That will be all for today.

Adding to the initial notes, I love spoiling stuff, love talking about what's to come, discuss ideas, and such, so if any of you wanna know more, remember there's my Tumblr and my Twt in my profile here. I'll be happy to answer anything at all!!
And don't worry, I can't spoil that much of LWC because there are just a few notes about it for now... hehe

Oh, and in the meantime, may I remind you I have a total of 20, yes! 20 she-ra fanfics now!? So maybe, see you on another fic!!

The Spell of Obtainment

Chapter Summary

The Head Sorceress feels fulfilled and happy for the first time in quite a while, and *everyone* has noticed. Even her brother, who's inner struggles, boiling for two years, have begun to overwhelm him.
As doubt and resolve clash, the sorcerer will have to focus on what matters the most to him: his sister's happiness.

So… should he bring his project to fruition?

»And yet, despite his resolve during the day, each night, doubt would haunt him.
»Why was he doing this?
»To fix his mistake, yes, but why this way!? Why was this his first idea!?
» (…) What if his talent alone wasn't enough?
»Should he ask for help, maybe?
»No, no. This was his problem to fix, and getting others involved, putting them in danger like he was… He would never do such a thing.
»No, this was his risk to take.

While Castaspella remains oblivious of his plan, her own troubles will keep her quite busy; after all, what makes her happy is also making her suffer…

Chapter Notes

This chapter is a gamble.
You may like it, you may despise it, you may think it's quite ironic or just plain hypocritical.
I don't know.
But I decided to write this long long ago and have been dying to finally elaborate the notes and post it.

In any case, I think it's actually the perfect conclusion to the cycle, even if it opens the door to the plot of the next part. I believe that, with this, Micah's arc is complete to the ultimate extent, not just resolving the arc I wrote, but also resolving the arc started in the series when he was a teen.
So, I hope you enjoy the chapter regardless of whether you agree with my vision or not. And if you disagree, don't hesitate to tell me why! All opinions are more than valid and I really appreciate it when my readers share their honest thoughts about my writing, be it positive or negative.

Oh, and a final comment: the little silly discussion with which the chapter opens is actually kinda important; if you read carefully, it has a certain subtext that will be further explored in *Life Will Change*.

Now yes… Without further ado, the final chapter:

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Head Sorceress woke up with a smile on her lips.

This wasn't really the first time she did, but it felt special regardless.

Humming contentedly, she pushed herself up a bit and looked back at a frowning Shadow Weaver. It wasn't exactly surprising but it did confuse Castaspella enough to ask about it.

—Good morning— she let out, extending the last word, as she leant forward, closer to the pensive woman. —What's on your mind?

Well? What was on her mind?

Some complicated dilemma she couldn't figure out?

More self-loathing?

Perhaps a bit of an inner-debate about whether she deserves to be in her current situation or not…

Regardless, she wouldn't tell her.

Instead, she mocked her —Just wondering why you're so clingy in your sleep.

—Hey! As if this were the first time I hug you when asleep…

—I didn't say it was, just that *now* I wonder why you do it— the woman pointed out, her smirk widening.

—I-I don't know. I just like it— Castaspella replied, stammering a bit and blushing as she looked away, suddenly shy.

It immediately made Shadow Weaver laugh.

—Don't take it so seriously… Did you forfeit your ability to tell when I'm just mocking you?

—N-no, I'm just…— she began, but got interrupted by a yawn. —I'm just waking up!

—Sure, as if you weren't a little fool…

—Oh, shut up— the sorceress immediately countered, letting out a smirk.

However, when she leant forward again, clearly aiming to kiss her, Shadow Weaver stopped her; the woman raised a hand and placed a pair of fingers on Castaspella's lips, delicate but firm.

That was a "no".

—Get dressed— she requested.

—What? Why?

—Because you can't just go around in a blanket, can you?— the woman teased her.

—But there's no rush. Why won't you let me kiss you first?

—Why do you want to kiss me first? Just get dressed…

—Bea… Are you embarrassed?— Castaspella tentatively asked.

—Does it seem like I am?

—It does look like you're suddenly shy or something. You had no issues with me kissing you like this last night— the sorceress reminded her.

—Well, I am not. I just want you to get dressed before you catch a cold, alright?— Shadow Weaver finally let out, getting slightly annoyed.

—Fine! I will… But now you owe me an explanation…

—I don't owe you a thing— the woman retorted, squinting. —Just get dressed.

—I swear, if you say it again…

—You will *what* exactly?— Shadow Weaver defied her.

—Try me— Castaspella dared her, adjusting her sleeves after putting them on.

—Get… *dressed*…

—Bitch!— the sorceress immediately exclaimed, jumping at her and stealing a kiss. —You just had to, of course, you had to— she sighed.

—Satisfied?

—No, you didn't tell me what your problem is. And you didn't kiss me back— she complained, pouting.

—Is it completely necessary? Don't you have things to do?

—I have a full day ahead of me, trust me, but I want to know what's wrong with you first!

—Nothing's wrong, woman. Just leave to do your things…

—Bea, please— Castaspella begged, cupping her face. As Shadow Weaver immediately looked away, blushing, she added —I'm trying not to be pushy, and I want to respect your boundaries, but I'm worried.

—Less worrying and more respecting then— the woman replied, rolling her eyes and trying very hard to seem aloof.

The sorceress groaned and rested her head under Shadow Weaver's chin, while her hand still cupped the woman's cheek and slightly caressed it.

—Did I do something wrong?

—Don't start… That's guilt you're playing with…

—No, no. I'm not trying to make *you* feel guilty. *I really feel guilty now*! Did I do anything you didn't like or that made you feel uncomfortable?— Castaspella insisted, lifting her head.

—Funny that you put it that way— Shadow Weaver noted. —I am quite uncomfortable, yes.

—Why?

—Think, just *think*.

And so the sorceress did.

After a moment, she finally sighed —It's the love in general, isn't it? All this situation, you still feel it's all a show of weakness, don't you?

—Clever.

—What can I do to help, then?

—You? Nothing. It's all me against myself.

—And if I distract you a bit from this? Nothing has changed, between you and me, I mean. We're still just…

—*Everything* changed, Cas. And that is fine. But…— Shadow Weaver sighed, resigned. —I suppose a distraction can help me a bit, yes.

—Why don't I tell you what I have to do today, then? Meanwhile, you can tie up my hair— she proposed.

—Alright…

—Well, for starters, there are new pupils, so we have to arrange their classes and tutors. That means I'll have to call for a few meetings today, only for that. Then there's my classes themselves and the graduates whose investigations I'm guiding!— Castaspella began. —Oh! And I also have a lot of sweaters to knit for Wrong Hordak! He uses them all the time, so they get worn out pretty quickly. Princess Entrapta is *literally* paying me to make more for him— she recalled, giggling. —I never thought I would get paid to knit sweaters! It's so exciting!

—Only you would find that exciting— Shadow Weaver pointed out, smiling fondly.

Perhaps the sorceress was right, things hadn't changed that much. It just felt like everything was different.

—Is it wrong that I find it exciting?

—No…— the woman sighed, as she fixed Castaspella's bun in place. —You haven't changed a bit in all these years… Except for the white hair— she teased her.

—What!? Don't tell me I forgot to dye them again!

—You were dying it!?

—You didn't know?

—I should have guessed— Shadow Weaver admitted. —But why do you dye it?

—I-I don't- Well, I just… think it looks… I don't know… weird— the sorceress shyly admitted.

—It doesn't.

—Really?

Castaspella gave her a look so full of hope that the woman was stunned for a second.

—Yes, really. I think you should leave it as it is— she replied, taking a deep breath with her eyes closed.

When she opened them again, she let out a smile and pulled the woman closer to kiss her.

—Thank you— Castaspella uttered.

—Thank me by letting me decide when I want to kiss you, alright?

—Of course.

—Now don't forget your cape— Shadow Weaver reminded her before the sorceress could teleport away.

—Oh! Right, right— she chuckled. With her cape and the blanket hanging from one of her arms, she drew the teleportation spell, and hesitated before activating it. —Just, promise me you will speak more.

—What do you mean?

—When something doesn't sit right with you, you always say it. So keep doing it now. No matter how ridiculous you think it is, tell me, alright?

—Fine, fine. I will…

Castaspella immediately smiled upon hearing that and finally activated the spell, disappearing from the groove, hence making Shadow Weaver's summoned body sink under the ground once again.

There was *something* in the Head Sorceress' walk, like a spring in her step, that everyone noticed and had no reservations talking about. Soon there was a new wave of gossips, but Castaspella didn't care this time. As long as she didn't have to hear people discussing those gossips right in front of her, she didn't care.

The one who did care a bit was Micah, whose inner struggle became more and more visible with each passing day…

Even his pupils talked about how happy the Head Sorceress looked, and how they were sure something had to have happened with Shadow Weaver for her to be like that; in those moments, he would take a really deep breath, close his eyes, focus on the part about his sister being *happy*, and exhale pretending he heard nothing.

That was easier.

He just had to focus on that: his sister is *happy*. With his project almost ready to be executed, he just needed to keep it in mind and *do it*.

And yet, despite his resolve during the day, each night, doubt would haunt him.

Why was he doing this?

To fix his mistake, yes, but why this way!? Why was this his first idea!?

Well, his exhaustive investigation on the matter of Shadow Weaver's state had proved this was the only solution… After all, while researching to fix that little project, he had also investigated other possibilities in parallel, all of which proved fruitless…

This was definitely the only way: he had to… extract that terrible thing from the core of Etheria and keep it on the surface, sealed away somewhere safe so it wouldn't keep pulling Shadow Weaver underground like it does.

If only there was a safer way…

But his modifications seemed to work. He had crafted a more complex sigil that combined several manners of sealing energy *and* matter, just to be sure, which should now be more than enough. And if, this time, he kept his focus on the spell, there was no way that cursed thing would be able to escape, right!?

But what if it did? What if his talent alone wasn't enough?

Should he ask for help, maybe?

No, no. This was *his* problem to fix, and getting others involved, putting them in danger like he was… He would never do such a thing.

No, this was *his* risk to take.

The fewer people involved, the better…

About a week passed, and the Head Sorceress had spent every single day busy; not with the usual official matters, not with her new pupils tutoring, but rather with the investigation drafts of the acolytes she was guiding.

So busy, in fact, that she had even decided to take the documents with her to the magical groove that night.

—What's with all those papers?— Shadow Weaver asked, honestly curious. —You haven't brought work here in a while…

—It's just- Remember I told you I guide a few investigations? Well, these are it. Just drafts for now, but, they are so long. And all of them expect feedback as soon as possible!

—Maybe you should make it clear they will have the feedback as soon *as you can*. After all, I believe they should value quality over speed— the woman opined.

—Perhaps, but… I don't know. I don't want to leave them waiting for long— Castaspella argued.

—But you can't spend day and night reading those. And maybe you should ask for help— Shadow Weaver pointed out. —Didn't you say your friend the ambassador can learn the whole content of any form of document with a simple touch?

—Yes, but this is *my* work to do.

—And you are allowed to ask for help— she insisted.

—Fine! I'll ask him to help me… Once I've read everything.

—How stubborn…— the woman sighed.

—Come on, I said I will ask for help! But I still want to read everything myself— the Head Sorceress countered.

—Have you even eaten tonight before coming here?— Shadow Weaver inquired, folding her arms as she expected a negative.

—I…

—You didn't.

—Alright, I didn't, no.

—See what I mean?

—I'm not really hungry either.

—I don't care. You must eat, you're *alive*— the woman reproached her.

—It's nice that you worry about my health, but trust me, I don't need to eat every night. I'll be fine— she assured her.

—Cas…

—Do I really have to?

—Yes.

—Alright— she sighed. —I'll go for some dinner and then return— she decided.

—*Without* the papers— Shadow Weaver clarified.

—Fine, fine. I'll come back without them— she accepted, letting out a smile as she found it endearing how much she cared, despite showing it in such a… mean way.

Mean or not, Castaspella had to admit that leaving her work aside and resting so well that night actually helped. Besides, she had been struggling to comprehend the last bits she had read, so it was only logical that she needed to take a break from it.

Realizing as much, the Head Sorceress decided to have lunch in the tranquility of the gardens. And shortly after she finished, as she returned what she used to the kitchen, her niece appeared in Mystacor, looking for her.

By mere chance, the two crossed paths just as Castaspella left the kitchen, and almost bumped into each other.

—Oh, Auntie! So-sorry, I wasn't looking.

—Ah, Glimmer. What a surprise! What are you doing here? Is everything alright?

—O-of course— the Queen quickly replied. —Nothing happened.

—Then what can I help you with?— she gently asked.

—Auntie, I- Can we talk?

—Oh, sure— Castaspella immediately accepted. However, Glimmer's worried expression alarmed the sorceress and she added —Tell me the truth: Is something wrong?

—I just… need to talk with you in private— the Queen insisted.

—Alright, let's go to my room— she proposed.

Glimmer teleported them both to her room straightaway and let out a long sigh.

—I don't know where to begin.

—Let's take a seat first, alright? Just… take your time— her aunt suggested, inviting her to sit on the couch.

—Okay— the Queen sighed again. Leaning back and looking at the roof, she began —In short, it's about Dad. He has this secret project he's been working on and I'm concerned. When he talked with Bow, he told him he's trying to "fix his mistake", but also said he feels like a hypocrite for how he's trying to do it.

—He's… what?

—Well, I think he means he's trying to… you know… bring Shadow Weaver permanently to the surface— Glimmer explained.

—But we've tried everything and it's impossible— Castaspella argued, looking away with a defeated expression. —Not even the First Ones' technology can help.

—I know, Auntie. But Dad seems convinced that whatever he's planning will work— the Queen insisted. —What I'm worried about is the part that makes him feel like a hypocrite. I don't know what he's planning, but it sounds dangerous.

—Dangerous how?

—I don't know exactly how, but… he's always so confident in his prowess and suddenly he's hesitant? It must be dangerous.

—We can't do anything based on suppositions, Glimmer…

—I know! But- Shou-shouldn't we talk with him? If whatever he's planning to do is dangerous, shouldn't we talk him *out* of it?

—I understand what you mean, but *when* have we been able to talk your father out of anything?— Castaspella pointed out. She then took a deep breath and let out a long sigh. —Listen, Dear, you can try talking to him, but I doubt it will be of any use. Besides, with how secretive he has been about it, there's no chance we can stop him from doing it.

—You mean it will be too late when we find out what his plan is, right?

—Exactly. I'm sure he's counting on that.

Looking down, the Queen sighed —Then what do I do? I'm worried, Auntie.

—I understand— she assured her, leaning forward slightly to place a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. —It's just that your father… Well, you know he's stubborn. We all are, no?— the sorceress chuckled. —And he's an adult. We can't attempt to control his life; especially after years of reproaching him for trying to do so with my life…

—Then we just, what? Wait until he does it?

—I suppose we have no option. We'll just have to be ready to, I don't know, deal with whatever he's doing if it really is dangerous.

—Why would he change his mind like this? I-I mean, what happened that he's doing something that makes him hesitate so much yet still goes through with it to-to bring her back!?— Glimmer wondered, confused and almost indignant at how bizarre she found it.

—I understand as much as you do— Castaspella let out. —But I wouldn't dare ask him. I'm just glad to know that he has apparently let go of his hatred.

—I really hope he did.

Later that same day, an interesting gathering took place in Bright Moon.

More than a week had passed, but finally the princesses who joined a *certain* bet were all free to get together with the Best Friends Squad and Double Trouble to learn the results and pay up.

Ah, and Sea Hawk joined them out of curiosity…

The shape-shifter brought the famous case with them and, as they all sat with a few snacks, they took the list of bets the group had made years ago. Writing everything down had been a sound decision, indeed.

And so, the Queen took the initiative and revealed how it went.

—No way…— Mermista grunted, folding her arms and leaning back. —We lost to *Flutterina*?

—That was just a character, you know?— Double Trouble reminded her.

—Yes, yes…

—Ah, but my dear Princess, you weren't so wrong— Sea Hawk interrupted. He then addressed Glimmer, pointing out —It sounded like your aunt *did* confess in a rather subtle manner, wouldn't you say?

—Not so fast, Darling— the shape-shifter denied, before the Queen could reply. —It is clearly written here that they would *both* subtly confess and argue until they understood what the other meant— they read. —Yet this was quite unilateral, wasn't it?

—Yeah— Adora conceded. —What Shadow Weaver said was… not really a confession. More like a roundabout way of admitting she loves her too? Maybe?

—Explicitly, she only called her "remarkable"— Catra explained. —It was more like Double Trouble said: it began like a rejection, arguing she doesn't deserve her.

—Aww, I really wish I was there— Spinnerella lamented.

—But did that woman say, you know, that she loves her too?— Netossa asked.

—Um…— Glimmer hesitated, exchanging a glance with Bow.

—You never mentioned if she did— he told her, grimacing.

—Because she didn't…— Adora admitted, looking away. —But she, um, thanked her and, you know, kissed her… Doesn't that mean the same?

This time, Spinnerella and Netossa exchanged a glance, unsure. Then, they looked over at Perfuma and Frosta, who frowned worried, and noticed the way Scorpia nervously tapped her pincers against each other.

—Well, you know. It's Shadow Weaver. That's, like, a lot— she nervously pointed out.

—Yes, but… that's kind of *sad*— Mermista commented, arms still folded.

—I think Scorpia is right— Bow disagreed. —We can't dismiss the fact that this is still Shadow Weaver— he insisted. Glancing back at Adora and Catra for a moment, he went on —She changed her attitude a lot, apologized to our friends, and Casta assures there have been many more things she progressed on, although we don't notice. But she's still the same person who tried to convince Adora that her love for Catra was a weakness. If she thinks that about love, she will… probably never admit it if she loves Casta.

Looking down, Adora sighed deeply before saying —Bow is right. She's unlikely to ever admit loving her, but the fact that she didn't completely reject the Head Sorceress is already a lot. In her own, twisted way, that's love…

—"Twisted" being the keyword here— Catra clarified. —Everything that is so easy and straightforward for us to do or say, or even think, it's nearly impossible for her, save in a roundabout way— she explained. However, she then looked down too and added —I understand what it is to… be convinced of… things that make it difficult to process stuff like friendship or love; for you all, it was something basic. I might be wrong, but I'm almost sure neither of you had to question whether you deserved love in any form… Or whether you were allowed to give love.

—But you learnt that stuff and now there's hardly any difference with how any of us views love— Netossa pointed out.

—I wasn't even twenty when I was *given the chance* to learn that— she quickly pointed out. —Yeah, I was still reluctant and made all those jokes about hating princesses, but I wasn't looked down on by you and told I would never be accepted or loved— she explained. —I am not trying to justify Shadow Weaver, but she only ever got rejection from everyone; that sorceress is the only person who put her trust in her and believed she could grow, learn to regret.

—But if it was difficult for Catra, with all our support and being so young, just imagine how difficult it must have been for Shadow Weaver, being an adult, and having only Castaspella's support— Adora interceded.

They all remained silent, reflecting; Spinnerella took Netossa's hand and gave her a worried look, Frosta exchanged a quick glance with Glimmer to confirm they both agreed, and Double Trouble stared at Catra with a wary look.

—You sure understand her, don't you, Kitten?— they finally said.

—When she "rejected" Castaspella at first, she said something along those lines; she argued she never doubted she deserved power but that her pursuit of it led her to where she's now, regretting everything. What she did doubt was whether she deserved to be loved by someone as remarkable as the sorceress… Actually, she seemed pretty sure she doesn't deserve it.

—It wouldn't surprise me if she still thinks so— Adora sighed.

—Queen Glimmer— Sea Hawk called. —You do understand this might… hurt your aunt more than anything, don't you?

—Perhaps…— she admitted, looking away. —But Auntie has been dealing with her for a long time now, I'm sure she'll be… fine.

—Alright!— Double Trouble suddenly said, clapping their hands once to call everyone's attention, and attempting to get rid of the sour mood that had settled. —Time to pay up, Loves.

—Agh…

Most of the princesses let out annoyed grunts, Scorpia laughed shyly, while Bow and Adora covered their faces with their hands.

—You all agreed to this, so no complaints now— the shape-shifter reminded them. —Come on now; our Kitten here and I are waiting.

Indeed, Catra had won a while ago already, yet she preferred to wait until the main bet was fulfilled to receive her earnings. After all, her bet bordered on cheating…

Once the payments were done, Double Trouble promptly left before Glimmer could invite them all to stay for dinner. And the only ones who stayed were Mermista with Sea Hawk, Spinnerella, Netossa, and Frosta.

Even Adora and Catra preferred to return home with Finn.

It was an eventful night…

The following day, as promised, the Head Sorceress sought aid with the investigations. After all, she needed to clear her head a bit; keep herself busy without overworking herself either.

Hence, she asked an acolyte to fetch Delwyn for her.

However, after being told she required his help, the ambassador had been looking for Castaspella for a good while to no avail. He was told she was in the council room, but the councillors there said she had left for her room. And yet, when he went and knocked, there was no response.

Since then, he had been everywhere, until he finally decided to check the library…

—Oh, Head Sorceress. At long last.

Looking up from a mess of scrolls and papers, she exclaimed —Delwyn! Just in time!

—I heard you were looking for me…

—Yes, yes. I need your help with this before my head explodes— she explained, gesturing at him to approach. —I'm guiding a few acolytes in their investigations, but they all *coincidentally* finished their drafts at the same time, as if it were on purpose— she went on, letting out a tired sigh. —Can I ask you to give me your opinion?

—Of course— he cheerfully replied.

—Thank you *very* much.

Delwyn took a moment to place his hands on each document, clearly doing a thorough revision of each, and didn't speak until he was done. Then, he remained pensive for a moment, his demeanor going from a focused frown to a more interested expression as he opened his eyes and nodded.

—Well, these are all quite complex, but they mostly took time to explain each concept clearly for anyone to understand all the technicalities of their investigations. Only the one on rogue magical creatures in the area of Plumeria requires a bit more clarification of certain terms and the specific paradigm from which the information is viewed— he reckoned.

—Oh, that one. Yes, I see your point— Castaspella admitted. —That's the most difficult to read, indeed.

—The others seem fine to go, in my opinion— he assured her.

—That's excellent, thank you very much— she smiled.

However, there was something in her expression that made Delwyn ask —Is there anything bothering you?

—Huh? What makes you say that?

She looked mostly surprised, which confirmed his suspicions, so he dared say —Something tells me you busied yourself with the investigations because there's something *else* on your mind you're trying to avoid…

—Is it that obvious?— she sighed.

—I'm sure those who know you have noticed…

—It's nothing too important…

—I believe it's quite important for you— he insisted. —If you need to talk about it, I'll gladly listen — he offered.

The Head Sorceress sighed deeply. Delwyn's offer was actually quite tempting.

And why not? He had proved to be a great friend, after all…

—I… suppose it would be a good idea— she accepted, leaning back on her chair.

The ambassador smiled gently, took a seat in front of her, and nodded.

—No pressure. Just tell me whatever you feel comfortable sharing.

—Thank you— she sighed. —Well, it's… about Spin.

—I heard you're now… officially together— he commented.

—Yes, that *would* be right. But that's part of the problem. I-I feel… confused. I'm not sure of what she really feels— Castaspella began. —Sometimes it seems like she loves me back, sometimes it's like she hates the thought of loving me overall. I dare say she may even hate that *I* love *her*! It's so… difficult to understand— she explained.

—Have you talked about this with her?

—I've tried. But… she's a bit reluctant to explain herself.

—Maybe she herself doesn't know for sure what she's feeling.

—But- I mean… I can understand her being shy or something, but why would she refuse to kiss me even when in private?— she questioned. —I mean, sometimes she does; she said she wants me to let her decide when to kiss me, a-and that's fine! But I don't know if when she doesn't want to, it's because I did something wrong!

—I see— Delwyn sighed. —To begin with, let me assure you, you aren't doing anything wrong, alright? It sounds like it's her own struggle.

—Well, yes, she said that too…

—Then trust her. I…— he hesitated. —My partner was the same. Even after marrying, they wouldn't want to show affection in public, and in private it was difficult too.

—But why?

—In their case, and I don't want to presume it's the same with her, in their case it was because they felt it was ridiculous. They just… felt stupid. So sometimes he would show affection in beautiful ways, conventional ways, like kisses or hugs… But then there were the times they'd even push me away if I tried to do any of that— he explained. —They had other ways of showing love that are non-conventional and that I learnt to appreciate. So, I believe you should focus more on that, decipher what her love language is, and let her grow accustomed to showing love in a way that is probably new, and more difficult for her to process.

Castaspella closed her eyes and tilted her head back as she let out a sigh.

He was right.

—That's… true. Thank you— she finally said, looking back at him. —And sorry to bother you with this.

—Please, it wasn't any trouble. I asked…

Micah's project had been ready for about a month now. Everything was ready, no more preparations were needed, except those to begin the spell.

It was time.

Resolved, but somewhat angry at himself, he gathered his things and headed for the Lunarium. However, when he arrived, he changed his mind and shook his head.

Not there… He needed *more space*.

Where else, then, but the gardens?

Yes, that would work much better…

Soon, he was settling everything, getting ready to start, without noticing that a curious councilman had followed him. Hidden, he observed the King Father until he caught a glance of the scrolls he was using and went pale.

Shocked, the councilman took a few steps back and ran down the corridor…

—Auntie!

The Queen appeared in the magical groove, screaming for her aunt. Fortunately, she was only conversing with Shadow Weaver this time.

—Glimmer? What happened?

—There's no need to yell here, your Majesty.

—Leave your mockery for another moment, this is serious!— she exclaimed, frantic. —Dad is doing something! The-the councillors say it's that spell Shadow Weaver did!

—He's doing *what*!?— the women asked in unison.

—How can it be!? What is he doing!?— Castaspella began asking, just as agitated as her niece.

Meanwhile, the woman had tried to look at the sky between the leaves, to no avail, and let out an angry grunt.

This wasn't right.

—You have to stop him— she ordered. —Now!

—Yes, yes. Let's go— the Head Sorceress agreed, placing a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. —We can't let your father do this.

—A-alright— the Queen stammered.

As she finally teleported away with her aunt, Shadow Weaver was pulled back to the core of Etheria, with a feeling of fear she couldn't stand.

Why was he doing that!?

Of all the people who could ever attempt that spell too… how could it be *him*!?

As the two appeared on Mystacor, they rushed to the Lunarium but stopped in their tracks when they noticed a commotion in the gardens. Before they could so much as wonder what was going on, a pair of councillors found them.

—Head Sorceress! Queen Glimmer! Come quickly!

They didn't hesitate to follow them into the gardens, and made their way through the group of curious acolytes until they reached Micah. He was preparing things around a water basin, and a series of scrolls laid open at his feet.

—Everyone, please stay back. I'll speak with him— the sorceress ordered before approaching him. —Brother, what are you doing!?

—Dad!

—No, no, no. You shouldn't be here. None of you…

—Dad, we know what you're doing!

—Did you think no one would notice!?— Castaspella asked, indignant and confused. —The council told Glimmer you're trying to perform the Spell of Obtainment! Why!?

—I…— he tried to reply, but could only let out a sigh. —I know what I'm doing, please trust me.

—We trust you, but we can't trust that spell— his sister argued.

—If you trust me, then leave! I don't want to put anyone at risk— he insisted.

—Dad, we can't just let you risk your life either!

—I- Just… let me do this— Micah pleaded. —I know it can work now…

—We can't let you risk yourself like this— Castaspella sentenced, her tone gentle.

—Listen, I've investigated a lot. I understand why breaking the mask sent Shadow Weaver under the surface, and this is the only way to undo that— he explained. —The mask was an anchor, without it, the parasitic magic at the core pulls her down towards it. There are no other ways to extract that magic from the core other than the Spell of Obtainment— he elaborated.

—Brother, you don't have to go to such lengths to fix what you did. I-I would never want you to put your life at risk just for that!

—Listen, it's not the same Shadow Weaver did. This is just to summon that thing from the core and keep it sealed here in Mystacor. No one will try to take its power— he explained. —Please let me do it.

—Dad…

—Or… help me— he finally asked, resigned. —I don't want anyone else involved, I don't want anyone to be- to suffer what I did. But I know it will be worse if I just force you all away to do it on my own.

Castaspella and Glimmer exchanged a glance, then looked down, worried.

—First, tell me: Why are you doing this? What made you change your mind to-to even consider doing this? Why are you suddenly risking your own life to fix what you did?

Castaspella kept looking away, unable to look at him, but he knew it was better to answer truthfully.

—Two years ago… she- I still can't believe it, but she apologized. I-in fact, I went to speak with her to apologize too, and I guess she realized it and said "sorry" before I could.

—Tha-that was what you talked about!?— Castaspella exclaimed. —She… refused to tell me…

—Then I supposed she was… embarrassed? Or didn't want to get your hopes up— Micah reflected. —I can't really blame her.

—Still, Dad. This is insane. You can't do this alone. You shouldn't be doing it at all.

—I'm determined. I *will* do it, with or without help— he sentenced. Right after, he approached his sister and hugged her tightly. —I'm so sorry…

—I know, Brother— she muttered. After a moment of hesitation, the Head Sorceress hugged him back, eyes closed, and took a deep breath. Then, stepping back, she opened them again, closed her fists tightly, resolved, and looked up at him as she asked —What do we do?

—A-Auntie, are you sure?

—I won't lie, I have my doubts, but I always… theorized that, if the council had helped, it would have worked— she admitted.

—And I completely agree now— he assured her.

Then, Castaspella crouched a bit to Glimmer's height, and with a pleading look, she told her —If you choose to help too, our odds will be better; Micah's resolve and your angelic powers are variables that Spin didn't have in her time.

—Auntie… you sound like…

—When I supported the plan of using the failsafe, I know— Castaspella interrupted. —I trusted *our* plan was the best option, the only way to defeat Prime. And while it did work, there were just as many risks as now— she went on. —This is a bargain, Glimmer, I won't force you to help us if you don't want to, the situation isn't the same. So… feel free to refuse, but don't try to stop us.

—Yo-you were trying to stop him just moments ago!

—But he won't. And I refuse to leave him alone in this. So I… don't have a choice.

The Queen let out a sigh.

There was no point in further discussing this if they were both so determined.

—I… O-okay. I'll help you out. I don't wanna lose either of you— she finally decided. —Just let me warn everyone to stay away, alright?

—I'll prepare everything in the meantime— Micah nodded.

And so, while the siblings handled the preparation of the spell, the Queen approached the acolytes and councillors that observed from the sides.

—I need everyone's attention, please— she began, in her most commanding voice. —Everyone has to clear this place immediately, for your own safety.

—You will allow them to perform the spell!?— someone exclaimed in utter shock.

—This has *not* been authorized by the council!— a councilwoman pointed out, indignant.

—I am allowing it and take full responsibility. However, the council will have the chance to judge my father's actions *afterwards*.

—But…

—I won't say it again. Clear the area, that's an order from your Queen— Glimmer interrupted, severe, but mostly afraid of what could happen if they interfered.

Fortunately, everyone complied and left the gardens, even the councillors, except for Nolrem, who instead approached her, saying —Are you sure of what you're doing, your Majesty?

—I'm trying to protect you… and my family.

—As someone who saw the consequences of Light Spinner's attempt, I must warn you: that parasite is dangerous, a menace. If it were to escape, no one would be safe.

—I… understand— she accepted, looking away. But then, it occurred to her —Then there's one last precaution we need to take. Please find Adora and bring her here. If the worst were to happen, she's the only one who can keep everyone safe. From that thing, and… from us.

—I will, your Majesty.

—Thank you.

With that, Nolrem finally left, and she let out a deep sigh. She was nervous, scared, worried.

She didn't know what to expect, but still returned with her father and aunt, determined to help. If she could face her own dad when chipped and using black magic, then she wouldn't cower now.

As Castaspella felt her approach, she turned to thank her and said —We are ready to begin, and once we start, we can't stop. Are you sure you want to do this?

—Want? No. But if you are decided, then I must— Glimmer replied, serious. —As family, I don't want to abandon you. And as Queen, knowing my powers can improve the odds of succeeding, I have

a responsibility and *must* do everything I can to keep Etheria safe— she assured. —I won't let Mom's sacrifice, and all our efforts to defeat Prime, be in vain.

—I'm sure your mother would be proud.

—Let's get done with this— Glimmer sighed. —Everything prepared, Dad?

—I've verified everything. The seals are ready to be activated— he nodded. —But before we begin, I must warn you: that thing, that parasite, it will… try to grab us; it has several eyes and arms that- Well, they are very scary and it's virtually impossible to defend from them— he honestly explained, shivering at the memory. —So, for the seals to work and keep it contained, we must stay focused on the spell, *never* break the connection. Please— he begged. —I don't want to scare you, I just want you to know everything I didn't know so you are prepared.

—Of course— Castaspella uttered. —But, are you completely sure this will work? Because, I swear, if Spin disappears instead…

The sorceress gave him a chilling glare and the threat was left unspoken.

However, Micah held her sight and assured her —She won't. I promise, Sis.

Having said that, the three exchanged a look, one last confirmation they were doing this, and positioned themselves around the basin.

As the sorcerer began, he asked them to do exactly as he said and follow his movements. Flashes of the events from his teenage experience crossed his mind as he saw everything happening the exact same way as back then, except for the fact that they weren't in the Lunarium this time.

He realized such limited space had played against them when he attempted it with Light Spinner, and wouldn't allow for the containment to adapt to the parasite's size, no matter how big it turned out to be.

But now he had to focus, the black magic began filling the bright pink rhombus they had cast and soon, the parasite would try to wrestle its way out.

—Dad…

—I know, I know— he let out, fearful. —Just stay focused, baby girl. Don't let it scare you.

But she was honestly afraid, just like him, so she took a shivering breath and poured all her magic into the spell. Her angelic powers made the containment glow even brighter, moments before several eyes opened in the black mass filling it.

Both her and Castaspella gasped as they saw hands suddenly spawn and push against the walls of the rhombus. From now on, they couldn't hesitate anymore; no matter how scary it looked, no matter how much it fought to escape, if they wavered for a single second, it would give the thing an opening.

With the three fully focused, it was going perfectly. The parasite pushed, the containment grew and stretched but didn't break…

Until Castaspella felt an indescribable pain overtake her and lost focus for a moment.

—Ah!— she gasped, breathless, doubling down in pain.

—Auntie!

—Sis!

Both screamed at the same time, yet couldn't so much as spare a glance at her, for if they lost focus too, the containment would break.

—Dad! What do we do!? What's happening to her!?

—I-I don't know!

—I'm fine!— the Head Sorceress exclaimed, making an effort to return to the spell before it started to fail.

But she had to cast the seal from zero, weakening the containment just enough for the parasite to crack it.

—No, no, no!— the Queen panicked, as she saw a few arms slip through the fissures and reach for them.

—Listen to me!— Micah exclaimed. —Stay focused!— he said, right before one of those arms wrapped around him.

—Dad!

The Queen's panic only increased and she looked back at the containment right as another arm aimed for her face.

Cursing under her breath, she focused intently on the spell while bracing for impact, ready to resist the parasite's grab.

But its arm never touched her…

A bright light suddenly cut through the black arms, making them vanish; for each one that slipped through a crack, a new beam would slash right through it. And before she could process it, the Queen saw some of the gaps close.

Castaspella had managed to cast her seal again, despite the notorious effort she was making. Relieved, Glimmer looked back to where the light that saved them came, only to find She-Ra standing behind her, sword in hand.

She had arrived just in time.

And, along with her, Catra with Melog. *Something*, a hunch, told her that thing wasn't just dangerous, it was *just* like those awful dark powers Shadow Weaver had threatened her with so many times… It froze her in place for a moment until Melog made her notice that, behind her, a group of acolytes were gathering at the entrance of the gardens.

—What are you doing!? Stay back!— she quickly warned them, rushing at them. They were quite lucky she did because, at that exact moment, a bunch of arms escaped again, and Adora missed two that aimed at the reckless acolytes. —Of course not!— Catra stated.

As Melog took a threatening stance, she quickly summoned her illusionary animal form to fight back the parasite's arms. Adora quickly vanished them with a slash of her sword, but she preferred to keep

her projection in place just in case.

—What on Etheria is going on here!?— she suddenly heard behind her.

—Stay back, Arrow Boy. You'll distract Sparkles there— she warned him, without looking back.

The King swallowed hard and obeyed; he didn't have to think twice: he was holding Glow in arms, and Finn accompanied them too. If his wife and either Adora or Catra saw they were there, they would surely panic.

—What are they doing?— he uttered, looking in shock as he instinctively held Glow a bit closer, and extending a hand protectively in front of Finn. —Is this…— he began, thinking aloud, but trailed off as realization hit. —This was the secret project. And I told him to go ahead… Glimmer's going to kill me— he nervously laughed.

—Why are my moms fighting that thing?— Finn asked, stepping forward yet immediately stopped by Bow.

—Stay here with me; your moms will be fine— he assured them, trying to keep calm for the sake of the kids.

—But that's scary!

—I know, but your moms are very brave, alright?— the King insisted, giving them a gentle look.

—I want to be brave too!

—Then stay here with me and help me keep Glow safe, yes?— he quickly replied, fearing they would just run off into the gardens.

—A-alright— they nodded, and extended their hands towards Glow.

Relieved, Bow crouched to their height and sat his baby next to Finn, who knelt and hugged her. Worried still, but trying his best to calm down his rapidly beating heart, he sat with the kids and mentally told himself over and over again that his friends have it under control, that everything will be fine.

Meanwhile, at the core of Etheria, the parasitic magic little by little began disappearing, sipping away as if absorbed by something. However, as it did, the spirit of Shadow Weaver felt it fight. She felt it struggle, enraged and desperate, and it brought back that painful sensation she had learnt to keep at bay.

It was far stronger now, so much so that keeping her feelings in check, observing them instead of fighting them, no longer worked.

Just *what* was happening!?

Clearly, the councillors were right…

But why would Micah be doing such a thing!?

It didn't matter; what mattered was that the spell caused such an alteration in the space she was in, that now Castaspella must have been feeling her pain.

Enduring this, it was probably a deserved punishment, but… the sorceress shouldn't have to bear it too…

—Just a bit more! We're almost done!— Micah exclaimed, using all his strength to compensate and make it easier for his sister.

—Auntie! Can you keep going?— Glimmer asked her, sparing a few glances at her.

—Yes, yes— she replied, breathless. —Don't worry about me. I'm alright…

—What's going on with you?

—Remember the sudden pain I would feel years ago?

—From Shadow Weaver!? Wasn't that controlled!?— the Queen exclaimed.

—Focus!— Micah warned them.

However, Castaspella still replied —Well, it's back…

—Then we should finish this quickly— Glimmer stated, focusing intently again.

And so, with the three of them focused, the few cracks left in the pink rhombus disappeared; the thing was finally sealed away, and the King Father put up the final extra seals to stabilize the containment.

Realizing the danger had passed, Adora dismissed She-Ra and so did Catra with her projections. Behind her, the acolytes and councillors who joined remained shocked, staring at the arrested parasite.

—It worked…— Nolrem sighed, as a bittersweet sensation overwhelmed him. A part of him still considered it had been reckless of Micah to do this, and even more loathsome that the Head Sorceress *helped*. Yet another part felt somehow guilty; if only he had spoken up for his childhood friend all those years ago, he wouldn't have lost her. After all, help was all she needed, all she asked for. —I am so sorry…

—We must help him with that thing— Arden stated, looking at the other councillors around him.

—But…

—It's done now— they interrupted. —If we don't want that thing to escape, we *must help*. He requires more magical energy to keep up the seals; I know what I'm talking about.

Of course he knew, it was his area of expertise, so no one dared doubt him.

Geldirik gave the order and, followed by the councillors currently present, they approached the King Father, promptly lending him the energy necessary to sustain the pink rhombus.

At that same moment, Sahm arrived at the entrance to the gardens and stared in shock. He had no idea what was going on, but something made him run back to fetch Ari and his fellow classmates, who happened to be at Mystacor that day.

As Micah led the way to a chamber he had already prepared to contain the parasite, Glimmer and Adora went to check on Castaspella.

Catra was about to follow when she heard —Mom!

Shocked, she looked back and saw Finn, still hugging Glow, and rushed towards them, giving Bow a murderous look.

—You brought them here!?

—I couldn't leave them alone! And I had no idea what you were doing!

Melog meowed in reproach but he couldn't understand it.

—Really?— Catra asked it. —You know he can't understand you— she reminded it. She then turned to the King to explain —Melog says it warned you to stay put…

—Oh… that was what it meant— he nervously chuckled, scratching the back of his neck. —I'm sorry, but I had no idea.

—I know, Arrow Boy. Thanks for keeping them safe here.

—Of course.

Back outside, next to the water basin, Castaspella sat down, breathing heavily. The pain had stopped, but she was exhausted.

—Head Sorceress, are you alright?— Adora asked, worried.

—I'm… fine. Better now— she assured them, albeit gasping for air.

—Are you sure, Auntie?

—Wha-what happened?— Adora asked.

—Remember that pain I felt years ago?

—That came through the spell? But it hasn't happened the past few years— she argued, confused.

—I know. But… whatever we just did… must have caused her this pain again— she explained. —It's gone now, so… don't worry.

Relieved, Adora looked away as her anger finally settled.

—Now, I must ask— she began, severe. —What have you done? What was that thing?

—Adora… remember when we saw that mural on our way to the Failsafe?— Glimmer began.

—You didn't…— she uttered, shocked as realization hit. —You said it had disastrous consequences. Tha-that's what Shadow Weaver did! How could *you* do it!?

—I know what you must be thinking. But Micah was determined to do it. And if I left him alone, the same way the council left Spin alone, I fear what would have happened to him.

—Then I suppose that's also why you did it— Adora reflected, addressing Glimmer. When the Queen nodded, she asked —Then why did *he* do it? Why would he want to do it if you said it put his life in danger when he was just a child?

—I didn't understand either, but he… he said he wanted to fix his mistake, and that this was the only way— Castaspella explained, finally recovered. As she struggled to get up, she added —Even if that wasn't the case, the fact that he couldn't be talked out of it is why I helped him.

—You didn't do it to bring her back, just to protect him— Adora reckoned.

—Exactly.

—Then how do we know if it worked?— Glimmer wondered. —Dad was so sure… if it really was as he said, then Shadow Weaver's spirit should be drawn to the surface now.

—I… can try calling for her like I used to— Castaspella thought aloud, placing a hand on her chest.

However, Adora wasn't listening to them anymore.

She felt so confused…

She knew that what they had done was wrong; if she hadn't arrived in time, their recklessness would have cost them their lives, most likely.

But she had prevented it.

Speaking of the failsafe, it felt a lot like that situation. She could have died, but Catra was there to save her from her recklessness, and thanks to that, they saved Etheria from Prime.

Well, bringing back Shadow Weaver was hardly comparable to saving the whole of Etheria, but… if she could be a bit selfish, deep down it *was* just as important for her and for her wife.

Especially since she apologized.

Too late, maybe, but after it happened, she and Catra had been wishing to have her back on the surface permanently. The woman had grown, had become *better*, and yet they didn't have her around now?

Quite unfair…

After bearing her presence for half their lives, they didn't have her *now* that she was closer to being the caring person they longed for?

—Adora!— Glimmer suddenly exclaimed, extracting her from that musing.

The Queen was pointing at the edge of the gardens, towards where her aunt was running.

There she was.

The Head Sorceress didn't hesitate to hug her tight and kissed her briefly without thinking.

—Oh, so-sorry, we… are in public— she suddenly realized, blushing.

—A bit too late— Shadow Weaver muttered, looking around at the acolytes gathered at the entrance and holding her close by the waist as if instinctively hiding behind her.

—I'm just so…

—Happy? Excited?— the woman interrupted, her tone a bit mocking. —I suppose that's to be expected, if it weren't for the fact that you allowed your brother to perform the most dangerous spell. And after all your reproaches— she pointed out.

—I know, trust me, I know— Castaspella sighed. —But I couldn't stop him, and I told you: if the council had helped you, perhaps it would have succeeded. So now I *had* to help him. A-and Glimmer also helped so we had more in our favour.

—You were all terribly reckless— Shadow Weaver immediately sentenced, severe. It made the sorceress proud of her for a second, until the woman added —How could you do it without the moon alignment to help!? And he was trying to do it alone!? Unbelievable…

—You are irremediable— Castaspella muttered, shaking her head. —Don't look at me, I *wanted* to stop him…

—Obviously. But, seeing how it worked…— she began. —Remind me to thank him.

—Of course…

—Master!— they suddenly heard, and turned around just in time to see the whole group of former pupils rush towards them.

Castaspella preferred to give them some space, and Shadow Weaver internally cursed. A part of her was moved, they were so excited to see her back in Mystacor… But then there was the part of her that felt overwhelmed and practically wanted to run or scare them all away.

However, Castaspella gave her an encouraging look, and the woman took a deep breath, ordered them to calm down, and prepared to answer their questions and welcomes.

—Excuse me— a voice called the Head Sorceress, and she turned to find Delwyn standing next to her. —I suppose congratulations are in order.

—I… don't know— she admitted, looking down. —What we did was far from correct. She's back but… now I…

—Have to do your work and judge what happened here.

—Yes.

—How are you supposed to do that if you participated?— the ambassador asked, confused.

—Geldirik, as foreman-councilman, has to take over in these cases. I mean, even if I hadn't helped, Micah is my brother, I shouldn't judge him myself.

—Judgement aside… Would you say it was worth it?

After thinking for a second, staring at the excited group gathered around Shadow Weaver, she looked back at him and said —She's here. It's what I wanted, what they wanted, what Adora and Catra wanted… So I suppose it was.

—Then I'm sure that, whatever the decision of the council ends up being, it will be little to bear in comparison.

Castaspella chuckled, looking down, and agreed —I suppose, yes. I think I'm ready to face whatever they resolve. But I'm afraid of how this will affect Glimmer and Micah.

—Why?

—Glimmer is the Queen of Bright Moon; yet she helped with something that could have endangered all of Etheria. Again— she began. —And Micah went behind the council's back to perform a forbidden spell. Again!

—I see…

—Never mind— she then sighed, shaking her head. —Don't burden yourself with this.

—In any case, I am glad that, after all those years since we met, you can finally be happy with her— Delwyn stated.

—It's been so long… So much happened.

—But then again, all worth it, isn't it?

—Yes…

With everything that happened, inevitably, foreman-councilman Geldirik called for a meeting for that night, and everyone knew what it was about.

Saying the King Father was nervous would be an understatement, and coming across Shadow Weaver didn't exactly help.

Without saying a word, he intended to simply walk past her, but she wouldn't let him.

—You probably don't want to see me yet, but I must talk to you— she began.

—What about?— he asked, annoyed and looking away, arms folded.

—I reckon you don't want my… appreciation for what you did, but at least let me better apologize to you— she requested.

—Where is this coming from? You already did, why again?

—Saying "sorry" was hardly enough.

—Just forget it— he dismissed her, ready to leave again.

However, he stopped in his tracks when she refused —I can't because *you* won't forget it.

—Alright, I'll listen to you— he accepted, turning to face her once more.

—Years ago, your sister asked me if I ever… felt like a mother to you— she began. —And while I refused to reply, the truth is… I actually refused to accept it. Now, I dare say I did, which was wrong as I was your tutor, but I had never been prouder of someone before— she explained. She then chuckled and added —I would have been honored to be your mother.

—Tha-that's…— Micah stuttered, trying to hide that, deep inside, he felt moved by her words. —That's nonsense. I-it would be weird…

—It's obviously symbolic, Micah.

—If you really felt like a mother, if you had *actually* seen me as a son, you wouldn't have risked my life like you did— he argued.

—I said I felt like a mother, doesn't mean I would be a good one— she joked. —But in all seriousness, I never intended to put you at risk. I was… so sure it would work— she then added.

Right that moment, Castaspella was about to turn around the corner and enter the corridor where they were talking, but heard their voices and couldn't help stopping to avoid interrupting them. She didn't want to eavesdrop and was about to leave, but hearing what they were talking about picked her curiosity.

—I-it doesn't matter now…

—It matters to you… and to your sister— Shadow Weaver sentenced.

—Just… let's agree on one thing: What you did, what *I* did, was wrong. Completely wrong. And just like I will take responsibility for my actions, so you should have done— he told her.

—It took me too long, but I finally did. You can ask Cas…

—Perfect. Then we have nothing else to discuss— he replied.

—Does all of this mean you won't… antagonize me anymore? Or try to undermine my relationship with your sister?— she asked, with a tone between surprised and condescending.

—What it means, is that you're off the hook *for now*. As long as you don't give me reasons to want you gone, I'll do nothing against you— he explained, frowning in anger. —In short: Don't you dare hurt Casta in *any* way because I will find a way to make you pay for it. As long as she's happy, you have nothing to worry about— he clarified.

—You have my word— she promised.

Having heard that, Castaspella cried tears of joy.

The one thing she wanted, for them to come to terms, to give up their animosity, had finally happened.

For the Head Sorceress, all of this meant one thing: Everything would change from now on.

Their life would change.

Chapter End Notes

That, my dears, was almost 10k words.
A lot, fr...
And just in time before my B-day in 3 days!! (the 9th)

But I hope it's actually a good thing that it was so lengthy... After all, you'll have no more content until Feb 2024 <("^_^)

In any case, I'll be waiting for your comments, and you shall see the aftermath of their actions in the next part!!!

I really hope you liked it, or at least enjoyed it, and hopefully all the hate you had for Micah has diminished a bit XD

This was the end of his arc after all! He went through a bit of a SW-ish phase which culminated with him doing exactly the same she did, yet with better results; not only because of the variables (like having help and angelic powers on his side) but also, more metaphorically, because he learnt from LS's mistakes and did things right.

I think...
That's my opinion.
And I'll gladly ~~hear~~ read yours (^_^)

Anyways... This is my final note; hopefully I'll see you in another fic, and/or in *Life Will Change* next year :D

I don't know how to end the note, so I'll cut it here. Bye, everyone! Thank you for accompanying me in this wild ride! \(^o^)/

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!